

COLLEGE FOOTBALL BETTING GUIDE

VSIN **PRO**

IRISH EYES FIRST CFP TITLE

TIPS & STRATEGIES FOR BETTING COLLEGE FOOTBALL

OUR **PRO** GUIDE INCLUDES

- MATT YOUMANS' PRESEASON TOP 50
- PREVIEWS FOR ALL 138 FBS TEAMS
- BEST BETS, CONFERENCE CHAMPS FROM HOSTS/EXPERTS

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COMMON ABBREVIATIONS USED THROUGHOUT THIS GUIDE

ATS – Against the Spread • Avg - Average • CL – Closing Line • CONF – Conference • DC - Defensive Coordinator • DEF - Defense • DOG - Underdog
EFF STRG - Steve Makinen Effective Strength Rating • Fav - Favorite • FT – Final Total • HC - Head Coach • H2h – Head-to-Head • HOME FA – Home Field Advantage • L - Losses • L# - Last number of games • LY – Last Year • MOV – Margin of Victory • O - Over • OC - Offensive Coordinator • Off - Offense
OL – Opening Line • OT – Opening Total • Opp – Opponent • O/U – Over/Under • PA - Points Against • PCT - Percentage • PF - Points For
PPG - Points Per Game • PRJL'S – Projected Losses • PRJW'S – Projected Wins • PYPG – Passing Yards per Game • ROAD FA – Road Field Advantage
RS - Returning Starters • RYPG – Rushing Yards per Game • SM BR - Steve Makinen Bettors' Rating • SM PR - Steve Makinen Power Rating
SS – Schedule Strength • SU - Straight Up • TO - Turnovers • TYPG – Total Yards per Game • U - Under • W - Wins • YPP – Yards per Play
YPPT – Yards per Point • YPR – Yards per Rush

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ODDS WITHIN GUIDE
ARE SUBJECT TO CHANGE

photos by USA Today Network

Greetings, everyone!

Welcome to the 2026 VSIN College Football Betting Guide! This is the most important Guide that we put out because it is so hard to follow the college football offseason and we have previews for all 138 FBS teams to help you prepare for the season ahead.

To say that this is a team effort is an understatement, so before I explain more about what's in this year's edition, I'd like to thank Senior Editor Zachary Cohen, Editor Michael Dolan, Guide Designer Matt Devine, and everybody on our creative and marketing teams. We also had a ton of host participation in terms of best bets and heartfelt thanks go out to all of those who submitted picks and predictions.

Special thanks to these fantastic writers for the best preseason content you are going to find anywhere:

- Matt Youmans' Top 50 and Pac-12 Previews
- Zachary Cohen's Heisman Trophy Overview and Big 12 Previews
- Jonathan Von Tobel's Mountain West and SEC Previews
- Wes Reynolds' Big Ten Previews
- Adam Burke's Home-Field Advantage Values, New Head Coach Profiles, American, ACC, Conference USA, Independents, MAC, and Sun Belt Previews
- Frequent guest Paul Stone's Top 15 Quarterbacks

And, of course, our VSIN Analytics Guru Steve Makinen, who has provided his Favorite Season Win Total Bets, Power Ratings Projections, and Stats and Ratings for all of the teams.

You can find VSIN on SiriusXM Channel 158, on the [VSIN Watch App](#), on YouTube TV as part of the Sports+ package, on our YouTube page, on radio affiliates and regional sports networks across the country, wherever you get your podcast content, and through [VSIN.com](#).

Keep an eye out this month for our 2026 Average Joe Betting Contest, which gives contestants the option to pick college football games alongside the NFL to win some cool prizes. It's free to play and just one more perk of being a member of the VSIN audience.



Thank you for your support and good luck this college football season!

Adam Burke
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2026 SEASON PREDICTIONS

	FEMI ABEBEFE	MATT BROWN	STORMY BUONANTONY	ADAM BURKE	ZACHARY COHEN	SEAN GREEN	PAUL HOWARD	RYAN KRAMER	JENSEN LEWIS	STEVE MAKINEN	JOHN MCKECHNIE	PATRICK MEAGHER	MITCH MOSS	TIM MURRAY	WES REYNOLDS	SCOTT SEIDENBERG	TYLER SHOEMAKER	PAUL STONE	DUSTIN SWEDELSON	DAVE TULEY	MATT YOUNANS	JONATHAN VON TOBEL
ACC CHAMPION	Miami	Miami	Miami	Clemson	Miami	SMU	Miami	Virginia Tech	Miami	Miami	Miami	SMU	Miami	Miami	Miami	SMU	Miami	Miami	Miami	Miami	Louisville	Miami
BIG TEN CHAMPION	Ohio State	Oregon	Oregon	Oregon	Oregon	Penn State	Oregon	Ohio State	Ohio State	Oregon	Oregon	Indiana	Indiana	Oregon	Indiana	Oregon	Oregon	Ohio State	Oregon	Indiana	Oregon	Oregon
BIG 12 CHAMPION	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	BYU	Texas Tech	BYU	BYU	Texas Tech	Kansas State	BYU	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	BYU	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	Texas Tech	BYU	Texas Tech	BYU	Texas Tech
SEC CHAMPION	Texas	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	Texas A&M	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	Texas	Texas	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	Georgia	Georgia
AAC CHAMPION	Navy	UTSA	UTSA	UTSA	Navy	UTSA	Navy	UTSA	Navy	UTSA	East Carolina	Navy	Navy	UTSA	Navy	Memphis	South Florida	Navy	Memphis	UTSA	UTSA	UTSA
CUSA CHAMPION	Western Kentucky	Liberty	Western Kentucky	Liberty	Western Kentucky	Delaware	Western Kentucky	Liberty	Liberty	Western Kentucky	Delaware	Western Kentucky	Liberty	Liberty	Delaware	Western Kentucky	Western Kentucky	Liberty	Liberty	Western Kentucky	Jacksonville State	Liberty
MAC CHAMPION	Western Michigan	Western Michigan	Toledo	Toledo	Western Michigan	Miami (OH)	Western Michigan	UMass	Western Michigan	Western Michigan	Western Michigan	Miami (OH)	Miami (OH)	Miami (OH)	Western Michigan	Miami (OH)	Western Michigan	Miami (OH)	Western Michigan	Toledo	Western Michigan	Miami (OH)
MWC CCHAMPION	UNLV	UNLV	New Mexico	UNLV	UNLV	Air Force	New Mexico	Air Force	New Mexico	UNLV	North Dakota State	North Dakota State	New Mexico	New Mexico	Air Force	UNLV	North Dakota State	Air Force	New Mexico	UNLV	UNLV	Hawaii
PAC-12 CHAMPION	San Diego State	Boise State	Boise State	Boise State	Boise State	San Diego State	Boise State	Fresno State	San Diego State	Boise State	Texas State	Boise State	San Diego State	Fresno State	Fresno State	Boise State	Boise State	Boise State	Boise State	Boise State	Fresno State	Boise State
SUN BELT CHAMPION	James Madison	Arkansas State	Old Dominion	Old Dominion	Old Dominion	Troy	James Madison	Marshall	James Madison	James Madison	James Madison	Old Dominion	Marshall	Marshall	Marshall	James Madison	James Madison	Arkansas State	Troy	James Madison	Marshall	Arkansas State
CFP FINAL FOUR #1	Miami	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Texas A&M	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Ohio State	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Georgia	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Texas	Notre Dame	Notre Dame
CFP FINAL FOUR #2	Texas	Oregon	Oregon	Oregon	Oregon	Penn State	Oregon	Georgia	Texas	Texas	Miami	Indiana	Miami	Oregon	Georgia	Oregon	Oregon	Ohio State	Miami	Indiana	Oregon	Georgia
CFP FINAL FOUR #3	Ohio State	Georgia	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	BYU	Georgia	Ohio State	Notre Dame	Oregon	Oregon	BYU	Indiana	Georgia	Indiana	Texas	Ohio State	Georgia	Oregon	Georgia	Georgia	Alabama
CFP FINAL FOUR #4	Oregon	LSU	BYU	Texas Tech	LSU	SMU	Texas Tech	Virginia Tech	Georgia	Georgia	Ohio State	Notre Dame	Georgia	Ohio State	Oregon	Georgia	Georgia	Texas	Georgia	Notre Dame	Ohio State	Miami
CFP TITLE GAME #1	Texas	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Penn State	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Ohio State	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Georgia	Miami	Notre Dame	Georgia	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Texas	Notre Dame	Notre Dame
CFP TITLE GAME #2	Oregon	Georgia	Oregon	Oregon	Texas	Texas A&M	Georgia	Virginia Tech	Texas	Texas	Miami	BYU	Georgia	Georgia	Oregon	Georgia	Oregon	Ohio State	Oregon	Indiana	Oregon	Alabama
CFP CHAMPION	Oregon	Georgia	Oregon	Notre Dame	Texas	Texas A&M	Notre Dame	Virginia Tech	Ohio State	Texas	Miami	Georgia	Georgia	Notre Dame	Oregon	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Notre Dame	Oregon	Texas	Notre Dame	Alabama

VSIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL

BEST BETS

DAVE ROSS

VIRGINIA TECH OVER 6.5 WINS (-140) & ALT OVER 7.5 WINS (+120)

I'm going with the silver-bullet approach: one shot. Firing on all Virginia Tech futures. Over 6.5 at -140 and adjusted Over 7.5 at +120.

I love their chances this year to really compete in year one under James Franklin. The funny thing is, he was in the CFP semis two years ago and then ran out of Happy Valley for Blacksburg. One man's trash is another man's treasure. He'll thrive in Hokieland, and keeping Brent Pry as the DC is the hidden gem. One of the best, if not the biggest, winners in the portal. Don't be surprised if they find themselves in Charlotte playing for an ACC title this year. I won't be.

MATT YOUMANS

FRESNO STATE OVER 6.5 WINS (-120)

Matt Entz coached North Dakota State to two FCS national championships in five years and compiled a 60-11 record. Last year, he took over a losing Fresno team and produced a 9-4 finish. That team was limited by mediocre quarterback play, and Entz brought in Maryland transfer Khristian Martin, a dual-threat playmaker. Four of the top five pass catchers are returning, including leading receiver Josiah Freeman. Three of the top offensive linemen in the Pac-12 pave the way for experienced running backs Bryson Donelson and Rayshon Luke. The Bulldogs host Boise State on Oct. 10 in what could be the most important matchup of Pac-12 play. Entz coached Fresno, a 17-point underdog, to a 30-7 win at Boise last year. After a trip to USC in early September, Fresno has a realistic shot to reel off three consecutive wins against Sacramento State, San Jose State and Rice. Circa Sports posted 6.5 with the league's 12th flex game included in the win total.

MICHIGAN UNDER 8.5 WINS (-160)

The Big Ten is loaded again this season — starting with Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana — and the Wolverines have been losing ground. The fallout from the Jim Harbaugh era ended with the firing of Sherrone Moore, who led a clumsy coaching staff that failed to develop freshman quarterback Bryce Underwood. The talent level is down and the schedule's degree of difficulty is up. Michigan will play the Buckeyes and Ducks on the road and host Indiana, Iowa, Penn State and Oklahoma. The hiring of veteran coach Kyle Whittingham is a huge positive, but almost everything would need to go right for the Wolverines to win nine games, and it's more likely Whittingham will go 7-5. The price is getting high (-160 or more), but pay it.

DAVE TULEY

TEXAS TO WIN SEC (+295) & NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP (+700)

Longtime readers of my Tuley's Takes columns, especially in horse racing, know I am not deterred when a bet on a team (or horse) comes up short, as I'd rather be too early on a team/horse peaking than too late. Last year, I bet Texas to win the CFB Playoff and obviously came up short as QB Arch Manning didn't reach his well-bred potential as early as I was hoping. The Longhorns had a disappointing season but showed signs of competence, and I'm hoping that I was just a year too early (similar to me betting the Detroit Lions to win this season's Super Bowl after losing with them last year). Texas is the second-betting choice in the SEC behind Georgia, and obviously we're hoping they win the conference on the way to the CFB Playoff and natty.

INDIANA TO WIN BIG TEN (+245)

Also last year, I wasn't a believer in Indiana for most of the season, but fortunately grabbed the Hoosiers at +330 to win the College Football Playoff in the VSIN Bowl Betting Guide and rode them to the title. Obviously they lost Heisman Trophy winner Fernando Mendoza as the NFL's No. 1 overall draft pick, but coach Curt Cignetti has to be given his due for one of the biggest turnarounds in not only CFB but sports history with the Indiana football program, and I'm confident he'll have them in the running again. It looks like a three-horse race in the Big Ten between Indiana, Ohio State and Oregon, so +245 is a fair price. And I might also take a shot at the Hoosiers to repeat as national champions, as it feels like they're being overlooked at just short of 13-1.

TOLEDO TO WIN MAC (+365)

As an alumnus of Northern Illinois (class of 1988), I've been a longtime fan of the Mid-American Conference. I have mixed feelings about the Huskies moving to the Mountain West Conference this season, as I'll be able to go to their games at UNLV every other year but will miss watching them in the MAC. But I'm still a MAC fan and see this as another three-horse race with Toledo, Western Michigan and Miami-Ohio. Toledo has a new coach in Mike Jacobs, who has won everywhere he's been, including two straight SoCon titles at Mercer. And Toledo is used to rebuilding after losing coaches, as happens with mid-majors, and competing every year. Running back CJ Miller and WR Adjatay Dabbs come from Mercer with Jacobs to help whoever wins the QB job.

AARON MOORE

TEXAS TO WIN NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP (+700)

Sign me up as a follower of the Arch Manning Redemption Tour. The prized QB at the start of last season was far from being someone who could lead his team to a national championship. The version at the tail end of last year was a lot closer to doing so. Besides more experience for Manning and leading WR Ryan Wingo, Texas added another downfield threat with Auburn transfer Cam Coleman. The offense will be there, and Will Muschamp on the sidelines should help the defense. After the Big Ten flexed its muscles with a national championship the past three seasons, the 7-1 on the Longhorns is a good buy-low scenario for what should be one of the two best teams in the SEC.

CLEMSON UNDER 5.5 CONFERENCE WINS (-150)

The ACC schedule makers didn't do Dabo Swinney any favors as he looks to lift the Tigers back into contention. Sure, Clemson is warming up to the transfer portal, but the odd migration patterns of the ACC will make it hard for Clemson to secure six conference wins. A mid-September flight to Berkeley comes in between home games against North Carolina and Miami. The end of their season features three of their last four games on the road.

SMU TO REACH ACC CHAMPIONSHIP GAME (+200)

If veteran QB Kevin Jennings can lead his team to at least one win during SMU's first two conference games of the season (at Florida State and at Louisville), the Mustangs will be set up nicely for the remainder of ACC play. There should be plenty of October and November ACC wins for the Mustangs. The finale in Palo Alto comes on the heels of a trip to South Bend, but it is hard now to envision Stanford being a roadblock to a championship game appearance.

STEVE MAKINEN

TEXAS TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (-200)

Over the last two springs, the Texas staff has brought in the No. 1 and No. 3 ranked recruit/transfer classes in the country according to 247 Sports. To me, that means this locker room is probably the most talented in the country this season. Now naturally, that talent has to be cultured on the field, but head coach Steve Sarkisian has proven he can do that, taking the Longhorns to the CFP title game two years ago. Last year, to me, was an unrealistic set of expectations for this team, as the pressure on Texas and QB Arch Manning was palpable every time they took the field. The fact that the Longhorns still won 10 games despite a 5-7-1 ATS record shows just how much even the experts behind the bookmaking counter thought of this group. This team won its final three games of '25 after some of that pressure was lifted, and Manning exploded in those

contests. The offense put up 456 yards in the bowl win over Michigan. That is the momentum they will be carrying into 2026. The fact that this program plays the toughest schedule in the nation this year, according to my numbers, is relevant to a degree, but in my opinion, it is Texas' opponents who are drawing the short straw here. I don't see a team with this much talent losing more than a couple of games, in which case a playoff berth will be a lock.

BOISE STATE TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+450)

Last year, two Group of Five teams made the CFP despite losing game(s) in the regular season. This year, I expect that total to be one. To me, the most likely candidate is Boise State, which moves over to the newly formed Pac-12. When I ran my updated power ratings versus the 2026 schedule, the Broncos' +1.7 difference was one of the biggest I've ever had. I think the oddsmakers are giving a bit too much credit to the strength of the new conference, where BSU is the clear favorite. QB Maddux Madsen returns as a senior, and HC Spencer Danielson is in his fourth year with the program. The opener at Oregon is the only likely loss I see on the '26 slate. By the time it's all said and done in December, I believe this team will have the strongest resume of the non-P4 teams.

UNLV TO MAKE MOUNTAIN WEST CONFERENCE TITLE GAME (+110)

I have gone through the UNLV schedule for '26, which is minus nemesis Boise State this year after the Broncos left for the Pac-12, and I am struggling to find even a single game where the Runnin' Rebels will not be expected to win or at least be extremely competitive. With the meteoric rise New Mexico made last year, the Runnin' Rebels' Mountain West consistency in recent years makes them the favorite in the MWC this season. Including Auburn transfer QB Jackson Arnold, UNLV head coach Dan Mullen has brought in highly respected recruiting classes to carry on the momentum of 30-12 over the past three years. Mullen has been able to bring in numerous P4 transfers, which should have the Runnin' Rebels in the hunt for MWC titles year in and year out for the near future. Running this team's power rating against the 2026 schedule produced a 9-3 record, 6.2-1.8 in league play. I think +110 to reach the MWC title game is a gift of a line.

TYLER SHOEMAKER

ARKANSAS UNDER 4.5 WINS (-170)

TSI projects just 4.3 wins for the Razorbacks this year, but when you comb through the schedule and look at the win probabilities in a vacuum, there are only two games in which they have a > 60% win probability, but 10 (!) games in which the win probability is < 40%, with zero games falling in the middle as "coin flips." So, it's going to take them way overachieving relative to expectation in three games, plus winning the two they're supposed to, in order for this bet to lose.

SOUTHERN MISS UNDER 3.5 WINS (+105)

I think a lot of credit is being given to Southern Miss by some models (FPI) based on what they did last year, but head coach Charles Huff is now at Memphis, and the Golden Eagles are undergoing another turnover for the second straight season. I think there's going to be a major step back, with TSI projecting 3.3 wins, and only one game with a win probability > 60%. In fact, they've got 10 games where their win probability is < 40%, with just one coin-flip game. So, for this bet to lose, they have to win the one they're supposed to win, plus the coin flip, plus two more that they're sizable underdogs in.

PAUL STONE

TEXAS TECH TO WIN BIG 12 CHAMPIONSHIP GAME (-105)

With the Brendan Sorsby saga now (mostly) behind them, the Texas Tech Red Raiders can shift their focus to defending their Big 12 championship. Quarterback is clearly the Red Raiders' biggest question, but all indications are that starter Will Hammond will be ready for the Sept. 5 opener against Abilene Christian after suffering a torn ACL in his right knee last October. The former four-star recruit is not a greenhorn by any stretch after starting the 2024 Liberty Bowl against Arkansas and then two games last season in relief of an injured Behren Morton. With a healthy Hammond under center, Tech projects to be a double-digit favorite in all 12 of its regular-season games. I like the Red Raiders to repeat as conference champions at the short price.

BYU +3 VS. UTAH (GAME OF THE YEAR - NOV. 7)

Long-time Utah defensive coordinator Morgan Scalley is now a first-time head coach there, while BYU's Kalani Sitake, who worked with Scalley for almost a decade in Salt Lake City, is entering his 11th season as the Cougars' head man. On top of the perceived coaching edge, I believe BYU has the superior roster. Sophomore quarterback Bear Bachmeier was a pleasant surprise as a true freshman, and senior LJ Martin (1,305 yards rushing in 2025) is one of the nation's most underappreciated backs. Meanwhile, Utah has questions on both the offensive and defensive lines. BYU is 23-4 straight up over the last two seasons. I like the Cougars to go into Salt Lake City and come away with the outright victory in "The Holy War."



NORTH TEXAS UNDER 5.5 WINS (+100)

Last season, North Texas won 12 games and finished in a three-way tie for first place in the American Conference before falling to Tulane, 34-21, in the league title game. However, former head coach Eric Morris and many of that team's key pieces have migrated northward to Stillwater, Oklahoma, where they will suit up for the Oklahoma State Cowboys in 2026. Returning just eight percent of their total snaps from one season ago, it's difficult to envision the Mean Green breaking even in Neal Brown's first season. North Texas opens with games against Indiana, UNLV and Texas State and could lose all three. Brown may ultimately find success in Denton, but I believe the revamped Mean Green are in for a tough opening act.

PAULY HOWARD

NORTH DAKOTA STATE UNDER 9.5 WINS (-200)

I'm shocked that they are the third choice to win the league and have this high of a win total after making the move to the Mountain West. People are trashing the league with all the teams that have left, but 10-2 is a big ask.

PENN STATE OVER 8.5 WINS (-150)

I'm not a fan of Matt Campbell, but the schedule is a joke. He brings all of his players from Iowa State and doesn't have to face Oregon, Ohio State or Indiana.

OKLAHOMA STATE OVER 5.5 WINS (-180)

Drew Mestemaker is ready for the NFL, and he has a great story just getting on the field at North Texas. Eric Morris had a good team last year, and he took all of his players with him. I like the coach and the quarterback, and only need six wins.

NORTH TEXAS UNDER 6.5 WINS (-200)

They return zero starters with Morris leaving town. The Mean Green are also in a tough league, making this a work in progress.

JENSEN LEWIS

PARLAY: NOTRE DAME, OHIO STATE, TEXAS TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+115)

Set it and forget it. Barring some ridiculousness that will catastrophically affect many other futures bets on these three programs, I'm getting the top teams entering this regular season to "do their job" and make the College Football Playoff. The Buckeyes return elite talent in Heisman hopefuls Jeremiah Smith and Julian Sayin, giving Ryan Day a chance at an even better overall team than last season's group. Their team win total Over 9.5 is also a solid foundational future to invest in. Marcus Freeman and the Fighting Irish remaining independent and not facing a potential SEC/Big Ten conference gauntlet gives the team an incredible advantage in the expanded CFP era. Their talent and depth are as good as any team entering this season. The Longhorns spent gobs of NIL money to bolster both sides of the ball, giving Steve Sarkisian potentially his best chance at a national title since taking the job in Austin. It does mean more in the SEC, and it feels like the Horns are leaving no stone unturned in 2026.



Bear Bachmeier

Lane Kiffin

LSU TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+160)

Lane Kiffin's arrival in Baton Rouge is arguably the most compelling storyline entering this season, not only in the SEC, but in college football. An overhauled roster through the transfer portal, paired with significant NIL investments, augments the attractiveness of this future bet. Year 1 of Kiffin usually translates to drastic improvement, especially on offense. Quarterback Sam Leavitt will run a high-octane attack, complete with fresh wideout transfers: big-play threats Jayce Brown (Kansas State) and Jackson Harris (Hawaii) headline the group, alongside speed demon Winnie Watkins, who followed Kiffin from Ole Miss. The schedule is favorable, considering the Tigers will avoid Georgia, so they'll need to take advantage of winnable early conference matchups before a gauntlet in November (Alabama, Texas, Tennessee). Nine wins feels incredibly viable and enough in the expanded playoff system. Count the Tigers as chaos candidates in this year's CFP!



ZACHARY COHEN

I wrote up the Big 12 for this guide, so you'll see some predictions from me there. However, the only win totals I actually took in the conference were Arizona State Over 6.5 (-110 - 3 units), BYU Over 8.5 (-134 - 3 units), Houston Over 7.5 (-155 - 3 units), and UCF Over 5.5 (-140 - 3 units). I also took all four of the candidates I mentioned in my Heisman Trophy column: Darian Mensah (12-1), John Mateer (25-1 - 0.5 units), Marcel Reed (30-1 - 0.5 units), and Drew Mestemaker (75-1 - 0.25 units).

The rest of my futures are as follows:

LSU OVER 8.5 WINS (-104 - 3 UNITS) & TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+240)

The Tigers have some very tough games on the schedule, but they'll play Clemson, Texas A&M, Alabama, and Texas in Death Valley. If they simply split those four games, they should be looking at a 9-3 season — and there's a decent chance they go 3-1 in those contests. LSU will no longer be weighed down by the poor coaching of Brian Kelly. Lane Kiffin is in the building, meaning the Tigers have one of the brightest offensive minds leading the program. Kiffin also brought along Charlie Weis Jr., a great offensive coordinator, and was able to keep Blake Baker, one of the nation's top defensive coordinators.

This is going to be a very well-coached team, and the talent is undeniable. Kiffin was active in the transfer portal, scooping up stars for nearly every position group. However, it's the offense that should make this season special. Arizona State transfer Sam Leavitt should be a star under center in Kiffin's offense, and he has several weapons at his disposal in Florida transfer Eugene Wilson and Hawaii transfer Jackson Harris — in addition to talented Ole Miss transfer Winston Watkins. Kiffin also has a good group of running backs, and he really beefed up his offensive line.

MICHIGAN OVER 8.5 WINS (+140 - 1.5 UNITS)

Michigan has home games against Oklahoma, Iowa, Penn State, and Indiana, and going 3-1 in those contests will be necessary, with the

Wolverines facing Oregon and Ohio State on the road. At plus-money odds, I'll take my chances with Michigan accomplishing that feat.

Kyle Whittingham has always been one of the coaches I trust the most, and I think he did a good job of quickly retooling this roster. Whittingham was able to keep seven offensive starters from last year's Wolverines squad, and Jason Beck, a brilliant play-caller, will get his crack at coaching them. Beck should be able to turn Bryce Underwood into one of the most feared signal-callers in college football.

Michigan is also loaded on defense. The Wolverines were able to keep defensive backs Jyaire Hill and Zeke Berry, and Whittingham could also have a star in defensive lineman Enow Etta. On top of that, John Henry Daley and Smith Snowden, two absolute studs, transferred in from Utah.

This team is big, physical, and talented, so nine wins should be expected, even with things in Ann Arbor having taken a strange turn since the 2023 championship.

WISCONSIN OVER 6.5 WINS (+100 - 3 UNITS) & ALT OVER 7.5 WINS (+230)

This is undoubtedly a bit of a homer pick, and it's one I believe I've lost every year since I started working for VSIN. However, this is where we list the futures we have for the upcoming college football season, and these are two of mine.

Things have been miserable since Luke Fickell took over the Wisconsin program, but they were trending in the wrong direction long before he was hired. The Badgers were getting smoked by the Big Ten's elite teams, and the program's recruiting was in the toilet. Fickell has at least turned around the latter, which is part of the reason why the 2026 team is as talented as it is. He also has some NIL money to work with now, which should help address the team's competitiveness when facing superior programs.

This year, Wisconsin doesn't play many of the big brands. The toughest games on the schedule feature the Badgers facing Notre Dame (in Green Bay), Penn State (road), USC (home), and Iowa (road). Outside of those four games, Wisconsin should be able to win at a high clip, and I'd expect the Badgers to win at least one of the daunting matchups.

The reality is that Fickell has been just as unlucky as he has been bad. His quarterback rooms have been decimated by injuries since he arrived in Madison. If the team can keep Old Dominion transfer Colton Joseph healthy, the Badgers will have a dynamic dual-threat playmaker under center. They'll also have a much-improved offensive line, and the defense is absolutely loaded — with Fickell having done great work to keep Mason Posa and Cooper Catalano around.

Things should start trending in the right direction for Wisconsin this year, and eight wins should be the goal.



Jack Layne

BYU TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+330)

BYU is an Over team for me when looking at regular-season win totals (8.5), but I'm not stopping there. The Cougars have some tough games on the schedule, including road games against TCU and Utah and a home game against Notre Dame. But those games also give BYU a shot at picking up the kind of wins the committee wanted to see last year.

This team should be extremely productive on both sides of the ball. On offense, LJ Martin, one of the nation's top running backs, is back to work behind a tremendous offensive line. Bear Bachmeier should also make significant strides as a passer in Year 2 under center. On the other side of the ball, the Cougars have seven starters back from last year. They also added Cal transfer linebacker Cade Uluave, who has the potential to turn this defense into a top-10 unit in the nation.

Kalani Sitake has done remarkable things since taking over his alma mater, but the best is yet to come. This BYU team has been knocking on the door of a College Football Playoff appearance, and this feels like a year in which the Cougars will kick it off its hinges.

BEN STEVENS



NEW MEXICO TO WIN THE MOUNTAIN WEST (+265)

If you don't know the name Jason Eck by now, you will soon. Eck led the Lobos to nine wins in 2025, the most by a New Mexico head coach in his first year in program history. And from that history-making team, 14 starters return for the 2026 campaign, including QB Jack Layne. In fact, 63% of the Lobos' production from last season is back in Albuquerque this year, which is the second-most among Group of Six programs and the most in the Mountain West. In today's climate of college football, to have that sort of buy-in across your program is saying something. And in the newly reshaped Mountain West, the Lobos have both UNLV (the favorites) and NDSU (the third-best price) at home, where New Mexico was a perfect 6-0 in 2025. Invest early in Albuquerque.

UCLA OVER 6.5 WINS (+110)

If there are 1,000 Bob Chesney believers, I am one. If there are 100 Bob Chesney believers, I am one. If there is only one Bob Chesney believer, it is me. If there are zero Bob Chesney believers, I have perished from this Earth. So yes, I think UCLA's new head man is going to continue the winning ways he has at every previous stop, at every level of college football, in Westwood from the very start. Everybody in CFB is clamoring for the next Curt Cignetti. To me, Cignetti is the anomaly, not the standard. But if you wanted a coach to follow in that archetype, it is Chesney. In 16 years as a CFB head coach, from D-III to the FBS level, he has a .717 win percentage with eight conference titles to boot. And after leading JMU to the CFP last season, I think Chesney will continue to prove his acclaim in the Big Ten. There are 42 newcomers to the Bruins in 2026, 10 of them following Chesney from James Madison, including All-American Wayne Knight (RB/all-purpose returner) and Sahir West (EDGE and Sun Belt Freshman of the Year). QB Nico Iamaleava returns under the new staff, and I'm betting on him to take a stride this season. UCLA's schedule is also quite manageable, playing only three of the six teams that have a win total of 8.5 or better, and facing three of the five teams with a win total of 5.5 or lower.

KENTUCKY OVER 4.5 WINS (-148)

When asked at SEC Media Days why he believes he can win in Lexington, new head coach Will Stein responded, "Because of me, honestly." And I trust Stein. The Wildcats are investing in this football program, as seen in the portal class entering this new season. Notre Dame transfer Kenny Minchey steps in at the QB spot, and if you've seen what Stein has done for the college careers of Bo Nix, Dillon Gabriel, and Dante Moore, I have little doubt he will elevate Minchey as well. The Cats also added some nice pieces at the skill positions in CJ Baxter (RB, Texas), Jovantae Barnes (RB, Oklahoma), Nic Anderson (WR, LSU), etc. Faring well against Kentucky's schedule is going to be no easy task, but such is life in the SEC. The Wildcats have notable home games against Alabama, LSU, Vandy, Florida, and in-state rival Louisville this season, and I would not be stunned if Stein guides UK to a win in two or three of those games to get us Over this win total comfortably.

DUSTIN SWEDELSON

DARIAN MENSAH TO WIN THE HEISMAN TROPHY (16-1)

We have reached a point in the new landscape of college football where we know which programs handle the transfer portal best. Maybe no team has been better at finding QBs in the portal and maximizing their abilities than the Miami Hurricanes. When Cam Ward arrived in Coral Gables two seasons ago, he had averaged 3,484 passing yards and 24 passing touchdowns at Washington State over two seasons. He then transformed into a Heisman Trophy finalist and eventual No. 1 overall draft pick by throwing for over 4,300 yards and 39 touchdowns. In 2025, Carson Beck transferred from Georgia. Beck finished with a career high 30 touchdowns and led Miami to the National Championship Game. Now enters Darian Mensah, fresh off 3,900-plus passing yards and 34 touchdowns, while leading Duke to the 2025 ACC Championship. If he gets the bump that his predecessors received in their one year playing in offensive coordinator Shannon Dawson's offense, then he will be in New York for the Heisman ceremony at the end of the year. How does he get there aside from scheme? Well, throwing to sophomore superstar WR Malachi Toney certainly helps. Toney led the nation in receptions and the ACC in receiving yards and receiving touchdowns last year. He is capable of taking short passes a long way, which will not only boost Mensah's stats but also open up opportunities for others in the offense. That's where Cooper Barkate comes in. Barkate was with Mensah at Duke last season after previously playing at Harvard. He quickly became Mensah's go-to target, finishing with 72 catches, 1,106 yards and seven TDs. They already have chemistry and, combined with Toney, could form the best QB-plus-two-WR combination in the nation. The Hurricanes also added WR transfer Cam Vaughn, who had 800 yards and five TDs two seasons ago at Jacksonville State, and former South Carolina WR Vandrevius Jacobs, who was productive with 548 yards and four touchdowns a season ago. Factor in the Miami defense lost some major pieces to the NFL, which could result in more shootouts and gaudy stats for Mensah. This number is also just too long for the QB of the largest favorite to win a Power Four league.

KENTUCKY OVER 4.5 WINS (-150)

There is a lot to like here, even with the challenges of Kentucky being a basketball school. The Wildcats scored 17 points or fewer six times in 2025 and still found five wins on the schedule. If the offense can improve a little, they should be able to at least maintain five wins and get over this total. That's why they turned to Will Stein. While Stein has never been a head coach before, he did guide an Oregon offense the last three seasons that turned Bo Nix into a first-round pick, Dillon Gabriel into a third-round pick, and took Dante Moore from UCLA cast-off to potential top-five draft pick. His latest QB project is Kenny Minchey. Minchey didn't see a lot of action at Notre Dame, but he battled current Heisman Trophy favorite CJ Carr down the stretch for the starting job a year ago. Multiple beat reporters appeared on VSiN and thought Minchey had the clear leg up in the competition. Whether those practices in South Bend, Indiana, translate to game results in Lexington, Kentucky, remains to be seen, but it does let us know the talent the Wildcats have under center this year. Stein is making sure he has big targets to throw to, bringing in big-body transfers at WR. LSU transfer Nic Anderson (6'4", 205 lbs.) had almost 800 yards and 10 TDs at Oklahoma in 2023, Southern Utah transfer Shane Carr (6'2", 185 lbs.) went for over 1,300 yards and 10 TDs over the last two seasons, plus Arkansas transfer Ja'Kayden Ferguson (6'2", 184 lbs.) and UAB transfer Xavier Daisy (6'3", 212 lbs.) join the fold as well. The run game gets a huge upside boost from former Texas RB

CJ Baxter, who missed all of 2024 with an injury. And most importantly, they rebuilt this offensive line with four-star transfers in Tennessee OT Lance Heard, Ohio State OG Tegra Tshabola, and Baylor center Coleton Price. The defense brings in plenty of talent from all over, but the reason I bet this is the improved offense. If they reach their potential, they could even get to six wins this year.

NC STATE OVER 7.5 WINS (+105)

Dave Doeren enters Year 16 at NC State, where he has only failed to get to eight wins one time since 2020. It may not be pretty, and it may not excite you, but Doeren wins football games. The offense that scored 30.2 points per game a year ago lost some juice with Hollywood Smothers and its five leading pass catchers leaving. But QB CJ Bailey returns for his third season and his second under offensive coordinator Kurt Roper. It's shocking Bailey stayed in Raleigh; he could have made a lot of money in the portal after throwing for 3,105 yards, 31 total TDs and nine INTs. His return is why this team can get to eight wins. He is a special player and should have some help via the transfer portal. WR Davion Dozier comes in from App State, where he had 448 yards and five TDs in eight games last year. The Wolfpack also added two underutilized Miami WR transfers in JoJo Trader and Chance Robinson. While 5'8" Victor Snow might be the most interesting, as he is coming off 815 yards and eight TDs at Buffalo. LT Jimarion McCrimon, who joins from East Carolina, was a massive addition. But most notably, the defense, which allowed the second-most explosive plays in the ACC, has been upgraded with five potential starters. Edge Harvey Dyson led the American with eight sacks a year ago. LBs Raul Aguirre (Miami) and Da'Karri Nelson (Penn State) could make big impacts. And the secondary adds Georgia CB Ondre Evans and Penn State safety King Mack (58 tackles, 3 passes defended) to go with second-year starting CB Brian Nelson. Even if they lose the opener at Virginia, which feels like a coin-flip game, Richmond, Appalachian State, Wake Forest, Stanford, Florida State and North Carolina all feel like wins. So we would need just two more wins from going to Virginia, at Vanderbilt, vs. Cal, vs. Duke and vs. Syracuse. That feels very doable.

ARKANSAS UNDER 4.5 WINS (-166)

Ryan Silverfield was a weird hire for Arkansas. It felt like he did less with more in the American Conference and was somehow rewarded. Well, congratulations, Ryan. You're an SEC head coach, with possibly the fewest resources, and in your first year you have a top-five most difficult schedule. Week 2 at Utah is followed a week later by Georgia. Tulsa on September 26th feels like a win, but it's a dreaded lookahead spot with a trip to Texas A&M looming the following week. They finish with a brutal run starting on Halloween with Missouri at home, at an improved Auburn squad, vs. South Carolina, at Texas and vs. LSU. I don't see four wins, let alone five. It looks like, at best, wins are vs. North Alabama, Tulsa and maybe at Vanderbilt. Whichever QB the Razorbacks choose will lack experience. AJ Hill played in two games for Memphis last year, going 19 for 32, 223 passing yards, one TD and one INT. KJ Jackson saw action in five games for Arkansas, completing 33 of 54 passes for 441 yards and three TDs. Expect this team to keep the ball on the ground with a deep stable of RBs: Braylen Russell is a bruiser, Sutton Smith ran for 669 yards and seven TDs at Memphis, and Jasper Parker was a four-star recruit at Michigan. Former Boise five-star Chris Marshall went for 30 catches, 574 yards and two TDs last season, but can they get him the ball consistently? They brought in some big transfers to fix a defense that was 129th in scoring a year ago, but this doesn't seem like a team built to play from behind. And I expect them to be behind a lot this year with that schedule.



Braylen Russell

HOUSTON OVER 8.5 WINS (+130)

I hate going back to the same team two years in a row in this guide, but they cashed last year going 10-3, and I like their chances this year. QB Connor Weigman returns for his senior season after throwing for 2,705 yards, 36 total touchdowns and nine interceptions. Weigman returns to the same OC, Slade Nagle, for the first time in his career. The Cougars added former Tulane RB Makhhi Hughes, who couldn't crack the rotation in Oregon last year despite a 2024 in which he ran for 1,400 yards and had 17 total touchdowns. Another huge transfer was UTSA TE Patrick Overmyer, who will fill the void left by Tanner Kozio. Overmyer will get plenty of looks in this Houston offense. Oregon State transfer WR Trent Walker compiled over 1,700 yards the last two seasons in Beaverton. Plus, Amare Thomas is back coming off 966 yards and 12 TDs a year ago. The Cougars are relying on the portal to fill holes on defense. But the secondary will anchor this group with All-Big 12 CB Will James back. Former Stephen F. Austin safety Javion White had 50 tackles in 2025. While Oregon DE transfer Ashton Porter, Oklahoma State DE De'Marion Thomas and Ole Miss LB Jaden Yates came to Houston to get more playing time. If Fritz and DC Austin Armstrong can bring this team together, not only do I like Over 8.5 wins, but I think 16-1 to win a wide-open Big 12 could be interesting as well.

MITCH MOSS

TEXAS TECH TO WIN BIG 12 CHAMPIONSHIP (+100)

I usually don't bet conference winners this far out at even money, but I couldn't resist this year with the Red Raiders. The team lived up to the transfer-portal-paying-hype last year by clobbering 11 opponents by 20+ points. The 2024 version was loaded to the gills and lost a lot of talent, but reloading the six-shooters is a way of life in the state of Texas.

Two notes to consider:

From the Pick Six Previews magazine: your average Big 12 team has averaged two four-star transfers over the past two recruiting periods. Texas Tech inked 20. The team avoids playing BYU and Utah in the regular season, and their most difficult conference opponents are all at home.

Professional bettor Brad Powers told Follow The Money on April 28th, 2026: "I downgraded them three points because I thought there would be some regression. Then, with the Sorsby news, I downgraded them another 3.5 points. So about a full touchdown downgrade since last year's team, and I still have Texas Tech favored in every single game — per my power ratings — by double-digits. That's how easy of a schedule Texas Tech has."

OLE MISS OVER 8.5 WINS (+150) & TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+220)

Shop around if you're high on this team, as the numbers are all over the map. There is a ton to like about the 2026 version of Ole Miss despite losing Lane Kiffin as head coach. If you only watched games last year and paid attention to nothing else, QB Trinidad Chambliss popped as the best or second-best player in the country, along with Fernando Mendoza. I don't care about his age, nor does being a Division II transfer mean anything to me. The kid plays the position at an extremely high level and is back to lead what will once again be a high-powered machine on offense. Playing with a chip on their shoulder was evident after Kiffin bailed on the team, and I expect that to be a theme this season as well. However, momentum isn't really a thing, especially from one season to the next. What will be a real carryover is the overall firepower on offense along with Chambliss. RB Kewan Lacy was first-team All-SEC and rushed for 1,567 yards and scored 24 TDs. The team lost playmaking WRs on offense, but loaded up once again via the portal. The same is true on defense. Kiffin poached key players on that unit to tag along to LSU, but Ole Miss signed eight four-star transfers on that side of the ball. I loved what I watched with the Rebels last season, and am betting on it to continue this year.

ADAM BURKE

GEORGIA SOUTHERN OVER 3.5 CONFERENCE WINS (-115)

The Eagles will take some lumps early in the season with non-conference tilts against Clemson and Houston, but those could help in the long run with a very manageable conference schedule. Two of their Sun Belt road games are quite winnable - Coastal Carolina and Georgia State - and I also expect them to put up terrific passing numbers with multi-time transfer Max Johnson in a pass-happy scheme. That could help them with a home upset of James Madison or a road dub over Old Dominion, which would certainly lock this in. Even if they don't get either of those, I have them favored five times in conference play and therefore think this one can get there.

APPALACHIAN STATE TO WIN SUN BELT (18-1)

Even though my pick in our chart was Old Dominion, the 18-1 price tag here is worthy of a dart throw. Dowell Loggains, who was the OC at South Carolina in 2023-24, including LaNorris Sellers' spectacular redshirt freshman season in '24 with 674 rushing yards (4.1 YPC) and 2,534 passing yards (18/7 TD/INT ratio), now has more dual-threat options in Boone than he previously had. When Loggains took over at App State, Sellers saw a drop of nearly 5% in his completion percentage, threw for fewer yards, and only had 1.8 YPC. While Loggains wasn't the only loss for the Gamecocks, I do think it's a fair illustration how much better the App State offense can be this season with more mobile QBs and a faster tempo. Old Dominion and James Madison, the two top teams in the East, play at App State and the Mountaineers avoid Louisiana and Troy, the two top teams in the West.

OREGON TO REACH BIG TEN CHAMPIONSHIP GAME (+100)

DraftKings had Ohio State and Indiana as odds-on prices to make it to the Big Ten title game as of the Tuesday before the CFB Guide came out. Per my numbers, Oregon is an underdog once (at Ohio State) and -5.5 or higher in every other Big Ten game. They avoid Indiana, host Michigan and Washington, and I think they have to win one of the two main road games, USC and Ohio State, to get there. The Buckeyes and Hoosiers both feel vulnerable given their significant losses on both sides of the ball. Ohio State under OC Arthur Smith is worrisome, given that they'll likely squander their talent advantage again and play slowly, which makes them more beatable. Dan Lanning in big games is a worry, but I don't think the Week 10 game against Ohio State is unattainable. The common opponents between Oregon and Indiana, who do not play each other, are USC, Nebraska, Northwestern, Ohio State, Michigan, and Washington. Oregon has four of those games at home, including Michigan and Washington, two places the Hoosiers have to go, and even Nebraska if the Cornhuskers wind up being any good.

SEAN GREEN

JARON-KEAWE SAGAPOLUTELE TO WIN HEISMAN TROPHY (65-1)

The lefty from Hawaii is going into Year 2 as the starting QB at Cal, and the sky is the limit. He threw for 3,454 passing yards and 18 TDs as a freshman while taking them to a 7-6 record. JKS showed off in some late-season big-game wins for Cal when they upset SMU and Louisville, while throwing for 653 yards in those games. If he can elevate this Cal team above its seven-win season last year, he'll be in the mix for the Heisman.

AIR FORCE TO WIN MOUNTAIN WEST (+550)

Air Force is returning 14 starters, and this is one of Troy Calhoun's better teams in years. Calhoun has never had a losing season three years in a row, so I expect the Falcons to turn things around in a big way. Their QB Liam Szarka is the perfect fit for the Air Force style of attack, as he's a great dual-threat QB. In Szarka's starts, Air Force averaged 39 PPG, and with some small improvements this Air Force team will be flying high.

WES REYNOLDS

PENN STATE TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+450)



Last year, Penn State had College Football Playoff and championship aspirations. Then, they lost in 2OT at home in the big showdown with Oregon, and that started a six-game losing streak, and James Franklin was fired after consecutive losses as over 20-point favorites at UCLA and vs. Northwestern. The Nittany Lions rallied under interim coach Terry Smith, still on staff as assistant head coach, to make and win a bowl game.

Enter Matt Campbell and 24 transfers (seven offensive starters and four defensive starters) from Iowa State. Call it Curt Cignetti and James Madison to Indiana from two years ago on steroids. Campbell led Cyclones football to its best decade in program history with seven bowl appearances in 10 seasons. All of college football wondered when he was going to make the leap to the bigger job, and he finally did when Penn State came calling. Campbell was not AD Pat Kraft's first choice, but he may end up being the right choice.

The core of his Iowa State teams are now wearing dark blue and white in Happy Valley. Those teams went 17-7 over the last two seasons, including four victories over ranked teams, with QB Rocco Becht not missing a start in over three seasons despite playing through a variety of injuries. Shoulder surgery kept him out of spring practice except for 7-on-7.

Like Cignetti and the JMU crew from two years ago at Indiana, these players and coaches will have a chip on their shoulders to prove they can play against the step up in class against tougher competition. Also like that group, Penn State is the beneficiary of a highly favorable schedule. Out of their 12 games, the Nittany Lions are likely underdogs in only two of them, at Michigan and at Washington. They avoid all of the consensus top-three Big Ten teams in the regular season: Oregon, Ohio State, and Indiana.

While this is the first year for these Iowa State players in the Big Ten, they do have experience playing physical, grinder Big Ten games against Iowa in the CyHawk game, where the Cyclones defeated Kirk Ferentz and Iowa in three of the last four years.

If the College Football Playoff shakes out like last year, there will be four SEC teams, Notre Dame getting in this year, the Big 12 champion, the ACC champion, the Group of Six representative, and four Big Ten teams. The battle for the likely fourth Big Ten spot should be between Michigan, USC, and Penn State. Michigan and USC both have more difficult schedules.

Penn State, unlike last season, gets to also be the beneficiary of lower expectations.

We Are!

RUTGERS UNDER 5.5 WINS (-150)

Greg Schiano's second act at Rutgers in the Big Ten has proven to be more difficult than his first act in the Big East. The NIL era has been even less kind to the Scarlet Knights, and player retention is certainly an issue, as Rutgers needs to make a decision to put more resources into the program if they are going to be competitive in the Big Ten.

Rutgers does have two All-Big Ten offensive skill players in RB Antwan Raymond and WR KJ Duff. However, they will have a new QB responsible for getting them the ball, as "The Greek Rifle" Athan Kaliakmanis has graduated. Boston College transfer Dylan Lonergan and returner AJ Surace are battling for the starting job. The Scarlet Knights are also looking for three new starters on the OL.

Defensively, though, is where Rutgers has been an absolute mess. The Scarlet Knights ranked 125th nationally in total defense, which is why Travis Johansen was brought in as defensive coordinator after coaching South Dakota to the FCS Playoffs last year.

While the non-conference slate is manageable (vs. UMass, at Boston College, vs. Howard), Rutgers is likely to be an underdog in every conference game except for perhaps the season finale against Michigan State.

Schiano's teams always fight hard, but the talent, especially on defense, is still lacking.

Matt Campbell





Rayshon Luke



FRESNO STATE TO WIN PAC-12 (+650)

Fresno State went 9-4 in Matt Entz's first season in the San Joaquin Valley. Entz is used to winning, having brought North Dakota State two FCS Championships.

The Bulldogs are still looking for a QB, but have arguably the best running attack, and certainly the most returning production with Rayshon Luke and Bryson Donelson combining for nearly 1,400 yards last season. Fresno has the best lines in the new Pac on both sides of the ball, and they were ranked No. 2 nationally in pass defense (only Ohio State ranked higher). In this day and age of the portal, it is rare to bring back more than a couple of starters, but the Bulldogs have six back on defense. Plus, they get conference favorite Boise State at home.

STORMY BUONANTONY

FLORIDA STATE UNDER 6.5 WINS (-160) & ALT UNDER 5.5 WINS (+155)

Mike Norvell's squad went from 60 to 0 real fast. They had 10 wins in 2022 and 13 in 2023, but ever since missing out on the playoff that year with Jordan Travis' injury, it's been a mess. Things fell apart with a 2-10 season 2024, and just when you thought they were poised for a bounce back upsetting Alabama and starting 3-0 to open last season, they withered away again, losing seven of their last nine games. Since the day the CFP field was announced in 2023, FSU has gone 7-18 with a -25 turnover margin. With that in mind, if I were a head coach on the hot seat, I'm not sure Ashton Daniels would be who I'd hitch my wagon to as QB1. In his career at Stanford and Auburn, he's been inconsistent at best and erratic and turnover-prone at his worst. While, generally speaking, the roster overall should be better this season — they have the 22nd-best "newcomer class" in the country per ESPN — have you seen their schedule? It's the hardest by far in the ACC. They face SMU right away in Week 2, at Alabama in non-conference Week 3, vs. Virginia, at Louisville on a short week, at Miami, vs. Clemson, at Pitt, vs. NC State and close out the season against Florida. In summation, they face all the tough teams in the ACC and a pair of SEC teams out of conference. I could easily see this team being discouraged and checked out by October. Six wins felt generous to me, and I'm betting it as such.

PENN STATE OVER 8.5 WINS (-160) & TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (+425)

While the Matt Campbell hire feels a little like a consolation prize after Penn State's coaching search largely resulted in its primary targets leveraging the job for extensions at their current schools, I still think they still landed a solid coach. While he's not the recruiter James

Franklin is, Campbell is a great evaluator, developer and the type of coach who tends to do more with less. And I don't know what he did to curry favor with the CFB scheduling gods, but they are looking down on him for Year 1 at State College. No Ohio State, no Oregon and no Indiana on the slate. They face a trio of G5 non-conference opponents in Marshall, Temple and Buffalo. Their toughest game on paper is against USC on October 10th, but they'll have a White Out crowd at their back and Lincoln Riley's USC teams have historically struggled on the road. While games at Northwestern and Washington aren't gimmes, none of their Big Ten opponents outside of SC have a win total over 7.5. As for the roster Campbell will field, he brought over his most trusted soldiers from Iowa State, including QB Rocco Becht. His season was derailed by injuries last year, but he is back healthy, paired with his former OC Taylor Mouser, top WRs Brett Eskildson and Chase Sowell and stud TE Ben Brahmer. If Becht stays healthy, I think this is a 10-win team, and if they're winning double-digit games in the Big Ten, it would be hard to keep them out of the CFP, so I don't hate a sprinkle on them getting into the 12-team field.

IOWA OVER 7.5 WINS (-120)

This was a win total I wrote up in the guide last year that cashed, and I'm going back to the well with Kirk Ferentz in Year 28. Iowa hasn't gone a full non-Covid season with fewer than eight wins since 2014, averaging 8.7 wins per season over the last 12 years, though two of those seasons include bowl wins. I think that continued success carries over with one of the more manageable schedules in the Big Ten. They'll have a three-week stretch that's really challenging early, at the Big House, hosting Ohio State and then at Washington, but after that, there's no obvious loss on the schedule, especially considering the success they had against some of those conference opponents last season. A big part of why I liked Iowa so much last year was I thought they finally had a QB, but even with Mark Gronowski coming up far short of my expectations, they still won all the games they were supposed to, and that's my thought entering this season. Ferentz says the QB competition between Hank Brown and Jeremy Hecklinski could go deep into August, but I don't think either will be much of a downgrade from the QB play they got last season. Some may shy away from Iowa seeing they are last in the Big Ten in returning production on defense, which made Ferentz, who had never had more than nine total transfers in a single season, grab eight players from the portal just on that side of the ball — but I trust Phil Parker to get the most out of those players. The Hawkeyes' defense in recent history under Parker hasn't ranked lower than sixth in DEF SP+ since 2018. They were ninth in the nation in total defense last year, 20th in 2024, seventh in 2023 and second in 2022. They should be stout again. I have the Iowa trend of eight-win seasons paying us out again in 2026.



Byrum Brown

NORTH DAKOTA STATE ALT UNDER 8.5 WINS (+145)

Their original win total of 9.5 is an obvious Under in my opinion, but for a team I view as an eight-win group, I'd rather get plus-money odds on an alternate Under 8.5 than lay upwards of -220 on Under 9.5. While I do feel like the championship culture and style of play they've established for years at the FCS level will translate immediately to the new-look Mountain West, the first-year schedule isn't friendly for a program making the jump. They see an old friend in Jacksonville State in non-conference play, and it's among the favorites to win Conference USA. They also have to face the top three teams in the league on the road at UNLV, at UNM and at Hawaii. They also face the elevation in not only Albuquerque but Colorado Springs, with another road trip to a potential MW sleeper in Air Force. From a talent standpoint, they might have been in a better position making the jump last season compared to now, when they're breaking in a new starting QB (Nathan Hayes is a fifth-year senior but a career backup), a new skill group and a largely new secondary. They're always good up front and should be again, but there are other teams in the Mountain West that I'm more inclined to grab a win-total Over or view as a contender to win the conference.

NEW MEXICO TO MAKE COLLEGE FOOTBALL PLAYOFF (20-1)

This is a perceived value play for me more than anything else based on the current state of the Group of Six. While I do give Boise State the benefit of the doubt as the top G6 team entering the season, given their program history and returning production, it caught me a bit off guard to see them so short at 5-1 to make the CFP. I think that the G6 spot could be pretty wide open this year. Even in the Mountain West, most books have New Mexico and UNLV on the same line, pricing-wise, to win the conference and for season win totals, yet UNLV is 10-1 to make the CFP compared to UNM at 20-1. Navy and UTSA out of the American are 9-1 and 10-1, respectively. The math isn't math-ing for a Lobos team that was one of the best surprise teams in college football last year. In Jason Eck's first year with the program, he led New Mexico to a 9-3 mark and brought back more production than any other team in the conference. A lot will hinge on the health of starting QB Jack Layne, who's returning from an elbow injury, but all reports are that he's in a great place to start camp. Looking at the schedule as well, it appears pretty manageable. Yes, they're at Oklahoma in Week 3 and have a tough road trip to Hawaii, but they host UNLV, who they beat in Vegas last year, host Air Force, who they beat in Colorado Springs, and host newcomer NDSU. Those are potential marquee games that, if won, could put New Mexico at 10-2 or 11-1 at the end of the year, heading to a MW title game and a potential CFP berth.

OREGON TO REACH BIG TEN TITLE GAME (+100)

I personally view Oregon as the favorite in the Big Ten, so seeing them behind both Ohio State and Indiana just to make the title game — and with a plus sign in front of the price — felt like a must-play. They avoid Indiana altogether, who appeared to be their Kryptonite last season; road trips to USC and Ohio State will be challenging, and they do welcome Michigan and Washington to Autzen Stadium, but my gut says they don't lose more than one of those games. Oregon has lost a combined five games the last three years. They're the model of consistency, and with the talent they have coming back paired with the schedule they face, I'd be pretty shocked if they weren't playing for the Big Ten title in December.

JONATHAN VON TOBEL



AUBURN OVER 6.5 WINS (-115)

Call me crazy, but I'm buying the USF takeover at Auburn. Byrum Brown amassed 4,238 yards both passing and rushing and totaled 42 touchdowns last year, and is one of the best quarterbacks in the country. He's got two receivers from USF with him in the fold, and defensive coordinator DJ Durkin remains on staff. He's been one of the best defensive play-callers in college football over the last three seasons. The Tigers have everything they need to be a surprise contender in the SEC.

NORTH DAKOTA STATE UNDER 8.5 WINS (+140)

I'm not buying the seamless transition the market is selling with North Dakota State. The Bison lost a lot of talent to the portal, including two First-Team All-MVFC offensive linemen. The team has just 10 starters back and brought in zero starters via the portal. They only bring in three Power Four transfers, one of which is a punter from Minnesota. Programs at the top of the Mountain West — UNLV and New Mexico — retooled with transfer talent from all over the country. The internal promotion and development might work in the long run for NDSU, but not this season.

AIR FORCE OVER 7.5 WINS (+120)

Look out, this is going to be one of the surprises of the season. The Falcons averaged 29.8 points and 407 yards per game last season. They ranked 11th in the country EPA per play and 15th in both EPA per play when rushing the football and rushing success rate. Liam Szarka is back at quarterback to lead that unit, and the defense should be improved with Steve Russ, a former Troy Calhoun staff member, as defensive coordinator. Eight or more wins and a potential berth in the Mountain West title game are in the cards for the Falcons.

HAWAII TO WIN MOUNTAIN WEST (+600)

Hawaii is one of two teams — Air Force being the other — that could absolutely steal the Mountain West from the projected teams at the top. The 'Bows have preseason Mountain West Offensive Player of the Year Micah Alejado back. The signal-caller completed 66% of his passes for 3,106 yards while tossing 24 touchdowns to nine interceptions last season with a bad ankle. Now that he has a season under the belt, and is healthy, he and this team will be great. They also get to host New Mexico, UNLV and NDSU.

GUNNER STOCKTON TO WIN HEISMAN TROPHY (20-1)

I'm buying 'Stock' on the Georgia signal-caller. He was great in the fourth quarter last season — he completed 83.6% of his passes for 8.5 yards per attempt and totaled nine touchdowns — and now has a season under his belt. He leads a title contender and plays in the SEC. The moments will be there, and so too will the benefit of the doubt from the voters. Simply put: He's the starting quarterback for a 10-plus win team in the SEC. I'll take my chances.

JOHN MCKECHNIE

MIAMI (FL) TO WIN NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP (11-1)

Roster continuity is overrated in this era, and the elite teams are able to reload on the fly by being the best at transfer portal management. The 'Canes came up just short of a national title last year, and despite some notable losses in the trenches, they might be even better this year. They upgraded at quarterback with Darian Mensah coming in from Duke, and he'll have his top target, Cooper Barkate (72/1106/7), joining him. Adding that combo to an offense that already has elite line and skill position talent like Malachi Toney, and we have something serious cooking in Coral Gables. The ACC being this down means that Miami is almost a shoo-in to make the dance; the question will center on whether they're battle-tested enough come CFP time. The talent is absolutely there for a title run.

TEXAS A&M UNDER 8.5 WINS (-120)

There's some regression headed for College Station after things broke the Aggies' way time and again in 2025. Marcel Reed has limitations that are hard to fix in one offseason, and he'll no longer have KC Concepcion to bail him out. Mario Craver is fun, but not an engine for a passing game. The defense will keep them in games, but the offense will let them down in key spots. Games in Baton Rouge, Tuscaloosa and Norman will be tough, as will hosting Texas and Tennessee.

TIM MURRAY

FLORIDA STATE UNDER 6.5 WINS (-175)

Let's start with the schedule. Florida State plays a pair of SEC teams, at Alabama and Florida, including a revenge game against the Crimson Tide after the Seminoles beat Alabama 31-17 last year in Week 1. The ACC did not do Florida State any favors this year. Of the Seminoles' eight ACC games, FSU will play the top seven teams in the conference according to the DraftKings oddsboard: Miami, SMU, Louisville, Clemson, Virginia, Pittsburgh, and NC State.

Thinking back to last year, Florida State reached No. 8 in the AP Poll before losing a Friday night game in OT to Virginia. The Noles dropped off a cliff and missed a bowl game for a second straight year after going

13-0 and winning the ACC back in 2023. Florida State could be due for some positive regression after losing four one-score games last season, but the talent is questionable. Entering 2024, Florida State brought in 23 transfers, which was rated the sixth-best transfer portal class according to 247 Sports. This season, the Seminoles added 23 transfers that ranked just 27th nationally according to 247 Sports. Additionally, going from Tommy Castellanos to Ashton Daniels, who transferred from Stanford and Auburn, is a big drop-off.

We will know what Florida State has this season on Labor Day Monday against SMU. The Noles are a short home underdog against the Mustangs. If FSU drops that game, it would not be surprising if the season started to spiral quickly and head coach Mike Norvell were fired midseason.

GEORGIA TO WIN SEC CHAMPIONSHIP (+310)

There is a lot of hype entering this season surrounding Texas, and understandably so. Arch Manning is back, the Longhorns are loaded at wide receiver (Ryan Wingo, Cam Coleman, Emmett Mosley), and Texas attacked the portal hard (#3 class per 247 Sports). With that said, it seems like the two-time defending SEC champion is being slightly overlooked entering this year. QB Gunner Stockton is back for another season after leading Georgia to a conference championship last year. RB Nate Frazier also returns to lead one of the top running back rooms in the country. Frazier led the Dawgs with 947 rushing yards and 11 rushing touchdowns last year. Per Bill Connelly's SP+, Georgia is eighth nationally in returning production (68%) and No. 5 in returning production on defense. The wide receiver room is certainly a question mark entering the year, with the departure of Zachariah Branch and TE Oscar Delp, but Georgia Tech transfer WR Isiah Canion has the potential to be a breakout star.

For an SEC schedule, Georgia made out pretty well. The Dawgs avoid Texas, LSU, and Texas A&M while hosting Oklahoma in late September. Georgia is projected to be a favorite in all 12 games, with road trips to Alabama and Ole Miss as the shortest spreads. Georgia will have an elite defense this year, and it would be surprising if they are not back in Atlanta for the SEC Championship.

TEXAS TECH TO WIN BIG 12 CHAMPIONSHIP (+100)

The offseason in Lubbock was quite the circus with the Brendan Sorsby drama. The day he was ruled ineligible, I bet Texas Tech to win the Big 12. The Red Raiders have the most talent in the Big 12, and the schedule they were handed was a gift. If you take a look at the Big 12 futures odds, Texas Tech avoids BYU, Utah, and Kansas State, who are 2-4 on the oddsboard, and then hosts the next four teams on the oddsboard (Houston, Arizona State, Arizona, TCU).

Texas Tech has a good chance to be a double-digit favorite in every game this season because the talent on their roster is far superior to the rest of the Big 12. Brett Ciancia summed it up well in Pick Six Previews: "Over the past two cycles, the average Big 12 team has signed two four-star transfers. Texas Tech signed 20."

Lastly, head coach Joey McGuire has said on multiple occasions that he expects QB Will Hammond to be ready for Week 1. Hammond tore his ACL last October. If the Red Raiders aren't playing in the Big 12 Championship it would be a disastrous season in Lubbock.

LINCOLN KIENHOLZ TO WIN HEISMAN TROPHY (100-1)

A long-shot Heisman winner has hit the last two years, so why not a third?

Indiana QB Fernando Mendoza was 55-1 to win the Heisman before the season last year, and Colorado's Travis Hunter was 50-1 two years ago. Back in 2016, Louisville QB Lamar Jackson entered the season 100-1 to win the Heisman. Could another Cardinal QB be primed to bring home some hardware in New York City this December?

Obviously this is quite the long shot, but Lincoln Kienholz is a relatively unknown commodity entering the college football season. Kienholz was a four-star recruit out of South Dakota back in 2023. After spending three seasons at Ohio State, Kienholz transferred to Louisville this offseason. Kienholz is a unique athlete, and that is something that could be unlocked by Louisville head coach Jeff Brohm. Brohm has always thrived with transfer quarterbacks, including Miller Moss, Tyler Shough, and Jack Plummer. Kienholz will have an opportunity to announce his presence with authority, Nuke LaLoosh style, in a Week 1 showdown against Ole Miss on Labor Day Sunday. After Louisville hosts SMU in Week 3, we will know if this ticket has some legs or if it is toast.

A full-page photograph of a football player, Matt Youmans, in action. He is wearing a gold helmet with a silver facemask, a blue long-sleeved jersey with gold accents and the number 13, and gold pants. He is holding a brown football with both hands, ready to throw. The background is a blurred crowd of spectators at a stadium.

LEAVE NO DOUBT

IRISH TOP MATT YOUMANS'
PRESEASON TOP 50

by Matt Youmans

Revenge is often an overrated angle, and Notre Dame coach Marcus Freeman is not playing it up. After the Fighting Irish got the cold shoulder from the College Football Playoff committee in December, Freeman didn't complain or look for sympathy. He took accountability, essentially saying his team was left out because it left some doubt.

Notre Dame lost its first two games by a total of four points, but those were by far the most important games of its season. In the end, a 10-game win streak against a bunch of cupcakes and a couple of fringe ranked teams was not enough to overcome a slow start. That's why "Leave No Doubt" is Freeman's motto for the Irish this season.

While there is some revenge to exact against Miami, the Irish are focused on the bigger picture and will be playing the role of avengers — an angry group seeking to inflict punishment and setting out for retributive justice for the way last year's team was wronged by the committee and the system.

Of course, Notre Dame is always polarizing, inspiring either love or hate with little middle ground, similar to In-N-Out Burger, LeBron James or a high-ranking political figure. While some haters will say it was right to exclude the Irish from the playoff, the truth is it was wrong. Oddsmakers know it was wrong, and the power rankings showed it.

At the end of last season, Notre Dame was No. 3 in my power rankings, behind only Ohio State and Indiana. A flawed CFP system that included James Madison and Tulane also welcomed Southeastern Conference pretenders Oklahoma and Alabama into the 12-team bracket. There is no doubt the Irish would have been favored against all four of those teams.

On a neutral field in a playoff game, the Buckeyes might have been the only team favored against the Fighting Irish. How about the Hoosiers? Indiana, the 16-0 national champion, has not been defeated since it was a 7-point underdog in a 27-17 loss at Notre Dame in the first round of the 2024 playoff.

That's a long setup for this announcement: Notre Dame is No. 1 in the VSiN preseason Top 50 for 2026. The decision is not unanimous and the numbers show it's a close call. This poll is a result of power rankings created by me and professional handicapper Paul Stone. After the two sets of rankings produced an average number for each team, there were some ties. In this case, I broke the tie and ranked the Irish at the top with Oregon No. 2 and Ohio State No. 3.

"My top five are bunched tightly, but when in doubt, go with Ohio State," said Stone, who ranks the Buckeyes first. "Is there a more complete team than Oregon on paper entering the season? I don't think so. If someone wants to argue that Notre Dame should be the preseason No. 1, I'm not offering much resistance."

"There isn't much separating the top seven teams," Fox Sports analyst Chris "The Bear" Fallica said. "One could throw Texas, Georgia, Ohio State, Oregon, Indiana, Miami and Notre Dame into a hat and pull them out in any order and I'd probably say, 'OK, I can buy that.'"

Notre Dame will be favored in all 12 games and likely a double-digit favorite in 10 of those games. Sophomore quarterback CJ Carr, who debuted in a 27-24 loss at Miami last year, is one of the Heisman Trophy favorites along with Texas quarterback Arch Manning.

"The Irish enter the season with the nation's top defense, and few would be surprised if Carr leaves Manhattan with the Heisman the second Saturday in December," Stone said.

Notre Dame also has a "kind schedule," Stone noted, but the schedule is not a factor in my power rating. I favor the Irish over every other team on a neutral field, even if it's by only one or two points against the other teams in the top five. Miami and BYU are the strongest opponents set to face the Irish, who open the season against Wisconsin at Lambeau Field.

If you start a power rating simply by grading the coach, quarterback and defense, who rates better than Notre Dame? The Irish return 10 starters on defense, Carr matured quickly as a freshman with 24 touchdown passes to six interceptions, and Freeman guided the Irish to the national title game after the 2024 season.

In his preview magazine, Phil Steele noted, "This defense is loaded with depth and talent at every level. All nine sets of my power ratings are calling for 12-0. ND has playoff experience and a great shot at winning it all."

It can be argued Oregon deserves to be No. 1, and the same goes for Ohio State. The Ducks, who return quarterback Dante Moore and much more, could be the fourth different Big Ten team in four years to win it all. The Buckeyes bring back quarterback Julian Sayin and wideout Jeremiah Smith, who has 163 receptions for 2,558 yards and 27 touchdowns in two seasons, but they lost seven NFL draft picks on the defensive side.

"The Buckeyes have to replace some elite talent in the back two levels of their defense, but they have allowed less than 13 points a game in each of the past three seasons, and Jeremiah Smith is arguably the most impactful player in college football," Stone said. "The Ducks are stacked on both lines and have no apparent weaknesses. One of these days (coach) Dan Lanning is going to break through and bring a championship to Eugene. Might this be the year?"

Fallica is hesitant to buy the Longhorns, who have reached the playoff two of the past three years and bring back Manning and dominant defensive end Colin Simmons, among many others. Everything is bigger with Texas, which is reportedly spending \$35 million on its player roster and close to \$25 million on its coaching staff.

"I think Texas is No. 1 heading into the season based solely on numbers, but factor in the schedule and they certainly could go 9-3," Fallica said. "The Longhorns predictably did well in the transfer portal and Manning played at a much higher level over the second half of the season."

The Longhorns went 7-1 to finish last season, with Georgia dealing the loss, 35-10. The Bulldogs are a popular pick to win the SEC with a stronger defense and veteran quarterback.

My power rankings, combined with Stone's rankings, form the VSiN preseason Top 50.

**PAUL STONE'S
TOP 10**
OHIO STATE
OREGON
NOTRE DAME
GEORGIA
TEXAS
MIAMI
INDIANA
LSU
MISSISSIPPI
OKLAHOMA

**MATT YOUMANS'
TOP 10**
NOTRE DAME
OREGON
GEORGIA
OHIO STATE
TEXAS
INDIANA
MIAMI
LSU
BYU
MISSISSIPPI

1. NOTRE DAME

If sophomore quarterback CJ Carr stays healthy, the Irish should go 12-0 and claim the top seed in the CFP. Two running backs were drafted in the NFL's first round and both (Jeremiah Love and Jadarian Price) were from Notre Dame, yet that position is still loaded with talent and features Aneyas Williams, Kedren Young and Nolan James. The offensive line ranks among the nation's best, and Ohio State transfer Quincy Porter boosts the receiving corps. The defense is elite. This team is highly motivated and shows no weaknesses.

2. OREGON

Ducks coach Dan Lanning lost his defensive coordinator (Tosh Lupoi, California) and offensive coordinator (Will Stein, Kentucky) to head coaching jobs, but he doesn't lose often. Lanning is 48-8 in four years, including 17-1 in Big Ten play the past two years. The downside is the Ducks were blown out by eventual national champions Ohio State and Indiana in playoff games the past two years. Senior quarterback Dante Moore will be an early NFL pick, and the defensive front is arguably the nation's strongest.

3. OHIO STATE

The Buckeyes are as good as it gets at the offense's most important positions with quarterback Julian Sayin (77% completions and 32 touchdowns last season), running back Bo Jackson (1,090 yards) and receiver Jeremiah Smith (87 receptions, 1,243 yards and 12 touchdowns). The defense must replace a lot of NFL talent, though reloading is seldom a problem. The Michigan monkey, meaning a four-game losing streak, is finally off coach Ryan Day's back, but now he's got a Curt Cignetti problem and plays at Indiana in October.

4. GEORGIA

In the so-called 'year of the quarterback' in college football, Georgia senior Gunner Stockton is often overlooked because he's not a top NFL prospect. But he's a clutch dual-threat playmaker (24 passing and 10 rushing touchdowns last season), and leading rusher Nate Frazier also returns. Two-time national championship coach Kirby Smart is 40-5 in SEC play since 2021. "Georgia's offense might lack the firepower of some of the other contenders, but the Dawgs can run the ball and play sound defense," Stone said.

5. TEXAS

Big checks were written to get Arch Manning more offensive help as coach Steve Sarkisian brought in Auburn receiver Cam Coleman and NC State running back Hollywood Smothers. Sark also made a sharp hire by getting Will Muschamp as defensive coordinator. "Manning rebounded nicely last season after stumbling through September," Stone said. "Manning has the top trio of receivers (Coleman, Ryan Wingo and Emmett Mosley) in the country, plus his running ability will be showcased more this season."

6. INDIANA

The Hoosiers were No. 16 in these power rankings a year ago, so are they underrated again? Curt Cignetti, 27-2 in two seasons in Bloomington, is a former Nick Saban assistant who looks like the new version of him. Top overall pick Fernando Mendoza and seven other draft picks are gone to the NFL. Cignetti sees something in TCU quarterback Josh Hoover (42 turnovers in 31 career starts). Indiana ranked No. 2 in scoring defense (11.7 ppg) but will be near the top again despite losing some key players.

7. MIAMI

Cignetti got a few scares last season, and one came from the Hurricanes in a 27-21 national title game. Duke transfer quarterback Darian Mensah could be an upgrade from Carson Beck. Mensah benefits from the return of leading rusher Mark Fletcher (1,192 yards, 10 touchdowns) and leading receiver Malachi Toney (109 catches, 1,211 yards and 10 touchdowns). First-round draft picks Rueben Bain and Akheem Mesidor will be missed on the defensive front. Miami has never won the ACC and coach Mario Cristobal's team is the odds-on favorite (-135).

8. LSU

New coach Lane Kiffin used LSU's resources to hit the transfer portal and the haul was huge. The top quarterbacks (Sam Leavitt, Arizona State; Husan Longstreet, USC) are transfers, and so are the three top receivers (Eugene Wilson, Florida; Jackson Harris, Hawaii; Winston Watkins, Ole Miss) and veteran left tackle Jordan Seaton (Colorado). Senior linebacker Whit Weeks and transfer end Princewill Umanmielen (Ole Miss) lead the defense.

9. MISSISSIPPI

Pete Golding won two of three playoff games after taking over for Kiffin, and his job as head coach was made much easier when dual-threat quarterback Trinidad Chambliss (4,464 total yards and 30 touchdowns) was granted an extra year of eligibility and running back Kewan Lacy (1,567 rushing yards, 24 TDs) returned. Golding lost two defensive starters to LSU, but the defense will be strong. The schedule is brutal, so Golding will be tested.

10. OKLAHOMA

Senior quarterback John Mateer had a hot hand to start last season, but he never was the same after a hand injury. Expectations are high for Mateer, who suddenly resembles a bodybuilder and should put up big numbers. Brent Venables is not a great head coach, but he can coach defense with the best of them, and the Sooners return senior safety Peyton Bowen and several other veterans from the nation's No. 7 scoring defense (15.5 ppg).

11. TEXAS A&M

In two years in College Station, coach Mike Elko has won 19 games. His 11-2 record last season was a bit of a downer considering the Aggies lost their final two games to Texas and Miami. Junior quarterback Marcel Reed can look electric at times, but he slumped and put up a total of only 20 points in the losses to the Longhorns and Hurricanes. It's not going to be easy for Elko to replace 10 players who were NFL picks.

12. TEXAS TECH

This news did not fly under the radar: quarterback Brendan Sorsby, a transfer from Cincinnati, departed the program amid a gambling controversy. Will Hammond is returning from a knee injury and should be fine as the starter when healthy. Red Raiders coach Joey McGuire had the money to reload after losing five defensive starters to the NFL. Texas Tech is the Big 12 favorite (-105) thanks to a ridiculously soft schedule.

13. BYU

The second choice on the Big 12 odds board is BYU (+550), but coach Kalani Sitake does not draw an easy schedule. Back-to-back games versus Notre Dame (Oct. 17) and at UCF (Oct. 24) will be pivotal. The Cougars are loaded with experience and talent on defense. The offense is in good hands with sophomore quarterback Bear Bachmeier (3,033 passing yards and 15 touchdowns; 527 rushing yards and 11 TDs) and star running back LJ Martin.

14. USC

It's time for Lincoln Riley to reach the CFP in his fifth year as USC coach. Two seniors — quarterback Jayden Maiava (3,711 passing yards, 24 touchdowns) and running back Waymond Jordan — will operate behind one of the nation's top offensive lines. The defensive line is also a strength. Riley pulled in a top-ranked recruiting class and needs to win now. The Trojans host Ohio State, Oregon and Washington and play at Indiana, Penn State and Wisconsin.

15. ALABAMA

It was never going to be easy to follow Nick Saban, and Kalen DeBoer has made it look difficult. DeBoer is 20-8 in two seasons, which is OK at most programs but not in Tuscaloosa. Replacing first-round quarterback Ty Simpson will be either Keelon Russell or Austin Mack. There are all sorts of questions all over the offensive depth chart. There is plenty of talent on defense, but the Crimson Tide will enter the season as a boom-or-bust mystery team.

16. WASHINGTON

The Demond Williams saga in January threatened to derail Washington's season before it started. Williams entered the transfer portal for a better deal, but the dual-threat quarterback jumped the gun and basically was forced to return to Seattle. Williams totaled 3,676 yards and 31 touchdowns. Third-year coach Jedd Fisch (9-4 last season) should carry playoff hopes into November, when the Huskies host Indiana and Penn State and finish at Oregon.

17. PENN STATE

Rocco Becht should feel at home in Happy Valley, and that's because the senior quarterback will have more than 20 of his former Iowa State teammates with him. Matt Campbell took the Nittany Lions' coaching and took a bunch of Cyclones, including leading rusher Carson Hansen, along for the ride. D'Anton Lynn, formerly at USC and UCLA, was a good hire as defensive coordinator. The schedule sets up well for Campbell to win at least eight games.

“

18. FLORIDA

Jon Sumrall arrives from Tulane as the new coach and should be a breath of fresh air in Gainesville after fans suffered through the ill-fated “Sun Belt” Billy Napier era. Whether the Gators finish in the top half of the SEC will depend on who wins the QB job (Georgia Tech transfer Aaron Philo or last year's backup, Tramell Jones) and how well he plays. Leading rusher Jadan Baugh (1,170 yards) returns, and the defense should be solid.

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19. LOUISVILLE

A year after losing the quarterback competition at Ohio State, Lincoln Kienholz will probably help the Cardinals win a lot of games in the ACC. Jeff Brohm, who coached Purdue to the Big Ten title game in 2022 and has a 28-12 record at Louisville, is an overachiever. Leading rusher Isaac Brown is back and an experienced offensive line looks outstanding. The Cardinals host SMU and Pitt and don't play Miami and Clemson.

20. MICHIGAN

The hiring of Kyle Whittingham, who spent 21 years as Utah's coach, was a home run even if he's lost something off his fastball. He inherits a high-priced quarterback project in sophomore Bryce Underwood, who failed to develop under the previous staff. The backup QBs are promising if Underwood flops, and leading rusher Jordan Marshall returns. A big question mark shadows this Wolverines team, which Stone ranks 15th and I rank 28th.

21. IOWA

The Hawkeyes had Indiana on the ropes early last season and blew the game, 20-15, in Iowa City. Iowa also let one get away in an 18-16 loss to Oregon. Still, the Hawkeyes finished 9-4 with a bowl win as 28th-year coach Kirk Ferentz always seems to get to at least eight wins. He lost seven NFL draft picks and has to hope Hank Brown, last year's backup quarterback, and running back Kamari Moulton can move the offense.

22. UTAH

Devon Dampier is a dynamic playmaker who passed for 24 touchdowns and rushed for 10 last season when the Utes went 11-2. Dampier and leading returning rusher Wayshawn Parker will help new coach Morgan Scalley keep up Utah's high standards for winning. Scalley was the defensive coordinator for 10 years under Kyle Whittingham. The Utes do have some concerns on the offensive and defensive lines for the first time in a long time.

23. HOUSTON

It took only one year for coach Willie Fritz to turn around the Cougars, who went from 4-8 in his debut to 10-3 last season. Houston's offense should be high-flying as veteran quarterback Conner Weigman (36 total touchdowns, including 25 through the air) comes back and is backed up by No. 1-ranked recruit Keisean Henderson. Top receiver Amare Thomas (12 TDs) returns. A defense full of veterans appears strong enough to survive in the Big 12.

24. CLEMSON

Change with the times or get left behind. Dabo Swinney is finally changing by hitting the transfer portal. He also changed offensive coordinators and brought back Chad Morris. Christopher Vizzina (and maybe freshman Tait Reynolds) replace longtime starting QB Cade Klubnik, who was drafted by the Jets. Senior end Will Heldt leads a defense that lost five NFL draft picks. Clemson hosts Miami on Oct. 3 and could contend for the ACC title.

25. SMU

Senior quarterback Kevin Jennings has playoff experience from two years ago, and although he slipped some and turned the ball over too often last season, hopes are high for the offense (32.2 ppg) with the addition of Cal transfer running back Kendrick Raphael. The defense is being rebuilt. Rhett Lashlee has been a bet-on coach in ACC play — the Mustangs upset Miami as 10-point underdogs last year — with a 38-16 record in four years in Dallas.

26. TENNESSEE

Volunteers coach Josh Heupel finds ways to create offense and he needs to develop highly-touted freshman quarterback Faizon Brandon in a hurry. It will help to have leading rusher DeSean Bishop (1,076 yards, 16 touchdowns) in the backfield again. New defensive coordinator Jim Knowles, formerly at Penn State and Ohio State, will make a difference.

27. MISSOURI

The Tigers started 5-0 last season and won eight regular-season games prior to a disappointing bowl performance. Ahmad

Hardy (1,649 yards and 16 touchdowns) is the catalyst for the offense and arguably the best running back in the SEC. Ole Miss transfer Austin Simmons is the new quarterback. One problem is a new-look defense that won't be improved.

28. ARIZONA

With 72 touchdown passes as a three-year starter in Tucson, Noah Fifita is one of the Big 12's best and he gives the Wildcats a shot in almost every game. Arizona (9-4) lost three games by six points or fewer last season. The Wildcats will get tough tests on the road in September (BYU), October (Texas Tech) and November (Kansas State).

29. VIRGINIA TECH

One team's trash is another team's treasure. Penn State fans are happy to get rid of coach James Franklin after 12 years and Virginia Tech fans are thrilled to have him. The Hokies (3-9) will be much improved due to Franklin's ability to recruit talent. “Big Game” James gets a soft launch with the toughest road games (Clemson, SMU and Miami) late in the season.

30. SOUTH CAROLINA

Overhyped as a top NFL prospect a year ago, quarterback LaNorris Sellers slumped as a passer as the Gamecocks slipped from 9-4 to 4-8. Sellers totaled 25 touchdowns in 2024 and that number dipped to 18 last season. Are you buying or selling? Shane Beamer is coaching a more experienced team, but the schedule is brutal and there are concerns in Columbia.

31. MINNESOTA

P.J. Fleck is money in bowl games (7-0) as coach of the Golden Gophers, and he's consistent with 8-5 records each of the past two years. He's got a good shot to be a winner again with quarterback Drake Lindsey and leading rusher Darius Taylor returning. Senior end Anthony Smith is one of the Big Ten's best defensive players.

32. KANSAS STATE

Bill Snyder, one of the all-time greats, and Chris Klieman, who retired in December, are extremely tough coaching acts to follow at K-State. Collin Klein, a former Wildcats quarterback and offensive coordinator, takes over the top job. Veteran quarterback Avery Johnson and leading rusher Joe Jackson return, but multiple holes must be filled on defense.



33. TCU

After Indiana swooped in to swipe quarterback Josh Hoover, the Horned Frogs looked to the Ivy League for an answer. Jaden Craig, a first team all-conference passer at Harvard, will run coach Sonny Dykes' offense. Since getting crushed 65-7 by Georgia in the 2022 national championship game, TCU has posted records of 5-7, 9-4 and 9-4. Dykes destroyed Bill Belichick and North Carolina 48-14 in last season's opener. The rematch is in Ireland.



34. VIRGINIA

The Cavaliers cashed in on close-game luck last season by going 3-0 in overtime games and winning another by two points, so don't count on another 11-win season for coach Tony Elliott. Virginia has two new quarterbacks, Beau Pribula (Missouri) and Eli Holstein (Pitt). This team looks weaker, but a soft schedule excludes Miami, Clemson and Louisville.

35. AUBURN

New coach Alex Golesh, who won 23 games in three years at South Florida, has an offensive background and brought senior quarterback Byrum Brown with him. While leading rusher Jeremiah Cobb comes back, the entire receiving corps is new and includes two USF transfers. Junior linebacker Xavier Atkins (team-high 84 tackles, nine sacks) leads an inexperienced defense. The Tigers finished 1-7 in SEC play last year.

36. BOISE STATE

The Broncos (9-5 last season) won the last three Mountain West championships and are +170 favorites to win the eight-team Pac-12. If they don't win the league, a defensive decline will likely be the reason. Boise could boast the conference's top quarterback, Maddux Madsen, and top running back, Dylan Riley. Madsen must bounce back after regressing last season.

37. GEORGIA TECH

Dual-threat quarterback Haynes King led the Yellow Jackets to nine wins and put a scare into Georgia, but he's gone and replaced by Alberto Mendoza. The brother of Heisman Trophy winner Fernando Mendoza transferred from Indiana, and running back Justice Haynes transferred from Michigan. The defense looks strong. Brent Key has been a bet-on coach as an underdog (15-5 ATS).

38. NEBRASKA

UNLV transfer quarterback Anthony Colandrea is the key to coach Matt Rhule's success in his fourth season with the Cornhuskers. Colandrea totaled 4,080 yards (3,459 passing and 621 rushing) and 32 touchdowns for the Rebels. Nebraska (7-6 last season) faces Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana but should have enough talent to go bowling again.

39. NORTH CAROLINA STATE

Junior quarterback CJ Bailey had offers if he hit the transfer portal, but the 6-6, 210-pounder stayed with the Wolfpack. Bailey passed for 3,105 yards and 25 touchdowns while adding six rushing scores during an 8-5 season. Leading rusher Hollywood Smothers transferred to Texas, but No. 2 rusher Jayden "Duke" Scott is back. Miami is not on the ACC schedule.

40. VANDERBILT

Adjusting to life after quarterback Diego Pavia, a Heisman finalist, won't be easy, but the Commodores won't be bad. Jared Curtis, the No. 2-ranked incoming freshman QB, can lean on a pair of seniors — running back Sedrick Alexander and wideout Junior Sherrill. Vandy coach Clark Lea (10-3 last season) will field another solid defense.

41. ARIZONA STATE

Kenny Dillingham has done an amazing coaching job at Arizona State. He followed a 3-9 debut season with records of 11-3 and 8-5. His fourth season will probably fall somewhere in the middle as in 6-6. With quarterback Sam Leavitt transferring to LSU, the Sun Devils turn to Kentucky transfer Cutter Boley. The defense lost nine starters.

42. PITTSBURGH

As a freshman, Mason Heintschel passed for 16 touchdowns and showed some running ability in his nine starts. Don't expect to see a "Heintschel for Heisman" campaign, but

he's got potential and is supported by a veteran offensive line. Panthers coach Pat Narduzzi, who's no game-management genius, will put together a decent defense.

43. ILLINOIS

Senior quarterback Katin Houser, a transfer from East Carolina, replaces Luke Altmyer in coach Bret Bielema's run-oriented offense. The top three running backs return, but the offensive line is mostly new and won't be improved. It's a rebuilding year for the Fighting Illini defense. Bielema's team will take steps back after going 9-4 and 10-3 the past two seasons.

44. CALIFORNIA

Tosh Lupoi, the former Oregon defensive coordinator, takes over in Berkeley. The Golden Bears lost most of their best defensive players and will rely on their offense to lead the way. Sophomore quarterback Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele seems to be a rising star after passing for 3,454 yards and 18 touchdowns for a 7-6 team.

45. NORTHWESTERN

A 19-19 record does not reflect how well David Braun has coached up the Wildcats in his three years. Braun inherited a seemingly hopeless 1-11 team. Northwestern's strength should be its defense, although the coaching staff is intriguing with Chip Kelly taking over as offensive coordinator. The new QB is likely to be Michigan State transfer Aidan Chiles.

46. OKLAHOMA STATE

Mike Gundy is out after two decades, and new coach Eric Morris brings a big offensive reputation with him from North Texas. He's also bringing quarterback Drew Mestemaker, who led the nation in passing yards (4,379) last year. The Cowboys (1-11 last season) could be the nation's most improved team.

47. UCLA

The Bruins were bad last season at 3-9, but they did upset Penn State 42-37 as 24-point underdogs in Pasadena. Bob Chesney, who coached James Madison to the CFP, is rebuilding with several transfers and will energize the program. Will he be able to rejuvenate inconsistent young quarterback Nico Iamaleava?

48. WISCONSIN

There was a lot of excitement in Madison when Luke Fickell was hired as coach in 2023, but the thrill is long gone after back-to-back losing seasons. The Badgers' quarterback play was abysmal a year ago, and that should change with the addition of dual-threat Old Dominion transfer Colton Joseph. Wisconsin's schedule ranks as the Big Ten's easiest.

49. BAYLOR

After everything fell apart at Florida, young quarterback DJ Lagway transferred to Baylor. Lagway, once hyped as one of the nation's top recruits, can be electric if he's playing with confidence. He's replacing Sawyer Robertson, who passed for 31 touchdowns last season. Bears coach Dave Aranda must improve the defense and win or he's done in Waco.

50. NAVY

After an 11-2 season, with the losses to Notre Dame and North Texas, the Midshipmen must replace star quarterback Blake Horvath. Braxton Woodson, who's 6-3 and 215 pounds, will have big shoes to fill. Navy has a physical offensive line and a solid defense, but the key to the season will be Woodson, who's fast and skilled but has not played much.



QUANTIFYING COLLEGE FOOTBALL'S BIGGEST ADVANTAGE: HOME-FIELD ADVANTAGE

by Adam Burke

3.5 POINTS (SU + ATS HOME WIN% OF 70% OR HIGHER)

Alabama	North Dakota State
Boise State	Notre Dame
BYU	Ohio
Georgia Southern	Ohio State
Indiana	Oregon
Iowa	SMU
Jacksonville State	Texas
James Madison	Texas Tech
Marshall	Toledo
Miami (OH)	UTSA
Mississippi	Washington
Missouri	Western Michigan

3 POINTS (65-69.99%)

Arizona	LSU
Ball State	Miami (FL)
Central Michigan	Oklahoma
Connecticut	South Florida
Delaware	USC
Georgia Tech	Utah State
Hawaii	Washington State
Kansas State	Western Kentucky

2.5 POINTS (60-64.99%)

Arkansas State	Minnesota
Colorado	Navy
Duke	North Carolina State
Eastern Michigan	North Texas
Florida State	Penn State
Georgia	Pitt
Illinois	TCU
Iowa State	Tennessee
Kennesaw State	Tulane
Liberty	UNLV
Memphis	Utah
Michigan	Vanderbilt

Note: Any team between 40-59.99% has a standard HFA of 2 points.

1.5 POINTS (35.01-39.99%)

Arkansas	Middle Tennessee
Baylor	Northern Illinois
Florida Atlantic	Stanford
Michigan State	UCLA

1 POINT (35% OR LOWER)

Charlotte	Nevada
Georgia State	Purdue
Kent State	Tulsa
Massachusetts	UTEP

The college football landscape is changing literally and figuratively this season, as the Pac-12 is back with eight teams, the Mountain West looks a lot different, and a team from California will play in the MAC. Home-field advantage is probably more dynamic than ever, in the sense that it depends on a variety of factors. Having one simple baseline probably isn't enough, but having something is better than nothing and that has been my approach over the last several seasons.

Playing at home is never really going to be a bad thing, so there is still an inherent "advantage", even though its value will always be subjective. Weather, rest, travel, and all of the usual factors come into play, but there are others. A night game in Death Valley (either one) is going to carry more weight than a noon kickoff against a Group of Six school. A school where the basketball

program outpaces the football program could see home-field lessened once November rolls around and students are more invested in hoops. How invested are the alums and adults in that particular program nowadays? It's very hard to pin down these qualitative factors.

But, at least if we have some kind of value in mind, we can adjust accordingly, whether we actually attempt to quantify all of those variables or just keep them in mind when handicapping the game. To find that baseline, I've decided to take a three-year sample of home records, as that would seem to capture the team's current state and also create a sample size large enough to minimize some noise. With over 100 different head coaches and thousands of transfers in FBS over the last three seasons, even three years may be tricky, but it seems like a happy medium.

Based on the straight up (SU) and against the spread (ATS) home win percentages for these teams, I've created a series of buckets. The standard home-field advantage I've settled on is two points. For teams that sit between 40% and 59.99% at home, their home-field advantage is two points. For teams above or below those thresholds, the HFA varies.

For this season, there are 24 teams with my max HFA of 3.5 points for having a SU + ATS Win% of 70% or higher. There are 16 teams with 3 points of HFA for a SU + ATS Win% of 65-69.99%. There are 24 teams with 2.5 points of HFA for 60-64.99%.

On the flip side, there are eight teams with 1.5 points of HFA for 35.01-39.99% and eight teams with 1 point of HFA for 35% or lower. Again, I want to stress that I consider these numbers to be starting points for creating point spreads on games. All of those factors and variables mentioned above should be considered on a case-by-case basis.



The home records are courtesy of Steve Makinen and his extensive database, so my thanks go out to our VSin Analytics Guru.

Here are those teams for the 2026 season.

With the HFA numbers established for all 138 FBS teams, those are then put together with my college football power ratings to produce a game spread. If my power ratings have Ohio State 14 points better than USC and the game is in Columbus, that would make my line on the game Buckeyes -17.5 with their 3.5 points of home-field advantage.

This season, I expect to have some deviations on a week-to-week basis in conference play, since we have Sacramento State in the MAC, Northern Illinois in the Mountain West, and Texas State in the Pac-12, just as some examples of conference realignment and how those teams will be visiting new venues, playing at elevation, or having long travel with some odd kickoff times. Similarly, teams that go to them will be doing something different.

As I continue to say, home-field advantage is an "inexact science", but a true case of 'something is better than nothing' and at least there is some sort of criteria that teams meet in order to have the values that they do.

2026

college football win totals I'm betting now

by Steve Makinen

After going back through the coaching changes, the Stability Scores, the transitional systems, the recruiting rankings, and playing out the schedule by my power ratings, I've locked in on my team season-win total bets that I will be making. You'll see that based upon the recent success I've enjoyed, I've again opted for more Unders than Overs this season.

My overall four-year record is now 57-42-2 for 57.6%, highlighted by 34-17-1 (66.7%) on Unders. I have become much better at identifying teams that are due for struggles. Hopefully I can see a clearer picture of which teams will improve this year.

14 teams I project to go Over their DraftKings season win props

BOISE STATE - OVER 7.5 WINS

The Broncos +1.7 difference represents one of the biggest I've ever had in projecting wins against the schedule using my power ratings, and I even double- and triple-checked the numbers to be sure. I think the oddsmakers are giving a bit too much credit to the strength of the new Pac-12, and in my opinion, BSU is the obvious favorite. QB Maddux Madsen returns as a senior, and head coach Spencer Danielson is in his fourth year with the program. With the opener at Oregon the only likely loss I see on the 2026 slate, I think Boise takes the newly formed Pac-12 and exceeds the modest win total of 7.5. I'd probably even be willing to bet it up to at least 8.5.

FRESNO STATE - OVER 6.5 WINS

Fresno State surprised me last season by exceeding expectations in head coach Matt Entz's first year. Sometimes it takes a coach a bit of time to find his footing. In terms of FSU football, Entz did not, as his team finished 9-4. He responded to that success by adding an extremely improved recruiting class as graded by 247Sports. Considering the Bulldogs' success last year, and now transitioning into the remade Pac-12, the future looks bright for Entz & Co. With 13 starters back, they also qualify for a unique transition system, indicating that of the 141 teams over the last five years that brought back at least four starters more than the prior season, only 40 got worse. The average improvement of the group that didn't drop off was a winning percentage bump of 15% (+3.2 wins) and ATS rise of 6.7%.

FLORIDA ATLANTIC - OVER 5.5 WINS

Second-year head coach Zach Kittley's first team at Florida Atlantic was, if nothing else, fun to watch. The Owls had the most offensive plays per game and the most passing yards per game in the country last year. However, they also led the nation in giveaways. Now, with a year in the new system under their belt, I see a lot of reasons for potential

improvement. QB Caden Veltkamp is back for his senior year after throwing for over 3,600 yards last season, along with 11 other starters. FAU qualifies for three different transition angles as well. 1) Over the last five seasons, there have been 18 teams that managed to go .500 or better against the spread despite having a -0.8 or worse turnover differential per game. Of those teams, only four regressed in the follow-up campaign, and the average improvement for the entire group was 8.7% SU while winning 1.4 more games on average. 2) In the "there's nowhere to go but up" category, since 2021, there have been 21 teams that have won four or fewer games in a season while enduring a -0.8 or worse turnover ratio. Only two of those 21 teams regressed. The average win improvement for the other 19 teams was 2.3 per season, and the SU win % upgrade was 15.3%. 3) Of the 141 teams over the last five years that brought back at least four starters more than the prior season, only 40 got worse. The average improvement of the group that didn't drop off was a winning percentage bump of 15% (+3.2 wins) and ATS rise of 6.7%. With a lot of American Conference teams facing questions this season, I think this has the chance to be FAU's best football year since the Lane Kiffin days.

HOUSTON - OVER 8.5 WINS

The move to the Big 12 has helped Houston put together its best five-year recruiting classes on record. Under head coach Willie Fritz, a new, consistent standard is being established. Last season, this team won nine games in the regular season and then beat LSU in a thrilling Texas Bowl game. QB Conner Weigman, a former A&M transfer, had a huge year for the Cougars and is back for his senior season. In all, there are 19 starters back, making Houston one of two teams with a Stability Score of 18 on my scale, with Notre Dame being the other. It should also be noted that teams returning 17+ starters have combined to go 55.7% ATS in the first four weeks of the last five college football seasons, meaning this program should be able to carry over the momentum of last year's solid finish. Plus, of the 141 teams over the last five years that brought back at least four starters more than the prior season, only 40 got worse. The average improvement of the group that didn't drop off was a winning percentage bump of 15% (+3.2 wins) and ATS rise of 6.7%. This should be a big year for Fritz & Co.

ILLINOIS - OVER 7.5 WINS

After getting a winner with the Illini last year on their Over win total prop, I'm going back to the well in 2026. Fifth-year coach Bret Bielema brought in another solid recruiting class this spring, best on record, in fact, and it's clear that this program is reaping the benefits of winning on the field. Bielema's group has won 19 games over the last two seasons and has improved from a Big Ten bottom-feeder as far as recruiting is concerned to a mid-level destination. To me, it seems obvious that this program has turned a corner and is here to stay. They do lose QB Luke Altmyer, but replacing him is another former Big Ten starter, Katin Houser from Michigan State. There are 11 other starters in place. The Illini do face Ohio State and Oregon, but in all honesty, it's hard to see them as a likely loser in any other game.

KANSAS STATE – OVER 7.5 WINS

It came as a bit of a shock for KSU fans when Chris Klieman announced his retirement as head football coach in December. He stepped away citing personal health and family considerations and did it with the Wildcats coming off a 6-6 season, but also with a reasonable amount of starting experience coming back. Leading that charge is third-year starting QB Avery Johnson. In Klieman's place steps Collin Klein, who gets his first head coaching gig after spending seven seasons in Manhattan as an offensive assistant before serving as Texas A&M's OC the last two years. As I look at last season, KSU was so close to bigger successes, but suffered five of its six losses by six points or fewer. That, combined with Johnson returning as a senior, makes this an ideal situation for Klein to step in and have some immediate positive impact. He played at KSU from 2008-12 so already has a tremendous bond with the program, and his hiring was met with a lot of optimism. With no Texas Tech or BYU on the 2026 slate, I think this team has an outside shot at contending for a Big 12 title game berth.

SOUTH ALABAMA – OVER 5.5 WINS

Sometimes, there's no rhyme or reason to figuring out why a specific improvement or decline in a recruiting season occurs. I don't think South Alabama fans care about the how or why here, but in his third season, coming off a disappointing 4-8 record, head coach Major Applewhite was able to secure his best recruit/transfer class this spring, with the 86th ranking beating last year's grade by 31 positions. Several of the newcomers are P4 transfers. It gives USA at least a shot at getting a lot better on the field this fall. Also encouraging is the fact that QB Bishop Davenport is back for his senior season after leading this team to 26.5 PPG last year. The Sun Belt Conference doesn't have a lot of teams contending for the role of favorite this season, and the Jaguars' conference slate is mild at best. I like this team to return to a bowl game this fall.

SOUTH CAROLINA – OVER 6.5 WINS

South Carolina dropped by five wins in the regular season last year, and quite honestly, it was unexpected. The Gamecocks lost four games by 10 points or less, all against teams that were ranked in the Top 25 at the time. Fortunately for head coach Shane Beamer, many of the key players decided to steady the ship and come back for another run, including QB LaNorris Sellers, this team's offensive star. This is another team with several key transition systems to consider, among them: 1) One of the biggest improvements in wins from one season to the next you'll find comes when nine or more offensive starters, including the quarterback, return from a team that won 50% or less of its games outright in the prior season. The average win increase is +2.7 wins & 13.3% SU. 2) There have been 43 teams over the last five seasons that have endured losing seasons despite outscoring their opponents. Of those, 17 of them brought back 13 or more starters, including their quarterback. The collective improvement of this group of teams was about 20% SU (+3.4 wins) and 8.9% ATS. These teams combined to go 56.5% ATS, a profit-making collection. Beamer's team has a realistic shot of heading to Florida in October with a 4-1 record at least. A win there would give this team a ton of momentum in returning to where they were two years ago.

SYRACUSE – OVER 4.5 WINS

There are a lot of reasons why teams can yo-yo from one season to the next nowadays in college football. Losing a lot of key players from a successful team the prior year is at the head of the list in terms of why teams might drop. That clearly affected Syracuse in 2025, as the Orange went from 10-3 to 3-9. Turnovers can also be big, and they were for 'Cuse last season. However, in the "there's nowhere to go but up" category, since 2021, there have been 21 teams that have won four or fewer games in a season while enduring a -0.8 or worse turnover ratio. Only two of those 21 teams regressed. The average win improvement for the other 19 teams was 2.3 per season, and the SU win % upgrade was 15.3%. Overall, recruiting at Syracuse has seen an upgrade under Fran Brown, who begins his third season with the program. He is obviously a pretty strong salesman, as

he was able to land the second-highest-rated class the Orange have seen in the last 17 years, despite coming off a 3-9 record. With QB Steve Angeli back for his senior season, and the ACC looking down for 2026, I think the Orange have a good chance to rebound.

TEXAS – OVER 9.5 WINS

The pressure on Texas and QB Arch Manning last year was palpable; you could sense it every time they took the field. Expectations were beyond reasonable control. The fact that the Longhorns still won 10 games despite a 5-7-1 ATS record shows just how much even the experts behind the bookmaking counter thought of this group. Well, they say that all is well that ends well, and head coach Steve Sarkisian's team won its final three games of 2025, and Manning exploded statistically in those contests. The offense put up 456 yards in the bowl win over Michigan. That is the momentum they will be carrying into 2026. In addition, a program that achieved its first-ever No. 1 recruiting ranking in the country on record last year, then followed it up with a No. 3 rank, seems due for lofty goals. There is one key transitional system I have my eye on regarding Texas: Only three of the last 33 teams since 2021 that had nine or more offensive returning starters, including the quarterback, from a team that won 45% or less of its games against the spread in the prior season, got worse. The average win increase of the other 30 teams was +2.0 wins, 6.7% SU, and 16.8% ATS. These teams were also about 53% ATS. Two additional wins would put this team at 11-1. I think that's realistic with the talent that is in place here and a QB 100% ready to fulfill his immense promise.

TEXAS A&M – OVER 8.5 WINS

VSIN college football fans will know that I throw the term "stability" around often, particularly in the offseason. One of the more stable teams prepping for 2026 across the country is head coach Mike Elko's Texas A&M squad, a team that reached the CFP last year but was stymied by Miami at home. With Elko in his third year now in College Station, I think last year's growth of three wins will prove to be a big stepping stone forward for the program into elite territory. QB Marcel Reed returns again for the Aggies as a junior, along with 17 other starters! Teams returning a starting quarterback for at least a second straight season as a starter usually show nice improvement, typically by about 0.9 wins per season (+1.4% win pct). When you add the same head coach/offensive coordinator to the recipe along with at least seven other total offensive returning starters, the improvement jumps by 1.3 wins per season and 53.3% ATS combined, a profitable group. Of the 38 teams, only 12 won fewer games. Similarly, only three of the last 33 teams since 2021 that had nine or more offensive returning starters, including the quarterback, from a team that won 45% or less of its games against the spread in the prior season, got worse. The average win increase of the other 30 teams was +2.0 wins, 6.7% SU, and 16.8% ATS. These teams were also about 53% ATS. As I said earlier... very stable situation here, and a very talented roster and coaching staff. That's usually a great combination.



Marcel Reed



Nico Iamaleava

UCLA – OVER 6.5 WINS



After guiding James Madison to the CFP last season, a lot of power conference schools had interest in Bob Chesney, and he eventually settled at UCLA, where he takes over for DeShaun Foster, who guided the Bruins through two seasons of 8-16 football. The 2025 UCLA team was a massive disappointment, particularly after landing QB Nico Iamaleava in the transfer portal. Nico was a lightning rod for the program and was vilified when the team struggled and praised during the shocking three-game Big Ten winning streak in October. Chesney does get Iamaleava back for 2026, plus numerous Power Four starters in as transfers. In all, this program is expected to have what amounts to 18 starting players filling spots for this fall, a lofty number in this day and age. Clearly there is major room for improvement when a team wins less than 50% of its games in the prior season, but some of the biggest improvement is realized when these teams bring back their starting quarterback plus hire a new head coach and coordinators. Over the last five seasons, the average winning percentage increase of the 21 teams that have done this has been 15.2% SU (+2.1 wins) and 13.3% ATS. Only one of the 21 teams got worse. Will it amount to winning on the field this season? Well, the schedule has what I would consider to be six very winnable home games, and the win total is only 6.5 at DraftKings. I think this situation has a good chance of surpassing that number, and there will be an obvious coaching upgrade.

UNLV – OVER 7.5 WINS

Do yourself a favor...go through the UNLV schedule for 2026, which is minus Boise State this year after the Broncos left for the Pac-12, and tell me if there are any games which you designate in the “likely loss” category. In my opinion, with the meteoric rise New Mexico made last year, the Runnin’ Rebels’ Mountain West consistency in recent years makes them the favorite in the league. Including Auburn transfer QB Jackson Arnold, UNLV Head Coach Dan Mullen seems to have picked up right where successful prior coach Barry Odom left off, bringing in highly-respected recruiting classes to carry on the momentum of 30-12 over the past three years. Mullen has been able to bring in numerous P4 transfers with the allure of Sin City. This should have the Runnin’ Rebels in the hunt for MWC titles year-in and year-out for the near future. Running this team’s power rating against the 2026 schedule produced a 9-3 record. The most balanced wagering option at DK on the win total sits at a modest 7.5. I would have no problem betting it upward either.

VIRGINIA TECH – OVER 6.5 WINS

Though James Franklin had very good success at Penn State, his teams could never meet the demands of the fans in Happy Valley. That said, he was perhaps never as effusive in his praise of his team’s offseason work as he has been this season. The excitement for Hokies’ football is palpable, mostly because of the eagerness Franklin is showing to get things started. He was able to retain 15 of this team’s starters from last year and added three more through the portal, including PSU QB Ethan

Grunkemeyer, who started seven games as a freshman last year.

There are two nice transitional angles

backing the Hokies for improvement in 2026: 1) Of the

141 teams over the last five years that brought back at least four starters more than the prior season, only 40 got worse. The average improvement of the group that didn’t drop off was a winning percentage bump of 15% (+3.2 wins) and an ATS rise of 6.7%. 2) In the “there’s nowhere to go but up” category, since 2021, there have been 21 teams that have won four or fewer games in a season while enduring a -0.8 or worse turnover ratio. Only 2 of those 21 teams regressed. The average win improvement for the other 19 teams was 2.3 per season, and the SU win % upgrade was 15.3%. With the upgraded coaching staff, the vast experience returning, and the overall excitement peaking, DK has posted a win total of about 6.5, which to me seems a little understated in a season of a lot of question marks in the ACC. There are some very probable wins early on the schedule, which could propel this team to a very nice 2026 season.

15 teams I project to go Under their DraftKings season win props

COASTAL CAROLINA – UNDER 4.5 WINS

Is there cause for concern already in Myrtle Beach as new head coach Ryan Beard begins his tenure with the Coastal Carolina program? The Chanticleers have been a bowl-game fixture and Sun Belt contender over the last half-decade or so. His first recruiting class was a nightmare by program standards, this coming on the heels of what is a sliding performance chart. Beard’s predecessor Tim Beck failed to live up to the successes of his predecessor Jamey Chadwell and was eventually fired at the conclusion of the 6-6 regular season last year. His swan song was a 59-10 drubbing at the hands of James Madison. The program followed that up with another bowl game loss. In the final three regular season games, Beck’s CCU team was outscored 155-57. Thus, the Chanticleers will be looking to snap a four-game losing skid in their opener at West Virginia. There is a junior college transfer QB sitting No. 1 on the depth chart right now in Tre Guerra, and very little starting experience coming back elsewhere. The win total is at 4.5, a very low number considering where this program has been in recent years. I think the experts are telling us this is going to be a trying season in Myrtle Beach.

CONNECTICUT – UNDER 5.5 WINS

New head coach Jason Candle spent a decade at Toledo, and it was a very successful run, as he went 81-44 and the Rockets finished at least .500 in every season. He gets the chance to keep the momentum going at UConn. Here the Huskies come off back-to-back nine-win seasons under former coach Jim Mora, Jr. Candle’s experience and past successes alone might not be enough this season, as he will have one of the most inexperienced rosters in the country and the schedule is a bit tougher than we’ve been accustomed to with UConn under Mora. Oddsmakers are, in fact, expecting a pretty sharp drop-off this season in Storrs, as UConn’s win total is set at a mere 5.5 after the recent run of success. With three Power Four schools on the schedule and a handful of other prominent G5 programs, I think we’re going to see some first-year struggles for Candle & Co. If it’s data you are hoping for besides the zero stability rating, consider that teams that are off of seasons in which they won 60% or more of their games outright and have four or fewer offensive starters returning, plus are breaking in a new quarterback

have dropped by an average of -3.7 wins, -26% outright, -11.7% ATS, and -6.6 PPG offensively. The eight teams that added a new head coach plummeted by 29% and -4.4 wins per season, and UConn fits the bill. If that weren't enough, there is a potential landmine system that has affected teams coming off a season in which they enjoyed a positive 1.0 or better turnover differential but are now starting fresh at quarterback. The 27 most recent teams that have fit this bill over the last decade have dropped by 2.6 wins per season in the next campaign, representing a 18.5% plunge outright and 11.8% dip ATS.

IOWA STATE – UNDER 5.5 WINS

Matt Campbell left quite an impression and lasting legacy at Iowa State in the decade he was in Ames. Unfortunately, when he opted to leave for Penn State, he also took a lot of his players he worked so hard to recruit to ISU with him. As a result, new head coach Jimmy Rogers, last out of Washington State, starts his first season here essentially from scratch. On the roster are only two players on each side of the ball with any FBS starting experience, and one is a transfer QB Jaylen Raynor from a Sun Belt program. It could be a very long year in Ames, and most respected prognosticators have this perennial contending program projected at the bottom of the Big 12. Of course, DraftKings' oddsmakers don't seem to be as much in a doom-and-gloom forecast mode for ISU as those trying to analyze the numbers. They have set the season win total for the Cyclones at 5.5, just 2.5 off of last year's 8-4 season. If you recall, this program opted out of a bowl game after too many players transferred out. There are a couple of probable wins on the non-conference slate, but at this point, it's hard to see ISU favored in any Big 12 game. Look at a couple of the data systems suggesting a Cyclones fall: 1) Over the last five years, 51 teams have had at least eight fewer returning starters than the prior season, and only 15 of them have improved that season. The average drop-off of those that didn't improve was a winning percentage decline of 24% (-3.3 wins) and ATS drop of about 6.3%. 2) Teams that are off seasons in which they won 60% or more of their games outright and have four or fewer offensive starters returning, plus are breaking in a new quarterback, have dropped by an average of -3.7 wins, -26% outright, -11.7% ATS, and -6.6 PPG offensively. The eight teams that added a new head coach plummeted by 29% & -4.4 wins per season. I'm dead set on Under on this one, as a lot of conference rivals will be ready to pounce on a formerly prominent program in transition.

KENTUCKY – UNDER 4.5 WINS

For Mark Stoops to last a decade in the SEC at perhaps the conference's premier basketball school says a lot about the stability he brought to the Kentucky program. In all, he took the Wildcats to eight bowl games and won 82 games. His dismissal came after an embarrassing 41-0 season-ending loss to Louisville, as university brass decided it was time to move on. The new hire is a Louisville guy, as Will Stein played quarterback there for five years and started his coaching career there some 13 years ago. Since then, he has made a few stops, including most recently serving as offensive coordinator for Oregon. He led a high-powered offense there with QB Dante Moore, but there isn't that type of talent right now at UK, nor has there been on that side of the ball for a long time. There is a lot of other transfer talent fresh to Lexington as well, but that might not make it any easier for the new regime in Year 1. The DK win total is a modest 4.5, and when looking at the schedule, it would still require an upset or two. It's Arkansas or Kentucky for the bottom of the SEC this season. Let's lean Under here.

LIBERTY – UNDER 8.5 WINS

To this day, I've always been puzzled as to why head coach Jamey Chadwell left Coastal Carolina and Myrtle Beach and opted for Liberty. I have felt that recruiting would naturally be tougher in Lynchburg, VA. Well, after a solid 2025 graded class came in and produced a 4-8 record, the 2026 class bottomed out by 34 ranking positions. I'm not sure the worst is behind the Flames, and I'm intrigued as to why oddsmakers would post a significantly improved win total of 8.5 after last year's struggles, or why some respected prognosticators would have the Flames

atop CUSA in the preseason? Plus, after three straight years of having the nation's easiest schedule on paper, this year Liberty is sixth-easiest. This team might be better in 2026 than last year, but five games better? That seems like a stretch.

MEMPHIS – UNDER 7.5 WINS

Charles Huff is making his third coaching stop in as many years after guiding Marshall and Southern Miss to successful seasons in 2024 and 2025. He makes a jump up this time to Memphis, where he takes over a program that has been one of the better and most consistent Group of Five teams for the last decade-plus. Like his predecessors at Memphis, including most recently Ryan Silverfield, you'd have to believe that this job is viewed as another step up the ladder for the oft-moving Huff. His name has become synonymous with instability, and unlike recent seasons, Memphis is not picked among the elite teams in the American Conference in 2026, sixth in fact by Phil Steele. There is only one 2025 Tigers' starter back, so most of what you'll see from this team will be totally fresh. There is a unique transitional angle in play for the Tigers here too: There have been 33 teams over the last six seasons that have recorded 4+ blowout wins of 20 points or more in one season, then had to change head coaches for one reason or another. Only five of the 33 teams got better the next season, and collectively, they dropped by an average of 17.2%, or 2.8 wins per season, as well as 11.4% ATS. As a group, they were 44.2% ATS. The inexperience will certainly be a factor, as will the supposed starting QB, after the spring game listed as Marcus Stokes, a transfer from D-2 Western Florida. This might be too big of a step up for Stokes and Huff.

MISSOURI STATE – UNDER 4.5 WINS

It was a solid first season at the FBS level and in Conference USA for Missouri State as the Bears won seven games and received a bowl bid, a game they would eventually lose to Arkansas State. Year 2 at college football's top level looks to be a little more challenging, however, as the program moves on from Ryan Beard, the head coach of the last three years, who led them through a very successful transition. Casey Woods, who last served as SMU's offensive coordinator, takes the reins in his first chance as a head coach. He inherits a team with a Stability Score of zero for the season. There is very little experience on the roster, including at QB, where Duke transfer Henry Belin is expected to take over as a senior, and he is guiding a program that generally overachieved last season. Beating expectations by so much is a tough ask of any team. DraftKings sets the main win total line at 4.5. That might be overzealous, especially after a season in which the Bears won five games by seven points or fewer. Close wins are often characterized as getting "lucky" over the course of a season. Well, teams that have a lot of them and then come back inexperienced are naturally expected to drop. Over the last 13 seasons, 73 teams brought back 14 starters or fewer and had a new QB from a team that was fortunate to get four or more close wins of seven points or fewer in the prior season. Only 11 of these teams finished better the next season, with the average win drop being 2.6 per season, a 16.7% plunge.

NEBRASKA – UNDER 6.5 WINS

Last year was supposed to be the year that head coach Matt Rhule and Nebraska took that elusive step forward. Or was it the year before? Or the year before that? Well, years of failing to live up to billing might have finally come crashing down on Nebraska and Rhule. His 2026 recruit/transfer class ranked 66th in the country. Not only is that a severe drop-off from the program's 15-year average, but it was the worst ranking the Cornhuskers have received in that time span by 31 positions. I can't imagine this will help improve on back-to-back 7-6 seasons. Typically, when expectations fail to be met year in and year out, it is the problem of those setting the expectations, not the team. For this year, the season win prop is set at 6.5, similar to recent seasons seemingly without much consideration given to what personnel was lost or gained in the offseason. In my opinion, the Cornhuskers are down a bit, and the last seven weeks of the Big Ten slate are ridiculously tough. Let's go Under on this one.

NORTHERN ILLINOIS – UNDER 3.5 WINS

Talk about a challenging set of circumstances facing Rob Harley in 2026 for Northern Illinois. Not only is he a new head coach for the first time, he is also doing it under the tag of interim and is guiding a team that is in a transition year to a new and more challenging conference. It wasn't like the team he is taking over was elite last year either. The Huskies finished 3-9 for former coach Thomas Hammock. I don't know exactly what the most optimistic NIU fans are hoping for this fall, but it's probably too much. The Phil Steele guide shows NIU with exactly zero players with starting experience on the roster for the defense this season. That unit posted respectable numbers in the MAC last year, allowing 24.3 PPG. Defensive coordinator changes and inexperience are also a recipe for trouble. Of the 24 teams that have changed defensive coordinators after a season allowing fewer than 25 PPG and brought back four or fewer defensive starters, only six teams have improved their won-lost percentage. The average decline for the other 18 teams was 26.1% (-3.9 wins) on winning percentage and 13.9% ATS. These teams also covered only 44.4% of their point spreads and allowed 7.9 PPG more. The offense scored just 17.1 PPG, so the fact that five starters are back from that unit with another transferring in may or may not be a blessing. How are they going to keep up with some of the better offenses from the Mountain West? Patience is best preached in circumstances like this, but it's hard to see more than a win or two this season.

NORTH TEXAS – UNDER 5.5 WINS

North Texas scored the most points in the country last year, and new head coach Neal Brown was only able to bring in better recruit/transfer classes than four other programs across the country.

Pardon my French, but that is utter failure to start his tenure.

The biggest loss is, of course, QB Drew Mestemaker, and replacing him is virtually impossible. There's a reason oddsmakers have dropped this team's win total prop significantly coming off a 12-win season. For

UNT, the win total figure at DK is 5.5, which of course would represent a drop of 6.5 wins.

To answer whether or not the Mean Green will be better or worse, they will undoubtedly be worse. How much worse is the issue. It is backed up by data: 1) Over the last five years, 51 teams have had at least eight fewer returning starters than the

prior season, and only 15 of them have improved that season. The average drop-off of those that didn't improve was a winning percentage decline of 24% (-3.3 wins) and ATS drop of about 6.3%. 2) Teams that are off seasons in which they won 60% or more of their games outright and have 4 or fewer offensive starters returning, plus are breaking in a new quarterback over the last five seasons, have dropped by an average of -3.7 wins, -26% outright, -11.7% ATS, and -6.6 PPG offensively. The eight teams that added a new head coach plummeted by 29% & -4.4 wins per season. Taking a look at the 2026 slate, it could be a difficult three-game start for Brown & Co. with a trip to defending champion Indiana first up. Yikes. Look out below.

OHIO U – UNDER 6.5 WINS

Ohio U is another team undergoing massive change for first-year head coach John Hauser, although he was the DC here previously, so perhaps less change than other teams on this Under list. However, teams that are off of seasons in which they won 60% or more of their games outright and have four or fewer offensive starters returning, plus are breaking in a new quarterback, have dropped by an average of -3.7 wins, -26% outright, -11.7% ATS, and -6.6 PPG offensively. The eight teams that added a new head coach plummeted by 29% and -4.4 wins per season. A 4.4-win drop would put the Bobcats at 3.6-8.4. Now, while that may be a bit drastic considering the consistency this program has performed with over the last decade, a drop is expected nonetheless. I think we also need to consider that this team won five of its nine games by seven points or fewer. Radical change can turn that around quickly. Close wins are often characterized as getting "lucky" over the course of a season. Well, teams that have a lot of them and then come back inexperienced are naturally expected to drop. Over the last 13 seasons, 73 teams brought back 14 starters or fewer and had a new QB from a team that was fortunate to get four or more close wins of seven points or fewer in the prior season. Only 11 of these teams finished better the next season, with the average win drop being 2.6 per season, a 16.7% plunge.

SACRAMENTO STATE – UNDER 4.5 WINS

In my opinion, there are even varied levels of Stability Scores of zero in college football nowadays. I don't give negative numbers, but if I did, what Sacramento State and new head coach Alonzo Carter are facing in 2026 would qualify. Not only is he a new coach with a new staff and an almost entirely new roster, but his program is jumping from FCS to FBS and is playing in a conference in a completely different area of the country. And, here's a weird one for you. As Sacramento State got ready for its final season of FCS-level football a year ago, it scored a program-high 73rd-ranked incoming recruit/transfer class. As it transitions to FBS this year, the class is ranked 122nd. Perhaps potential recruits didn't like the potential challenges of dealing with a MAC schedule, the Midwest, the mid-week games, etc. As one of the more consistent and high-performing teams from the FCS, the Hornets believe they are ready to compete at the FBS level and in the MAC. The Hornets have won 7+ games in five of the last six seasons of football.

That said, there have been 33 teams over the last six seasons that have recorded 4+ blowout wins of 20 points or more one season, then had to change head coaches for one reason or another. Only five of the 33 teams got better the next season, and collectively, they dropped by an average of 17.2%, or 2.8 wins per season, as well as 11.4% ATS. As a group, they were 44.2% ATS.

Phil Steele picks them last in the conference, behind even UMass, whose win total is 2.5. Yes, expectations are low.

SAN JOSE STATE – UNDER 4.5 WINS



Recruiting efforts have dropped off severely at San Jose State and third-year head coach Ken Niumatalolo has not been able to revive them. Last year the results finally showed on the field as the Spartans finished 3-9. The incoming talent doesn't suggest things will get much better in 2026. It seems that Niumatalolo's coaching magic from his years at Navy has worn off. For this year, he has only three starters back from last year's 3-9 team, and over the last five years, 51 teams have had at least eight fewer returning starters than the prior season, and only 15 of them have improved that season. The average drop-off of those that didn't improve was a winning percentage decline of 24% (-3.3 wins) and ATS drop of about 6.3%. SJSU has also changed offensive coordinators, and offensive coordinator changes, when combined with little experience returning, is also a trouble sign. Over the last five seasons, there have been 56 teams that have hired new offensive coordinators the same season they had four or fewer offensive starters returning and a new quarterback. Only 19 teams improved. The 37 teams that did not declined by -17.8% (-2.4 wins) on winning percentages, and -4.1% ATS. They collectively have gone just 45.1% ATS, making them a strong play-against group. The average scoring output dropped about 5.6 PPG. The Spartans can't afford any drop. This program's best days might be behind them for a little while.

Ken Niumatalolo

SOUTH FLORIDA – UNDER 8.5 WINS

I am as excited as anyone to see what Brian Hartline can do at South Florida, but I get the feeling that first-year expectations might be a little over-exuberant. Since joining the Ohio State staff in 2017, it was obvious that Hartline was making a beeline for a prominent head coaching spot in college football. As a wide receiver coach and offensive coordinator, his players and teams were among the best in the country. He gets a pretty strong opportunity here, taking over a USF program that made nice strides under Alex Golesh, finishing last season 9-4. It's a situation that truly looks hard to predict, at least right away. Hartline figures to be successful in short order, and this would then be just a quick hurdle onto a Power Four job. The season win total at 8.5 via DraftKings seems a little aggressive, though. I'll lean Under, especially since the teams that are off of seasons in which they won 60% or more of their games outright and have four or fewer offensive starters returning, plus are breaking in a new quarterback, have dropped by an average of -3.7 wins, -26% outright, -11.7% ATS, and -6.6 PPG offensively. The eight teams that added a new head coach plummeted by 29% & -4.4 wins per season.

TOLEDO – UNDER 7.5 WINS

There are 10 teams this season starting with Stability Scores of zero. One of them is Toledo, who, for the last decade or so, has annually been one of the more stable situations year-in and year-out. The Rockets program has been known for having a lot of returning starters each summer, and correspondingly, a lot of success under previous coach Jason Candle. Well, the first domino fell in the spring after Candle's departure, as the commotion caused was felt in the recruiting results, where replacement Mike Jacobs seems to have taken a big swing and miss in the area of recruiting. To put it simply, Toledo's 120th ranking from 247Sports is almost a 40-position drop off the 16-year average. Ouch. Jacobs does take over a program that has been in great shape, but there will be some significant challenges this season. The Rockets lost a lot more starts/experience than they brought in via the transfer portal. Officially, there will only be six players with starting experience back, only two of them Toledo players from the offense. The win total is set at 7.5, and the Rockets are one of only two MAC teams starting the season with new coaching staffs. Still, they are picked first in the conference by many prognosticators. It's tough to envision this season not being at least a slight decline. I think this prop goes Under.





by Adam Burke

As much as college football has changed, some things still remain the same. Group of Five programs continue to provide a feeder system for the deeper-pocketed Power Four schools in terms of coaching staffs. The G5 - now G6 with the return of the Pac-12 - presently doubles as a minor league system of sorts in the NIL era, where players are hoping to get called up to a major conference and a significant payday. There used to be a big imbalance, where mostly coaches would preach brotherhood, family, and loyalty and then bounce to collect a bigger bag. Players have that opportunity now, too.

There are 138 FBS schools this season, and 35 of them (25.4%) have new head coaches, if we include guys who are interims or had the interim tag removed. While not quite the 31.3% in the NFL with 10 new sideline bosses for 32 teams, it is another year of drastic turnover with coaches and players in college football. Hitting the playbooks is becoming more difficult than hitting the textbooks, as some of these players will go through multiple coordinators and head coaches while they're in school.

With 30 and 28 head coaching changes over the last two seasons, respectively, we've seen some teams gel very quickly and others struggle to have everything come together. These are not professionals; they are student-athletes. While most of them are paid to play, maturity levels vary wildly at this age and some schemes require more focus and learning than others. It is important to know the teams with the new head coaches for a variety of reasons, so let's look at them and try to pinpoint some teams that could improve right away, improve gradually, or could be in for a rough year.

CHARLES HUFF **MEMPHIS**

This will be an interesting season for Huff. He seemed like a bit of an odd hire at Marshall, having primarily served as a running backs coach in his career, but he was on Nick Saban's staff when the Thundering Herd came calling. After a 32-20 run in Huntington, he went to Southern Miss because Marshall let the reigning Sun Belt Conference champion head coach walk away. He took a big chunk of his roster to Southern Miss and went 7-5 before leveling up to Memphis. As mentioned above with Silverfield, Memphis has a pretty robust NIL budget thanks to FedEx and Huff, who has connections all over the country from his different stops, could find immediate and prolonged success with resources he didn't have at his two previous stops.

NEAL BROWN **NORTH TEXAS**

I wouldn't call myself a glass-half-full person by nature, but when it comes to new coaching hires, I'm often optimistic. I can't say that about North Texas's hire of Brown, who was let go from West Virginia in 2024 and served as Steve Sarkisian's assistant in 2025. Brown has over 120 games of head coaching experience under his belt, all at the FBS level. He was very successful at Troy with three 10-win seasons in a row before heading to Morgantown. He is an offensive-minded guy, but not like Eric Morris, who ran more of a run-and-shoot style. It might work and the bar isn't terribly high, given that the program has three winning seasons since 2013, but it feels like UNT is drifting closer to mediocrity again rather than living up to what should be their new standard.

WILL HALL **TULANE**

Losing Willie Fritz and then Jon Sumrall would be tough for any program, but not taking a third swing at a rising name feels like a miss. Instead, Tulane promoted pass game coordinator Will Hall, who had a miserable tenure at Southern Miss, going 14-30 over three seasons and seven games. Hall went to Hattiesburg after serving as Tulane's OC in 2019-20 and was a fairly hot commodity after some strong seasons at West Alabama and West Georgia as a young head coach, but his star faded after the Southern Miss years. It just feels like the Green Wave took the easy route and that seems really disappointing.

BRIAN HARTLINE **USF**

Suffice it to say that December 3 was a day that Ohio State fans had been dreading for a long time. Hartline, who was a star WR for the Buckeyes from 2005-08, was on the staff in Columbus from 2017-25 and directly responsible for Marvin Harrison Jr., Garrett Wilson, Emeka Egbuka, Jaxon Smith-Njigba, Chris Olave, Carnell Tate, and now Jeremiah Smith. The absurd receiver pipeline is just one attractive element to Hartline, who was Ohio State's OC/co-OC the last three seasons. USF is looking to keep up the offensive prowess they had under another Ohio State alum in Alex Golesh, but it's fair to question Hartline's experience outside of his offensive bubble. Just as important as Hartline might be DC Josh Aldridge, who is just in his second year calling plays.

TOSH LUPOI **CALIFORNIA**

Lupoi's first crack at being a head coach is with his alma mater and allows his coaching career to come full circle. Lupoi was a Golden Bear from 2000-05 and the program's defensive line coach from 2008-11. In looking at Lupoi, it got me thinking about racehorses and bloodlines. Lupoi's college coaching career has been under Jeff Tedford, Steve Sarkisian, Nick Saban, and Dan Lanning. He also spent three seasons in the NFL under Freddie Kitchens, Dan Quinn, and Urban Meyer. There is a ton of coaching experience in that list and the 44-year-old Lupoi had to pick up a lot of things. On the other hand, even well-bred horses don't always work out and Lupoi, who follows another guy who had a lot of good mentors in Justin Wilcox, is another defensive-minded guy at a place that badly needs an injection of offense.

TAVITA PRITCHARD **STANFORD**

In retrospect, I don't think we give enough credit to Jim Harbaugh and David Shaw for what they did at Stanford. If somebody can replicate that in today's NIL era, it will be one of the best coaching jobs we've ever seen. The program got a \$50 million donation in October 2025 from former player Bradford Freeman and had instituted a revenue-sharing model in the spring of 2025. Even with the weight that a Stanford degree carries, Andrew Luck, and now Pritchard, who played for the Cardinal from 2006-09 and coached for them from 2011-22, know the academic requirements in Palo Alto severely limit the player pool. Pritchard has spent the last three seasons with the Commanders coaching up QBs, including, of course, Jayden Daniels. "Unimaginative" is the best way to describe the hire after Frank Reich responded to Luck's plea to serve as a stopgap last season.

JAMES FRANKLIN **VIRGINIA TECH**

I made sure to double-check that Ohio State and Michigan did not move to the ACC before discussing Franklin. The guy is a solid motivator, a good recruiter, and a pretty lackluster in-game coach, but the conference lacks premier teams right now, and this is a perfect landing spot for him. As a guy who is just 8-7 in bowl games and 2-1 in the CFP, he's had a very high regular-season floor with two 9-4 seasons at Vanderbilt in the early 2010s when that was a rough job, and six double-digit winning seasons at Penn State. There's a lot of talent in the Hokies' pipeline and Franklin, a southeastern PA native, should do very well recruiting in the DMV and the Keystone State. This could be and should be a quick transformation.



James Franklin

JIMMY ROGERS IOWA STATE

Time will tell whether or not this is a good hire, but AD Jamie Pollard has made some good ones with Matt Campbell on the football side and Fred Hoiberg, Steve Prohm, and T.J. Otzelberger on the basketball side. He spent \$4 million to buy Rogers out of his Washington State contract, so he was locked in from the jump on the 39-year-old, who won the FCS National Championship in his first season as a head coach at South Dakota State and lost in the semifinal in Year 2. This will be just his third year at the FBS level, having served as a GA at Florida Atlantic in 2012 under Carl Pelini and then as the head coach of Wazzu last season. Pollard unequivocally deserves the benefit of the doubt here and Rogers is inheriting a much better foundation than his predecessor did from Paul Rhoads.

COLLIN KLEIN KANSAS STATE

After spreading his wings to fly to College Station for two seasons, Klein is back in the Little Apple to coach at his alma mater. Klein was on the staff in 2014-15 and again from 2017-23, serving primarily as the QB coach and then OC. He's one of the best players in the program's history and he does seem to be a solid coach, given that he's only 36 and already has this job after Chris Klieman and Bill Snyder, two guys who excelled in Manhattan for boosters and bettors. With OC Sean Gleeson and DC Jordan Peterson, this is a young staff that will learn and grow together, so bumps in the road are inevitable and this was just a 6-6 program last season.

ERIC MORRIS OKLAHOMA STATE

A return to the glory days of Oklahoma State football may not be that far away. It is hard to believe that this was a top-10 team in 2021 and a 10-win team in 2023 with just how badly it has gone the last two seasons. The Cowboys were a combined 4-20, prompting the pink slip for longtime head coach Mike "Teach Me How To" Gundy. That included an 0-18 record in the new-look Big 12. Enter Eric Morris, who played and coached under Mike Leach and Kliff Kingsbury, and who led North Texas to the program's first AP ranking in over 65 years and a chance at being the G5 CFP representative. The gunslinger mentality is back in Stillwater and I think the Cowboys make a big leap, especially with an excellent DC in Skyler Cassity.

MORGAN SCALLEY UTAH

After basically a decade of being the head coach-in-waiting, except for a short period of time after a scandal involving the use of racial stereotypes, Scalley gets his shot with Whittingham off to Michigan. Scalley coached the Utes in the Las Vegas Bowl to a 44-22 win and now he's the full-time guy. The Salt Lake City native played at Utah and has coached at Utah since 2007, serving as DC for the last 10 seasons. He certainly knows the program and is plenty familiar with the recruiting pipelines. It may work out, though Year 3 in the Big 12 might be a little bit rocky.



Morgan Scalley

KYLE WHITTINGHAM MICHIGAN

Sherrone Moore's ugly departure from Ann Arbor on the heels of Jim Harbaugh's tainted National Championship created the need for a well-respected, accomplished football lifer to clean up the program. Enter Whittingham, who calls somewhere other than Salt Lake City home for the first time since he was the DC at Idaho State from 1992-93. I'll be honest - Whittingham has long been viewed as one of the game's elite coaches, both against the spread and in terms of maximizing talent. His Utah teams were always tough to face because of their presence in the trenches. But, I am skeptical of the 66-year-old entering the Big Ten and a program with extreme expectations.

PAT FITZGERALD MICHIGAN STATE

It might be unfair to call a College Football Hall of Famer an underwhelming hire, but this is an underwhelming hire. Fitzgerald was dismissed from Northwestern in 2023 following an investigation into hazing and sexual assault. A thorough investigation was completed and Fitzgerald was shown the door, though it's hard not to wonder if he would have had more program support if the team hadn't gone 1-11 the previous season and 3-9 the season before that. Either way, Fitzgerald, who was a volunteer coach at his son's high school for the last three seasons, gets another chance after the aspirational hire of Jonathan Smith didn't work out. It feels like the ceiling in East Lansing is very low moving forward.

MATT CAMPBELL PENN STATE

Of all the Power Four hires, this is the hardest one to project in my estimation. After a decade at Iowa State, where Campbell really built up the Cyclones amid a lot of financial and reputational shortcomings in a high-octane offensive conference, Penn State is a different beast. Campbell's four-year run at Toledo was great and his decade in Ames was tremendous, but this is a BIG job. Campbell has strong Ohio ties, which should help with recruiting and he did really well to get D'Anton Lynn, a Texas native, as the DC, giving Penn State a lot of connections from coast to coast. What stood out at Iowa State is how Campbell maximized the talent he was able to recruit. With more fertile recruiting grounds now, what can he do with more talent? That'll be the big question, and maybe one not quite answered in 2026.

BOB CHESNEY UCLA

The hire of former James Madison head coach Curt Cignetti seemed to work out at Indiana, and now the Bruins' athletic department is hoping for the same with Chesney, who was at Holy Cross prior to his two seasons with the Dukes. Chesney is a winner with a career 132-52 record and he took JMU to the College Football Playoff as the G5 representative last season. For a Bruins bunch that has only finished the season ranked one time since 2014, the bar isn't terribly high, so Chesney, a strong hire by all accounts, has the chance to rapidly improve the program, even with a tough Big Ten schedule.



CASEY WOODS **MISSOURI STATE**

Missouri State had to be quietly planning for Ryan Beard to be offered another job, but they probably didn't think it would be so soon. With Beard off to Coastal Carolina following the program's first FBS season, AD Patrick Ransdell, who got the job just before the start of the football season, moved quickly to hire Woods from SMU. Woods has worn a lot of different hats, including OC under Rhett Lashlee and director of player personnel at Auburn. Ransdell understands mid-major football, having worked at App State and UCF previously, so I think he's trustworthy in isolating Woods as quickly as he did. A guy who has worked under Gus Malzahn, Bill Clark, Eli Drinkwitz, and Lashlee, and is also the son of 50-year coaching vet Sparky Woods, probably ends up being a solid hire.

ALEX MORTENSEN **UAB**

Mortensen isn't a new head coach, per se, as he took over when Trent Dilfer was booted from Birmingham, but he's the full-time guy now. He was 2-4 in his six games and led a big upset of Memphis in his first game at the helm, which may very well have been the deciding factor in just keeping him. The Dilfer hire was out of left field, to say the least, when the players desperately wanted Bryant Vincent to take over the job permanently when he filled in for Bill Clark, but that didn't happen. Simply elevating Mortensen from OC reeks of being too cheap to make an impact hire.

JASON CANDLE **UCONN**

On the surface, this looks like a great hire. Candle went 81-44 at Toledo and had no problems succeeding Matt Campbell with the newfound success he brought to the Rockets. At the same time, Campbell only won the MAC twice in 10 seasons as the head coach and owns a career bowl record of 3-5. Not to mention, the Rockets have had a penchant for losing games as a big favorite, losing more than 10 times as a TD+ favorite from 2021-25. On the plus side, he won't see a lot of big favorite roles with the Huskies. On the downside, a program like UConn simply has to win games in which they are favored and Candle has had major problems doing just that.

MARK CARNEY **KENT STATE**

Anybody who wins five games at Kent State deserves Coach of the Year consideration. For Carney, starting the season 3-5 meant his interim tag was stripped off. The team was 0-16 in MAC play and 1-23 overall under Kenni Burns, so Carney's .500 record in the conference and 5-7 season was remarkable. While they fell short of bowl eligibility, they did beat rival Akron and also beat Bowling Green. The overall numbers look a lot worse given losses of 62-14, 66-10, and 44-0 to Texas Tech, Florida State, and Oklahoma in non-conference play. Otherwise, Carney's team was competitive most weeks and should be again this season.

JOHN HAUSER **OHIO**

"New" head coach is a loose term here, as Hauser was the assistant head coach and DC for the Bobcats before HC Brian Smith was placed on leave at the end of the regular season. There's something to be said about continuity in college football in 2026 and Hauser follows Smith and Tim Albin, who were both on the staffs of their predecessors. Hauser has spent his entire FBS career in the MAC and is plenty familiar with the Buckeye State as a Columbus native and Wittenberg University grad, so he should be able to keep getting good in-house talent from a top-10, borderline top-five, state for high school football.

ALONZO CARTER **SACRAMENTO STATE**

Two things first... Yes, Sacramento State is an FBS team now. And, yes, they are in the MAC. Carter is a Brent Brennan disciple in some respects, though he was already coaching high school ball when Brennan was playing for UCLA. Carter was on Brennan's staffs at both San Jose State and Arizona, serving most recently as the assistant head coach and running backs coach. He hasn't been a head coach since 2016 at Contra Costa Junior College. Given the wild commitment to the basketball team with head coach Mike Bibby and GM Shaquille O'Neal, Carter, a one-time backup dancer for MC Hammer, seems like an odd hire by comparison. However, the Oakland native is said to be a great mentor and resource for students.

MIKE JACOBS **TOLEDO**

Jacobs, a Maumee native from northwestern Ohio, worked his way up the hard way, serving as the head coach at Division II Notre Dame College (OH) and Lenoir-Rhyne before getting an opportunity in the FCS ranks at Mercer. It is kind of rare to see a head coach with this sort of path, as many have been coordinators or position coaches at the FBS level, and usually from a P4 school at some point. Jacobs is 94-23 in his career as a head coach and took Mercer to the FCS Playoffs in back-to-back seasons. Mercer had one of the nation's best defenses in 2024 and the offense racked up nearly 500 yards per game in 2025. Given Candle's inability to do what needs to be done as a favorite, this could end up being quite the upgrade.

ROB HARLEY **NORTHERN ILLINOIS**

If Sacramento State being in the MAC wasn't enough of a mind-eff, Northern Illinois is a member of the retooled Mountain West. Harley was the DC last season under Thomas Hammock and is the interim HC for this season after Hammock took a job with the Seahawks. Harley is a Pat Narduzzi disciple and also was a GA under Narduzzi and Mark Dantonio for two years. The 43-year-old has never been a head coach, and finds himself in a weird situation to say the least with the travel, games at elevation, and the transfer portal opening up when Hammock left in February.

JIM MORA **COLORADO STATE**

Let's all take a second and come to terms with the fact that Colorado State is now in the Pac-12...Alright, now let's think about Mora, who got a second kick at the college coaching can at UConn and did extremely well with it. The football lifer was 27-23 in Storrs with back-to-back nine-win seasons, which is no small feat. His first four seasons at UCLA were pretty good, but the bottom fell out quickly. To provide some continuity, Mora kept interim HC Tyson Summers in his previous DC role. The Rams haven't won a bowl game since 2013 and have had a winning record just once since 2017. Perhaps Mora's previous stops are examples of what he can do at schools with lowered expectations, much like this one.

JAMARCUS SHEPHARD **OREGON STATE**

Going the defensive route didn't work, so Oregon State has gone in the other direction. Tyler Bray really walked into a brutal situation after Jonathan Smith left, as the Beavers floated around like a feather in the wind when the Pac-12 dissolved. They played as a Pac-12 team in name only, mostly facing a Mountain West schedule and even played fellow orphan Washington State twice last season. Bray went 5-14 and now Shephard, a longtime wide receivers coach, most recently with Kalen DeBoer at both Washington and Alabama, takes the reins. Like Washington State, Oregon State should be ready to invest in the program with a conference to call home again, but Shephard has never been more than a co-OC/assistant head coach and now is a head coach looking to install a dramatically different offense.

KIRBY MOORE **WASHINGTON STATE**

Moore, whose time at Boise State crossed over with brother Kellen, who has a slightly more high-profile job, is on the fast track. The 35-year-old isn't coaching the Saints like his 37-year-old brother, but three years of calling plays at Missouri and one at Fresno State now has him in a head coaching role. Grabbing a branch of the Chris Petersen, Kalen DeBoer, Eli Drinkwitz coaching tree is far from a bad idea, but he's going to need to grow into the role with a program that hasn't really been investing in its roster while being a Pac-12 orphan with Mountain West guardianship. Now back in the Pac-12, the program will invest in the head coach and the roster all at once and that will probably take some time.

RYAN SILVERFIELD **ARKANSAS**

After a decade at Memphis, Silverfield packed up the family and took I-40 to I-49 for probably the only SEC opportunity he was ever going to get. It would be unfair to call him the last person at the bar when the “ugly lights” came on, but AD Hunter Yurachek had two strikes in the count and had to put a ball in play. Silverfield was seemingly the bronze medalist behind Jon Sumrall and Alex Golesh, and you can see why. He inherited a good program and a NIL budget filled by FedEx at Memphis and never won the conference. The irony is not lost on me that the Razorbacks went from an OL coach in Sam Pittman to another OL coach in Silverfield, as they look to finish the season ranked for just the second time since 2011.

ALEX GOLESH **AUBURN**

You can see what Auburn was thinking here, as the Tigers have scored just 18.5 and 19.1 PPG against SEC opponents over the last two seasons. Golesh is an offensive guy through and through, spending his entire collegiate coaching career on that side of the ball. After four seasons under Matt Campbell and three under Josh Heupel, Golesh got his first HC opportunity at South Florida and went 23-15 before taking the Auburn gig. Given that the defense is in the hands of veterans D.J. Durkin and Tim Banks, Golesh's chief objective is to find points and he's done that pretty much everywhere he's been. His first-year success will be contingent on how the USF transfers adapt to P4 life, including QB Byrum Brown.

JON SUMRALL **FLORIDA**

Sumrall's trajectory is becoming increasingly common in college football. The 43-year-old played four years at Kentucky, where he then served as a grad assistant from 2005-06 before getting a FCS gig at San Diego in his mid-20s. From there, he moved up the ranks, eventually serving as the co-DC at Kentucky before two seasons as the head coach at Troy and two at Tulane. Having immediate success adds commas to your bank account in CFB and that's the case for Sumrall, who made the CFP with Tulane in 2024 and has won at least 11 games in three of his four seasons as a HC. While he inherited a mess at Troy from Chip Lindsey, he inherited a strong foundation at Tulane thanks to Willie Fritz. Florida, one of the sport's premier programs, could be classified as somewhere in between, so we'll see how long it takes Sumrall to bring them back to relevance.

WILL STEIN **KENTUCKY**

Personally, I really like this hire, especially when paired with a strong DC grab in Jay Bateman. Stein, the mastermind of the Oregon offense the last three seasons, is a Louisville native and played QB there from 2008-12. Props to the Kentucky athletic department for realizing that the program needs to modernize offensively. What Mark Stoops did, including eight straight bowl game appearances from 2016-23, was very impressive with the team's tenacious defense and ball-control offense, but for Kentucky to take the leap into being a legitimate contender, a more dynamic offense will be required, especially in the SEC. Former Dan Lanning OC Kenny Dillingham has done pretty well at Arizona State, but the Sun Devils were 3-9 in his first season as he tore the team down to the studs. Something to keep in mind with Stein.

LANE KIFFIN **LSU**

The Lane Train made a lot of noise leaving Oxford for Baton Rouge, as he bailed on his College Football Playoff squad to set things in motion with the Tigers. There are a lot of must-see games during the CFB season - it's possible that none of them will top September 19, when LSU visits Ole Miss. Lane is one of the most recognizable cast members in the college football soap opera, but he's also a guy who recruited at an obscene level and led a collective 32-6 run over his final three seasons with the Rebels. Does his move to LSU conjure up memories of his ill-fated stint at USC? Probably, based on the blue blood running through the veins of both institutions. But we cannot argue that Kiffin plays an exciting style of football and gets dudes who can ball out on both sides. Just what LSU needs.

PETE GOLDING **MISSISSIPPI**

This was a tough situation for AD Keith Carter. The players rallied around Golding amidst the made-for-TV drama of Lane Kiffin's exit. At the same time, with Kiffin's offensive reputation and penchant for recruiting, including the JUCO ranks, it is hard not to feel underwhelmed about Golding. That said, the Rebels played extremely well in the CFP, beating Tulane and Georgia before falling short to Miami. Golding has also worked under now-Browns head coach Todd Monken at Southern Miss, new Arkansas DC Ron Roberts at SE Louisiana, Frank Wilson at UTSA, Nick Saban at Alabama, and Kiffin.

RYAN BEARD **COASTAL CAROLINA**

After overseeing Missouri State's transition from FCS to FBS, Beard took the Bears to a bowl game in their first season as a member of Conference USA. He didn't coach in it, as Coastal Carolina came calling and he hit the ground running in Conway. Beard, who is Bobby Petrino's son-in-law, was at Missouri State for six seasons, first as the DC under Petrino and then as the head coach when Petrino went to be the OC at Texas A&M. Beard, who was a defensive back at Western Kentucky, has been very successful in getting his players to get to the quarterback. Coastal Carolina only had 19 sacks last season and their 80 sack yards were the seventh-fewest. Just some food for thought.

BILLY NAPIER **JAMES MADISON**

Following up Curt Cignetti and Bob Chesney was going to be an unenviable task for anybody, but it's "Sun Belt Billy" who gets the chance. Look, his stint in Gainesville was an abject disaster, but he was really good at Louisiana, winning 40 games in four seasons. He inherited a solid foundation from Mark Hudspeth and gets the same here with the Dukes. Florida is a different beast and some guys just aren't built for that burden. If JMU struggles, it'll likely be less about Napier and more about the mass exodus of talent over the last two seasons.

BLAKE ANDERSON **SOUTHERN MISS**

Anderson's second stint at Southern Miss was to serve as the OC and QB coach, but Charles Huff left for Memphis and the Golden Eagles opted to keep it in-house with Anderson. He's got a decade of FBS coaching experience, but also had an unceremonious departure from Utah State and didn't coach in 2024. He took Arkansas State to new heights from 2014-20 and had an 11-win season at Utah State to start his tenure, but this is a fairly uninspiring hire in Hattiesburg. He's won at both stops and has done so while navigating some very difficult and tragic family circumstances, so we'll see how this stop goes.



Blake Anderson



NOBODY BELIEVED THEN. NOBODY'S BETTING NOW.

by **Matt Youmans**

If the Curt Cignetti story was a Disney movie, it would be mocked as absurd and completely unrealistic. A coach who waited several years for his first big shot finally gets it with the losingest program in college football history, and Indiana goes 16-0 to win the national championship in his second season.

"Hoosiers" was a classic movie based on a true high school basketball Cinderella story in the 1950s, and Cignetti basically scripted the sequel.

"What if I told you at the end of the 2023 season that Indiana would have an undefeated national champion in two years? There's no chance anyone would have believed me," DraftKings oddsmaker Matt Grill said. "You would say there's absolutely no way in hell that could happen. It was a forgotten program. I still don't know how he did it."

Indiana lost its 2023 season finale at Purdue to finish 3-9. In their history, the Hoosiers never had a 10-win season and owned only three bowl wins. In two years in Bloomington, Cignetti has a 27-2 record. Last year, he upset Ohio State to win the Big Ten championship before blowing out Alabama in the Rose Bowl and Oregon in the Peach Bowl on the way to a victory over Miami for the national title.

"Cignetti is amazing," Grill said. "I think Indiana is going to keep it going, but pretty much no one is betting Indiana."

Ohio State, Notre Dame and Texas are attracting a majority of the affection as college football futures action heats up in Nevada and across the country. In their bid for a repeat, the Hoosiers are getting a cold shoulder from the betting public at most books. Indiana is posted at 10-1 odds as the fifth choice on the board at Circa Sports.

"Texas is currently the favorite to win the title, though it didn't open that way, and it's because we've taken sharp action on them," Circa vice president of operations Mike Palm said. "We took our sharpest limit bet on Texas at +750."

The limit bet on Longhorns was for \$10,000, Palm said. Texas is the +650 favorites at Circa, followed by Ohio State (+700), Notre Dame (+725), Oregon (+730) and Georgia (+950).

"We've seen a ton of public interest in Notre Dame and Oregon — those are our two biggest realistic liabilities," Palm said.

Boomer's Sportsbook director Nick Bogdanovich said the public is "betting Notre Dame with both hands," driving the Fighting Irish from 8-1 to 6-1 odds.

Notre Dame started last season 0-2, losing games to Miami and Texas A&M by a total of four points, and finished 10-2. The Irish were controversially excluded from the 12-team College Football Playoff and are expected to stage a revenge tour behind coach Marcus Freeman and a veteran team headlined by sophomore quarterback CJ Carr.

"Notre Dame should be able to navigate this schedule to an undefeated regular season," Palm said. "Whether the Irish are good enough to beat Texas and Ohio State is a different question."

Two years ago, the Irish eliminated Indiana and Cignetti in the first round of the CFP and fell to Ohio State in the national title game. The

Buckeyes are currently the +600 favorites at DraftKings, ahead of Notre Dame at +650.

"We took a lot of money on Notre Dame early when we opened 10-1," Grill said. "I've got Ohio State as my No. 1 team right now."

Grill's power ratings show Notre Dame and Indiana tied at No. 2, followed by Oregon, Georgia, Texas, Texas Tech, Miami, Texas A&M and Alabama. Grill said he's not sold on the Longhorns and quarterback Arch Manning, who was overhyped entering last season.

"I'm sure I've got a similar Top 10 to about everyone else out there," Grill said. "The potential is there with Texas. It's an embarrassment of riches. If Arch is improved and slinging it, they could be phenomenal. But Texas disappoints every year for how long now?"

Texas hosts Ohio State on Sept. 12 in one of the season's most pivotal games. Manning was a bust in the teams' season opener a year ago, when the Buckeyes won 14-7. In addition to the game at Texas, the Buckeyes will face road tests against Indiana, Iowa and USC as part of a grueling schedule.

"My top three teams are Ohio State, Oregon and Notre Dame," South Point sportsbook director Chris Andrews said. "I know we have action on those three, plus USC."

With coach Lincoln Riley under pressure entering his fifth year, the Trojans are 35-1 longshots at DraftKings. USC hosts Oregon in late September, hosts Ohio State in late October and plays at Indiana on Nov. 14.

Aside from Cignetti, the coach who's probably talked about the most in the media is Lane Kiffin, who ditched Mississippi prior to the CFP and took the LSU job. The Tigers are a 16-1 shot at Circa.

"We've seen sharp interest in LSU, and USC has been bet from 50-1 down to 30-1," Palm said.

Not everyone believes in and roots for Kiffin, of course, and his childish diva act gets annoying. The most action the Boomer's book has seen in the Yes/No playoff market, Bogdanovich said, is on LSU to miss the playoffs at -125.

Texas and Georgia are the SEC's best bets to break the Big Ten's three-year championship reign strung together by Michigan, Ohio State and Indiana. The Hoosiers must replace Heisman Trophy-winning quarterback Fernando Mendoza, and the Heisman market is generating action all over the board with a surplus of marquee QBs this season. At DraftKings, Carr is the Heisman favorite at +700 and Manning is the +800 second choice.

"The expanded playoff certainly creates more futures action in Yes/No playoffs as well as to win the national championship," Palm said. "The expansion to 12 teams tripled the handle in those markets. I don't want to see more than 16 teams. I actually think 12 is a very practical number, and beyond 16 will include too many teams with no chance of winning the title."

Not long ago, before Cignetti showed up and changed everything, Indiana seemed to be a team with no shot of winning a championship.

The recent history of the Heisman Trophy suggests it's become a quarterback's award. Travis Hunter, a rare two-way superstar, broke the mold in 2024, but he's the exception — only five non-quarterbacks have won since 2000. That trend has only intensified since college football's NIL era officially kicked off in July 2021. Since NIL money started flowing openly, four of the last five winners have been quarterbacks.

There's a newer wrinkle worth watching, though: three of the last four winners have been hired guns. Caleb Williams, Jayden Daniels, and Fernando Mendoza all won after transferring in from other power programs, and that's a pattern to keep in mind entering the 2026 season.

One more thing to file away: the preseason betting favorite rarely actually wins. Depending on the book, CJ Carr and Arch Manning currently top the oddsboard. Both enter the new season with outrageous hype, and it's warranted given what we saw from them last season. Still, if either one ends up hoisting the trophy, it'll mark the first time since 2014 that the preseason favorite has won.

Considering all of that, let's get into some picks to win the Heisman Trophy in 2026. Here are four of my favorites, but I'll also mention that I'm closely monitoring Alabama's quarterback competition between Keelon Russell and Austin Mack.

DARIAN MENSAH **MIAMI (12-1)**

Nobody's raiding the portal quite like Mario Cristobal. With the help of offensive guru Shannon Dawson, Miami has landed Cam Ward, Carson Beck, and now Mensah in the portal era. The Hurricanes helped Ward become the No. 1 pick in the 2025 NFL Draft, as he was undeniable after throwing for 4,313 yards with 39 touchdowns and only seven picks in his final college season. Beck didn't go in the first round of the 2026 NFL Draft, but he was picked in the third after throwing for 3,813 yards and 30 touchdowns. Now it's Mensah's turn to go to work in this quarterback-friendly system.

Mensah arguably arrives in Coral Gables as a more polished player than Ward and Beck were at the same stage. Last season, despite being surrounded by underwhelming talent, Mensah threw for 3,973 yards with 34 touchdowns and only six interceptions. He also posted a PFF passer grade of 85.0. Mensah is extremely dangerous throwing to every part of the field, makes big-time throws in the face of pressure, and has played in some massive games. He's the total package.

Mensah now gets to play for one of the biggest brands in football, and he'll be surrounded by weapons. Malachi Toney was one of the best players in college football last season, Cooper Barkate was Mensah's top receiver at Duke, and Miami has high hopes for 6-foot-4 sophomore Joshua Moore. Mensah will also be working behind a better offensive line than he had in either of his previous two college seasons.

There's a real chance Mensah puts up ridiculous numbers for a Hurricanes team that should win double-digit games and reach the College Football Playoff. That makes him the best of the chalkier options when you're looking at the Heisman Trophy odds.

JOHN MATEER **OKLAHOMA (25-1)**

It's a little surprising to see Mateer available at 25-1 odds. Early last season, Mateer looked like he was on his way to winning the Heisman Trophy. Through four games, he was putting up absurd numbers as both a thrower and a runner. But a broken thumb on his throwing hand changed everything. Mateer came back and threw three interceptions against Texas on October 11, and it felt like he was never the same quarterback afterward.

Mateer enters the 2026 season at full strength. That means he should hit the ground running, even with Oklahoma playing a difficult schedule. Mateer is back in Ben Arbuckle's offense, which he's

mastered at this point. He also has an excellent group of pass-catching options and should be operating behind an improved offensive line.

Rushing upside has always mattered when it comes to this award, and that gives Mateer something other candidates don't have. Two years ago, Mateer rushed for 826 yards and 15 touchdowns for Washington State. He might not have that in him in the SEC, but his legs will still be a major factor for the Sooners.

With so many showcase games on the schedule — at Michigan, at Georgia, vs. Texas, vs. Ole Miss, vs. Texas A&M — Mateer has a real chance to rack up Heisman moments. Oklahoma just needs the slightest bit of team success to put him back in the conversation.

MARCEL REED **TEXAS A&M (30-1)**

Reed didn't receive any votes for this award last season, but he wasn't far off from having a seat at the table. Reed threw for 3,169 yards with 25 touchdowns, rushed for 493 yards and six scores, and was the drink-stirrer for one of the best teams in college football. With another year of experience, things are likely to ramp up a little.

Texas A&M will have a new offensive coordinator in Holmon Wiggins, but he was the wide receivers coach and co-offensive coordinator last season. That means this offense shouldn't change too much, and it's one Reed is fully comfortable with. The Aggies don't ask too much of him as a passer, but he's capable of making most throws. There's also room for improvisation, and that's where Reed's elite rushing ability shows up.

Reed is going to have a very good wide receiver group this season, with Mario Craver, a first-team All-SEC performer last year, leading the pack. He's also going to have a large offensive line blocking for him. Reed just needs to cut down on his interceptions, as the 12 he threw in 2025 were unacceptable. Reed also happened to throw eight of those in his final five games, meaning he made his biggest mistakes in the biggest games.

With one more year of seasoning, and improved decision-making, Reed should make a real run at the Heisman. At the very least, a healthy Reed should make a strong early case, presenting opportunities to monetize a ticket later on. If Texas A&M can pick up a road win over LSU on September 26, there's a good chance the Aggies will be 7-0 heading into a road game against Alabama on October 24.

DREW MESTEMAKER **OKLAHOMA STATE (75-1)**

Mestemaker led all of FBS in passing yards last year, throwing for 4,379 yards, 34 touchdowns, and nine interceptions in a masterful freshman season. He then decided to follow head coach Eric Morris from North Texas to Oklahoma State, where he'll be playing alongside several of his former teammates.

Mestemaker will have to adjust to a significant jump in competition, facing strong Big 12 defenses after seeing nothing but soft AAC units. Still, Mestemaker should be able to handle it. He's a future first-round pick playing behind a better offensive line, he has serious talent at the skill positions, and he knows this offense like the back of his hand.

It's just hard to imagine this being anything but a massive season for Mestemaker, but grabbing him means hoping for some team success at Oklahoma State. That's the main concern here. The Cowboys are going to be excellent offensively, but will the defense be able to get off the field? The lineup on the defensive side of the ball features only four players with starting experience, so new defensive coordinator Skyler Cassity will be banking on a bunch of unknown commodities.

Making the College Football Playoff isn't a requirement for Heisman contention, but Mestemaker probably needs to win eight or so games to really win voters over. That might be unlikely in Year 1, but he's worth a flier at 75-1.

TAKING ADVANTAGE OF COLLEGE FOOTBALL STABILITY IN 2026



by Steve Makinen

Last year was an eye-opener for my “world-famous” college football stability system. Prior to the 2025 campaign, I shared my concern about how program stability was changing, largely because of the transfer portal. However, since the system had only suffered a single losing season since 2013, I figured I owed it to VSIN readers to go with the methodology “as-is.” Well, unfortunately, that backfired a bit for me and for everyone who has benefited from the Stability System for many years, as the final record wound up being just 30-36 ATS. I promised that I would dig into the nuts and bolts of the concept to see whether what I was doing still made sense in this new era. I did and now have some new data to share.

The College Football Stability System is for the first four weeks of every season (Weeks 0, 1, 2, and 3). It is the foremost strategy I employ every year to find value early. The thought behind it is that teams in more stable year-to-year situations are better bets early, while those that have undergone significant offseason change should be faded. I feel the logic is fundamentally sound. Returning fewer starters, starting over at quarterback, and welcoming new head coaches or coordinators are always hurdles for teams.

One of the biggest areas of transition for teams nowadays is the transfer of starting quarterbacks. To me, the position is of such importance that a transfer quarterback for a team, even if he has three years of starting experience somewhere else, I still consider him a NEW quarterback, or more effectively, a change at QB. He is still learning new schemes, and while his veteran experience may lessen some of the bumps along the way, there are still hurdles to overcome early on with this new player in this most key position. There can be degrees to this; however, in the current era, some QBs, such as Rocco Becht of Penn State, followed their former school's head coach and OC to a new school. To me, this is still a big change. So, to clarify how I am dealing with the transfer portal starters, here is your answer: I consider former starters acquired through the transfer portal at non-QB positions as starters.

This is where the new numbers and changes will come in. I have conducted regression analysis on my College Football Stability System and here are the results. First off, my results still did show that the FIRST FOUR WEEKS (0, 1, 2, and 3) were the most impacted by stability. So, I will be sticking with that. Also, since most of the changes I've seen in the college football world have occurred since the COVID season, I have looked back at the results of the various stability factors in the first four weeks after 2021. Here are those results. Note that these trends only include FBS vs. FBS games.

- NEW head coaches are 91-153 SU and 110-132 ATS (45.4%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus returning head coaches since 2021
- NEW offensive coordinators are 157-203 SU and 177-178 ATS (49.9%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus returning offensive coordinators since 2021
- NEW defensive coordinators are 165-198 SU and 163-195 ATS (45.5%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus returning defensive coordinators since 2021

- NEW starting quarterbacks are 159-178 SU and 157-172 ATS (47.7%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus returning defensive coordinators since 2021
- Teams with 0-7 total returning starters are 21-60 SU and 40-41 ATS (49.4%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus teams returning 8+ since 2021
- Teams with 17+ total returning starters are 107-89 SU and 108-86 ATS (55.7%) in the first four weeks of the CFB season versus teams returning 16 or fewer since 2021

From this info, bettors can certainly discern that having new head coaches, new defensive coordinators, and many returning starters are the most impactful offseason developments.

I also recognized that CONFERENCE GAMES on my stability system were pulling down the winning percentages. In fact, teams with an old stability edge of seven points or more in conference games were only winning around 49.5% ATS.

The other two things I found that were negatively impacting my Stability System results were 1) games with point spreads of 30+ and 2) leaving out teams with an edge of 6 on the stability scores.

With the stats above in mind, my official new College Football Stability System(s) will read as follows:

Play ON any team with a STABILITY SCORE EDGE of 6+ in non-conference games in the first four weeks of the season (weeks 0, 1, 2, 3), assuming the game DOES NOT have a point spread of -30 or higher for either team. (335-222 SU and 302-243-12 ATS, 55.4% since 2013)

AND

Play AGAINST any team with STABILITY SCORES of 0-6 in non-conference games in the first four weeks of the season (weeks 0, 1, 2, 3) versus teams with higher scores, assuming the game DOES NOT have a point spread of -30 or higher for either team (FADE record 259-136 SU and 217-173-4 ATS, 55.6% since 2013)

Doing regression on the tweaked Stability Score Edge System, I found that over the last 13 years, there were only two losing seasons, one of them being last year. The second angle, teams with 0-6 scores, even lost a year ago, as they were 22-26 ATS. In my opinion, both systems are still very viable.

Just below, I've put together a chart of the College Football Stability Scores for 2026. When the season arrives, I will put together lists in each of the first four weeks detailing the top mismatches. Again, I have now found that a Stability Mismatch score of 6 is the minimum on which I will consider a play for this thought process in non-conference games. Incidentally, USC (15) hosting San Jose State (7) in Week 0 would be a play for 2026 except the Trojans are 35.5-point favorites. Instead, Hawaii (14) -3.5 at Stanford (3) and UNLV (10) -3.5 hosting Memphis (2) are the first two playable games for Week 0.

Here is how the scores are determined:

Returning Head Coach Points

Yes, same Head Coach as 2025: 4 points
No, new Head Coach for 2026: 0 points

Returning Offensive Coordinator Points

Yes, same Offensive Coordinator as 2025: 3 points
No, new Offensive Coordinator for 2026: 0 points

Returning Defensive Coordinator Points

Yes, same Defensive Coordinator as 2025: 3 points
No, new Defensive Coordinator for 2026: 0 points

Same Starting Quarterback Points

Yes, same Starting Quarterback as 2025: 4 points
No, new Starting Quarterback for 2026: 0 points

I reiterate...I consider a transfer quarterback who is expected to start for his team a NEW QUARTERBACK, regardless of the level of starting experience he brings to the table. For 2026, there are again numerous

recognizable QBs that have found new starting homes across the country. For instance, Josh Hoover at Indiana or Sam Leavitt at LSU are among the veteran QBs across the country that boast big-game college football experience but will be in new schemes this fall. While they are not your typical first-year quarterbacks, they are NEW to those programs.

Total Number of Returning Starters Points

0-7 returning offensive and defensive starters: 0 points
8-9: 1 point
10-12: 2 points
13-16: 3 points
17-19: 4 points
20-22: 5 points

A perfect score is 19. The worst score a team can have is ZERO, and that has happened more often in each of the last four years than it had in the 10 years prior combined. So, as you analyze the chart of the 138 FBS teams, you'll see that there are some very interesting numbers. Some of the key things you are going to want to note as we head into the season, especially based upon the trend records I showed earlier.



1. There are 33 new head coaching situations, 68 new offensive coordinators, and 63 new defensive coordinator situations.

2. The number of returning starters for the 138 teams range from 1 to 19. As I showed earlier, teams returning 17+ starters have combined to go 55.7% ATS in the first four weeks of the last five college football seasons. For the record, the teams with 17+ starters returning are:

- | | |
|--------------|-----------------|
| • ARIZONA | • UCLA |
| • HOUSTON | • USC |
| • NOTRE DAME | • VIRGINIA TECH |
| • TEXAS A&M | |

3. There are 10 teams with Stability Scores of ZERO. From 2022-2025, the average was just 6.25, meaning this season is lining up as one of the most unstable on record. Theoretically, these are the most unstable programs heading into 2026:

- | | |
|---------------------|--------------------|
| • CONNECTICUT | • NORTH TEXAS |
| • IOWA STATE | • SACRAMENTO STATE |
| • JAMES MADISON | • SOUTH FLORIDA |
| • MISSOURI STATE | • SOUTHERN MISS |
| • NORTHERN ILLINOIS | • TOLEDO |

4. The rest of the teams that will be FADE teams in the first four weeks of the season besides those with ZERO scores are this group:

- | | |
|------------------------|------------------------|
| • ARKANSAS (3) | • KENTUCKY (2) |
| • AUBURN (4) | • LSU (6) |
| • BOSTON COLLEGE (5) | • MEMPHIS (2) |
| • BOWLING GREEN (4) | • MICHIGAN STATE (5) |
| • BUFFALO (4) | • OHIO U (3) |
| • CALIFORNIA (6) | • OKLAHOMA STATE (2) |
| • CINCINNATI (5) | • OREGON STATE (6) |
| • COASTAL CAROLINA (1) | • PENN STATE (3) |
| • COLORADO STATE (3) | • STANFORD (3) |
| • EAST CAROLINA (4) | • TULANE (4) |
| • FLORIDA (3) | • UTAH (5) |
| • GEORGIA TECH (6) | • VIRGINIA TECH (4) |
| • KANSAS STATE (6) | • WASHINGTON STATE (1) |

5. On the opposite side of the argument are the teams that would be considered MOST stable heading into 2026. Here are the 14 teams with STABILITY SCORES of 16 or higher:

- | | |
|----------------------------|-------------------|
| • ARIZONA STATE (18) | • MINNESOTA (17) |
| • BOISE STATE (16) | • NC STATE (16) |
| • DELAWARE (16) | • NEW MEXICO (16) |
| • FLORIDA ATLANTIC (16) | • NOTRE DAME (18) |
| • GEORGIA (17) | • OHIO STATE (17) |
| • HOUSTON (18) | • OKLAHOMA (17) |
| • LOUISIANA LAFAYETTE (16) | • TEXAS (17) |

Of note here, eight of these teams are Power Four conference teams along with national title contender Notre Dame and Group of Six CFP hopeful Boise State.

**THE FOLLOWING
PAGES HAVE MY
STABILITY SCORES
FOR EACH TEAM
ENTERING THE
2026 SEASON**



TEAM (CONFERENCE)	2025 RECORD	CHANGE? (0-YES)				RET STRS	TOTAL STABILITY
		HC?	OC?	DC?	QB?		
AIR FORCE (MWC)	4-8	4	3	0	4	2 (12)	13
AKRON (MAC)	5-7	4	3	3	0	2 (11)	12
ALABAMA (SEC)	11-4	4	3	3	0	2 (10)	12
APPALACHIAN ST (SBC)	5-8	4	0	3	0	0 (5)	7
ARIZONA (B12)	9-4	4	3	3	4	3 (14)	17
ARIZONA ST (B12)	8-5	4	3	3	0	2 (12)	12
ARKANSAS (SEC)	2-10	0	0	0	0	3 (13)	3
ARKANSAS ST (SBC)	7-6	4	0	3	0	2 (10)	9
ARMY (AAC)	7-6	4	3	0	4	2 (11)	13
AUBURN (SEC)	5-7	0	0	3	0	1 (9)	4
BALL ST (MAC)	4-8	4	3	3	0	0 (6)	10
BAYLOR (B12)	5-7	4	3	0	0	2 (12)	9
BOISE ST (P12)	9-5	4	3	3	4	2 (11)	16
BOSTON COLLEGE (ACC)	2-10	4	0	0	0	1 (9)	5
BOWLING GREEN (MAC)	4-8	4	0	0	0	0 (6)	4
BUFFALO (MAC)	5-7	4	0	0	0	0 (6)	4
BYU (B12)	12-2	4	3	0	4	3 (13)	14
C MICHIGAN (MAC)	7-6	4	3	3	0	1 (8)	11
CALIFORNIA (ACC)	7-6	0	0	0	4	2 (11)	6
CHARLOTTE (AAC)	1-11	4	3	3	4	1 (9)	15
CINCINNATI (B12)	7-6	4	0	0	0	1 (9)	5
CLEMSON (ACC)	7-6	4	0	3	0	2 (10)	9
COASTAL CAROLINA (SBC)	6-7	0	0	0	0	1 (9)	1
COLORADO (B12)	3-9	4	0	0	0	3 (15)	7
COLORADO ST (P12)	2-10	0	0	3	0	0 (7)	3
CONNECTICUT (IND)	9-4	0	0	0	0	0 (5)	0
DELAWARE (CUSA)	7-6	4	3	3	4	2 (12)	16
DUKE (ACC)	9-5	4	3	3	0	2 (11)	12
E MICHIGAN (MAC)	4-8	4	3	0	4	2 (12)	13
EAST CAROLINA (AAC)	9-4	4	0	0	0	0 (7)	4
FLA ATLANTIC (AAC)	4-8	4	3	3	4	2 (12)	16
FLA INTERNATIONAL (CUSA)	7-6	4	3	3	0	0 (7)	10
FLORIDA (SEC)	4-8	0	0	0	0	3 (13)	3
FLORIDA ST (ACC)	5-7	4	0	3	0	2 (11)	9
FRESNO ST (P12)	9-4	4	3	3	0	3 (13)	13
GA SOUTHERN (SBC)	7-6	4	3	0	0	1 (9)	8
GEORGIA (SEC)	12-2	4	3	3	4	3 (14)	17
GEORGIA ST (SBC)	1-11	4	3	0	4	1 (8)	12
GEORGIA TECH (ACC)	9-4	4	0	0	0	2 (10)	6
HAWAII (MWC)	9-4	4	3	3	4	0 (7)	14
HOUSTON (B12)	10-3	4	3	3	4	4 (19)	18
ILLINOIS (B10)	9-4	4	3	0	0	2 (11)	9
INDIANA (B10)	16-0	4	3	3	0	3 (16)	13
IOWA (B10)	9-4	4	3	3	0	1 (9)	11
IOWA ST (B12)	8-4	0	0	0	0	0 (4)	0
JACKSONVILLE ST (CUSA)	9-5	4	0	3	4	1 (9)	12

TEAM (CONFERENCE)	2025 RECORD	CHANGE? (0-YES)				RET STRS	TOTAL STABILITY
		HC?	OC?	DC?	QB?		
JAMES MADISON (SBC)	12-2	0	0	0	0	0 (5)	0
KANSAS (B12)	5-7	4	3	3	0	2 (12)	12
KANSAS ST (B12)	6-6	0	0	0	4	2 (12)	6
KENNESAW ST (CUSA)	10-4	4	3	3	0	1 (9)	11
KENT ST (MAC)	5-7	4	0	0	4	2 (10)	10
KENTUCKY (SEC)	5-7	0	0	0	0	2 (11)	2
LA LAFAYETTE (SBC)	6-7	4	3	3	4	2 (10)	16
LA MONROE (SBC)	3-9	4	0	0	4	1 (8)	9
LIBERTY (CUSA)	4-8	4	0	3	0	2 (12)	9
LOUISIANA TECH (SBC)	8-5	4	0	3	4	1 (9)	12
LOUISVILLE (ACC)	9-4	4	3	0	0	3 (14)	10
LSU (SEC)	7-6	0	0	3	0	3 (14)	6
MARSHALL (SBC)	5-7	4	3	0	4	1 (9)	12
MARYLAND (B10)	4-8	4	0	3	4	3 (16)	14
MASSACHUSETTS (MAC)	0-12	4	0	3	0	1 (9)	8
MEMPHIS (AAC)	8-5	0	0	0	0	2 (10)	2
MIAMI FL (ACC)	13-3	4	3	3	0	2 (12)	12
MIAMI OHIO (MAC)	7-7	4	0	3	0	2 (12)	9
MICHIGAN (B10)	9-4	0	0	0	4	3 (14)	7
MICHIGAN ST (B10)	4-8	0	0	3	0	2 (12)	5
MIDDLE TENN ST (CUSA)	3-9	4	0	3	0	0 (6)	7
MINNESOTA (B10)	8-5	4	3	3	4	3 (13)	17
MISSISSIPPI ST (SEC)	5-8	4	3	0	0	2 (11)	9
MISSOURI (SEC)	8-5	4	0	3	0	2 (12)	9
MISSOURI ST (CUSA)	7-6	0	0	0	0	0 (5)	0
N DAKOTA ST (MWC)	12-1	4	3	3	0	2 (10)	12
N ILLINOIS (MWC)	3-9	0	0	0	0	0 (6)	0
NAVY (AAC)	11-2	4	3	0	0	2 (11)	9
NC STATE (ACC)	8-5	4	3	3	4	2 (10)	16
NEBRASKA (B10)	7-6	4	3	0	0	3 (15)	10
NEVADA (MWC)	3-9	4	0	3	0	0 (5)	7
NEW MEXICO (MWC)	9-4	4	3	3	4	2 (12)	16
NEW MEXICO ST (CUSA)	4-8	4	3	3	0	2 (10)	12
NORTH CAROLINA (ACC)	4-8	4	0	3	0	1 (9)	8
NORTH TEXAS (AAC)	12-2	0	0	0	0	0 (5)	0
NORTHWESTERN (B10)	7-6	4	0	3	0	2 (12)	9
NOTRE DAME (IND)	10-2	4	3	3	4	4 (17)	18
OHIO ST (B10)	12-2	4	3	3	4	3 (14)	17
OHIO U (MAC)	9-4	0	3	0	0	0 (5)	3
OKLAHOMA (SEC)	10-3	4	3	3	4	3 (16)	17
OKLAHOMA ST (B12)	1-11	0	0	0	0	2 (10)	2
OLD DOMINION (SBC)	10-3	4	0	3	0	0 (7)	7
OLE MISS (SEC)	13-2	0	0	3	4	3 (16)	10
OREGON (B10)	13-2	4	0	3	4	3 (15)	14
OREGON ST (P12)	2-10	0	0	0	4	2 (10)	6
PENN ST (B10)	7-6	0	0	0	0	3 (16)	3

TEAM (CONFERENCE)	2025 RECORD	CHANGE? (0-YES)				RET STRS	TOTAL STABILITY
		HC?	OC?	DC?	QB?		
PITTSBURGH (ACC)	8-5	4	3	0	4	3 (13)	14
PURDUE (B10)	2-10	4	3	0	4	2 (11)	13
RICE (AAC)	5-8	4	3	3	0	0 (6)	10
RUTGERS (B10)	5-7	4	3	0	0	2 (12)	9
S ALABAMA (SBC)	4-8	4	0	3	4	1 (8)	12
SACRAMENTO ST (MAC)	7-5	0	0	0	0	0 (6)	0
SAM HOUSTON ST (CUSA)	2-10	4	3	3	0	0 (7)	10
SAN DIEGO ST (P12)	9-4	4	3	0	4	3 (13)	14
SAN JOSE ST (MWC)	3-9	4	3	0	0	0 (3)	7
SMU (ACC)	9-4	4	3	0	4	2 (12)	13
SOUTH CAROLINA (SEC)	4-8	4	0	0	4	3 (14)	11
SOUTH FLORIDA (AAC)	9-4	0	0	0	0	0 (7)	0
SOUTHERN MISS (SBC)	7-6	0	0	0	0	0 (1)	0
STANFORD (ACC)	4-8	0	0	0	0	3 (14)	3
SYRACUSE (ACC)	3-9	4	3	0	4	2 (11)	13
TCU (B12)	9-4	4	3	3	0	2 (12)	12
TEMPLE (AAC)	5-7	4	3	3	0	2 (10)	12
TENNESSEE (SEC)	8-5	4	3	0	0	3 (14)	10
TEXAS (SEC)	10-3	4	3	3	4	3 (16)	17
TEXAS A&M (SEC)	11-2	4	3	0	4	4 (18)	15
TEXAS ST UNIV (P12)	7-6	4	3	0	4	2 (11)	13
TEXAS TECH (B12)	12-2	4	3	3	0	3 (15)	13
TOLEDO (MAC)	8-5	0	0	0	0	0 (6)	0
TROY (SBC)	8-6	4	0	3	4	0 (6)	11
TULANE (AAC)	11-3	0	0	3	0	1 (8)	4
TULSA (AAC)	4-8	4	3	3	4	1 (9)	15
TX-SAN ANTONIO (AAC)	7-6	4	0	3	4	1 (8)	12
UAB (AAC)	4-8	4	3	0	0	0 (4)	7
UCF (B12)	5-7	4	3	3	0	2 (12)	12
UCLA (B10)	3-9	0	0	0	4	4 (18)	8
UNLV (MWC)	10-4	4	3	3	0	0 (6)	10
USC (B10)	9-4	4	3	0	4	4 (17)	15
UTAH (B12)	11-2	0	0	0	4	1 (8)	5
UTAH ST (P12)	6-7	4	0	3	0	2 (12)	9
UTEP (MWC)	2-10	4	0	3	0	0 (6)	7
VANDERBILT (SEC)	10-3	4	3	3	0	3 (13)	13
VIRGINIA (ACC)	11-3	4	3	3	0	3 (14)	13
VIRGINIA TECH (ACC)	3-9	0	0	0	0	4 (17)	4
W KENTUCKY (CUSA)	9-4	4	0	3	4	0 (7)	11
W MICHIGAN (MAC)	10-4	4	3	0	4	2 (10)	13
WAKE FOREST (ACC)	9-4	4	3	3	0	2 (11)	12
WASHINGTON (B10)	9-4	4	0	3	4	3 (14)	14
WASHINGTON ST (P12)	7-6	0	0	0	0	1 (8)	1
WEST VIRGINIA (B12)	4-8	4	0	3	4	2 (12)	13
WISCONSIN (B10)	4-8	4	3	3	0	2 (10)	12
WYOMING (MWC)	4-8	4	0	3	0	0 (5)	7

THE YEAR OF THE QUARTERBACK

by Paul Stone

A year ago, Fernando Mendoza did not top any preseason lists that ranked the elite quarterbacks in college football, and that turned out to be a big miss by many analysts. Mendoza managed to outplay several other overhyped quarterbacks en route to winning the Heisman Trophy, leading Indiana to the national championship and becoming the No. 1 pick in the NFL Draft.

The importance of the quarterback to a team's success is obvious, but scouting the position accurately is not always easy.

In 2024, a record six quarterbacks were selected in the first round of the draft, including the first three overall picks. Now, after back-to-back down years at the position, some analysts believe the 2027 draft could challenge the first-round record.

Time will tell, but this has the potential to be "The Year of the Quarterback" in college football. While names like Manning, Chambliss and Carr are certain to garner their share of headlines during the upcoming season, the depth of this year's class is what sets it apart.

Without further ado, this is how I rank the top quarterbacks entering this season.

2. TRINIDAD CHAMBLISS, OLE MISS

Was there a better single-game performance in 2025 than the masterpiece turned in by Chambliss in the Rebels' 39-34 CFP quarterfinal win over Georgia? Eluding would-be Dawg defenders play after play, the Ferris State transfer threw for 362 yards against one of the nation's stingiest stop units. Currently listed at 15-1 to win the Heisman, one could argue Chambliss is the best betting option on the board.

3. CJ CARR, NOTRE DAME

Manning and Chambliss share top billing, but it would be no surprise if Carr hoisted the hardware in Manhattan come the second Saturday in December. Draft analyst Todd McShay hailed Carr as the MVP at the recent Manning Passing Academy, proclaiming "it wasn't even close." The Irish are legitimate national championship contenders, so Carr's possibilities for individual and team accolades seem endless.

4. DANTE MOORE, OREGON

After struggling as a true freshman at UCLA and then sitting behind Dillon Gabriel at Oregon as a sophomore, the Detroit native showed why he was one of the top recruits in the Class of 2023, leading the Ducks to the CFP semifinals last season. Moore was projected by some as a

potential top-five selection in this past April's draft, but he opted to return to school.

5. GUNNER STOCKTON, GEORGIA

Despite an NIL deal reportedly north of \$1 million, Stockton drives a hand-me-down 1984 Ford F-150 pickup gifted by his grandfather with over 300,000 miles. Like his truck, he's an old-school throwback who may not throw the prettiest ball yet competes with grit and comes through in clutch moments.

receivers may be among the nation's finest after scoring big in the portal.

10. DARIAN MENSAB, MIAMI

Coming out of St. Joseph High School in Santa Maria, Calif., Mensah was a largely-ignored two-star prospect who ultimately ended up with just two offers: Tulane and Idaho State. After spending one season each at Tulane and Duke, Mensah (56 career passing TDs) steps into the South Beach spotlight as he attempts to guide the Hurricanes back to the playoff.

11. BEAR BACHMEIER, BYU

As a true freshman, Bachmeier threw for 3,000 yards or more, rushed for 500 or more, accounted for at least 25 TDs, and had 10 or fewer turnovers, becoming only the 19th power conference quarterback to accomplish that

feat in the past 20 years. With a full offseason to sharpen his skills, Bachmeier is an intriguing Heisman long shot at 80/1 at Westgate.

12. MARCEL REED, TEXAS A&M

At his best, Reed can beat opponents with his arm (more than 5,000 yards passing across the past two seasons) and legs (more than 1,000 yards rushing during the same term). At his worst, the Nashville product has turned the ball over 21 times in 21 career starts - including a total of five in back-to-back losses to Texas and Miami to end the 2025 season.

13. JAYDEN MAIABA, USC

The Honolulu native began his career at UNLV, but a stellar freshman season there in 2023 (almost 3,100 yards passing) caught the eye of Lincoln Riley and others. Maiaba has a big arm, but needs to protect the football (26 interceptions in three seasons) and perform better on the road. If he does those things and new receivers emerge, he could be a dark horse contender for national honors.

14. BYRUM BROWN, AUBURN

The 6-foot-3, 232-pound dual-threat Brown had better rushing (1,008 yards) and passing (3,158 yards) numbers at South Florida last season than Mateer did at Washington State in 2024. If Brown remains healthy, the Tigers could throw a wrench in someone's playoff plans.

15. CJ BAILEY, NORTH CAROLINA STATE

At 6-foot-6 with a quick release and big arm, Bailey has certainly attracted the attention of NFL scouts. With 22 starts under his belt in just two years on campus - if he can refine his mechanics and sharpen his accuracy - it's not out of the question that he could ultimately play his way into the first round of the draft.

“

1. ARCH MANNING, TEXAS

Perhaps the most polarizing figure in all of college sports, Manning began the 2025 season as the Heisman favorite, but he sputtered in September and quickly fell from grace. From October on, however, the nephew of two former Super Bowl MVPs showcased his talents, throwing for 2,012 yards in the season's final eight games, while accounting for 21 touchdowns against just three turnovers during that span. Expect to see the Longhorns utilize Manning more in the running game after his 155-yard rushing outburst against Michigan in the Citrus Bowl.

”

6. JULIAN SAYIN, OHIO STATE

With college football's top pass catcher, Jeremiah Smith, and an embarrassment of other riches at his disposal, Sayin is a solid bet to post Heisman-worthy numbers in his second season as the Buckeyes' starter. Games against Texas, Indiana, USC, Oregon and Michigan certainly provide the platform to attract the voters' attention. At a double-digit price (12-1 at Circa), Sayin may be worth a look in the Heisman market.

7. JOHN MATEER, OKLAHOMA

Opinions are mixed on Mateer, who was hindered by a bum thumb on his throwing hand throughout much of the 2025 campaign. Supporters say he's among the nation's elite at his position, while detractors want more evidence against top-shelf opposition. The tough Texan is a true dual threat, having rushed for 847 yards and 15 TDs in 2024 at Washington State.

8. LANORRIS SELLERS, SOUTH CAROLINA

Gamecock quarterbacks have been sacked more than 40 times in each of the past three seasons. With more experience up front, the dynamic Sellers could shine with additional time to operate. At 6-3 and 245 pounds, Sellers is a load to bring down as evidenced by his 674 rushing yards in 2024. For those dreaming of a bigger Heisman payout, Sellers is currently 50-1 at the Westgate SuperBook.

9. SAM LEAVITT, LSU

After guiding Arizona State to the first-ever 12-team CFP in 2024, Leavitt's production dipped last season, primarily because of a foot injury which shortened his season by five games. The dual-threat Leavitt might not have a Cam Skattebo in his arsenal, but the Tigers'

Putting together my college football power ratings for the 2026 season involves analyzing the returning players/coaches for the teams, making adjustments based on last year's finish and the current perception of teams, and also ensuring I have not assumed anything out of the window for normalcy for each team's recent history or conference strength. That last point has become a bigger challenge each passing year as some teams completely revamp their rosters through the transfer portal.

Only 52 teams are returning their starting quarterbacks from last season, and several of the country's most prominent teams from a year ago are not, most notably title game participants Indiana and Miami (FL). If you're thinking the coaching carousel was significant in the offseason, the 33 changes to programs this season in that regard are a fairly high number.

Last year, of the five teams from the Power Four (or Independent) that I projected to win 10+ games in this same exercise, only one of them made the CFP. However, the year before, four of the five made up the four semifinal teams. For 2026, there are seven teams that are projected to win 10+ games, and that group is Notre Dame (11.2), Texas Tech (10.7), Oregon (10.3), Indiana (10.2), Miami (FL) (10.1), Ohio State (10.0) and Georgia (10.0). As you look at the conference overview pages, you'll see other teams such as Penn State, Texas, and BYU that could join those frontrunners.

I've taken my adjusted power numbers for 2026 and run them against the complete schedule to project the season standings. You will also find a listing of all 138 FBS teams and their schedules, with my projected power ratings lines for each game.

Before unleashing the projections, however, let's look at some of the highlights from the analysis:

- According to my figures, after two straight seasons of Florida playing the toughest schedule nationally, Texas takes over for 2026, at least as it stands now. The Longhorns are ranked just ahead of Oklahoma, Kentucky, Mississippi State, and Arkansas in that regard, all SEC teams. My projections have the Longhorns finishing at 9-3 in the regular season, but I could easily be talked into more, as I believe they are a legit national title contender. The schedules of the other four SEC teams on the list are mostly due to conference opponents. The first non-SEC team on the list is Michigan at No. 6.
- The "easiest" schedule this season belongs to UMass, who unseats Liberty for that honor after the Flames held the designation for the last three seasons. The Minutemen's 2026 opponents average a 26.21 power rating. To put that in perspective, it would be like playing a team at Bowling Green's level every week for an entire season. Even still, my numbers call for them to go just 3.4-8.6 this season. However, even with an easier slate last season, UMass went 0-12. In terms of other weak schedules, Buffalo, Sacramento State, and Ohio, all other MAC teams as well, check in at Nos. 2-4. The first non-MAC team on the weak schedule list is Jacksonville State, at No. 5, out of Conference USA. For the record, Liberty is the No. 6.
- Notre Dame has the highest win projection of any team, with 11.2, a half win better than Texas Tech (10.7). Oregon (10.3), Indiana (10.2), and Miami (FL) (10.1) round out the top five. The only other double-digit win projections go to Ohio State and Georgia.
- Assuming the projections play out accurately, besides Texas Tech, Oregon, Indiana, Miami (FL), and Ohio State the other Power Four conference teams that would be expected to contend for a spot in the College Football Playoff this year would be Georgia, Texas, Penn State, BYU, and perhaps SMU or Utah. All of those teams are expected to win 8.9 or more regular-season games, according to my

projections. Some of the intriguing "longshot" contenders could include Alabama, Texas A&M, LSU, and USC.

- Boise State (9.2), James Madison (9.1), UNLV (9.0), and Navy (8.5), and New Mexico (8.5) have the highest projected win totals among the Group of Six teams, although each faces an early test or two that might prevent them from going undefeated and challenging for the coveted CFP spot.
- In terms of teams expected to improve from last season, either by an enhanced power rating or projected wins compared to last regular season, Oklahoma State (+14) and Virginia Tech (+10) are the two teams I have with double-digit power rating increases. In terms of the biggest win total gains expected for this season, the projections call for OSU (+4.7), VT (+4.3), and Liberty (+4.1) to all win at least four games more than a season ago.
- There are a crazy number of eight teams that drop by 10 points or more in my power ratings for the 2026 preseason when compared to last year's finish. The biggest loser, if you will, is North Texas, who falls by a huge 14-point downgrade. It's not hard to understand why when you realize that new head coach Neal Brown is taking over virtually a brand-new team, one with no starter back from the 2025 group that went 12-2 and scored 45.1 PPG.
- Other big drops belong with James Madison (-12.5) and Tulane (-11.5), two other complete rebuilds for new coaches. The worst drops among P4 programs belong to Vanderbilt (-10.5) and Iowa State (-10).
- In terms of biggest win total declines compared to the 2025 regular season, you'll find North Texas (-5.1), North Dakota State (-4.0), Connecticut (-3.7), and Vanderbilt (-3.6) at the top of the list. Perhaps the most interesting team among that group is NDSU, who moves up to FBS for the first time and figures to see better and more consistent tough competition on a weekly basis in the Mountain West.
- In terms of the projections and how they correlate to the Season Win Totals offered up at DraftKings, here are the biggest differences. Teams expected to win more games than their DK win props include Boise State (+1.7), UNLV (+1.5), Arkansas State (+1.3), Miami (OH) (+1.3), Georgia Southern (+1.3), Western Kentucky (+1.2), and Navy (+1.0) as the teams exceeding a 1.0 difference. The Broncos +1.7 difference represents one of the biggest I've ever had in this exercise, and I even double- and triple-checked the numbers to be sure. I think the oddsmakers are giving a bit too much credit to the strength of the new Pac-12, and in my opinion, BSU is the obvious favorite. I guess the same goes for the Runnin' Rebels, who figure to benefit greatly from Boise leaving the Mountain West.
- Teams expected to fall short of their season win props by the biggest margins include Northern Illinois (-1.1), Georgia State (-1.0), Florida (-0.9), Sam Houston State (-0.8), and Cal (-0.8). Interestingly, Northern Illinois makes a jump in conference strength by moving from the MAC to the Mountain West. Also, Florida gets a new head coach in Jon Sumrall, who seems to have the enthusiasm meter pegged, but perhaps not the roster yet to compete in what looks like a very strong and balanced SEC. In general, I'm not a fan of big conference teams making regular coaching changes when it appears some progress is being made, as it sets the program back usually.

Throughout this year's Guide, you will find my projected standings for each of the conferences. The teams are sorted by CONFERENCE WINS. You will also find their season win total from DraftKings, their 2026 Steve Makinen Power Rating, Home and Road Field Ratings, Schedule Strength & National Ranking, plus their overall & conference record projections.

STEVE MAKINEN'S POWER RATINGS

TEAM	POWER RATING	TEAM	POWER RATING	TEAM	POWER RATING
AIR FORCE	37.0	JAMES MADISON	41.5	PITTSBURGH	50.5
AKRON	25.0	KANSAS	46.0	PURDUE	39.0
ALABAMA	61.0	KANSAS STATE	51.0	RICE	27.5
APPALACHIAN STATE	30.0	KENNESAW STATE	31.5	RUTGERS	42.5
ARIZONA	52.5	KENT STATE	23.5	SOUTH ALABAMA	29.0
ARIZONA STATE	49.5	KENTUCKY	47.0	SACRAMENTO STATE	21.5
ARKANSAS	45.5	LOUISIANA	32.5	SAM HOUSTON STATE	18.5
ARKANSAS STATE	33.5	LOUISIANA-MONROE	22.0	SAN DIEGO STATE	43.0
ARMY	40.0	LIBERTY	34.5	SAN JOSE STATE	27.0
AUBURN	52.5	LOUISIANA TECH	33.0	SMU	55.5
BALL STATE	20.0	LOUISVILLE	53.5	SOUTH CAROLINA	54.0
BAYLOR	47.0	LSU	60.5	SOUTH FLORIDA	41.0
BOISE STATE	50.5	MARSHALL	34.0	SOUTHERN MISS	25.5
BOSTON COLLEGE	37.5	MARYLAND	45.5	STANFORD	39.0
BOWLING GREEN	26.5	MASSACHUSETTS	16.0	SYRACUSE	42.0
BUFFALO	28.0	MEMPHIS	41.0	TCU	51.0
BYU	57.5	MIAMI	63.0	TEMPLE	34.0
CENTRAL MICHIGAN	30.5	MIAMI OHIO	36.0	TENNESSEE	57.0
CALIFORNIA	45.5	MICHIGAN	59.0	TEXAS	66.0
CHARLOTTE	20.5	MICHIGAN STATE	42.5	TEXAS A&M	62.5
CINCINNATI	44.5	MIDDLE TENNESSEE STATE	21.0	TEXAS STATE	37.5
CLEMSON	54.0	MINNESOTA	49.0	TEXAS TECH	61.5
COASTAL CAROLINA	28.0	MISSISSIPPI STATE	47.0	TOLEDO	35.5
COLORADO	43.0	MISSOURI	54.5	TROY	36.0
COLORADO STATE	32.5	MISSOURI STATE	25.0	TULANE	42.5
CONNECTICUT	31.5	NORTH DAKOTA STATE	37.0	TULSA	32.5
DELAWARE	31.0	NORTHERN ILLINOIS	21.5	UTSA	41.0
DUKE	46.5	NAVY	44.0	UAB	26.0
EASTERN MICHIGAN	28.0	NORTH CAROLINA STATE	48.0	UCF	44.5
EAST CAROLINA	40.5	NEBRASKA	50.5	UCLA	48.0
FLORIDA ATLANTIC	33.5	NEVADA	28.0	UNLV	44.0
FLORIDA INTERNATIONAL	28.5	NEW MEXICO	42.0	USC	60.0
FLORIDA	55.5	NEW MEXICO STATE	25.0	UTAH	54.5
FLORIDA STATE	50.0	NORTH CAROLINA	44.5	UTAH STATE	36.5
FRESNO STATE	42.5	NORTH TEXAS	34.5	UTEP	22.5
GEORGIA SOUTHERN	33.5	NORTHWESTERN	45.5	VANDERBILT	51.5
GEORGIA	67.5	NOTRE DAME	68.5	VIRGINIA	50.5
GEORGIA STATE	23.0	OHIO STATE	71.0	VIRGINIA TECH	51.0
GEORGIA TECH	49.0	OHIO U	31.5	WESTERN KENTUCKY	36.5
HAWAII	38.5	OKLAHOMA	61.0	WESTERN MICHIGAN	37.5
HOUSTON	53.0	OKLAHOMA STATE	46.5	WAKE FOREST	46.5
ILLINOIS	51.0	OLD DOMINION	37.0	WASHINGTON	56.5
INDIANA	66.0	OLE MISS	60.5	WASHINGTON STATE	38.0
IOWA	55.5	OREGON	68.5	WEST VIRGINIA	45.0
IOWA STATE	41.5	OREGON STATE	32.0	WISCONSIN	47.5
JACKSONVILLE STATE	34.0	PENN STATE	57.0	WYOMING	30.5

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AMERICAN

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

The American Conference seems pretty wide-open for the 2026 season and it's fair to wonder if any team will have the record or resume to represent the Group of Six in the College Football Playoff. There are four new head coaches and five second-year head coaches in the conference, so nine of the league's 14 teams are tough to project. Tenured coaches might have an inside track this season, but anything could happen.

In terms of preseason conference winner odds, only the MAC has a higher-priced favorite than the American and seven of the 14 teams are priced at +800 or lower. Navy is the tepid favorite here with one of the more tenured coaches in the conference, as Brian Newberry begins his fourth season at the helm. UTSA's Jeff Traylor and Army's Jeff Monken are the only two sideline bosses with more years under their belts than Newberry. It probably isn't a coincidence that UTSA (+480) and Army (6-1) are the second and third favorites, respectively, behind Navy (+310).

Life is tough in the American Conference for college football these days. As mentioned, nine of the 14 teams have head coaches hired within the last two seasons because this conference is a springboard to Power Four jobs. Furthermore, any players that stand out are going to be on the minds of SEC, ACC, Big Ten, and Big 12 teams that are looking to fill some voids and plug some holes. In some respects, the service academies have an advantage in that they aren't watching players go out the door for NIL paydays, but they also can't leverage the transfer portal to their advantage.

Outside of Army and Navy, just about every program in the conference has fewer than 10 returning starters. But, that doesn't mean they are immune to big personnel losses, especially in Navy's case with QB Blake Horvath.

In a high-variance conference, there should be money to be made, whether you can isolate overachievers or underachievers with props and futures before the season or on a weekly basis.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
NAVY	7.5	44	2.3	0.8	35.19 (86)	8.5	3.5	6.2	1.8
TULANE	7.5	42.5	3.4	0.6	35.2 (84)	8.0	4.0	5.7	2.3
EAST CAROLINA	7.5	40.5	3	0.7	33.46 (96)	8.0	4.0	5.6	2.4
TX-SAN ANTONIO	7.5	41	4.1	-0.5	36.05 (80)	7.7	4.3	5.3	2.7
MEMPHIS	7.5	41	2.9	0.7	35.48 (81)	7.3	4.7	5.0	3.0
ARMY	7.5	40	2.5	0.8	34.11 (92)	7.5	4.5	4.8	3.2
SOUTH FLORIDA	8.5	41	2.9	0.3	31.46 (112)	8.4	3.6	4.8	3.2
NORTH TEXAS	5.5	34.5	3.5	0.1	34.04 (93)	5.9	6.1	4.3	3.7
TEMPLE	5.5	34	3.4	-0.8	35.45 (82)	5.6	6.4	3.7	4.3
TULSA	5.5	32.5	1.5	-0.6	34.23 (91)	5.3	6.7	3.1	4.9
FLA ATLANTIC	5.5	33.5	2	-0.5	34.81 (88)	5.4	6.6	2.9	5.1
RICE	3.5	27.5	3.2	-0.2	37.1 (76)	3.3	8.7	1.9	6.1
UAB	3.5	26	2.7	-1.1	34.78 (89)	3.6	8.4	1.7	6.3
CHARLOTTE	2.5	20.5	1	0.5	36.78 (77)	2.1	9.9	0.9	7.1

ARMY

BLACK KNIGHTS



Rival Navy had the upper hand on Army heading into last season because QB Blake Horvath still had eligibility left, whereas Bryson Daily had exhausted his. The loss of Daily was exacerbated by the loss of star RB Kanye Udoh. Replicating their 12-2 record from 2024 was going to be an insurmountable challenge, and the fact that the Black Knights still did well enough to have a winning record at 7-6 thanks to a bowl game blowout of a severely-undermanned UConn squad was another example of how solid Jeff Monken has been in West Point.

Monken is starting off his 13th year here. If we take UTSA's Jeff Traylor out of the mix, Monken's 12 years are nearly what the rest of the conference's head coaches have combined. The Black Knights have had one losing season since 2015 and have a high floor once again.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
A Hellums injury would be brutal for Army, as they have no game experience behind him. Furthermore, Woody is a big loss on the defensive side. As it is, Army was outgained by nearly a full yard per play in conference action. Yes, that's expected to a certain degree because of how much they run the football relative to their opponents, but that was absolutely not the case in 2024 when they outgained conference foes by nearly 1.2 YPP. The conference members adjusted and it took a long time for Navy to adjust back when it happened to them. The Black Knights play at a rest disadvantage in each of their first three October games and UTSA is the only team projected in the top-half of the conference that they avoid. My projection is 6.92 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & ATS, 5-8 O-U
Head Coach: Jeff Monken - 13th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	BRYANT (-36.6)	5.5
9/12	SOUTH FLORIDA (-1.2)	41.0
9/25	AT TEMPLE (-3.4)	34.0
10/3	AT LOUISIANA TECH (-3.9)	33.0
10/10	TULANE (+0.6)	42.5
10/17	FLA ATLANTIC (-9.5)	33.5
10/23	AT TULSA (-6.8)	32.5
10/31	AT MEMPHIS (+3.1)	41.0
11/7	AIR FORCE (-5.6)	37.0
11/21	EAST CAROLINA (-1.3)	40.5
11/28	AT RICE (-10.1)	27.5
12/12	VS. NAVY (+4)	44.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **34.11**
#92 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.5 / 0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

8*

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Cale complete the season?

That’s Cale Hellums, Army’s starting QB, who split time last season to a degree with Dewayne Coleman. The 5-foot-10 Hellums had 304 carries last season for 1,223 yards and 18 TDs. He added four passing TDs and 694 yards as well. But, that’s a really brutal workload for a smaller-statured guy and something that obviously has to be considered with any long-term position on Army. It’s entirely possible that Monken and OC Cody Worley found something in converted QB and all-name-team member Godspower Nwawuihe, who ran for 171 yards in the Fenway Bowl. Considering Noah Short, Hayden Reed, Coleman, and Briggs Bartosh are all gone, somebody has to help Hellums with rush attempts, as he had nearly 41% of the carries.

Will the conference adjust to Army in Year 3?

This will be Army’s third year in the American. So far, they are 12-4 in league play, but that mark is a tale of two seasons with an 8-0 record in Year 1 and a 4-4 record in Year 2. When Navy joined the AAC in 2015, they went 7-1 in league play in each of their first two seasons before dropping to 4-4 in Year 3 and then 2-6 in Year 4. The absences of Daily and Udoh absolutely played a role, but the Black Knights had 5.7 YPC in 2024 and 4.38 YPC in 2025 in conference games. Army is also +12 in TO margin in two years of conference play. Obviously their style of play limits the potential for turnovers, but it’s still something to think about.

Who is going to step up on defense?

DC Nate Woody is now in Cincinnati, so pass game coordinator Daryl Dixon, not to be confused with The Walking Dead character of the same name, has that role. Dixon has been with the program for the last 10 seasons, so he’s very familiar with the scheme and the types of players that Army has on defense. It’s almost always an undersized unit in the trenches, but often an experienced crew. This season is a bit of an exception. While there are a lot of seniors on the two-deep, the top seven tacklers are all gone, including Andon Thomas, who led the team with 113 tackles. Dixon, who has mostly coached defensive backs, needs to find more negative plays, as the Black Knights only had 15 sacks.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

10-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+850

AMERICAN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.6	87
YARDS PER POINT	14	54
PLAYS PER GAME	66.3	97
TIME OF POSSESSION	34:25	1
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.5%	44
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	329.8	105
YARDS PER PLAY	5	106
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	56.7	1
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	253.1	4
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	47
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	9.1	136
COMPLETION %	55.1%	125
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	76.7	136
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.4	16
TURNOVERS	0.7	5
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.9	27
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	25
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.3%	124
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	343.5	37
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	73
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	149.9	63
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	81
COMPLETION %	64.4%	99
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	193.6	23
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	60
SACKS	1	128
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

CHARLOTTE 49ERS



Apparently Tim Albin felt like Charlotte Green was a brighter shade than Bobcat Green, as he gave up a pretty good gig at Ohio to take on arguably the biggest challenge in the American Conference. Charlotte is probably the second-toughest job behind Rice, where the academic standards are a hindrance, but the results point towards this as the toughest job given that the 49ers were 1-11 overall, 0-8 in conference play, and only beat FCS Monmouth.

Albin had three straight double-digit winning seasons at Ohio before suffering through his first season in the Queen City. And "suffer" is the accurate description because the team only scored 14.3 PPG, gave up more than 36, got outgained by nearly two yards per play, and the closest conference loss was by 11 points. Other than that, Mrs. Lincoln, how was the play?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 2.5

The product on the field should look better, but finding two more wins on the schedule than last season is a chore. Charlotte should begin 1-0 against The Citadel, but Temple, Tulsa, and UAB are their most winnable games on paper otherwise and every single one of them is on the road. Depth is still an issue here and probably the best QB on the roster (Harrell) will be out until mid-October or so. My projection is 1.81 wins.

2025 Record: 1-11 SU & 5-7 ATS, 6-6 O-U

Head Coach: Tim Albin - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	THE CITADEL (-8.8)	12.5
9/12	AT OLE MISS (+42.8)	60.5
9/19	AT APPALACHIAN ST (+11.2)	30.0
9/26	LA LAFAYETTE (+11.2)	32.5
10/3	MEMPHIS (+20.2)	41.0
10/10	AT NORTH TEXAS (+17)	34.5
10/17	AT TEMPLE (+16.4)	34.0
10/30	TULANE (+21.6)	42.5
11/7	AT UAB (+7.7)	26.0
11/14	EAST CAROLINA (+19.7)	40.5
11/21	AT TULSA (+13)	32.5
11/28	NAVY (+23.3)	44.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **36.78**
#77 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

4*

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

At least there's nowhere to go but up, right?!

The bar has been set so low at Charlotte now that I'm not even sure a toddler could crawl under it. Since joining the FBS ranks over a decade ago, Charlotte has one bowl game appearance. Last season was probably as close to rock bottom as it has gotten. The defense managed just 14 sacks, the offense had just 2.7 yards per carry, and a lot of it had to do with how painfully thin the roster was when Albin took the job. Neither the incoming class nor the portal class graded all that highly for 247Sports relative to the rest of the conference, but there are a lot more warm bodies and some of them are probably better at football than the ones that were there.

Is there a starting QB on the roster?

Charlotte's boosters and supporters did open their wallets to try and get Albin a real QB last season, picking up Grayson Loftis from Duke and Conner Harrell from North Carolina. Harrell suffered a season-ending injury after emerging as the better option with a 66.7% completion rate and a 4/2 TD/INT ratio, leaving it in the hands of Loftis, who had an 8/8 TD/INT ratio with just a 55% completion rate. Even Zach Wilcke got some reps, though he's since moved on. This season, the starting gig may fall on the shoulders of Western Carolina transfer Cole Gonzales, at least until Harrell returns. None of the options are particularly good. On the plus side, almost all the backs and receivers are new, which can only help after last season's 4.6 YPP.

Where's the beef?

One of the problems that plagued Charlotte last season, and has clearly been a thing for several years now, is that they are not big enough or strong enough up front. Last year's team was -2.3 in yards per carry differential. The team before that was -1.6 YPC. The 2019 Charlotte team had a positive YPC differential and that's the one that went bowling. Not to mention, the 49ers haven't had more than 20 sacks in a season since that '19 campaign. Prior to becoming the OC at Ohio, Albin primarily coached offensive linemen and running backs. Clearly the athletic department felt the same way when they hired Biff Poggi in terms of the team's lack of toughness in the trenches. If Albin can improve that, he can find some momentum.

ODDS TO WIN...

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****400-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	11.8	135
YARDS PER POINT	22.1	135
PLAYS PER GAME	63.3	122
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:39	122
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.1%	121
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	260.6	133
YARDS PER PLAY	4.1	134
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.2	127
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	72.8	136
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.5	135
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.7	58
COMPLETION %	57.0%	117
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	187.8	101
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.9	125
TURNOVERS	1.8	118
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	36.5	131
YARDS PER POINT	13	113
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.8%	108
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	473.4	134
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	127
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	214.3	127
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	121
COMPLETION %	67.4%	126
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	259.1	121
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	112
SACKS	0.9	130
TURNOVERS	1.4	54

EAST CAROLINA PIRATES



It is often bittersweet for a Group of Six program when a head coach is having a lot of success. Blake Harrell is 14-5 as the head coach at East Carolina, as he led the team to five wins in their final six games in 2024 and then a 9-4 record this past season. Harrell also owns upset wins over two ACC programs in bowl games, including in-state rival NC State, who did get revenge in the season opener last year, but in a very competitive 24-17 game.

We'll see if this will be Harrell's last season with the program or not, as the 46-year-old could either take a big-time defensive coordinator job or level up as a head coach. If he has similar success this season, it will be a thoroughly impressive coaching job with virtually none of last season's major contributors back in the fold. Not only that, but Harrell is working alongside two new coordinators as his previous ones are now at Ole Miss and South Florida.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

For ECU to get to 8-4 or better, they'll really have to earn it. Opening the season with Alabama in Tuscaloosa isn't ideal, not to mention they play three weeknight games, including two road Thursday games, and face Temple and Army with rest disadvantages, as both of those teams will be coming off of the bye. However, East Carolina also doesn't face UTSA or Tulane, two of the four teams that beat the Pirates last season. My projection is 7.72 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 8-4-1 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Blake Harrell - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT ALABAMA (+23.5)	61.0
9/12	APPALACHIAN ST (-14.3)	30.0
9/19	AT OLD DOMINION (-1.4)	37.0
9/26	NC CENTRAL (-24.9)	18.0
10/10	RICE (-16.2)	27.5
10/15	AT UAB (-12.5)	26.0
10/22	AT MEMPHIS (+2.7)	41.0
10/31	TEMPLE (-10.3)	34.0
11/6	SOUTH FLORIDA (-2.2)	41.0
11/14	AT CHARLOTTE (-19.7)	20.5
11/21	AT ARMY (+1.3)	40.0
11/28	FLA ATLANTIC (-10.5)	33.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **33.46**
#96 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

4

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

More run or more shoot?

The new OC is Jordan Davis and that means a scheme change in Greenville. Davis was working under Eric Morris at North Texas, an offense that led the nation in points per game with over 45, yards per game with just over 512, and ranked third in yards per play. While the prevailing thought would be that a Morris-led offense would just chuck the ball around the field, that wasn't the case. Drew Mestemaker threw for nearly 4,400 yards and had 463 pass attempts, but RB Caleb Hawkins had 231 carries for 1,434 yards and the team had 517 rush attempts. Davis got backup RB Ashton Gray to transfer and also WR Landon Sides, so he has skill guys who know the scheme. The ECU run game actually fell from 4.8 yards per carry to 4.1, so that has a good chance to go back up.

Who will run the show?

Well, that's the biggest question for ECU from a personnel standpoint. Miami transfer Emory Williams and now four-time transfer Mitch Griffis, who was at Texas Tech last season, are the main options. Williams is the bigger, more athletic option, but Griffis may more closely resemble Mestemaker's skill set, though he doesn't have the size. Katin Houser, another portal find by Harrell, who really seems to have his finger on the pulse of free agency, was very solid last season. Whether it's Williams or Griffis, good numbers should come again. The offensive line could be shaky at the outset, which perhaps puts Williams in the driver's seat for the job.

Can Harrell work his magic again?

With two returning starters back on defense, Harrell and DC Josh Aldridge did a masterful job. The Pirates allowed just 20.1 PPG and just over 5.1 YPP. Statistically, everything got better. The team was better against the run, generated more sacks, and the defense had 24 takeaways leading to a +10 TO margin. It does need to be said that the Pirates allowed just 390 yards in their wins over Campbell and Coastal Carolina and 71 rushing yards on 53 carries, so their conference numbers weren't nearly as strong as the full body of work suggests. That said, ECU still outgained American foes by 0.65 YPP, as the offense got stronger as the season went along. He's basically starting from scratch in terms of returning starters and has a new DC this time around.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****20-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+580****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.8	25
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	63
PLAYS PER GAME	78.1	2
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:22	115
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.5%	28
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	441.8	19
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	44
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	43.5	9
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	176.7	36
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	88
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33	44
COMPLETION %	64.1%	41
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	265.2	24
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	29
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.5	34
YARDS PER POINT	17.1	16
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.8%	11
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	367.7	54
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	40
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	129.9	33
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	37
COMPLETION %	63.6%	85
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	237.8	96
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	47
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	1.8	15

FLORIDA ATLANTIC OWLS



The makings of a good football team were present in Boca Raton last season. Even though Florida Atlantic finished 4-8, failing to reach six wins for the sixth straight season, you could see Zach Kittley's plan in motion. The youngest coach in FBS, and big proponent of the Air Raid offense, had plenty of growing pains. One stat stood out well above the rest - the Owls were -21 in TO margin. Clean that up and we might have something here. It will be up to Caden Veltkamp to do that, after he threw 17 interceptions, but the burden is also shared by DC Brett Dewhurst, whose defense forced a paltry eight turnovers.

In a conference desperately lacking returning starters, Kittley has a couple handfuls of them and brought in 30 more players via the portal, including some defenders capable of creating negative plays. This will be a high-variance team again with their high volume of pass attempts and a defense asked to survive in that environment, but Kittley has been a rapid riser up the coaching ranks for a reason.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5

The season might start rather slowly with Florida and Navy on the docket, but the three games before the bye are very, very winnable. The back half of the schedule is a bit of a challenge, but this was a 4-8 team with a -21 TO margin that definitely has more talent in Year 2 of this new system. This isn't a super strong opinion and more of a lean, but Kittley is a sharp football mind and he's had a lot more time to evaluate the guys that fit and don't fit what he's aiming to achieve. Last season was also his first as a head coach and he did double duty as the OC. Surely he learned a lot. My projection is 5.64 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 7-5 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Zach Kittley - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT FLORIDA (+25.4)	55.5
9/12	NAVY (+9.3)	44.0
9/19	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-7.1)	28.5
9/26	AT LA MONROE (-8.5)	22.0
10/3	TEXAS SOUTHERN (-32)	3.5
10/17	AT ARMY (+9.5)	40.0
10/24	RICE (-8.2)	27.5
10/29	AT NORTH TEXAS (+5)	34.5
11/5	TX-SAN ANTONIO (+5)	41.0
11/14	AT TULSA (+1)	32.5
11/21	SOUTH FLORIDA (+5.8)	41.0
11/28	AT EAST CAROLINA (+10.5)	40.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **34.81**
#88 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

5*

DEFENSE

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Are we in the Caden Veltkamp camp?

Veltkamp is really the only starting QB for FAU and he needs to be better. Drew Devillier transferred in from Rice and redshirt freshman Jordan Magwood threw nine passes last season. Veltkamp was asked to throw a lot and FAU did trail a lot, so the 17 interceptions may not all be on him, especially considering he had just 11 of them in three seasons at Western Kentucky. Easton Messer caught 104 balls for 1,052 yards and several others saw work in this scheme, including returnee Dominique Henry. Guys will put up numbers, but Messer is still the only true go-to guy and that could continue to hold Veltkamp back and the rest of the team by extension. Veltkamp threw seven picks over the first three games and six over the last three games, so he did show he could take care of the ball in the middle of the season. A silver lining, perhaps.

Can Kittley find some balance on offense?

The rushing numbers were downright laughable for the Owls. They averaged 105 yards on 3.5 yards per carry and even mustered just 82 yards and 2.9 yards per carry in American Conference play. This is not exactly a conference known for a lot of physical, stalwart defenses, but there were no holes on the ground whatsoever. The OL was shifting to a very pass-heavy blocking scheme, so maybe that had something to do with it. While the OL has a lot of new faces and some guys playing new positions, the running back room looks more intriguing. Kaden Shields-Dutton had 5.5 yards per carry and Kittley went the JUCO route to get Leonard Farrow, who averaged over seven yards per carry at Fairmont State. If a running game and more ball control are attainable, that will help the defense tremendously.

Will the Owls stop the run?

The FAU defensive line was objectively terrible last season. American Conference foes ran for an average of 232 yards per game and that even includes a 68-yard performance from UAB. While the offense needs work, and the offensive line is very light on experience, Kittley and his staff really hammered the defensive side of the ball in the portal. Some guys are in Year 2 of the scheme and others are newcomers to the roster, but you can tell that the DL and really the front seven in general were focal points. It is wild to think that FAU averaged a 150-yard differential in rushing yards over their eight conference games. That simply cannot happen again.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****23-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.1	61
YARDS PER POINT	16.1	103
PLAYS PER GAME	79.8	1
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:26	114
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.7%	92
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	435.7	22
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	67
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.3	126
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	97	128
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	121
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	48.7	1
COMPLETION %	66.2%	22
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	338.7	1
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	76
TURNOVERS	2.6	136
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	38.4	134
YARDS PER POINT	11.7	133
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.8%	127
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	449	128
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	106
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	213.1	126
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	112
COMPLETION %	65.4%	105
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	235.9	90
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	102
SACKS	1.8	76
TURNOVERS	0.7	123

MEMPHIS TIGERS



Memphis went from Group of Five College Football Playoff contender to an afterthought in a hurry, as the Tigers lost to Tulane at home and then followed that up with three straight losses, including a defeat in the Gasparilla Bowl after head coach Ryan Silverfield left for Arkansas and a ton of players left the program. This is basically a brand-new roster for head coach Charles Huff, who spent one year at Southern Miss after Marshall inexplicably let him walk as the reigning Sun Belt champion HC.

This is a great spot for Huff, who has a lot of NIL money to play with and a pretty solid program that hasn't had a losing season since 2013. A winning record in 2014 ended six straight seasons of futility and the program has been strong ever since, including four double-digit winning seasons since 2017. It may take a year with new schemes and a ton of transfers, but Huff seems to be an outstanding coach based on the returns we've seen thus far.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5
In Huff I trust. These are two good coordinator hires and it sure feels like Huff's done a good job of motivating players that were either discarded by their own schools or castoffs from another. The non-conference schedule is tough with UNLV and Boise State, but the conference schedule isn't all that bad for the Tigers. They do play at Tulane, USF, and Navy, but Huff has plenty of time over the first six games prior to the visit to NOLA to get his team in shape. Huff has worked under James Franklin and Nick Saban. He knows how to identify talent. My projection is 7.38 wins.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Charles Huff - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT UNLV (+5.5)	44.0
9/5	ARKANSAS ST (-10.5)	33.5
9/12	AT BOISE ST (+12.7)	50.5
9/19	TENN-MARTIN (-29.3)	14.5
10/3	AT CHARLOTTE (-20.2)	20.5
10/10	UAB (-19)	26.0
10/16	AT TULANE (+4.2)	42.5
10/22	EAST CAROLINA (-2.7)	40.5
10/31	ARMY (-3.1)	40.0
11/12	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+2.2)	41.0
11/21	AT NAVY (+4.6)	44.0
11/28	TEMPLE (-10.7)	34.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.48**
#81 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.9 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

5

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What will this offense look like?

Huff went back to the Sun Belt for his OC, as Kevin Decker was at Old Dominion the last few years. Decker led an ODU offense that ranked in the top 20 in yards per play and averaged 32 PPG. He had a Fordham offense that averaged over 600 yards per game back in 2021. This is a guy who believes in a high-octane, explosive offense that starts with the ground game and the pass comes off of it. The Monarchs averaged 5.6 yards per carry and nearly 240 rushing yards per game. How all the transfer pieces and parts fit in will be fascinating to see. Marcus Stokes was a multi-year starter at West Florida and Air Noland was a very highly-touted recruit who never saw the field at Ohio State and transferred to South Carolina.

Who are the impact players on offense?

Whether it's Stokes, Noland, or maybe even Huff recruit Denzel Gardner, there still aren't any truly experienced or established skill-position guys. Dallan Hayden had over five yards per carry at Ohio State, but was ineffective at Colorado. Jaylin Carter only had 166 yards last season at Southern Miss and Manny Covey had under 300 yards in three seasons at Cincinnati. The wide receivers are all in a similar boat, as some of them have impressive yards per reception numbers, but not many receptions. This is basically a bunch of noteworthy recruits who couldn't crack the lineup at their previous schools, so all of them have chips on their shoulders. That could make for a fun offense, especially if Decker can play with tempo.

Will the defense suffer as a result of the offense?

Huff made a really, really good DC hire in Lance Guidry, who he worked with at Marshall and has been a DC at many different places. Like the offense, virtually nobody who played for the Tigers last season is on the roster, so this unit has been revamped via the portal as well. Huff did bring several Golden Eagles with him, including J'Mond Tapp, who had 7.5 sacks, and Ian Foster and Anthony Richard, who both had 10 pass breakups. There aren't as many noteworthy recruits on defense, so the upside of the defense might be lower than that of the offense, but the collection of Southern Miss players should help.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

10-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+600

AMERICAN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.4	20
YARDS PER POINT	13	25
PLAYS PER GAME	71.3	41
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:58	22
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.9%	50
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	409.5	31
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	41
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.6	49
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	178.7	35
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	26
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32	55
COMPLETION %	66.7%	18
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	230.8	63
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	63
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.3	51
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	46
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.8%	86
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	369.8	55
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	60
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	133.3	36
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	35
COMPLETION %	60.6%	49
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	236.6	93
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	94
SACKS	1.6	101
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

NAVY MIDSHIPMEN



When they zig, you zag. Credit to Navy head coach Brian Newberry for bringing in OC Drew Cronic, as the wrinkles in the Middies offense have given them a new life in the American Conference. The team was 14-2 in conference play over the first two seasons in the AAC, but then it went downhill as teams adjusted. In fact, under Ken Niumatalolo, the Middies only had one other winning season in conference after that 14-2 start. Under Newberry, Navy is 18-7.

Cronic's Wing-T, modified triple-option has given teams a lot of things to worry about when scouting. The Middles scored 17.7 PPG in 2023. In two seasons under Cronic, they've scored 31.3 and 31.5 PPG with 6.3 and 6.5 yards per play. However, now Blake Horvath, Alex Tecza, and all-time leading receiver Eli Heidenreich are gone. Was it Cronic or was it just a generational run of offensive leaders?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
The conference schedule is not too demanding for Navy and they should be better than both service academies again. They do play at UTSA and at what should be an improved FAU team. Notre Dame is on the slate, as well as a home game against Memphis, but no Tulane or East Carolina. Both North Texas and Notre Dame are off of byes when they face Navy. With two years worth of film on the Cronic offense and some massive personnel losses, heavy regression is possible. My projection, though, is for 7.56 wins.

2025 Record: 11-2 SU & 5-8 ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Brian Newberry - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TOWSON (-28.9)	16.5
9/12	AT FLA ATLANTIC (-9.3)	33.5
9/25	AT UAB (-16.1)	26.0
10/3	AT AIR FORCE (-5.3)	37.0
10/10	TULSA (-14.4)	32.5
10/17	AT TX-SAN ANTONIO (+0.3)	41.0
10/24	NORTH TEXAS (-11.7)	34.5
10/31	VS. NOTRE DAME (+24.7)	68.5
11/7	TEMPLE (-13.1)	34.0
11/21	MEMPHIS (-4.6)	41.0
11/28	AT CHARLOTTE (-23.3)	20.5
12/12	VS. ARMY (-4)	40.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.19**
#86 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / 0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

5

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How can Navy replicate the wrath of Horvath?

Horvath will be talked about in the same breath as Keenan Reynolds and Malcolm Perry. Every few years, it seems like a stud QB comes around in Annapolis and Horvath will be held in that light. He threw for over 3,000 yards and ran for over 2,600 yards. Only Reynolds and Bill Byrne have thrown more passing TDs in Navy history. It should also be noted that Reynolds played four years, while Horvath played three. Braxton Woodson has some enormous shoes to fill. He's plenty familiar with the scheme, having started games the last two seasons and being used when Horvath was banged up. In fact, Woodson had 9.4 yards per carry on his 44 attempts last season. But, Horvath (58.8%) only trailed Roger Staubach in completion percentage with at least 120 pass attempts. Woodson is not that kind of thrower with a 46.3% completion rate.

What about the other losses?

Tecza and Heidenreich, who was drafted in the seventh round by the Steelers, are monumental losses of production as well. Tecza ran for 902 yards on 5.7 yards per carry with 10 rushing TD last season and ended his Navy career 12th in rushing yards with 2,236. Tecza is seventh all-time among running backs in rushing yards. Heidenreich had over 500 yards on the ground and 941 yards on 51 catches. He passed Rob Taylor for the program's lead in receiving yards and finished his career fifth in scrimmage yards. Oh, and fourth-leading rusher and second-leading receiver Brandon Chatman also exhausted his eligibility. This scheme creates productive players, but Navy is missing 93.5% of their passing yards, over 83% of their rushing yards, and over 84% of their receiving yards from last season.

What does that mean for the defense?

That is the million-dollar question here. Perhaps sensing the urgency, Newberry is going back to his roots to serve as his own defensive play-caller, even though he demoted P.J. Volker back to safeties coach and promoted Eric Lewis to DC. The losses are nowhere near as heavy on this side, as five of the top seven tacklers are back, but the 5.9 YPP allowed by the Middies last season was the most they've surrendered since 2021, as were the 25 PPG. Navy's defensive numbers need to be put in the proper context because of their offensive scheme, which limits possessions. With a decline in offensive production expected, the defense could feel the brunt.

ODDS TO WIN...

600-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+750

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+380

AMERICAN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.8	34
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	46
PLAYS PER GAME	63.8	117
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:22	14
3RD DOWN CONV. %	49.7%	7
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	403.9	39
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	18
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	49.1	3
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	270.8	1
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	6
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	14	135
COMPLETION %	57.7%	107
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	133.2	133
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.5	2
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.5	74
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	68
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.3%	75
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	384.6	74
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	94
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	151.8	66
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	60
COMPLETION %	64.8%	103
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232.8	84
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	114
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

NORTH TEXAS

MEAN GREEN



The motto for North Texas football this season might be, "Don't cry because it's over; smile because it happened". Eric Morris is now at Oklahoma State after leading the Mean Green to probably the best season in program history. UNT went 12-2, scoring over 45 PPG, and won a bowl game for the first time since 2013. It will be up to Neal Brown to keep the program on the map, as Morris and pretty much every player of consequence has left Denton. Things like this are possible in the transfer portal era, but this may very well be the most stripped-down program we've ever seen.

The top returning running back had 95 yards on 21 carries. The top returning pass-catcher had seven grabs for 80 yards. The top returning tackler had 32 stops and 1.5 sacks. The top returning DB had four pass breakups. Even the kicker and the punter are gone. With new schemes and new coordinators, having some leftover players may not have really made that big of a difference anyway, but this team is guys who played sparingly last season and a collection of transfers from every corner of the country.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5
UNT opens at Indiana and then hosts UNLV before visiting Texas State to open the season. They'll go to Navy, UTSA, and Tulane, so the road games are very difficult. The home games are all attainable, but UNT might lose every road game, leaving no margin for error at home. While Jackson is stepping down in class with his first non-Power Four team, he hasn't taken great care of the football. To call it a rebuilding year in Denton is an understatement. My projection is 5.81 wins, but I still like the Under.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 10-4 ATS, 10-4 O-U
Head Coach: Neal Brown - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT INDIANA (+35.2)	66.0
9/12	UNLV (+6.9)	44.0
9/19	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (+5.6)	37.5
9/26	HOUSTON BAPTIST (-40.3)	-1.5
10/1	AT TULSA (-0.6)	32.5
10/10	CHARLOTTE (-17)	20.5
10/24	AT NAVY (+11.7)	44.0
10/29	FLA ATLANTIC (-5)	33.5
11/7	RICE (-10.7)	27.5
11/14	AT TX-SAN ANTONIO (+10.5)	41.0
11/21	AT TULANE (+11.3)	42.5
11/28	UAB (-13.1)	26.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **34.04**
#93 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.5 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

5

2

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who are these f*%ing guys?

Being a Clevelander, of course one of my favorite movies is Major League and the clip of the construction worker looking at the roster in the newspaper and asking, “Who are these effing guys?!” after the conniving owner cleared out the roster is among the most quotable lines. I will say, while all of these guys are new to Denton, there are a few notable names. Tayven Jackson originally went to Tennessee and got some starts for Indiana and also UCF, so he’s the clubhouse leader to be the QB. Jahiem White had 6.5 yards per carry at West Virginia, as he rejoined Brown in the Lone Star State. Aaron Alexander racked up 91 tackles last season at Arkansas State. But, other than those few guys, most of these guys simply didn’t latch on at their previous schools.

Is this a better fit for Neal Brown?

Brown is going to be his own OC, which may work out great or may not work out at all. It was his work as an OC at Troy, Texas Tech, and Kentucky that got him his first head coaching job. Troy didn’t play with a ton of tempo or light up the scoreboard while he was there, but did score 30+ PPG in each of his last three seasons. West Virginia only averaged 30+ PPG in two of his six seasons. Not only are expectations exceedingly low with how bare the cupboard is, but the North Texas athletic department was willing to go high-octane, up-tempo, run-and-shoot style with Morris and his assistants. He might be able to reinvent himself, or at least go back to his Texas Tech days.

What is the state of the North Texas program?

Sometimes things from above can trickle down to the team and create a difficult situation. Even last season, there wasn’t a ton of investment in the program. UNT got very fortunate that Mestemaker, who had barely played QB in high school, was a stud. RB Caleb Hawkins had one Division I offer and it was North Texas. He had 25 rushing TDs and over 1,400 yards. Skyler Cassity was a stellar DC hire by Morris, but who would have thought it would lead to the best defense the program has seen in forever? Will the students show up to support a team that has been stripped to the studs? Will the athletic department invest more in the roster?

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****24-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	44.6	1
YARDS PER POINT	11.6	4
PLAYS PER GAME	71.7	37
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:59	120
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.3%	23
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	516.2	1
YARDS PER PLAY	7.2	3
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.4	52
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	199.8	19
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	7
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.9	38
COMPLETION %	68.3%	10
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	316.4	2
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.3	4
TURNOVERS	1.4	82
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.5	84
YARDS PER POINT	14.2	79
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.7%	106
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	404.2	86
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	64
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	232	134
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	124
COMPLETION %	56.9%	19
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	172.2	6
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	16
SACKS	1.6	100
TURNOVERS	2	7

RICE OWLS

Last season was a transitional one for Rice, as Scott Abell embraced one of the most challenging and difficult jobs in FBS after making the leap from FCS Davidson. Rice has an enrollment under 4,000, strict academic requirements, and hasn't had a winning season since 2014. You would think that being in Houston with all of the Texas high school football talent, it would be easier to put together a competent roster, even with the low acceptance rate, but it hasn't been.

Even last season, Rice was granted a bowl game because others backed out and the school's Academic Progress Rate (APR) scores were worthy of an opportunity, but the team only had a 5-7 regular season. They only scored 19.1 PPG and dropped by nearly a full yard per play on offense, while giving up 1.3 more YPP on defense. It's a tough gig and it looks like another tough year, but Abell seems up for the challenge and brought in a decent number of P4 transfers.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5
Rice got a pretty favorable schedule last season, but that is not the case this season. Outside of Navy, they face all of the teams that project to be average or better and they do not face Charlotte or UAB, their only two conference wins last season. Notre Dame is on the schedule this season, along with a trip to Fresno State. If Rice is 3-8 going into the final game, which is plausible, that's against Army, who is a terrible matchup for a less-accomplished option team. My projection is 3.72 wins.

2025 Record: 5-8 SU & ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Scott Abell - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	HOUSTON BAPTIST (-33)	-1.5
9/12	AT NOTRE DAME (+45)	68.5
9/19	W MICHIGAN (+6.5)	37.5
9/26	AT FRESNO ST (+18)	42.5
10/3	TX-SAN ANTONIO (+9.8)	41.0
10/10	AT EAST CAROLINA (+ 16.2)	40.5
10/17	TULSA (+1.2)	32.5
10/24	AT FLA ATLANTIC (+8.2)	33.5
11/7	AT NORTH TEXAS (+ 10.7)	34.5
11/14	TULANE (+12.4)	42.5
11/19	AT TEMPLE (+10.1)	34.0
11/28	ARMY (+10.1)	40.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **37.10**
#76 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

3

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the offense improve in a hurry under Jacurri?

The Jacurri in question is Jacurri Brown, who spent two years at Miami and two years at UCF, but he's only thrown 148 passes with more interceptions (9) than touchdowns (6). What Brown has done, though, is effectively run the football. He has 137 carries for 821 yards, so better than six yards per carry. At Davidson back in 2024, Wildcats QBs only had 152 pass attempts in 11 games, as the team ran the ball 640 times for 3,720 yards, with QB Andrew Frazier third in rush attempts and rush yards. Quinton Jackson was the best player on offense for Rice last season with 889 yards and 4.9 yards per carry. Last season, the Owls had 647 rush attempts against 224 pass attempts. I would expect an even starker split this season.

Can the option offense even be successful?

Not all options are created equal, as Navy has recently modified theirs and Army just runs theirs like a well-oiled machine, but Rice is attempting to do their version of an option in a conference that already has two service academies. It makes scheming a lot easier for the opposing defense to see a lot of similar core concepts and blocking schemes. Rice didn't face Army last season, but will this season. However, they did face Navy and only had 3.1 yards per carry. Memphis held them to 2.4 YPC, while UTSA allowed 3.8, UAB allowed 3.4, and USF allowed 3.8. Brown could be a difference-maker as a better runner than Chase Jenkins, but Rice just might not be in the best conference for this.

Is everything 'Kay on defense?

'Kay as in "okay" under DC Jon Kay, who was a holdover from the previous regime. It is a bit surprising that a head coach would simply promote the previous head coach's linebackers coach to DC and it didn't really seem to work out well last season. The Owls allowed 6.3 YPP and nearly 33 PPG. It was the worst defensive effort for the team since 2022. And, even with a run-heavy approach, the team still finished -4 in turnover margin with just seven takeaways. Rice was tied for ninth in the nation in turnovers lost and still finished with a negative TO margin. The top seven tacklers from last season are gone, but starting from scratch probably isn't a bad thing with this defense.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****200-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.5	123
YARDS PER POINT	16.5	109
PLAYS PER GAME	67.5	81
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:25	13
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.5%	110
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	289.1	128
YARDS PER PLAY	4.3	131
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	48.9	4
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	192.8	25
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	93
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	17.1	133
COMPLETION %	66.3%	21
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	96.3	135
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.6	131
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	34.3	122
YARDS PER POINT	12.2	128
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.2%	100
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	416.5	106
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	122
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169	88
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	99
COMPLETION %	62.8%	77
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	247.5	110
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.6	124
SACKS	1.9	69
TURNOVERS	0.6	133

SOUTH FLORIDA BULLS



USF wound up being a good stop for a promising, up-and-coming, offensive mind with his first head coaching job in Alex Golesh. Golesh has now leveled up to Auburn after posting a trio of winning seasons in Tampa. Now it's Brian Hartline's turn, as the world's best wide receiver recruiter has left Ohio State to put his stamp on his own program. Hartline hasn't coached anywhere other than Columbus in his collegiate career, so we'll see how it goes, but his first objective will be to try and keep up the offensive standards set by Golesh.

Five teams averaged 40+ PPG last season and the Bulls were one of them. In American Conference play, the Bulls averaged 49 PPG. That's a high bar to live up to, but what really established the ceiling for USF was that the defense improved at a similar pace to the offense. With basically a brand-new roster and his first try as a head coach, Hartline has his work cut out for him this season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

With over 4,000 yards and 42 touchdowns from Byrum Brown, USF went 9-3 in the regular season last year. While the non-conference slate is substantially easier this time around, the Bulls play Memphis and UTSA on short weeks, with Memphis coming off of the bye for that game. From a spread standpoint, USF could be favored in 10 or 11 games, but there's a reason why the vig is slanting towards the Under and why a lot of questions without answers have the market down on this program this season. My projection is 8.56 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Brian Hartline - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-15.5)	28.5
9/12	AT ARMY (+1.2)	40.0
9/19	DELAWARE ST (-33.3)	10.5
9/26	AT BOWLING GREEN (-13.4)	26.5
10/3	TEMPLE (-10.7)	34.0
10/8	AT TX-SAN ANTONIO (+3.8)	41.0
10/17	KENT ST (-21)	23.5
10/31	UAB (-19)	26.0
11/6	AT EAST CAROLINA (+2.2)	40.5
11/12	MEMPHIS (-2.2)	41.0
11/21	AT FLA ATLANTIC (-5.8)	33.5
11/28	TULANE (-0.8)	42.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.46**
#112 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.9 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

4

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Hype or hope?

Not all highly-touted recruits make it. The transfer portal gives players with that kind of pedigree the chance to go to a G6 program and attempt to get back on the radar. At USF, most of those players are quarterbacks, as Hartline and OC Tim Beck got Michael Van Buren by way of Mississippi State and LSU and Luke Kromenhoek by way of Florida State and Mississippi State. MVB did have some success at those two stops, including an 8/2 TD/INT ratio at LSU last season with four starts and some relief efforts. There are so many unproven players on this side of the ball and it's fair to wonder if Hartline is a program-builder or was just able to thrive with the foundation already set at Ohio State.

What the Beck?

You can understand why Hartline turned to Tim Beck as the OC, as the 60-year-old has been coaching since the late '80s. It took him 35 years to get his first head coaching gig and it didn't go particularly well at Coastal Carolina with a 20-18 record. So, he's an OC again and I find it underwhelming, personally. Most of the guys acquired via free agency didn't play very much at their previous schools, but 247Sports graded USF's portal haul the best in the conference and 58th nationally with 44 total commits. That's a lot of scouting and a lot of new faces.

Could the defense outpace the offense in 2026?

While the hiring of Beck is pretty bland in my eyes, the hiring of Josh Aldridge as DC is not. Aldridge has been working at conference rival East Carolina under head coach Blake Harrell, who has proven to be an outstanding defensive mind and a pretty darn good HC. Stopping the run is the key to success in this conference. Most teams run the ball well or have run-heavy schemes. Aldridge's ECU unit allowed just 3.6 yards per carry. Everybody seems to allow passing yards and 60+% completion percentages, but the teams that stop the run position themselves for success. That was true of USF last season with just 3.7 YPC. This may not be a polished defense, but it is a big front seven.

ODDS TO WIN...

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****11-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+800****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	38.6	5
YARDS PER POINT	12.6	15
PLAYS PER GAME	73.2	17
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:06	133
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.8%	16
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	486.3	2
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	7
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.8	29
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	208.8	12
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	16
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.6	61
COMPLETION %	66.2%	23
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	277.6	15
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.8	11
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.2	49
YARDS PER POINT	16.2	28
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	70
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	392.4	78
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	36
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	149.8	62
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	42
COMPLETION %	61.5%	59
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	242.6	103
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	37
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	2	7

TEMPLE OWLS



All three Owls in the American Conference got new coaches last season. Rice and FAU seemed to make some progress towards the future, but Temple may have done the best in the present. K.C. Keeler's team fell painfully short of a bowl game, as they were 5-3 with four shots to get it done for the first time since 2019, but lost to East Carolina, Army, Tulane, and North Texas to miss out. In fairness, it was when the schedule really ramped up.

In a lot of ways, Temple's season worked out the way it should have. They were favored four times and won all four of those, plus a home upset of UTSA. They lost to Army and Navy by one point in each of those games. With Keeler and former Montana State OC Tyler Walker, the offense improved by more than a touchdown per game. Unfortunately, even with a +11 TO margin, Temple couldn't pull off enough upsets to end the bowl drought. Without their QBs from last season, is a regression to the mean in play?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5
Keeler certainly has the chance to get his team to a bowl game for the first time in the 2020s, but where will the wins come from? Except for Penn State, all of the home games on the schedule are extremely winnable, especially Rhode Island, UConn, Charlotte, UAB, and Rice. If Temple does what they did last year and wins when they're supposed to win, that's five and they'd only need one more to go Over the total. Only playing five road games is a plus, especially with no long travel. However, Keeler couldn't get to six wins with a +11 TO margin last season and this year's group looks worse at the most important position. My projection is 5.33 wins.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 7-5 ATS, 8-4 O-U
Head Coach: K. C. Keeler - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	RHODE ISLAND (-12.8)	24.0
9/12	PENN ST (+20.4)	57.0
9/19	AT TOLEDO (+6.3)	35.5
9/25	ARMY (+3.4)	40.0
10/3	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+10.7)	41.0
10/10	CONNECTICUT (-5.7)	31.5
10/17	CHARLOTTE (-16.4)	20.5
10/31	AT EAST CAROLINA (+10.3)	40.5
11/7	AT NAVY (+13.1)	44.0
11/14	UAB (-12.5)	26.0
11/19	RICE (-10.1)	27.5
11/28	AT MEMPHIS (+10.7)	41.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.45**
#82 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.4 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

7

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will lead Temple in 2026?

Evan Simon was a calming presence and a productive one for Temple, as he posted a 25/2 TD/INT ratio, leading the team to its first positive TO margin in quite some time. Before Keeler took over, Temple was -10, -20, and -11 in TO margin under Stan Drayton. Simon's safe, reliable throws didn't produce a ton of yardage, and he only had 19 TD passes after throwing six in the first game against UMass, but he protected the ball and gave the undermanned defense a better chance than his predecessors. With Simon and backup Gevani McCoy gone, there is virtually no experience on the roster, with Penn State's Jaxon Smolik, who played in four games over three years at Penn State, and Ajani Sheppard, who played five games at Rutgers and zero last season at Washington State, as the primary QB options. It looks like a huge downturn is coming.

Where will the negative plays come from?

Temple only had 16 sacks last season and still allowed over six yards per play. While the defense shaved off nearly six PPG, it was really all about the turnover margin, as most of the per-play and rate stats weren't really that much better under DC Brian Smith. The Owls had one of the worst red-zone defenses in the nation, were below the national average in third-down defense, and allowed 30 plays of 30+ yards. There are more returnees on offense than defense, so Smith has a lot of work to do. While three of the top four tacklers are back, the team's leaders in pass breakups and sacks are not among them.

Will the real Temple Owls please stand up?

Temple finished the season -624 in yards, but they had some wild swings. The Owls outgained UMass by 165 yards, Howard by 439, and Navy by 134. On the flip side, they were outgained by 411 yards by Oklahoma, 140 by Georgia Tech, 381 by East Carolina, 202 by Tulane, and 289 by North Texas. In other words, over their last four games, even outgaining Army, they were -854 yards (while being +1 in TO margin!). That speaks to a major depth issue late in the season, something that Keeler and his staff have possibly addressed. The top of the American doesn't seem as strong this season, but the conference as a whole seems better than it was last year, so Temple may have closer games to navigate.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****400-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****31-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.4	75
YARDS PER POINT	12.8	20
PLAYS PER GAME	63.3	122
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:35	78
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.2%	101
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	325.7	110
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	90
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.5	112
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	131.3	95
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	77
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.2	81
COMPLETION %	60.5%	79
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	194.5	98
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	103
TURNOVERS	0.4	2
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.7	108
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	100
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.3%	77
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	422	109
YARDS PER PLAY	6.2	120
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	207.9	125
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	122
COMPLETION %	62.6%	73
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	214.1	51
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	116
SACKS	1.3	119
TURNOVERS	1.3	66

TULANE GREEN WAVE



Who knows what would have happened for Tulane last season if Jake Retzlaff hadn't violated the Honor Code at BYU. The Green Wave were going to be a good team, but perhaps it was Retzlaff who elevated them into a great team, one that represented the Group of Five in the College Football Playoff. It didn't go well for them when they got there, as an Ole Miss team that beat them 45-10 in the regular season beat them 41-10 in the CFP, but it was a good reward at the end of Jon Sumrall's short tenure.

Sumrall inherited a pretty strong foundation and brought over some of his talent from Troy, a luxury that Will Hall may not have. While there are a handful of holdovers, a lot of last season's production is gone and it doesn't look like Darian Mensah, Retzlaff, or all-time passing leader Michael Pratt are walking through that door. The schedule is pretty soft and the talent pipeline is still fairly strong, but this has all the makings of a transitional year for Tulane.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5
And yet, the schedule should help them out in a big way. The Green Wave are likely to split their non-conference games against Duke, South Alabama, Kansas State, and Southern Miss. They have a bye prior to playing Army's triple-option. They don't play Navy or East Carolina and get Memphis and UTSA at home in consecutive weeks. Maybe Hall, who has had two different stints at Tulane and had lots of success at West Alabama and West Georgia as the HC, deserves a little more benefit of the doubt than I've given him credit for since his time at Southern Miss was messy and included a conference change. My projection is 7.56 wins.

2025 Record: 11-3 SU & 6-7-1 ATS, 4-10 O-U
Head Coach: Will Hall - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT DUKE (+6.8)	46.5
9/12	S ALABAMA (-16.4)	29.0
9/19	AT KANSAS ST (+11.7)	51.0
9/26	SOUTHERN MISS (-21)	25.5
10/10	AT ARMY (-0.6)	40.0
10/16	MEMPHIS (-4.2)	41.0
10/24	TX-SAN ANTONIO (-5.4)	41.0
10/30	AT CHARLOTTE (-21.6)	20.5
11/7	TULSA (-14)	32.5
11/14	AT RICE (-12.4)	27.5
11/21	NORTH TEXAS (-11.3)	34.5
11/28	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+0.8)	41.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 35.20
#84 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 3.4 / 0.6
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

8

3

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Hall experience the regression Sumrall did not?

Tulane's 11-3 record certainly stands out, but let's look deeper, shall we? The Green Wave only outscored opponents 27.7-23.9 and only outgained them by a half-yard per play, with that discrepancy largely coming from a +24 sack differential. Tulane won four games in which they were outgained and five games by one score. Some of that may have been Sumrall and his late-game coaching in close contests. Some of that may have been luck. Some of that may have been Retzlaff, who led the team in rushing and had 16 rushing scores. But, it sure feels like it could all come crashing down on Hall, who was an awful head coach at Southern Miss and doesn't have nearly the offensive upside of last year's squad.

Who are the impact players on offense?

The fact that Retzlaff was available was truly a gift for Tulane because they were not set up well at the running back position with Makhi Hughes' transfer. Jamauri McClure had 6.5 yards per carry on just 83 attempts and Javin Gordon only had 4.0 YPC on 128 attempts. Shazz Preston was the leading receiver by 200 yards and he's gone, leaving behind second-leading WR Anthony Brown-Stevenson, who only had two fewer catches than Preston. Zeon Chriss-Gremillion has played like 12 years of college football and the only notable thing is that he's got a hyphenated last name now. Kadin Semonza was there last year, but redshirted and didn't play at all after starting for Ball State. So the answer to that question is that we don't know.

Is the defense going to bail out the offense?

Tulane's portal class ranks seventh in the 14-team American Conference, so that's not terribly impressive given that they've had three seasons of 11+ wins and another 9-5 campaign over the last four years. Promoting Tayler Polk to full-fledged DC as opposed to co-DC may have helped keep leading tacklers Jack Tchienchou and Chris Rodgers around. That said, this was a defense that struggled against the pass last season, giving up 262 yards per game and a 67.6% completion rate. Most of the 25 takeaways from last season are gone. Concerns run really deep on both sides of the ball.

ODDS TO WIN...

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****12-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+680****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.7	52
YARDS PER POINT	14.9	79
PLAYS PER GAME	67.9	74
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:51	39
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.1%	39
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	411.6	29
YARDS PER PLAY	6.1	24
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.6	48
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	166.4	52
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	42
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.4	80
COMPLETION %	61.7%	66
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	245.1	46
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	27
TURNOVERS	1.2	59
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.9	48
YARDS PER POINT	16.1	30
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.6%	65
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	384.2	72
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	57
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	122.6	27
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	22
COMPLETION %	67.6%	128
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	261.6	122
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	100
SACKS	2.6	27
TURNOVERS	1.8	18

TULSA

GOLDEN HURRICANE



As expected, the Golden Hurricane looked better, but it didn't translate into that much better of a record. Tulsa went 4-8, a modest one-game improvement over the previous season, but Tre Lamb's team is moving in the right direction. This was arguably the worst defense in the nation in 2024 with 42.5 PPG and 7.1 YPP allowed. The secondary got torched left and right, as opponents averaged well over 300 passing yards per game. While Lamb's team didn't make many strides on offense, they gave up nearly 14 fewer points per game and 1.5 fewer yards per play, including more than a 100-yard improvement in terms of passing yards against.

Now we see if Lamb and new OC Kevin Barbay can inject some life into that side of the ball. Like most G6 teams, a lot of players moved on, but QB Baylor Hayes was not one of them and that could make a major difference. He'll have a new group of skill players, but the 36-year-old Lamb was a QB at Tennessee Tech and then the OC there as a rapid riser in the coaching ranks.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5
I'll give Lamb and his staff the benefit of the doubt here, in spite of a challenging schedule. While Tulsa avoids East Carolina and Memphis, road games at Navy, Tulane, and UTSA make for a very tough conference schedule. That said, all four American home games are very winnable, along with East Texas A&M. If the Golden Hurricane can beat Sam Houston State on the road in Week 2, this one should get there and the team should go bowling for the first time since 2021. My projection is 5.43 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 6-6 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Tre Lamb - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	OKLAHOMA ST (+11.7)	46.5
9/12	AT SAM HOUSTON ST (-12.1)	18.5
9/19	TEXAS A&M-COMM (-27.8)	6.0
9/26	AT ARKANSAS (+15.2)	45.5
10/1	NORTH TEXAS (+0.6)	34.5
10/10	AT NAVY (+14.4)	44.0
10/17	AT RICE (-1.2)	27.5
10/23	ARMY (+6.8)	40.0
11/7	AT TULANE (+14)	42.5
11/14	FLA ATLANTIC (-1)	33.5
11/21	CHARLOTTE (-13)	20.5
11/28	AT TX-SAN ANTONIO (+13.2)	41.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **34.23**
#91 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.5 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

4*

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Hayes have a sophomore slump?

Hayes didn't put up eye-popping numbers, but did help lead the offense to 424 yards in the upset win over Oklahoma State that really opened some eyes about the direction of this program. Unfortunately, Tulsa followed that up with three straight blowout losses to conference top dogs, but they were competitive for the most part from that point forward against comparable or lesser foes. Hayes will be without 1,000-yard rusher Dominic Richardson and his top three pass-catchers, but now that the program has shown a bit more stability, transfers are more willing to come in. Expect Tulsa to run the rock a lot, with some more designed runs for Hayes, but also with productive Auburn and Old Dominion transfers at RB.

What will be Tulsa's biggest area of improvement?

The offensive line is what looks like the group to push this team forward. Tulsa should get some sort of steak or fast food restaurant NIL deal because they have some beef on the offensive line. Lamb brought in transfers from Texas A&M and Ole Miss last season and now added South Alabama's starting center in Malachi Preciado, who was originally at Purdue. All of the starters and the guys on the two-deep are at or above three bills on the scales and I think that's exactly what he wants. Tulsa had nearly 500 rush attempts last season and I'd expect an even higher amount this season.

Can the Golden Hurricane turn Tulsa into "Tolsa"?

While the defense improved in several key areas, taking the football away from the other team was not one of them. Tulsa's defense mustered just 11 takeaways last season, leading to a -9 TO margin. It has been a long time since this program was on the positive side of the TO battle, but this might be the year. As long as they don't fumble the ball with a run-first offense, more turnovers on defense should help the cause. While the team's top two tacklers are gone, the team's top defensive backs have returned and Year 2 of DC Josh Reardon's scheme not only features players who know it, but also transfers who are likely better fits.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

300-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

35-1

AMERICAN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.1	97
YARDS PER POINT	17.6	120
PLAYS PER GAME	76.5	6
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:08	119
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.4%	86
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	388.8	62
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	98
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.3	27
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	167.5	50
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	78
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	34
COMPLETION %	58.4%	100
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	221.3	72
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	100
TURNOVERS	1.7	116
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.9	102
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	102
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.8%	109
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	409.1	94
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	68
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	188.1	110
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	76
COMPLETION %	62.9%	79
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	221	60
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	80
SACKS	1.6	97
TURNOVERS	0.9	108

UAB BLAZERS



At the end of the 2022 season, players rallied in support of interim head coach Bryant Vincent, who had served as the OC under predecessor Bill Clark before he stepped aside to focus on his health. The athletic department had other ideas and hired Trent Dilfer, who went just 9-21 over two-and-a-half seasons. Alex Mortensen, son of late ESPN analyst Chris, led an upset win over Memphis in his first game, but then the Blazers lost the next three games before finishing the season with a win over Tulsa.

Apparently that was enough for the penny-pinching AD to keep Mortensen around, as he'll get his first crack without the interim tag. Last season was disastrous for the Blazers, including a pregame stabbing incident in the locker room prior to the loss against USF, so it's probably unfair to judge Mortensen based on his six-game sample. Virtually everybody on defense is gone and most of the offense, a development that was in motion before the regular season even ended last year.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5
Even though UAB got to four wins last season in the midst of all sorts of turmoil, the schedule is pretty rough. The game against ULM should be a win, but as the second game of the season with a ton of new players and schemes, that could be a high-variance one both ways. It seems like UAB has to get that one because Samford and maybe Charlotte look like the other best chances, leaving the need for at least one upset somewhere along the line. Because I expect UAB's pass game to become less important, their game state worries me because they project to trail a lot. My projection is 3.63 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Alex Mortensen - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AT ILLINOIS (+29.4)	51.0
9/12	LA MONROE (-7.5)	22.0
9/19	AT LA LAFAYETTE (+10.5)	32.5
9/25	NAVY (+16.1)	44.0
10/3	SAMFORD (-23.3)	5.0
10/10	AT MEMPHIS (+19)	41.0
10/15	EAST CAROLINA (+12.5)	40.5
10/31	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+19)	41.0
11/7	CHARLOTTE (-7.7)	20.5
11/14	AT TEMPLE (+12.5)	34.0
11/21	TX-SAN ANTONIO (+11.8)	41.0
11/28	AT NORTH TEXAS (+13.1)	34.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 34.78
#89 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.7 / -1.1
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

4

3

1

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How does the rebuild look?

Veteran DC Todd Grantham is a nice start, as he's coached for some premier college teams and was also an NFL DC. Given that UAB returns one guy with more than 20 tackles, Grantham truly has as blank a slate as you can get. Portal pickups from every corner of the country make up that unit, along with most of the offense, though QB Ryder Burton, who came to UAB by way of BYU and West Virginia, is at least a starting point. A lot of the guys on offense are multi-time transfers that haven't latched on anywhere, including the patchwork offensive line. Some impact guys will emerge on both sides of the ball, but nobody on the two-deep is "proven".

Should Mortensen call his own offense?

Mortensen was the OC when he got promoted and kept running the offense when he took over as the interim head coach. He's going to keep doing that this season, even though he's overseeing the entire program now. At least the presence of somebody like Grantham helps in the sense that he's been around forever and doesn't need anybody looking over his shoulder. Not much seemed to change for the offense late in the season besides a higher frequency of running the football, even in blowout losses to UConn, North Texas, and South Florida. That means Georgia transfer Rod Robinson and ULM transfer Bam McReynolds will be focal points in the gameplan.

Is Grantham just what the Blazers defense needs?

Steve Russ and Sione Ta'ufu'ou were the two DCs during the Dilfer era, as Ta'ufu'ou went back to Cal prior to last season and Russ was brought over from Air Force. Russ is a longtime linebackers coach and had some seasons as the DC in Colorado Springs, but plotting a defensive course on a triple-option team is far different than what he experienced in Birmingham. Not surprisingly, UAB was better against the run on his watch, but also gave up a lot more explosive pass plays. Grantham has been a lot of places and, while his scheme might be kind of complex, he's certainly the best DC that the Blazers have had in a long time. Grantham was making \$1.3 million last season at Oklahoma State, but was fired just four games into the season. Mortensen is only making \$1 million, so this is likely a large investment to bring in Grantham and that says something.

ODDS TO WIN...

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****300-1****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.1	85
YARDS PER POINT	16.3	107
PLAYS PER GAME	73.1	18
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:49	25
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.0%	19
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	393.8	51
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	75
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.7	97
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	126.5	97
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	97
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.7	14
COMPLETION %	64.8%	35
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	267.3	23
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	67
TURNOVERS	1.9	125
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	37.9	133
YARDS PER POINT	10.9	136
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.0%	110
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	415.1	104
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	123
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	190.9	113
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	94
COMPLETION %	65.4%	106
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	224.2	67
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.5	134
SACKS	1.4	112
TURNOVERS	0.7	123

UTSA ROADRUNNERS



If not now, when? That is the main question for UTSA this season, as they are starting an 11-1 season in the face and a chance to be the G6 representative in the College Football Playoff. This season, you don't have to be a conference champion, you just have to be the highest-ranked team in the CFP rankings, though winning your conference probably helps. If UTSA were to upset Texas, things would get really interesting. For now, they just have to avoid any slip-ups on paper, as they should be favored in nine or 10 games.

This is one of the most experienced offenses in the American Conference and Rick Bowie is a very intriguing fit as the new OC. The defense does have to get better for UTSA and it's fair to wonder if Jess Loepp, who has been the DC since 2020, makes it through the season. Regardless, this is a team that should come into 2026 with enormous expectations and the chance to actually reach them.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

The Roadrunners have lost to Army in all three seasons with the AAC/American, but avoid them this season. That said, they do get Navy. But, the Middies come to San Antonio, along with USF and Tulsa, who I think will be much improved this season. The toughest conference test is a trip to Tulane in late October. A good chunk of money was earmarked to improve this roster for 2026 and it should help. Again, Traylor has to avoid the bad losses, but this may very well be the best team in the conference. My projection is 7.77 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & ATS, 10-3 O-U

Head Coach: Jeff Traylor - 7th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TX-RIO GRANDE (-25.9)	18.5
9/12	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (-0.3)	37.5
9/19	AT TEXAS (+28.7)	66.0
9/26	COLORADO ST (-12.9)	32.5
10/3	AT RICE (-9.8)	27.5
10/8	SOUTH FLORIDA (-3.8)	41.0
10/17	NAVY (-0.3)	44.0
10/24	AT TULANE (+5.4)	42.5
11/5	AT FLA ATLANTIC (-5)	33.5
11/14	NORTH TEXAS (-10.5)	34.5
11/21	AT UAB (-11.8)	26.0
11/28	TULSA (-13.2)	32.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **36.05**
#80 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **4.1 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

8

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

2

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the pass rush bounce back?

Per 247Sports, UTSA brought in 21 transfers. Twelve of them are on the defensive side. Out of the 12 teams in the American with the transfer portal available to them, 247 ranks their class 11th, so we'll see if the right pieces and parts were purchased in free agency. One notable thing about the transfer class is that Jeff Traylor and the defensive staff focused on pass rushers. UTSA had 46 sacks in 2023 and 42 sacks in 2024. They had just 24 sacks last season. G6 players who can get to the quarterback are often the most sought-after by bigger schools with bigger NIL budgets. For example, Jimmori Robinson had 10.5 sacks in 2024 and played at West Virginia last season. Trey Moore, who had 14 sacks in 2023, finished his collegiate career at Texas. The goal is to rotate a lot of d-linemen and get fresh pass rushers out there. It sure seems like the depth is a lot stronger this year.

Will Owen McCown be the best QB in the conference?

For UTSA to get where they want to go, it is up to McCown, the program's third-leading passer. He'll pass Eric Soza for second in Week 1 against UTRGV, but he won't make it to Frank Harris, whose throne he took over full-time with the 2024 season. McCown fell just shy of 3,000 passing yards last season, but did have 30 TD passes. His top WR, Devin McCuin, was picked up by Ohio State (and they know a thing or two about wide receivers), but he has some rapport with David Amador and AJ Wilson, plus there are others who have been on the roster for a while. As mentioned, Bowie is an interesting hire as OC. He was at Western Kentucky last season after serving in the same role at Abilene Christian in 2024 and at Valdosta State in 2022-23. He's led some prolific passing offenses and should be able to unlock more from McCown.

Can Traylor avoid the devastating loss?

UTSA won the Conference USA title in 2021 and 2022, but since joining the American, he's had some forgettable conference games. Last season, UTSA lost to Temple and Army as a favorite and also lost as a favorite to Texas State in non-conference play. In 2024, the Roadrunners lost to Rice and Tulsa in favorite roles. To this point, the Roadrunners haven't even played in the conference title game. That should change with this year's schedule, but Traylor also needs to take care of his affairs when he's expected to, something that he's struggled to do previously.

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****10-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+475****AMERICAN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	34.5	14
YARDS PER POINT	12.1	7
PLAYS PER GAME	70	55
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:40	28
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.6%	72
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	417.2	25
YARDS PER PLAY	6	28
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.9	83
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169.2	47
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	24
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.3	33
COMPLETION %	65.3%	29
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	248	42
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	62
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.6	90
YARDS PER POINT	12.7	118
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.9%	20
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	375.6	62
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	83
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	161.3	77
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	86
COMPLETION %	59.2%	30
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	214.3	52
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	81
SACKS	1.7	94
TURNOVERS	1.2	81

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ACC

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

From a College Football Playoff standpoint, the ACC had grown accustomed to leaving the party early until Miami showed up in a big way this past season. Clemson was a major player in the late 2010s, including two National Championships, but their one appearance in the last five seasons was a one-and-done as the No. 12 team in 2024. Florida State had a cameo appearance back in 2014 and relative newcomer SMU, who joined the conference in 2024, had a very short-lived appearance that same season.

The Hurricanes were unable to finish the job and lost to Indiana, but Mario Cristobal was able to flip the proverbial bird to the doubters and haters with wins over Texas A&M, Ohio State, and Ole Miss before the 27-21 loss to the Hoosiers. The question now is whether or not Miami can piggyback off of that success. Because if they can't, it looks like another season in which the ACC will be represented in the CFP simply by virtue of being a major conference with an automatic bid and having a seat at the table tall enough to get a team in the field.

Incredibly, Miami didn't even play in the ACC Championship Game last season, as that was between Duke and Virginia. The Blue Devils upset the Cavaliers, which kept Virginia out of the CFP. In the end, it worked out and the conference's best team made the biggest statement in December and January.

Despite some extremely heavy personnel losses, especially on defense, the Hurricanes (-136) still seem to have the inside track in the conference as a very clear odds-on favorite to celebrate in Charlotte on December 5. With SMU (7-1) and Louisville (8-1) as the only other teams lined in single digits to win the ACC at time of publish, it sure looks like the door is open for somebody to step up and challenge Miami. After all, five teams went 6-2 in conference play and five more went 4-4 last season. I'll be nice and call it parity. Really, this just isn't a very good conference top to bottom.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
MIAMI FL	10.5	63	1.7	0.1	42.83 (61)	10.1	1.9	7.9	1.1
SMU	8.5	55.5	4	0.1	43.62 (56)	8.9	3.1	6.8	2.2
LOUISVILLE	8.5	53.5	3.8	-0.1	45.67 (40)	8.2	3.8	6.3	2.7
CLEMSON	7.5	54	1.7	0.1	45.89 (38)	7.7	4.3	5.0	3.0
VIRGINIA	7.5	50.5	1.8	0.5	41.5 (68)	7.8	4.2	5.2	3.8
PITTSBURGH	7.5	50.5	3.3	-0.6	42.72 (62)	7.6	4.4	5.0	4.0
GEORGIA TECH	6.5	49	2.4	0.6	46.97 (30)	6.5	5.5	4.4	3.6
NC STATE	7.5	48	2.2	-0.4	42.44 (63)	7.2	4.8	4.9	4.1
VIRGINIA TECH	6.5	51	2.3	-0.2	43.23 (60)	7.3	4.7	4.8	4.2
DUKE	5.5	46.5	3.4	0.6	44.25 (47)	6.4	5.6	4.4	4.6
FLORIDA ST	6.5	50	2.9	-0.4	46.93 (31)	6.2	5.8	3.7	4.3
CALIFORNIA	6.5	45.5	2.2	-0.1	44.12 (48)	5.7	6.3	3.8	5.2
WAKE FOREST	5.5	46.5	2	0.3	43.47 (57)	6.2	5.8	3.5	5.5
NORTH CAROLINA	4.5	44.5	1.4	0.1	48.71 (24)	4.6	7.4	2.6	5.4
SYRACUSE	4.5	42	2.4	-0.3	46.9 (32)	4.5	7.5	2.8	6.2
STANFORD	3.5	39	1.9	-0.6	49.52 (15)	3.2	8.8	1.6	7.4
BOSTON COLLEGE	3.5	37.5	1.9	-0.6	49.01 (19)	3.0	9.0	1.4	6.6

BOSTON COLLEGE EAGLES



Bill O'Brien has spent a big chunk of his coaching career working with quarterbacks and that has to be his primary focus for this season. Dylan Loneragan and Grayson James split time last season, collectively posting a 19/10 TD/INT ratio, but this was a very poor football team. O'Brien was 7-6 in his first season, but the Eagles fell to 2-10 in Year 2 and didn't have nearly enough offensive firepower to overcome a defense that ranked 132nd in the nation in yards per play allowed.

He has virtually no D-I experience at the QB position heading into this season and very little in the way of returning production, but a team that went 2-10 needs an overhaul anyway and that's precisely what has happened in Chestnut Hill, as the program looks to bounce back from its worst season since 2012. If there is no bounce back, it could very well be O'Brien's last season at the helm.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

The Eagles don't play in the best conference, but the only clear favorite role will be at home against Maine in Week 3. Road trips to Cincinnati, SMU, Georgia Tech, Duke, Notre Dame, and Miami all look like clear losses, which accounts for half of their scheduled games. In their five FBS home games, they'll face a talent disadvantage and two of them - Rutgers and Virginia Tech - come so early in the season with a brand new roster that they're likely to get off to a very poor start and this isn't the kind of team or schedule you want to be chasing with, as my projections call for 3.42 wins.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 6-6 ATS, 8-4 O-U
Head Coach: Bill O'Brien - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT CINCINNATI (+9.5)	44.5
9/11	RUTGERS (+3.1)	42.5
9/19	MAINE (-22.2)	17.0
9/26	VIRGINIA TECH (+11.4)	51.0
10/3	AT SMU (+22.6)	55.5
10/17	PITTSBURGH (+10.5)	50.5
10/24	AT GEORGIA TECH (+14.5)	49.0
10/31	AT DUKE (+13)	46.5
11/7	FLORIDA ST (+10.2)	50.0
11/14	AT NOTRE DAME (+35.4)	68.5
11/21	SYRACUSE (+2.3)	42.0
11/28	AT MIAMI FL (+27.8)	63.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.01**
#19 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL



OFFENSE



DEFENSE



THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can O'Brien find a quarterback?

The early leader in the clubhouse looks to be Saginaw Valley State transfer Mason McKenzie, who had zero FBS offers coming out of high school. He's billed as a dual-threat guy with nearly 6,000 yards of total offense and nearly 50 touchdowns to his name, but this is a serious step up from playing Division II football. At least Grayson Wilson was offered by multiple FBS teams and ultimately enrolled at Arkansas. The North Little Rock native didn't play, so he gets a clean slate now. O'Brien, who will serve as his own OC, also has a freshman in Femi Babalola to consider, as he had several D-I offers and might be the best long-term option.

Will Ted raise the Roof?

In hopes of fixing the putrid defense, O'Brien has gone to a longtime friend in Ted Roof. The two worked together at Georgia Tech in the '90s and again at Duke when Roof was the head coach from 2003-07, which is the only time he has ever been a head coach. He went 6-45 with the Blue Devils, which is probably why he's only been a DC and a position coach ever since. Roof was semi-retired after getting dismissed by UCF in October 2024, but O'Brien coaxed him off the couch to help a unit that allowed over 6.5 yards per play overall and almost 470 yards per game in ACC play. Roof has a mostly blank slate with leading tackler KP Price back, but his goal will be to find sacks, as BC only had 17 last season.

How much will the growing pains hurt?

In terms of skill-position production, the Eagles have basically none of what they got last season. Leading WR Lewis Bond had 88 catches for 993 yards and he's gone, along with the other two top receivers. The top returnee is actually TE Kaelan Chudzinski, son of former Browns head coach Rob Chudzinski. Not only is the WR room a ghost town when it comes to statistics, but the team's top two leading rushers, who accumulated 13 TD and over 1,100 yards, are also gone. Liberty transfer Evan Dickens and holdover true sophomore Bo MacCormack may have to help in the passing game given all the unproven wideouts. If nothing else, Dickens ran for 1,339 yards for the Flames.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****400-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.7	101
YARDS PER POINT	17	116
PLAYS PER GAME	71.5	39
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:49	99
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.4%	100
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	368.5	78
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	88
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.7	119
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	104.5	120
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	117
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.7	14
COMPLETION %	61.7%	65
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	264	25
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	73
TURNOVERS	1.9	125
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	34.8	123
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	107
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.5%	103
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	457.4	131
YARDS PER PLAY	6.8	133
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	192.3	115
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.3	130
COMPLETION %	65.7%	110
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	265.1	125
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.7	126
SACKS	1.2	121
TURNOVERS	1	98

CALIFORNIA GOLDEN BEARS



The boosters in Berkeley were ready to make a change and that's precisely what happened, as first-time HC Tosh Lupoi has taken over at his alma mater. The Walnut Creek native played at Cal from 2000-05 and also got his coaching career underway there in 2008. For Lupoi, who has coached under some pretty esteemed mentors, this isn't a total teardown and rebuild because of the presence of QB Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele, but he will have a mostly blank slate to work with on defense.

Cal has co-OCs and co-DCs, so we'll see if everybody can work in harmony and raise the ceiling of this program. Being in the ACC presents a lot of logistical challenges and some rough travel, so depth is a priority with this program and it could take some time to build that up. That's especially true given some of the academic requirements to call Berkeley home.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

Even though Cal may not match last season's seven-win total, there's a very good chance that they are a much more aesthetically-pleasing football team this season. JKS has the chance to grow and this should be a much more innovative squad on both sides of the ball. Unfortunately, with a completely new coaching staff, Cal doesn't have a bye until early November and, while they avoid Miami, Florida State, Louisville, and Georgia Tech, growing pains are inevitable and I like this bet with a projection of 5.74 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-8 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Tosh Lupoi - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	UCLA (+0.6)	48.0
9/12	AT SYRACUSE (-1)	42.0
9/19	WAGNER (-45.3)	3.0
9/25	CLEMSON (+6.4)	54.0
10/3	AT UNLV (+1.8)	44.0
10/10	VIRGINIA TECH (+3.1)	51.0
10/17	WAKE FOREST (-0.9)	46.5
10/24	AT SMU (+14.1)	55.5
10/31	AT NC STATE (+4.8)	48.0
11/14	AT VIRGINIA (+6.9)	50.5
11/21	STANFORD (-9.3)	39.0
11/28	PITTSBURGH (+2.2)	50.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.12**
#48 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.2 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

8*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will it work out better this time?

It is wild to think that Cal had No. 1 overall pick and National Championship winner Fernando Mendoza for two seasons and went just 6-7 both times. For the most part, Justin Wilcox did what he was expected to do defensively, as the Golden Bears held opponents under 28 PPG in six of the last seven seasons. But, it was the offense that never really seemed to be able to get it going, despite a good amount of returning starters and returning production. Hiring another defensive-minded HC in Lupoi might work out, but the onus is really on Jordan Somerville and former NFL WR Ike Hilliard to find some more explosiveness on that side of the ball. Somerville is just 30 years old, but his one year as an offensive assistant with Oregon in 2022 was enough for Lupoi to want him as a co-worker again.

Is JKS going to be a sophomore sensation?

Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele is a mouthful, but the 'Ewa Beach, HI native might be a name everybody has to learn to pronounce this season. He was originally committed to Oregon, but transferred to Cal to get a better opportunity prior to his freshman season. He got the keys to this offense and posted over 3,400 passing yards with an 18/9 TD/INT ratio and a 64.2% completion rate as a true freshman. He'll have to learn a new scheme and will have to develop a rapport with some new WRs, as Jacob De Jesus and Trond Grizzell combined for 163 catches and over 1,800 yards prior to leaving. Hilliard's presence should really help here, especially with 1,000-yard Ohio standout Chase Henderson and big-bodied Rutgers transfer Ian Strong. With a lot of starting experience on the OL, JKS could have a monster season.

Can the defense turn positives into negatives?

Michael Hutchings and Lupoi didn't really cross paths at Oregon, as Lupoi came in as the DC in 2022 and Hutchings had moved from Eugene to Bowling Green, coaching up linebackers at Western Kentucky. That was also a one-year stop, as the now 31-year-old spent the last three seasons coaching defensive backs with the Vikings. Cal only had 21 sacks last season and 13 takeaways. Of course there is a big talent gap between Cal and Oregon, but Lupoi's defense tied for 26th in takeaways with 21 in 15 games and racked up 30 sacks. Cal allowed 4.7 yards per carry and a 61.7% completion rate. Only three starters are back on defense, but that's probably a good thing.

ODDS TO WIN...

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****22-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****35-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.5	81
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	58
PLAYS PER GAME	70.7	49
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:07	62
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	61
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	349.2	92
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	108
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.3	125
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	74.3	135
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.5	134
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.8	12
COMPLETION %	63.1%	54
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	274.9	18
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	68
TURNOVERS	1.1	38
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.2	87
YARDS PER POINT	12.9	114
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.4%	102
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	375.9	63
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	74
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	165.1	81
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	108
COMPLETION %	62.2%	66
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	210.8	45
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	35
SACKS	1.5	107
TURNOVERS	1	98

CLEMSON TIGERS



Sports are a “what have you done for me lately” business. Is it fair to wonder if Dabo Swinney has built up enough goodwill to withstand another disappointing season? The bar at Clemson is making the College Football Playoff and being a National Championship contender. Going 7-6 while under some scrutiny for being slow to react to the current landscape of college football and the transfer portal doesn't sit well with a lot of deep-pocketed folks.

On the other hand, as Dabo begins his 19th season at the helm, his Tigers had won at least 10 games in 13 of the previous 14 seasons, going 9-4 in the other one. With scapegoat Garrett Riley gone and old friend Chad Morris back in the mix as OC, is a bounce back season imminent?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

We'll find out very quickly how Clemson looks for this season with the opener against LSU, but I have to think Swinney is beyond relieved to have Morris back, his OC from 2011-14. It was painfully clear that he and Riley were oil and water and I have to think that had a lot to do with how Klubnik's Clemson career ended. The defense was extremely good last season and it shouldn't take much for the offense to improve with the pipeline of talent Dabo has established. Vizzina was a top-10 QB in his 2023 class per 247 and this is an excellent WR room. The Tigers are worthy of a look at 14-1 to win the ACC. My projection is 7.88 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-8 ATS, 4-9 O-U
Head Coach: Dabo Swinney - 19th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT LSU (+9.9)	60.5
9/12	GA SOUTHERN (-22.7)	33.5
9/19	NORTH CAROLINA (-11.1)	44.5
9/25	AT CALIFORNIA (-6.4)	45.5
10/3	MIAMI FL (+7.4)	63.0
10/17	CHARLESTON SOUT (-47.3)	8.5
10/24	VIRGINIA TECH (-4.9)	51.0
10/31	AT FLORIDA ST (-1.2)	50.0
11/7	AT SYRACUSE (-9.7)	42.0
11/14	GEORGIA TECH (-6.1)	49.0
11/20	AT DUKE (-4.2)	46.5
11/28	SOUTH CAROLINA (-1)	54.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.89**
#38 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.7 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

10

OFFENSE

5

DEFENSE

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What is the ceiling for the offense?

Normally the loss of a three-year starter and 10,000-yard passer would seem like a big blow. Cade Klubnik had about as underwhelming a senior season as you could have, posting just a 16/6 TD/INT ratio one season after 43 total touchdowns. Injuries didn't help, as the Tigers lost Bryant Wesco midway through the season and Antonio Williams never seemed fully healthy. Also, it seemed like Swinney was at odds with Riley on a weekly basis, even throwing him directly under the team's charter bus more than once. To be honest, even though Christopher Vizzina is light on experience with just 105 pass attempts, the return of Morris and a new voice in the huddle will probably help.

Who will better the backfield?

It wasn't all on Klubnik last season. The Tigers collectively ran for just 3.9 yards per carry, a significant drop from 5.1 YPC the year prior. In 2023, both Phil Mafah and Will Shipley ran for better than five yards per tote. As the sole feature back in 2024, Mafah ran for over 1,100 yards. This past season, Adam Randall had 4.8 yards per pop, but Klubnik's lack of success running the ball hurt the team's per-carry metrics. Randall is gone, so we'll have to wait and see who emerges as the primary ball-carrier. Chris Johnson had over seven yards per carry at SMU and Gideon Davidson was a four-star recruit and top-five RB in the 2025 class per 247.

Could this be a top-10 defense?

Last season's defensive improvements were overshadowed by offensive regression. Former Indiana head coach Tom Allen did some great things in Year 1 as the DC, as the team was dramatically better against the run and held opponents to just 20.5 PPG. The secondary wasn't great and the loss of second-round pick Avieon Terrell won't help, but three of the top four tacklers are back, including the team's top sack man in Will Heldt. Year 2 in this scheme paired with an offensive uptick and we could be looking at a Clemson team that more closely resembles what we've grown accustomed to seeing. That would be beneficial, given that Vizzina has to grow into the QB1 role on offense.

ODDS TO WIN...

110-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+600****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****14-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.8	71
YARDS PER POINT	15	83
PLAYS PER GAME	69.8	58
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:07	35
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.4%	105
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	386.9	65
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	58
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.6	110
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	116.6	111
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	103
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.6	17
COMPLETION %	65.2%	32
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	270.3	21
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	57
TURNOVERS	1.3	62
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.4	33
YARDS PER POINT	17	19
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.9%	16
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	364.5	51
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	47
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	108.9	16
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	28
COMPLETION %	60.9%	53
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	255.6	120
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	53
SACKS	2.7	21
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

DUKE BLUE DEVILS



Having success at a program like Duke is more and more impressive with each passing season. Not only does the school have some stronger academic requirements than most in that part of the nation, players that come in and have success wind up wanting a bigger stage in the SEC, ACC, or elsewhere. For the third straight season, head coach Manny Diaz had to hit the transfer portal to find a QB, eventually going with San Jose State's Walker Eget to replace Darian Mensah, who had a strong 34/6 TD/INT ratio last season.

The Blue Devils return their 1,100-yard rusher, but lose their QB, top three pass-catchers, and Diaz has to mostly retool the defense with a handful of returnees, but only a couple of impact starters. Of course, while his old employer went to the National Championship Game out of the ACC, it is Diaz's Duke team that is the reigning conference champs.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

Portal poaching for these mid-tier, Power Four schools is hard to overcome annually and I can't help but wonder if this is the season it hits hard. Duke is 18-9 with two nine-win seasons under Diaz, but the market's position on Duke seems to say a lot. The schedule is a little tougher with Miami on the conference slate and the talent level of the program definitely seems to have dropped. Even before Diaz, Mike Elko and David Cutcliffe were overachieving in Durham, but the new college football landscape is a lot to overcome year in and year out. My projection, however, is for 5.94 wins.

2025 Record: 9-5 SU & 6-7-1 ATS, 10-4 O-U

Head Coach: Manny Diaz - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TULANE (-6.8)	42.5
9/12	AT ILLINOIS (+7.2)	51.0
9/19	STANFORD (-11.5)	39.0
9/26	WILLIAM & MARY (-33.4)	17.0
10/10	AT GEORGIA TECH (+4.3)	49.0
10/17	NORTH CAROLINA (-5.3)	44.5
10/23	AT VIRGINIA (+5.2)	50.5
10/31	BOSTON COLLEGE (-13)	37.5
11/7	AT NC STATE (+3.1)	48.0
11/14	AT MIAMI FL (+17.6)	63.0
11/20	CLEMSON (+4.2)	54.0
11/28	AT WAKE FOREST (+1.4)	46.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.25**
#47 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.4 / 0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

7

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who does what Darian did?

Mensah was really good for Duke after transferring in from Tulane and now he's leveled up again as the expected starting QB for, ironically, Miami. He completed over two-thirds of his passes and nearly passed for 4,000 yards while leading the conference in pass attempts, passing yards, and passing touchdowns. Eget played extensively with the Spartans and had over 5,500 yards, but only 30 TD against 19 INT. It might be up to redshirt freshman Dan Mahan, who got all the spring opportunities he could handle with Eget hurt. OC Jonathan Brewer saw his group improve by a full yard per play and 8.3 PPG in Year 2, but he's mostly starting from scratch in Year 3.

Should the show run through Sheppard?

Nate Sheppard ran for 1,132 yards and 11 TD with 5.7 yards per pop as a true freshman last season. Despite the loss of an NFL-caliber lineman in the April draft, the Blue Devils are still big and experienced up front. While Eget or Mahan have an intriguing transfer in Penn's 1,000-yard WR Jared Richardson, their other two primary receivers for this season look like 5-foot-8 Jayden Moore and 5-foot-9 Javen Nicholas, a Charlotte transfer. While Duke's offensive numbers improved, the defensive numbers got significantly worse in Diaz's second year, so a ground-and-pound type of approach might be a good way to go at least early on, perhaps leading to some value on Unders.

Can Manny find the manpower on defense?

As an offense, Duke had 6.2 YPP, 285 passing yards per game, and a 66.4% completion percentage. Opponents had 6.3 YPP, 277 passing yards per game, and a 67.2% completion rate. In other words, the Blue Devils were rather fortunate that Mensah played as well as he did and that the team finished +10 in TO margin. Duke was comfortably outgained on a per-play basis in ACC action. The Blue Devils also went from 43 sacks down to 26. Across the board, the defensive numbers were worse, including a 1.3-yard spike in YPP allowed that is hard to overlook given the offensive losses. With Diaz so accomplished on the defensive side, it's time for that unit to step up.

400-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****35-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****60-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.8	15
YARDS PER POINT	12.3	12
PLAYS PER GAME	70.8	45
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:54	68
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.2%	80
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	414.6	27
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	29
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.6	99
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	137.2	86
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	71
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.3	18
COMPLETION %	65.5%	27
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	277.4	16
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	45
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.4	96
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	76
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.2%	118
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	435.4	119
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	121
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	146.3	58
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	69
COMPLETION %	67.3%	125
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	289.1	136
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.5	122
SACKS	1.8	81
TURNOVERS	1.8	14

FLORIDA STATE SEMINOLES



Letting go of the head coach has gotten increasingly expensive in recent years, as agents have been doing one heck of a job securing buyouts for their clients. In some cases, it doesn't matter and the school and the boosters come together and raise the necessary cash. Other times, the chopping block finds assistants and position coaches as they wear the blame and the shame for things going wrong. In Tallahassee, it seems to be the latter, as Mike Norvell is still employed, but with a new special teams coordinator, a new OC after Gus Malzahn retired, and a second-year DC.

With Norvell's buyout still sitting north of \$50 million at the conclusion of this season, it will be interesting to see if a third straight season of non-contention and not even a bowl game appearance will be tolerated by the decision-makers. After all, Florida State has never had a head coach with three straight losing seasons. That dark cloud could hang over the program throughout the course of the season, especially with a slow start.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

This isn't a bet due to the cost-prohibitive vig and the fact that the Seminoles do project to have a good defense. Even if Daniels is an average QB, they can find their way into 7-5 or so, but I do think that the floor is lower than the ceiling is high. With roadies at Alabama, Miami, and Louisville plus home games against SMU, Clemson, and Florida, it's a tough-looking slate that leaves minimal margin for error. My projection is 6.35 wins.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Mike Norvell - 7th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	NEW MEXICO ST (-27.9)	25.0
9/7	SMU (+2.7)	55.5
9/19	AT ALABAMA (+15.1)	61.0
9/26	C ARKANSAS (-39.7)	13.5
10/3	VIRGINIA (-1.9)	50.5
10/9	AT LOUISVILLE (+7.7)	53.5
10/17	AT MIAMI FL (+15.1)	63.0
10/31	CLEMSON (+1.2)	54.0
11/7	AT BOSTON COLLEGE (-10.2)	37.5
11/13	AT PITTSBURGH (+4.2)	50.5
11/21	NC STATE (-5.3)	48.0
11/27	FLORIDA (+2.2)	55.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.93**
#31 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.9 / -0.4**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

5

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the luck level out?

The Seminoles were 0-5 on the road last season and 2-6 overall in conference play. Don't let their full-season stats fool you because they completely slaughtered East Texas A&M 77-3 and Kent State 66-10. In those two games, they were +1,101 yards, so their per-play stats and total stats look as though they deserved a far better fate than 5-7. That being said, they were still +0.84 YPP in ACC games, losing with a yardage edge to Virginia, Miami, Stanford, Clemson, and NC State. Is that bad luck or is that bad coaching? Even with more production on both sides of the ball, the Seminoles were still -5 in TO margin and only mustered 14 takeaways in 12 games. However, they also only recovered two of the 14 fumbles they forced, so that weirdly-shaped ball simply didn't bounce their way.

Is Ashton Daniels the missing piece?

Duce Robinson, the 6-foot-6 one-time No. 1 TE recruit in the nation, had his breakout season with 56 catches for 1,081 yards and freshman Micahi Danzy had over 21 yards per reception. Ousmane Kromah had 5.7 yards per carry on 72 attempts and Samuel Singleton had over seven yards per pop on 51 totes. The majority of those passes and handoffs came from Tommy Castellanos, the Boston College transfer who led the team in rushing with just 557 yards and had a 15/9 TD/INT ratio. Daniels, who had flashes at Stanford, only started three games at Auburn, but now he's on this roster. It sure seems like Norvell's albatross buyout is holding the program hostage financially, as Daniels and redshirt freshman Kevin Sperry are not the types of QBs programs like FSU should have given the current landscape. Frankly, neither was Castellanos.

What are the biggest concerns on defense?

First-year DC Tony White fashioned a really good unit. While the Seminoles did get shredded by Florida in the finale and also gave up 46 points to Virginia, most of their data points were really solid. In all, White shaved 6.0 PPG, 1.0 YPC, and 0.8 YPP off of the team's stat sheet year over year. Only one player had more than 50 tackles and, while he's gone, the team's sack leader, tackles for loss leader, and a 133-tackle monster from Southern Miss give White and his assistants a good foundation to build off of and one that they're likely to need.

ODDS TO WIN...

180-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****20-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****35-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29	40
YARDS PER POINT	15.5	94
PLAYS PER GAME	72.4	33
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:28	113
3RD DOWN CONV. %	49.0%	9
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	448.9	11
YARDS PER PLAY	6.2	22
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.3	21
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	205.9	14
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	23
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29	97
COMPLETION %	57.7%	109
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	243	48
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.4	17
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.7	47
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	73
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.4%	64
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.8	33
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	26
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	141.1	48
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	27
COMPLETION %	62.6%	72
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	199.7	32
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	57
SACKS	2.5	28
TURNOVERS	1.1	86

GEORGIA TECH YELLOW JACKETS



With three straight losses to end the season, Georgia Tech's last 10-win season moved another year back in the rearview mirror, but Brent Key got very close in his fourth full season at the helm. The Yellow Jackets actually started the season 8-0 and had a clear path to the College Football Playoff, but inexplicably ran out of gas late in the year, dropping three of their last four and also the bowl game to BYU.

Key and the coaches had success with Texas A&M transfer Haynes King and they've turned to the portal again for Alberto Mendoza, the younger brother of Fernando Mendoza, the reigning National Championship QB and No. 1 overall pick. We have no idea what to expect from him since Curt Cignetti rarely took his foot off the gas at Indiana and he didn't play very much.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

The schedule isn't overly kind to the Yellow Jackets, especially late in the season. If James Franklin has Virginia Tech going in the right direction, the year ends with the Hokies, Pitt, Louisville, Clemson, Wake Forest, and Georgia. Getting to seven wins will be a task. But, given what Key has done thus far, the caliber of coordinators he has hired, and how well the program has done in the portal, I see more reasons for optimism than pessimism, even with a projection of 6.02 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-6 ATS, 7-6 O-U

Head Coach: Brent Key - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	COLORADO (-9)	43.0
9/12	TENNESSEE (+5)	57.0
9/19	MERCER (-24.1)	26.5
9/26	AT STANFORD (-8.7)	39.0
10/10	DUKE (-4.3)	46.5
10/17	AT VIRGINIA TECH (+3.7)	51.0
10/24	BOSTON COLLEGE (-14.5)	37.5
10/31	AT PITTSBURGH (+4.2)	50.5
11/7	LOUISVILLE (+2)	53.5
11/14	AT CLEMSON (+6.1)	54.0
11/21	WAKE FOREST (-4.6)	46.5
11/28	AT GEORGIA (+19.8)	67.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.97**
#30 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.4 / 0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

10

OFFENSE

5

DEFENSE

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How coordinated will Georgia Tech be to start the season?

There are a lot of new faces. Only one player with at least six receptions is back among the WR and TE rooms. Justice Haynes transferred in from Michigan and looks to be the starter at RB in front of Malachi Hosley, who is easily the most productive skill player back for the Yellow Jackets, even though King led the team in rushing yards and rushing touchdowns. Three starting offensive lineman and the OL coach are also gone. OC Buster Faulkner took the same role at Florida and DC Blake Gideon went back to Texas. So, to summarize - new QB, new feature back, all new WR, two new, albeit very productive, transfer TEs, and new coordinators on both sides of the ball. Key has done a magnificent job and turnover is nothing new, but this is a lot.

Did Key make the right hires?

There are silver linings on both sides of the ball, though. New DC Jason Semore has spent the last three seasons with Charles Huff, first at Marshall and then at Southern Miss. The Golden Eagles had 29 takeaways last season, which was the fourth-most in FBS, and 23 of those were interceptions, which led the nation. New OC George Godsey, who played QB for Georgia Tech from 1998-2001, heads back to his alma mater after four seasons as the Ravens' TE coach. Given that a couple of Tech's best portal pulls were tight ends, Godsey might be an excellent fit. From a schematic standpoint, I'd look more of a ball-control offense from the Yellow Jackets. GT was 97th in average time of possession last season. Expect a jump there.

Is this the year?

Georgia Tech should enter the season believing that they can be in contention for the College Football Playoff, since the ACC is the weakest of the Power Four conferences and the schedule, with Tennessee at home early in the season, gives them a chance to be in that discussion as the first CFP rankings come out. But, what I'm talking about is whether or not this is the year that Georgia Tech beats Georgia. Regardless of how the ACC and the CFP shake out, that would be a monumental achievement for Key and the program. The Bees last won in 2016, but they've come very close, losing in eight overtimes two seasons ago and losing 16-9 in a total rock fight last season. They've covered every Georgia game under Key, but this one is back on the road.

ODDS TO WIN...

400-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****20-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****35-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.9	33
YARDS PER POINT	14.8	76
PLAYS PER GAME	67.5	81
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:34	79
3RD DOWN CONV. %	47.3%	13
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	443	17
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	9
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.3	54
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	195.3	21
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.4	11
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.4	79
COMPLETION %	69.3%	8
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	247.7	43
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	23
TURNOVERS	1.1	38
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.1	67
YARDS PER POINT	15.5	38
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.9%	88
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	405.3	87
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	107
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	168.3	87
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	102
COMPLETION %	61.8%	63
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	237	94
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	90
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	0.7	128

LOUISVILLE CARDINALS



Getting to the next level is what Jeff Brohm needs to do at Louisville. Since coming back in 2023, the Cardinals have won 10, 9, and 9 games, but have only made the ACC Title Game one time and have played in the Holiday, Sun, and Boca Raton Bowls. For all of the wins and the strong players that have gone through the program, Brohm has lost as a touchdown or better favorite at least twice in each of the last three seasons. To be fair, one of the 2024 losses in that role was to SMU, who wound up being a surprise CFP team. The others? Pitt, Kentucky, Stanford, Virginia, and Cal.

Those devastating losses illustrate the slim wiggle room for Louisville because Brohm has also led upset wins over Miami, Clemson, and Notre Dame in the last three seasons, with last year's win over the runner-up Hurricanes in Coral Gables when they were No. 2 in the nation. It is remarkable how consistent Brohm has been in three seasons, not just with the overall record, but also with the path taken to get there.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 8.5

The conference schedule does not have Miami or Clemson and the games against SMU and Pitt are at home. The season opener against Mississippi in Nashville will be a good litmus test for both teams, especially since the Rebels bid a not-so-fond farewell to Lane Kiffin prior to last year's CFP. Brohm always finds ways to make the passing game work and this might be his first 200-yards-per-game rushing attack. If Brohm can cut two of his trademark losses down to one, I think this gets home at a nice plus-money price, even though my projection is 8.02 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 4-9 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Jeff Brohm - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	VS. OLE MISS (+7.2)	60.5
9/11	VILLANOVA (-29.3)	28.0
9/19	SMU (-1.7)	55.5
9/26	WAKE FOREST (-10.5)	46.5
10/3	AT NC STATE (-3.2)	48.0
10/9	FLORIDA ST (-7.7)	50.0
10/17	AT SYRACUSE (-9)	42.0
10/31	STANFORD (-18.9)	39.0
11/7	AT GEORGIA TECH (-2)	49.0
11/14	AT NORTH CAROLINA (-7.5)	44.5
11/21	PITTSBURGH (-7.4)	50.5
11/28	AT KENTUCKY (-4)	47.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.67**
#40 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.8 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

9

DEFENSE

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Kienholz the missing “Linc”?

Miller Moss turned out not to be the answer, as the USC transfer took over for Tyler Shough and put up some pretty pedestrian numbers last season, falling short of 3,000 yards with just 16 TD passes. But, at least Moss had a lot of collegiate experience and so did Shough when he came over from Texas Tech. This time, Brohm has gone the portal route again, but with Ohio State’s Lincoln Kienholz. The multi-sport star athlete out of South Dakota only threw 36 passes over three seasons in Columbus. The talent should be there, and Brohm does have a more experienced option in two-year West Georgia starter Davin Wydner, but getting the QB position right would be a huge start for the Cardinals.

What can Brown do for Louisville?

That’s actually the law offices of Brown & Brown, as Isaac and Keyjuan (no relation) racked up just shy of 1,600 yards on the ground and 13 touchdowns. Isaac couldn’t live up to his freshman season with 1,173 rushing yards, but he also missed a handful of games. Given that he had 8.8 yards per carry, who knows what he would have done with better health fortunes. Keyjuan had over seven yards per carry. Given that Chris Bell and Caullin Lacy, who had 132 of the team’s 268 receptions and over 54% of the team’s receiving yards, are both gone, Kienholz as a runner and the two Browns are the keys to offsetting a brand-new WR corps.

Does the defensive dominance continue?

Lost in the fact that Brohm always loses a game or two that he shouldn’t is that the Cardinals have had a stellar defense on his watch. Co-DCs Ron English and Mark Hagen are gone, with English stepping away for his son’s senior season at Navy. Brohm kept things internal and promoted LB coach Mark Ivey, who was a holdover from Scott Satterfield’s staff, and DB coach Steve Ellis. Louisville has allowed slightly over 21 PPG in two of Brohm’s three seasons and slightly over 24 PPG in the other. The Cardinals haven’t allowed more than 3.7 yards per carry under Brohm and even allowed just 4.7 YPP last season, finishing 15th in that department. With only one of the top six tacklers back, it could be a struggle to keep the bar that high, but they’ve come out strong from major losses in Brohm’s other seasons.

ODDS TO WIN...

150-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+550****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+800****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.2	48
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	29
PLAYS PER GAME	66.3	97
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:11	58
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.5%	109
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	371.4	75
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	48
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.6	101
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	158.5	58
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	28
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.8	57
COMPLETION %	63.8%	44
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	212.9	86
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	93
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.5	34
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	62
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.1%	23
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	315.8	19
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	16
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	117.7	22
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	26
COMPLETION %	60.0%	39
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	198.2	28
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	8
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	1.7	27

MIAMI HURRICANES



Clemson finally has some company. No, Miami didn't finish the job and become the second champion from the ACC in the College Football Playoff era, but at least they were able to make a run. The Tigers have played 11 CFP games. The other ACC teams were Florida State in 2014 and SMU in 2024 prior to the Hurricanes' run last season. In other words, it took a decade for an ACC team other than Clemson to play more than one CFP game.

Ultimately, winning the last game of the season is what matters, but the Hurricanes did make some conference history and much-maligned head coach Mario Cristobal exterminated some demons, which was good to see given that those demons were once again present in the regular season with two losses as a double-digit favorite. With some raised expectations as the odds-on conference favorite, we'll see if he can avoid those bumps in the road.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 10.5

Road games at Clemson and Notre Dame absolutely stand out here because of Cristobal's penchant for losing a game that he shouldn't as a big favorite. If the 'Canes drop one of those two, then they have to run the table otherwise for this bet to go through because season win total wagers don't include conference title games or the playoff. Miami should be in both, but that doesn't mean Over 10.5 is the way to go here, though this looks like an excellent team on paper. My projection is for 10.62 wins.

2025 Record: 13-3 SU & 11-5 ATS, 7-9 O-U
Head Coach: Mario Cristobal - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	AT STANFORD (-22.2)	39.0
9/10	FLORIDA AM (-65.6)	-1.0
9/18	AT WAKE FOREST (-14.6)	46.5
9/26	C MICHIGAN (-35)	30.5
10/3	AT CLEMSON (-7.4)	54.0
10/17	FLORIDA ST (-15.1)	50.0
10/24	PITTSBURGH (-14.8)	50.5
10/31	AT NORTH CAROLINA (-17.2)	44.5
11/7	AT NOTRE DAME (+9.2)	68.5
11/14	DUKE (-17.6)	46.5
11/21	VIRGINIA TECH (-13.9)	51.0
11/28	BOSTON COLLEGE (-27.8)	37.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **42.83**
#61 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.7 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

4

DEFENSE

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How do we evaluate last season?

A lot of things have to go right to legitimately contend for a championship and that did happen for Miami, as they saved some of their best football for the CFP. Carson Beck was excellent, the defense was ferocious, both coordinators were outstanding, and the Hurricanes beat Texas A&M, Ohio State, and Ole Miss before falling to Indiana. Here's the thing - even in a 10-win season two years ago, Miami lost to Georgia Tech and Syracuse in big favorite roles. Cristobal lost to Georgia Tech as a 20-point favorite in 2023. A month-long perfect storm came at the right time, but Miami also got a little bit fortunate to backdoor into the CFP as an at-large after not even playing in the ACC Title Game. Which Miami was the real one?

Is the Miami offense even better?

Beck posted a 30/12 TD/INT ratio, with four of those interceptions coming in the regular-season loss to Louisville. He ultimately threw for over 3,800 yards and completed over 70% of his passes, but you have to wonder if Shannon Dawson's offense has another gear with an objectively more talented QB. Darian Mensah had a 34/6 TD/INT ratio last season at Duke after a strong season at Tulane. He's been extremely well-coached throughout his career and enters a great situation here with Mark Fletcher & Co. all back at RB and 1,200-yard WR Malachi Toney back to lead a rebuilt group that includes Mensah's Duke teammate Cooper Barkate, who had 1,100 yards himself. Dawson impressed me a lot in the CFP and this offense looks loaded.

But, how much will the defense drop off?

Corey Hetherman, another stellar coordinator, got a ton of production out of last season's defense. Unfortunately, most of that production is gone. While leading tackler Mohamed Toure is back, it won't be easy to replace 22 combined sacks from Akheem Mesidor and Rueben Bain. Jakobe Thomas was second in tackles and first in interceptions and he was drafted by the Vikings, while Keionte Scott was taken in the fourth round by the Bucs. This is and has always been a strong recruiting pipeline, especially on defense. Truth be told, offensive losses would concern me way more than defensive ones based on the program's reputation. But, Hetherman will need to find new go-to guys pretty quickly.

ODDS TO WIN...

11-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-250****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****-135****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30	32
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	28
PLAYS PER GAME	67.6	79
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:24	6
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.4%	21
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	395	50
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	30
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.7	60
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	147.9	68
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	82
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.7	75
COMPLETION %	70.7%	5
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	247.1	44
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	28
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	15.6	5
YARDS PER POINT	19.3	4
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.2%	14
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	301	11
YARDS PER PLAY	4.5	10
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	89.1	6
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3	8
COMPLETION %	59.2%	31
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	211.9	48
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	22
SACKS	3.2	3
TURNOVERS	1.5	38

NORTH CAROLINA STATE WOLFPACK



In a college football world where the longtime head coaches are riding off into the sunset or can't seem to keep up with how frantic the offseason is nowadays, Dave Doeren is starting his 14th season at NC State. While the ceiling in Raleigh doesn't seem to be very high, the floor certainly is, as the Wolfpack have gone bowling in each of the last six seasons (the 2021 Holiday Bowl was canceled) and all but two seasons under Doeren, one of which was his first year with the program.

However, the Wolfpack haven't won more than nine games since 2002 and, even in a lackluster ACC, haven't really been a College Football Playoff contender. With arguably the softest conference schedule, one missing Miami, Clemson, Pitt, SMU, and Georgia Tech, perhaps this could be the season in which the bar gets raised. There are worse preseason bets than NC State at 22-1 to win the ACC where you can hedge in the title game if they get there and face one of those five teams not on the regular season schedule or have a rematch with Louisville or Virginia. CORRECTION: The opener vs. Virginia IS a conference game.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

The schedule is the primary reason to buy stock in NC State for this season. Avoiding most of the projected top ACC teams is a huge help. The road trip to Stanford is out of a bye week and Cal comes across the country the following week. The non-conference game at Vanderbilt is a tough one, but App State is a winnable non-con game at home. Again, this has been a high-floor program under Doeren and the floor is even higher this season with the friendly schedule, even though my projection is for 7.09 wins.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 7-6 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Dave Doeren - 14th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT VIRGINIA (+4.7)	50.5
9/11	RICHMOND (-37.3)	12.5
9/19	AT VANDERBILT (+6.6)	51.5
9/26	APPALACHIAN ST (-21)	30.0
10/3	LOUISVILLE (+3.2)	53.5
10/10	WAKE FOREST (-3.4)	46.5
10/23	AT STANFORD (-6.7)	39.0
10/31	CALIFORNIA (-4.8)	45.5
11/7	DUKE (-3.1)	46.5
11/14	SYRACUSE (-8.5)	42.0
11/21	AT FLORIDA ST (+5.3)	50.0
11/28	AT NORTH CAROLINA (-1.7)	44.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **42.44**
#63 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.2 / -0.4**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

10

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who are the impact players on offense?

QB CJ Bailey had 31 total touchdowns and threw for over 3,100 yards last season while adding 215 more on the ground, but he's without his five top receivers from last season and leading rusher Hollywood Smothers, who had 5.9 yards per carry. Backup QB Will Wilson is still around, as he was a short-yardage ball carrier with 10 touchdowns, but he only threw five passes, which means Coastal Carolina transfer Tad Hudson is the backup. While nobody had more than 629 receiving yards, four players had 430+ receiving yards and seven players had 37+ receptions. The top returnee is Keenan Jackson, who started 13 games and only had 28 catches for 281 yards. Maybe Buffalo transfer Victor Snow and Miami transfer Joshisa Trader, along with holdover RB Jayden Scott, can stand out instead of last season's by-committee approach.

Who are the impact players on defense?

The obvious follow-up question, but the same concerns with the offense carry over to this side of the ball, too. Leading tackler Caden Fordham had 143 stops with 3.5 sacks and 6.5 tackles for loss. His 3.5 sacks tied for second with Travali Price, who is also gone, and right behind Tra Thomas with four. Guess what? He's gone as well. So is top pass rusher Cian Sloane, who had 16 QB hits, and Sabastian Harsh, who had 13 QB hits. Devon Marshall had 16 pass breakups. He's also gone. So, second-year OC Kurt Roper and second-year DC DJ Eliot have a lot of work to do with a lot of younger players and a ton of transfers.

How can Doeren's team raise the ceiling?

As mentioned, there are a lot of impact players gone on both sides of the ball, but even then, this was a slightly above average offense, a pretty average defense, and a team that lacked explosiveness. The Wolfpack had 20 sacks, which was tied for 107th, and just nine interceptions. They were 128th in third-down defense and 51st in third-down offense. They were second TD% in the red zone, so that was one area where they stood out. Conversely, they gave up over 200 plays of 10+ yards. While that's just a one-year sample size, only the 2021 season was special from a stats standpoint, as the team was +11.4 in PPG and +1.2 in YPP. That team also went just 9-4.

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****12-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****22-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.1	50
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	34
PLAYS PER GAME	66.9	89
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:01	66
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.1%	46
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	374.3	72
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	50
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.3	89
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	139.1	83
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	75
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.6	61
COMPLETION %	67.3%	16
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	235.3	57
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	53
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.6	86
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	53
3RD DOWN CONV. %	47.6%	130
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	430.6	114
YARDS PER PLAY	6.1	118
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	144.8	56
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	83
COMPLETION %	62.8%	75
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	285.8	133
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	105
SACKS	1.5	107
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

NORTH CAROLINA TAR HEELS



On the whole, the Bill Belichick experiment looked like a failure in Year 1. The program's PR department was hard at work thanks to Bill's grad-student-aged girlfriend and the play on the field was about as messy. That said, Belichick has long been known as a defensive genius and the Tar Heels did have their best unit on that side of the ball in quite some time. They only allowed 4.9 yards per play, just 3.5 yards per carry, and just 24.5 PPG, including just 25 PPG to conference opponents.

But, the offense was putrid, a shocking contrast to what we've come to expect UNC football to display. Largely because of the offense, the Tar Heels fell short of bowl eligibility for the first time since 2018 and sent OC Freddie Kitchens packing, bringing in Bobby Petrino for that role. Now that UNC seems to have settled into the Belichick era, are better days ahead?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

The schedule is definitely rough with an overseas opener in Dublin against TCU, a road game at Clemson, Miami, Louisville, and Notre Dame at home, and two September bye weeks. That said, the talent level seems greatly improved. I'll like the Tar Heels more if they go with O'Neill or Burgess at QB over Edwards, but Belichick looks closer to having this whole thing work out. They will need to pull some upsets, though, something they didn't really do last season. My projection is 4.81 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-6-1 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Bill Belichick - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	VS. TCU (+6.4)	51.0
9/12	E TENN ST (-25.8)	20.5
9/19	AT CLEMSON (+11.1)	54.0
10/3	NOTRE DAME (+23.6)	68.5
10/10	AT PITTSBURGH (+9.2)	50.5
10/17	AT DUKE (+5.3)	46.5
10/24	SYRACUSE (-4.2)	42.0
10/31	MIAMI FL (+17.2)	63.0
11/7	AT CONNECTICUT (-9.2)	31.5
11/14	LOUISVILLE (+7.5)	53.5
11/21	AT VIRGINIA (+7.7)	50.5
11/28	NC STATE (+1.7)	48.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.71**
#24 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

4

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Does Billy Edwards start all season long? Or at all?

Edwards committed to Wake Forest in 2020 and enrolled in 2021. Since then, he's been at Maryland, Wisconsin, and now North Carolina, as he only started two games last season and didn't really look the part before suffering a season-ending injury. It was said that Wisconsin paid about \$1 million in total NIL compensation to Edwards. Perhaps UNC got a deal given that he needed a medical waiver to be eligible for this season and did virtually nothing last season. Would UNC be better off with 6-foot-5 Miles O'Neill or 6-foot-4 freshman Travis Burgess? O'Neill was a Petrino recruit to Texas A&M and Burgess is a dual-threat four-star and the No. 9 QB in the class for 247. It sure seems like the Tar Heels should bet on upside and not on Edwards, who was a mediocre starter for the Terps two seasons ago.

Did the Tar Heels prioritize the right players?

The QB position looks to be in flux, but the Tar Heels kept their leading rusher, leading receiver, and leading sack man even though there was a mass exodus to the transfer portal. It sure seems like Belichick and former VSiN personality Michael Lombardi isolated the in-house players they were willing to pay to stay and those they were willing to pay to come to Chapel Hill. RB Demon June only had 464 yards, as the team only ran for 3.7 yards per carry, but he was clearly the best of the backs. WR Jordan Shipp easily paced the team with 60 receptions for 671 yards and June was actually third in receiving yards. Melkart Abou-Jaoude had 10.5 sacks. Kaleb Cost and Jaiden Patterson were also holdovers at defensive back. It's a solid core. Now we'll see how the coaches and recruiting coordinators did to bolster it.

What is the perception of the program?

There was certainly a lot of coverage early about North Carolina football with the hiring of Belichick and all of the off-the-field stuff with his girlfriend and others around the program. From the outside, the optics weren't great. However, the Tar Heels pulled in the 19th-ranked recruiting class of incoming freshmen and over 40 recruits, so whatever the school is selling, some players certainly seem to be buying. Only West Virginia got more class of 2026 commits. We know Belichick can identify talent and the players that fit what he wants to do. A case could be made that there's a lot of hope this season.

ODDS TO WIN...

400-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****65-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****150-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.3	126
YARDS PER POINT	16.6	111
PLAYS PER GAME	61	132
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:59	96
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.6%	98
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	287	129
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	119
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.6	130
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	97.2	126
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	118
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.5	77
COMPLETION %	64.6%	38
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	189.8	100
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	117
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.2	70
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	99
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.7%	95
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	349.4	41
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	30
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	125.7	28
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	24
COMPLETION %	64.0%	91
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	223.6	65
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	38
SACKS	2.5	28
TURNOVERS	0.8	116

PITTSBURGH PANTHERS



The 2025 season for Pitt might as well have been sponsored by nearby Kennywood Amusement Park. It was almost as if the Panthers borrowed a roller coaster and transported it roughly 20 miles up the road to Acrisure Stadium. When the hills, drops, barrel rolls, and inverted loops finished, the Pitt Train rolled into the station with an 8-5 record. In their eight wins, they scored 61, 45, 48, 34, 30, 53, 35, and 42. You never really knew week in and week out which Pitt offense would show up.

We have a pretty good idea this season, as Mason Heintschel officially has the job because Eli Holstein is now with Virginia. Heintschel was solid as a true freshman in his nine starts. He'll have to develop a rapport with a bunch of new receivers, but knowing what Pat Narduzzi is capable of on defense, the Panthers may be able to take advantage of a friendly schedule and put themselves on the CFP radar.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

The schedule is favorable, there's no denying that and why the vig on Over 7.5 is what it is. Pitt avoids Clemson and SMU, plus they do not face Notre Dame this season, but there is a very strong possibility that Virginia Tech is markedly better under James Franklin and that teams like North Carolina and Florida State are much better than what we saw last season. Pitt has a late bye with a lot of new faces and will play five of the last eight games on the road, including a trip to Berkeley, another team that could greatly improve, to finish the regular season. My projection is 7.43 wins.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Pat Narduzzi - 12th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MIAMI OHIO (-17.1)	36.0
9/12	UCF (-10)	44.5
9/17	SYRACUSE (-12.1)	42.0
9/26	BUCKNELL (-49.5)	3.5
10/2	AT VIRGINIA TECH (+3.4)	51.0
10/10	NORTH CAROLINA (-9.2)	44.5
10/17	AT BOSTON COLLEGE (-10.5)	37.5
10/24	AT MIAMI FL (+14.8)	63.0
10/31	GEORGIA TECH (-4.2)	49.0
11/13	FLORIDA ST (-4.2)	50.0
11/21	AT LOUISVILLE (+7.4)	53.5
11/28	AT CALIFORNIA (-2.2)	45.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **42.72**
#62 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.3 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

13

7*

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What should we think about the perplexing Pitt offense?

The Panthers had some big scoring barrages, but this was an offense that was 20th in PPG while sitting just 67th in yards per play and 120th in third-down conversion rate. They allowed 44 sacks, which was the fifth-most in the nation. Collectively, the ball carriers mustered just 3.5 yards per carry. It should be noted here that Pitt had four pick-sixes out of their 15 interceptions, plus a couple of punt return touchdowns. In fact, Pitt special teams played a huge role in their field position, racking up four kick returns of 40+ yards. It was actually a similar story for Pitt in 2024, as they were 30th in scoring offense and 69th in YPP. So, what should we think? I honestly don't know, but their special teams prowess has a lot to do with it.

Will the special teams be special again?

Well, that's another big question because special teams coordinator Jacob Bronowski now holds that position at Auburn. In his place, Pitt hired Mike Priefer, who was fired from the same role at North Carolina last season. The Panthers have a new kicker after Trey Butkowski went 20-of-23 on field goals and 43-of-44 on extra points. Sam Hunsaker was only 15-of-22 on field goals at Northern Arizona with a long of 50, a place where the elevation is up over 7,000 feet. Acrisure Stadium/Heinz Field can be very tough for kickers. Pitt also has a new punter and new kick/punt returners. It is an underrated facet of the game, but one that seemed to help Pitt a lot last season and that may not be the case this season.

Can anybody find the block button?

Some publications and previews are talking up the Pitt offensive line because of their experience. Well, those who have been around the last two years have experience in letting defenders get to the QB. Pitt has allowed 87 sacks over the last two seasons. While Heintschel will have new blind side protection from Penn transfer Netinho Olivieri, a lot of guys are back who contributed to the 44 sacks and the 3.5 YPC that ranked 119th in the nation. Perhaps it does get better in Year 3 of the Kade Bell offense, but it is yet another reason to look at last season's point output with some skepticism.

250-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+850

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

17-1

ACC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.4	20
YARDS PER POINT	12.3	11
PLAYS PER GAME	72.8	24
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:17	91
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.1%	112
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	385	66
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	80
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.8	84
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	113.8	113
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	119
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.5	21
COMPLETION %	62.4%	57
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	271.2	20
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	46
TURNOVERS	1.8	122
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.1	67
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	110
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.5%	18
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.6	32
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	21
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	99.9	11
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.8	3
COMPLETION %	63.1%	81
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	240.7	99
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	63
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	1.8	21

SMU MUSTANGS



It is fair to wonder if this will be the last season in Dallas for Rhett Lashlee. He inherited a decent foundation from Sonny Dykes, but he has taken the Mustangs to a new level, posting two 11-win seasons in 2023 and 2024 and another successful campaign in 2025. While the Mustangs didn't reach the CFP like they did the previous season, they were still lumped into the five-way tie for second place and beat Miami, but the tiebreakers didn't fall in their favor after doing themselves no favors in the loss at Cal to end the regular season.

Lashlee is 38-16 here and senior QB Kevin Jennings will run out of eligibility after this season, barring major injury and a potential waiver, so there's a good chance that suitors will come a-callin' and he'll have some tough decisions to make. For now, he has another premier ACC contender in the Lone Star State.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

While I don't expect Lashlee's team to regress too much, especially with the consistency in their metrics over the last three seasons, we'll find out a lot about them right away with road games against Florida State and Louisville in September. A road trip to South Bend is also on the slate this season. They'll catch Virginia Tech and new HC James Franklin on November 7 with a rest disadvantage. Last year's team was 8-4 in the regular season and beat Arizona in the Holiday Bowl. I could see a similar season this year, though my projection is 8.66 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 6-7 ATS, 4-9 O-U
Head Coach: Rhett Lashlee - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/7	AT FLORIDA ST (-2.7)	50.0
9/12	CAL DAVIS (-31.4)	28.0
9/19	AT LOUISVILLE (+1.7)	53.5
9/26	MISSOURI ST (-34.4)	25.0
10/3	BOSTON COLLEGE (-22.6)	37.5
10/17	VIRGINIA (-8.5)	50.5
10/24	CALIFORNIA (-14.1)	45.5
10/31	AT SYRACUSE (-11.2)	42.0
11/6	VIRGINIA TECH (-8.7)	51.0
11/14	WAKE FOREST (-12.7)	46.5
11/21	AT NOTRE DAME (+16.7)	68.5
11/28	AT STANFORD (-14.7)	39.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.62**
#56 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **4 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Has SMU done enough to reload on offense?

Jennings posted a 26/13 TD/INT ratio last season and did virtually nothing as a runner, which was the biggest difference from 2024 to 2025. Jennings wasn't a prolific runner by any means, but he had 300 more rushing yards in '24 compared to '25. As a guy with double-digit interceptions in each of the last two seasons, offsetting those with production in other ways is important. But, he heads into this season without his two top receivers in yardage from last season and four of the top five, plus leading rushers TJ Harden and Chris Johnson both moved on. SMU went portal shopping for RB Kendrick Raphael, who is at his third ACC school now, and some help at WR and TE. Lashlee is his own OC, but did lose right-hand man Casey Woods to the HC job at Missouri State. As a reminder of how old we're all getting, D'Eriq King is one of the co-OCs.

Is the defense the bigger worry?

The Mustangs have surpassed six yards per play on offense in each of Lashlee's four seasons at the helm and last year's 32.2 PPG were the lowest in that span. But, the defense has been the separator from Lashlee's first year record of 7-6 to the 31-10 over the last three seasons. Last year's unit was 0.5 YPP worse than the previous one, but allowed 1.6 fewer PPG. Over the last three seasons, SMU has racked up 125 sacks, and last season, even with Jennings' interception issue, the Mustangs were +9 in TO margin with 28 takeaways. Former DC Scott Symons is still in Dallas, but now with the Cowboys. Lashlee kept it in-house and promoted from within, but five of the top seven tackles are gone, including leading sack man Isaiah Smith. Per 247Sports, SMU brought in the sixth-ranked transfer portal class in the 17-team ACC with a lot of needs at impact positions on both sides of the ball.

Let's talk more about sacks, shall we?

Some handicappers I respect greatly look at sack differential as a major tenet of their handicapping. SMU was +16 last season, a decrease from +25 the season prior and +31 the year before that. While Jennings has had some issues taking care of the football, this is a pass-first offense and he has only been sacked 33 times on well over 800 dropbacks. While he's not an explosive runner, he has 171 carries over the past two seasons that have turned potential negative plays into slightly positive or at least not completely detrimental plays. On the other side, it will be interesting to see if new DC Maurice Crum and holdover co-DC Ricky Hunley Jr. can keep up the pressure on defense, considering all four Mustangs with at least five sacks have moved on.

ODDS TO WIN...

100-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+350****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+700****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.4	20
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	32
PLAYS PER GAME	67.9	71
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:22	125
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.9%	50
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	418.3	24
YARDS PER PLAY	6.2	23
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.7	120
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	133.3	89
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	57
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.8	19
COMPLETION %	65.8%	25
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	285	10
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	33
TURNOVERS	1.3	78
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.2	31
YARDS PER POINT	18.8	6
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.7%	41
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	398.8	83
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	38
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	112.4	18
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.2	14
COMPLETION %	62.3%	68
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	286.4	134
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	66
SACKS	2.8	18
TURNOVERS	2.1	5

STANFORD CARDINAL



Armed with a \$50 million donation to the NIL collective, Stanford will go into the season with Davis Warren at QB and a first-time head coach. Time will tell if Andrew Luck will get this program going in the right direction, as the Cardinal haven't won more than four games since 2018. But, the roster looks underwhelming again this season and Tavita Pritchard will have his hands full with a whole lot of travel and a first-time offensive coordinator - er, excuse me, "Andrew Luck Director of Offense".

Life in the ACC is not easy and Stanford will play roadies at Duke, Wake Forest, Louisville, and Virginia Tech, as well as a road trip to South Bend in mid-October to take on Notre Dame. With high academic requirements, the portal isn't as much of a shopping spree for Stanford as it is for other schools and that looks like it will hold the program back once again.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

Last year's team was pretty awful in a lot of ways and still got to four wins, even after starting 0-2. But, the schedule is very worrisome, especially with all the travel, plus Stanford faces NC State and Louisville with both of those teams off of their byes. In their four wins last season, Stanford was +10, -43, -151, and -15 in yardage differential, so they got fortunate to win the games that they did. Realistically, the product on the field will probably look better, but that doesn't mean it will translate into victories. My projection is 3.65 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Tavita Pritchard - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	HAWAII (-3.1)	38.5
9/4	MIAMI FL (+22.2)	63.0
9/19	AT DUKE (+11.5)	46.5
9/26	GEORGIA TECH (+8.7)	49.0
10/3	AT WAKE FOREST (+10.1)	46.5
10/10	AT NOTRE DAME (+33.9)	68.5
10/17	ELON (-21.6)	19.0
10/23	NC STATE (+6.7)	48.0
10/31	AT LOUISVILLE (+18.9)	53.5
11/14	AT VIRGINIA TECH (+14.9)	51.0
11/21	AT CALIFORNIA (+9.3)	45.5
11/28	SMU (+14.7)	55.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.52**
#15 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

7

DEFENSE

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Stanford finally protect the football?

The Cardinal only played six games during the 2020 COVID season and were +2 in turnover margin. Since then, they are -33 over the last five seasons combined. Ben Gulbranson, who got the bulk of the passing reps, had more interceptions (10) than touchdowns (9) and the team collectively posted a 14/12 TD/INT ratio. Warren, who missed last season with a torn ACL, had a 7/9 TD/INT ratio at Michigan. UCF transfer Dylan Rizk could be an option or true freshman Mike Mitchell, who originally committed to Vanderbilt, may get some looks. If nothing else with Pritchard, he's been working with Jayden Daniels over the last couple of seasons and had five seasons as the Commanders OC, so he may find success with one of the QBs.

Will there be more protection in Palo Alto?

First-time OC Terry Heffernan has spent a lot of time as an offensive line coach in his career and that can only be a good thing for this team. Over the last five seasons, along with turning the ball over too much and not forcing enough turnovers, the Cardinal have allowed 31, 41, 41, 39, and 41 sacks, while only getting 15, 23, 23, 26, and 23 of their own. Whether it is Warren, Rizk, or Mitchell, all three are more mobile than their predecessors, so that should also help the cause. The sack differential isn't the only reason why Stanford has struggled, but being -83 over the last five seasons sure isn't helping.

Can Kris Richard fix the defense?

The offensive shortcomings of the program have certainly been on display, but this defense has really taken a turn for the worst as well. Last year's defense was the first since 2019 to allow fewer than 30 PPG, not that 29.2 PPG is that much better. It was also the first defense to allow under 6.0 YPP since 2018. Richard, the longtime NFL DC and DB coach, has been named the "David Shaw Director of Defense" and this will be his first time at the collegiate level since he was a grad assistant at USC in 2008-09. Fortunately, Stanford has a lot of smart kids, so they should be able to grasp a complex NFL-caliber scheme. There aren't many returnees on defense, but one of them is Matt Rose, who had nearly twice as many tackles as any other player.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****300-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****400-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.8	117
YARDS PER POINT	16.3	106
PLAYS PER GAME	68.7	65
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:49	73
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.7%	84
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	306.5	124
YARDS PER PLAY	4.5	127
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.7	98
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	84.5	132
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.6	133
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.6	49
COMPLETION %	57.3%	113
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222	70
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	83
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.2	87
YARDS PER POINT	14	81
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.1%	91
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	408.2	92
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	91
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	119.3	24
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	32
COMPLETION %	66.1%	113
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	288.9	135
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	103
SACKS	1.9	69
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

SYRACUSE ORANGE



There may not have been a more impactful injury for a team than the loss of Steve Angeli for Syracuse. The Orange were off to a 3-1 start and beat Clemson as a 17-point underdog, but the Notre Dame transfer was lost for the season and the bottom completely fell out. Angeli posted a 10/2 TD/INT ratio and was thriving in OC Jeff Nixon's system, but then the others who took over posted a 7/13 TD/INT ratio and the Orange lost eight straight games by 35, 13, 17, 25, 17, 28, 63, and 22 points.

Going from a stunning 10-3 record in 2024, as Fran Brown brought in a spectacular transfer portal class, to 3-9 was one of the biggest declines in the nation. That will happen with a -13 TO margin and a -17 sack margin. Also, Syracuse was a regression candidate after going 10-3 with just a +4.9 PPG differential the season prior, including two overtime wins. It seems very, very likely that the 2026 season falls somewhere in the middle.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5
The schedule is the main thing to hold against the Orange. They open with New Hampshire and Cal and then play their first road game at Pitt on a short week. The early bye followed by nine straight games is not easy, but the Orange do avoid any long road trips. In fact, all six road games are in the Eastern Time Zone and their toughest games on paper - Louisville, SMU, Clemson, Notre Dame - are at home. Even though they'll be an underdog a lot, this might be one of my favorite win total bets in the ACC, despite my projection of just 4.68 wins.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 4-7-1 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Fran Brown - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	NEW HAMPSHIRE (-24)	19.5
9/12	CALIFORNIA (+1)	45.5
9/17	AT PITTSBURGH (+12.1)	50.5
10/3	AT CONNECTICUT (-6.3)	31.5
10/10	AT VIRGINIA (+10.6)	50.5
10/17	LOUISVILLE (+9)	53.5
10/24	AT NORTH CAROLINA (+4.2)	44.5
10/31	SMU (+11.2)	55.5
11/7	CLEMSON (+9.7)	54.0
11/14	AT NC STATE (+8.5)	48.0
11/21	AT BOSTON COLLEGE (-2.3)	37.5
11/28	NOTRE DAME (+25.1)	68.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 46.90
#32 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.4 / -0.3
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

4*

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the real Steve Angeli please stand up?

Angeli only threw 80 passes at Notre Dame, though he did have a 10/1 TD/INT ratio with a 72.5% completion rate. He was a real spark plug for the Orange offense with over 1,300 yards in his four starts before the injury robbed him, and potentially Syracuse, of what looked to be a special season. Maybe Angeli, who was a three-star incoming freshman per 247Sports in 2022, and a three-star transfer per the same outlet in 2025, was simply going to thrive with his first real shot at starting. If the clock strikes midnight and he turns into a pumpkin, Amari Odom started at Kennesaw State and Malachi Nelson is on his fourth team after being one of the top recruits in his class several years ago. Angeli does have a brand-new crop of WRs, as the top returnee caught eight passes last season.

Does the defense set the ceiling for the season?

Let's assume that Angeli comes back fine, develops a rapport with his new wideouts, and the offense is humming. Angeli's absence and a lot of carelessness with the football really hurt the defense, as they allowed 34.9 PPG and 6.5 YPP. Even when the Orange went 1-10 during the 2020 COVID season, they only allowed 32.7 PPG. Over the final eight games, the Orange allowed 30+ points seven times and also allowed Notre Dame to drop 70 on them. The hire of Vince Kehres may be one of the best DC hires of this coaching cycle. The former Mount Union head coach went 95-6 at the D-III level with two National Championships before spending the last six seasons as Toledo's DC. In that span, the Rockets allowed between 13.3 PPG (last season) and 25.1 PPG, while allowing over 5.0 YPP just once.

Are too many people sleeping on Syracuse?

Angeli back. Kehres hired. Brown also went to the MAC and grabbed special teams coordinator Alex Bayer from Bowling Green. Per Phil Steele's special teams rankings, Syracuse has been 131st and 100th in the Brown era, though Bill Connelly's SP+ rankings had Syracuse 35th, so that is a massive discrepancy between the two. In any event, the Orange were 83rd in kick return average and 106th in punt return average. Better field position with a healthy offense and an improved defense means that Syracuse could truly be better in all three facets of the game.

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****300-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****150-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	16	128
YARDS PER POINT	19.7	128
PLAYS PER GAME	73.4	15
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:48	40
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.7%	115
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	314.7	120
YARDS PER PLAY	4.3	130
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.4	53
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	118.5	105
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	125
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.8	39
COMPLETION %	55.1%	124
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	196.3	95
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.8	128
TURNOVERS	1.9	125
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.9	129
YARDS PER POINT	12	129
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.0%	69
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	430.7	115
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	129
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	182.3	102
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	132
COMPLETION %	68.0%	130
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	248.5	113
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	113
SACKS	1.5	104
TURNOVERS	0.6	129

VIRGINIA CAVALIERS



After three underwhelming seasons in Charlottesville, Tony Elliott struck gold last season. Investment into the offensive line paid tremendous dividends, as the Cavaliers went from 47 sacks down to 18 and from 3.7 yards per carry up to 4.6. With those improvements, the offense jumped up 8.1 PPG and the defense improved by 9.2 PPG, all leading to an 11-3 season and a spot in the ACC Championship Game as the conference's only team to go 7-1 in league play.

But, the obvious, burning question is whether or not that was a one-year flash in the pan or something more. Elliott won 11 games combined in his first three seasons at the helm. Even though the OL remains mostly intact and provides a really good foundation for the offense, virtually everybody else on that side of the ball is new and that is the major area of concern going into the 2026 season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

This isn't a bet for me, but just a pick for the Guide. The truth is that it depends on what you think about teams like North Carolina, Virginia Tech, Syracuse, and Florida State because the Cavaliers avoid Clemson and Miami yet again. They do play at SMU and play West Virginia in Charlotte, so the schedule is harder overall. While 8-4 is the most likely outcome, that feels closer to the ceiling for this team with the harder schedule and some regression signs, even though my projection is 7.79 wins.

2025 Record: 11-3 SU & 9-5 ATS, 5-9 O-U
Head Coach: Tony Elliott - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	NC STATE (-4.7)	48.0
9/11	NORFOLK ST (-55.5)	-3.5
9/19	VS. WEST VIRGINIA (-6.2)	45.0
9/26	DELAWARE (-21.4)	31.0
10/3	AT FLORIDA ST (+1.9)	50.0
10/10	SYRACUSE (-10.6)	42.0
10/17	AT SMU (+8.5)	55.5
10/23	DUKE (-5.2)	46.5
10/31	AT WAKE FOREST (-2.5)	46.5
11/14	CALIFORNIA (-6.9)	45.5
11/21	NORTH CAROLINA (-7.7)	44.5
11/28	AT VIRGINIA TECH (+2.3)	51.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **41.50**
#68 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.8 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is the offense sustainable?

Simple question. Complex answer. Even in UVA's three losses last season, they were +98, +124, and +11 yards, only getting outgained three times, which, ironically, all came in wins. But, the losses are really heavy at the skill positions. Veteran QB Chandler Morris is gone after throwing for 3,000 yards and a 16/9 TD/INT ratio. More importantly, J'Mari Taylor is gone after rushing for over 1,000 yards with 14 TDs. He was also fourth in receptions and receiving yards. Everybody who finished ahead of him is also gone. So, this will be a brand new offense in that regard with Penn State/Missouri transfer Beau Pribula and also Pitt transfer Eli Holstein at QB. 247Sports has Virginia with the eighth-ranked transfer class in the ACC, which includes those two, plus RB Peyton Lewis and WR Da'Shawn Martin.

Is the defense sustainable?

The obvious follow-up question. In the other seasons under Elliott, the defense allowed 24.0, 33.8, and 28.8 points before last season's 19.6 PPG. Four of the top six tacklers are back and Virginia's portal haul on defense seems more proven than their portal haul on offense. Last season's uptick came under second-year DC John Rudzinski, so maybe it was just a matter of players knowing the scheme and thriving within it. Top pass rushers Daniel Rickert and Mitchell Melton are both gone, along with leading tackler Devin Neal. It's entirely possible that Rudzinski's third year will live up to last season, but it seems unlikely. UVA had 31 sacks last season after racking up 30 over the previous two seasons combined.

"Cluster Luck" or scheme?

I was first introduced to the term "Cluster Luck" in Joe Peta's book, Trading Bases. Essentially, the root of the concept is that performance with runners in scoring position, both offensively and defensively, dictates a large chunk of what happens during the season. Because performance with RISP is volatile from season to season, it isn't really a stat to rely on for projecting future results. To bring it back to Virginia football, the Cavaliers were 11th in third-down conversion rate on offense and second on defense. UVA had nearly twice as many offensive third-down conversions than their opponents and 35 more in conference games. The Cavaliers ran 163 more plays than their opponents. Will they achieve something similar this season?

ODDS TO WIN...

200-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+950****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****16-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.9	41
YARDS PER POINT	13.7	48
PLAYS PER GAME	74.6	10
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:51	24
3RD DOWN CONV. %	49.3%	8
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	396.3	47
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	79
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.1	40
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	163.5	55
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	64
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.2	25
COMPLETION %	63.9%	43
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232.8	61
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	96
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.8	18
YARDS PER POINT	15.8	32
3RD DOWN CONV. %	28.9%	2
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	313.8	17
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	20
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	118.9	23
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	20
COMPLETION %	60.0%	37
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	194.9	24
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	29
SACKS	2.1	60
TURNOVERS	1.6	32

VIRGINIA TECH HOKIES



This won't be the best team in the ACC, but could very well be the most compelling. James Franklin gets a fresh start in Blacksburg and the program is in the midst of a badly needed refresh. Of course, the likeliest scenario given what we saw Franklin do for years at Penn State is that the Hokies go 9-3 while losing to Clemson, SMU, and Miami. Kidding aside, that would be a huge year for Virginia Tech as they try to get back to the standards that they had under Frank Beamer and for a little bit under Justin Fuente.

Those three aforementioned games are all on the road, so that does limit the ceiling for the Hokies in Year 1, but the schedule is set up to get the hype machine moving quickly. Franklin's hiring should add just a little more juice to the Enter Sandman entrance at Lane Stadium and elevate the talent level of the program in a hurry.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5
The juice is somewhat pricey here, but the Hokies getting off to a 5-0 start prior to a trip out west to Cal is very much on the table. The latter portion of the schedule is where things really ramp up, but that may also be about the time Franklin finds a groove with his team. The talent pipeline in the DMV and the old stomping grounds for Franklin in Pennsylvania should really elevate the baseline for this team in short order, probably as soon as this season. The thing about Franklin is that he doesn't often lose games he should win, something that trips up nearly every other ACC program. My projection is 7.1 wins.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: James Franklin - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	VMI (-63.1)	-9.0
9/12	OLD DOMINION (-15.7)	37.0
9/19	AT MARYLAND (-3.2)	45.5
9/26	AT BOSTON COLLEGE (-11.4)	37.5
10/2	PITTSBURGH (-3.4)	50.5
10/10	AT CALIFORNIA (-3.1)	45.5
10/17	GEORGIA TECH (-3.7)	49.0
10/24	AT CLEMSON (+4.9)	54.0
11/6	AT SMU (+8.7)	55.5
11/14	STANFORD (-14.9)	39.0
11/21	AT MIAMI FL (+13.9)	63.0
11/28	VIRGINIA (-2.3)	50.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.23**
#60 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

17

9

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How talented are the Hokies?

Per 247Sports, VT brought in the fourth-ranked transfer portal class in the conference, which is a list that includes Penn State QB Ethan Grunkemeyer, UNC QB Bryce Baker, WR Que'Sean Brown. The 5-foot-8 Brown had over 1,200 yards at Duke. Grunkemeyer wound up starting seven games for the Nittany Lions last season and has some chemistry with new TE Luke Reynolds. Marcellous Hawkins had over six yards per carry and should be featured more prominently without a running threat like Kyron Drones at QB. The offense only mustered 21.4 PPG, but had 4.9 YPC, even with Drones bringing the average down, so Franklin was able to focus on the skill spots instead of rebuilding the OL.

Can you quantify continuity?

Probably not directly, but Franklin likely gained some trust from the players and respect from the athletic department by keeping Brent Pry within the program as the DC. Franklin and Pry do go way back, so it was just a perfect-storm situation, but one that should ease the transition of leadership. The defense didn't experience a mass exodus, as four of the top six tacklers returned and a lot of guys who played in some capacity last season. With Pry able to focus more on the defense, he brought in Jaquez White from Troy to fill a need at corner. Also, several Penn State players followed Franklin. The defense was uncharacteristically bad last season with over 30 PPG allowed, but improvement seems imminent.

Is Virginia Tech this year's Virginia?

The Cavaliers won 11 games over three seasons before going 11-3 last season with an appearance in the ACC Title Game. It's entirely possible, as the Hokies hit the portal for passers and the talent level has been elevated with virtually each position group. The biggest difference between VT and UVA is that the Cavaliers didn't have to play SMU, Clemson, or Miami and the Hokies do. The Commonwealth Clash at the end of the season could be a really intriguing game if Franklin can flip the script from his Penn State days of losing to Ohio State and Michigan as the class of the conference.

ODDS TO WIN...

180-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****16-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****28-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.9	113
YARDS PER POINT	17	117
PLAYS PER GAME	65.7	107
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:44	103
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.3%	78
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	338.5	100
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	89
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.2	45
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	185	30
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	25
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26	114
COMPLETION %	53.5%	132
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	153.5	125
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.9	126
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.4	113
YARDS PER POINT	12.4	123
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.3%	125
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	399.9	84
YARDS PER PLAY	6	108
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	167.5	85
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	88
COMPLETION %	67.9%	129
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232.4	83
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	109
SACKS	1.4	112
TURNOVERS	0.5	135

WAKE FOREST

DEMON DEACONS



One of the more surprising performances from a first-year head coach came out of Winston-Salem, where Jake Dickert led the Demon Deacons to a 9-4 record. The hire was met with mixed feelings when Dave Clawson amicably parted ways with the program, but Dickert came over from Washington State and immediately had success. Sustaining that success will be a chore, though.

There are a ton of new faces here, even though Wake Forest has been doing some pretty good fundraising of late for their NIL budget. The offense is basically brand new aside from leading receiver Carlos Hernandez. The defense has a fair number of holdovers and DC Scottie Hazelton did an outstanding job with that group last season. With a much more difficult schedule, we'll see how Dickert does in Year 2.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

I think Dickert is a good coach and I thought that at Washington State, too, but there are a lot of red flags blowing violently in the breeze with this team coming off of last season. Obviously that's been accounted for in the market number here, but the road schedule is tough, plus Miami and then the two (for better or worse) ACC Championship Game teams in Virginia and Duke at home. Even the non-conference roadie at Purdue could be a tricky one. With one of the worst portal hauls in the conference and a lot of lost production on offense, a downturn should be expected, even though my projection is 6.01 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Jake Dickert - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AKRON (-23.8)	25.0
9/12	AT PURDUE (-6.3)	39.0
9/18	MIAMI FL (+14.6)	63.0
9/26	AT LOUISVILLE (+10.5)	53.5
10/3	STANFORD (-10.1)	39.0
10/10	AT NC STATE (+3.4)	48.0
10/17	AT CALIFORNIA (+0.9)	45.5
10/31	VIRGINIA (+2.5)	50.5
11/7	MERRIMACK (-44)	4.0
11/14	AT SMU (+12.7)	55.5
11/21	AT GEORGIA TECH (+4.6)	49.0
11/28	DUKE (-1.4)	46.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.47**
 #57 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2 / 0.3**
 (HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

2

DEFENSE

9

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Should Wake Forest have aimed higher at QB?

Robby Ashford and Deshawn Purdie gave the Demon Deacons probably more than they were expecting with an 18/11 TD/INT ratio and Ashford's nine rushing scores with 554 yards. There was no clear-cut No. 1 for a while, as Ashford, who was originally at Auburn and then South Carolina, eventually settled in as the starter. Because of his mobility, Wake Forest only allowed 17 sacks after surrendering 91 over the two previous seasons and at least 35 in each of the last four seasons. Southpaw slinger Gio Lopez isn't that same type of player and this is a rebuilt offensive line. Lopez only had a 10/5 TD/INT ratio at nearby North Carolina and seems like a very underwhelming addition for co-OCs Rob Ezell and Dan Enos.

Can the defense orchestrate a repeat performance?

Hazelton's unit was truly stellar. The Demon Deacons shaved off over 10 PPG and 1.4 YPP year over year with the new coaching staff. In fact, Wake Forest was ninth in YPP nationally and had a top-10 red zone defense. Leading tackler Nick Anderson is gone, but top pass rusher Langston Hardy is back after he had seven sacks and 10 tackles for loss. Safety Davaughn Patterson couldn't declare for the NFL Draft, but he'll be in it this upcoming April. The strength of the returnees on defense, coupled with some plug-and-play transfers, brings me back to the first question. It doesn't seem like Wake Forest had to shell out a lot to keep the defense intact, so why not shoot higher on offense?

Have you seen the Regression Monster?

If you haven't, you're about to. Wake Forest beat Virginia Tech, SMU, and Virginia in underdog roles last season. The defense was spectacular in the red zone, but they seemed to bend a lot up until that point, as the Deacs were tied for 119th in red zone attempts against, but tied for 57th in red zone TDs allowed and finished 10th in red zone TD%. Similarly, the offense was tied for 86th in red zone attempts and tied for 104th in red zone TDs. They tied with Texas State for the most plays of 60+ yards with 11 and tied for second in plays of 50+ yards with 15. I strongly question their ability to keep up those types of situational numbers.

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****40-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****74-1****ACC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.9	63
YARDS PER POINT	14.2	56
PLAYS PER GAME	68.3	67
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:29	82
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.0%	62
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	381.5	71
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	53
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.3	65
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	146.4	73
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	80
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.7	60
COMPLETION %	56.8%	119
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	235.1	58
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	55
TURNOVERS	1.5	94
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.1	44
YARDS PER POINT	14.6	64
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.7%	41
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	336.3	26
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	12
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	129.1	31
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	23
COMPLETION %	58.9%	28
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	207.2	39
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	7
SACKS	2.1	58
TURNOVERS	1.1	89



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BIG 12

Preview

previews by Zach Cohen

Texas Tech stole the headlines in the Big 12 last season, winning the league and grabbing an automatic College Football Playoff berth. The Red Raiders did flame out in the postseason, losing 23-0 to Oregon in the quarterfinals. However, Joey McGuire's program officially made its presence felt on the national stage. We also saw a tremendous season out of conference runner-up BYU, we witnessed Utah and Houston win double-digit games, and the depth of the league was impressive with nine teams finishing with winning records.

Heading into the 2026 season, the Red Raiders are once again expected to finish on top. However, Texas Tech will have to do it without Brendan Sorsby, who was supposed to take the passing game to another level before a gambling scandal derailed everything. The Red Raiders will now need to fight off some much-improved teams without an elite signal-caller.

Texas Tech is an odds-on favorite to win the Big 12 Conference Championship, but BYU and Utah aren't too far back on the oddsboard. Kansas State, Houston, and Arizona are also shorter than 20-1 at DraftKings Sportsbook, and it'd be foolish to rule out 2024 conference champion Arizona State.

This simply should be a fascinating year in what has become one of the most interesting leagues in college football.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
TEXAS TECH	10.5	61.5	3.9	0	41.18 (69)	10.7	1.3	7.7	1.3
BYU	8.5	57.5	3.2	0.5	44.1 (49)	9.0	3.0	6.8	2.2
UTAH	8.5	54.5	4	0.2	43.39 (58)	8.9	3.1	6.1	2.9
KANSAS ST	7.5	51	3.8	0	42.21 (65)	8.2	3.8	5.5	3.5
HOUSTON	8.5	53	1.6	0.2	41.96 (66)	8.2	3.8	5.4	3.6
ARIZONA	7.5	52.5	2.7	0.5	44.57 (46)	7.8	4.2	5.0	4.0
TCU	6.5	51	3.5	0	43.79 (55)	7.3	4.7	4.7	4.3
ARIZONA ST	6.5	49.5	2	0.5	46.13 (35)	6.4	5.6	4.5	4.5
OKLAHOMA ST	5.5	46.5	2	-0.8	45.6 (41)	5.7	6.3	3.9	5.1
BAYLOR	6.5	47	1.6	0.1	45.99 (37)	5.9	6.1	3.7	5.3
UCF	5.5	44.5	3.2	-0.7	42.24 (64)	5.8	6.2	3.6	5.4
KANSAS	5.5	46	3.2	-0.1	43.92 (52)	5.7	6.3	3.4	5.6
WEST VIRGINIA	5.5	45	2.8	-0.2	44.94 (44)	5.6	6.4	3.4	5.6
COLORADO	4.5	43	2.7	-0.6	46.67 (33)	4.4	7.6	2.8	6.2
IOWA ST	5.5	41.5	2.7	0.3	43.93 (51)	4.8	7.2	2.8	6.2
CINCINNATI	5.5	44.5	1.9	-0.3	46.47 (34)	5.3	6.7	2.8	6.2

ARIZONA WILDCATS



Brent Brennan was put in a rough spot when he was hired by the Wildcats. After a wildly successful run at San Jose State, he was tasked with filling Jedd Fisch's massive shoes in Tucson. Fisch completely turned this program around, then he understandably bolted for a good Big Ten job. Unfortunately, all of that led to a late start for Brennan, who didn't have time to get things right. Arizona then stumbled to a 4-8 season in 2024, putting Brennan on the hot seat to start 2025.

Brennan responded to all of that with a fantastic 2025 season, with the Wildcats going 9-4 and being a couple very close losses away from achieving much bigger things. His coaching staff changes were a home run, he did great work in the transfer portal, and he seems to have a good pulse on recruiting. Brennan is now in good standing with the university, and expectations are somewhat high with star quarterback Noah Fifita returning with 13 other starters. What does 2026 have in store?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
The Wildcats will be getting points against the Cougars and Red Raiders, and they play six other games that I'd consider coin-flip contests. So, while this Arizona team has the potential to be just as good as last year's squad, it feels unrealistic to expect eight wins. It's also worth noting that the Wildcats had a +18 turnover margin last year, meaning some regression is likely coming there. Brennan is doing good work with this program, but a slight dip could be coming.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 8-5 ATS, 4-9 O-U
Head Coach: Brent Brennan - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	N ARIZONA (-32.8)	22.0
9/12	AT BYU (+7.7)	57.5
9/19	N ILLINOIS (-33.2)	21.5
9/26	AT WASHINGTON ST (-11.6)	38.0
10/3	CINCINNATI (-11)	44.5
10/10	AT WEST VIRGINIA (-5.2)	45.0
10/24	IOWA ST (-13.4)	41.5
	AT TEXAS TECH (+12.4)	61.5
11/6	TCU (-4.2)	51.0
11/14	UTAH (-0.5)	54.5
11/21	AT KANSAS ST (+1.8)	51.0
11/28	ARIZONA ST (-5.2)	49.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 44.57
#46 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.7 / 0.5
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

4*

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What type of year can be expected from Noah Fifita?

Last year, Fifita threw for 3,228 yards with 29 touchdowns and six interceptions, and he also happened to finish the 2025 season as PFF’s 17th-ranked passer. It was a major bounceback campaign after a down 2024 season, and he’s now considered one of the top returning signal-callers in football heading into 2026. Fifita has a solid group of weapons, a decent running game, and an established rapport with returning offensive coordinator Seth Doege. All of that should amount to a solid season, right? We’ll see. It’s hard to completely ignore that 2024 season, Arizona has to replace three starters along the offensive line, and Fifita does occasionally run into trouble with injuries. The hope will be that Fifita can replicate his 2025 success — and possibly even build on it. But that’s also what fans in Tucson were hoping for in 2024.

Can the Arizona passing defense survive key losses in the secondary?

Arizona finished tied for seventh in Game on Paper’s Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.14) last year, and a third-ranked EPA/Dropback Allowed (-0.24) played a big role in that. DC Danny Gonzales did an awesome job with his defensive backs last season, but he’ll need to do an even better job in 2026. Arizona lost four defensive backs to the NFL, with one of them being second-round pick and All-Big 12 corner Treydan Stukes and another being All-Big 12 safety Dalton Johnson. Brennan and Gonzales did hit the portal hard, bringing in several players with the potential to be instant-impact starters. However, last year’s Wildcats defense was special because of its ability to slow down some of the conference’s most explosive passing games. Any substantial dropoff in the secondary will hurt.

Is the schedule simply too tough for the Wildcats?

Arizona will play road games against BYU, Texas Tech, Kansas State, and West Virginia. The first two teams are expected to finish near the top of the Big 12, while K-State’s win total of 7.5 suggests it’s right on par with U of A and would likely be favored in Manhattan. Also, West Virginia has historically been a tough place to play when the team is good, and the Mountaineers are expected to be much better in 2026. The Wildcats also happen to host Utah, TCU, Cincinnati, and Arizona State. Finishing above .500 in conference play will be a challenge.

250-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

10-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

19-1

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.2	28
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	27
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	31
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:48	41
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.5%	54
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	395.3	49
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	68
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.3	63
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	152.6	64
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	60
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.9	27
COMPLETION %	62.3%	60
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	242.7	49
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	77
TURNOVERS	1.1	38
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.7	24
YARDS PER POINT	15.4	39
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.5%	36
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	318.9	20
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	14
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	145.5	57
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	45
COMPLETION %	54.9%	9
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	173.4	7
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.8	6
SACKS	1.6	101
TURNOVERS	2.4	1

ARIZONA STATE SUN DEVILS



How much have the expectations changed in Tempe? Well, last year's 8-5 season felt like a massive disappointment, which is outrageous given this team went 3-9 in 2023. That's because Kenny Dillingham took ASU to the College Football Playoff in 2024, which was Year 2 with him leading the program.

Arizona State now heads into 2026 looking to build on last year, but doing so would mean thriving without Sam Leavitt under center. The 2024 Big 12 Offensive Freshman of the Year and second-team All-Big 12 performer is off to play for Lane Kiffin and LSU. Last year's team had to deal with the loss of Cam Skattebo, and this year's team won't have Leavitt. That's two core pieces of that special 2024 team.

In addition to dealing with a good bit of roster turnover, the Sun Devils also have to navigate a tough schedule. That means the odds are stacked against Dillingham, but he has been there before.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5
Arizona State likely isn't heading back to the College Football Playoff in the near future, but this program isn't going anywhere either. Dillingham continues to do a good job of reloading his rosters, and it just doesn't feel right seeing the Sun Devils with a win total of 6.5. Arizona State undoubtedly has a difficult schedule, but the following games are more than winnable: vs. Morgan State, vs. Kansas, vs. Baylor, vs. Hawaii, vs. Kansas State, vs. Colorado, at UCF, vs. Oklahoma State, at Arizona. That's enough for a play on the Over, and the Sun Devils might even be live to hit some alternate Overs.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 6-6-1 ATS, 5-8 O-U
Head Coach: Kenny Dillingham - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MORGAN ST (-46.8)	4.5
9/12	AT TEXAS A&M (+14.9)	62.5
9/19	VS. KANSAS (-4.1)	46.0
10/3	BAYLOR (-4.4)	47.0
10/10	HAWAII (-13.7)	38.5
10/17	AT TEXAS TECH (+15.4)	61.5
10/24	KANSAS ST (-0.5)	51.0
10/31	AT BYU (+10.7)	57.5
11/7	COLORADO (-9.1)	43.0
11/14	AT UCF (-2.3)	44.5
11/21	OKLAHOMA ST (-5.8)	46.5
11/28	AT ARIZONA (+5.2)	52.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.13**
#35 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

17

8

9

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How good can Cutter Boley be?

Boley had an up-and-down year as Kentucky’s starter last season, throwing for 2,160 yards with 15 touchdowns and 12 interceptions. However, he largely had an unreliable supporting cast, and he wasn’t working with anyone with Dillingham’s reputation. Boley might take some time to get comfortable in his new surroundings, but he’s a 6-foot-5 quarterback with a big arm and above-average athleticism. Dillingham once tried to get Boley to Oregon, so he clearly believes in his ability. While there might be question marks about the offense heading into the season, something tells me this group will exceed expectations. Boley has all the tools to be a high-level starter, the offensive line looks to be improved, and the Sun Devils have weapons at wideout — including intriguing Boston College transfer Reed Harris.

Is Marcus Arroyo the right guy to be calling the shots for a Dillingham-led team?

Dillingham mostly called plays for Arizona State in 2024, when the team averaged 6.1 yards per play. Last year, with play-calling responsibilities being passed to Arroyo, that number dropped to 5.6. In fairness, Leavitt playing only five games hurt, and the Sun Devils didn’t do a great job of accounting for the loss of Skattebo in the backfield. But Arizona State has one of the brightest offensive minds in college football on the sidelines. As long as Dillingham is there, fans will wonder why he’s not calling plays. That’s especially true fresh off a year in which the Sun Devils were just 49th in Adjusted EPA/Play (0.01).

Will Brian Ward get enough out of his defensive backs?

Arizona State added some big-time transfers when looking at the defensive linemen and linebackers who were brought in — with Colorado State’s Owen Long being one who could immediately turn heads on a bigger stage. However, the Sun Devils desperately need things to click in the secondary, where they were 49th in Dropback EPA/Play (-0.03) last year. LSU transfer Ashton Stamps was a good addition at corner, and ASU looks to have some impressive safeties. But how good a job Ward does of coaching this group up will be a major swing factor when it comes to the success of this season.

300-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

12-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

25-1

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.8	80
YARDS PER POINT	16.7	112
PLAYS PER GAME	74.2	11
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:48	26
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.9%	107
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	414	28
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	54
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.6	30
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	193.1	24
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	27
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.5	50
COMPLETION %	58.0%	105
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	220.9	73
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	86
TURNOVERS	1.7	111
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.9	58
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	70
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.9%	53
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	360	46
YARDS PER PLAY	5	33
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	127.3	30
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	29
COMPLETION %	60.2%	42
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232.8	84
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	39
SACKS	2.6	23
TURNOVERS	1.2	81

BAYLOR BEARS



Things started so well for Dave Aranda. After going 2-7 in his first year in Waco, Aranda led the Bears to a 12-2 record and a Sugar Bowl victory in Year 2. However, Baylor has now had three losing seasons in the last four years, and it's honestly shocking that Aranda still has his job.

Can Aranda reward the program's decision-makers for having the faith to keep him around another season? That's the big question. This defense is expected to be a little better than it was a year ago, and DJ Lagway is a high-profile addition at quarterback. So, there's plenty to be excited about if you're a Baylor fan — or backer. But the schedule is rather tough, and the team's win total sits at 5.5. If Over bettors don't cash their season-long plays, Aranda's likely looking for a defensive coordinator job next year.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5
Baylor has a really tough schedule. A neutral-site game against Auburn on September 5 could ultimately decide whether this team hits the six-win mark, but the Over still feels like a better play than the Under. The Bears have the talent required to take a huge step forward on defense, and it's hard not to be excited about Lagway potentially finding himself in a more quarterback-friendly offense.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 2-10 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Dave Aranda - 7th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	VS. AUBURN (+5.6)	52.5
9/12	PRAIRIE VIEW (-31.8)	16.5
9/19	LOUISIANA TECH (-16.4)	33.0
9/26	COLORADO (-6.2)	43.0
10/3	AT ARIZONA ST (+4.4)	49.5
10/17	TCU (+2.4)	51.0
10/24	AT KANSAS (+2.1)	46.0
10/30	AT UCF (+0.6)	44.5
11/7	IOWA ST (-6.8)	41.5
11/14	AT BYU (+13.6)	57.5
11/21	TEXAS TECH (+12.9)	61.5
11/28	AT HOUSTON (+7.5)	53.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.99**
#37 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.6 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

5

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Jake Spavital unlock DJ Lagway?

Lagway was once viewed as the savior in Florida. He was the top-ranked quarterback in the 2024 recruiting class, and he put some great stuff on film when he first got opportunities in Gainesville. Unfortunately, things turned quickly for the dual-threat quarterback. Last year, he threw 14 picks and took 19 sacks, making far too many mistakes at the most important position on the field. Some piled-up injuries definitely played a role in that, but it was clear a change in scenery was needed. Well, Lagway will now be playing for an elite play-caller in Spavital, and he's taking control of an offense that put up 31.1 points per game last year. If the group up front can do a good job of keeping Lagway upright, we could see a major turnaround. Sawyer Robertson put up massive numbers in this offense, and Lagway is arguably more talented. If Lagway has his deep-ball touch this season, we should see plenty of big plays in a Spavital offense that is known for wideouts streaking down the field with defenders nowhere in sight.

How will the Bears stack up in the trenches?

Keeping Lagway upright was mentioned in the previous burning question and it'll be a revamped offensive line tasked with doing so. Aranda and Co. have Kaden Sieracki, a starter last year, back at right tackle, but four fresh faces were brought in at the other spots. Three of those four were starters. Baylor should be bigger and deeper along the line, so the potential is there for this group to be much improved from a year ago. The Bears also have a loaded defensive line, so there's a chance this team is way more physical than it was in 2025. And overall, the squad should have the toughness required to compete regularly in the Big 12.

Is the Baylor defense going to be a mess again?

Aranda is no longer calling the defense. While he's viewed as a great defensive mind, he's wisely stepping aside and allowing a new voice to step in. Joe Klanderman is the guy hoping to solve Baylor's recent defensive issues. Klanderman spent the last six years with Kansas State, and he has been open about wanting his team to be active in the opposing backfield. We should see a good amount of blitzing. That will leave the secondary a little more exposed than usual, but the defensive backs on this team are good enough to manage that. Realistically, this defense has improved at all three levels, so last year's 32.6 opponent points per game should come down considerably.

250-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

25-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

45-1

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.1	30
YARDS PER POINT	14.9	81
PLAYS PER GAME	77.6	3
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:48	101
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.4%	77
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	449.5	10
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	34
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.4	88
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	134.1	88
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	90
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.4	3
COMPLETION %	60.3%	81
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	315.5	3
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	54
TURNOVERS	2	130
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	34.9	125
YARDS PER POINT	11.7	131
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.4%	93
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	409.5	96
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	92
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	206.5	123
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	116
COMPLETION %	62.8%	76
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	203.1	37
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	55
SACKS	0.9	130
TURNOVERS	0.6	129

BYU COUGARS



Kalani Sitake has done absurd things as the head coach of his alma mater. BYU has won double-digit games in four of the last six seasons, and last year's Cougars squad had a real case for making the College Football Playoff field. Sitake has been so successful that Penn State was dying for him to take over the Nittany Lions program. In the end, BYU's boosters dipped into their bottomless pit of money to bring him back.

Sitake will now look to take a step forward this season, meaning he'll be looking to get the Cougars into the CFP for the first time ever. Doing so will be difficult, as the Big 12 is loaded with talented teams. However, BYU returns nearly every impactful player from last year's 12-win team.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 8.5

You can nitpick some things when looking at this year's BYU team, but it's pretty clear this squad has the goods. Winning nine games will be tough with the Cougars' difficult schedule, but they do get Notre Dame at LaVell Edwards Stadium. That helps in one of their biggest challenges of the season, and there's a real chance that'll be the only game of the season in which they'll be getting points. If that's not the case, perhaps they'll be 'dogs at Utah on November 7. Either way, there should be nine wins here.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 10-4 ATS, 6-8 O-U

Head Coach: Kalani Sitake - 11th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	UTAH TECH (-56)	5.0
9/12	ARIZONA (-7.7)	52.5
9/19	AT COLORADO ST (-24.1)	32.5
10/3	AT TCU (-3.5)	51.0
10/9	IOWA ST (-18.9)	41.5
10/17	NOTRE DAME (+8.8)	68.5
10/24	AT UCF (-10.3)	44.5
10/31	ARIZONA ST (-10.7)	49.5
11/7	AT UTAH (+0.5)	54.5
11/14	BAYLOR (-13.6)	47.0
11/21	AT KANSAS (-8.8)	46.0
11/28	CINCINNATI (-16.5)	44.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.10**
#49 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

13

OFFENSE

5*

DEFENSE

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How much better will Bear Bachmeier be as a passer?

Bachmeier wasn't supposed to be a freshman starter for BYU, but he ran with the opportunity. He threw for 3,033 yards with 15 touchdowns and only seven picks, and he also ran for 527 yards and 11 touchdowns. However, Bachmeier was far more comfortable running than he was passing, and improving his accuracy to become a more cerebral pocket passer is the next stage in his development. Bachmeier had an overall PFF grade of 78.9 last year, so he graded out as a top-50 quarterback. It was, however, his rushing grade (77.0) that raised his overall profile. If the passing grade can surpass the rushing grade in 2026, BYU has something special at the quarterback spot.

Can the wide receiver group overcome the loss of Parker Kingston?

Kingston had 97 receptions for 928 yards and five touchdowns last year, so BYU was hoping to have the shifty slot man back for another season. But that possibility was thrown out the window when the skilled wideout was expelled from school for his off-field conduct. BYU will now be relying heavily on an unproven group of pass catchers. That said, Bachmeier will not only be hoping to progress as a passer, he'll be doing so without receivers he's comfortable working with. It'll be interesting to see who emerges as the top dog, but don't sleep on Oregon transfer Kyle Kasper. He's a 6-foot-6 contested-catch weapon who also moves pretty well for a player his size.

Will new DC Kelly Poppinga hit the ground running?

BYU is coming off back-to-back seasons in which the defense has allowed 19.6 or fewer points per game. Last year, the Cougars actually gave up only 19.1, so the vibes should be nothing but positive with eight players who started games in 2025 back — including talented Cal transfer Cade Uluave. But BYU will have a new coach leading the defense, as Jay Hill went to join Kyle Whittingham at Michigan. Things should be fine considering the playmakers the Cougars have scattered throughout the defense, but you never quite know.

ODDS TO WIN...

90-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+330

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+550

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.5	44
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	41
PLAYS PER GAME	67.8	75
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:35	10
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.4%	58
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	383.8	67
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	45
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.1	47
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	156.2	61
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	69
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.6	86
COMPLETION %	63.6%	45
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	227.5	65
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	42
TURNOVERS	1.2	44
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.6	23
YARDS PER POINT	17.2	13
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.0%	29
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	355.3	43
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	39
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	132.5	35
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	46
COMPLETION %	57.9%	21
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222.8	62
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	40
SACKS	2.2	53
TURNOVERS	1.8	19

CINCINNATI BEARCATS



Cincinnati finished last season with a 7-6 record, which was somewhat disappointing considering the amount of returning starters (15 who started games the previous year) they had heading into the year. One of those starters was Brendan Sorsby, who threw for 2,800 yards, 27 touchdowns, and five interceptions. He also rushed for another 580 yards and nine touchdowns. Replacing Sorsby and several other offensive weapons will be a challenge, plus the defense really struggled to get stops toward the end of the season.

As we look to 2026, Scott Satterfield is going to need to do a great coaching job to overcome a brutal schedule. However, Satterfield has won seven or fewer games in six consecutive years, so his shine is starting to wear off — if it hasn't already. This will be a big season for the Bearcats.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

Hiring Woody and bringing in some instant-impact transfers should result in meaningful change for the defense, but it's hard to imagine what this offense will look like without Sorsby. Well, if Cincinnati doesn't have an offense capable of generating explosives, it's likely this will turn into a long year — and a long year for the Bearcats could mean a short year for Satterfield, who should really be on the hot seat. Honestly, if Cincinnati loses to Boston College on September 5, this season could go off the rails.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 6-7 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Scott Satterfield - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	BOSTON COLLEGE (-9.5)	37.5
9/12	W CAROLINA (-23.6)	22.5
9/19	VS. MIAMI OHIO (-8.8)	36.0
9/26	KANSAS ST (+4.6)	51.0
10/3	AT ARIZONA (+11)	52.5
10/17	AT WEST VIRGINIA (+3.6)	45.0
10/24	TEXAS TECH (+15.1)	61.5
10/31	UTAH (+8.3)	54.5
11/7	AT HOUSTON (+10.4)	53.0
11/14	AT IOWA ST (+0)	41.5
11/21	COLORADO (-4)	43.0
11/28	AT BYU (+16.5)	57.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.47**
#34 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

9

OFFENSE

3

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does this offense look like without Sorsby and Cyrus Allen?

Last year, the Bearcats were No. 5 in the country in Game on Paper's Adjusted EPA/Play (0.14). This was an explosive offense with Sorsby at the helm. This year, Sorsby is long gone — and we genuinely have no idea what he'll be doing with his time — while Allen, the team's top receiver, is off to the Chiefs. Allen had 13 touchdown catches last year, so this team lost a star quarterback and a big-play pass-catching weapon. Joe Royer also happened to be a good tight end for Satterfield's group, but he's another player off to the NFL. Replacing Sorsby will be Georgia Southern transfer JC French, who is an accurate passer that likes to deal opponents death by a million paper cuts. He's not a threat to consistently complete deep balls. Cincinnati also has an underwhelming group in the backfield, and the receivers are unproven. There's a chance this unit takes a massive step back.

Can the defense chop a few points off last year's 25.6 points per game allowed?

Cincinnati finished 74th in the nation in scoring defense last year. Considering the Bearcats offense is likely in for some serious regression, being a better defensive team is imperative. Cincinnati appears to have a better situation in the secondary, where they have a few big-time MAC contributors transferring in — they raided Northern Illinois for defensive backs Jacob Finley and Jasper Beeler, and they also got MLB Filip Maciorowski from the Huskies. The Bearcats also have some good size along the D-Line, and the linebacking corps looks solid. On top of that, new defensive coordinator Nate Woody largely did a good job in that role at Army. There's some excitement surrounding his aggressive 3-4 scheme. This should be a better defense than we saw last year.

Will this team win three Big 12 games?

Cincinnati starts the season with winnable games against Boston College, Western Carolina, and Miami (Ohio). After that, it gets harder to find the wins. The Bearcats will host Kansas State and Colorado, and they go on the road to face West Virginia and Iowa State. Going 3-1 in those four games will likely be necessary in order for Cincinnati to find a way to six victories. It'd be surprising if the Bearcats won road games against Arizona, Houston, and BYU, and home-field advantage likely won't be enough for Cincinnati to take down Texas Tech or Utah.

300-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****50-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****98-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27	62
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	68
PLAYS PER GAME	60.4	134
TIME OF POSSESSION	24:34	136
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.4%	75
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	390.8	59
YARDS PER PLAY	6.5	13
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.3	114
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	170.5	41
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.4	10
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.4	100
COMPLETION %	59.8%	85
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	220.3	74
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	40
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.8	77
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	45
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.5%	105
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	423.6	110
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	79
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	187.6	108
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	79
COMPLETION %	67.0%	121
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	236	91
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	92
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	0.8	121

COLORADO BUFFALOES



After going 4-8 in Deion Sanders' first year in Boulder, Colorado won nine games in Year 2. That was a year in which Shedeur Sanders put up stupid numbers as a passer, and Travis Hunter won the Heisman for his contributions as both a wide receiver and a cornerback. Unfortunately for Coach Prime, the success of those players meant they had to go to the NFL. That made for a disaster of a season in 2025, as the Buffs lacked an identity, went 3-9 overall, and finished 1-8 in Big 12 play.

Things should be different heading into 2026. Sanders is doing much better with regards to some of the health concerns that have made life difficult for him both on and off the field. He has also made some big coaching staff changes, and he and his staff went hard in bringing in reliable contributors via the transfer portal. Now, in Year 4, a bowl game appearance should be on the table.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

We're going to learn a lot about Colorado this year. Can this program be successful without Sanders' kids and a two-way star like Hunter? Last year's team didn't have enough talent to compete in the Big 12, but this year's group has the size, balance, and skill to hang around. That said, if this coaching staff does its job, five wins should be attainable. Colorado should easily pick up one against Weber State, and there's no reason the team can't be competitive in home games against Kansas State, Houston, and UCF. Road games against Northwestern, Baylor, Oklahoma State, and Cincinnati also seem like reasonable spots to project wins. That's seven games in which the Buffaloes will need to pick up four wins. I'd say it's more likely than not they'll get them.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 5-7 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Deion Sanders - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AT GEORGIA TECH (+9)	49.0
9/12	WEBER ST (-31.3)	14.5
9/19	AT NORTHWESTERN (+5.2)	45.5
9/26	AT BAYLOR (+6.2)	47.0
10/3	TEXAS TECH (+15.8)	61.5
10/17	UTAH (+9)	54.5
10/24	AT OKLAHOMA ST (+6.1)	46.5
10/31	KANSAS ST (+5.3)	51.0
11/7	AT ARIZONA ST (+9.1)	49.5
11/13	HOUSTON (+7.5)	53.0
11/21	AT CINCINNATI (+4)	44.5
11/28	UCF (-1.9)	44.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.67**
#33 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

15

OFFENSE

8

DEFENSE

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How will OC Brennan Marion’s “Go-Go” system look in the Big 12?

Marion’s fast-paced, power rushing offense was highly successful at UNLV and Sacramento State, but it’ll be interesting to see whether it translates to the big leagues. Marion’s offenses feature multiple backs, and he relies on fresh legs to rip off big runs up the middle. The success of the rushing attack also allows for plenty of deep balls, as it is a variation of a spread offense. As long as the Buffaloes get some strong play up front, there’s really no reason this shouldn’t work. And Colorado has two potential pros — Leon Bell and Bo Hughley — at tackle, and Demetrius Hunter is a proven starter at center. That said, the O-Line should be pretty solid.

Will Julian Lewis show out at the quarterback position?

Lewis was a five-star recruit and the third-ranked quarterback in the class of 2025, and he’s viewed as the future of Colorado football. Last year, over parts of three games, Lewis threw for 589 yards with four touchdowns and no picks. He wasn’t great in that stretch, but he wasn’t miserable either. This year, Lewis is expected to begin his rise to stardom. A traditional pro-style quarterback, Lewis isn’t going to be looking to do as much improvisation as we saw out of Shedeur in Boulder. But he has the arm talent required to make the types of downfield throws Marion needs. If he can’t, Utah transfer Isaac Wilson — brother of Zach Wilson — could get a shot.

Can former Virginia Tech DC Chris Marve get the defense on track?

Colorado looked to be moving in the right direction on defense, as the team allowed 23.1 points per game in 2024 after having allowed 34.8 points per game in 2023. However, things got ugly again last season, with the Buffaloes giving up 30.5 points per game and finishing 56th in the nation in Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.03). Being a top-25 defense should be the goal for Colorado in 2026, and it isn’t an unrealistic one considering the team was 13th in Adjusted EPA/Play allowed (-0.13) in 2024. Marve also happens to have a lot of talent to work with. The Buffs really beefed up through the transfer portal, adding several all-conference Group of Five performers at all three levels of the defense. Sanders was also able to bring in some corners from big-time programs. That said, this will truly fall on Marve, as the group certainly isn’t lacking playmakers.

ODDS TO WIN...

500-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

90-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

110-1

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.9	107
YARDS PER POINT	15.7	98
PLAYS PER GAME	68.8	62
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:49	100
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.4%	74
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	328.4	108
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	116
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.8	58
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	125.7	99
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	112
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.8	85
COMPLETION %	58.8%	96
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	202.8	92
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.5	98
YARDS PER POINT	14	82
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.2%	34
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	425.7	112
YARDS PER PLAY	6	114
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	222.5	132
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	127
COMPLETION %	55.4%	11
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	203.2	38
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	91
SACKS	1.2	126
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

HOUSTON COUGARS



Willie Fritz has won at a high level everywhere, so it should come as no surprise that he has some serious momentum at Houston. This program has been viewed as a sleeping giant for years, and Fritz was the perfect hire to get the Cougars over the hump. Fritz only needed two years to turn Houston into a 10-win team, as last year's group won nine games and then added a 10th with a victory over LSU in the Texas Bowl. The next step for the Cougars is making the College Football Playoff.

Houston's win total is either 7.5 or 8.5 depending on where you look, but this team has a ton of talent — with 19 projected starters who started in 2025 — and a reasonable schedule. There isn't much preventing the Cougars from turning in a special season, and we'll learn a lot about them when they travel to Lubbock for a meeting with Texas Tech on September 18.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

Not only is Houston worthy of a juiced Over at 7.5 wins, but this is a team worth attacking with some alternates. There's a real chance the Cougars earn double-digit wins this year, with road games at Texas Tech and Utah being the only two spots on the schedule where Houston should be getting points. Fritz has done a good job of building this program up, going 4-8 in Year 1 and rapidly improving to 10-3 in Year 2. Well, the team he's putting on the field in Year 3 is arguably the most talented group he has ever coached, which says a lot considering the kind of success he had at Tulane. Making the College Football Playoff is on the table in 2026.

2025 Record: 10-3 SU & 9-4 ATS, 8-5 O-U

Head Coach: Willie Fritz - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	OREGON ST (-23.2)	32.0
9/12	SOUTHERN (-61.9)	-6.5
9/18	AT TEXAS TECH (+12.2)	61.5
9/26	AT GA SOUTHERN (-16)	33.5
10/3	UCF (-10.8)	44.5
10/10	AT KANSAS ST (+1.6)	51.0
10/17	OKLAHOMA ST (-8.9)	46.5
10/24	AT UTAH (+5.3)	54.5
11/7	CINCINNATI (-10.4)	44.5
11/13	AT COLORADO (-7.5)	43.0
11/21	AT WEST VIRGINIA (-5.4)	45.0
11/28	BAYLOR (-7.5)	47.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **41.96**
#66 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.6 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

19

OFFENSE

10*

DEFENSE

9

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Fritz afford to keep QB Keisean Henderson on the bench all season?

Conner Weigman was solid for Houston last season, throwing for 2,705 yards with 25 touchdowns and nine interceptions. He also rushed for 700 yards and 11 scores. Weigman was, however, a little inefficient as a passer, finishing with a PFF grade of 63.5 as a thrower. He also struggled mightily in some of Houston's biggest games. That makes things interesting with Henderson lurking. Henderson was a five-star recruit who could have gone anywhere in the country, but he chose to play for the Cougars. The 18-year-old has top-tier mobility and a smooth delivery. It's going to be tempting for Fritz to get him on the field at some point, as elite play under center could turn Houston into a legitimate national title contender.

Is Houston getting the Tulane version of Makhi Hughes?

In 2024, Hughes rushed for 1,401 yards with 15 touchdowns for the Green Wave. He also caught 19 passes for 176 yards and two touchdowns. Hughes was one of the top running backs in football as both a freshman and a sophomore, and big things were expected from him when he transferred to Oregon for the 2025 season. However, Hughes was a non-factor in Eugene, so he decided to redshirt after four games. Now, Hughes reunites with Fritz in Houston, where he'll be the top back in a loaded backfield. Hughes has cooked in this system in the past, and he'll be running behind a much-improved offensive line. He should return to stardom and serve as the head of the snake for a very good football team.

Does this defense have the potential to be a top-15 unit in the country?

Last season, Houston was tied for 41st in the nation in Game on Paper's Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.05). This year, nine players who started games in 2025 are here on defense, and some intriguing transfers — like Ashton Porter, De'Marion Thomas, and Jordan Allen — will make this a more dynamic group. With a slight spike in pass-rushing production, along with steadier play in the secondary, this can be a very good defense. Houston gave up only 22.8 points per game a season ago, and the goal will be shaving off a field goal or so. Defensive coordinator Austin Armstrong has the talent, size, and depth he needs to accomplish that.

ODDS TO WIN...

200-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+850****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****16-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.3	38
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	47
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	31
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:06	16
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.8%	53
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	398.8	44
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	63
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.9	18
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	176.5	37
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	70
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.1	94
COMPLETION %	64.5%	40
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222.3	69
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	44
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.8	55
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	60
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.5%	49
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	364.8	52
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	50
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	136.5	42
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	40
COMPLETION %	61.1%	56
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	228.3	78
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	82
SACKS	2.2	51
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

IOWA STATE CYCLONES



Matt Campbell's run with Iowa State will not be forgotten, and it'll be hard for the Cyclones to retool with the 46-year-old now at Penn State. However, Iowa State did pick up a proven winner in Jimmy Rogers, who won a Division I Championship with South Dakota State in 2023 and then did a solid job in his lone season with Washington State last year.

Rogers brought over defensive coordinator Jesse Bobbit, who had the Cougars performing like an elite defense last season. He also hit the transfer portal extremely hard, bringing in a mix of high-major players in need of more opportunity and successful lower-level players looking for a bigger stage.

It'd be foolish to rule out Rogers turning Iowa State into a winner, as good coaches can win in Ames. However, it might take more than a season for this team to move on.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Iowa State should be able to win games against Southeast Missouri and Bowling Green, but winning on the road against Iowa will be tough in Year 1 with this coaching staff. It's also hard to pick out three conference victories considering the way this offense looks on paper. That said, even if you're optimistic about Rogers' fit with Iowa State, this does feel like it's going to be a trying season. With so many Big 12 teams looking to make big leaps this season, this could be the conference punching bag. So, the Cyclones will likely struggle to reach the five-win mark, but perhaps they'll ramp things up in a big way in 2027.

2025 Record: 8-4 SU & 5-6-1 ATS, 4-8 O-U

Head Coach: Jimmy Rogers - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	SE MISSOURI ST (-35)	9.0
9/12	AT IOWA (+16.8)	55.5
9/19	BOWLING GREEN (-17)	26.5
9/26	UTAH (+10.5)	54.5
10/3	WEST VIRGINIA (+0.6)	45.0
10/9	AT BYU (+18.9)	57.5
10/24	AT ARIZONA (+13.4)	52.5
10/31	OKLAHOMA ST (+1.5)	46.5
11/7	AT BAYLOR (+6.8)	47.0
11/14	CINCINNATI (+0)	44.5
11/20	AT UCF (+5.9)	44.5
11/28	KANSAS ST (+6.8)	51.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.93**
#51 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

4

2

2

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the Cyclones have one of the best defenses in the Big 12?

If there's one place Iowa State could thrive in 2026, it's the defensive side of the ball. Last year, Bobbit ran a top-50 defense in Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.05), and only 25 teams allowed fewer points per game than Washington State's 20.2. He can really coach up a defense, and this team is going to be plenty talented. While most of Campbell's players are gone, the Cyclones were able to bring in a bunch of key pieces from Washington State — along with some other big-time contributors from smaller programs. This defense should be in a very good place, even after losing transfer safety Braden Awls for the season after tearing his ACL in spring practice.

Are the big boys along the revamped offensive line ready for a jump in competition?

The Cyclones added a ton of players with starting experience along the O-Line, with Braden Smith (Tarleton State), Caden Mass (Sioux Falls), Colin Amick (Montana), and Jake Taylor (Oklahoma) all having been starters before. However, those first three played against much worse competition, so it'll be interesting to see how they handle the size in the Big 12. Also, Taylor missed all of last year after starting four games at Oklahoma, so it's not like we've seen him recently. All in all, Iowa State did a good job of filling some holes — plus the group has plenty of depth — but we still know very little about how this will look. If it doesn't work out well, the Cyclones will be in for a very long season.

What is there to be excited about on offense?

Not only is the offensive line a bit of a question mark, the entire offense feels like one. Quarterback Jaylen Raynor is an exciting player, as he was a fun dual-threat weapon for Arkansas State last year. However, he does turn the ball over a little too often, and there isn't much that suggests he'll be able to carve up Big 12 defenses. The Cyclones also lack proven pass-catching options, and they have a pretty shaky group of running backs behind the retooled offensive line. Considering the lack of talent and experience, there's a real world in which this is the worst offense in the Big 12.

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****70-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****100-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.9	79
YARDS PER POINT	15.4	93
PLAYS PER GAME	70.7	47
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:22	32
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.6%	93
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	383.5	69
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	71
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.5	31
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169.8	45
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	63
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.2	91
COMPLETION %	58.3%	101
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	213.7	84
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	61
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.4	32
YARDS PER POINT	17.3	11
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.5%	58
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	370.4	58
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	78
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	143.5	53
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	82
COMPLETION %	62.0%	64
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.9	76
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	54
SACKS	1.2	121
TURNOVERS	1.5	44

KANSAS JAYHAWKS



After three years with Kansas, Lance Leipold looked to be on his way to becoming a Lawrence legend. The Jayhawks went 2-10 in Leipold's first year, 6-7 in his second, and then exploded for a 9-4 season in 2023. Leipold's work helped secure some serious financial investments from the university. However, after back-to-back 5-7 seasons in 2024 and 2025, Leipold suddenly finds himself with an uncomfortably warm seat.

The good news for Kansas is that Leipold was able to bring offensive coordinator Andy Kotelnicki, a former Broyles Award nominee, back after an up-and-down stint with Penn State. That will at least mean the Jayhawks will be running the most successful offense they have run in decades. The question is whether Kansas has the talent required to achieve bowl eligibility.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

Without Daniels' playmaking to mask some of their deficiencies, this could be a tough year for Kansas. The Jayhawks should handle their business against lower-tier schools like Long Island and Middle Tennessee, but it's hard to believe in them against Missouri or in the entire Big 12. Kansas might be able to make something out of home games against Baylor and UCF, but this isn't a team that can be trusted in 50-50 games with these quarterback options and a mediocre defense. And if things do go extremely poorly, it'll be interesting to see what happens with Leipold.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 4-7-1 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Lance Leipold - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	LIU POST (-42.2)	7.0
9/11	MISSOURI (+5.8)	54.5
9/19	VS. ARIZONA ST (+4.1)	49.5
10/3	MIDDLE TENN ST (-28.6)	21.0
10/10	AT UTAH (+12.6)	54.5
10/17	AT KANSAS ST (+8.9)	51.0
10/24	BAYLOR (-2.1)	47.0
10/31	AT TCU (+8.6)	51.0
11/7	UCF (-5.4)	44.5
11/14	AT WEST VIRGINIA (+1.9)	45.0
11/21	BYU (+8.8)	57.5
11/28	AT OKLAHOMA ST (+2.6)	46.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.92**
#52 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Does reuniting with OC Andy Kotelnicki make up for losing Jalon Daniels?

In 2022, Kansas averaged 35.6 points per game. Then, in 2023, the Jayhawks averaged 34.8 points per game. Kansas was one of the most potent offensive teams in the nation, which is why James Franklin brought Kotelnicki to Happy Valley. That move ultimately didn't work out for anyone, so Kotelnicki is back to working with Leipold. You can expect this offense to be extremely efficient when the necessary pieces are in place, but they aren't right now. The quarterback situation looks pretty ugly with Daniels, one of the best dual-threat quarterbacks in college football last year, gone. Kansas also appears to be lacking game-changing talent in the wide receiver room, so Kotelnicki might not produce an elite offensive product right away.

Will the offensive line be good enough to support a run-heavy approach?

Kotelnicki's pro-style system utilizes a lot of pre-snap motion that are designed to create mismatches, but none of it works without an efficient, physical running game. That means offensive line play will be massive heading into 2026, and that's especially true with a questionable quarterback situation. The Jayhawks are set at left tackle, where Calvin Clements started 12 games in 2025 and looks the part of a future pro. Kansas also has left guard Amir Herring back from last year, and the team brought in some impressive bodies to fill out the rest of the line. There's some real potential for this to turn into one of the better groups in the Big 12, which could prevent the offense from completely spiraling.

Is there hope on defense after a disastrous 2025 season?

While bringing Kotelnicki back is nice, Leipold needs to figure out how to stabilize his defense. New defensive coordinator DK McDonald is being tasked with patching up a unit that gave up 26.8 points per game last year. The Jayhawks were also unable to crack the top 100 in Game on Paper's Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (0.05) last season. Things should be a little better on this side of the ball in 2026, as Leipold addressed some needs in the transfer portal. However, this team either needs to be much stronger when it comes to getting after the quarterback or much steadier in the secondary. If that's not the case, the best quarterbacks in the Big 12 will torch Kansas.

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****30-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****45-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.5	68
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	51
PLAYS PER GAME	65	111
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:25	51
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.1%	81
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	368.8	77
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	43
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.9	70
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	157.8	60
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	44
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.3	102
COMPLETION %	60.5%	80
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	211	88
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	51
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.5	85
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	75
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.9%	97
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	409.5	95
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	100
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	184.1	105
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	113
COMPLETION %	64.1%	94
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	225.4	68
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	84
SACKS	1.9	74
TURNOVERS	0.9	108

KANSAS STATE WILDCATS



After going 6-6 in 2025, Chris Klieman decided to step down from his position as head coach of Kansas State. He cited family and personal health as the reasons he ultimately chose to retire. Klieman had won at least nine games in three consecutive seasons prior to last year's disappointing campaign, doing a good job as the replacement for the legendary Bill Snyder. But the Wildcats are hoping for even bigger things out of Collin Klein, who played for K-State from 2008 to 2012 and then served as the team's offensive coordinator in 2022 and 2023.

Klein is viewed as a brilliant offensive mind. He's only 36 years old, and this is his destination job. All of that is great for the program. However, this will be his first time calling the shots for an entire team, so there's no guarantee this will be a seamless transition. But the Wildcats do have a good amount of talent on both sides of the ball, and Avery Johnson, an electric dual-threat quarterback, is back under center. Many have this team pegged as a sleeper.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
It isn't hard to see why people like the Wildcats to be sneaky-good in the Big 12 this year, but it still feels like a seven-win season is more likely than an eight-win season. Kansas State does have the benefit of playing some tougher games at home, but that doesn't guarantee wins. The Wildcats can easily get tripped up against Houston, Kansas, and Arizona, even with the games being played in Manhattan. The Wildcats have a lot of questions to answer when it comes to stopping the run, and I'm not sold on Klein instantly fixing the offense. Johnson has to earn back the trust he lost, and the receiver group looks mediocre.

2025 Record: 6-6 SU & 5-7 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Collin Klein - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	NICHOLLS ST (-43.1)	12.5
9/12	WASHINGTON ST (-16.6)	38.0
9/19	TULANE (-11.7)	42.5
9/26	AT CINCINNATI (-4.6)	44.5
10/10	HOUSTON (-1.6)	53.0
10/17	KANSAS (-8.9)	46.0
10/24	AT ARIZONA ST (+0.5)	49.5
10/31	AT COLORADO (-5.3)	43.0
11/7	OKLAHOMA ST (-9.1)	46.5
11/14	AT TCU (+3.5)	51.0
11/21	ARIZONA (-1.8)	52.5
11/28	AT IOWA ST (-6.8)	41.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 42.21
#65 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 3.8 / 0
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

7*

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How much better can the Wildcats be against the run?

While this team is now being coached by an offense-forward mind, this defense has been hyped up throughout the offseason. People are understandably high on the Kansas State secondary, which has a good combination of talent and experience. However, the Wildcats allowed 164.0 rushing yards per game last season, and having a strong group of defensive backs is relatively meaningless when you can't stop the run. Kansas State appears to have addressed this by adding Oklahoma State transfer Wendell Gregory, Cincinnati transfer Kamari Burns, and Kentucky transfer Austin Ramsey — along with a few productive linebackers — but it's difficult to bring in an entirely new crop of players. Perhaps this group will perform more like a top-40 rushing defense, but expecting a bigger turnaround than that probably isn't fair.

Can Avery Johnson take his game to another level?

Johnson threw for 2,712 yards with 25 touchdowns and 10 interceptions in 2024, and he also rushed for 605 yards with seven touchdowns. That had many feeling very excited about what the 2025 season would look like, but Johnson didn't get any better. He threw for 2,385 yards with 18 touchdowns and six picks, and he rushed for 477 yards and eight scores. Is this simply who Johnson is at this point? Realistically, there should be another gear he can reach. He's one of the most impressive athletes in the nation at his position, and the return of Klein should mean he's playing in the perfect offense. If Kansas State is going to win eight or nine games this year, Johnson will need to be a little sharper as a passer while maintaining his juice as a runner.

Who's catching the passes for this team?

Jayce Brown was an absolute burner for this offense last year, catching 41 balls for 712 yards and five touchdowns. His big-play ability caught the attention of Lane Kiffin, so he'll now be catching passes in Baton Rouge. That leaves a massive hole in this wide receiver group. Jaron Tibbs and Josh Manning have both been productive in the past, but will either of them be able to consistently create space when Klein isn't scheming them open? Perhaps Izaiah Williams, who followed Klein from Texas A&M, will break out and be the piece this offense is missing.

ODDS TO WIN...

200-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+750****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****14-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.6	43
YARDS PER POINT	12.6	16
PLAYS PER GAME	62.5	127
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:01	95
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.8%	91
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	361.4	82
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	35
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	80
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	173.9	38
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	20
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.3	108
COMPLETION %	58.7%	99
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	187.5	102
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	80
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.9	66
YARDS PER POINT	15	54
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.8%	66
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	389.1	76
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	41
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169.4	89
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	54
COMPLETION %	56.3%	16
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	219.7	57
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	50
SACKS	2.3	41
TURNOVERS	2.3	3

OKLAHOMA STATE COWBOYS



Oklahoma State is one of the most fascinating teams in the country. There will likely be a statue of Mike Gundy in Stillwater at some point, but it was clear the game passed him by. He had zero interest in adjusting to the new age of college football, which is why the Cowboys went a combined 4-11 under his watch in 2024 and 2025. That forced Oklahoma State's hand in moving on, and the team ultimately decided on Eric Morris as the new leader of the program.

North Texas went 12-2 last season — with Morris on the sidelines for 11 of the wins — and had the most explosive offense in college football. He's another Air Raid coach who brings a ton of excitement to this storied team, and he also brought a bunch of his former players in for Year 1.

Playing in the Big 12 means a quick turnaround won't be easy for Morris, who went 5-7 in his first year with North Texas. However, he has some legitimate stars playing for his offense, including Drew Mestemaker. So, even if this season isn't a smashing success, it will be fun to watch.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5

The way this defense looks is definitely a bit concerning, but Cassity has done more with less. Realistically, as long as this offense lives up to expectations, wins will come with a manageable schedule. Oklahoma State should beat Tulsa and Murray State easily, and home games against UCF, Colorado, and Kansas should be winnable. If the Cowboys can just take care of those five, hitting the Over means the Pokes need one road win in games against West Virginia, Iowa State, and Kansas State. That feels like it's going to happen.

2025 Record: 1-11 SU & 6-6 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Eric Morris - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT TULSA (-11.7)	32.5
9/12	OREGON (+20.9)	68.5
9/19	MURRAY ST (-44)	5.5
9/26	AT WEST VIRGINIA (+2.1)	45.0
10/10	UCF (-4.7)	44.5
10/17	AT HOUSTON (+8.9)	53.0
10/24	COLORADO (-6.1)	43.0
10/31	AT IOWA ST (-1.5)	41.5
11/7	AT KANSAS ST (+9.1)	51.0
11/14	TEXAS TECH (+13)	61.5
11/21	AT ARIZONA ST (+5.8)	49.5
11/28	KANSAS (-2.6)	46.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.60**
#41 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

6

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Mestemaker capable of consistently lighting up Power Four competition?

Mestemaker was the best Group of Five quarterback in the nation last year, and he also posted the best numbers of all FBS quarterbacks. The 20-year-old has NFL scouts drooling over his big arm, his solid mobility, and his ability to read defenses. The sky truly feels like the limit for him, but how much of what he did last season will translate to the Big 12? Mestemaker had more interceptions than touchdowns in two of the Mean Green's biggest games (vs. South Florida and at Tulane). Those losses weren't only on him, but he will need to prove that he can handle much tougher competition in 2026. We'll learn a lot on September 12, as Oklahoma State will face Oregon.

Did Morris do well enough in building out this offensive line?

Oklahoma State lost seven players from last year's group of offensive line options, so Morris went out and hit the portal. One of the players he brought over was Johnny Dickson, who was a second-team All-AAC guard last year. He also grabbed three Power Four starters, along with a starting guard from Coastal Carolina. This unit won't be lacking in experience, but will it be good enough? Morris is pretty excited about the way the line is coming together, and he did add some solid depth pieces. This is one of the most important position groups in the country this year, as Morris needs the line to hold up in order for his offense to explode in the Big 12.

Does this defense have enough legitimate dudes?

North Texas' 0.06 Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed mark was pretty miserable last year, but the Mean Green were good enough defensively to allow Mestemaker to win games with his arm. That will be the goal again in 2026. Skyler Cassity was praised for the job he did in turning North Texas into a high-turnover defense last year, and he'll be hoping an aggressive style pays off again in the Big 12. The issue is that this team is really lacking talent. The Cowboys only have four players who started in 2025 in their projected starting lineup. Outside of that, they're banking on youth and unproven transfers. This could be one of the worst defenses in the Big 12, which is why it's hard to fully buy into Oklahoma State as a sleeper in the conference.

400-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****20-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****30-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	13	133
YARDS PER POINT	22	134
PLAYS PER GAME	65.3	110
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:31	109
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.5%	117
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	286.4	131
YARDS PER PLAY	4.4	129
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.9	94
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	117.5	109
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	108
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.5	77
COMPLETION %	57.1%	115
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	168.8	117
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.5	134
TURNOVERS	1.5	96
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.7	127
YARDS PER POINT	12.2	127
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.7%	107
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	435.7	120
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	126
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	170.3	91
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	78
COMPLETION %	66.2%	115
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	265.5	126
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.1	133
SACKS	1.6	97
TURNOVERS	1	98

TCU

HORNED FROGS



Sonny Dykes took TCU to the College Football Playoff National Championship Game in 2022, but he has achieved modest results since. In 2023, the hangover from a deep run resulted in a 5-7 season. Dykes did, however, rebound to post back-to-back 9-4 seasons. This year, the expectations are much higher. TCU is looking to contend for the Big 12 title, as 13 players who started in 2025 are projected to start for a Horned Frogs team that has also recruited and developed at a high level. Dykes also did well in bringing in Harvard transfer Jaden Craig to replace Josh Hoover, who transferred to Indiana.

In reading the tea leaves with people who cover this team — or generally analyze college football — you'd think this team is live to rack up double-digit wins. However, the Horned Frogs have some tricky schedule spots this year, and some of the holes on defense could hold the team back quite a bit.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
TCU's season-opening game against North Carolina will be huge. That matchup in Dublin will tell us a lot about the new-look Horned Frogs, but a loss there would mean curtains for the Over. TCU plays several tough road games, as the team will go on the road to battle UCF, Baylor, Arizona, and Texas Tech. The Horned Frogs also host BYU and Utah, which are two of the best teams in the Big 12. There might be a lot of buzz surrounding this TCU squad, but the schedule is tough, the overhaul of the offense feels a bit ambitious, and having uncertainty at linebacker could be a bit problematic. The Under seems like the play here.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-5-1 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Sonny Dykes - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	VS. NORTH CAROLINA (-6.4)	44.5
9/12	GRAMBLING (-53.8)	1.5
9/19	ARKANSAS ST (-21.1)	33.5
9/26	AT UCF (-3.3)	44.5
10/3	BYU (+3.5)	57.5
10/17	AT BAYLOR (-2.4)	47.0
10/24	WEST VIRGINIA (-9.7)	45.0
10/31	KANSAS (-8.6)	46.0
11/6	AT ARIZONA (+4.2)	52.5
11/14	KANSAS ST (-3.5)	51.0
11/21	UTAH (+0.20)	54.5
11/26	AT TEXAS TECH (+14.4)	61.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 43.79
#55 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 3.5 / 0
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

6

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What will TCU look like with Gordon Sammis as offensive coordinator?

Sammis is coming off a very successful stint as UConn’s OC. The Huskies were actually sixth in the nation in EPA/Play (0.13) last year, according to Game on Paper. However, there’s a good chance this looks nothing like a standard Dykes team. We usually see the Air Raid from TCU, but Sammis runs a pro-style offense. The timing could be perfect though. Hoover is no longer under center for the Horned Frogs, so hitting the field and slinging the ball around for an hour is no longer an option. Instead, TCU will look to get more out of a massive offensive line and a good group of running backs. That doesn’t mean the Horned Frogs won’t be throwing, but this should be a more physical football team.

How much will the team miss Hoover?

Hoover threw some bad interceptions, but he was a spectacular quarterback for Dykes. In 2024, he threw for 3,949 yards with 27 touchdowns and 11 picks. He then threw for 3,472 yards with 29 touchdowns and 13 picks last year. TCU will have a different look without Hoover’s massive arm, but Craig should be productive in the Big 12. The Harvard transfer doesn’t have the same aggressiveness as Hoover, but he’s less mistake-prone and offers more mobility. His job will be to distribute the ball to TCU’s playmakers, and this team has plenty of them — including talented wideout Jordan Dwyer.

Is there a world in which TCU is a top-25 defense?

With the Horned Frogs moving away from a high-octane spread offense, being better defensively is a must. Last year, TCU was just outside the nation’s top 50 in EPA/Play and Adjusted EPA/Play at Game on Paper. This year’s team needs to be closer to the top 25. The defensive line should be a strength, and the secondary is absolutely loaded. The biggest question mark is the linebacking corps, which mostly features first-time starters. If defensive coordinator Andy Avalos doesn’t get consistent play from his linebackers, the Horned Frogs could be in for a disappointing season.

250-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

12-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

30-1

BIG 12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.8	34
YARDS PER POINT	14	53
PLAYS PER GAME	71.5	40
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:20	88
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.1%	26
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	415.8	26
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	32
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34	82
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	131.7	94
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	96
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.7	20
COMPLETION %	65.7%	26
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	284.2	11
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	31
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.7	63
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	67
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.8%	43
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	372.5	60
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	54
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	129.4	32
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	31
COMPLETION %	60.5%	48
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	243.1	105
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	79
SACKS	1.7	94
TURNOVERS	1.8	21

TEXAS TECH

RED RAIDERS



Texas Tech was a wagon last season. While the Red Raiders got shut out when they faced Oregon in the College Football Playoff, they ran through the Big 12 regular season — with their only loss coming in a road game at Arizona State, when starting quarterback Behren Morton was hurt — and finished seventh in the country in Net Adjusted EPA/Play (+0.17) at Game on Paper.

Head coach Joey McGuire is fishing with dynamite when it comes to navigating the transfer portal. Texas Tech has as deep a funding pool as any program in the country, so this team is constantly able to load up on big-time performers. This offseason was no different, so the Red Raiders will be loaded again.

Texas Tech enters this season with 15 players who started in 2025, so talent and experience won't be issues. However, that number should have been 16, as the Red Raiders were supposed to have Brendan Sorsby. The star quarterback was one of the biggest prizes in the transfer portal, but he's ineligible to play college football this year after being caught betting on sports earlier in his career.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 10.5
Suggesting Texas Tech will win 11 games at nearly -200 odds is a tough sell, but it is pretty likely the team reaches that number. Even without an elite signal-caller, this team is absolutely loaded. The schedule is also extremely weak. The toughest road game the Red Raiders will play is at Baylor, and it's just hard to imagine them losing to Houston, Arizona State, and TCU at home. Don't be surprised if Tech cruises to the College Football Playoff. That's where disappointing quarterback play and the slightest dip on defense could burn them.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 11-3 ATS, 5-9 O-U
Head Coach: Joey McGuire - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	ABILENE CHRISTIAN (-39)	26.0
9/12	AT OREGON ST (-26)	32.0
9/18	HOUSTON (-12.2)	53.0
9/26	SAM HOUSTON ST (-47)	18.5
10/3	AT COLORADO (-15.8)	43.0
10/17	ARIZONA ST (-15.4)	49.5
10/24	AT CINCINNATI (-15.1)	44.5
10/31	ARIZONA (-12.4)	52.5
11/7	WEST VIRGINIA (-20.6)	45.0
11/14	AT OKLAHOMA ST (-13)	46.5
11/21	AT BAYLOR (-12.9)	47.0
11/2	TCU (-14.4)	51.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **41.18**
#69 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / 0**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

15

7

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Should Will Hammond be the starter for a top-tier team?

Hammond had some solid games last season. He actually went on the road and threw for 169 yards with two touchdowns and no picks in a beatdown of Utah, and he added 61 yards on the ground in that one. However, Texas Tech was not planning to start him this season, and being handed the keys to a championship-caliber team is a massive responsibility. Are we sure he can handle that right now? Hammond was a four-star recruit out of high school, he's athletic, and he's pretty accurate. But he's also inexperienced, he's coming off a torn ACL, and this coaching staff probably wanted him on the bench another year or two. That leaves some uncertainty at the most important position on the field.

Will there be a significant dropoff in offensive line play?

Texas Tech lost two starters from last year's line, including second-team All-Big 12 guard Davion Carter. The Red Raiders weren't able to bring in any clear starters to replace them either. That means this team will be relying on part-time starters who transferred in, or on younger players. That isn't exactly a deathblow, but the line is going to need to be excellent in order for Hammond to play at a high level. The group up front also needs to be ready to open up big holes for star running back Cameron Dickey. If Texas Tech's blocking isn't as good as it was last year, that's one of the few things that can derail the season.

Do the Red Raiders have another top-five defensive season in them?

Last year, Texas Tech was first in the nation in Game on Paper's Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.25), fifth in Yards Per Play Allowed (5.6), and first in Havoc Rate (19.3%). The Red Raiders also allowed fewer points per game (11.8) than all but two teams in the country. Texas Tech looked impenetrable for most of last season, and many of the top players from that unit are gone — including No. 2 overall pick David Bailey. However, McGuire loves some of the young pieces that will have bigger roles in 2026, Austin Romaine and Brice Pollock are both back, and the team added a legitimate star in Miami (Ohio) transfer Adam Trick. Shiel Wood has also proven to be a fantastic defensive play-caller. The Red Raiders should be pretty special on this side of the ball again.

ODDS TO WIN...

22-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-200****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****-105****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	37.3	7
YARDS PER POINT	11.9	5
PLAYS PER GAME	77	5
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:35	47
3RD DOWN CONV. %	48.8%	10
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	443.6	16
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	39
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.1	28
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	170.5	42
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	66
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.9	26
COMPLETION %	64.5%	39
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	273.2	19
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	37
TURNOVERS	1.4	82
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	12.2	2
YARDS PER POINT	21.8	3
3RD DOWN CONV. %	30.0%	6
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	264.8	2
YARDS PER PLAY	3.9	1
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	69.9	1
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.2	1
COMPLETION %	59.8%	36
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	194.9	24
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.6	5
SACKS	2.8	13
TURNOVERS	2.4	2

UCF KNIGHTS



The first time Scott Frost took the UCF job, he needed only two years to turn an 0-12 team into a 13-0 team. This time around, no one is expecting that type of turnaround. However, Frost did win five games in 2025, improving on the team's 4-8 season under Gus Malzahn in 2024. Things also happen to be moving in the right direction in recruiting and transfer portal hunting.

There's a solid buzz in Orlando right now, and Frost is now looking to get the Knights back to a bowl game. After having only 10 returning starters last season, UCF has 13 heading into this season. Frost also happened to upgrade some key spots. If the Knights can prevail in some 50-50 road games, this could turn into a great season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5

UCF should be bowl bound this year, making the Over the right play when thinking about the win total. The Knights really should earn wins over Bethune-Cookman, Georgia State, and Iowa State, and the following games all seem winnable: at Pitt, vs. TCU, at Oklahoma State, vs. Baylor, at Kansas, vs. Arizona State, at Colorado. Picking up wins in three of those seven is all UCF needs to hit the six-win mark. That seems extremely reasonable given the talent on this roster.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 4-8 ATS, 6-6 O-U

Head Coach: Scott Frost - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	BETHUNE-COOKMAN (-44.5)	3.0
9/12	AT PITTSBURGH (+10)	50.5
9/19	GEORGIA ST (-24.8)	23.0
9/26	TCU (+3.3)	51.0
10/3	AT HOUSTON (+10.8)	53.0
10/10	AT OKLAHOMA ST (+4.7)	46.5
10/24	BYU (+10.3)	57.5
10/3	BAYLOR (-0.6)	47.0
11/7	AT KANSAS (+5.4)	46.0
11/14	ARIZONA ST (+2.3)	49.5
11/20	IOWA ST (-5.9)	41.5
11/28	AT COLORADO (+1.9)	43.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **42.24**
#64 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / -0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

5

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How much better can the offensive line be?

The Knights lost four of last year's five starters, but they had one of the worst lines in the Big 12. A fresher look up front should be a good thing for this team, especially with Preston Cushman being the lone returnee. He was at Ole Miss two years ago, and having an SEC talent is always a nice thing. The Knights added two other full-time starters and another who played a good chunk of games. Connor Meadows is also back after starting a few games for the Knights at center late last season. This won't be one of the better lines in the Big 12, but this coaching staff is expecting the group to be better than it was last year.

Is this offense primed for a significant leap?

If the offensive line holds up its end of the bargain, UCF's offense should look a little more like the 2017 UCF offense. The quarterback situation was a mess last year, but it should be a strength in 2026. Alonza Barnett III threw for 2,806 yards with 23 touchdowns and eight picks for a good JMU team last year, and he also rushed for 589 yards and 15 scores. He's a high-level dual-threat signal-caller, and he's also a leader and a proven winner. The Knights also happen to have a ton of talent at the skill positions, with Duane Thomas and Dylan Wade as two of their more dangerous pass-catching weapons. Josh Derry is also an intriguing wideout, as he lit up the FCS with Monmouth last season.

How does DC Alex Grinch follow up a solid Year 1 showing in Orlando?

UCF only allowed 23.6 points per game last season, lowering the number from the 26.9 the team gave up in 2024. Grinch has had an up-and-down career as a defensive coordinator, but he did a very good job with last year's team. The passing defense was especially impressive, with the Knights allowing only 185.0 yards per game through the air. UCF actually brings back four starters from that secondary, so the passing defense should be a strength again. The Knights also happened to bring back some studs in defensive tackle RJ Jackson and linebacker Lewis Carter. On top of that, the staff signed some instant-impact starters — some from the Group of Five and others from the Power Four. This unit should be solid this season, even if some of its numbers look slightly worse.

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****30-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****62-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.4	109
YARDS PER POINT	17.8	122
PLAYS PER GAME	68.4	66
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:27	50
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.1%	113
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	363.2	81
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	78
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.2	104
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140.9	79
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	54
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.5	32
COMPLETION %	62.3%	61
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222.3	68
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	102
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.1	60
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	85
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.5%	49
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	348.5	39
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	37
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	150.2	64
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	51
COMPLETION %	63.7%	87
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	198.3	29
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	42
SACKS	2.1	56
TURNOVERS	1	98

UTAH UTES

It's going to be strange seeing Utah without Kyle Whittingham. The two-time Pac-12 Coach of the Year has been with the Utes since 1994, and he did a good job of maintaining the standard of excellence that Urban Meyer put in place in his two years with the program (2003 and 2004). It is, however, Whittingham's right-hand man that is taking over in Utah, as longtime defensive coordinator Morgan Scalley, who has been with the program since 2007, will get his crack at the top job.

Scalley has been tremendous coaching up the Utes' defense, and there's no reason he can't continue the tradition of winning in Salt Lake City. This year's team is actually plenty talented, but the fact that Whittingham went to Michigan did make things interesting. Whittingham took offensive coordinator Jason Beck with him to Ann Arbor, and some players followed — including defensive stars John Henry Daley and Smith Snowden.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5
It's always incredibly difficult for road teams to win games at Rice-Eccles Stadium, and Utah definitely has some impressive top-end talent on both sides of the ball. However, the Utes lost a legendary coach in Whittingham, they seem weaker in the trenches than usual, and Dampier's arm abandoned him in big games last year. All of that makes it a little hard to buy into this team winning nine games. This team seems a little more likely to trip up in coin-flip games, or even lose some games you'd normally expect the Utes to win. The Arkansas game on September 12 should teach us quite a bit about the group.

2025 Record: 11-2 SU & 9-3-1 ATS, 9-4 O-U
Head Coach: Morgan Scalley - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	IDAHO (-38.5)	19.5
9/12	ARKANSAS (-12.4)	45.5
9/19	UTAH ST (-22.8)	36.5
9/26	AT IOWA ST (-10.5)	41.5
10/1	KANSAS (-12.6)	46.0
10/17	AT COLORADO (-9)	43.0
10/24	HOUSTON (-5.3)	53.0
10/31	AT CINCINNATI (-8.3)	44.5
11/7	BYU (-0.5)	57.5
11/14	AT ARIZONA (+0.5)	52.5
11/21	AT TCU (-0.20)	51.0
11/27	WEST VIRGINIA (-13.7)	45.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.39**
#58 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **4 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

8

OFFENSE

4*

DEFENSE

4

* = Returning QB



THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What's going on at the quarterback position?

Devon Dampier is back for the Utes after throwing for 2,490 yards with 24 touchdowns and only five interceptions last year. He also rushed for 835 yards and 10 scores. Dampier is a dynamic dual-threat option under center, and he showed some minor improvements in accuracy during his first season with Utah. However, this team is going to give Byrd Ficklin snaps to see what he can do. At times, this approach will be tough for opponents to stop, but what happens when Utah faces elite defenses? As the saying goes, "when you have two quarterbacks, you really have none." Will the Utes be able to consistently convert in key third-and-long situations? If not, their schedule could get the better of them.

Will the offensive line be this team's Achilles heel?

Utah normally has big, burly dudes along the offensive line, and blocking is rarely an issue with this program. However, the Utes don't return a single starter from last year's team, and the only projected starter who was consistently starting games in 2025 is Montana State transfer Cedric Jefferson. Utah does have some impressive young pieces to play up front this year, including true freshman Kelvin Obot. He looks the part of a future pro. But there's nothing that suggests this will be one of the better units in the Big 12, and this offense won't look great without strong blocking.

Is this defense good enough for the Utes to compete at the highest level?

It's brutal that Scalley was this team's defensive coordinator last year, yet the team wasn't able to keep Snowden and Henry Daley around. The Utes now enter the season with some major concerns on defense, which is quite new for a program that is consistently excellent on this side of the ball. Utah only has four returning starters in the projected lineup, and it's the defensive line and linebackers that look shaky. The Utes should be extremely tough to throw against, but will they be able to stop the run? That's looking like a potential weakness, and being unable to stop opponents from picking up chunk yardage has a trickle-down effect that impacts the secondary.

100-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+350****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+650****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	39.5	4
YARDS PER POINT	12.2	9
PLAYS PER GAME	74	12
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:45	43
3RD DOWN CONV. %	51.2%	4
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	480	4
YARDS PER PLAY	6.5	12
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	44.1	7
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	265.8	2
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	6	1
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.8	98
COMPLETION %	61.7%	64
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	214.3	81
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	52
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.8	16
YARDS PER POINT	18.8	7
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.6%	37
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	370.3	57
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	46
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	190.8	112
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	114
COMPLETION %	49.4%	1
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	179.5	14
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.1	10
SACKS	2.6	23
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

WEST VIRGINIA MOUNTAINEERS



Rich Rodriguez went 4-8 in his return to West Virginia. It wasn't the greatest season in the world, but his team won the Backyard Brawl against Pittsburgh and hung around in some games against good teams. Now, with a more talented roster and a much easier schedule, people are expecting the Mountaineers to flirt with bowl eligibility.

After having only 10 returning starters heading into last season, Rodriguez has 12 entering the 2026 season. West Virginia did well by adding some big-time transfer talent on offense, so this team should be a bit harder to stop. However, this was a shaky team on the defensive side of the ball last year. If the Mountaineers' defense can't find ways to consistently get off the field, Year 2 of the Rich Rod return won't be much better than Year 1.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

West Virginia should get off to a 2-0 start, as the team will take on Coastal Carolina and Tennessee-Martin. From there, things get a little tougher. The Mountaineers will face a tough Virginia team before hosting Oklahoma State to kick off the Big 12 season. The outcome of that meeting with the Cowboys could determine whether they go Over or Under 5.5. The lean here is Under, though. Hawkins is a good running quarterback, but he has been underwhelming as a passer. Also, this defense needs to be much better after getting torched last year. If not, the offense needs to be flat-out special, which doesn't seem likely.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 7-5 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Rich Rodriguez - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	COASTAL CAROLINA (-20.1)	28.0
9/12	TENN-MARTIN (-33.2)	14.5
9/19	VS. VIRGINIA (+6.2)	50.5
9/26	OKLAHOMA ST (-2.1)	46.5
10/3	AT IOWA ST (-0.6)	41.5
10/10	ARIZONA (+5.2)	52.5
10/17	CINCINNATI (-3.6)	44.5
10/24	AT TCU (+9.7)	51.0
11/7	AT TEXAS TECH (+20.6)	61.5
11/14	KANSAS (-1.9)	46.0
11/21	HOUSTON (+5.4)	53.0
11/27	AT UTAH (+13.7)	54.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.94**
#44 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.8 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the Mountaineers get any better defensively?

West Virginia allowed 30.8 points per game last year, and the team was also just 64th in the nation in Adjusted EPA/Play Allowed (-0.01). The Mountaineers are going to need to be much better in 2026, and that's especially true when looking at the passing defense. They gave up 265.0 yards per game through the air last season, ranking 129th in FBS. West Virginia looked to address the weak passing defense by adding some bigger corners from smaller programs, and the team also looks a bit better at safety. However, it's still hard to fully buy into a complete turnaround here, and the team looks weak along the defensive line. So, anything the Mountaineers gain defending the pass could be given back defending the run.

What can be expected from some of these offensive pieces?

Michael Hawkins should be a good quarterback in the Rich Rod offense. He undoubtedly has room to improve as a thrower, but he's an electric runner and made some big plays at Oklahoma. The Mountaineers also added Cam Cook from Jacksonville State. Last season, Cook rushed for 1,659 yards and 16 touchdowns. He should be one of the best running backs in the conference this year, giving West Virginia a running element the team lacked in 2025. An improved offensive line should also help there. The only position group that leaves a bit to be desired is the wide receiver room. It's unclear who will step up and make plays for Hawkins on money downs. The best bet is probably Jaden Bray.

Will special teams be a problem for West Virginia?

Western Kentucky transfer Jack Cassidy is set to be the kicker for the Mountaineers, but he's just 3 of 3 on field goals in his career. He did go 2 of 2 on 50+ yarders, so he clearly has a leg. But it'll be interesting to see how he handles the pressure of playing for a massive program. If he can't, Alabama transfer Peter Notaro will get his crack at it. We'll also have to see how Bryan Hansen looks playing outside of Colorado. He averaged 47.9 yards per punt last season, so he has performed at a high level before. But it's easier to kick for distance at that altitude. Let's see how he looks in Morgantown.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****40-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****50-1****BIG 12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.6	114
YARDS PER POINT	16.5	110
PLAYS PER GAME	72.9	22
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:29	131
3RD DOWN CONV. %	28.6%	133
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	324.5	111
YARDS PER PLAY	4.5	128
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.7	15
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	139.5	81
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	124
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.6	104
COMPLETION %	57.2%	114
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	185	106
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	94
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.4	118
YARDS PER POINT	13	111
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	71
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	435.4	118
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	89
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	152.2	67
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	36
COMPLETION %	66.9%	120
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	283.2	132
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.5	123
SACKS	2.3	41
TURNOVERS	1.6	31

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BIG TEN

Preview

previews by Wes Reynolds

The Big Ten is aiming for its fourth consecutive CFP National Championship here in 2026. In 2023, Michigan won its first national title since 1997 before Jim Harbaugh left his alma mater and took his NCAA show-cause penalty to return to coaching in the NFL. In 2024, the Wolverines' archrival Ohio State, led by the most talented roster in college football, removed the critics from Ryan Day's back and won its first national title since 2014. Well, the Big Ten "three-peated" last season. So, was it Ohio State again? Michigan? Penn State? Oregon? USC? No, it was the Indiana Hoosiers going 16-0 and becoming the first FBS team since Yale in 1894 to go 16-0.

Curt Cignetti and his Hoosiers also won their first outright Big Ten Championship since 1945. Indiana's rise to national prominence not only included these championships but was also home to its first Heisman Trophy Winner Fernando Mendoza. Indiana (+250) will attempt to defend with heavy retention on the offensive line and defense to go along with a portal overhaul that includes TCU transfer QB Josh Hoover to replace Mendoza.

Ohio State (+180), defeated by the Hoosiers in the Big Ten Championship Game, returns QB Julian Sayin and WR Jeremiah Smith as perhaps the best QB-WR tandem in college football. Oregon (+260), who lost to the Hoosiers twice, brings back 14 starters including QB Dante Moore and arguably the nation's best defensive line.

Those three teams will be consensus top five nationally to start the season, but USC (14-1) is looking to get to the top of the Big Ten for the first time with a defense led by former TCU coach Gary Patterson, who was lured out of retirement.

Four programs have new coaches including Michigan (15-1), who brings in Kyle Whittingham from Utah to restore its tarnished image from the Harbaugh recruiting violations and the Sherrone Moore scandal; Michigan State (500-1), who turns to former Northwestern head coach Pat Fitzgerald; Penn State (20-1), who brings in Matt Campbell from Iowa State to win the big ones that James Franklin seemingly never could; UCLA (160-1), who figured that if Indiana can hire a successful head coach from James Madison, then why not do the same with Bob Chesney?

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
OREGON	10.5	68.5	3.9	0.9	47.28 (28)	10.3	1.7	7.4	1.6
OHIO ST	9.5	71	3.8	0.2	50.07 (10)	10.0	2.0	7.4	1.6
INDIANA	10.5	66	3.8	0.2	43.83 (54)	10.2	1.8	7.2	1.8
PENN ST	8.5	57	3.1	0.8	44.01 (50)	9.3	2.7	6.4	2.6
USC	8.5	60	3.8	-0.5	49.41 (16)	8.3	3.7	5.4	3.6
MICHIGAN	7.5	59	2.7	0.8	50.94 (6)	7.8	4.2	5.3	3.7
IOWA	7.5	55.5	3.1	0.7	44.91 (45)	8.1	3.9	5.3	3.7
WASHINGTON	7.5	56.5	3.9	-0.5	47.12 (29)	7.9	4.1	5.0	4.0
ILLINOIS	7.5	51	3.3	0.9	46.05 (36)	7.3	4.7	4.7	4.3
WISCONSIN	6.5	47.5	1.4	-0.2	45.33 (43)	6.1	5.9	4.1	4.9
UCLA	6.5	48	1.4	0.3	48.46 (25)	5.9	6.1	3.8	5.2
MINNESOTA	5.5	49	3.6	-0.7	45.38 (42)	6.3	5.7	3.7	5.3
NEBRASKA	6.5	50.5	2.3	0.1	49.2 (17)	6.3	5.7	3.5	5.5
MARYLAND	5.5	45.5	2.1	-0.3	45.81 (39)	5.4	6.6	3.3	5.7
NORTHWESTERN	5.5	45.5	2.1	0	50.04 (11)	4.9	7.1	2.4	6.6
MICHIGAN ST	4.5	42.5	1.2	-0.1	50.49 (8)	4.0	8.0	2.4	6.6
RUTGERS	5.5	42.5	2.1	0	43.86 (53)	4.9	7.1	2.3	6.7
PURDUE	3.5	39	1.5	-0.4	50.47 (9)	2.9	9.1	1.5	7.5

ILLINOIS

FIGHTING ILLINI



Illinois won 19 games over the course of the last two seasons, which was the most in program history over a two-year span. Three-year starting QB Luke Altmyer was largely responsible for those victories, but he has graduated and four offensive line starters also depart due to graduation or transfer portal. Katin Houser returns to the Big Ten (Michigan State) after starting for the better part of two seasons at East Carolina, where he went 13-6 as a starter.

The Illini prides itself on playing old-school, physical Big Ten football under Bret Bielema, but they ranked just 13th in the conference running the football (138.1 YPG) and ranked 12th in scoring defense (23.6 PPG). Defensive coordinator Aaron Henry left for a job on the Notre Dame staff and Bobby Hauck, after a successful eight-year second act as Montana head coach, comes in to reinvent what was a stale Illinois defense.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

The schedule is manageable and the Illini should start with three non-conference victories playing UAB, Duke, and Southern Illinois at home. While they avoid Indiana, USC, Penn State, and Michigan, Illinois does open the Big 10 campaign at Ohio State. Aside from the Buckeyes, the rest of the road schedule is not all that arduous, going to Maryland and facing two teams with new coaches – Michigan State and Northwestern. Oregon will be a likely home loss, and they do have three of the last four at home, but all in coin flip games – Nebraska, Iowa, and Northwestern – where they more than likely must win all three to get to eight victories. The rebuilding of both lines up front will not be able to be completed in just one season.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 8-4-1 ATS, 5-8 O-U

Head Coach: Bret Bielema - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	UAB (-29.4)	26.0
9/12	DUKE (-7.2)	46.5
9/19	S ILLINOIS (-24)	30.5
9/26	AT OHIO ST (+22.9)	71.0
10/3	PURDUE (-15.7)	39.0
10/10	AT MICHIGAN ST (-8.2)	42.5
10/24	OREGON (+15.1)	68.5
10/31	AT MARYLAND (-4.3)	45.5
11/6	NEBRASKA (-3.7)	50.5
11/13	AT UCLA (-2.5)	48.0
11/21	IOWA (+1.9)	55.5
11/28	AT NORTHWESTERN (-4.3)	45.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **46.05**
#36 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.3 / 0.9**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

7

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Katin Houser's second stint in the Big Ten go better than his first?

After a redshirt year in 2022, Katin Houser could not win the starting job at Michigan State over Noah Kim, who later transferred to Coastal Carolina and finished last year at Eastern Michigan, so he transferred to East Carolina. Houser became the full-time starter for ECU last year and threw for 3300 yards (65.9% completions) and 19 TDs while also rushing for nine. He has a better group around him in Champaign than he did in East Lansing three years ago, but this is a new system, and he is behind an offensive line that must replace four starters.

Can Illinois get more physical up front?

While the offensive line must replace four starters, including first-team All-Big Ten tackle J.C. Davis, last year's group struggled to run the football consistently and looked overmatched against the better defensive lines they faced including Duke, Indiana, Ohio State, and Wisconsin as they gave up an average of five sacks to those units. Bielema feels good about his backfield as they moved second-leading rusher Kaden Feagin to tight end, and he is one of the better OL evaluators and developers in the country but only imported one Power Four transfer (C Jake Renfro – Wisconsin).

How quickly can they adjust to Bobby Hauck's new 3-3-5 defense?

Hauck's Montana teams ranked in the top 20 for scoring defense and inside the top 10 for takeaways amongst FCS teams in three of the last five seasons. The main attrition comes on the defensive line where five rotational players, including second-round pick DE Gabe Jacas, are being replaced by Group of Six or FCS talent. This unit is the biggest question mark on the roster, but the secondary is not, with four returning senior starters including All-Big Ten free safety Xavier Scott. While the Illini rated just 14th in the conference for pass defense, this defensive backfield is one of the better ones in the league and a new scheme could catch opponents by surprise.

ODDS TO WIN...

200-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****22-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****200-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.5	58
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	38
PLAYS PER GAME	66.9	89
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:45	42
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.0%	41
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	368.3	79
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	62
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.1	69
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	132.2	92
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	100
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.2	93
COMPLETION %	66.6%	20
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	236.2	56
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	25
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.3	62
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	77
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.8%	122
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	361	49
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	55
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	135.6	40
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	58
COMPLETION %	64.8%	102
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	225.4	69
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	44
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

INDIANA HOOSIERS



Indiana football begins "Chapter 3" as Curt Cignetti calls it on the heels of becoming the first team in the modern era to go 16-0 and win the National Championship. Unfortunately for Cignetti's program, there is already a famous movie titled "Hoosiers" because last season is certainly worthy of having its story told in a film as the longtime doormat of the Big Ten became a college football powerhouse.

Despite the loss of Heisman Trophy Winner and No. 1 overall NFL Draft pick Fernando Mendoza, along with seven other draft picks (eight in all, the program record) and eight UFAs, the cupboard is not bare. Indiana is not going the way of a one-hit wonder, as they are priced at -350 to return to the CFP. Cignetti kept his staff intact plus returns 10 starters (six on defense for Broyles Award winning defensive coordinator Bryant Haines) and adds eight other Power Four starters by way of the portal, including TCU QB Josh Hoover, the current active FBS passing leader with 9,629 yards and 71 touchdowns in 36 games (31 starts), who will start behind arguably the best offensive line in college football.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 10.5

10.5 is the right number for Indiana's win total when you look at another manageable schedule where the Hoosiers avoid a double revenge spot with Oregon (perhaps until the Big 10 Championship Game) and will be favored in every game apart from Ohio State (small home dog). Indiana is likely to return to the College Football Playoff for a third consecutive season under Cignetti (27-2 in two years), but there are a couple of tricky spots (at Nebraska, at Washington, vs. USC) where they can lose a close one. The Hoosiers are also +37 in turnover margin over the last two seasons and at some point, one would think that would regress to the mean at least a little bit. Going over 10.5 is buying at the top of the market, but all Cignetti does is win. Google him!

2025 Record: 16-0 SU & 10-6 ATS, 10-6 O-U

Head Coach: Curt Cignetti - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	NORTH TEXAS (-35.2)	34.5
9/12	HOWARD (-66.6)	3.5
9/19	W KENTUCKY (-33.1)	36.5
9/25	NORTHWESTERN (-24.3)	45.5
10/3	AT RUTGERS (-21.6)	42.5
10/10	AT NEBRASKA (-13.4)	50.5
10/17	OHIO ST (+1.4)	71.0
10/24	AT MICHIGAN (-4.5)	59.0
10/31	MINNESOTA (-21.5)	49.0
11/14	USC (-10.3)	60.0
11/21	AT WASHINGTON (-5.8)	56.5
11/28	PURDUE (-31.2)	39.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.83**
#54 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.8 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

16

OFFENSE

7

DEFENSE

9

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Hoover handle it?

“Hoover can handle it” was the 1989 ad slogan for the Hoover appliance company. Josh Hoover was 19-12 as a productive starter at TCU and has shown that he can fling the football. What he has not always shown is the ability to take care of the football, having amassed 33 turnovers in 36 career games. Based on the last two seasons in Bloomington, that turnover habit has a good chance of being rectified, considering no team has fewer giveaways over the last two seasons in FBS than Indiana (17). Hoover does not have the size nor is he the athlete that Mendoza was, so Cignetti and offensive coordinator Mike Shanahan will likely run less RPO than the Hoosiers did last season.

Production AND potential?

One of the more notable Coach Cig-isms is his fondness for saying “production over potential”. His team loses a lot of offensive production with not only Mendoza, but the top two receivers, including first-rounder Omar Cooper Jr., and the top two rushers. There is still talent at receiver with Charlie Becker (Charlie B from Nashville, Tennessee as constantly described by FOX’s Gus Johnson) and Michigan State transfer Nick Marsh (1311 yards, nine TDs L2Y) and at running back with Khobie Martin (508 yards, six TDs) and Turbo Richard (1027 yards, 11 TDs L2Y at Boston College). The skill position talent could be better for Indiana, but the losses, primarily those who came with Cig from James Madison, were strong culture guys.

How will the Hoosiers handle being the ‘Hunted’ instead of being the ‘Hunter’?

Indiana has always been a game circled on opponents’ schedules typically because they always seemed to be the Homecoming game. Now, the Hoosiers are circled because everyone gets up for the defending National Champions. Cignetti will continue to operate with a bit of a chip on his shoulder to prove that last season was not a fluke. Because they are Indiana there will be a lot of doubters that they can make another run in the CFP, which is probably how Cignetti and the Hoosiers like it. Is the program culture strong enough to sustain or was it just “lightning in a bottle”?

ODDS TO WIN...

+800**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-350****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+250****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	39.5	3
YARDS PER POINT	11.1	3
PLAYS PER GAME	68.1	69
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:28	5
3RD DOWN CONV. %	55.5%	1
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	437.1	21
YARDS PER PLAY	6.4	15
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.3	20
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	207.3	13
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	22
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.1	120
COMPLETION %	70.7%	3
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	229.8	64
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.2	6
TURNOVERS	0.5	3
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	12.5	3
YARDS PER POINT	22.3	1
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.3%	8
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	278.6	6
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	17
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	79.7	3
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	11
COMPLETION %	62.3%	67
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	198.9	30
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	23
SACKS	2.7	19
TURNOVERS	2	7

IOWA HAWKEYES



The 2025 season was the usual for Iowa football, as the Hawkeyes had yet another winning season (9-4) and have had 13 of them in a row under Kirk Ferentz, who enters his 28th season in Iowa City as the Big Ten's longest-tenured coach. In fact, he passed Woody Hayes last season as the conference's all-time winningest coach.

Iowa is the model of consistency, but with the success of Indiana, the pressure is even greater from programs like theirs to get more. Last season, the Hawkeyes lost one-score games to Indiana, Oregon, and USC, so it is fair for them to wonder what might have been. This season, Iowa replaces 27 seniors (16 of them starters) and the roster has the largest turnover of the Ferentz era. The Hawkeyes have always relied on development, but you cannot exclusively rely on that today as they add a program-record 16 transfers this season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5
With all the question marks on the roster, 7.5 wins is the correct total here, so there is not much of a true betting edge. The schedule begins with three non-conference home games, but two of them are against in-state rivals Iowa State and Northern Iowa. It gets more challenging with trips to Michigan and Washington and a home game vs. Ohio State sandwiched in between. The second half of the schedule is substantially more manageable. Ferentz has never won fewer than eight games in a season since 2015 save for the COVID season in 2020 and 2023 with two vacated wins due to tampering with former QB Cade McNamara before he officially entered the portal. He and his staff get the benefit of the doubt, even with an inexperienced QB and many new faces on defense and special teams.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 9-3-1 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Kirk Ferentz - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	N ILLINOIS (-36.6)	21.5
9/12	IOWA ST (-16.8)	41.5
9/19	N IOWA (-42.6)	16.5
9/26	AT MICHIGAN (+5.5)	59.0
10/3	OHIO ST (+12.6)	71.0
10/9	AT WASHINGTON (+4.2)	56.5
10/24	AT MINNESOTA (-3.6)	49.0
10/31	WISCONSIN (-11.3)	47.5
11/7	AT NORTHWESTERN (-8.6)	45.5
11/14	PURDUE (-20)	39.0
11/21	AT ILLINOIS (-1.9)	51.0
11/27	NEBRASKA (-8)	50.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.91**
#45 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.1 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

5

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who starts at quarterback?

Iowa has had to dip into the portal to find its starting QB for the last few seasons. Last season, it was Mark Gronowski coming in from winning two FCS National Championships at North Dakota State. Now Gronowski and his 58 career wins as a starter are gone and offensive coordinator Tim Lester has two candidates that were in the program last year – Hank Brown, who started one game for Auburn two years ago, or Jeremy Hecklinski, who has two passing attempts in his career. Whoever wins the job must provide a jolt to a passing offense that has rated 129th, 130th, and 130th in the FBS in the last three seasons. More than likely, Iowa relies on its running game behind a talented offensive line and its running back tandem of Kamari Moulton (878 yards, five TDs) and South Dakota transfer L.J. Phillips (1920 yards, 19 TDs in 2025).

Can Phil Parker rebuild the Iowa defense again?

The default answer is ‘yes’ as the long-time defensive coordinator is considered one of the best in the game. The Hawkeyes stop unit ranked inside the top 10 nationally last season in scoring defense, passing defense, and total defense, plus the rush defense (17th) was not too shabby either. However, just three starters return and six of the top eight defensive linemen are gone. Safety Zach Lutmer (71 tackles, three INTs) is the star of the unit. There is inexperience here, but Parker was rightfully given the benefit of the doubt long ago.

Will Iowa's special teams remain special?

Aside from the roster attrition, arguably the biggest loss for Iowa could be special teams coordinator LeVar Woods, who has been on Ferentz's staff since 2008, and served in the coordinator role since 2018. Woods is now in the same role and the assistant head coach for Pat Fitzgerald's new staff at Michigan State. Chris Polizzi was promoted to the new role and has the task of keeping Iowa's annually elite special teams at that level. The first task is to find a replacement for two-time All-Big Ten return specialist Kaden Wetjen and replacing both his kicker and punter.

ODDS TO WIN...

120-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+900****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****60-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.9	42
YARDS PER POINT	11	2
PLAYS PER GAME	61.4	130
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:07	36
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.4%	45
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	316.9	118
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	87
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.5	43
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	165.8	54
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	50
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	22.5	128
COMPLETION %	63.3%	50
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	151.1	127
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	92
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	16.8	8
YARDS PER POINT	17.2	14
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.1%	31
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	289.3	9
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	11
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	113.3	21
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	21
COMPLETION %	58.4%	26
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	175.9	12
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.1	11
SACKS	1.9	69
TURNOVERS	1.2	81

MARYLAND TERRAPINS



Mike Locksley certainly must be considered on the hot seat after consecutive 4-8 campaigns. After a promising 4-0 start last season, the Terps lost each of their next three games by four points or less and the young team could not recover as it ended the year on an eight-game losing streak. This year, Maryland returns 71% of its production (second nationally to Notre Dame per ESPN's Bill Connelly).

Quarterback Malik Washington did about all you can ask for a true freshman starting in the Big Ten. He threw for just under 3000 yards on a 17/9 TD/INT ratio and ran for 4 TDs. Leading rusher DeJuan Williams (501 yards, three TDs) also returns along with four offensive line starts. Eight starters are also back for second-year defensive coordinator Ted Monachino's unit.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Locksley has always been a high-level recruiter, and he has brought big-time talent into the program and has kept DMV talent from leaving home, but he cannot live off the 23-16 three-season run (2021-2023) forever. This is a juicy price to lay at around -170 to -175, but the schedule is permissible early on with Hampton as the opener and then two games at UConn and vs. Virginia Tech, who both have new head coaches. The Terps do have trips to Ohio State and USC but also avoid Oregon, Indiana, and Michigan amongst the league's top teams. If they can go 3-0 in the non-conference like last season, they have a few winnable conference games (UCLA, Rutgers, Wisconsin, at Purdue) where they could get bowl-eligible and play a postseason game for the first time since 2023.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Mike Locksley - 8th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	HAMPTON (-50.6)	-3.0
9/12	AT CONNECTICUT (-9.8)	31.5
9/19	VIRGINIA TECH (+3.2)	51.0
9/26	UCLA (+0.7)	48.0
10/3	AT NEBRASKA (+7.6)	50.5
10/10	AT OHIO ST (+29.6)	71.0
10/17	RUTGERS (-5.1)	42.5
10/31	ILLINOIS (+4.3)	51.0
11/7	AT PURDUE (-4.7)	39.0
11/14	WISCONSIN (-0.3)	47.5
11/21	AT USC (+18.6)	60.0
11/28	PENN ST (+10.2)	57.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.81**
#39 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

16

OFFENSE

8*

DEFENSE

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How will Malik Washington take to the new offense?

Pep Hamilton moves to an advisor role and Clint Trickett takes over as offensive coordinator after spending last season in the same role at Jacksonville State. Trickett wants to implement more RPO and use Washington more as a runner. He will also look to increase the tempo with increased motion and more snaps. While the offensive line did not create many holes up front running the ball, they did only allow nine sacks. Washington can throw the ball all over the yard, but his receiving corps must be more reliable as they were plagued by drops all last season.

Can Maryland develop a running game?

The answer to that question in recent years is a definitive 'no' as the turtle has not needed to be feared on the ground since they had a 1000-yard rusher in 2022 (Roman Hemby, who later transferred to Indiana). Harry Dalton III was highly touted out of high school and transferred from USC to help Washington and Williams. Maryland ranked second-to-last in the Big Ten last year only averaging 104.3 yards per game (122nd nationally). Washington is a potential star, but this group needs more production for him to truly realize his potential.

Can the defense continue to progress under Monachino?

Monachino was on the Baltimore Ravens staff that won Super Bowl XLVII and he knows elite defensive talent, especially up front having coached Terrell Suggs and Elvis Dumervil. Maryland edge rushers Zahir Mathis and Sidney Stewart were both named freshmen-All Americans and now they are joined by five-star freshman Zion Elee out of Baltimore. Senior linebacker Daniel Wingate (102 tackles, 6.5 TFLs) leads the linebacker corps, and the talented secondary is led by strong safety Lavain Scruggs (64 tackles, two INTs) and Messiah Delhomme (39 tackles) will be counted on to replace third-round pick Jalen Huskey. The Terps can clearly get after the quarterback, but they have struggled in the middle at stopping the run.

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****60-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****500-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.6	102
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	108
PLAYS PER GAME	66.5	95
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:08	132
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.3%	88
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	355.1	87
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	77
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	23.8	136
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	101.3	124
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	67
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42	4
COMPLETION %	56.9%	118
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	253.8	34
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	121
TURNOVERS	1.2	56
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.4	75
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	52
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.2%	119
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	413.1	101
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	63
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	186.9	107
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	84
COMPLETION %	64.4%	98
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.2	72
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	58
SACKS	2.2	48
TURNOVERS	1.7	24

MICHIGAN WOLVERINES



Perhaps no program is undergoing more of a culture change than Michigan. It has been a turbulent two-year span in Ann Arbor. The program was subject to an NCAA investigation into recruiting violations and in-person scouting infractions towards the end of the Jim Harbaugh era. Then Harbaugh's successor Sherrone Moore was fired last December for an inappropriate relationship with a staff member. So, the Wolverines needed to hit Ctrl+Alt+Delete and reboot.

Enter Kyle Whittingham, who, at 66, leaves Utah after 21 seasons after compiling a 177-88 record. Whittingham and Utah mutually agreed to part ways, but he expressed the desire to continue coaching and then Michigan came open after the Moore scandal. The hire seemed to come a bit out of left field, but Whittingham seems to fit the identity of Michigan football. He is old-school, leads with the running game, and looks to establish being more physical and tough along the line of scrimmage on both sides of the ball.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

The cupboard is not bare for Whittingham in terms of the talent he inherits. On the other hand, he and his Wolverines get a "welcome to the Big Ten" schedule that has six ranked opponents on it and does not get to avoid any of the top teams in conference play. Whittingham is, without question, a proven winner, but this is still a program in some transition and one with a QB that still has a lot to prove before he can be given the benefit of the doubt.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 4-9 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Kyle Whittingham - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	W MICHIGAN (-24.5)	37.5
9/12	OKLAHOMA (-0.4)	61.0
9/19	UTEP (-39.4)	22.5
9/26	IOWA (-5.5)	55.5
10/3	AT MINNESOTA (-7.2)	49.0
10/17	PENN ST (-3.9)	57.0
10/24	INDIANA (+4.5)	66.0
10/31	AT RUTGERS (-15.2)	42.5
11/7	MICHIGAN ST (-19.3)	42.5
11/14	AT OREGON (+12.6)	68.5
11/21	UCLA (-13.4)	48.0
11/28	AT OHIO ST (+15)	71.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **50.94**
#6 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / 0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Bryce Underwood ready to take the next step?

Underwood is one of the most hyped recruits in the history of Michigan football. He started last year as a freshman and showed flashes of what made him the No. 1 ranked overall player nationally in the 2025 recruiting class. However, his numbers (2429 yards, 11/9 TD/INT, 60.3% completions, 392 rushing yards, six TDs) last year were largely underwhelming. On the surface, he should be improved just with better coaching and development under new offensive coordinator Jason Beck and QB coach Koy Detmer. Beck's power spread took New Mexico's offense from 44th to fourth nationally in 2024 and made even more progress last year at Utah going from 115th to fourth. The new staff wants Underwood to run more, but he does have help in that area with Jordan Marshall (932 yards, 10 TDs) and five-star freshman Savion Hiter behind an offensive line that returns four starters.

Can the defense be rebuilt?

Former Weber State head coach Jay Hill was the defensive coordinator for the last three years at BYU, Whittingham's alma mater, and improved the Cougars to a top-20 scoring defense last season. Michigan will run a 4-2-5 base with varied looks, blitzes, and a mix of both man and zone coverages. While this group looked ahead of the offense in the spring game, there is not much experience here. John Henry Daley (11.5 sacks) was a first-team All-American at Utah last year and helps shore up the defensive line. The secondary has a lot of talent with the return of starting corners Zeke Berry and Jyaire Hill, Rod Moore at safety, and the additions of nickel Smith Snowden (two INTs, nine PBU), who was All-Big 12 at Utah and Chris Bracy (81 tackles) from Memphis. The linebacker room remains a concern; expect opponents to attack Michigan over the middle until that group improves.

Will Whittingham be able to get higher-level talent to fit into his culture?

Whittingham clearly wants to restore Michigan to its long-standing identity of discipline, toughness, and physicality. He was able to do that at Utah, recruiting good and solid talent and developing them into something more. Now, he has four-stars, five-stars and ultimately a much higher ceiling in terms of pure talent. Whittingham has two decades of success that shows that his way works, but this is a different ball game at Michigan and he and his team will be tested immediately facing a difficult schedule with dates vs. Oklahoma, Iowa, Penn State, Indiana, at Oregon, and at Ohio State.

40-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+250

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

15-1

BIG TEN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.5	57
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	67
PLAYS PER GAME	66	103
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:47	74
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.6%	29
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	397.9	45
YARDS PER PLAY	6	25
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.2	38
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	211.2	11
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	5
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.2	113
COMPLETION %	59.4%	93
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	186.8	104
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	65
TURNOVERS	1.3	76
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.4	21
YARDS PER POINT	15.9	31
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.4%	48
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	323.5	22
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	23
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	112.2	17
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	18
COMPLETION %	63.6%	84
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	211.4	46
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	24
SACKS	2.2	53
TURNOVERS	1.5	43

MICHIGAN STATE SPARTANS



Jonathan Smith came to East Lansing as the man thought to be what was needed to get Sparty back to the success of the Mark Dantonio era. Two years later, after a 9-15 record (4-15 officially due to five vacated wins in 2024 courtesy of violations under Mel Tucker), Smith was out. Dantonio's teams at Michigan State were always defense-first and built on toughness, so Michigan State looked to the days of Big Ten past to find a coach that shares that same mentality and may have found it with Northwestern's all-time winningest coach Pat Fitzgerald.

Fitzgerald was terminated at his alma mater three years ago after significant hazing allegations in his program were reported. He later sued for wrongful termination, and the case was settled last August to clear a path for his return to coaching.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 3.5

It is worth laying -150 or so available in the market here. While there are certainly plenty of roster questions across the board, Sparty must feel as good about its QB situation as they have in the last few seasons. The market might be underestimating Fitzgerald's history as a proven program builder. Fitzgerald has also put together a good staff mixed with a couple holdovers for continuity's sake, plus younger coaches like former Spartan linebacker legend Max Bullough, Nick Tabacca as offensive line coach, and James Adams as safeties coach. The schedule is not easy with trips to Notre Dame and Michigan, but this team needed some new and positive energy and should respond to this new staff.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 7-5 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Pat Fitzgerald - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	TOLEDO (-8.7)	35.5
9/12	E MICHIGAN (-15.2)	28.0
9/19	AT NOTRE DAME (+29.9)	68.5
9/26	NEBRASKA (+6.9)	50.5
10/3	AT WISCONSIN (+6.5)	47.5
10/10	ILLINOIS (+8.2)	51.0
10/17	NORTHWESTERN (+1.8)	45.5
10/24	AT UCLA (+7)	48.0
11/7	AT MICHIGAN (+19.3)	59.0
11/14	WASHINGTON (+12.3)	56.5
11/20	OREGON (+25.7)	68.5
11/28	AT RUTGERS (+2.2)	42.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 50.49
#8 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 1.2 / -0.1
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Has Michigan State finally found its quarterback?

After Payton Thorne, with a large assist from eventual Super Bowl LX MVP running back Kenneth Walker, led them to an 11-2 season in 2021, it has been a revolving door at QB with neither Katin Houser nor Noah Kim nor Aidan Chiles able to lead the Spartans to success. Alessio Milivojevic, who was Mr. Backdoor Cover against Nebraska, Indiana, and Michigan last year, took over the starting job in the final four games of the season, as the Spartans went just 1-3, but two of the three losses were by three points. The backup QB is always the most popular player with the fans when the starter is struggling. He showed promise, but now can he be the full-time guy? Cam Fancher has 28 starts over the last four years combined at Marshall, Florida Atlantic, and UCF and he will push Milivojevic, but the incumbent (986 yards in four starts) should hold the job for Fitzgerald and new offensive coordinator Nick Sheridan, who comes in from the same role at Alabama.

Who is there for Milivojevic at wide receiver?

Michigan State's top three receivers from last season, including one of the big gets in the portal Nick Marsh (Indiana), are now gone. Chrishon McCray (24-320-2) is the leading returner but at 5-foot-10, he doesn't bring the typical size of a number one option. KK Smith (Notre Dame) and Fred Moore (Michigan) were never really featured at their former destinations so perhaps they have a new lease on life here. Redshirt freshman Braylon Collier could be the next outstanding receiver in East Lansing. Nevertheless, the running game led by UConn transfer Cam Edwards (1240 yards in 2025) will need to carry a heavier load.

Can they get better at the line of scrimmage?

Last year, Michigan State only had 22 sacks in 12 games, 86th nationally. This year, they only have one starter back on the defensive line. Fitzgerald will turn to NC State transfer Kenny Soares, who was with him at Northwestern, to spark a pass rush. On the offensive side, five transfers come in with 72 career starts including Trent Fraley, who was the FCS Rimington Award winner last year at North Dakota State. The Spartans OL gave up 72 sacks over the last two years, and they will need this portal group to come together quickly.

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****500-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.1	93
YARDS PER POINT	14.6	70
PLAYS PER GAME	67.5	80
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:10	59
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.1%	114
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	336.5	101
YARDS PER PLAY	5	104
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.5	102
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	118.2	107
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	104
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.7	58
COMPLETION %	62.5%	56
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	218.4	76
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	79
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.5	97
YARDS PER POINT	12.6	119
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.6%	84
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	382.6	69
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	98
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	152.3	68
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	89
COMPLETION %	65.7%	109
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	230.4	80
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	97
SACKS	1.8	76
TURNOVERS	0.7	123

MINNESOTA GOLDEN GOPHERS



P.J. Fleck is now in his 10th season of rowing the boat at Minnesota. The Gophers have gone to bowl games in seven of his nine seasons (7-0 in bowls) and have won eight or more games in four of the last five years. The boat is steady in the Land of 10,000 Lakes, but can it pick up a little speed to challenge the conference elite at least occasionally?

Minnesota returns 68% of its 2025 production per ESPN's Bill Connelly and is led by redshirt sophomore quarterback Drake Lindsey (63.5%, 2432 yards, 19/6 TD/INT), who started all 13 games as a freshman. Running back Darius Taylor missed nearly half of the season last year but has almost 2,500 yards in 28 career games for the Gophers. Including Taylor, three of the top four pass catchers are back plus six defensive starters as Minnesota remains a consistent upper half of the Big Ten program while being bottom half in terms of NIL.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

The Gophers get a break in the schedule avoiding Ohio State and Oregon but still must travel to Indiana, Penn State, and Washington. Lindsey has the potential to be a special QB in Minneapolis but still lacks a true No. 1 receiver (can Auburn transfer Perry Thompson fill that void?). They also have questions on the interior of both the offensive and defensive lines. In each of the last two years, Minnesota has defeated a ranked opponent as a home underdog – No. 25 Nebraska (2025) and No. 11 USC (2024). They will likely need to do the same against Michigan or Iowa in similar spots this year to once again eclipse this win total.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 5-7-1 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: P. J. Fleck - 10th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	E ILLINOIS (-47.6)	5.5
9/12	MISSISSIPPI ST (-5.5)	47.0
9/19	AKRON (-27.9)	25.0
9/26	AT WASHINGTON (+12.1)	56.5
10/3	MICHIGAN (+7.2)	59.0
10/10	AT PURDUE (-7.8)	39.0
10/24	IOWA (+3.6)	55.5
10/31	AT INDIANA (+21.5)	66.0
11/7	UCLA (-4.3)	48.0
11/14	AT PENN ST (+11.8)	57.0
11/21	NORTHWESTERN (-7.1)	45.5
11/27	AT WISCONSIN (+0.6)	47.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.38**
#42 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.6 / -0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

13

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Minnesota can Row the Boat, but can they Run the Ball?

Taylor rejected numerous overtures in the portal to stay at Minnesota and should be healthy from the hamstring injuries that plagued him last season. However, the Gophers only ranked 116th in the nation running the ball at just 3.57 yards per carry. Taylor still had 915 yards from scrimmage last year despite missing five games, but the offensive line needs to improve dramatically as the Gophers dug many holes for themselves offensively ranking just 127th in FBS for total offense. Lindsey should continue to progress, but it is all on the offensive line, which returns three starters and adds transfer right tackle Bennett Warren from Tennessee.

Who replaces Koi Perich in the secondary?

Portal gains and losses are a way of life in college football, but losing Perich to the portal (Oregon) stings extra for the Gophers, as he was a local product (Esco, MN) and was arguably the most talented player on the defense. In 2024, he was first-team All-Big Ten as a freshman with five interceptions while also contributing on offense and special teams. Kerry Brown (four PBU, two INTs) is back in the secondary along with linebacker Maverick Baranowski (103 tackles) and defensive end Anthony Smith, whose 12.5 sacks led the Big Ten. TJ Bush also comes in from Cal, and he has had 91 pressures and 13 sacks over three seasons at Liberty and Cal. There is still talent here, but the loss of Perich could lower the ceiling a bit for this solid unit.

Who can plug the holes?

Minnesota is solid on the edge with Smith. Bush, and Karter Menz (6.5 sacks), and they should be able to get to the opposing quarterbacks. The Gophers do return 65% of their overall defensive production, but do lose their four top defensive tackles from last season including seventh-round draft pick Deven Eastern. Minnesota had to hit the transfer portal hard and brought in Naquan Crowder and Sid Kaba, both from Marshall, along with Xion Chapman from FIU. The interior defensive line is still unproven and the Big Ten has several of the top-10 offensive lines in the country.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****35-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****300-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.4	116
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	59
PLAYS PER GAME	61.1	131
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:03	94
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.4%	57
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	277.5	132
YARDS PER PLAY	4.5	125
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.4	133
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	90.6	130
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	123
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.8	56
COMPLETION %	62.3%	59
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	186.9	103
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.9	127
TURNOVERS	0.6	4
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.8	56
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	74
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.9%	89
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	356.4	44
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	56
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	130.3	34
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	43
COMPLETION %	67.3%	124
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.2	71
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	99
SACKS	3.1	4
TURNOVERS	1	98

NEBRASKA CORNHUSKERS



In 2023, Matt Rhule came to Lincoln with the reputation of a quick rebuild of programs from what he did at Temple and then at Baylor. Three years later, Rhule is 19-19 at Nebraska and the natives are getting a bit restless. Dylan Raiola, a legacy player whose father Dominic and uncle Donovan played at Nebraska, was thought to be the savior at quarterback for which Nebraska has been searching. He posted a 13-9 record in two seasons as a starter but broke his leg vs. USC and was done for the season after a promising 6-2 start. Dylan transferred to Oregon after the season and uncle Donovan was fired as offensive line coach. Defensive coordinator John Butler and defensive line coach Terry Bradden were also let go.

Winning can cure any dissension in the ranks and transfer QB Anthony Colandrea did a lot of that at UNLV last season, leading the Rebels to 10 victories. He is a playmaker who threw for 3,459 yards and accounted for 33 touchdowns while winning Mountain West Player of the Year, but will need to live up to the high expectations to cool Rhule's hot seat.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

After three likely non-conference wins at home, Nebraska's schedule picks up in October, having to take on playoff teams in consecutive weeks, hosting Indiana and traveling to Oregon. The Huskers also draw Ohio State in the home finale. With a new defensive scheme and a difficult schedule, Nebraska looks like a middling team once again and the seat will only get hotter for Rhule.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 4-8-1 ATS, 10-3 O-U

Head Coach: Matt Rhule - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	OHIO U (-21)	31.5
9/12	BOWLING GREEN (-25.6)	26.5
9/19	N DAKOTA (-17)	36.5
9/26	AT MICHIGAN ST (-6.9)	42.5
10/3	MARYLAND (-7.6)	45.5
10/10	INDIANA (+13.4)	66.0
10/17	AT OREGON (+21.8)	68.5
10/31	WASHINGTON (+3.2)	56.5
11/6	AT ILLINOIS (+3.7)	51.0
11/14	AT RUTGERS (-6)	42.5
11/21	OHIO ST (+18.4)	71.0
11/27	AT IOWA (+8)	55.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.20**
#17 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

15

8

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is there a true QB competition?

Colandrea did not transfer to sit, but TJ Lateef (904 yards, five TD passes) was highly touted out of high school and did start five games as a true freshman last season, so he has familiarity with Dana Holgorsen's Air Raid offense. Colandrea should win the job as the more proven commodity and will have targets as starting receivers Nyziah Hunter (43-617-5) and Jacory Barney Jr (45-484-5) return and Kwazi Gilmer started 19 games at UCLA over the last two seasons.

What happens to the running game without Emmett Johnson?

Johnson was a first-team All-American last year, rushing for 1,451 yards and accounting for 15 touchdowns. The Huskers did not elect to bring in a running back out of the portal instead they will look to the returning sophomore duo of Mekhi Nelson and Isaiah Mozee. Nelson was arrested in late June on an aggravated battery charge, but charges were dropped. Nevertheless, his availability for fall camp has still yet to be determined, so true freshman Jamal Rule may have his number called early. Up front, Nebraska added guards Paul Mubenga (LSU), Brendan Black (Iowa State), and tackle Tree Babalade (South Carolina), so they should have a bigger and more agile group that must protect the QB better than last year's bunch (33 sacks allowed).

Can the transition from 3-3-5 to Rob Aurich's 4-2-5 scheme go smoothly?

Rob Aurich led a top-10 defensive unit at San Diego State last season and was hired to improve a defense that gave up 131 points over its final three games of the season. The Huskers need to find a balance defensively, as they ranked third nationally in pass defense, but only 98th in rush defense. With just 22 sacks in 13 games, Nebraska simply could not get to opposing quarterbacks. They went to the portal to add Owen Stoudmire (Boston College), Jahsear Whittington (Pitt), and Anthony Jones Jr (UCLA) up front. To shore up the linebacker corps, Owen Chambliss follows Aurich in from San Diego State and Dexter Foster transfers in from Oregon State to go along with Vincent Shavers Jr (61 tackles, 7.5 TFLs). The secondary is the best unit on the team with three starters back – Andrew Marshall (45 tackles), Rex Guthrie (63 tackles), and Donovan Jones (59 tackles).

200-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****25-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****120-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.2	69
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	45
PLAYS PER GAME	66.3	97
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:36	46
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.1%	25
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	355.3	86
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	76
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.4	75
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	142.1	77
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	83
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.1	94
COMPLETION %	67.9%	12
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	213.2	85
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	59
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.1	67
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	103
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.3%	75
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	345.1	38
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	69
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	183.8	104
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	119
COMPLETION %	58.1%	23
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	161.3	4
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	28
SACKS	1.6	101
TURNOVERS	0.9	106

NORTHWESTERN WILDCATS



A new era of Northwestern football begins on October 2, as the new, \$862 million Ryan Field officially opens when the Wildcats host Penn State. This is now David Braun's program as the Pat Fitzgerald chapter finally closed with a settled lawsuit and Fitzgerald returning to coaching at Michigan State (they play on October 17).

While not an official trade, Michigan State now has Northwestern's old coach, while the Wildcats have Michigan State's old quarterback, as Aidan Chiles transfers into Evanston. Chiles had the plug pulled on him after nine games last season in East Lansing but gets a second chance in the Big Ten with new offensive coordinator Chip Kelly, who finally gives Northwestern a creative mind on offense, along with new QB coach Jerry Neuheisel, who recruited Chiles out of high school.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

While there is a great deal of excitement surrounding Northwestern football with the opening of the new Ryan Field. That excitement gets a dose of reality though when you look at the Wildcats' schedule. They face all three playoff teams from the Big Ten last season – Indiana, Oregon, and Ohio State. Not only that, but they also play all three of them on the road. The first game at Ryan Field vs. Penn State should be emotional and so should facing former coach Fitzgerald at Michigan State. Plus, the Wildcats have games with Penn State, Iowa, and Illinois who were also bowl teams last season. Chiles' accuracy and ball security issues could also reappear. The defense can only carry this team so far against this bear of a schedule.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 7-4-2 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: David Braun - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	S DAKOTA ST (-16)	31.0
9/19	COLORADO (-5.2)	43.0
9/25	AT INDIANA (+24.3)	66.0
10/2	PENN ST (+10.2)	57.0
10/10	BALL ST (-28.1)	20.0
10/17	AT MICHIGAN ST (-1.8)	42.5
10/24	RUTGERS (-5.1)	42.5
10/31	AT OREGON (+26.9)	68.5
11/7	IOWA (+8.6)	55.5
11/14	AT OHIO ST (+29.3)	71.0
11/21	AT MINNESOTA (+7.1)	49.0
11/28	ILLINOIS (+4.3)	51.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **50.04**
#11 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / 0**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Chip Kelly rebuild Aidan Chiles?

Chiles followed his old Oregon State coach Jonathan Smith to Michigan State two years ago. The result was garnering an 8-12 record over two seasons as a starter and being benched after nine games. Chiles is the athletic and mobile quarterback that Kelly likes in his fast, no-huddle spread offense. However, Kelly must assist in restoring his confidence. One way to do that is to rely on a triple-threat rushing attack led by the returning Caleb Komolafe (941 yards, 11 TDs), speedy gadget back Joseph Hinton (486 yards), and Gavin Sawchuk (486 yards last year at Florida State). Five of last year's top six pass catchers including Griffin Wilde (71-880-8) are also back for the Wildcats. Chiles also got a nice gift with the return of Jackson Carsello at center, which allows the highly-talented Ezomo Orotokhai to stay at guard, plus Grant Seagren, who started 12 games at Oklahoma State last year, slots in at left tackle.

Who can get after opposing passers?

Northwestern was just 14th in the Big Ten with 23 sacks last season and nearly half of them came from the now departed Anto Saka and Aidan Hubbard. Michael Kilbane (7.5 TFLs, 3.5 sacks) and defensive tackle Brendan Flakes cannot do it up front all by themselves, so much will be needed and expected from defensive end Jamaal Johnson (UCF) and linebacker Kobie McKinzie. The secondary is the best unit on the team led by all-Big Ten safety Robert Fitzgerald (115 tackles), corner Josh Fussell, and nickel Braden Turner (two INTs, two FF last season).

Can David Braun get lower-level talent to play up in the Big Ten?

Braun comes from an extensive FCS background with stints at Northern Iowa and North Dakota State. The 2023 Big Ten Coach of the Year showed that he could do more with less and successfully navigated the difficult times surrounding Pat Fitzgerald's termination. Nevertheless, he will have to coach up some G6, FCS, and D-II programs that are in line to start for the Wildcats.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****55-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****125-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.8	99
YARDS PER POINT	15.2	86
PLAYS PER GAME	64.6	113
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:00	20
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.1%	38
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	331.1	104
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	91
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.3	78
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	150.1	66
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	53
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.1	94
COMPLETION %	58.2%	102
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	181	111
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	115
TURNOVERS	1.7	111
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.9	27
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	27
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.3%	113
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	342.3	36
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	77
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	141.8	49
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	72
COMPLETION %	66.1%	114
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	200.5	33
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	88
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

OHIO STATE BUCKEYES



Ohio State enters 2026 with something rare – a losing streak. The Buckeyes dropped the last two games of 2025 losing to Indiana, for the first time since 1988, in the Big Ten Championship Game and then being upset as the No. 2 seed in the Cotton Bowl by Miami. They did end a four-game losing streak to “the team up north” (Michigan), and finished 12-2, but it is never enough in Columbus, and the Buckeyes are not standing pat as there are significant changes.

The Buckeyes added 18 players through the portal and have 50 new players in the program including yet another top-five recruiting class. Adding a former NFL coach worked last year with Matt Patricia as defensive coordinator, so Ryan Day is trying the same thing on offense with Arthur Smith. Even with so many changes from last season, Julian Sayin and Jeremiah Smith return to form arguably the best QB-WR combination in the nation to head up what is annually one of the most talented rosters in college football.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 9.5

Ordinarily a win total in single digits would be a slam dunk over for the Buckeyes considering they haven't had fewer than double-digit victories in a full season since 2011. However, there are 51 newcomers on this roster and this schedule is loaded. Ohio State has road trips to Texas, Iowa, Indiana, USC, and Nebraska plus host Illinois, Oregon, and Michigan at “The Horseshoe”. Ohio State ran the slowest-paced offense in college football, but this year they should take the training wheels off Sayin and Arthur Smith could do for the offense what Patricia did for the defense last season.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 10-4 ATS, 4-10 O-U

Head Coach: Ryan Day - 8th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	BALL ST (-55.3)	20.0
9/12	AT TEXAS (-2)	66.0
9/19	KENT ST (-51.9)	23.5
9/26	ILLINOIS (-22.9)	51.0
10/3	AT IOWA (-12.6)	55.5
10/10	MARYLAND (-29.6)	45.5
10/17	AT INDIANA (-1.4)	66.0
10/31	AT USC (-7.4)	60.0
11/7	OREGON (-5.4)	68.5
11/14	NORTHWESTERN (-29.3)	45.5
11/21	AT NEBRASKA (-18.4)	50.5
11/28	MICHIGAN (-15)	59.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH

50.07
#10 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS

3.8 / 0.2
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

8*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the Buckeyes offensive line get back to being dominant again?

To be fair, they were dominant in the regular season and only allowed six sacks. Then, they gave up five sacks against Indiana and five more against Miami. There are many reasons to point out for those two losses. Did Ryan Day get too conservative with the gameplan? Did the Ohio State offense run too slow of a tempo? It is fair to answer in the affirmative to both those questions, but the most obvious reason the Buckeyes lost those games is because their offensive line got whipped up front. Four starters are back and Bo Jackson rushed for almost 1100 yards as a freshman behind the group. While the downfield passing game will be the most explosive part of the offense, Arthur Smith wants to run the ball more aggressively and will allow Sayin to use his legs more.

Can Matt Patricia's defense be No. 1 again?

Last year, Patricia had to replace eight starters in his first season as defensive coordinator, and all his group did was to become the No. 1 defense in the country by holding opponents to a paltry 9.3 points per game and allowing just 219.1 yards per game. This year, Patricia also must replace eight defensive starters, as they were all drafted into the NFL last spring. The talent is always top-notch here, but there is not a superstar like last year. Kenyatta Jackson Jr (6.5 sacks) is likely the next first rounder from this group, and he is joined on the defensive line by Alabama transfer James Smith and UCF transfer John Walker. Other transfers that will start included Earl Little Jr. (Florida State) and Terry Moore (Duke) at free safety to go along with corners Jermaine Matthews Jr (two INTs) and Devin Sanchez along with strong safety Jaylen McClain (53 tackles).

Who can be Jeremiah Smith's running mate?

Smith has been the most talented receiver in college football since he stepped on the field as a true freshman two years ago. Even No. 4 overall pick Carnell Tate was the second option to him. Brandon Inniss returns and Chris Henry Jr. is the latest five-star freshman prospect at receiver for the Buckeyes. Transfer Devin McQuin had 726 yards and eight touchdowns at UTSA last season. This is still arguably the most talented corps in the country, but it will be interesting to see who becomes the No. 2 option to Smith, who will see every type of coverage you can throw at him.

ODDS TO WIN...

+600**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-275****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+180****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.6	26
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	30
PLAYS PER GAME	64	115
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:11	8
3RD DOWN CONV. %	51.7%	2
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	405.2	36
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	17
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.5	86
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	145.3	74
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	59
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.2	90
COMPLETION %	76.1%	1
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	259.8	29
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	10
TURNOVERS	0.8	10
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	10	1
YARDS PER POINT	22.3	2
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.3%	9
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	223.3	1
YARDS PER PLAY	3.9	2
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	89.2	7
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3	9
COMPLETION %	61.6%	60
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	134.2	1
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.5	3
SACKS	2.5	30
TURNOVERS	0.8	111

OREGON DUCKS



Since Dan Lanning took over the Oregon program in 2022, the Ducks have gone 48-8. They have made the College Football Playoff in both years and ran through the Big Ten in their first season in the conference back in 2024. The one thing that they have not done is win a National Championship as they have been blown out by the last two National Champions (Ohio State two years ago in the Rose Bowl and Indiana last year in the Peach Bowl).

This year Oregon starts out as a bit of a victim of its own success as both offensive coordinator Will Stein (Kentucky) and Tosh Lupoi (Cal) depart for head coaching jobs. Drew Mehringer (co-OC/tight ends coach) and Chris Hampton (co-DC/defensive backs coach) are promoted from within. For all the coaching staff changes, Oregon returns 66% of its net production per ESPN's Bill Connelly. There is no bigger return than junior quarterback Dante Moore, who turned down the NFL Draft. In addition, eight starters are back on defense which is called by Lanning, so it should once again be an elite group.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 10.5

There is never much margin for error in taking a win total over 10.5 wins especially with tough trips to both USC and Ohio State, and a lot has to go right to clear this number like the offensive line being able to gel together and the young skill position players being ready to step into starting roles after being productive backups. Nonetheless, Oregon may just have the most talented roster in college football, and they have a lot to prove after being humiliated to end their season each of the last two years. This may just be a "show no mercy" season for the Ducks where they have their best shot at a National Championship.

2025 Record: 13-2 SU & 9-6 ATS, 8-7 O-U

Head Coach: Dan Lanning - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	BOISE ST (-22)	50.5
9/12	AT OKLAHOMA ST (-20.9)	46.5
9/18	PORTLAND ST (-69)	3.5
9/26	AT USC (-5.6)	60.0
10/10	UCLA (-24.1)	48.0
10/17	NEBRASKA (-21.8)	50.5
10/24	AT ILLINOIS (-15.1)	51.0
10/31	NORTHWESTERN (-26.9)	45.5
11/7	AT OHIO ST (+5.4)	71.0
11/14	MICHIGAN (-12.6)	59.0
11/20	AT MICHIGAN ST (-25.7)	42.5
11/28	WASHINGTON (-16.4)	56.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **47.28**
#28 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / 0.9**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

15

6*

9

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Dante Moore get it done when it matters most?

Moore is justifiably one of the favorites for the Heisman Trophy having thrown for 3,565 yards and 30 TDs in his first year as a starter in 2025. He also has an embarrassment of riches for weapons around him, including Jordon Davison and Dierre Hill Jr., who combined for 1,323 yards on the ground as freshmen backups. Sophomore receivers Dakorien Moore and Jeremiah McClellan should be ready to step up into starting roles, plus Evan Stewart returns after missing last season with a knee injury. Moore will put up monster numbers again, but it remains to be seen if he can do it on the biggest stage. In the two games vs. Indiana last year, he was sacked nine times and had four turnovers including the pick-six on the opening snap of the Peach Bowl.

Can the offensive line hold up in the postseason?

Rimington Trophy finalist Iapani Laloulu anchors the line at center for the third straight season and Dave Iuli returns at right guard. The Ducks will need to replace three starters, but this offensive line is the only group to be a finalist for the Joe Moore Award each of the last three years which begs the question of why it has so much difficulty holding up in the big games? When you combine the season-ending playoff losses of the last two years, the Oregon offense has had 11 three-and-outs, given up 11 sacks, and allowed 21 TFLs. To get to that elusive National Championship Game, this group needs to be better when it matters most.

Will the defensive line be able to create more negative plays?

Oregon may have the best defensive line in the country with the returns of defensive tackles Bear Alexander and A'Mauri Washington along with edge rusher Matayo Uiagalelei and linebacker Teitum Tuioti. These four have combined for 45.5 sacks the last two seasons. Even with these gaudy sack numbers, Oregon still finds difficulty getting off the field at times and ranked just 52nd nationally in third-down stops. Defensive tackle transfers D'Antre Robinson (North Carolina) and Jerome Simmons (Louisiana-Monroe) should help matters though as depth pieces in stopping the run.

ODDS TO WIN...

+800**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-320****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+260****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.4	13
YARDS PER POINT	12.7	18
PLAYS PER GAME	67.4	83
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:51	38
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.2%	24
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	448.4	12
YARDS PER PLAY	6.7	6
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.6	51
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	194.7	22
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.3	13
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.4	87
COMPLETION %	71.4%	2
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	253.6	35
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.6	13
TURNOVERS	1.1	36
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.2	11
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	49
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.8%	61
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	275.8	5
YARDS PER PLAY	4.3	5
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	120.7	26
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	19
COMPLETION %	51.7%	3
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	155.1	2
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.5	4
SACKS	1.9	68
TURNOVERS	1.5	39

PENN STATE NITTANY LIONS



Last year was supposed to be the year in Happy Valley for Penn State to return to the top of the college football mountain for the first time since 1986. The Nittany Lions started 3-0 and then lost a heartbreaker at home to Oregon in OT. That defeat sent them into a tailspin, as Penn State would lose six straight games including as 24-point road favorites at UCLA and as three touchdown home favorites vs. Northwestern, which resulted in James Franklin being fired the following day. They rallied to win the last four games under interim coach Terry Smith, who is being kept on staff as associate head coach.

After failing to land Kalani Sitake from BYU, Penn State signed Iowa State's Matt Campbell to an eight-year, \$70.5 million contract. After leading the Cyclones to arguably its best decade in program history, Campbell finally decided to make the jump for the big job. He brings along 11 assistants (including offensive coordinator Taylor Mouser) and staff with him from Ames plus 24 players, perhaps looking to duplicate Curt Cignetti's success of the last two years at Indiana.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 9.5

All last season, college football pundits were asking "who is this year's Indiana" that could take everyone by surprise and make the College Football Playoff? Well, it turned out to be Indiana again. This year the answer to that question could very well be Penn State. Indiana had a highly-manageable schedule in 2024, and Penn State has the same this season as they avoid the consensus top trio of Ohio State, Oregon, and Indiana altogether. There are road trips to Michigan and Washington, but they will be favored in every home game. This is a step up in competition for these Iowa State transfers, but they likely band together like the James Madison guys did for Indiana and set a new culture for the rest of the team to follow.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-8 ATS, 9-4 O-U
Head Coach: Matt Campbell - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MARSHALL (-25.6)	34.0
9/12	AT TEMPLE (-20.4)	34.0
9/19	BUFFALO (-31.7)	28.0
9/26	WISCONSIN (-12.8)	47.5
10/2	AT NORTHWESTERN (-10.2)	45.5
10/10	USC (-0.6)	60.0
10/17	AT MICHIGAN (+3.9)	59.0
10/31	PURDUE (-21.5)	39.0
11/7	AT WASHINGTON (+2.6)	56.5
11/14	MINNESOTA (-11.8)	49.0
11/21	RUTGERS (-17.6)	42.5
11/28	AT MARYLAND (-10.2)	45.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **44.01**
#50 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.1 / 0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

16

OFFENSE

8

DEFENSE

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Rocco Becht stay healthy?

Becht is one of the 24 transfers coming with Campbell to Happy Valley. The quarterback made 39 consecutive starts at Iowa State despite sustaining a torn labrum, a sprained AC joint, and two concussions last season. He had offseason surgery and was limited to 7-on-7 drills. Alex Manske, also transferring from Iowa State, also missed spring practice with injury. Connor Barry, a D-III transfer from Christopher Newport, is the only other QB on the roster who has taken a college snap. If Becht is healthy, he will have a lot of familiar weapons around him with running back Carson Hansen (1771 yards, 19 TDs last two years at ISU) along with Ben Brahmer, Gabe Burkle, Chase Sowell, and Brett Eskildsen, who were his top four pass catchers at Iowa State. Ohio State transfer James Peoples and Quentin Martin Jr (103 yards in Pinstripe Bowl) join Hansen in the backfield.

How will all the transfers mix in with the returning players?

Campbell brings in his 24 from Iowa State, but brings in 40 total transfers as the Nittany Lions are replacing 70 players from last year's team, including eight that were taken in last spring's NFL Draft. For comparison, Cignetti brought in 29 transfers, including 12 from his team at James Madison (22 were from the Group of Five or lower) during his first season at Indiana in 2024. Thirty-six of Campbell's 40 transfers are from Power Four schools, so at least there is some talent that has played the highest competition in FBS. Nevertheless, the Big Ten is still a step above the Big 12.

How quickly can D'Anton Lynn get this defense up to speed?

Lynn improved the USC defense over the last two years, and Campbell immediately hired the former Penn State player to be his new defensive coordinator. This is a new scheme for these players with a 4-2-5 alignment, but seven of Lynn's defensive starters were also starters for an Iowa State group that finished one spot outside of the top 25 for scoring defense (20.2 PPG).

ODDS TO WIN...

60-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+425

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

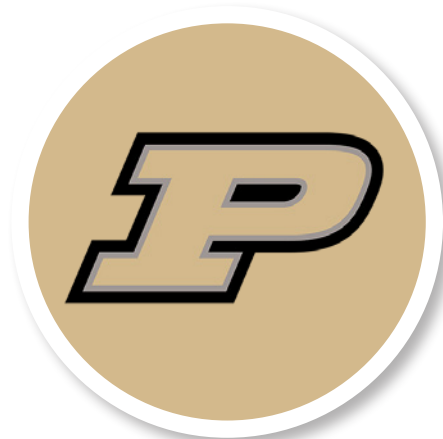
20-1

BIG TEN

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.3	38
YARDS PER POINT	12.1	8
PLAYS PER GAME	63.3	121
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:36	76
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.4%	31
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	353.9	88
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	51
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.1	55
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169.5	46
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	36
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.7	117
COMPLETION %	67.9%	13
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	184.4	107
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	64
TURNOVERS	0.8	8
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.8	38
YARDS PER POINT	15.6	35
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.5%	82
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340	31
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	42
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	148.4	60
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	62
COMPLETION %	64.0%	93
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	191.6	21
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	45
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	0.8	112

PURDUE BOILERMAKERS



It was another tough season for Purdue in Barry Odom's first year. The Boilermakers improved from 1-11 to just 2-10 and the program is currently on an 18-game losing streak in Big 10 play and has zero victories over Power Four opponents in this two-year span. It also must be difficult to be at the bottom of the conference and see your archrival at the top as the defending National Champions.

While results have yet to show on the field, Purdue is in better shape and has more continuity than it had before Odom's arrival. The coaching staff is better, but the talent is still not good enough to compete week in and week out in the Big Ten. They did not bring in a quarterback from the portal, so this is Ryan Browne's show again. Browne (2153 yards, 9/10 TD/INT ratio) played with an ankle injury last season and his play suffered because of that and the loss of now graduated running back Devin Mockobee.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 3.5

Purdue is still a long way away from getting back to the competitiveness of the Jeff Brohm years, but Odom and his staff are an upgrade over the disastrous tenure of Ryan Walters. The schedule is relatively manageable considering the Boilermakers avoid Ohio State, Oregon, Michigan, and USC. Unfortunately for them, they cannot avoid Old Oaken Bucket rival Indiana who has beaten them by a combined score of 122-3 the last two seasons. Nevertheless, you still have a settled quarterback and better personnel on the lines and some conference games where the talent gap is not as large. Four wins seems doable, but that is likely the ceiling.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 4-7-1 ATS, 4-8 O-U

Head Coach: Barry Odom - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	INDIANA ST (-31.7)	9.5
9/12	WAKE FOREST (+6.3)	46.5
9/19	AT UCLA (+10.8)	48.0
9/26	NOTRE DAME (+29)	68.5
10/3	AT ILLINOIS (+15.7)	51.0
10/10	MINNESOTA (+7.8)	49.0
10/16	WASHINGTON (+15.5)	56.5
10/31	AT PENN ST (+21.5)	57.0
11/7	MARYLAND (+4.7)	45.5
11/14	AT IOWA (+20)	55.5
11/21	WISCONSIN (+6.8)	47.5
11/28	AT INDIANA (+31.2)	66.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **50.47**
#9 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.5 / -0.4**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

5*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the transfers help Browne?

Browne clearly must improve under center, but in fairness, he did not have a great deal of help last season. While Purdue returns second-leading rusher Antonio Harris (69-305-2), the bulk of production will come from portal additions like running backs Fame Ijeboi (Minnesota), Jerrick Gibson (Texas), and Travis Terrell (Jackson State). The Boilers also added three receivers – Bisi Owens (Penn), Assad Wassem (Florida Atlantic), Xavier Townsend (Iowa State) – from the portal who are all expected to start. De’Nylon Morrisette also returns from missing last season with an ankle injury.

Can the Boilermakers be more physical up front?

Purdue struggled in many areas last season, but they especially had difficulty in short-yardage (85th on third downs) and red-zone (119th) situations. Odom fired his offensive line coach Vance Vice, who came with him from UNLV, and brought in Zach Crabtree, who worked with offensive coordinator Josh Henson previously at USC. The coaching change should be an upgrade, and Purdue added more beef up front. While left tackle Joey Tanona returns, as many as four new starters from the portal could start including center Boaz Stanley (21 starts at South Carolina), left guard Micah Banuelos (5 starts at USC), and right tackle Nuki Mafi (12 starts last year at Oklahoma State).

Is Kane able?

Kevin Kane was the defensive coordinator here under previous head coach Ryan Walters in the 2023 and 2024 seasons. The Boilermakers finished last in the league in most defensive categories during those two seasons. He was replaced with the new staff coming in and coached linebackers at Minnesota last season. Kane now gets a second chance at the DC position and has more autonomy in calling the defense and he likes to attack more than Walters did. Plus, it was not like Purdue really got any better here ranking 17th in the Big Ten for total defense.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****1000-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.4	124
YARDS PER POINT	19.6	127
PLAYS PER GAME	65.7	107
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:14	126
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.1%	95
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	339.9	99
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	85
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.4	124
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	118.5	105
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	89
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.6	30
COMPLETION %	58.8%	97
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	221.5	71
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	106
TURNOVERS	1.8	118
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.2	117
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	104
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.3%	101
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	436.6	122
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	130
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	191.4	114
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	111
COMPLETION %	65.5%	108
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	245.3	106
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.7	136
SACKS	1.8	76
TURNOVERS	0.8	116

RUTGERS

SCARLET KNIGHTS



The second act for Greg Schiano at Rutgers certainly has had more difficulty than the first. In the late 2000s, Schiano got the Scarlet Knights near the top of the Big East, but in his second stanza, he is just 31-41 six seasons as a member of the Big Ten. There is credence to the thought that Schiano is coaching a bit with an arm tied behind his back because Rutgers has not really made the financial investment necessary to get this program more competitive in the Big Ten.

Schiano is a proven good coach but eventually results must materialize. That task is made even more difficult with "The Greek Rifle" Athan Kaliakmanis's graduation and now having to replace a two-year starter at quarterback. Furthermore, the Scarlet Knights ranked 125th nationally in total defense which is why Travis Johansen was brought in as defensive coordinator after coaching South Dakota to the FCS Playoffs last year. Schiano will still have involvement on defense as always, but Johansen will be given more autonomy than his predecessors.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Even with all the defensive issues, Rutgers should be able to put up some points again with Loneragan most likely to win the QB job, Raymond, and Duff. The Scarlet Knights avoid Oregon and Ohio State on the schedule, so on paper they look to have one of the easier schedules in the Big Ten and all three non-conference games are winnable, including at Boston College where Loneragan would face the school where he started nine games last season. Rutgers will need to win a coin flip game or two (at Maryland, at Northwestern, Michigan State).

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 6-6 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Greg Schiano - 7th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	MASSACHUSETTS (-28.9)	16.0
9/11	AT BOSTON COLLEGE (-3.1)	37.5
9/19	USC (+14.9)	60.0
9/25	HOWARD (-41.4)	3.5
10/3	INDIANA (+21.6)	66.0
10/17	AT MARYLAND (+5.1)	45.5
10/24	AT NORTHWESTERN (+5.1)	45.5
10/31	MICHIGAN (+15.2)	59.0
11/7	AT WISCONSIN (+6.4)	47.5
11/14	NEBRASKA (+6)	50.5
11/21	AT PENN ST (+17.6)	57.0
11/28	MICHIGAN ST (-2.2)	42.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.86**
 #53 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / 0**
 (HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

4

DEFENSE

8

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who wins the quarterback job?

Sophomore AJ Surace saw limited action last season behind Kaliakmanis and now he battles Boston College transfer Dylan Lonergan (66.9% completions, 2,025 yards, 12/5 TD/INT, nine starts). Once upon a time, Lonergan was a four-star recruit brought to Alabama by Nick Saban. Whoever wins the job does have some weapons to work with as Rutgers, who consistently has player retention problems due to NIL, was able to retain running back Antwan Raymond (1,275 yards, 13 TDs) and big 6-foot-6 receiver K.J. Duff (60-1,084-7).

Can the offensive line get better?

With all the issues on defense, Schiano and offensive coordinator Kirk Ciarrocca must play a little bit more ball control on offense. Two senior starters – left tackle Tyler Needham and right guard Kwabena Asamoah – are back, but there are also three open spots heading into fall camp. Jim Turner, most recently the interim head coach of the UFL's Memphis Showboats before the franchise was eliminated, replaces Pat Flaherty as offensive line coach. Turner has a bit of a checkered past dating back to being fired as the Miami Dolphins OL coach for a pattern of harassment and bullying. Center Hank Zilinskis (Colorado), Everett Small (Eastern Michigan), and Isaiah Cook (Delaware State) all have starting experience at their previous stops.

Defense? Defense, anyone?

Rutgers ranked 125th in FBS for total defense, allowing 432.9 yards per game, which was the worst of any team in the Power Four. Only three starters are back from that group and that might not be a bad thing. Johansen brought in some of his FCS brethren to fill out his defensive staff including Drake head coach Joe Woodley to coach the rush ends and Drake defensive coordinator Adam Cox to coach the safeties. Safety Kaj Sanders (65 tackles) had half of his tackles in the last five games. Rutgers is largely rebuilding the defense through the portal for the second consecutive season. We will see if this rebuild goes better than the first.

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****250-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****600-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.8	70
YARDS PER POINT	15.2	89
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	27
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:11	15
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.4%	56
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	393.5	53
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	70
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.1	39
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	137.5	85
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	107
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.3	66
COMPLETION %	61.3%	71
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	255.9	30
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	21
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.8	121
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	98
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.3%	92
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	452.5	129
YARDS PER PLAY	7.8	136
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	217.6	129
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	7	136
COMPLETION %	67.5%	127
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	234.8	88
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	132
SACKS	0.8	133
TURNOVERS	0.8	116

UCLA BRUINS



Bob Chesney has been a rising star in the coaching ranks for several years now after leading Holy Cross to the FCS Playoffs five times in seven years and then getting James Madison into the College Football Playoff just two seasons after Curt Cignetti left for Indiana. Like Cignetti, Chesney brings a lot of his staff (eight assistants) with him to his new home from JMU including offensive coordinator Dean Kennedy and defensive coordinator Colin Hitchens. He also brings in 10 of his 42 transfers from James Madison.

However, it is the player who is staying that is the starting point, as quarterback Nico Iamaleava returns to work with a new staff that led James Madison to the No. 16 offense (452.6 yards per game) in the nation.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

They are clearly hoping that history repeats itself in Westwood with what Cignetti did in Bloomington. Chesney is a good coach and he and his staff are a massive upgrade over Deshaun Foster and his group, and he has a chance to turn this around at UCLA, but this team is still a bit overpriced. The non-conference slate, especially with games at Cal and vs. San Diego State are not gimme wins. While they avoid Ohio State and Indiana, the Bruins still have trips to Michigan and Oregon. A 6-6 campaign is certainly realistic, but getting to seven wins seems to be a reach with so many new faces and so many unproven positions.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 4-8 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Bob Chesney - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT CALIFORNIA (-0.6)	45.5
9/12	SAN DIEGO ST (-6.3)	43.0
9/19	PURDUE (-10.8)	39.0
9/26	AT MARYLAND (-0.7)	45.5
10/10	AT OREGON (+24.1)	68.5
10/17	WISCONSIN (-2.1)	47.5
10/24	MICHIGAN ST (-7)	42.5
10/31	NEVADA (-21.4)	28.0
11/7	AT MINNESOTA (+4.3)	49.0
11/13	ILLINOIS (+2.5)	51.0
11/21	AT MICHIGAN (+13.4)	59.0
11/28	USC (+10.1)	60.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.46**
#25 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

18

OFFENSE

10*

DEFENSE

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Nico Iamaleava ready to take the next step?

After all the drama surrounding his transfer from Tennessee, Iamaleava had a disappointing inaugural campaign in Westwood, throwing for just 1,929 yards in 11 starts. However, he did complete 64.4% of his passes and only threw seven interceptions while adding 505 yards and four touchdowns on the ground. Chesney brings him some help from James Madison including all-purpose running back Wayne Knight (1,373 rush yards, nine TDs; 397 rec yards, one TD) to go along with returning backs Jaivian Thomas and Anthony Woods, plus three offensive line starters Riley Robell, Carter Sweezie (both All-Sun Belt), and JD Rayner. Essentially a brand-new receiving corps joins holdover Mikey Matthews (33-348-2) with Landon Ellis (James Madison), Leland Smith (San Jose State), Brian Rowe (South Carolina), Aidan Mizell (Florida), and Semaj Morgan (Michigan) entering the fold.

Can a true No. 1 wide receiver emerge?

One of the reasons for Iamaleava's disappointing passing numbers is because the wide receivers did not give much help. Nico is a playmaker that is most effective throwing on the run instead of standing in the pocket, so receivers must get some separation. Rowe, from South Carolina, is the most talented of the group. Ellis (624 yards) has familiarity with the offense from his time at James Madison. Smith (43-688-3) posted good numbers at San Jose State.

Can the defensive line get some pressure on opposing quarterbacks?

No team in FBS was worse in doing so than UCLA last season, as they only registered 10 sacks. Chesney did go into the transfer portal and brought in key players like Sun Belt Freshman of the Year Sahir West (seven sacks) and Aiden Gobaira (four sacks) from James Madison. Oklahoma transfer linebacker Samuel Omosigho (50 tackles, two sacks). The talented secondary masked a lot of the defensive line's weaknesses last year and it will be a talented group in the back again, but the defensive line must help them out up front or the Bruins will give plenty of points just like last year (33.4 PPG, 125th nationally).

ODDS TO WIN...

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****30-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****160-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.2	121
YARDS PER POINT	17.7	121
PLAYS PER GAME	63.5	120
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:09	92
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.3%	88
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	320.8	112
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	99
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.2	115
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140.5	80
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	45
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.1	84
COMPLETION %	63.4%	47
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	180.3	112
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	123
TURNOVERS	1.1	38
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.4	119
YARDS PER POINT	11.6	134
3RD DOWN CONV. %	54.8%	136
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	387.3	75
YARDS PER PLAY	6	112
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	190.7	111
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	125
COMPLETION %	66.2%	116
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	196.6	26
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	72
SACKS	0.8	132
TURNOVERS	0.8	112

USC TROJANS



When Lincoln Riley was hired at USC five years ago, many college football talking heads and media did not think it was a question of when he would win a National Championship at USC, but how many would he win? Well to answer either of those questions in the affirmative, Riley must get them into the playoff first, which he did three times at Oklahoma. This group could very well be his most talented in five seasons with 14 starters returning and the nation's No.1 recruiting class.

Even with all those starters returning, including QB Jayden Maiava and leading rushers King Miller and Waymond Jordan, there are still some questions for this team, mainly on defense. Former TCU head coach Gary Patterson has not coached full-time on any staff in nearly four years but was lured out of semi-retirement to become the new defensive coordinator, the third in four seasons, for the Trojans. Riley is halfway through his 10 year, \$110 million contract and is hoping this gamble pays off.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5
The Trojans have a ton of talent, especially this No. 1 ranked recruiting class, but most of them might be a year away from making a real impact. They also do not avoid any of the elite Big Ten teams on this year's schedule. They will score plenty of points as they always do under Riley, but there is some concern on defense with yet another new defensive coordinator with a new system. After a soft September where a 4-0 start is likely, the Trojans get thrown in the deep end with a tough schedule. Until they can prove it in big games, this looks like a similar season to last year.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 4-8-1 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Lincoln Riley - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	SAN JOSE ST (-36.3)	27.0
9/4	FRESNO ST (-21.6)	42.5
9/12	LA LAFAYETTE (-31.1)	32.5
9/19	AT RUTGERS (-14.9)	42.5
9/26	OREGON (+5.6)	68.5
10/3	WASHINGTON (-7.8)	56.5
10/10	AT PENN ST (+0.6)	57.0
10/24	AT WISCONSIN (-10.6)	47.5
10/31	OHIO ST (+7.4)	71.0
11/14	AT INDIANA (+10.3)	66.0
11/21	MARYLAND (-18.6)	45.5
11/28	AT UCLA (-10.1)	48.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.41**
#16 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.8 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL



OFFENSE



DEFENSE



* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Gary Patterson be able to put some fight into the USC defense?

Defense has seemed like a bit of an afterthought during Riley's early tenure, but it did show the most improvement last season under D'Anton Lynn as the Trojans ranked No. 51 scoring defense (23 points per game), No. 47 pass defense (207.5 yards per game) and No. 58 run defense (143.2 yards per game). Lynn got the call to return to his alma mater Penn State as defensive coordinator, so Patterson returns to full-time coaching for the first time since 2021. Patterson switches the defense to a 4-2-5 where there is a lot of depth up front including defensive ends Kameryn Crawford (5.5 sacks, 10.5 TFLs) and Braylan Shelby (4.5 sacks), defensive tackles Jahkeem Stewart and Jide Abasiri plus the addition of Michigan State transfer Alex VanSumeren (52 tackles) to improve a run defense that ranked 12th in the conference. The back seven has talent but must replace All-American Bishop Fitzgerald in the secondary.

Who takes over at receiver for Makai Lemon and Ja'Kobi Lane?

Between Lemon, the Biletnikoff Award winner, and Lane, 1,900 receiving yards and 15 touchdowns are gone. Tanook Hines (34-561-2) will get the first crack at being Maiava's top target. NC State transfer Terrell Anderson had 628 yards last year on 16.1 yards per reception. The talent level of the group appears to be a little down from USC's typically high level which means the Trojans may run the ball more with the tandem of Miller and Jordan, who combined for over 1,500 yards and 15 touchdowns, running behind an offensive line that returns all five starters.

Can the Trojans win away from home and beat someone good?

In Riley's four seasons at USC, the Trojans are 5-11 vs. ranked opposition. This season there are likely as many as five ranked opponents (Oregon, Washington, Penn State, Ohio State, and Indiana) on the schedule. The good news is that Oregon and Ohio State pay a visit to the LA Coliseum where the Trojans went 7-0 last season. However, the Trojans are only 10-10 in true Big 10 road games under Riley. They get a couple tests with trips to Penn State and Indiana. If USC wants to be taken seriously as a playoff contender again, then the Trojans must win more consistently on the road.

ODDS TO WIN...

35-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+240****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****14-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.8	12
YARDS PER POINT	13	23
PLAYS PER GAME	66	103
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:01	67
3RD DOWN CONV. %	51.3%	3
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	465.9	6
YARDS PER PLAY	7.1	4
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.6	99
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	169.9	44
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	18
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.3	52
COMPLETION %	66.7%	18
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	296	5
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.2	7
TURNOVERS	1.2	60
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23	43
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	47
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	73
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	350.8	42
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	53
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	143.2	52
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	68
COMPLETION %	65.7%	111
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	207.5	40
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	48
SACKS	2.4	33
TURNOVERS	1.4	52

WASHINGTON HUSKIES



Jedd Fisch and the Huskies improved from 6-7 to 9-4 in his second season and the Huskies looked primed and ready perhaps to challenge the top of the Big Ten with 65% of its production back. Then, days after signing a \$4 million NIL deal to return to Washington, quarterback Demond Williams Jr. announced he was entering the transfer portal and was reportedly about to sign for more money with LSU. Fortunately for all parties, this did not end up in court and Williams returned to Seattle.

Three of the four losses last season came against top-25 teams. Washington has gotten itself to the upper level of the Big Ten in just its third year in the conference, but it is now time for them to take the next step and knock off some of the league's elite. Having Williams back is certainly a necessary step for that to happen.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

Washington opens with a full September slate at home so they should start 4-0 before the trip to USC. Perhaps that gets its confidence rolling into the season and the Huskies can finally knock off a good team. The Huskies only averaged 9.3 points per game and 4.3 yards per play against Ohio State, Michigan, Wisconsin, and Oregon, who were the four best defenses they faced. Simply put, Williams also must be better against the better teams.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-6 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Jedd Fisch - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	WASHINGTON ST (-22.2)	38.0
9/12	UTAH ST (-24.7)	36.5
9/19	E WASHINGTON (-45.8)	15.5
9/26	MINNESOTA (-12.1)	49.0
10/3	AT USC (+7.8)	60.0
10/9	IOWA (-4.2)	55.5
10/16	AT PURDUE (-15.5)	39.0
10/31	AT NEBRASKA (-3.2)	50.5
11/7	PENN ST (-2.6)	57.0
11/14	AT MICHIGAN ST (-12.3)	42.5
11/21	INDIANA (+5.8)	66.0
11/28	AT OREGON (+16.4)	68.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **47.12**
#29 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

8*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Demond Williams Jr. all-in?

NIL and transfer portal are the way of the world in college football today. However, this got perilously close to Williams leaving and lawyers were about to get involved. Williams got some bad advice from his representatives and perhaps all of that is behind him. Can everyone let bygones be bygones? If so, Williams is one of the more dynamic quarterbacks in the conference. He led the Huskies last season to top-five marks in both scoring offense (No. 4, 34.1 PPG) and total offense (No. 5, 409.9 YPG), but this time around he must do it without his best players from last season including wide receiver Denzel Boston and running back Jonah Coleman. Receiver Dezmen Roebuck (42-560-7) and tight end Decker DeGraaf (32-360-2) are back and four-star receivers Jordan Clay, Mason James, and Trez Davis are part of Washington's highest-rated recruiting class in school history.

Who emerges at running back?

Jonah Coleman is off to the NFL and his heir apparent Adam Mohammed transferred to Cal. They added seniors Jayden Limar (Oregon) and Trey Cooley (Troy) out of the portal, but both missed the spring with injuries and Jordan Washington (27-233-1) was also injured in spring ball, so redshirt freshman Quaid Carr and true freshman Brian Bonner got most of the reps. Whoever emerges in the backfield should have a very good offensive line to run behind as four starters return including the Hatchett brothers – center Landen and right guard Geirean – plus five-star freshman Kodi Greene should start at left tackle.

Can the Huskies beat anyone good?

Washington has shown the ability to beat the teams that they are supposed to beat, but this is a program still looking for a signature victory to get the Husky faithful to fully believe in Fisch. The Huskies are just 2-7 in Big Ten road games under Fisch with the two victories coming last year at Maryland and at UCLA. This year there are tests at USC, at Oregon, and at Nebraska and hosting Indiana in the home finale. Much will depend on Williams, who had just 645 yards with three touchdowns and six interceptions in Washington's four defeats.

ODDS TO WIN...

120-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+400****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****25-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.1	24
YARDS PER POINT	12.6	17
PLAYS PER GAME	65.8	105
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:06	93
3RD DOWN CONV. %	47.2%	14
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	392.8	55
YARDS PER PLAY	6	27
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.7	74
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	153.3	63
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	51
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.3	101
COMPLETION %	69.4%	6
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	239.5	53
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.5	15
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.4	14
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	23
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.6%	59
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	319.2	21
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	18
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	102.3	12
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	15
COMPLETION %	60.6%	51
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	216.9	54
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	15
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.5	39

WISCONSIN BADGERS



It was thought that Luke Fickell would be the guy to restore Wisconsin Football to the Barry Alvarez era. It hasn't gone that way in Madison, though, as Fickell has gone 7-6, 5-7, and 4-8 in his three seasons and no coaching hot seat in the Big Ten is hotter than his. For the first time since 1978, the Badgers did not have a player get selected in the NFL Draft, a streak of 47 seasons.

This is a complete roster makeover with 33 transfers. For the fourth straight year, Wisconsin had to get a starting QB out of the portal with Colton Joseph from Old Dominion. Joseph (4,251 passing yards, 32 touchdowns; 1,654 rushing yards, 24 touchdowns over two seasons) was the Sun Belt Player of the Year and could provide a jolt for the worst scoring offense (12.8 PPG – 133rd) in the Power Four. Wisconsin scored 81 points in nine Big Ten games during the 2025 season. The defense was solid as usual, but this team will once again find wins hard to come by if these numbers do not improve.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

After the opener vs. Notre Dame at Lambeau Field, the schedule gets a bit more manageable with three of the next four games at home vs. Western Illinois, Eastern Michigan, and Michigan State. The Badgers also avoid Ohio State, Oregon, and Indiana. Joseph makes this offense better for sure, but the ceiling is still low with very few proven playmakers. Wisconsin had to rely more on the portal than usual and are looking for some kind of quick fix. Although the schedule is substantially easier, getting to seven wins is a big ask for a team that lacks talent at many positions.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 6-6 ATS, 2-10 O-U

Head Coach: Luke Fickell - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	VS. NOTRE DAME (+21)	68.5
9/12	W ILLINOIS (-43.5)	6.0
9/19	E MICHIGAN (-20.4)	28.0
9/26	AT PENN ST (+12.8)	57.0
10/3	MICHIGAN ST (-6.5)	42.5
10/17	AT UCLA (+2.1)	48.0
10/24	USC (+10.6)	60.0
10/31	AT IOWA (+11.3)	55.5
11/7	RUTGERS (-6.4)	42.5
11/14	AT MARYLAND (+0.3)	45.5
11/21	AT PURDUE (-6.8)	39.0
11/27	MINNESOTA (-0.6)	49.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **45.33**
#43 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

5

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can anyone make plays at receiver?

Wisconsin has very little production returning at the position, but that might not be a bad thing considering its leading receiver last year had less than 400 yards. The Badgers will need to rely on transfers and its young recruits. Chris Brooks Jr. and Eugene Hilton return, along with the additions of Oklahoma State transfer Shamar Rigby and Minnesota transfer Malachi Coleman. Offensive coordinator Jeff Grimes is likely to go with a more run-heavy approach, especially with a mobile QB like Joseph, but they need at least some production from this position.

Aside from Joseph, who is the Badgers rushing threat?

Wisconsin's identity has always been a power running game no matter who is the head coach, but last season they ranked just 115th nationally averaging just 116.7 yards per game. Leading rusher Darrion Dupree (83-363-2) returns but he has some company in the backfield with Abu Sama III (Iowa State) who rushed for 1933 yards and 13 touchdowns across three seasons and USC transfer Bryan Jackson II. Three starters are back on the offensive line to block for this group, but someone needs to emerge from the backfield as Joseph had more runs of 10 or more yards (37) than Wisconsin did as a team (33) last season.

How much of a load will the defense have to carry?

Somehow Wisconsin ranked 24th nationally in total defense being that they were on the field so often due to its anemic offense. Linebackers Cooper Catalano (56 tackles) and Mason Posa (61 tackles, four sacks) made major contributions as freshmen last season and now are the leaders of the unit, along with safety Matthew Jung (50 tackles). Aside from Jung, the secondary is all portal guys including Marvin Burks Jr. (Missouri), Javan Robinson (Arizona State), Cai Bates (Florida State), and Eric Fletcher (East Carolina). The front also has solid homegrown talent with Nicolas Clayton and Jaylen Williams alongside Sebastian Cheeks (three sacks). This could be a solid group again, but it really depends on if they can be kept off the field.

ODDS TO WIN...

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****30-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****150-1****BIG TEN**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	12.8	134
YARDS PER POINT	19.7	129
PLAYS PER GAME	60.3	135
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:38	44
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.3%	120
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	253.1	135
YARDS PER PLAY	4.2	133
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.3	65
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	116.7	110
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	122
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	22.7	126
COMPLETION %	57.7%	108
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	136.4	132
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	122
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.6	36
YARDS PER POINT	15	55
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.0%	54
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	323.6	23
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	43
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	105.3	15
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	17
COMPLETION %	69.8%	133
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	218.3	56
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	95
SACKS	2.6	23
TURNOVERS	0.5	134

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CONFERENCE USA

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

Recently, Conference USA has been the proving ground for teams moving up from the FCS ranks to the FBS world. This season, that is not the case, as the new teams are in the Mountain West and MAC. However, with Louisiana Tech off to the Sun Belt and UTEP to the Mountain West, Conference USA goes from 12 teams down to 10.

This is absolutely the weakest conference in college football. There were 136 FBS teams last season. Jeff Sagarin's end-of-season rankings had four teams in the conference 158th or lower. Four other teams were ranked 120th or lower. Ironically, the top two teams as ranked by Sagarin - Western Kentucky and Louisiana Tech - weren't even involved in the conference championship game. Kennesaw State won 19-15 over Jacksonville State in that one.

It was a truly impressive season for Kennesaw State. The Owls fired their longtime head coach during their first season as a FBS member in 2024 and hired Jerry Mack, who was a running backs coach in the NFL the season prior and had only been a head coach at NC Central in the mid-2010s. With that win, the Owls avenged their only conference regular-season loss and then got pumped by Western Michigan in the Myrtle Beach Bowl.

The Gamecocks may be able to avenge that title game loss, as they look to be a contender once again behind second-year head coach Charles Kelly, as the team lost head coach Rich Rodriguez, had very few returning starters, and still went 7-1 in league action before the loss in the title game.

Arguably the biggest storyline of the season is whether or not Liberty will bounce back. After a 21-5 start, including a College Football Playoff appearance, it all fell apart for Jamey Chadwell, as the Flames went just 4-8 last season. Liberty (+260) is the conference favorite over Western Kentucky (+280), who has the longest-tenured coach in the conference as Tyson Helton starts his eighth season. With Jacksonville State (+450) and Delaware (7-1) as the others lined in single digits, this looks to be a wide-open Group of Six conference again.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
W KENTUCKY	6.5	36.5	3.1	0.2	32.16 (106)	7.7	4.3	6.0	2.0
JACKSONVILLE ST	7.5	34	4.2	0.7	26.97 (134)	7.9	4.1	5.5	2.5
LIBERTY	8.5	34.5	2.1	0.2	27.06 (133)	8.1	3.9	5.4	2.6
KENNESAW ST	6.5	31.5	2	-0.6	30.78 (121)	6.5	5.5	4.5	3.5
DELAWARE	5.5	31	2.7	-0.1	30.85 (120)	6.1	5.9	4.3	3.7
FLA INTERNATIONAL	6.5	28.5	1.9	-0.1	27.93 (131)	6.0	6.0	4.1	3.9
NEW MEXICO ST	4.5	25	3.9	0	29.65 (126)	4.6	7.4	3.4	4.6
MISSOURI ST	4.5	25	2.8	0.1	33.83 (95)	4.2	7.8	3.0	5.0
MIDDLE TENN ST	3.5	21	1.2	-0.4	30.2 (123)	3.4	8.6	2.1	5.9
SAM HOUSTON ST	3.5	18.5	1.3	-0.1	32.22 (105)	2.7	9.3	1.7	6.3

DELAWARE

FIGHTIN' BLUE HENS



Accomplishments matter to these programs, especially the ones that have recently transitioned from FCS to FBS. For Delaware to finish last season with a bowl victory was a huge one for the trophy case, as Ryan Carty's Fightin' Blue Hens pulled the mild upset of Louisiana in the 68 Ventures Bowl. Whether that bowl game win had something to do with it or not, Delaware is in really good shape from a returning production standpoint, especially relative to their C-USA peers.

It all starts with QB Nick Minicucci, who threw for nearly 3,700 yards with a 23/7 TD/INT ratio. All of the running backs and top WR Sean Wilson are back around Minicucci, though his two best offensive linemen are not. Defensively, there's a bit of continuity here as well. While the Blue Hens were outgained on a per-play basis in C-USA action, the arrow seems to be pointing up in Year 2 with more scholarships and more depth.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

The most likely outcome for Delaware is 6-6 based on the heavy vig on Over 5.5, but Minicucci takes a lot of hits and the depth behind him is virtually non-existent. Add the long trek to the Land of Enchantment, reigning champ Kennesaw State, two road games against better P4 opponents than last season, and this year's schedule feels a bit trickier. Carty appears to be a solid coach and this appears to be a good program, but they were outgained on a per-play basis and struggled in the trenches in a subpar conference. My projection is 5.73 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-8 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Ryan Carty - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	MERRIMACK (-29.2)	4.0
9/12	AT VANDERBILT (+23.3)	51.5
9/19	COASTAL CAROLINA (-6)	28.0
9/26	AT VIRGINIA (+21.4)	50.5
10/2	LIBERTY (+1)	34.5
10/13	AT MIDDLE TENN ST (-8.7)	21.0
10/20	MISSOURI ST (-8.6)	25.0
10/27	AT W KENTUCKY (+8.7)	36.5
11/7	AT KENNESAW ST (+2.6)	31.5
11/14	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-5.3)	28.5
11/21	AT NEW MEXICO ST (-2)	25.0
11/28	JACKSONVILLE ST (+1)	34.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **30.85**
#120 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Manny Rojas put the 'D' back in 'elaware?

Even in a lackluster conference, the leap from FCS to FBS was on display on the defensive side for the Blue Hens. In their final season as a FCS member, they allowed 21 PPG and 5.3 YPP. In their first season at the FBS level, they allowed 31 PPG and 6.0 YPP. The biggest disappointment - or maybe most noticeable development - is that opponents ran for 4.6 yards per carry, including 4.5 YPC from Conference USA foes. Rojas has been with Delaware since 2020, so even before Carty took over. He kept him as the DC, but you wonder about his allegiance to him if the defense falters again in Year 2, especially with three of their four leading tacklers back and a few FBS-level transfers.

Will the offensive line be the team's downfall?

Last season, the Blue Hens only rushed for 3.8 YPC and a lot of that was because Minicucci had 112 carries for just 235 yards. His average of 2.1 YPC dragged down the team as a whole, though second-leading rusher Viron Ellison only had 3.9 YPC himself. While the offensive line technically only gave up 27 sacks, and just 14 in conference play, it was pretty clear that Minicucci was the reason why with scrambles and some designed short-yardage runs. Sadly, the Blue Hens lost two long-term OL starters in Patrick Shupp and Fintan Brose, though both tackles combined for 24 starts at various positions and the center is back as well. This was not an area flush with transfers for Delaware, so they'll have to hope internal options get better.

It's a game of adjustments, right?

Delaware played some tight games in league play, losing by a field goal to both Western Kentucky and Sam Houston State, while beating Middle Tennessee by three and Louisiana Tech by one. Coin flips like that will likely determine the outcome for the season, but those are more established programs at the FBS level with stronger recruiting pipelines. Delaware's talent level doesn't seem that much higher. They did not play Kennesaw State, Missouri State, or New Mexico State last season, but they will this season, with the NMSU game all the way out in Las Cruces on November 21. Kennesaw State won the conference. The others all have film on them now. How will Carty and his crew adjust?

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+700****CONFERENCE USA**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.5	45
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	65
PLAYS PER GAME	75.1	9
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:25	52
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.5%	55
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	411.2	30
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	65
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.6	110
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	118	108
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	101
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.4	6
COMPLETION %	61.6%	67
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	293.2	7
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	69
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.2	112
YARDS PER POINT	12.7	116
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.6%	78
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	410	97
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	97
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	156.4	72
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	85
COMPLETION %	62.4%	69
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	253.6	119
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	87
SACKS	2	63
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

FLORIDA INTERNATIONAL PANTHERS



An unsung hero in the 2025 coaching ranks was FIU's Willie Simmons, who took the team bowling for the first time since 2019. Mike MacIntyre was brought in to stabilize the ship after it hit extremely rough seas late in Butch Davis's tenure. He did, but with a trio of 4-8 seasons. Simmons, who was the head coach at Florida A&M and Prairie View A&M prior to getting this gig, coached the Panthers to their first winning record in conference play since 2018 and had nearly as many conference wins (5) as MacIntyre had over three years (6).

Simmons is college football's Mike Tomlin, as he has never had a losing season as a head coach. It got a little bit dicey last season, as FIU won four straight games to finish the regular season 7-5, otherwise the bowl blowout at the hands of UTSA could've ended that streak. Despite the financial commitment to this program from Armando Christian Perez, better known as Pitbull, and the school's location in Florida, this has been a hard place to win and a hard place to sustain winning.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

This is a pick for guide purposes, as the vig is heavy on the Under because the schedule is beefed up a bit more. What Simmons is doing is very impressive and this will be a highly competitive team yet again, plenty capable of getting to seven or eight wins if the ball bounces their way. However, their road games are at Jacksonville State, Liberty, Delaware, and Kennesaw State, who have three of the four shortest prices to win the conference. Roadies at USF and Florida Atlantic are tricky, especially in a revenge spot for the Owls, who lost in Miami last season. My projection is 5.99 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 8-5 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Willie Simmons - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+15.5)	41.0
9/12	BUFFALO (-2)	28.0
9/19	AT FLA ATLANTIC (+7.1)	33.5
9/26	LIU POST (-23.4)	7.0
10/7	NEW MEXICO ST (-5.4)	25.0
10/13	AT JACKSONVILLE ST (+9.8)	34.0
10/20	MIDDLE TENN ST (-9.8)	21.0
10/31	AT LIBERTY (+8.2)	34.5
11/7	MISSOURI ST (-5.3)	25.0
11/14	AT DELAWARE (+5.3)	31.0
11/21	AT KENNESAW ST (+5.1)	31.5
11/28	SAM HOUSTON ST (-12)	18.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **27.93**
#131 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

3

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does Simmons have in store for an encore?

So, that's the obvious first question. Interestingly, the team was worse in a few key statistical areas, falling from 5.7 to 5.6 YPP on offense and going up from 5.2 to 5.9 YPP on defense. However, if you look closer, what FIU did in conference play was very impressive. They racked up better than 6.2 YPP and allowed just over 5.6. It is always important to parse out the paycheck games for teams like this, where games at Penn State and at UConn don't have much merit in the metrics or for the next season. Unfortunately for Simmons, his leading QB, RB, WR, tackler, and defensive back are all gone, so he and his staff had a lot of work to do in the offseason.

Will Kohl cash in his latest opportunity?

To replace Keyone Jenkins, OC Nick Coleman and Simmons were able to wrangle JJ Kohl, who was originally at Iowa State then went to Appalachian State, where he had a 12/2 TD/INT ratio over six starts and some relief efforts. Kohl was a four-star in the 2023 class out of Iowa and is a massive human being at 6-foot-7 and 245 pounds. With a new QB, the loss of leading WR Alex Perry is probably less significant, as he was going to have to develop chemistry with everybody anyway, but Perry did have 530 more receiving yards and 25 more catches than anybody else, which is part of the reason why he's at Illinois now. It wouldn't be terribly surprising to see Kohl in something of a timeshare with Delaware transfer Zach Marker or freshman DJ Alexander, with the latter two as bigger running threats.

How much of a worry is the secondary?

Mister Clark had 13 pass breakups, primarily playing as the nickel, and also had 6.5 tackles for loss. He was a truly dynamic player on a defense that didn't have a lot of them. While the front seven has a few remaining pieces, including top sack man Kenton Simmons, the secondary is a grab bag of transfers. The projected starting corners are from Duke and FAU, while the player replacing Clark's role is a multi-time transfer, most recently from Oklahoma State. The safety position looks good with homegrown star Shamir Sterlin and two-year South Alabama starter Wesley Miller. The FIU QBs combined for 13 INT last season, but the defense had 21 takeaways (T-26th) and the team was exactly even in TO margin. Impact plays like that are going to be necessary again.

5000-1 CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1 MAKE THE PLAYOFF

11-1 CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.4	59
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	61
PLAYS PER GAME	71.8	36
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:35	29
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.1%	106
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	393.3	54
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	66
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.1	46
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	179.4	33
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	29
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.8	46
COMPLETION %	59.6%	87
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	213.9	83
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	98
TURNOVERS	1.7	111
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.8	109
YARDS PER POINT	13.2	105
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	71
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	417.7	107
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	95
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	166.4	84
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	103
COMPLETION %	60.9%	52
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	251.3	117
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	68
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	1.7	27

JACKSONVILLE STATE GAMECOCKS



It has been quite a ride thus far for Jacksonville State, as the Gamecocks have won nine games in four consecutive seasons, three of them as a FBS member. In that span, Jacksonville State is +24 in TO margin and that has made a huge difference, but they've also been good for two different head coaches in Rich Rodriguez and Charles Kelly. With Rich Rod back at West Virginia where it all started, the Gamecocks made what turned out to be a savvy hire of Kelly, who was an assistant here way back in the mid-90s. This is his first crack at being the head man in charge and Year 1 was a success.

We'll see what Year 2 has in store, as the Gamecocks will be without Cam Cook, who ran for 1,659 yards, but will fully turn the keys of the offense over to QB Caden Creel, a 1,000-yard rusher himself who also threw for over 1,500 yards. This was a much more efficient offense with Creel at the helm as opposed to Rutgers/Kentucky transfer Gavin Wimsatt and that means there's a lot of hope for this group, even if a new stud running back needs to emerge.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

This is not a bet, but I am cautiously optimistic that the Gamecocks can go 8-4 during the regular season. While they do go to Western Kentucky and Delaware, they avoid Liberty and should be comfortably favored in their four conference home tilts. This is an established program and even if there are some mild downturns, they can run the ball and might have the best QB in the conference. My projection is 7.47 wins.

2025 Record: 9-5 SU & 7-7 ATS, 8-6 O-U

Head Coach: Charles Kelly - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT N DAKOTA ST (+5.8)	37.0
9/5	E KENTUCKY (-22.2)	16.5
9/12	AT OHIO U (+0.6)	31.5
9/19	GA SOUTHERN (-5.2)	33.5
9/26	MIDDLE TENN ST (-17.6)	21.0
10/7	AT KENNESAW ST (-1.2)	31.5
10/13	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-9.8)	28.5
10/28	AT NEW MEXICO ST (-5.8)	25.0
11/7	SAM HOUSTON ST (-19.8)	18.5
11/14	AT W KENTUCKY (+4.9)	36.5
11/21	MISSOURI ST (-13.1)	25.0
11/28	AT DELAWARE (-1)	31.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **26.97**
#134 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **4.2 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

9

OFFENSE

4*

DEFENSE

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the running back by committee approach work?

Last season, Cook was a bell cow, racking up 295 rush attempts and 16 rushing touchdowns. Creel and Wimsatt were the next two leading rushers. Somebody is likely to emerge as more of a standout and perhaps it will be Jalen Likely, who only had seven carries in eight games last season, but had 7.4 yards per pop. He's just 5-foot-8, so taking a bunch of abuse like Cook did is likely out of the question. Justus Savage and Khristian Lando are bigger backs and both holdovers from last season, though OC Clint Trickett now holds the same role at Maryland. TE coach Taylor Housewright is the new OC and he has experience, having held the same role for two years at Montana State. Perhaps we see a little more throwing from Creel this season while waiting for an RB to step forward.

How will Housewright work Deondre Johnson into the offense?

Once upon a time in '24, Deondre made no money and life sure was slow. And all they said was 6'8" he stood and people thought the music that he made was good. (probably the first Montell Jordan reference in a VSIN Betting Guide) Alright, so I don't know if any of that is true - the money or the music - but 6-foot-8 WR Deondre Johnson is the top, and really only, returning receiver for the Gamecocks. He had 724 yards on just 30 receptions, as the next closest guy was TE Brock Rechsteiner with 36 grabs for 383 yards. With 59 trips into the red zone, Jacksonville State was just 93rd in TD%. Surely the 6-foot-8 guy will be more of a focal point this season, alongside a collection of transfers from other small schools and some homegrowns that will get more of an opportunity.

Is the Regression Monster lurking?

While the Gamecocks kept their streak of winning nine games alive, they scored nearly eight points per game fewer year over year, benefitting greatly from a +10 TO margin and a lot of wins in tight games. The Gamecocks were 7-2 in conference play with wins by 10, 2, 13, 3, 3, 9, and 3. Kennesaw State got revenge for their nine-point loss with a four-point win in the C-USA Title Game. Like I said, this is a team that is +24 in TO margin since joining the conference and was +11 in conference games, specifically, last season. They did average over six yards per play in conference games and did outgain the opposition overall and on a per-play basis, but not to the tune of a 7-2 record.

ODDS TO WIN...

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+450****CONFERENCE USA**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.8	64
YARDS PER POINT	14.9	80
PLAYS PER GAME	70.9	43
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:30	48
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.0%	82
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	399.3	43
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	46
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	46.5	5
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	240.6	5
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	19
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	22.6	127
COMPLETION %	59.9%	84
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	158.7	121
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	71
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.4	72
YARDS PER POINT	14.8	59
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.8%	45
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	390.2	77
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	75
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	148.5	61
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	52
COMPLETION %	61.0%	55
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	241.7	102
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	93
SACKS	2	63
TURNOVERS	1.7	26

KENNESAW STATE OWLS



The best story in the Group of Five may very well have been Kennesaw State and there were not enough people talking about it. This was a team that went 2-10 as a first-year FBS member in 2024. They went 10-4, won the conference, and did so with a first-year head coach and a lot of new personnel. The 2024 season was supposed to be a celebration for the program, finally graduating to FBS status with the wheels set in motion when they won 11+ games in four straight full seasons from 2017-21. But, as the team got closer, Brian Bohannon became less successful, going 5-6 in 2022 and 3-6 in 2023. He was fired nine games into the 2024 season, even after an incredible upset of Liberty a few weeks earlier.

A lot of players left in light of Bohannon's departure, but Jerry Mack got to work, quickly rebuilding the roster and he hit a home run with QB Amari Odom, who stabilized the offense and gave them a dual-threat component. With Odom gone, and the standards for the program reestablished, Mack's encore performance is going to be one to follow.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

From conference champs to maybe not even making a bowl game? There are a lot of signs that point in that direction. Even though there is only one clear loss on the schedule in non-conference as opposed to what we all assumed was two last season (only lost 10-9 to Wake Forest), the conference schedule is tough and it does seem like the teams in some of the toss-up games may have improved more than the Owls. My projection is 6.34 wins.

2025 Record: 10-4 SU & 9-5 ATS, 6-8 O-U

Head Coach: Jerry Mack - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	W GEORGIA (-14.2)	19.0
9/12	GEORGIA ST (-10.6)	23.0
9/19	AT TENNESSEE (+30)	57.0
9/26	AT ARKANSAS ST (+5.7)	33.5
10/7	JACKSONVILLE ST (+1.2)	34.0
10/14	AT MISSOURI ST (-3.1)	25.0
10/21	LIBERTY (+1.2)	34.5
10/28	AT MIDDLE TENN ST (-8.7)	21.0
11/7	DELAWARE (-2.6)	31.0
11/14	AT SAM HOUSTON ST (-11.1)	18.5
11/21	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-5.1)	28.5
11/28	AT W KENTUCKY (+8.7)	36.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **30.78**
#121 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

3

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Where's the offense?

This is a complete rebuild on offense. Odom is now at Syracuse and Dexter Williams is also gone. Rickie Collins transferred in from Syracuse and Landon Varnes was a JUCO starter with 31 TD passes against 14 picks last season at Mississippi Gulf Coast. Varnes picked the Owls over Arkansas State and Eastern Michigan, so we'll see if he ends up beating out Collins. Regardless of who barks out the signals, all of last season's running backs are gone and all but two wide receivers are elsewhere. OC Mitch Militello is a branch of the Josh Heupel tree and you wonder if maybe he has the personnel now to play faster. The Owls averaged 69 plays per game last season, but it wouldn't be surprising to see that number go up.

Can the Owls find more defensive consistency?

This is not a good offensive conference, but the Owls gave up more than 400 yards per game and were outgained by 0.5 yards per carry. While they did outgain the opposition on a per-play basis thanks to some explosives in the passing game, this was a defense that allowed nearly 6.5 yards per play in the month of November when the schedule ramped up. They had a 41-34 win over Missouri State and a 48-42 win over Liberty in a double-overtime tilt. They also got completely smacked by Western Michigan in the Myrtle Beach Bowl. The Owls were outgained in four of their eight conference wins. The top three tacklers are back, but will this defense take a step forward?

Is more Mack magic on the horizon?

As mentioned, this was virtually a brand-new team last season and it will be full of new faces again this season. Mack brought in more than 60 players via the portal last season. 247Sports has 29 graded transfers for the Owls and their class ranks third in the conference behind Sam Houston and Liberty. An eight-win improvement year over year was just incredible, especially with two Power Four teams to start the season in Wake Forest and Indiana. On one hand, it's fair to be excited that some of the transfers that didn't feature prominently last season will have the chance now in Year 2 in the system. On the other hand, there is basically zero returning production on offense and what are the chances lightning strikes again?

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****10-1****CONFERENCE USA**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.7	65
YARDS PER POINT	15.2	88
PLAYS PER GAME	71.3	42
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:41	105
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.9%	64
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	406.5	34
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	42
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.2	33
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	159.8	56
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	87
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.2	83
COMPLETION %	61.0%	78
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	246.7	45
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	22
TURNOVERS	1.3	76
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.5	73
YARDS PER POINT	15.6	36
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.0%	47
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	413.4	103
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	85
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	192.9	116
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	104
COMPLETION %	61.8%	61
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	220.5	59
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	71
SACKS	2.1	60
TURNOVERS	1.2	85

LIBERTY FLAMES



From one of the nation's biggest surprises to one of the biggest disappointments. Kennesaw State's eight-win improvement was a shocker, but so was Liberty's complete reversal of fortunes, going from 8-4 to 4-8, as head coach Jamey Chadwell posted his worst record since 2017 when he was the interim HC at Coastal Carolina while Joe Moglia tended to health issues and the Chanticleers went 3-9.

It is hard to pinpoint the cause of the Flames' decline, as they only beat Maine, UTEP, New Mexico State, and Delaware, losing four times as a favorite. While it is reasonable to point out Liberty's bad luck in close games, losing the last three in overtime to FIU, Louisiana Tech, and Kennesaw State, it was the sign of a team that didn't pay attention to the details. They had more interceptions than passing touchdowns, didn't have sacks or takeaways on defense, and didn't seem to have much leadership. As Chadwell begins Year 4 with a new DC, a bounce back is expected.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 8.5

It seems like just about every unit for Liberty has been improved in some way. We'll see if the QB position is actually better and if Udoh can match what Dickens did, but the depth is stronger at both positions and the offensive line looks significantly better. The biggest selling point for me, though, is the hire of Quinn as DC. Virginia Tech almost always has a strong defense and this is a guy who can identify talent in the DMV at a very high level. I fully expect the defense to be better against the run and that should make a huge difference. My projection is 8.24 wins, but I like their chances to win more of the close games.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 3-9 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Jamey Chadwell - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT JAMES MADISON (+10.9)	41.5
9/12	GARDNER WEBB (-21.4)	14.5
9/19	BALL ST (-17.1)	20.0
9/24	AT COASTAL CAROLINA (-4.5)	28.0
10/2	AT DELAWARE (-1)	31.0
10/8	SAM HOUSTON ST (-18.2)	18.5
10/21	AT KENNESAW ST (-1.2)	31.5
10/31	FLA INTERNATIONAL (-8.2)	28.5
11/7	AT NEW MEXICO ST (-5.8)	25.0
11/14	MIDDLE TENN ST (-16)	21.0
11/21	W KENTUCKY (+0.10)	36.5
11/28	AT MISSOURI ST (-6.9)	25.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **27.06**
#133 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

6

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Chadwell fix the passing game?

It's hardly a coincidence that Chadwell was getting ready to leave Coastal Carolina just as Grayson McCall was running out of eligibility. Chadwell did get former Chanticleer Ethan Vasko to transfer in, but that didn't really work out well, as he posted a 10/12 TD/INT ratio, threw for under 2,000 yards, and had just 2.6 yards per carry on 100 attempts. Vasko is still on the roster, but Chadwell also went to the transfer portal store and picked out Deshawn Purdie, formerly at Wake Forest. He also picked up some WR transfers from Charleston Southern and Indiana. Chadwell's offense is predicated on a lot of pre-snap motion to get guys into space, but Vasko didn't make those throws. Purdie is only a 50% passer over 282 attempts. While Chadwell has options, it remains to be seen if any of them are good.

But maybe he doesn't have to?

One of the top free agent pickups in the conference is former Army running back Kanye Udoh. After running for 1,117 yards in 2024, Udoh was able to transfer out of West Point and wound up at Arizona State, where he didn't see much action. Now he's back on the East Coast to fill the big cleats of Evan Dickens, who was a bright spot for an otherwise lackluster offense with 1,339 yards and 16 TD out of the backfield. Peyton Jones from Duke and Kam Davis from Florida State seem promising as well. When Chadwell had McCall, it was a pass-first offense. Now that he doesn't, it's a run-first offense with 508 carries against 316 pass attempts last season. All the QBs need to do is complete enough passes to keep defenses honest.

Is new DC Shawn Quinn the right man for the job?

Coordinator hires can be a huge deal at any program, but especially in the G6 conferences because the talent levels vary so much. Quinn, who was the outside linebackers coach at Virginia Tech, went 16-6 as the head coach at Savannah State before joining the Hokies. Ironically, Quinn was the DC the year before Chadwell took over at Charleston Southern, so the two have probably crossed paths, but never worked together until now. Leading tackler Derrell Farrar is back, but this is mostly a blank slate for Quinn. That's good because what hurt Liberty last season was allowing 0.7 more yards per carry than the two previous seasons and a linebackers coach turned DC should be able to fix that.

ODDS TO WIN...

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****84-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+260****CONFERENCE USA**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.4	75
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	91
PLAYS PER GAME	70.1	53
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:23	53
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.8%	83
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	388.6	63
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	57
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.1	16
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	193.3	23
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	39
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.7	116
COMPLETION %	54.8%	126
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	195.4	97
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	48
TURNOVERS	1.9	125
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.3	82
YARDS PER POINT	13.5	97
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.6%	121
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	381.8	66
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	76
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	179.2	101
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	96
COMPLETION %	59.8%	35
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	202.6	35
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	56
SACKS	1.2	121
TURNOVERS	1.1	86

MIDDLE TENNESSEE STATE BLUE RAIDERS



A very important Year 3 for head coach Derek Mason is on the horizon, as back-to-back 3-9 seasons have not inspired much confidence in the direction of the program. The Men of Murfreesboro haven't seen a bowl game since 2022 and saw modest improvement in 2025, but not nearly enough to be pleased with how things played out. Despite Mason's background on the defensive side of the ball, MTSU allowed 34.3 PPG in Year 1 and 30.9 PPG in Year 2, though they did improve by 0.8 yards per play.

With very minimal, if any, improvements to the offense, a new OC has hit the town, as Anthony Scelfo, previously at Southeastern Louisiana, is the new OC. We'll see if Scelfo can build on some late-season offensive gains under QB Roman Gagliano, who stuck around with the program despite opening some eyes over the final three games.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Bowl eligibility still looks like a tall task, but five wins is attainable, especially at the plus-money price being offered. Scelfo and a more robust running game with a more mobile QB should help, especially in C-USA, where teams that run the ball efficiently often fare better than others. I'll give Mason the benefit of the doubt that after his third portal and freshmen classes that he has players that better fit what he wants to do on defense. MTSU lost by 20 to FCS Austin Peay to open last season, so I presume they'll be ready for Murray State and they went out to Reno and beat Nevada last season. If they can split the non-conference games, three wins are available in conference play. My projection is 4.1 wins, but I like the value on the Over.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 6-6 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Derek Mason - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MURRAY ST (-17.7)	5.5
9/12	AT MARSHALL (+16.4)	34.0
9/19	NEVADA (+5.8)	28.0
9/26	AT JACKSONVILLE ST (+17.6)	34.0
10/3	AT KANSAS (+28.6)	46.0
10/13	DELAWARE (+8.7)	31.0
10/20	AT FLA INTERNATIONAL (+9.8)	28.5
10/28	KENNESAW ST (+8.7)	31.5
11/7	W KENTUCKY (+14.5)	36.5
11/14	AT LIBERTY (+16)	34.5
11/21	AT SAM HOUSTON ST (-0.80)	18.5
11/28	NEW MEXICO ST (+2.8)	25.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 30.20
#123 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 1.2 / -0.4
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

6

OFFENSE

2

DEFENSE

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Roman the right man to follow into battle?

Under Gagliano, the offense scored 26, 31, and 31 points with 541, 460, and 459 yards, numbers that were almost untouchable prior to Nicholas Vattiato’s injury. With over 1,000 passing yards in three starts and a couple of relief appearances to go with 4.3 yards per carry on 39 tries and a 7/0 TD/INT ratio, the question has to be asked - why wasn’t he starting to begin with? I won’t pretend to know the dynamics in the locker room or in the building, but the redshirt freshman was surely making less NIL money than the program’s all-time second-leading passer and it does feel like some teams, especially those at the G6 level, are unwilling to move on from entrenched starters that they have invested in.

Will Roman rebuild the offense in a day?

Probably not, but at least the end-of-season developments were promising. Scelfo has been at SE Louisiana coaching under his father since 2021, as this will be his first time calling plays at the FBS level. While Gagliano returns, others do not, as Cam’ron Lacy is back after leading the team with 549 yards, but nobody else with 30+ catches is back and leading rusher Jekail Middlebrook has also moved on. However, the running back room looks a lot stronger with holdover DJ Taylor, who had 7.7 yards per carry on just 26 attempts, Saginaw Valley State transfer Terence Brown, and Antonio Martin, who rushed for over five yards per pop for SELA in Scelfo’s first season as OC in 2024. Even if Gagliano isn’t the real deal, MTSU should run the ball a lot better.

Can Derek fix the ‘D’?

The cupboard wasn’t totally bare on defense when Mason took over for longtime head coach Rick Stockstill, but it wasn’t fully stocked either. Still, it was shocking to see MTSU give up 6.7 yards per play in his first year. After getting some better players in the front seven, the Blue Raiders shaved 1.2 yards per carry off year over year, but the secondary continued to struggle. MTSU was tied for 105th in the nation in passing plays of 20+ yards allowed. There are very few noteworthy holdovers from last season, except for Reggie Johnson, who was second in sacks with 3.5. This is a mostly rebuilt defense via the transfer portal, both from this past cycle and the one before it.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

50-1

CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.2	91
YARDS PER POINT	16.9	114
PLAYS PER GAME	70.7	47
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:23	85
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.3%	68
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	391.5	58
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	59
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.6	134
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	110.5	118
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	81
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.8	5
COMPLETION %	61.3%	72
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	280.9	12
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	91
TURNOVERS	1.2	56
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.6	100
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	101
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.9%	62
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	406.5	89
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	102
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	144.5	55
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	50
COMPLETION %	65.4%	107
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	261.9	123
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.3	120
SACKS	1.7	92
TURNOVERS	1.4	54

MISSOURI STATE BEARS



Missouri State is starting over in more ways than one this season. Former SMU OC Casey Woods is now the head coach and returning production is hard to find on the depth chart, as a lot of players followed head coach Ryan Beard to Coastal Carolina or found homes elsewhere. It's no surprise that Beard was scooped up, as he took the Bears to a bowl game in their first FBS season and outgained Arkansas State in a losing effort to finish 7-6.

Year 2 is always an interesting one for teams that recently transitioned, as they have more scholarships available, but also can't really sneak up on opponents anymore. Also, you often bid adieu to productive players who wanted to see the transition through and then either ran out of eligibility or got some more looks and better offers. The 43-year-old Woods has worked under Gus Malzahn, Eli Drinkwitz, Rhett Lashlee, and his dad Sparky has been a ball coach since 1976.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

The juice is heavy on this one, but it's really the only way to look. Perhaps Woods turns Belin or Locklear into a quality starting QB, but this is a team with major questions in the trenches and that is a lot to overlook given the uncertainty at the most important position on the field. This seems like a transitional year to get a feel for things and then Woods will find himself a more suitable QB in Year 2. They play all of the conference's top teams, including Western Kentucky, Delaware, and Jacksonville State on the road, so it could be a long year. My projection is 4.12 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & ATS, 5-8 O-U
Head Coach: Casey Woods - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT TEXAS A&M (+39.8)	62.5
9/12	LINDENWOOD (-14.3)	13.5
9/19	MARSHALL (+6.7)	34.0
9/26	AT SMU (+34.4)	55.5
10/8	AT W KENTUCKY (+14.5)	36.5
10/14	KENNESAW ST (+3.1)	31.5
10/20	AT DELAWARE (+8.6)	31.0
10/27	SAM HOUSTON ST (-9.4)	18.5
11/7	AT FLA INTERNATIONAL (+5.3)	28.5
11/14	NEW MEXICO ST (-2.8)	25.0
11/21	AT JACKSONVILLE ST (+13.1)	34.0
11/28	LIBERTY (+6.9)	34.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **33.83**
#95 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.8 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

5

OFFENSE

2

DEFENSE

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will fill the large cleats of Jacob Clark?

Clark was signed as an undrafted free agent by the Raiders, leaving Missouri State as the program's all-time second-leading passer. He posted a 28/11 TD/INT ratio in his final season, a year in which he played through some injuries and even missed a start. He's a notable loss and his absence is exacerbated by the loss of Shomari Lawrence, who ran for 1,021 yards and seven touchdowns. The next leading rusher was Ramone Green with just 52 carries for 278 yards. Duke transfer Henry Belin and UTEP transfer Skyler Locklear are the two QB newcomers via the portal, along with holdovers Cole Feuerbacher and Elijah Leonard. Belin spent four years with the Blue Devils and basically never saw the field. Locklear had turnover issues for the Miners. Locklear's QB coach from last season, Mark Cala, is the new OC, so we'll see how that dynamic plays out.

Will whoever plays QB even have a chance?

While King Large is an all-name team member and the projected starter at left tackle, he, like so many others on the line, is unproven. On one hand, that may not be a bad thing. The Bears allowed 52 sacks last season and mustered just 3.5 yards per carry, even with Lawrence's success. That's because when Clark wasn't sacked, he was busy running for his life with 94 carries for -16 yards. There is virtually no FBS experience with this group, but this is a program that has had problems protecting the QB since 2020, allowing 40+ sacks in five of those six seasons. Woods brought Hussam Ouri with him from SMU to serve as the offensive line coach and he might be the most important guy on that sideline this season.

Is the picture on defense any better?

A little bit, as leading tackler Jared Lloyd is back, along with two other starters in Christian Ford and Dylan Dixon. This wasn't a great defense last season anyway, as they allowed 5.9 YPP, including 388 rushing yards to a bad Louisiana Tech team in the season finale, though the players probably knew that Beard was on his way out. New DC Jack Curtis has over a decade's worth of experience in that role, but, much like the offense, the trenches are a focal point. Auburn had 30 sacks last season and held opponents to under three yards per carry with Curtis as a defensive analyst and assistant DL coach Brett Kulka, who will coach defensive ends for Missouri State.

5000-1 CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1 MAKE THE PLAYOFF

28-1 CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.3	83
YARDS PER POINT	16.1	104
PLAYS PER GAME	70	55
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:25	31
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.4%	99
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	390.1	60
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	55
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.3	103
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	111	116
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	115
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.5	41
COMPLETION %	63.4%	48
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	279.1	13
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.3	19
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.3	95
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	109
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.6%	79
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	396.6	81
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	104
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	160.5	75
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	101
COMPLETION %	63.7%	86
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	236.1	92
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	85
SACKS	1.9	69
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

NEW MEXICO STATE

AGGIES



The job that Jerry Kill did in Las Cruces seems to get more and more impressive with each passing day. Kill was the head coach of the Aggies in 2022 and 2023, leading them to a 17-11 record. Tony Sanchez has won seven games in two seasons. This is a very difficult job and success has been hard to come by to say the least. Aside from Kill's 7-6 and 10-5 campaigns, the program has one other winning season (2017) dating back to 2002. In many of those seasons, they've had three or fewer wins.

Frankly, it was surprising to see NMSU improve their record at all last season, going from 3-9 to 4-8, as they had as many interceptions (16) as touchdowns and had the absolute worst rushing offense in the nation. But, they went from -13 in TO margin in Sanchez's first season to exactly even last season, so the defense found more takeaways to help the cause, including nine fumble recoveries. The bar is low, but the Aggies will once again struggle to clear it.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Perhaps this is Sanchez's best team, but others in C-USA look improved, too, and every road trip is a hike for this team. Not only do they go to Miami and the Nashville area in conference play, but they have non-conference trips to Tallahassee and Honolulu. Depth was a huge issue last season and looks to be again, as 247Sports does have the program with 26 portal players, but the seventh-ranked class out of 10 teams. My projection is 4.61 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 6-6 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Tony Sanchez - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT FLORIDA ST (+27.9)	50.0
9/5	MERCYHURST (-23.8)	5.0
9/12	AT HAWAII (+17.2)	38.5
9/26	NEW MEXICO (+12.9)	42.0
10/1	W KENTUCKY (+7.8)	36.5
10/7	AT FLA INTERNATIONAL (+5.4)	28.5
10/21	AT SAM HOUSTON ST (-5.2)	18.5
10/28	JACKSONVILLE ST (+5.8)	34.0
11/7	LIBERTY (+5.8)	34.5
11/14	AT MISSOURI ST (+2.8)	25.0
11/21	DELAWARE (+2)	31.0
11/28	AT MIDDLE TENN ST (-2.8)	21.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **29.65**
#126 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / 0**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

4

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the offense be “Hedden” in the right direction?

Sanchez and OC David Yost, who has run productive offenses in the past at Texas Tech and Utah State, have choices at QB this season. Adam Damante, who started two games last season, is the top holdover, while Trey Hedden and Kalani McLeod came in via the portal. Hedden had turnover issues at Furman with a 30/22 TD/INT ratio, but also threw for more than 4,700 yards over 20 starts and change. McLeod took his only FBS offer and transferred in from Diablo Valley College. Given Hedden’s D-I experience, he’s the leader in the clubhouse to start, but everybody probably gets a look at some point.

What about the skill positions?

As mentioned, this was the worst rushing attack in the nation. The Aggies mustered just 77 rush yards per game and only crossed the century mark twice. Sprinter James Jones transferred in from Delaware State and true freshman Xavier Rucker was the highest-rated freshman to join the program. At wide receiver, three of the top four pass-catchers are gone, but nobody had eye-popping numbers. Truth be told, while offensive linemen aren’t really classified as skill-position players, this is the unit of the offense that looks the most improved with some starting experience at the FCS and JUCO ranks and one returning starter. That’s not to say that the offense will suddenly put up great numbers, but the running game should at least improve.

Is the defense ripe for regression?

While the defensive numbers improved greatly year over year, with nearly nine fewer PPG allowed and 0.8 fewer YPP, it really came down to simply forcing more turnovers. The Aggies only had 10 takeaways in 2024, including just one fumble recovery. Fumble luck was on their side with nine of them in 2025 to go along with 15 interceptions. The Aggies were also tied for 22nd in terms of red-zone attempts against. As encouraging as all of those things are, and there are a good number of returning starters and contributors, the defense still only managed 19 sacks and only has 33 sacks over the last two seasons. Ezra Christensen led the team with six sacks and 10 QB hits. Jamall Thompson had four sacks. Both are gone.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

25-1

CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.8	100
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	85
PLAYS PER GAME	72.6	26
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:16	56
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.3%	33
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	329.7	106
YARDS PER PLAY	4.5	126
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.5	123
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	77.3	134
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.6	132
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.2	9
COMPLETION %	59.3%	94
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	252.5	37
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	112
TURNOVERS	2.1	133
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.8	91
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	83
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.0%	90
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	415.3	105
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	80
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	173.8	94
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	91
COMPLETION %	64.0%	92
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	241.5	100
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	61
SACKS	1.4	112
TURNOVERS	2	7

SAM HOUSTON STATE BEARKATS



I wasn't right about everything in last year's College Football Betting Guide, but I was right about Sam Houston. The Bearkats went from 10-3 to 2-10, as Year 1 for Phil Longo did not work out at all. The offense was terrible, the defense was worse, and the Bearkats started 0-8 before a couple of stunning upsets over Oregon State and Delaware. They were favored once and lost that game by 27 points at New Mexico State.

On the plus side, Sam Houston will be playing back in their home stadium after being forced to relocate last season due to renovations. SHSU was on the plus side last season in turnover margin at +2, but still got outscored by 20 PPG overall and 19 PPG in conference play. It is extremely difficult to build off of those disastrous kinds of numbers, especially with seven yards per play allowed. Despite the debacle, the Bearkats still roll into the 2026 season with the same head coach and the same coordinators.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

The betting market seems to share that same sentiment with heavy juice on another 3-9 or worse campaign. The defense has experienced a full facelift, but there is no way to erase the scars of giving up nearly 500 yards per game in this conference. A dearth of talent is one thing, but that doesn't inspire a lot of confidence in the play-caller either. And then on the other side of the ball, Longo is in Year 2 of trying to install a new scheme, but he's attempting to put a Dodge Dart engine into a Geo Prizm. It's possible that this year's roster is closer to what he wants, but probably not close enough for much improvement. My projection is 2.66 wins.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 3-9 ATS, 7-5 O-U

Head Coach: Phil Longo - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT TROY (+20.2)	36.0
9/12	TULSA (+12.1)	32.5
9/19	NICHOLLS ST (-8.1)	12.5
9/26	AT TEXAS TECH (+47)	61.5
10/8	AT LIBERTY (+18.2)	34.5
10/14	W KENTUCKY (+16.9)	36.5
10/21	NEW MEXICO ST (+5.2)	25.0
10/27	AT MISSOURI ST (+9.4)	25.0
11/7	AT JACKSONVILLE ST (+19.8)	34.0
11/14	KENNESAW ST (+11.1)	31.5
11/21	MIDDLE TENN ST (+0.8)	21.0
11/28	AT FLA INTERNATIONAL (+12)	28.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.22**
#105 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.3 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

4

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

(Sam) Houston, what are the problems on offense?

Well, there are a lot of them. Longo has been a longtime OC who likes to play with tempo and move the ball with the Air Raid. The QBs combined for a 12/10 TD/INT ratio and mustered just 2,209 yards. The running game was serviceable with 4.3 yards per carry and running backs that averaged 5.8, 6.7, and 4.2 YPC, as the QBs dragged down the average big time. Ultimately, the QBs were the root of all the problems. The offensive line was far from great with 36 sacks allowed, but finishing 127th in PPG falls on the guys barking out the offense and the guys calling it. Landyn Locke threw for 765 yards last season and only completed 50.4% of his passes. He's the projected starter.

Can the defense get better even if the offense doesn't?

It could, and should, given that this was the worst defense in the nation in yards allowed per game. Even with UNLV, Hawaii, Texas, and Oregon State in non-conference play, the Bearkats still gave up more yards on a per-game basis to conference opponents in a terrible offensive conference. Among teams with exactly 12 games played, only Stanford allowed more passing yards. Only Georgia State, UAB, and UMass allowed more points per game. Returning production would be an oxymoron here, but there really isn't much of it anyway, as second-year DC Freddie Aughtry-Lindsay did a lot of portal shopping. 247Sports has the Bearkats down for the best portal haul in the conference and the secondary was a huge focal point.

Will the real Sam Houston please stand up?

KC Keeler returned home to southeastern Pennsylvania to take over at Temple following a 10-3 season in 2024. While that was thoroughly impressive, the Bearkats were just 3-9 with Keeler at the helm in 2023, their first season in Conference USA. The 10-3 team only scored 23.8 PPG with 20.5 PPG against and was only +0.2 in YPP differential. A +12 TO margin really did a lot of heavy lifting, as the team finished -2 in sack differential and went 6-0 in games decided by six or fewer points, including the New Orleans Bowl win over Georgia Southern. In other words, it's hard not to look at this team and feel like 2023 and 2025 are more of what we should expect.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

80-1

CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.8	122
YARDS PER POINT	17.8	123
PLAYS PER GAME	66.3	97
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:28	112
3RD DOWN CONV. %	22.2%	136
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	316.8	119
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	115
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.8	117
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	132.8	91
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	62
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.4	51
COMPLETION %	54.8%	127
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	184	108
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.7	130
TURNOVERS	1.3	78
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	37.8	132
YARDS PER POINT	12.8	115
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.7%	115
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	483.4	136
YARDS PER PLAY	6.8	134
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	207.5	124
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.4	131
COMPLETION %	70.4%	135
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	275.9	130
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	131
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.5	39

WESTERN KENTUCKY HILLTOPPERS



Virtually every college football program is in a constant state of motion these days given the current landscape of the sport. Sometimes, though, there are some programs that appear to be more stable than others and Western Kentucky seems to be one of them. While the ceiling isn't going to scrape the clouds, the floor is quite high in Bowling Green, where Tyson Helton has won at least eight games in six of his seven seasons. He's won nine games four times in that span and has only missed a bowl game once and we can probably blame COVID for that.

While Helton has been a constant, his right-hand man on offense hasn't been, and the Hilltoppers have a new OC this season in Bodie Reeder, who has run some pretty potent passing offenses, and seems to have a better fit here than his previous one at Middle Tennessee. If Reeder can get WKU back over 30 PPG, the consistent play from the defense will have the Hilltoppers poised for their first conference title since 2016.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

This is something of an alt win total because 6.5 is the prevailing number, but with very heavy Over vig. The tough part about this bet is that WKU may very well start 0-3, as they open the season a long way from home against Nevada before getting pummeled by Indiana and Georgia. But, the stage is set to go into the bye at 4-3. Four of the five toughest conference games come late in the year, when the growing pains may be a thing of the past. My projection is 7.2 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 10-3 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Tyson Helton - 8th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT NEVADA (-7.3)	28.0
9/12	AT GEORGIA (+32.7)	67.5
9/19	AT INDIANA (+33.1)	66.0
9/26	MERCYHURST (-34.5)	5.0
10/1	AT NEW MEXICO ST (-7.8)	25.0
10/8	MISSOURI ST (-14.5)	25.0
10/14	AT SAM HOUSTON ST (-16.9)	18.5
10/27	DELAWARE (-8.7)	31.0
11/7	AT MIDDLE TENN ST (-14.5)	21.0
11/14	JACKSONVILLE ST (-4.9)	34.0
11/21	AT LIBERTY (-0.1)	34.5
11/28	KENNESAW ST (-8.7)	31.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.16**
#106 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.1 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

4*

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How much will Rodney Tisdale improve?

Last season, QB Maverick McIvor and OC Rick Bowie were a package deal from Abilene Christian. McIvor did complete 67% of his passes, but had just a 12/7 TD/INT ratio, and wasn't much of a runner, though the Hilltoppers did go up nearly 4.5 PPG year over year. Bowie was a one-and-done, so Reeder now has the keys to the offense and Tisdale, who took over for McIvor, is the man in the spotlight. He completed just under 66% of his passes with a 9/7 TD/INT ratio and had 2.1 yards per carry. The numbers weren't great, but he was a true freshman and, while he has to learn a new playbook, he's the most dynamic option on the roster. Florida State transfer Brock Glenn has a chance at a fresh start here if Tisdale falters or gets hurt.

How long does it take the offense to gel?

Not only are there questions about Tisdale and Reeder, but KD Hutchinson is the only returnee of consequence at the skill positions. Tulsa transfer Ajay Allen will likely lead the by-committee approach at RB that had decent returns last season. Georgia Tech transfer Zion Taylor is probably the most notable WR added to the mix, but Jyzaiah Rockwell was a 1,100-yard receiver at the FCS ranks last season. It should be noted that the offensive line, while a hodgepodge of transfers, has a lot more experience and size than last season's group, including an Alabama transfer. If Tisdale can distribute the ball without turning it over and prove to be more of a running threat, this unit will be cooking with gas quickly.

Is the defense at risk of regressing?

Jaylen Lewis and Dave Herrard are really the only two returning contributors on defense, as DC Davis Merritt had a lot of scouting work to do. One silver lining is that only three players had 70+ tackles last season, as the Hilltoppers rotated a ton of guys in and out to try and stay fresh. Some of last season's backups will elevate to starting roles and that means that they've been in the system and are familiar with the scheme. Merritt has been on the staff for the last three years, so everything is pretty ingrained with those who are back in the fold. Last year's defense only had 19 sacks, though, but still allowed just 22.6 PPG, the fewest since 2019 when the Hilltoppers allowed just 20.1 PPG and just 3.7 yards per carry. Stopping the run was an issue last season that needs to be fixed this season and the low sack numbers and complete turnover with the front seven all have me pessimistic about the defense.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

150-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+280

CONFERENCE USA

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.4	59
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	62
PLAYS PER GAME	71.7	38
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:32	80
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.2%	17
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	393.7	52
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	64
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.8	108
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	132.1	93
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	79
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38	13
COMPLETION %	64.7%	37
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	261.6	28
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	78
TURNOVERS	1.8	117
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.3	51
YARDS PER POINT	17	17
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.6%	38
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	413.3	102
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	82
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	178.8	98
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	115
COMPLETION %	56.2%	15
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	234.5	87
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	30
SACKS	1.3	117
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

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INDEPENDENTS

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

Notre Dame and UConn are on two very different paths this season. With the new College Football Playoff qualification and seeding rules, all the Fighting Irish have to do is finish in the top 12 in the CFP rankings and they will automatically be in the field. Based on how good Notre Dame looks this season, it would be a major upset if they aren't in the field. In fact, DraftKings had the Fighting Irish at -800 to Make the CFP and the 'No' was 5-1 for anybody brave enough to take that chance.

While UConn never has CFP aspirations, the Huskies were at least worthy of being mentioned in the same breath as the Fighting Irish with back-to-back 9-4 seasons. Unfortunately, it does look like the tide will turn in Storrs, at least to some degree, with Jim Mora Jr. now at Colorado State. Many believe that Jason Candle is a good hire, but he's had a knack for losing games as a favorite over the course of his career at Toledo and the Huskies have basically nobody back from last season's team.

The story is different in South Bend. While star RBs Jeremiyah Love and Jadarian Price are now in the NFL, QB CJ Carr is among the Heisman favorites and the defense is chock full of returning production. After missing out on the CFP last season and after losing to Ohio State in the CFP Championship the previous season, there may not be a more motivated team than the Fighting Irish and the schedule has absolutely softened up after last season's early losses to Miami and Texas A&M proved too much to overcome in the rankings.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
NOTRE DAME	11.5	68.5	3.8	1	43.31 (59)	11.2	0.8	0.0	0.0
CONNECTICUT	5.5	31.5	3.9	0.2	32.83 (100)	5.3	6.7	0.0	0.0

CONNECTICUT HUSKIES



Jim Mora Jr. won 27 games in his four seasons at the helm with UConn. From 2012-21, the program had 26 wins. With Jason Candle taking over, the program ranks 138th in Phil Steele's Experience chart. With North Dakota State and Sacramento State now in FBS, 138th is officially dead last. That being said, while there's no returning talent from last year's Huskies team, Candle did bring some Toledo talent with him, so he's not walking into the facility with zero familiar faces.

The problem, at least on the surface, is that Candle wasn't able to bring any of his extremely productive players with him on offense and only a couple followed him on defense. This has all the makings of a transitional, rebuilding year for the Huskies and Candle himself, as his only other coaching stop outside of Toledo was D-III Mount Union from 2003-08. With no clear-cut starting QB and a ton of position battles elsewhere, it's sure to be an interesting first year.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

This does look like a transitional year, but that's not the whole reason why I'm down on UConn. While the degree of difficulty with the teams on the schedule isn't all that daunting, the team has trips to Air Force and Wyoming on Halloween and Thanksgiving weekend, respectively, so those are two elevation games late in the year. They also face Syracuse and Old Dominion at The Rent with those two teams off of byes, adding an extra challenge to two winnable home games. While the Huskies do only play five road games, I believe they fall short of bowl eligibility and my projection is 5.39 wins.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 6-5-2 ATS, 9-4 O-U

Head Coach: Jason Candle - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	LAFAYETTE (-17.4)	17.5
9/12	MARYLAND (+9.8)	45.5
9/19	AT SOUTHERN MISS (-3.8)	25.5
9/26	AT MIAMI OHIO (+6.6)	36.0
10/3	SYRACUSE (+6.3)	42.0
10/10	AT TEMPLE (+5.7)	34.0
10/23	MASSACHUSETTS (-19.7)	16.0
10/31	AT AIR FORCE (+7.8)	37.0
11/7	NORTH CAROLINA (+9.2)	44.5
11/14	JAMES MADISON (+6.9)	41.5
11/21	OLD DOMINION (+2.2)	37.0
11/28	AT WYOMING (+2.4)	30.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.83**
#100 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

5

OFFENSE

1

DEFENSE

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Was it something I said?

Normally new head coaches bring a collection of assistants with them. There's familiarity there, not only in terms of understanding the scheme and the playbook, but also the types of players that fit in that system. Well, Candle's OC is Nunzio Campanile, who was at Syracuse from 2023-25 and at Rutgers prior to that. His DC is Ryan Manalac, a fellow Ohio native who served as Pitt's linebackers coach and has never been a defensive coordinator at the FBS level. The special teams coordinator was at Washington State. His co-OC and QB coach was at South Carolina. I do applaud Candle for putting together a diverse staff with recruiting connections all over the country, but for a guy who was at Toledo for a decade as head coach, it is surprising to see how many new colleagues he has on the staff.

Can you tell us one interesting fact about yourself?

For spring practices and other team events, it must have felt like asking icebreaker questions in a new class. Even the players who have come from other schools are not really players that have stood out and would be recognizable, except for K'Von Sherman, who had 93 tackles last season for Toledo. Kalieb Osborne is one of the Rockets that came with Candle and he'll battle with Jake Merklinger from Tennessee and a couple of in-house options at QB. RB Kenji Christian is at his fourth school, with Toledo his most recent one. Three potential starters on the OL were together at Toledo, but didn't play much. The Huskies averaged 31.9 PPG and 35.3 PPG the last two seasons and 6.7 YPP last season. Suffice it to say that the fan base probably won't see those numbers.

Is keeping expectations low a good thing?

From 2021-25, Candle lost 10 times as a touchdown or more favorite. Aim low and shoot high might be the right approach here as a result, given that UConn won't be favored very much this season with a completely new roster. It is impossible to quantify what it might mean for Candle to be away from Toledo after coaching there for 16 years. His staff is a smorgasbord of coaches from other schools and that could end up being a positive in the present and the future. It might not be. Also, while the offense has major question marks on paper, the defense has a good chance at being solid, as Manalac is a Pat Narduzzi disciple and that guy knows a thing or two about defense. Furthermore, Toledo was second in yards against per game last season and third in yards per play against.

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****100-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.3	17
YARDS PER POINT	12.9	22
PLAYS PER GAME	66.6	94
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:57	97
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.7%	85
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	430.2	23
YARDS PER PLAY	6.5	14
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.8	117
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	155	62
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5	21
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.5	31
COMPLETION %	67.6%	14
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	275.2	17
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	30
TURNOVERS	0.2	1
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.2	81
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	43
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.8%	52
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	431.7	116
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	81
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	205.8	122
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	110
COMPLETION %	67.0%	122
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	225.9	70
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	76
SACKS	2.9	10
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

NOTRE DAME

FIGHTING IRISH



A season with 10 or 11 wins in the regular season cannot be described as a disappointment, right? In Notre Dame's case, it just might be. Perhaps calling it a "cupcake" schedule would be a little bit too critical, but it's a "bundt cake" schedule at the very least. The Fighting Irish get a crack at Miami in a major revenge game at home on November 7 and that looks to be far and away the biggest test for the team.

Obviously a lot of things can happen from a health standpoint, but Marcus Freeman and his staff have put together a spectacular roster. Freeman is 34-7 over the last three seasons. While Notre Dame gets to pick their schedule as an Independent, they've still been tested, facing 12 ranked teams in the regular season over that span. There's a chance that they only face two or three during the regular season this year.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 11.5

The pressure of going perfect may ultimately be too much, but Miami feels like the only major stumbling block and they've had to do a lot of retooling on defense. While we probably all underestimated Miami last season, Notre Dame was favored on the road in the lid lifter last season, for whatever that's worth. The Irish were so perturbed about their CFP snub that they didn't bother playing a bowl game, but you can tell that everybody has bought in, as the only players of note that left did so for the NFL and not for other schools. My projection is 11.42 wins, and they are favored by 8.5 or more in every game.

2025 Record: 10-2 SU & 6-5-1 ATS, 7-5 O-U

Head Coach: Marcus Freeman - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	VS. WISCONSIN (-21)	47.5
9/12	RICE (-45)	27.5
9/19	MICHIGAN ST (-29.9)	42.5
9/26	AT PURDUE (-29)	39.0
10/3	AT NORTH CAROLINA (-23.6)	44.5
10/10	STANFORD (-33.9)	39.0
10/17	AT BYU (-8.8)	57.5
10/31	VS. NAVY (-24.7)	44.0
11/7	MIAMI FL (-9.2)	63.0
11/14	BOSTON COLLEGE (-35.4)	37.5
11/21	SMU (-16.7)	55.5
11/28	AT SYRACUSE (-25.1)	42.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **43.31**
#59 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.8 / 1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

17

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

10

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Are there any weaknesses on offense?

Carr had a 24/6 TD/INT ratio last season and added three more scores on the ground, though he was hardly the rushing threat that Riley Leonard was. The depth behind Carr is a major worry if something were to happen to him, but he spent most of the spring and summer as the favorite to win the Heisman Trophy. The schedule surely has a lot to do with that, as anything under 11 wins would be a bit of a surprise, so he should be putting up numbers and winning games for a very visible program. While Jeremiyah Love and Jadarian Price are gone, taking over 2,000 rushing yards and 29 rushing scores with them, Aneyas Williams should be able to keep the bar high at that position. Similarly, while Jordan Faison is the only notable returnee at wide receiver, Jaden Greathouse is back after missing nearly all of last season due to injury. Plus, the offensive line looks very good, including the return of Charles Jagusah. So, in a word, no.

Are there any weaknesses on defense?

The TL;DR version of this question is one simple word - no. Unlike a lot of premier programs with heavy personnel losses, second-year DC Chris Ash has his top six tacklers back. The Irish were one of 11 teams to hold opponents to fewer than three yards per carry and only eight teams allowed fewer yards on a per-play basis. Notre Dame has had a lot of coaches and players roll through in the past seven years and they've only allowed more than 19.7 PPG one time. Hell, they've allowed under five yards per play in each of the last three seasons under Freeman. They are +31 in TO margin over the last two seasons, which is one area of concern, but not if Carr takes care of the ball. The defense will go ball-hawking again after securing 21 interceptions last season.

Anything else?

It feels like I've said about all I can say about this team. Notre Dame's two close losses last season were followed up by a bunch of blowout wins, as they outgained their other 10 opponents by more than 1,800 yards in total and outscored them by nearly 300 points. As long as the Irish avoid cluster injuries, the goal of a perfect season is very attainable, and that includes the CFP as well. It should also be noted that Notre Dame only plays four true road games - Purdue, North Carolina, BYU, and Syracuse. Two of their "road" games are in neutral settings, with one in Green Bay and one in Foxboro. The Irish get an extra week to prepare for Navy's triple-option with a well-timed bye that comes the week after they play in elevation at BYU.

ODDS TO WIN...

+650**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-800****MAKE THE PLAYOFF**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	42	2
YARDS PER POINT	10.9	1
PLAYS PER GAME	63.3	124
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:17	89
3RD DOWN CONV. %	48.2%	12
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	459.8	8
YARDS PER PLAY	7.3	1
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.3	63
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	204.7	15
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.8	2
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.9	109
COMPLETION %	67.2%	17
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	255.1	32
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.5	3
TURNOVERS	0.8	12
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.6	9
YARDS PER POINT	17.8	9
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.4%	35
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	312.3	16
YARDS PER PLAY	4.4	9
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	98.8	9
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3	7
COMPLETION %	55.7%	14
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	213.4	50
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	14
SACKS	2.8	14
TURNOVERS	1.9	11

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MAC

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

The Mid-American Conference performed a one-for-one swap this offseason, shipping off Northern Illinois to the Mountain West and acquiring Sacramento State from the Big Sky Conference at the FCS level. If you don't understand that trade from a geographic standpoint, neither do I, but the Hornets signed a five-year deal to be a football-only MAC member, as the basketball team will play in the Big West.

With UMass rejoining the MAC last season, the conference has 13 teams, with three in Michigan, one in New York, six in Ohio, one in Indiana, one in Massachusetts, and then one in California. As usual, realignment remains a head-scratcher, but we sure have some fascinating travel spots for this season as a result, especially when we get to MACtion in late October and early November with weeknight games.

On the whole, the conference isn't very strong again, but somebody will have to win it. UMass went 0-12 and 0-8 in conference play at one extreme, while Western Michigan went 10-4, including a 7-1 record against MAC opponents. The Broncos put an exclamation point on their season with a 10-point win over Miami (OH) in Detroit for the MAC Championship and a slaughter of Kennesaw State in the Myrtle Beach Bowl.

WMU (+360) is co-favored to run it back and their company is Miami, so we could be looking at our first MAC Championship Game rematch since Northern Illinois and Bowling Green played three straight title games from 2013-15. The Falcons (16-1) may not be much of a factor, but their archrival Toledo (4-1) is getting some market love, even with former head coach Jason Candle at UConn. Ohio (+650) and Central Michigan (+750) round out the single-digit shots in what looks like a wide-open conference again.

Three teams tied for second at 6-2 last season and there was a battle until the end in 2024 with two teams at 7-1 and two at 6-2. It usually comes down to the last week to see who will represent the conference at Ford Field and this season looks to follow that same path.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
TOLEDO	7.5	35.5	4	-0.5	27.24 (132)	8.2	3.8	5.9	2.1
MIAMI OHIO	6.5	36	2.3	0.7	29.65 (125)	7.8	4.2	5.8	2.2
W MICHIGAN	7.5	37.5	3.2	-0.3	32.98 (99)	7.5	4.5	5.7	2.3
OHIO U	6.5	31.5	3.8	0.3	26.72 (135)	7.2	4.8	5.1	2.9
C MICHIGAN	6.5	30.5	2.9	-0.8	31.43 (113)	6.0	6.0	4.4	3.6
E MICHIGAN	5.5	28	1.9	0.5	29.18 (127)	5.7	6.3	4.1	3.9
BOWLING GREEN	4.5	26.5	1.4	0.7	32.73 (101)	4.3	7.7	3.8	4.2
BUFFALO	5.5	28	1.9	0.4	26.4 (137)	6.2	5.8	3.8	4.2
AKRON	4.5	25	2.1	-0.3	31.19 (117)	4.3	7.7	3.1	4.9
SACRAMENTO ST	4.5	21.5	1.8	0.3	26.52 (136)	4.2	7.8	2.9	5.1
KENT ST	3.5	23.5	1.5	-0.6	35.31 (83)	3.7	8.3	2.9	5.1
BALL ST	3.5	20	3.7	-0.5	31.73 (111)	3.6	8.4	2.7	5.3
MASSACHUSETTS	2.5	16	1	-0.3	26.21 (138)	3.4	8.6	1.6	6.4

AKRON ZIPS

The Zips failed to win more games than they lost for the 10th consecutive season, as a 7-7 showing in 2017 is the best outcome for the program since going 8-5 under Terry Bowden back in 2015. While a 5-7 mark wasn't very impressive, context matters a lot here. For starters, five is the most wins for Akron since that 2017 season. Second, the team knew before even stepping foot on the field that a bowl game was not going to happen, as low Academic Progress Rate (APR) scores caused a bowl ban prior to the start of the campaign. To go 5-7 under those conditions was a huge win for Joe Moorhead.

Are the Zips slowly turning the corner? Maybe. There is no bowl ban for this season and it seems like the program got a little bit more investment than usual, as the school in the heart of the Rubber City has among the lowest NIL budgets in FBS. Not only that, but the APR scores forced the team to be away from the field and spend more time in the classroom, so the Zips have the chance at being even better this season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Moorhead got a lot out of a team that couldn't make a bowl game and the most impressive data point to me was a 19-16 road win at Bowling Green after losing to rival Kent State in OT. The Zips had every reason in the world to mail that game in and didn't. It should also be noted that the Zips were +480 in yards against MAC foes outside of the 45-3 loss to Toledo in which they were outgained 538-134. That game, and the 728 yards from Nebraska in a 68-0 loss, skewed the defensive numbers in a big way. This was maybe a better team than the 5-7 record showed and Moorhead is finally gaining ground with the direction of the program. My projection is 4.29 wins, but I do like this team.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 6-6 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Joe Moorhead - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AT WAKE FOREST (+23.8)	46.5
9/12	ROBERT MORRIS (-27.6)	-0.5
9/19	AT MINNESOTA (+27.9)	49.0
9/26	UNLV (+17.8)	44.0
10/3	AT C MICHIGAN (+8.7)	30.5
10/10	E MICHIGAN (+1.4)	28.0
10/17	AT MIAMI OHIO (+13.6)	36.0
10/24	AT KENT ST (+0.3)	23.5
11/3	OHIO U (+4.7)	31.5
11/10	W MICHIGAN (+10.1)	37.5
11/18	AT MASSACHUSETTS (-7.7)	16.0
11/27	BUFFALO (+1.3)	28.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.19**
#117 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

7

DEFENSE

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Reese Poffenbarger shake off the dust and cobwebs?

Poffenbarger, who was originally recruited to Miami (FL) after a strong season at Albany, will attempt to take advantage of a fresh start in Akron. Poffenbarger held a clipboard for Cam Ward at Miami in 2024 and for Drew Mestemaker at North Texas in 2025, but he has a minimal path of resistance at best here at Akron. He waltzes into a pretty good offensive situation. Moorhead was a longtime OC and QB coach before taking on this challenging job. RB Jordan Gant ran for over 1,000 yards, as the Zips finally showed signs of growth there, and leading WR Marcel Williams is among the pass-catchers that are back. Poffenbarger, though, has only thrown a total of 14 passes over the last two seasons.

Are the Zips improving in the trenches?

If you want to be a bad football team, be bad at the point of attack. This is a Zips program that gave up 63 sacks in Tom Arth's last season back in 2021 and then 56 sacks in Moorhead's first season in 2022. They've improved, dropping to 30 sacks in 2024 and 35 sacks in 2025. While that's not good enough to have a positive sack differential, last year's -9 was easily the best for the team in a very, very long time. The 26 sacks from the defense were the most since the Bowden era and the team's 3.7 yards per carry was the most in a non-COVID year since then as well. While none of these are impressive numbers, per se, they're better than what the Zips usually accomplish.

Which defense shows up in 2026?

In Moorhead's four seasons, the Zips have allowed 6.0, 5.2, 6.1, and 5.8 yards per play, while giving up 33.5, 28.0, 32.0, and 27.4 PPG. Given the annual shortcomings of the offense, any drop-off from the defense feels like a concern. Last season also saw the Zips with a positive TO margin for the first time in about a decade at +3 with 20 takeaways. The top eight tacklers are all gone from last season, but nobody had more than 66, so it's clear that Tim Tibesar's plan was to rotate everybody in. Unfortunately, those top eight had most of the production in terms of sacks, pass breakups, tackles for loss, and interceptions.

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****30-1****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.6	114
YARDS PER POINT	17.4	118
PLAYS PER GAME	72.8	25
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:18	54
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.8%	130
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.9	96
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	120
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.9	57
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	124.6	100
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	113
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.8	39
COMPLETION %	51.9%	135
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	216.3	78
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	105
TURNOVERS	1.5	93
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.3	89
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	95
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.8%	26
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	398.5	82
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	99
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	153.3	69
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	63
COMPLETION %	62.1%	65
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	245.3	106
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	117
SACKS	2	63
TURNOVERS	1.5	35

BALL STATE CARDINALS



The Men of Muncie need to figure something out and fast. Last year's dismal offensive performance with just 15.8 PPG led to the fourth straight season without a bowl game and Ball State hasn't had a winning record in conference play outside of the 2020 COVID season since 2013. The MAC is not exactly known for being a stout conference, but the Cardinals haven't played in the title game outside of the COVID year since 2008. Maybe downplaying the COVID year is a bit harsh, as Ball State did go 7-1 and beat San Jose State in the Arizona Bowl, but obviously there were a lot of factors in play that season.

In hopes of turning things around, the university hired Mike Uremovich as the head coach and his 4-8 season featured very little to be excited about. The Cardinals were simply brutal on special teams, mustered just 272 yards of offense per game, and finished -26 in sack differential with 49 sacks allowed. Returning production would have been an oxymoron here, but Ball State has next to none of it anyway, so Uremovich starts Year 2 with essentially a brand-new roster.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

This is a tepid take at best, as even with an offense that managed just 16 PPG in conference play, the Cardinals still won three of those eight games, plus the win over FCS New Hampshire. Unfortunately for the Cardinals, two of their three most winnable conference games are road visits to Kent State and UMass. They also shockingly upset Ohio last season and that probably doesn't happen again with a trip to Athens. It is tough to find four wins here, as my projection is 3.41 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 7-5 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Mike Uremovich - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT OHIO ST (+55.3)	71.0
9/12	STONY BROOK (-7.1)	17.5
9/19	AT LIBERTY (+17.1)	34.5
9/26	AT KENT ST (+5.5)	23.5
10/3	TOLEDO (+11.3)	35.5
10/10	AT NORTHWESTERN (+28.1)	45.5
10/17	AT BOWLING GREEN (+8.4)	26.5
10/24	SACRAMENTO ST (-1.9)	21.5
11/4	AT MASSACHUSETTS (-2.5)	16.0
11/11	BUFFALO (+4.7)	28.0
11/17	AT OHIO U (+15.8)	31.5
11/28	C MICHIGAN (+6)	30.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.73**
#111 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.7 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

6

OFFENSE

4

DEFENSE

2

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is there a starting QB on the roster?

By definition, yes, somebody will have to start games. However, there is no clear-cut answer as to whether or not any of the guys in the QB room can be FBS-level starters, even in the MAC. Keldric Luster barely played over two years at SMU and then barely played at Texas State last season. D-II transfer Tyler Mizzell threw 10 interceptions with 26 TD passes for the Concord U. Mountain Lions after transferring out of Wake Forest. Maybe redshirt freshman Khalel Wright, who was part of Uremovich's first freshman class last season, or this year's top true freshman QB recruit Mason Adkins will get a crack. While the bar is exceedingly low for a team that had 15.8 PPG, 4.5 YPP, 49 sacks, and a starting QB that threw for just 1,583 yards, it doesn't seem like the bar will move much higher.

How about the skill positions?

The Cardinals return one rushing TD from last season and two receiving TD. Granted, they didn't have many touchdowns to possibly bring back regardless, but these are pretty much two new groups of players as well. QB Kiael Kelly led the team with just 600 rushing yards (2.8 YPC) last season. Qian Magwood was the leading WR with 19 catches for 320 yards, followed by returnee Donovan Hamilton with 20 grabs for 244 yards. It's entirely possible that Uremovich likes the fit of his portal class and his two freshman classes more than what he inherited from Mike Neu, but as his own OC, last year's results were pathetic and the talent level of the roster looks similarly low heading into 2026, even if the offensive line might be better.

Is the news any better on defense?

Uremovich brought his Butler DC and longtime best friend Jeff Knowles with him to Muncie. This unit was actually something of a success story last season. Neu's final defense at Ball State gave up over 40 PPG. Knowles oversaw a unit that allowed 29.8 PPG and shaved off a full yard per play. Given how little help the offense was able to provide, this unit did its best, though some more pass rushers wouldn't hurt. The Cardinals played at a slow tempo in hopes of keeping the defense from getting exposed, as they averaged just 60.8 plays per game. The defense faced 67.3 plays per game, so given their heightened workload, that unit deserves a lot of credit. That being said, Knowles has only two returning starters and both are in the secondary.

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****90-1****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	14.2	132
YARDS PER POINT	18.3	125
PLAYS PER GAME	66.1	101
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:17	55
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.3%	128
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	258.8	134
YARDS PER PLAY	3.9	135
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.8	41
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	115.7	112
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	129
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	23.9	124
COMPLETION %	56.3%	120
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	143.1	130
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	124
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.9	93
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	94
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.6%	83
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	407.6	90
YARDS PER PLAY	6	113
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	183.7	103
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	105
COMPLETION %	62.8%	74
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	223.9	66
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	110
SACKS	1.6	97
TURNOVERS	1.2	77

BOWLING GREEN FALCONS



I felt like the Falcons were one of the more interesting teams that I wrote up last season because they hired former Ohio State standout and Tennessee State miracle worker Eddie George as the head coach. We saw flashes from the Falcons, as they upset Liberty in non-conference and upset rival Toledo in conference, but there were more disappointments than achievements. The Falcons lost four times as a favorite to MAC opponents and mustered very little on offense, especially in the passing game.

We'll never know if things would have gone better had Notre Dame/Missouri transfer Drew Pyne not gotten hurt, as four different quarterbacks saw action and they collectively had as many touchdowns (12) as interceptions. That position is still in a state of flux heading into this season. One major silver lining is that George and his staff were able to attack the portal alongside everybody else instead of doing so in March last season after he was hired.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Not a bet given the heavy vig, and we'll see how much George has grown and adapted to life in the MAC, because most of the wins will have to come from conference games. The Falcons play Nebraska, Iowa State, and South Florida in non-conference, so that'll be a tough stretch, plus conference play starts with perennial contender Miami of Ohio on the road. The schedule softens up considerably from that point forward and that's where the wins should come. If you can find an in-season win total on BG after they probably start 1-4, that might be the way to go. My projection is 4.26 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Eddie George - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TARLETON ST (+10.9)	38.0
9/12	AT NEBRASKA (+25.6)	50.5
9/19	AT IOWA ST (+17)	41.5
9/26	SOUTH FLORIDA (+13.4)	41.0
10/3	AT MIAMI OHIO (+11.1)	36.0
10/10	SACRAMENTO ST (-6.1)	21.5
10/17	BALL ST (-8.4)	20.0
10/24	AT BUFFALO (+2.7)	28.0
10/31	AT W MICHIGAN (+13.5)	37.5
11/10	KENT ST (-5)	23.5
11/20	AT TOLEDO (+12.3)	35.5
11/28	MASSACHUSETTS (-12.2)	16.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.73**
#101 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

6

OFFENSE

2

DEFENSE

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Are the Falcons set up for success?

Bowling Green had injuries, as every team does, but it seemed like last season was a series of fact-finding missions for George and his staff to isolate the players that best fit the system. Austyn Dendy looks like the feature back and had a solid freshman season with 4.6 yards per carry, but his 108 carries barely outpaced Chris McMillian with 84 and Cameron Pettaway with 72. Kaderris Roberts also had 48 carries. George was trying out everybody to see who would stick, and it was ultimately Dendy who did. This season, I would expect a tighter rotation with Dendy and Charleston Southern transfer Ke'Marion Baldwin, who had nearly five yards per carry for the Buccaneers. Similarly, a lot of guys that played, but maybe weren't focal points, now get chances at WR and on the offensive line, including the tight ends with a lot of 12 personnel in this scheme.

Will the defense take a step forward?

The offense only mustered 20.5 PPG and just 4.9 YPP, so the defense was under a lot of pressure. Linebackers coach Joe Bowden, who played with George as a member of the Tennessee Titans, is now the DC of a group that allowed just 24.3 PPG, but 5.6 YPP. Gideon Lampron basically never left the field and he'll be missed with 119 tackles, including 15 tackles for loss, but the defense was a lot like the offense in that a lot of guys played. Some of the expected starters were with George at Tennessee State two seasons ago, but either didn't start at BG or had transferred elsewhere. Even if the defense doesn't take a step forward, a similar baseline coupled with a better offense would be effective.

Did Eddie George learn some important lessons?

The Falcons had those two very impressive wins over Liberty and Toledo, but also blew leads against Kent State, Akron, and Eastern Michigan that would have made the season look a lot different and may have even led to bowl eligibility. The no-show against Central Michigan the week after the Toledo game was also a good teaching moment for everybody. Keep in mind, when George took over at Tennessee State, he hadn't really coached anywhere else. Instead, he had been an adjunct professor at Ohio State and Vanderbilt and had been doing some acting. Even though he's been around football all his life, coaching, especially in the current CFB landscape, is a lot different and his first recruiting cycle at the FBS level seems promising.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****16-1****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20	112
YARDS PER POINT	15.7	97
PLAYS PER GAME	65.4	109
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:13	34
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.5%	94
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	313.1	121
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	114
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.6	35
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	158	59
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	86
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	24.3	123
COMPLETION %	57.7%	110
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	155.1	124
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	107
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.8	64
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	87
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.6%	25
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	357.6	45
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	87
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	148.4	59
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	67
COMPLETION %	59.3%	32
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	209.3	44
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.9	108
SACKS	1.7	92
TURNOVERS	1.5	44

BUFFALO BULLS



Pete Lembo was dealt a harsh reminder about how hard it is to be a head coach at the G5 level and with the current state of affairs. Lembo's first season at Buffalo was spectacular, as the team went 9-4 and comfortably beat Liberty in the Bahamas Bowl. But, this past season, Buffalo went 5-7 and even the wins were scary, beating Kent State by only a field goal as a 23.5-point favorite and then barely beating Eastern Michigan and UMass as substantial favorites. They also lost to Akron as a double-digit favorite.

The Bulls had a swing of 16 in the turnover margin department, going from +9 to -7, as C.J. Ogbonna was outstanding in 2024 and Ta'Quan Roberson and Gunnar Gray were less so in 2025. Al-Jay Henderson went from a 1,000-yard rusher to a 755-yard rusher due to attrition on the offensive line. Last year's defense was even unequivocally better than the 2024 version, but the Bulls won four fewer games and now we have a lot of questions heading into Year 3 of the Lembo regime.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5
This is a bit of a price play here, as the juice on Over 5.5 is cost-prohibitive, but 6-6 does look like the most likely outcome. However, the schedule is pretty kind with two FCS opponents at home in non-conference, plus home games against UMass and Bowling Green. November roadies at Ball State and Akron are extremely winnable games and even the Week 2 trip to FIU has the chance for a happy flight home. Lembo gets a lot out of his talent and I think his program bounces back. My projection is 6.32 wins, but the Over 6.5 has some equity. With two FCS games, Buffalo needs to get to seven wins for a bowl, so unless they can get a waiver for winning six games if two of them are the FCS games, that should be a motivating factor.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 4-7-1 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Pete Lembo - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	ALBANY (-27.7)	2.5
9/12	AT FLA INTERNATIONAL (+2)	28.5
9/19	AT PENN ST (+31.7)	57.0
9/26	ROBERT MORRIS (-30.4)	-0.5
10/3	W MICHIGAN (+7.3)	37.5
10/10	AT TOLEDO (+11.1)	35.5
10/17	MASSACHUSETTS (-14.2)	16.0
10/24	BOWLING GREEN (-2.7)	26.5
11/3	AT MIAMI OHIO (+9.9)	36.0
11/11	AT BALL ST (-4.7)	20.0
11/18	C MICHIGAN (-0.2)	30.5
11/27	AT AKRON (-1.3)	25.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 26.40
#137 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 1.9 / 0.4
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

2

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Isn't there something 'special' about Lembo?

One area of the team that absolutely did improve last season was the special teams. Per Phil Steele, the Bulls were 13th in his special teams rankings, a jump of more than 40 spots, and Bill Connelly's SP+ had the Bulls 12th nationally. After he was let go by Ball State, he bounced around a bit as a special teams coordinator and really did a fine job in that role. Even with 22 turnovers lost, Brian Fremeau at BCF Toys had Buffalo 37th in Net Starting Field Position and only 23.5% of opponents' drives started less than 60 yards from the end zone. Special teams are a very underrated part of the game, especially in college football and especially with so much roster turnover, but being good in that area can absolutely elevate the floor of a team. Expect the Bulls to be good there again.

Is there anything special about the quarterbacks?

This is, by far, the most questionable position group on the roster. Everything starts with the QB and we saw that last season, as Buffalo excelled on special teams and played well on defense, but Roberson couldn't keep up with what Ogbonna did the year prior. Elijah Holmes threw for over 3,000 yards for the D-II Wingate Bulldogs, while redshirt freshman Jason Wright had 15 rush attempts, but no pass attempts. Personally, I think we see true freshman Qur'an McNeill sooner rather than later, as he had offers from Arkansas, Cincinnati, UConn, Syracuse, and Boston College, but opted for Buffalo. With a very light NIL budget, I'm guessing they invested pretty heavily in this kid.

Can Bowden rebuild the defense on the fly?

The offensive questions are plenty obvious, including the loss of two guys who had 62 receptions apiece, plus Henderson, but the defensive losses were heavy, too. Leading tackler Red Murdock had 142 stops, 61 more than Dion Crawford, and he's gone. So is Crawford. So is Mitchell Gosner, who was one of four Bulls with 70+ tackles. Everybody with 3+ sacks is out. But, the Bulls have 69 sacks over Lembo's two seasons, so they should have found somebody to get after the QB. Last year's defense only had 15 takeaways and only seven were interceptions. Quite a few in-house options have been elevated, so the program has guys who know the system.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****18-1****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.1	97
YARDS PER POINT	15.8	100
PLAYS PER GAME	69.3	60
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:13	127
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.5%	117
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	349.4	91
YARDS PER PLAY	5	100
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.8	106
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	111.6	115
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	111
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.4	22
COMPLETION %	57.6%	111
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	237.7	55
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	89
TURNOVERS	1.8	118
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.1	60
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	69
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.0%	29
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	364	50
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	25
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	171.1	92
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	44
COMPLETION %	55.5%	12
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	192.9	22
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	46
SACKS	2.8	16
TURNOVERS	1.3	66

CENTRAL MICHIGAN CHIPPEWAS



Are you a quarterback who would rather run the ball than throw it? You might want to consider going to Central Michigan while Matt Drinkall is still there. The former Army offensive line coach went 7-6 in his first season as the head coach at CMU, as he did a pretty good job of ramming square pegs through round holes. Drinkall's offense only averaged 3.9 yards per carry, which is not at all what you'd expect given his history with the Black Knights, but turning a team into a group capable of running that sort of offense takes time.

It's also not very easy to find players who come from that scheme or can pick up that scheme, given how spread offenses and more of the "run and gun" style are en vogue these days. Also, Jim McElwain was not running a power offense, so any of the holdovers were going to take some time to whip into shape, while also trying to win games with what the team was capable of executing. After a successful first season, Drinkall now pivots to doing what he originally wanted to do and that could be a good thing or a bad thing.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

Per Brian Fremeau of BCF Toys, there wasn't a single MAC team in the top 50 in Offensive Points Per Drive. We do have to take into account how some of the paycheck games against P4 teams skew the numbers, but a lot of MAC teams also mix in a FCS team or two. If Central Michigan can achieve this ground-and-pound, uber-methodical offensive attack and limit the available possessions in games, they should have a ton of success in this conference because the offenses by and large stink. Even with defensive concerns, that unit shouldn't be asked to do a ton. The conference schedule is a bit tougher for the Chips, but they host Sac State and only play three true conference road games, with one against lowly Ball State. My projection is 6.14 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 8-5 ATS, 7-6 O-U

Head Coach: Matt Drinkall - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT NEW MEXICO (+14.6)	42.0
9/12	COLGATE (-20.4)	13.0
9/19	WYOMING (-3.5)	30.5
9/26	AT MIAMI FL (+35)	63.0
10/3	AKRON (-8.7)	25.0
10/10	AT OHIO U (+5.6)	31.5
10/17	W MICHIGAN (+3.8)	37.5
10/24	MIAMI OHIO (+3.3)	36.0
11/4	VS. E MICHIGAN (-1.2)	28.0
11/11	SACRAMENTO ST (-11.6)	21.5
11/18	AT BUFFALO (+0.2)	28.0
11/28	AT BALL ST (-6)	20.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.43**
#113 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.9 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

8

5

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will this work in the MAC?

Objectively, the MAC is not a good conference. When offenses are humming, defenses are suffering. When teams prioritize defense to slow down the opposing offense, we see a lot of poor per-play and per-game numbers from those units. The MAC isn't traditionally viewed as a physical conference, even though a lot of schools are located in or near recruiting hotbeds for linemen talent on both sides of the ball. Drinkall is looking to run a lot of 21 personnel, as he has a mobile QB in Angel Flores, who was the team's second-leading rusher and top touchdown-getter last season. With a lot of returning linemen and some transfer portal acquisitions, Central Michigan is going to play a run-heavy, ball-control style of offense. Given the inefficiency most teams in this conference display, shortening the game and limiting possessions may be extremely fruitful.

How close is Drinkall to running the offense the way he wants?

That's the biggest question, probably, as Joe Labas completed 70.6% of his passes last season with a 13/6 TD/INT ratio while Flores was the running QB with 107 rush attempts against just 28 pass attempts. Brock Townsend had over five yards per carry for the Chippewas, while Vaughn Blue had over five yards per carry for Liberty. It is not easy to get wide receivers to buy in with this kind of playbook, but leading receiver Langston Lewis stuck around and that says a lot to me. While this is a slightly undersized line compared to most, that's by design, as the linemen need to be pulling and getting out ahead of the play to optimally run this scheme. They are very, very close.

Is the defense a bigger worry than the offense?

Last season, the offense only had 22.5 PPG, but they were assisted greatly by a defense that allowed just 23.5 PPG, including just 18 PPG in conference play. However, the losses are extremely heavy on that side of the ball. Jordan Kwiatkowski and Dakota Cochran combined for 199 tackles and 14.5 tackles for loss. Leading sack man Michael Heidman had 10.5 of the team's 28 sacks. While Jaion Jackson was probably the team's second-best corner, he's one of just two returning starters. This style of offense limits exposure for a defense, but this group definitely looks to be a major worry.

ODDS TO WIN...

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+800****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.3	110
YARDS PER POINT	15.6	96
PLAYS PER GAME	62.4	128
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:04	17
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.6%	108
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	317.8	117
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	96
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.8	25
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	159.5	57
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	95
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	19.6	132
COMPLETION %	68.9%	9
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	158.3	122
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	26
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.7	54
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	44
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.8%	96
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	376.8	65
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	70
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	153.3	70
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	87
COMPLETION %	58.3%	25
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	223.4	64
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	51
SACKS	2.2	51
TURNOVERS	1.6	34

EASTERN MICHIGAN EAGLES



The Chris Creighton magic may be dwindling in Ypsilanti. In a world where coaches change teams like they change underwear, Creighton is kicking off his 13th season with the program. However, after records of 5-7 and 4-8, the Eagles have missed the bowl season in consecutive years for the first time since 2014-15, Creighton's first two years with the team.

The program heads into 2026 with the lowest-ranked transfer portal class in the conference per 247Sports, but also tied with in-state rival Central Michigan for the largest freshman class. Creighton wants to be a program builder and watch players develop over multiple seasons. While admirable, and successful in the past, it is a hard route to take nowadays. Sticking with that theme, instead of going outside the program to replace DC Ben Needham, Creighton simply promoted two of the defensive assistants to revive a unit that has allowed 6.2 yards per play each of the last two seasons.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

The talent level on the roster doesn't really seem to be any stronger. While the Eagles do host Sacramento State in the Hornets' first MAC game, they have to go to UMass and Akron, two of their more winnable conference contests. With a neutral-site game against Central Michigan, the Eagles only play three conference home games. It does seem like other programs are evolving more and portal success seems paramount nowadays. Perhaps EMU goes bowling, but the ceiling is probably six wins and several outcomes below that seem more plausible. My projection is 5.39 wins.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 7-4-1 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Chris Creighton - 13th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	SACRAMENTO ST (-8.1)	21.5
9/4	SAN JOSE ST (-2.4)	27.0
9/12	AT MICHIGAN ST (+15.2)	42.5
9/19	AT WISCONSIN (+20.4)	47.5
9/26	LINDENWOOD (-16.4)	13.5
10/3	AT MASSACHUSETTS (-11.5)	16.0
10/10	AT AKRON (-1.4)	25.0
10/17	TOLEDO (+5.1)	35.5
10/24	AT OHIO U (+6.8)	31.5
11/4	VS. C MICHIGAN (+1.2)	30.5
11/17	AT W MICHIGAN (+12.2)	37.5
11/24	KENT ST (-7)	23.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **29.18**
#127 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

6*

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is this a case study in returning production in the transfer portal era?

Per Bill Connelly, Eastern Michigan ranks 24th in percentage of returning production and that’s even with the loss of a 1,000-yard rusher in Dontae McMillan. The team’s three leading tacklers are back, the starting QB, and top WR, and that’s seemingly a rarity in the current landscape of college football. Phil Steele has the Eagles No. 1 in the MAC and No. 7 nationally in his experience chart. How valuable is that continuity? With the P4-level teams, I’m not sure how much it matters, but it might in the G6, where the talent isn’t as strong and there are more transfers from JUCOs and lower-division schools. Unfortunately, the defense has more returning production than the offense and this is a defense that allowed 6.2 yards per play and only generated 14 sacks.

What is the ceiling for the offense?

EMU will roll with QB Noah Kim once again, the Class of 2020 Michigan State commit who is on his seventh season of college football. Kim had an 18/11 TD/INT ratio and was tops in the MAC with 2,817 passing yards, but the offense only had 24.1 PPG, even with just 11 sacks allowed. Kim is mobile enough to evade the pass rush and the combination of Braydon Bennett and the depth guys at running back should produce, as Bennett had over six yards per carry at Coastal Carolina. McMillan was the team’s second-leading receiver, so we’ll see who can help there, but this is largely a similar offense to last season, just with a less experienced offensive line. While EMU went from 5.1 YPP to 5.7 YPP from 2024 to 2025, they scored 1.8 fewer PPG. Make of that what you will.

Is that returning production the key for the defense?

Bryce Llewellyn had 102 tackles to lead the way and he’s back, along with the team’s second and third-leading tacklers. However, while there are a lot of returnees, impact plays were few and far between. The defense allowed 6.2 YPP for the second straight season and gave up nearly two more points per game. The defense improved greatly against the pass, but allowed a full yard more per carry. This was the 131st-ranked defense on third down, only had nine takeaways, and 126th in sacks. One potential silver lining is that the defense only allowed 5.6 YPP in conference games.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

10-1

MAC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.2	84
YARDS PER POINT	15.8	102
PLAYS PER GAME	68.3	68
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:36	106
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.0%	47
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	383.3	70
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	47
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.2	92
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	144.4	75
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	56
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	34
COMPLETION %	61.1%	76
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	238.9	54
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	72
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.9	93
YARDS PER POINT	13.7	92
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.2%	112
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	410.2	98
YARDS PER PLAY	6.1	116
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	232.7	135
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.6	134
COMPLETION %	60.4%	45
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	177.5	13
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	70
SACKS	1.2	121
TURNOVERS	0.8	116

KENT STATE

GOLDEN FLASHES



A lot of context is required when looking at Kent State's 2025 season. First, Kenni Burns was 1-23 over the previous two seasons and then got fired for cause in April, pushing OC Mark Carney into the head coaching role. Second, looking at the full-season stats would be disingenuous. Kent State lost 62-14 to Texas Tech, 66-10 to Florida State, and 44-0 to Oklahoma, getting outgained by over 1,000 yards combined. While Toledo also blew them out in conference play, the Golden Flashes were competitive in most of their other games and went 5-3 in them.

While the full record states that Kent State was outgained by 12.3 PPG and outgained by nearly 140 yards per game, conference play was a different story. They only allowed 5.2 YPP and gained nearly 5.7. They were +1 in TO margin. After going 0-16 against MAC opponents under Burns, they were 4-4 under Carney and there is a lot of hope around the program that this wasn't just a one-year blip.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 3.5

It will be a challenge to match the five wins from last season, given that the Flashes play Sacramento State on the road on a short week after the rivalry game against Akron and don't have the luxury of seeing UMass on the schedule. However, Carney's swing game might very well be the season finale at Eastern Michigan and I'm very low on the Eagles this season. This isn't a super strong play, but the talent level is better here again. And, hey, if you're looking for a possible X factor, Josh Cribbs is the new special teams coordinator. I do like this, despite a projection of 3.23 wins.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 7-5 ATS, 6-6 O-U

Head Coach: Mark Carney - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (+33.9)	54.0
9/12	WOFFORD (-8)	16.5
9/19	AT OHIO ST (+51.9)	71.0
9/26	BALL ST (-5.5)	20.0
10/3	OHIO U (+6.8)	31.5
10/10	AT W MICHIGAN (+17.8)	37.5
10/17	AT SOUTH FLORIDA (+21)	41.0
10/24	AKRON (-0.3)	25.0
10/30	AT SACRAMENTO ST (+0.4)	21.5
11/10	AT BOWLING GREEN (+5)	26.5
11/17	MIAMI OHIO (+11.7)	36.0
11/24	AT E MICHIGAN (+7)	28.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.31**
#83 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.5 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

10

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does Dru have in store for Year 2?

The Dru in question is Dru DeShields, who basically came out of nowhere last season to post an 18/3 TD/INT ratio with just over 2,000 passing yards. The redshirt freshman finally kept his ACL intact and it paid huge dividends for the Kent State offense, as they put up over 20 PPG for the first time since 2022. While the yardage totals still weren't eye-popping, even in conference play, taking care of the football and protecting the quarterback really made a difference. It was also an impressive season given that top WRs Chrishon McCray and Luke Floriea had moved on, as they combined for 84 of the team's 139 receptions the previous year.

What about the rest of the offense?

Here's the thing - DeShields staying healthy is vital because there is absolutely no FBS experience behind him. So, that's one concern and a massive one at that. The team's top four rushers from last season are all gone and so are the top two receivers by yardage. Wayne Harris led the team with 35 receptions, but only had 383 yards. While the wide receiver room didn't invite a lot of new faces to the party, virtually the entire running back room is new. It's also entirely possible that the offensive line is better, despite some lost starters. That group only helped the team to 2.9 yards per carry and if we even eliminate the brutal non-conference schedule, the Flashes had just 3.6 YPC in conference games. That's not good enough in this league, but a more stable passing game and a full recruiting cycle for Carney should help.

Will the "Sophomores and Seniors" defense work?

There is a fascinating dynamic on Cherokee Valeria's defense, as there are portal players that are seniors and some homegrown talent that will play big roles as sophomores. Many of the portal guys are second-year players in the scheme, so we may see more explosive plays out of them. The team's -3 sack differential last season was better than the -25 and -29 of the last two seasons, but more turnovers need to come. DeShields only had three interceptions as the primary QB and the Flashes were still negative in TO margin for the season. Like last season, they'll be under duress in the non-conference with South Carolina, Ohio State, and USF, but should be competitive in conference games again.

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****60-1****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.3	104
YARDS PER POINT	13.8	49
PLAYS PER GAME	59.9	136
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:40	121
3RD DOWN CONV. %	26.8%	135
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	293.6	126
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	111
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.9	94
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	97.6	125
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3	130
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	24.8	121
COMPLETION %	55.3%	123
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	196	96
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.9	34
TURNOVERS	1.1	42
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.1	126
YARDS PER POINT	12.4	121
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.6%	126
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	436.3	121
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	84
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	194.8	118
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	95
COMPLETION %	60.6%	50
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	241.5	100
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	83
SACKS	2	63
TURNOVERS	0.9	108

MASSACHUSETTS MINUTEMEN



The Minutemen really put the “ass” in UMass last season, as they were 0-12 and scored just 11.1 PPG. It was the first year for head coach Joe Harasymiak and one to forget to say the least. This wasn't a byproduct of getting super unlucky in the turnover department or anything like that either. This was a truly terrible team that got outgained at home by Bryant and lost all eight conference games by an average score of 38-11. The low point of the season was probably a 42-6 loss to Kent State, a team that hadn't beaten a FBS opponent since the end of 2022.

Now it's UMass who hasn't beaten a FBS team in a while, as their last win was against Army back on October 8, 2023, a game in which Kay'Ron Lynch-Adams ran for 234 yards. The Minutemen rushed for a total of 989 yards last season over 12 games. Since their last FBS win, the Minutemen have beaten Merrimack, Central Connecticut State, and Wagner. They'll get two FCS teams - Sacred Heart and Stonehill - this season, so 0-12 looks unlikely, but I guess you never really know.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 2.5

The betting market seems to be confident in three wins coming from the group of Sacred Heart, Stonehill, Sacramento State, Eastern Michigan, Ball State, and Akron and I can't blame them. This team is absolutely better on paper and the schedule is absolutely friendlier. That's not to say I'm rushing to put my money on them, since I don't even know if Harasymiak is a good coach, but this is Stonehill's first game against a FBS team and Sacred Heart lost by 28 to a UConn team that went 3-9 in 2023, so that should get the Minutemen at least one win away from cashing this. My projection is 2.77 wins.

2025 Record: 0-12 SU & 3-9 ATS, 9-3 O-U
Head Coach: Joe Harasymiak - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AT RUTGERS (+28.9)	42.5
9/12	SACRED HEART (-8.5)	9.0
9/19	STONEHILL (-16.8)	1.0
9/26	AT SACRAMENTO ST (+7.6)	21.5
10/3	E MICHIGAN (+11.5)	28.0
10/10	MIAMI OHIO (+19.7)	36.0
10/17	AT BUFFALO (+14.2)	28.0
10/23	AT CONNECTICUT (+19.7)	31.5
11/4	BALL ST (+2.5)	20.0
11/11	AT TOLEDO (+23.8)	35.5
11/18	AKRON (+7.7)	25.0
11/28	AT BOWLING GREEN (+12.2)	26.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **26.21**
#138 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

4

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will UMass win a game?!

Let's get the hardest question out of the way early. I'm going to say yes. Sacred Heart and Stonehill are two great options, but they also host Ball State and Eastern Michigan this season, two teams that they didn't play last season, and I think either one could be beatable, if not both. It is also Year 2 for Harasymiak and his assistants, although OC Mike Bajakian won't be along for the ride, as he's the new QB coach of the Cleveland Browns (I swear, the jokes write themselves with that organization). Given that the UMass offense had 3.9 yards per play and an 8/9 TD/INT ratio from the QBs, something tells me that Bajakian isn't really a big loss. New OC Max Warner, who was an offensive assistant at Toledo, seems like an upgrade.

Can UMass right the wrongs of last season?

Well, for starters, three different QBs started games and six different players, including two of the QBs, had at least 40 rushing attempts. Jacquon Gibson had 63 catches and nobody else had more than 27. Fifteen players had at least 20 tackles. Injuries played a part, but Harasymiak and his staff were just trying to find dudes that could ball pretty much all season long. There are quite a few P4 transfers on the roster now between this portal cycle and the coaching staff's first one. One of them is Pop Watson, who may start at QB. He's never really gotten a crack to start, but was a three-star recruit and the MaxPreps HS QB of the Year in Massachusetts back in 2021, so it's a homecoming for him and he headlines a much better QB room.

Will anybody get to the quarterback?

An absence of negative plays was an enormous issue for the UMass defense last season. They only racked up 13 sacks and allowed more than five yards per carry, including 5.1 YPC in conference action. Only Air Force and UCLA had fewer tackles for loss. Ironically, Rutgers was one of the teams with fewer sacks than UMass and that's where Harasymiak and his DC Jared Keyte came from. So, maybe it's just the scheme. Jackson State transfer Joshua Nobles had 10 sacks before transferring in, but got hurt before the season started. Edge William DePaepe was at Indiana. Linebacker Michael Robinson was at Rutgers. This group seems decidedly more talented.

10000-1 CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1 MAKE THE PLAYOFF

300-1 MAC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	9.7	136
YARDS PER POINT	24.4	136
PLAYS PER GAME	66.5	96
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:06	134
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.2%	132
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	237.5	136
YARDS PER PLAY	3.6	136
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.8	128
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	80.7	133
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.8	131
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.8	28
COMPLETION %	53.0%	133
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	156.7	123
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	4.5	136
TURNOVERS	1.4	80
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	39.6	136
YARDS PER POINT	11	135
3RD DOWN CONV. %	48.2%	131
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	437	123
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	125
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	234.1	136
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	120
COMPLETION %	70.9%	136
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	202.9	36
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	130
SACKS	1	128
TURNOVERS	0.6	129

MIAMI OHIO REDHAWKS



A 7-7 record at Miami feels like a down year for Chuck Martin, who begins his 13th season at the helm in Oxford. But, when you dig deeper, the season played out exactly as expected. Miami was an underdog in all seven losses and a favorite in all seven wins. How's that for following a script? Unfortunately, one of those defeats came at the hands of Western Michigan, who got revenge for a regular-season loss when it mattered most in the conference title game. That marks two seasons in a row that the RedHawks have lost in Detroit with the hardware on the line, but also their third straight Motor City appearance.

So, the goal is pretty clear for Martin and his players this season. Get back to the title game, but win it this time. Even though the G6 CFP berth is out there for somebody to take, it would take something really, really special for a MAC team to even be in the running, so the goals are pretty reasonable and pretty attainable for the RedHawks as they embark on a season with a lot of new faces on offense and some serious production to replace on defense.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

The MAC co-favorites should split their non-conference games down the middle, with two P4 losses and wins in the other two games. While the RedHawks don't get newcomer Sacramento State or Eastern Michigan, they do get UMass and Kent State on the road, so those are two very winnable roadies. The RedHawks have gone 21-6 in MAC play over the last three seasons, winning at least six games each time. With plus money on 8+ wins, I'll trust that Martin does what he almost always does. My projection is 7.77 wins.

2025 Record: 7-7 SU & 8-6 ATS, 7-7 O-U
Head Coach: Chuck Martin - 13th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT PITTSBURGH (+17.1)	50.5
9/12	HOLY CROSS (-23.7)	14.0
9/19	VS. CINCINNATI (+8.8)	44.5
9/26	CONNECTICUT (-6.6)	31.5
10/3	BOWLING GREEN (-11.1)	26.5
10/10	AT MASSACHUSETTS (-19.7)	16.0
10/17	AKRON (-13.6)	25.0
10/24	AT C MICHIGAN (-3.3)	30.5
11/3	BUFFALO (-9.9)	28.0
11/10	OHIO U (-6.5)	31.5
11/17	AT KENT ST (-11.7)	23.5
11/24	AT W MICHIGAN (+4)	37.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **29.65**
#125 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who wins the QB battle?

The winds of change blew through Oxford last season, as Brett Gabbert finally exhausted his eligibility. The program's all-time third-leading passer was first replaced by former rival Dequan Finn from Toledo, but Finn quit the program before playing his old team. Henry Hesson took over and was awful against the Rockets, leading Thomas Gotkowski to finish the season as the starter. Gotkowski only completed 44.2% of his passes, but he's still on the roster alongside Kansas transfer David McComb and D-II Fort Hays State transfer Caleb Heavner. McComb had offers from Memphis, Virginia Tech, North Texas, and Tulane, among others and is probably a better fit in that he's more Gabbert-like than Finn was.

Who sparks life back into Miami's running game?

Even with a mobile QB in Finn, the RedHawks put up just 4.2 yards per carry, their lowest since 2022. Furthermore, they only managed 4.1 yards per carry against MAC opponents. They had 4.94 YPC against MAC opponents two seasons ago, so that's probably the benchmark that Martin and OC Pat Welsh will be looking for. Along with Heavner, Martin went to Fort Hays State and secured Rodney Nelson, who averaged better than six yards per carry. D'Shawntae Jones had 4.4 yards per pop last season on 63 attempts and led the team with seven rushing touchdowns as a 5-foot-10, almost 250-pound back. Seems like there's a bit of a "thunder and lightning" component to the ground game to go with an offensive line that played together a lot last season.

Is the RedHawks defense in any danger?

One of the staples of the Martin era has been a stout defense. Last season's 21.7 PPG allowed was the most since 2022, but the 41 sacks were also the most in a long time. With a sub-50% completion rate from the offense, the defense was put into some tougher situations relative to previous seasons and still did just fine. They allowed under 200 passing yards per game in conference play and just 3.7 yards per carry. The defensive losses are extremely heavy, as Eli Blakey, Jackson Kuwatch, and Corban Hondru amassed more than 300 tackles, eight sacks, 11 pass breakups, and 12 QB hits. Top pass rusher Adam Trick had 8.5 sacks and 13 QB hits and he's also gone. Martin always finds defenders and losing guys is nothing new, but it might take some time with the group that departed.

ODDS TO WIN...

2000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****180-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+360****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.4	95
YARDS PER POINT	14.6	72
PLAYS PER GAME	63.1	125
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:17	90
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.0%	102
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	327.2	109
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	83
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.4	76
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	141.5	78
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	84
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.7	111
COMPLETION %	49.0%	136
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	185.7	105
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	75
TURNOVERS	1.2	44
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.4	46
YARDS PER POINT	14.9	57
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.7%	115
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	348.8	40
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	29
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140.2	46
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	41
COMPLETION %	58.0%	22
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	208.7	42
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	34
SACKS	2.9	9
TURNOVERS	1.4	52

OHIO U BOBCATS



Aside from an uncharacteristic 3-9 showing in 2021, the Bobcats have been one of the most consistent G5 teams in the nation. Last year's 9-4 mark was the first time since that '21 season that Ohio didn't win 10+ games, but given everything that they went through, it was another really good season. It wasn't surprising that the transfer of power from Frank Solich to Tim Albin resulted in a one-year blip, but now the Bobcats have another new head coach in John Hauser. While they've kept all of their promotions internal, from Albin to Brian Smith to Hauser, who was the interim head coach for the Frisco Bowl win over UNLV, you have to wonder if there's a big impact on one of these seasons.

Perhaps this could be the one, as Hauser, who was the defensive coordinator, is now looking at a program with one returning starter on offense, the loss of a multi-year QB in Parker Navarro, the loss of near-1,400-yard rusher Sieh Bangura, who transferred back into the program prior to last season, and a noticeably lackluster transfer portal class.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

It is entirely possible that an established, steady program can withstand and overcome all of the doom and gloom addressed above, but I have my doubts. Given how the Bobcats have had tenured starting QBs like Tettleton and the Rourkes, I won't be the least bit shocked if they take some lumps and embrace a transitional year with Davis, the three-star QB from the Columbus area, to set him up to follow the long line of productive predecessors. While the Bobcats do avoid reigning champ Western Michigan, they get Miami and Toledo over a three-week stretch, have to go out to Sacramento, and have some non-conference toss-ups. My projection is 6.91 wins, but I could see a down year.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-6 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: John Hauser - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT NEBRASKA (+21)	50.5
9/12	JACKSONVILLE ST (-0.6)	34.0
9/19	AT S ALABAMA (-0.7)	29.0
9/26	STONEHILL (-35.1)	1.0
10/3	AT KENT ST (-6.8)	23.5
10/10	C MICHIGAN (-5.6)	30.5
10/17	AT SACRAMENTO ST (-8.5)	21.5
10/24	E MICHIGAN (-6.8)	28.0
11/3	AT AKRON (-4.7)	25.0
11/10	AT MIAMI OHIO (+6.5)	36.0
11/17	BALL ST (-15.8)	20.0
11/27	TOLEDO (-0.3)	35.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **26.72**
#135 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.8 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

5

1

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the string run out at the quarterback position?

Whether you want to credit the scouting and talent evaluation, the system, the stability of the program, or just outright good luck, Ohio has been on a generational run of QBs since Tyler Tettleton showed up in 2009. Ohio's three all-time leading passers have all come within the last 20 years with Tettleton, Nathan Rourke, and Kurtis Rourke. While Navarro had trouble taking care of the ball with just a 27/22 TD/INT ratio in his two seasons as a starter, he ran for nearly 2,000 yards with 27 rushing scores. Hauser and OC Scott Isphording have options, including returnee Nick Poulos, who redshirted last season, New Hampshire transfer Matt Vezza, who ran for 600 yards, and incoming freshman Levi Davis. But, the bar is set so high here that virtually any of those options are likely to fall short.

Is QB the only concern on offense?

Hardly. The offensive line features all new starters. While pretty much everybody has been in the system for a long time, they are unproven, which is a major concern with Bangura's 1,392 yards and 15 rushing TDs and the team's top four wide receivers in yardage, including a 1,000-yard pass-catcher in Chase Hendricks all elsewhere. Even in the transfer portal era, Ohio has had a lot of continuity and returning production year over year, or have at least had high-upside players waiting in the wings. The offense looks unrecognizable this season. And, as potent as they've been on a per-play basis, with 6.1 and 6.2 YPP over the last two seasons, they still haven't scored 30 PPG since 2022 when they had a +12 TO margin.

Will the defense save the day?

It's possible, but it is interesting to note that Hauser was the co-DC at Miami of Ohio, so he was one of the few external hires in recent seasons. I'm not sure if that will matter or not. Kurt Mattix is back to be the DC after shacking up in Charlotte with Albin last season. The attrition on the defensive side is a lot lighter than the offensive side, but still noticeable. With the top two tacklers gone, top defensive back Tarik Pearson, and most of last season's very low total of 22 sacks, backups will have to step up and transfers will have to acclimate quickly. After racking up 36, 36, and 35 sacks over the previous three seasons, the 22 sacks were the fewest since that ill-fated '21 season with 17.

1000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

200-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+650

MAC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.8	71
YARDS PER POINT	15.4	92
PLAYS PER GAME	67.8	76
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:58	23
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.7%	42
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	395.9	48
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	31
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.1	17
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	220.6	10
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	15
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	23.8	125
COMPLETION %	61.1%	77
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	175.3	113
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	58
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.8	26
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	26
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.9%	28
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	341.4	35
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	61
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140.1	45
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	59
COMPLETION %	64.2%	95
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	201.3	34
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	75
SACKS	1.8	75
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

SACRAMENTO STATE HORNETS



Welcome the Sac State Hornets to the FBS ranks, as the team from the capital of California will play in the Mid-American Conference. There has been a lot of money funneled into athletics lately at the school, as the basketball program is coached by Mike Bibby, Shaquille O'Neal is the "GM", and home games have a party-like atmosphere. They're now in the Big West Conference, but the football team is in the MAC as a football-only member.

That is hardly the only change for the program, as they hit the FBS ranks with a new head coach in Alonzo Carter and a ton of new faces. Last year's team was led by Rodney Hammond, who had over 1,200 rushing yards, and Ernest Campbell, who had 755 yards on just 37 catches. HC Brennan Marion's up-tempo offense produced 33.8 PPG, but the scheme will be different this season. Also, the most obvious change for the Hornets will be the travel, with two trips to Michigan, one to Ohio, one to Indiana, and then the regular-season finale in Hawaii.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Mississippi Valley State and UMass look like the best (and maybe only) hopes for wins from the Hornets this season. Ohio, Kent State, and Toledo all head west in conference play and those are two of the better programs annually in the MAC, plus a Kent State team hungry for any win that they can get. Obviously this is a transitional year to say the least and one that is likely to feature a lot of hurdles and challenges. My projection is 4.82 wins.

2025 Record: 7-5 SU & 6-6 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Alonzo Carter - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT E MICHIGAN (+8.1)	28.0
9/5	MISS VALLEY ST (-37.8)	-13.5
9/12	AT FRESNO ST (+23.5)	42.5
9/19	N DAKOTA ST (+14.2)	37.0
9/26	MASSACHUSETTS (-7.6)	16.0
10/10	AT BOWLING GREEN (+6.1)	26.5
10/17	OHIO U (+8.5)	31.5
10/24	AT BALL ST (+1.9)	20.0
10/30	KENT ST (-0.4)	23.5
11/4	TOLEDO (+11.7)	35.5
11/11	AT C MICHIGAN (+11.6)	30.5
11/28	AT HAWAII (+20.4)	38.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **26.52**
#136 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.8 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

6

OFFENSE

1

DEFENSE

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Do the players get to keep their frequent flyer miles?

As long as they're flying commercial, they should be able to, but that all depends on how the tickets are booked. Hopefully the Hornets players do get to keep them, because they're going to log some miles this season. The biggest trip for the program last season was to head down to East Texas A&M. This season, Eastern and Central Michigan, Bowling Green, Ball State, and Hawaii are all on the schedule. Of course, they could take advantage of some teams making the long trek to them. While the travel is certainly a talking point, it should be noted that there are no back-to-back road games for the Hornets outside of the end of the season with a bye week in between and that they only leave California once prior to October 10.

Is this the real-life sequel to Coach Carter?

The 2005 movie featuring Samuel L. Jackson was based on a California high school basketball coach who had a talented team that wasn't showing up in the classroom and he put the season on hold to put academics first. Ken Carter was the head coach at Richmond High School in the West Contra Costa Unified School District. Alonzo Carter's only other college head coaching gig was at Contra Costa College in San Pablo. Alonzo, who grew up in Oakland, has a strong reputation in the athletics community in terms of mentoring players and assisting them off-the-field as much or more as he does on it. He's been at San Jose State and Arizona on Brent Brennan's staff over the last five years and now gets his own program. I don't know how the team will do in close games or what his clock-management will look like, but there are a lot of JUCO transfers and discarded players that make up his roster and I have to assume this team is going to play extremely hard every week.

Are the Hornets going to be competitive?

Playing hard is a nice trait to have, but does the roster have the talent to turn that into playing tight games and even winning some? Well, we'll have to wait and see, but 247Sports did grade Sac State's transfer portal class second in the MAC. QB Carson Conklin transferred to Fresno State when Marion took over, but has now come back to the place where he was the starter in 2024. There are major questions in the trenches on both sides and obviously new playbooks to learn with OC Eric Kiesau from Florida and DC Adam Clark from Northern Arizona. Any returnees on defense now have to learn a 3-3-5 stack and returnees on offense, while very few and far between, have a more traditional offense to learn. Competitive? Maybe, but it probably won't show in the standings.

ODDS TO WIN...

5000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

150-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

80-1

MAC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS

RANK

POINTS PER GAME

PARTICIPATED
IN FCS IN 2025

YARDS PER POINT

PLAYS PER GAME

TIME OF POSSESSION

3RD DOWN CONV. %

TOTAL YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER PLAY

RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME

RUSH YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT

PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME

COMPLETION %

PASSING YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT

TURNOVERS

DEFENSIVE STATISTICS

RANK

POINTS PER GAME

PARTICIPATED
IN FCS IN 2025

YARDS PER POINT

3RD DOWN CONV. %

TOTAL YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER PLAY

RUSH YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT

COMPLETION %

PASSING YARDS PER GAME

YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT

SACKS

TURNOVERS

TOLEDO ROCKETS



For the first time since 2016, the Rockets will not be playing for Jason Candle. Hell, for the first time since 2009, Candle isn't even with the program. He's now the head coach at UConn and the Rockets moved quickly to replace him with Mike Jacobs, who spent the last two seasons with Mercer at the FCS level. Jacobs is a northwest Ohio native and his staff also consists of people with Ohio ties, including former Tiffin and Ohio Dominican head coach OC Cris Reisert and Cleveland native and Youngstown State DC Jahmal Brown.

Jacobs was a long snapper and offensive lineman at Ohio State from 1997-2001 and got into coaching pretty much right after that. His first head coaching gig was at Notre Dame College about a half hour from downtown Cleveland. This is something of a step up for the 47-year-old, but he took Mercer to the playoffs in back-to-back seasons and may very well be an upgrade over Candle, something hard to say about a guy who won 65% of his games overall and 68% of conference games.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5
The schedule is pretty soft for Jacobs in Year 1, as the Rockets don't face Miami of Ohio, get reigning champ Western Michigan at home, and get a visit from San Diego State in non-conference action. It will take time for things to come together and the opener against Michigan State may not be pretty, especially for a defense that allowed just 13.3 PPG and 96 rushing yards per game last season, but Jacobs seems like a good hire and there's at least some familiarity thanks to all the transfers from a team that finished in the FCS Top 25 each of the last two seasons. My projection is 8.04 wins.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 9-4 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: Mike Jacobs - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	AT MICHIGAN ST (+8.7)	42.5
9/12	C CONN ST (-27.8)	12.0
9/19	TEMPLE (-6.3)	34.0
9/26	SAN DIEGO ST (+3.6)	43.0
10/3	AT BALL ST (-11.3)	20.0
10/10	BUFFALO (-11.1)	28.0
10/17	AT E MICHIGAN (-5.1)	28.0
10/24	W MICHIGAN (-2.3)	37.5
11/4	AT SACRAMENTO ST (-11.7)	21.5
11/11	MASSACHUSETTS (-23.8)	16.0
11/20	BOWLING GREEN (-12.3)	26.5
11/27	AT OHIO U (+0.3)	31.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 27.24
#132 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 4 / -0.5
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

2

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Holy Toledo, who are these guys?

There are virtually no recognizable names on the roster for the Rockets this season. Returning production is hard to find, as the top returnee in tackles had 35 and the top returnee in yards of any kind had 194 receiving yards. It's hardly a surprise, as Candle left when a lot of his players were running out of eligibility and a head coach leaving means that the transfer portal is wide open. 247Sports lists 37 transfers for the Rockets, who have the third-best MAC class per their ranking. John Alan Richter is not one of those transfers, so he's a name that Rockets fans may recognize. Otherwise, there are a lot of Mercer transfers who were with Jacobs, including RB CJ Miller and WR Adjatay Dabbs, plus there are some faces on the OL familiar to Reisert, as they came with him from Gardner-Webb.

What kind of offense should we expect to see?

Under Jacobs, Mercer racked up 6.8 yards per play last season with a balanced approach that left them third in the nation in yards per game. The Bears had 4.9 yards per carry on more than 400 rushing attempts and threw for over 3,800 yards. Toledo may have been a little more run-heavy last season, but that's also because they had a lot of leads to protect and some big leads at that. Obviously this year's team won't have the same defense as last year's squad, so we'll have to wait and see how the game state plays out. With Miller, Penn State transfer Cory Smith, and two senior tackles who played for the Rockets last season, I would expect them to lean on the run at the outset.

What kind of defense should we expect to see?

This is going to be an aggressive defense under Brown. Last year's Mercer group only allowed 3.4 yards per carry, but gave up 5.7 yards per play because they got burned for some explosives in the passing game. The Bears had 42 sacks in 12 games, but also only generated 15 takeaways. With 96 tackles for loss, you can see how they pursued the run heavily and also got to the quarterback, but an evasive QB had the chance to burn them. There are some running QBs in the MAC, but not as many this season as we've seen in other years. With quite a few Mercer transfers who know the scheme, this should be an exciting defense to watch.

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+400****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.4	46
YARDS PER POINT	14.2	57
PLAYS PER GAME	66.9	89
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:08	60
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.4%	67
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	403.4	40
YARDS PER PLAY	6	26
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.4	62
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	170.3	43
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	31
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.2	82
COMPLETION %	63.3%	53
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	233.2	59
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	41
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	14.4	4
YARDS PER POINT	19	5
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.0%	7
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	273.9	3
YARDS PER PLAY	4.1	3
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	104.4	14
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.9	6
COMPLETION %	49.9%	2
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	169.5	5
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	9
SACKS	2.8	14
TURNOVERS	1.7	27

WESTERN MICHIGAN BRONCOS



For a G6 team to return the conference's Offensive Player of the Year with the current state of college football seems rare. For that player to be the starting QB is even rarer. Then, add in a 1,000-yard running back from the previous season and all of a sudden you have the foundation of something special. Therefore, it should come as no surprise that Lance Taylor's Broncos are expected to make a strong run at repeating as MAC champs this season. Broc Lowry threw for 1,803 yards and rushed for 963 more with 23 total touchdowns and Jalen Buckley shook off an injury-plagued 2024 to reel off 5.6 yards per carry.

This is something of a throwback offense running double tight ends for OC Walt Bell, but it worked, as WMU played keep-away with 4.6 yards per carry. Even though they only had 5.2 yards per play, a +9 turnover margin helped and the defense was spectacular, shaving nearly two touchdowns per game off of their ledger year over year. But, it could be harder than it looks to stay on top.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
It is a luxury to be able to use the transfer portal for depth as opposed to impact, which is the case on offense, but the defense is a major work in progress. There is a ton of depth behind Buckley, but not so much behind Lowry, who had 203 carries, a lot for a 6-foot-1 QB. The Broncos also don't get the luxury of facing UMass and Ball State this season, so the conference slate is a bit tougher. They also draw Michigan, Rice, and Boise State in non-conference play. While they should beat Rice, that game will basically have a running clock with teams that averaged 49.8 and 44.5 rush attempts per game, meaning the margin for error could be thin. My projection is 7.39 wins.

2025 Record: 10-4 SU & 10-3-1 ATS, 6-8 O-U
Head Coach: Lance Taylor - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT MICHIGAN (+24.5)	59.0
9/12	MONMOUTH NJ (-15.6)	25.0
9/19	AT RICE (-6.5)	27.5
9/26	BOISE ST (+9.7)	50.5
10/3	AT BUFFALO (-7.3)	28.0
10/10	KENT ST (-17.8)	23.5
10/17	AT C MICHIGAN (-3.8)	30.5
10/24	AT TOLEDO (+2.3)	35.5
10/31	BOWLING GREEN (-13.5)	26.5
11/10	AT AKRON (-10.1)	25.0
11/17	E MICHIGAN (-12.2)	28.0
11/24	MIAMI OHIO (-4)	36.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.98**
#99 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

7*

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Martini be shaken and stirred?

The Martini in question is Greer Martini, the 30-year-old defensive coordinator who has big shoes to replace with the departure of Chris O'Leary. O'Leary is now the DC with Jim Harbaugh and the Chargers, as he left the organization for a year to call plays in Kalamazoo and then went right back. With O'Leary, the Broncos were tied for fourth in the nation with 43 sacks. They were +21 in sack differential, ranked 12th in third-down defense, and only allowed 24 red-zone trips in nine conference games. Martini was the linebackers coach and his unit was really good, but they had to go to the portal to replace those guys. Plus, Nadame Tucker and Rodney McGraw combined for 21.5 sacks and 26 QB hits, as Tucker had 14.5 sacks and was signed as a UDFA by O'Leary and the Chargers. McGraw is now with the Dolphins.

Can the offense pick up the slack?

The Broncos were just 109th in yards per play last season. Of course, run-pass distribution was a major factor, as they ran the ball over 600 times. They were seventh in total rush attempts, with three service academies ahead of them, plus Rice, who now runs the option, and Indiana. Lowry's ability to run was the separator and the separator for him in taking over the job full-time after he and Brady Jones were in something of a timeshare to start the year. With Lowry and Buckley, along with a pretty experienced offensive line, they'll be able to run. But, will they be able to pass enough to keep the opposing defense honest?

Did Lance already have his chance?

Lance Taylor was 10-15 over his first two seasons in Kalamazoo. Everything seemed to come together last season, sparked by the pass rush and the ability to wear down the other team's defense. The Broncos were 12th in average time of possession, but they were tied for 98th in plays of 10+ yards and tied for 110th in plays of 20+ yards. Under O'Leary, the defense shaved off 1.4 yards per play, after allowing 6.4 and 6.1 in Taylor's first two seasons. It sure seems like there are a lot of reasons to be skeptical of the team given the heavy personnel losses on defense and an NFL-caliber defensive coordinator.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****50-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+320****MAC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.2	92
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	74
PLAYS PER GAME	66.9	88
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:03	19
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.4%	66
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.6	97
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	97
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	43.7	8
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	203.5	16
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	38
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	21.6	130
COMPLETION %	59.8%	86
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	137.2	131
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	111
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.6	10
YARDS PER POINT	17.6	10
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.8%	11
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	309.8	14
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	22
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	135.8	41
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	49
COMPLETION %	54.4%	6
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	174.1	8
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	19
SACKS	2.8	17
TURNOVERS	1.5	36



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MOUNTAIN WEST

Preview

previews by Jonathan Von Tobel

They say success is the greatest revenge, but in this case of jilted lovers, the Mountain West might have some trouble making the defectors to the new Pac-12 jealous. Gone are Boise State, San Diego State, Fresno State, Colorado State and Utah State. To replace them, the conference brought in UTEP, Northern Illinois and North Dakota State. The Bison have a shot to be the hot new fling, but the Miners and Huskies are projected to be cellar-dwellers in their first seasons in the conference.

The aforementioned North Dakota State program — which dominated the FCS and the Missouri Valley Football Conference — is one of the short shots to win the Mountain West. UNLV and New Mexico are either tied as favorites or have slight variance in their prices to win it all, depending on the shop. All three programs have rightful claims to their status as true contenders, but the conference does go slightly deeper than that.

Hawaii returns quarterback Micah Alejandro, who was named preseason Offensive Player of the Year. Timmy Chang has improved his win total each season on the island and has both an effective offense and a favorable schedule in conference play. There is no doubt the Rainbow Warriors are a dark horse of sorts to win the Mountain West.

Then there is Troy Calhoun and Air Force. The Falcons won nine games over the last two seasons, but Calhoun has an experienced roster, including quarterback Liam Szarka, who led one of the most efficient offenses in the country last season. Air Force could absolutely find a way to the table of contenders by season's end.

Heartbreak usually leads to change. People hit the gym, change their diets and generally try to improve themselves when they get out of a long-term relationship. The Mountain West certainly tried to do that with the additions it made, but it's unlikely those that departed for the Pac-12 are amazed by the changes to the conference. Either way, this should be a raucous and volatile season in the Mountain West, and that is great for bettors.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
UNLV	7.5	44	3.2	0.9	33.36 (97)	9.0	3.0	6.2	1.8
NEW MEXICO	7.5	42	2.3	-0.2	32.64 (103)	8.4	3.6	5.7	2.3
HAWAII	7.5	38.5	3.7	-0.7	31.93 (108)	7.9	4.1	5.5	2.5
AIR FORCE	6.5	37	2.5	-0.1	31.34 (114)	7.4	4.6	5.1	2.9
N DAKOTA ST	8.5	37	3.5	0.5	28.33 (130)	8.0	4.0	4.8	3.2
WYOMING	5.5	30.5	3.6	-0.6	31.08 (118)	5.7	6.3	3.4	4.6
NEVADA	4.5	28	1.4	0	35.11 (87)	4.0	8.0	2.8	5.2
SAN JOSE ST	4.5	27	2.3	0.5	34.39 (90)	4.5	8.5	2.8	5.2
UTEP	3.5	22.5	1.6	-0.2	35.19 (85)	3.2	8.8	2.0	6.0
N ILLINOIS	3.5	21.5	1.1	0.5	36.6 (79)	2.4	9.6	1.7	6.3

AIR FORCE FALCONS



From 2019 to 2023, double-digit win seasons, bowl game appearances and competing for league titles was a regularity for Air Force. However, roster turnover and injuries led to a stark drop-off in production over the last two seasons. After winning 40 games in four seasons — excluding the COVID-shortened season — the Falcons mustered just nine in the last two. That does not fit with the expectations of the second-longest tenured coach in college football.

Troy Calhoun has what he needs to get back to those winning ways this season. An experienced quarterback, returning production from an offense that was one of the most efficient in the country and no expectations. All eyes are on UNLV, New Mexico or North Dakota State this season. Perhaps, they should be on Colorado Springs.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5
The key to success for Air Force will be the defense. If the Falcons can creep back toward just average on that end, then this will be a team that is a true threat in the Mountain West. The offensive line is strong, and Szarka is the best quarterback Air Force has had in years. His return — along with that of Allen — could mean this is going to be one of the best offenses in the country once again.

The Falcons have to face the big boys of the conference, but two of them — North Dakota State and UNLV — will have to make the road trip to Colorado. Air Force has to go to New Mexico to end the season, but they avoid Hawaii entirely. Duquesne, UConn, SJSU and UTEP make up the other winnable opportunities at home. Air Force could shake up expectations in the conference.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Troy Calhoun - 20th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	DUQUESNE (-28)	12.0
9/12	N DAKOTA ST (-2)	37.0
9/26	AT NEVADA (-7.5)	28.0
10/3	NAVY (+5.3)	44.0
10/10	AT N ILLINOIS (-14.3)	21.5
10/17	UNLV (+5.4)	44.0
10/23	AT WYOMING (-2.8)	30.5
10/31	CONNECTICUT (-7.8)	31.5
11/7	AT ARMY (+5.6)	40.0
11/14	SAN JOSE ST (-12)	27.0
11/20	UTEP (-17.2)	22.5
11/27	AT NEW MEXICO (+7.4)	42.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.34**
#114 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.5 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

4*

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is this the best offense in the Mountain West?

The Falcons averaged 29.8 points and 407 yards per game last season. They ranked 11th in the country EPA per play, and 15th in both EPA per play when rushing the football and rushing success rate. Only four starters are back from that group, but one of them is quarterback Liam Szarka, the first time in four years Calhoun has a returning signal-caller. Owen Allen — the team's second-leading rusher behind Szarka last season — is back as well. Three starters departed in the offseason along the offensive line, but the career starts for this unit match those from last season. It will be hard to match the production of one of the best offenses in the country, but this is potentially the best unit in the conference.

Will the defense do its part?

While the Falcons had one of the best offenses in the country, they quite literally had the worst defense. Air Force allowed 30.3 points and 423 yards per game. Opponents averaged 7.2 yards per play. The Falcons were dead last in the country in opponent EPA per play, 134th in net yards per play (-2.08) and 96th in success rate. This season, eight starters are back from that group, including eight of the top nine tacklers and tackles-for-loss leader Isaac Hubert. In an effort to regain some semblance of competence, Calhoun brought in Steve Russ as defensive coordinator. Russ most recently served in the same role at UAB, but was defensive coordinator here from 2014-2017. There is nowhere to go but up for this group.

Can Air Force surprise the Mountain West?

The Falcons drew a favorable schedule this season. They must play North Dakota State, UNLV and New Mexico, but the first two must make the trip out to Colorado Springs. Air Force also avoids playing Hawaii. One wonders how the newcomers to the conference — of which the Falcons play two at home — will fare getting ready for an option offense in the middle of the regular-season slog. Calhoun has been a consistent force in this conference. Given the production on offense and the potential for improvement on defense, this seems like a team that could make a surprising appearance in the Mountain West Championship, something that hasn't happened since 2015.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****40-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+600****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.1	49
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	64
PLAYS PER GAME	70.3	51
TIME OF POSSESSION	34:07	3
3RD DOWN CONV. %	50.0%	5
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	404.9	37
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	38
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	54.8	2
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	261	3
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	34
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	14.1	134
COMPLETION %	58.7%	98
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	143.9	129
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	10.2	1
TURNOVERS	1.1	42
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.9	110
YARDS PER POINT	13.7	93
3RD DOWN CONV. %	52.4%	135
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	437.5	124
YARDS PER PLAY	7.4	135
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	164.1	80
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	133
COMPLETION %	69.9%	134
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	273.4	129
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.6	135
SACKS	0.8	133
TURNOVERS	0.7	123

HAWAII

RAINBOW WARRIORS



Improvement has been the theme for Hawaii under Timmy Chang. The Rainbow Warriors have improved their record each season under Chang, and statistically, they have seen their numbers improve on each side of the field. Coming off a nine-win season, one would assume improvement is hard to achieve in 2026, but the 'Bows have everything they need to get it done.

Micah Alejado was named the preseason Offensive Player of the Year. Pofele Ashlock was named to the preseason All-Conference team. This should be one of the premier offenses in the conference. On the other side, linebacker Jamih Otis and defensive back Elijah Palmer are preseason All-Conference players as well. The talent is there, and the schedule provides opportunity. This has the makings of a massive season in Honolulu.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

Belief in Hawaii hinges on the growth and development of Alejado. The second-year signal-caller has provided no reason not to believe. He also has a plethora of weapons at his disposal to make the dream of Hawaii winning a championship tangible. All the Rainbow Warriors have to do is take advantage of the opportunity in front of them.

While the schedule has the challenge of all three conference powers, each of them must make the trip out to the islands. A road trip to Wyoming will be difficult, but it comes after a bye week for Hawaii. They have to go to NIU, UTEP and Nevada as well, all of which are games this team should take care of if they are what their potential suggests they are. Not only is this team worth playing Over on its win total, but they are a solid bet to be the Mountain West champion.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & ATS, 5-8 O-U
Head Coach: Timmy Chang - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT STANFORD (+3.1)	39.0
9/5	UNLV (+2.7)	44.0
9/12	NEW MEXICO ST (-17.2)	25.0
9/26	AT WYOMING (-3.7)	30.5
10/3	SAN JOSE ST (-14.7)	27.0
10/10	AT ARIZONA ST (+13.7)	49.5
10/17	NEW MEXICO (-0.4)	42.0
10/24	AT N ILLINOIS (-15.2)	21.5
11/7	AT UTEP (-13.7)	22.5
11/14	N DAKOTA ST (-4.7)	37.0
11/21	AT NEVADA (-8.4)	28.0
11/28	SACRAMENTO ST (-20.4)	21.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.93**
 #108 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.7 / -0.7**
 (HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

4*

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does a healthy Alejado look like in 2026?

Alejado had an incredible 2025 despite dealing with a nagging ankle injury, which he suffered in the season-opener against Stanford. The injury eventually led to Alejado missing two starts — Sam Houston State and Portland State — but the signal-caller still delivered. Alejado completed 66% of his passes for 3,106 yards while tossing 24 touchdowns to nine interceptions. The Las Vegas native was never a dual threat in high school, but still showed an ability to escape pressure and use his legs, as represented by the 614 yards and six touchdowns he rushed for over his last two seasons at Bishop Gorman. Improvement in the passing should largely be expected given his pedigree, but can Alejado add another dynamic to his game on the ground with a healthy ankle this season?

Does the steady improvement for the defense continue?

When Chang took the job in 2022, the Rainbow Warriors had just two starters back on defense and went on to allow 34.7 points per game and 6.6 yards per play. In every season since, Hawaii has allowed fewer points and yards per game, improved in yards per play each season and has seen the sack total climb from just 17 in 2022 to 30 last season. Only three starters are back for Chang in 2026, but Dennis Thurman is back for a second season at defensive coordinator, and the top three players in tackles for loss — along with leading sack-getter Elijah Palmer — are all on the roster. Hawaii does not need to be a shutdown unit by any stretch, so if they can improve or even maintain the production from last season, this unit should be a strength.

Can the 'Bows break through?

Hawaii has achieved a winning record in Mountain West play just three times since joining the conference in 2012, one of which occurred last season. Coming off a nine-win season, the goal for Chang and the Rainbow Warriors is a Mountain West Championship. The betting market believes this team is on the fringe of contention — it is the fourth option to win the conference at DraftKings (+450). Hawaii also gets the benefit of hosting all three teams — UNLV, NDSU and New Mexico — that are ahead of it in the betting market. Chang has improved his record every season at the helm. The trend would tell you that the 'Bows are on the brink of something big.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****28-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+450****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.5	36
YARDS PER POINT	13.5	42
PLAYS PER GAME	72.2	34
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:45	27
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.7%	27
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	397.3	46
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	61
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.6	131
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	103.3	121
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	105
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.3	7
COMPLETION %	65.3%	30
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	294	6
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	66
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.8	65
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	71
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.0%	46
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	372.8	61
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	88
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	142	50
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	64
COMPLETION %	58.8%	27
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	230.8	82
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	101
SACKS	2.3	44
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

NEVADA WOLF PACK



Nevada was never a dominant powerhouse in football, but this was a proud program with a track record of success. Ten wins over the last four seasons between two head coaches shows just how tumultuous the time has been in Reno. But, Jeff Choate is a fiery dude who does have a sturdy base with his Wolf Pack roster this season that could lead to some improvements.

Nevada is a prime example of a program that lacks the backing in the NIL era to stay relevant. There is more money out there for Nevada, but the results need to be there as well. No one is asking the Wolf Pack to make it to the CFP, but regular bowl appearances should be the norm in northern Nevada.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Quarterback is an obvious question for Nevada, but Duncan showed enough in his starts for Hawaii last season that the expectation should be that he wins the job and serves in the role admirably. If he can provide a steadier hand at the position, then this offense has enough talent to be much more effective. Assuming Choate can get the most out of this defense, this could be a difficult out for Mountain West foes.

The Wolf Pack draw some difficult opponents on the schedule. Nevada must go to both North Dakota State and UNLV while also hosting Air Force, New Mexico and Hawaii. But the potential of this defense under Choate, coupled with an offense that has some upside, could equate to an upstart season for the Wolf Pack in 2026.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 5-6-1 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Jeff Choate - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	W KENTUCKY (+7.3)	36.5
9/12	MONTANA ST (+13.6)	43.0
9/19	AT MIDDLE TENN ST (-5.8)	21.0
9/26	AIR FORCE (+7.5)	37.0
10/10	AT UTEP (-3.9)	22.5
10/17	AT N DAKOTA ST (+12.5)	37.0
10/24	SAN JOSE ST (-1.9)	27.0
10/31	AT UCLA (+21.4)	48.0
11/6	NEW MEXICO (+12.4)	42.0
11/14	AT N ILLINOIS (-5.4)	21.5
11/21	HAWAII (+8.4)	38.5
11/28	AT UNLV (+19.2)	44.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.11**
#87 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / 0**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

5

OFFENSE

2

DEFENSE

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who emerges among the trio of contenders for the quarterback job?

Nevada had one of the least efficient passing-attacks in the country in 2025. The Wolf Pack ranked 114th in passing success rate, 133rd in passing EPA per play and ranked in the 34th percentile in explosive pass rate. Those anemic numbers are why Nevada has a three-way competition at quarterback despite Carter Jones returning. Jones (1,019 yards 6 TD 8 INT) will fight UCLA transfer Luke Duncan and program stalwart AJ Bianco for the gig. Duncan is 6-foot-6 and started on the road against Ohio State last season for UCLA. Bianco has been in Reno for three seasons. The expectation is that Duncan will eventually win the job, but Choate has sworn this race is tight heading into fall camp. No matter who wins, the Wolf Pack will need much more from the position in 2026.

Can the running game find its legs once again?

If the passing game finds its way back toward average, it could mean wonders for the Nevada rush offense, which has some strong indicators of future success. Leading rusher Caleb Ramseur is gone, but Herschel Turner ran for 395 yards on 5.1 yards per carry and is back. He is behind what seems to be a strong offensive line on paper. Three starters return, including preseason All-Conference left tackle Jack Foster and right tackle Zach Cochnauer, who earned Fourth Team All-Conference honors last season. Choate also brought in both Jacob Norcross and Ethan Newman Jr. from Memphis to play center and right guard, respectively. Nevada averaged just 4.4 yards per carry and finished 76th in rush success rate last season. With the returning production and additions, this group could be much improved.

Can Jeff Choate work his magic with this defense?

Given Choate's defensive background, the effectiveness of this unit will always be in question. There has been steady improvement each of the last two seasons, but could this be the year they take the step toward above average? Choate certainly has the pieces. Defensive lineman Dylan LaBarbera and defensive back Aidan Walker were preseason All-Conference selections. Linebacker EJ Smith is back after an early injury ended his season as well. The Wolf Pack have allowed fewer points and yards per game, as well as yards per play, each year under Choate. It would not be surprising to see that trend continue this season.

ODDS TO WIN...

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****30-1****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	17.4	124
YARDS PER POINT	16.8	113
PLAYS PER GAME	60.9	133
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:05	64
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.9%	123
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	292.4	127
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	113
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.5	87
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	143.3	76
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	65
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.8	115
COMPLETION %	59.5%	90
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	149.1	128
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.8	129
TURNOVERS	2.2	134
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.5	83
YARDS PER POINT	13	112
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.9%	67
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	370.5	59
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	72
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	150.7	65
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	66
COMPLETION %	64.6%	101
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	219.7	57
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	67
SACKS	1.5	110
TURNOVERS	1.3	66

NEW MEXICO LOBOS



Head coach Jason Eck and the Lobos took the Mountain West by storm last season with a 9-4 record and six wins in conference play. Now, New Mexico is the favorite with one of the most experienced rosters in the country. Twelve starters are back from last year's squad, and among them are quarterback Jack Layne and reigning Defensive Player of the Year Jaxton Eck.

It's easy to see why the Lobos are considered the favorite by some to win the conference. However, there is a big difference between being the upstart 'dog and the hunted favorite. How will New Mexico deal with this massive role change?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

The win total is a tough play considering the juice on Over 7.5 and Under 8.5 wins, but if one were more likely than the other, it would be Under 8.5 victories. New Mexico did not fare well as a favorite last season, and now it faces a reality in which it will be the favorite in most of its conference games. Perhaps some improvement could mean the team handles that role much better, but with the continuity on the roster, the flaws remain the same as well.

The team's schedule presents some big challenges as well. Road trips for the Lobos include Oklahoma, Hawaii and Wyoming. They must host both UNLV and North Dakota State, as well as Air Force. Can they get the coin to flip heads consistently in those coin-flip type spots in conference play? That seems unlikely. New Mexico is a good team, but most of its damage dealt last season was as an underdog. This team as a favorite seems to be overvalued.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-6 ATS, 5-8 O-U

Head Coach: Jason Eck - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	C MICHIGAN (-14.6)	30.5
9/12	MERCYHURST (-39.2)	5.0
9/19	AT OKLAHOMA (+22.2)	61.0
9/26	AT NEW MEXICO ST (-12.9)	25.0
10/3	UTEP (-22)	22.5
10/17	AT HAWAII (+0.4)	38.5
10/24	N DAKOTA ST (-6.8)	37.0
10/31	AT SAN JOSE ST (-12.5)	27.0
11/6	AT NEVADA (-12.4)	28.0
11/14	UNLV (+0.6)	44.0
11/20	AT WYOMING (-7.7)	30.5
11/27	AIR FORCE (-7.4)	37.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.64**
#103 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

6

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is the quarterback position actually settled?

Layne is back after leading the Lobos to nine wins and a bowl berth, but despite his success, he might not be a lock to be the starting quarterback. Layne missed spring camp recovering from surgery on a torn flexor tendon in his throwing elbow. He also was not overtly dominant last season. Layne threw for 2,486 yards with just 13 touchdowns to 10 interceptions. He averaged only 7.6 yards per attempt. Good, not great numbers. Behind Layne is Oregon transfer Luke Moga. A former three-star recruit, Moga reportedly made the most of Layne's absence in spring and "dazzled" the media in Albuquerque. Moga is a strong athlete with enough upside to convince Oregon to recruit him at one point. Should Layne not be healthy, or even struggle early, this could be Moga's job before the season's end.

Will this defense be any better?

The Lobos return six starters from last season's unit. Their returning production is a strength on offense, but is it on defense? New Mexico was very strong in limiting big plays, finishing in the 67th percentile in explosive play rate allowed. However, it was in the 19th percentile in non-explosive EPA per play and the 36th percentile in late-down success rate. Linebacker is the position of strength for this group with the Mountain West Defensive Player of the Year back in the fold, but the team lost a good amount of production along the defensive line. It wouldn't be surprising to see this group allow more than the 3.4 yards per carry it limited opponents to in 2025, and bettors might want to expect a dip in sack production after the Lobos racked up 36 last season.

How does the team fare with expectations?

New Mexico was a surprise in 2025. The team closed as an underdog in seven of its games, but in the six games it was favored in, New Mexico went 3-3 SU and 1-5 ATS. This season, the team is either the outright favorite to win the Mountain West or tied on the oddsboard with UNLV. There is no question that the market will — as it stands in the offseason — make this team a favorite in the majority of its contests. It's a nice story when you're the underdog, but meeting market expectations is a whole new task when you're the hunted at the top of the pack.

ODDS TO WIN...

800-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****13-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+270****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.7	66
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	35
PLAYS PER GAME	65.8	105
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:07	61
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.8%	71
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	355.7	84
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	73
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.7	60
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	146.8	72
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	85
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.4	107
COMPLETION %	65.1%	33
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	208.9	91
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	47
TURNOVERS	1.8	122
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.3	39
YARDS PER POINT	15.2	48
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.0%	63
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	339.5	30
YARDS PER PLAY	5	34
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	112.8	19
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	16
COMPLETION %	68.1%	132
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.8	74
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	73
SACKS	3	6
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

NORTH DAKOTA STATE BISON



North Dakota State was the big fish caught by Mountain West commissioner Gloria Nevarez in the wake of the Defecting Five heading for the Pac-12. The Bison are a great football program with a long history of not only dominating at the FCS level, but also stepping up to challenge some of the best FBS programs in the country. NDSU retains that role as favorite despite stepping up to the FBS level, and many will be curious to see how it fares in the Mountain West.

Having said that, the Bison are entering this new journey with a largely homegrown roster. Not many transfers are on this team, and head coach Tim Polasek lost a lot of talent from last year's team to the transfer portal. This season will be a true test of NDSU's formula as a football program.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

Given the track record of North Dakota State, it is understandable that the team enters its first season in the Mountain West as one of the short shots to win the conference. That being said, it seems the lofty expectations of this team are somewhat high. The loss of talent in the transfer portal was immense, and there was not much brought back to supplement those losses. The Mountain West is no power conference, but these are teams built with former Power Four players that have some strong talent. There should be doubts about the Bison's ability to just walk in and dominate.

The Bison must also go to Air Force, UNLV, Hawaii and New Mexico in conference play. That's road trips to all of the contenders. The home schedule is far from daunting — especially non-conference games against Fordham and Sacramento State — but Wyoming, Nevada and UTEP all have potential for improvement this season. Can NDSU really come out on top of the majority of their MW road games? Doubtful.

2025 Record: 12-1 SU & 6-7 ATS, 7-6 O-U

Head Coach: Tim Polasek - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	JACKSONVILLE ST (-5.8)	34.0
9/5	FORDHAM (-39.2)	2.0
9/12	AT AIR FORCE (+2)	37.0
9/19	AT SACRAMENTO ST (-14.2)	21.5
10/3	WYOMING (-10.6)	30.5
10/10	AT UNLV (+9.7)	44.0
10/17	NEVADA (-12.5)	28.0
10/24	AT NEW MEXICO (+6.8)	42.0
10/31	UTEP (-18.2)	22.5
11/14	AT HAWAII (+4.7)	38.5
11/21	N ILLINOIS (-18.5)	21.5
11/27	AT SAN JOSE ST (-8.2)	27.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **28.33**
#130 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.5 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

5

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How does North Dakota State handle being a favorite at a higher level?

The role of favorite is nothing new to this program. North Dakota State was not only favored in every game it played last season, it closed as a 30+ point favorite in six of its 13 contests. The Bison have expectations — both internally and externally — of success in the Mountain West, but this is a higher level of competition. The powers that be in the conference did NDSU no favors either when mapping out the schedule for its inaugural season in the Mountain West. The Bison have road trips to Air Force, UNLV, New Mexico and Hawaii. Those will be coin-flip spots for North Dakota State. Gone are the days of bullying a lesser conference. NDSU is certainly capable of winning this league, but the road will be much tougher.

Will the lack of talent from the transfer portal burn the Bison?

North Dakota State took a different tact with its 2026 recruiting class than most: it brought in 29 high school players and only nine transfers. Three played at Power Four programs last season, and one of those three is punter Caleb McGrath. The Bison lost a lot of talent to the portal, including two First-Team All-MVFC offensive linemen. At the FCS level, the strategy of bringing in a large number of high school recruits with the plan of retaining and developing them is what worked for NDSU. However, this is not the FCS. Teams — especially in the Group of Five — are constantly retooling with G5 castoffs and former top prospects looking for a new home after failing to catch on at the power programs. The Bison have just 10 starters back and brought in zero starters in the portal. Will that end up burning them in their first season in the Mountain West?

Does the run of quarterback development continue?

When Cole Payton was selected by the Eagles with the 178th pick of the NFL Draft, that marked the fifth Bison starting quarterback drafted in the past 11 years. Nathan Hayes — the heir apparent to Payton — now has the pressure of keeping that run going. Hayes appeared in 10 games last season. He completed 57% of his passes for 381 yards with four touchdowns and one interception. Hayes has been in the system since 2022, so there should not be a learning curve of any sort. But he takes over an offense that does not have its top two rushers or receivers from a season ago.

600-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

1000-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+300

MOUNTAIN WEST

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME		PARTICIPATED
YARDS PER POINT		IN FCS IN 2025
PLAYS PER GAME		
TIME OF POSSESSION		
3RD DOWN CONV. %		
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER PLAY		
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME		
RUSH YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT		
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME		
COMPLETION %		
PASSING YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT		
TURNOVERS		
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME		PARTICIPATED
YARDS PER POINT		IN FCS IN 2025
3RD DOWN CONV. %		
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER PLAY		
RUSH YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT		
COMPLETION %		
PASSING YARDS PER GAME		
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT		
SACKS		
TURNOVERS		

NORTHERN ILLINOIS HUSKIES



Chaos is the word that best describes the offseason Northern Illinois went through. In February, their head coach — Thomas Hammock — departed for a job in the NFL with the Seattle Seahawks. Rob Harley was named the interim head coach in his stead. The roster turnover was immense, especially on defense.

The chaos continued into July, but in a positive sense when Taron Dickens suddenly became available in the transfer portal. Still, Harley has his hands full. The defense is building from the ground up, he seems to be a lame-duck coach and the team is transitioning to a new conference. Perhaps the Huskies can shock the Mountain West like they shocked Notre Dame two years ago, but there is a lot working against one of the conference's new additions.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

Data and statistics are always the best way to evaluate and project teams in sports, but sometimes vibes do matter. The vibes for Northern Illinois heading into the 2026 season aren't great, and then there is the data. No returning starters on defense, a new offense and quarterback for the offense and a new conference. None of that adds up to a positive outlook.

The schedule for the Huskies is insanely difficult as well. In non-conference, they will have road games at Iowa, Arizona and Georgia State. They avoid New Mexico in conference play, but they go to Wyoming, UNLV (off a bye week) and North Dakota State. Hawaii and Air Force make the trip to DeKalb as well. All of this likely equates to an ugly season for a team experiencing a hectic offseason.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Rob Harley (interim) - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT IOWA (+36.6)	55.5
9/12	ILLINOIS ST (+11.7)	34.0
9/19	AT ARIZONA (+33.2)	52.5
9/26	AT GEORGIA ST (+2)	23.0
10/10	AIR FORCE (+14.3)	37.0
10/17	AT WYOMING (+12.1)	30.5
10/24	HAWAII (+15.2)	38.5
10/31	AT UNLV (+25.2)	44.0
11/7	AT SAN JOSE ST (+7.3)	27.0
11/14	NEVADA (+5.4)	28.0
11/21	AT N DAKOTA ST (+18.5)	37.0
11/28	UTEP (-0.3)	22.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **36.60**
#79 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.1 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

6

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

0

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Taron Dickens the answer NIU needed at quarterback?

Two weeks prior to starting work on this guide, the quarterback position looked bleak for NIU. Brady Davidson and Jalen Macon were the only returners for the program. The two had combined to complete fewer than 50% of their passes for four touchdowns and three interceptions, and they were set to duke it out for the job. However, one-time UNC commit and former Western Carolina quarterback Taron Dickens was released by the Tar Heels due to academic issues in mid-July, and the Huskies struck. Dickens appeared in 18 games at Western Carolina. He completed 271 of 365 passes for 3,508 yards with 38 touchdowns to two interceptions while adding 97 rushes for 321 yards and a score. He also set an NCAA record for consecutive completions in a single game when he completed 46 straight passes against Wofford. His arrival is a huge win for the program.

What are the expectations for this defense?

Harley ran this unit last season, so there is some familiarity with the pieces, but this unit is being overhauled in a big way. The top 14 tacklers from 2025 are all gone. The leading returnee in that category is defensive end Jay'Shon Thomas with 21 tackles and two sacks. In order to offset the losses, Harley brought in quite a few bodies, but none come from the Power Four level, and most are FCS or even JUCO transfers. The Mountain West will not be confused for the SEC, but there are some very good offenses in this conference. Can Harley do his best work and rebuild this unit while the plane is in the air, or will this turn out to be one of the worst defenses in the country?

Is Harley set up for failure?

Harley is leading this team in 2026, but it is important to note he is just the interim head coach. Hammock caught the program by surprise when he left his alma mater for a job as the highest-paid running back coach in the NFL with the Seahawks in late February. For the sake of continuity, the athletic department promoted Harley, but he is in just his second season with the program. The roster is completely new, and the program is making the transition into a new conference. It seems Harley is in place to take the lumps before ultimately being replaced. How does that manifest for a team projected to win three or four games this season? This could get ugly quickly in DeKalb.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****250-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****80-1****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	16.9	127
YARDS PER POINT	17	115
PLAYS PER GAME	62.9	126
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:50	98
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.1%	122
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	286.7	130
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	124
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.2	22
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	188.8	28
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	40
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	20	131
COMPLETION %	52.3%	134
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	97.9	134
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	4.9	135
TURNOVERS	0.9	14
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25	59
YARDS PER POINT	14.8	58
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.0%	117
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	370.2	56
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	58
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	194.5	117
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	97
COMPLETION %	59.4%	33
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	175.6	11
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	41
SACKS	1.1	127
TURNOVERS	1.1	86

SAN JOSE STATE SPARTANS



It is fitting that blue is the main color for San Jose State, because sadness is the lone emotion any thought of the Spartan program evokes. SJSU has not won a bowl game since 2015, and it has not won more than seven games in a single season since 2012 (that lone bowl win was a 6-7 season). It seems that the Spartans are in for much of the same in 2026.

Ken Niumatalolo has a large rebuild on his hands. Only three starters are back for San Jose State, and they added only two starters in the transfer portal. Niumatalolo did a fantastic job in his first season at the helm in a similar situation, but that was with an ingenuitive offense that took the league by surprise. This is his third season, and many in the conference have seen this team's tendencies. Is everything truly as bleak as it looks?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Perhaps the Spartans can surprise the Mountain West like they did in 2023 when they won seven games in Niumatalolo's inaugural season. That was due to a surprising offense and a favorable schedule, and neither seem to be in the cards for San Jose State this season.

The Spartans have difficult road trips against USC, Hawaii and Air Force on the schedule. They must host an experienced Fresno State squad in non-conference play, as well as Wyoming, New Mexico, UNLV and North Dakota State. None of that includes spots against Eastern Michigan and UTEP on the road, which are coin flips at best. In this preview, I was wrong about Niumatalolo in 2023, but I'll take my chances and say he can't do it again.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 4-8 ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Ken Niumatalolo - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	AT USC (+36.3)	60.0
9/4	AT E MICHIGAN (+2.4)	28.0
9/12	CAL POLY SLO (-10.3)	19.5
9/19	FRESNO ST (+12.9)	42.5
10/3	AT HAWAII (+14.7)	38.5
10/9	WYOMING (+0.6)	30.5
10/17	AT UTEP (-3.4)	22.5
10/24	AT NEVADA (+1.9)	28.0
10/31	NEW MEXICO (+12.5)	42.0
11/7	N ILLINOIS (-7.3)	21.5
11/14	AT AIR FORCE (+12)	37.0
11/21	UNLV (+15.6)	44.0
11/27	N DAKOTA ST (+8.2)	37.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **34.39**
#90 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.3 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

3

2

1

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will be doing the spreading and the shredding?

Offensive coordinator Craig Stutzmann’s Spread & Shred offense took the Mountain West by storm two seasons ago, but it fizzled in 2025. This season, the offense has a completely new depth chart at quarterback, outside of one-time UCLA transfer Robert McDaniel. Luke Weaver is the presumed winner of the QB battle. Weaver started two games — Sam Houston State and Portland State — at Hawaii last season in place of the injured Micah Alejandro. He won both, completing 53 of 85 passes for 534 yards, five touchdowns and one interception. The redshirt senior is seasoned and well-traveled, having worked his way up from Modesto Junior College two years ago. He likely gives the Spartans the best chance in this offense.

Does another wide receiver emerge?

The common theme for the Spartans in Stutzmann’s offense has been the emergence of a previously non-heralded player at receiver. In his first season, Nick Nash erupted for 1,382 yards and 16 touchdowns. Last season, Danny Scudero caught 88 passes for 1,297 yards and 10 touchdowns. Who is next in line? It could be any of these receivers, as the top five pass-catchers from last season depart. Four transfers make up the receiver room, but one name to watch is Anthony Ivey. Ivey is a former four-star recruit who transferred in from Penn State. This is obviously a massive step down for him — which could be a red flag — but the pedigree is there, and so too is the system to maximize his talents.

Can Niumatalolo do it again?

On paper, this looks rough for Niumatalolo. The Spartans lost 24 starters to the transfer portal and brought in just two, according to Phil Steele. Only three full-time starters return from a three-win team. Receiver, defensive line and defensive back are position groups which lost every starter and need to be rebuilt. There are some former Power Four transfers in the mix, but all are making the transition to San Jose State for a reason. Niumatalolo is a good coach who surprised the entire conference with a seven-win season when he arrived. He has continuity on his staff, but he’ll have to do one of his best coaching jobs of a long career to get this group into the mix in the Mountain West.

5000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

400-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

20-1

MOUNTAIN WEST

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.5	108
YARDS PER POINT	19.5	126
PLAYS PER GAME	69.5	59
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:21	116
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.8%	52
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	401.6	41
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	36
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.2	135
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	112.9	114
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	61
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.5	2
COMPLETION %	55.7%	122
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	288.7	8
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	85
TURNOVERS	2.4	135
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.9	116
YARDS PER POINT	12.3	124
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.1%	33
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	405.9	88
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	103
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	159.5	74
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	53
COMPLETION %	66.5%	118
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	246.5	109
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.7	125
SACKS	1.5	104
TURNOVERS	1.2	77

UNLV REBELS



This has been an unprecedented run for UNLV. The Rebels have won 30 games over the last three seasons and made an appearance in the Mountain West Championship all three years. None of those trips to the title game have ended with UNLV hoisting a trophy, and now the feel-good story of the little ol' Rebels is turning into expectations of success from the fanbase. Dan Mullen did his part in his first season at the helm, but he must do it again with another roster built on the backs of transfers.

If not now, when? The conference has been completely overhauled. Gone are the Boise State Broncos, which bested UNLV in all three of the previous conference title games. The Rebels are the premier program in the conference now, as crazy as it sounds. Mullen keeps a cool exterior, but failing to win Mountain West — let alone not even making it — would be a colossal failure for him.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

Logic would dictate that UNLV just cannot keep up the run of success at quarterback the program has experienced the last three seasons. This depth chart seems to have more flaws to it than previous ones, especially with Orji coming off the horrendous injury he suffered last season. The former Michigan signal-caller is somewhat limited as a passer. If he isn't the same athlete, what happens if Arnold struggles and loses the job? It's also hard to buy the excuse the staff is selling when it comes to last season's defensive effort. This could be another subpar unit.

That's not to say that this team will be terrible, but nine or more wins seems like a real challenge for this group. UNLV will host both Memphis and Cal in the non-conference portion of its schedule. It has to face Hawaii and New Mexico on the road. North Dakota State will make the trip to Allegiant as well. The schedule, along with some flaws in the roster, make it seem like eight wins is an extremely likely outcome for the Rebels.

2025 Record: 10-4 SU & 7-7 ATS, 6-8 O-U
Head Coach: Dan Mullen - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
8/29	MEMPHIS (-5.5)	41.0
9/5	AT HAWAII (-2.7)	38.5
9/12	AT NORTH TEXAS (-6.9)	34.5
9/26	AT AKRON (-17.8)	25.0
10/3	CALIFORNIA (-1.8)	45.5
10/10	N DAKOTA ST (-9.7)	37.0
10/17	AT AIR FORCE (-5.4)	37.0
10/31	N ILLINOIS (-25.2)	21.5
11/7	WYOMING (-17.3)	30.5
11/14	AT NEW MEXICO (-0.6)	42.0
11/21	AT SAN JOSE ST (-15.6)	27.0
11/28	NEVADA (-19.2)	28.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **33.36**
#97 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / 0.9**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

3

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the run of success at quarterback continue?

UNLV has not returned a starting quarterback since Doug Brumfield in 2023. Five quarterbacks have started for the team over that span, and the Rebels still accumulated 30 wins and made three conference title games. This season, the presumed starter is Auburn transfer — and one-time five-star prospect — Jackson Arnold. Dan Mullen took in Anthony Colandrea last season, made him Mountain West Offensive Player of the Year and then got him a payday at Nebraska. Could he do the same for Arnold? Behind him is former Michigan quarterback Alex Orji, who is coming off a catastrophic leg injury and was not fully healthy in spring. The success of the co-favorite in the Mountain West rests on whether or not Mullen can work his magic at the most important position once again.

Who emerges at the other skill positions?

Running back Jai'den "Jet" Thomas is a known commodity for UNLV. Thomas ran for 1,036 yards, averaged 7.2 yards per carry and scored 13 total touchdowns last season. Outside of the First-Team All-Conference back, there is not much returning production. The top three receivers from last season departed in some form or fashion. There are big expectations for wide receiver Taeshaun Lyons, the leading returnee at the position (13 receptions, 222 yards). Outside of that, both running back depth and the wide receiver room as a whole are filled with transfers expected to carry large loads for the offense.

Does a calm offseason lead to improvement for the defense?

Defensive coordinator Paul Guenther joined the staff last March as an associate head coach and safeties coach, but was thrust into his current role when Zach Arnett resigned in April. Those around the program say Guenther did not have the ability to install his own scheme, and it led to some poor results. UNLV finished 104th in the country in opponent EPA per play, gave up 6.4 yards per play and 5.2 yards per carry. Guenther now has a full offseason to install his defense, but only four starters return. Either way, there is no excuse to lean on when it comes to preparation. This unit must be better this season if the Rebels are to finally win a conference title.

ODDS TO WIN...

500-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

10-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+270

MOUNTAIN WEST

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.8	15
YARDS PER POINT	13	24
PLAYS PER GAME	67.3	84
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:36	45
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.8%	15
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	439.9	20
YARDS PER PLAY	6.5	11
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.8	71
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	187.6	29
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.4	12
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.8	73
COMPLETION %	65.3%	31
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	252.3	39
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	20
TURNOVERS	1.2	60
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.8	78
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	61
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.5%	15
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	408.8	93
YARDS PER PLAY	6.1	117
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	178.8	99
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	123
COMPLETION %	60.1%	41
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	229.9	79
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	98
SACKS	2.2	46
TURNOVERS	1.5	36

UTEP MINERS



The betting market does not have much faith in Scotty Walden and the Miners. UTEP is the longest shot on the board to win the Mountain West at DraftKings (80-1), and the team has the lowest win total in the conference. The Miners won't win the conference, but there is a silver lining.

This is a roster with some upside and a good amount of returning production. They were a sneaky solid defense at times last season, and the staff has done a decent job plugging some holes with the transfer portal. There is certainly a strong chance this is not the squad that finishes last in the Mountain West.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 3.5

There is certainly enough on this roster on offense to be somewhat optimistic about their chances of climbing out of the national cellar when it comes to production. A lot will lie on the shoulders of Colson at quarterback, but he has the upside. The defense could also be better once it gets to conference play.

The Miners will take their lumps. They have road trips to Oklahoma and Michigan to start the season. They must also go to New Mexico, North Dakota State and Air Force while hosting Hawaii. But there are opportunities on this schedule in the form of matchups with Texas Southern, Oregon State, Nevada and San Jose State. If they spring an upset, this is a team that could achieve four wins on the season.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 3-9 ATS, 8-4 O-U
Head Coach: Scotty Walden - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	AT OKLAHOMA (+41.7)	61.0
9/12	TEXAS SOUTHERN (-20.6)	3.5
9/19	AT MICHIGAN (+39.4)	59.0
9/26	OREGON ST (+7.3)	32.0
10/3	AT NEW MEXICO (+22)	42.0
10/10	NEVADA (+3.9)	28.0
10/17	SAN JOSE ST (+3.4)	27.0
10/31	AT N DAKOTA ST (+18.2)	37.0
11/7	HAWAII (+13.7)	38.5
11/14	WYOMING (+5.8)	30.5
11/20	AT AIR FORCE (+17.2)	37.0
11/28	AT N ILLINOIS (+0.3)	21.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **35.19**
 #85 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.6 / -0.2**
 (HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

2

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can EJ Colson spark a rebuilding offense?

Colson — a transfer from Incarnate Word — started a game and appeared in another for UCF back in 2024. That did not go well — he went 9 of 16 for 64 yards and threw a pick — and he made his way to the Cardinals. Last season, Colson showed some promise. He completed 70.9% of his passes and threw for 2,142 yards with 16 touchdowns and four interceptions. He also added 287 yards and three touchdowns on the ground. Head coach Scotty Walden named Colson the starter in May, and with that comes a Herculean task: turn around an offense which was 131st in EPA per play and 129th in success rate. And do it with the team’s top four rushers and top seven receivers all out the door.

Could the running game surprise some defenses in the Mountain West?

It’s hard to project what an offense will do when not a single returning starter is back, but on paper UTEP could have done much worse in trying to improve its ground game. The Miners averaged only 116 yards per game and 3.7 yards per carry last season. The program has not averaged more than 3.9 per attempt since 2022. In order to fix it, Walden brought in some help along the offensive line. Left guard Brian Williams earned All-Conference honors in the SWAC last season, and right tackle Jaymon Lamb played in seven games for North Texas. At running back, the crown jewel seems to be Missouri transfer Tavorus Jones, a former four-star prospect who appeared in 20 games for the Tigers.

Can the defense keep it up?

UTEP quietly put together a strong defensive campaign in 2025. The Miners finished 14th in the country in opponent EPA per play and 20th in success rate. They placed in the 97th percentile in explosive play rate allowed and the 94th percentile in late-down success rate. Only four starters are back, but there is some talent here. Middle linebacker Jayden Wilson returns after finishing second in tackles (92) and third in tackles for loss (7.5). Justin Content and Xavier Smith are roaming the secondary once again. The two combined for 10 pass breakups, seven tackles for loss and two interceptions last season. Kyle Beyer takes over as defensive coordinator, but served as an analyst for this team last season. There is certainly a strong chance this could be an above-average unit in the Mountain West.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

80-1

MOUNTAIN WEST

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.6	102
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	75
PLAYS PER GAME	68.7	64
TIME OF POSSESSION	25:53	135
3RD DOWN CONV. %	30.1%	129
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	319.1	115
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	122
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.8	106
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	108.5	119
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	116
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.8	28
COMPLETION %	54.6%	128
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	210.6	89
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6	120
TURNOVERS	2	130
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.6	107
YARDS PER POINT	12.5	120
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.1%	3
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	393.9	79
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	48
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	178.7	97
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	74
COMPLETION %	61.2%	57
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	215.2	53
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	49
SACKS	2.2	48
TURNOVERS	1	98

WYOMING COWBOYS



It's always difficult to take over for a legend, especially one who had the success Craig Bohl did in his time at Laramie. Still, Jay Sawvel's time at the helm has been disappointing, even in the context of filling big shoes. The Cowboys have just seven wins under Sawvel, and the offense has been one of the worst in the conference in that time. The pressure is building despite the high elevation.

If there was a time Sawvel could save his bacon, it would be this season. He brought in an offensive mind to fix the team's biggest problem and landed a decent fish in the transfer portal to play quarterback. While the Cowboys lost talent to the portal, a majority of this roster has been part of the program. This could be a massively improved team if the right pieces hit.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

The upside of Wyoming begins with its offense. If Hughes and offensive coordinator Christian Taylor are the match they look like on paper, this offense could really stun the conference. That would allow Sawvel to focus on a defense which has a strong foundation.

Wyoming does have a difficult schedule in the context of the Mountain West, which could be what holds it back. The Cowboys draw Hawaii, North Dakota State, Air Force, UNLV and New Mexico. Two of those — NDSU and UNLV — are on the road and another two opponents come off bye weeks. Factor in road games against Colorado State and Central Michigan, and you're asking Wyoming to come out on the right side of 50-50 contests more often than not.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 2-10 O-U

Head Coach: Jay Sawvel - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT COLORADO ST (+4)	32.5
9/12	N COLORADO (-21.8)	13.0
9/19	AT C MICHIGAN (+3.5)	30.5
9/26	HAWAII (+3.7)	38.5
10/3	AT N DAKOTA ST (+10.6)	37.0
10/9	AT SAN JOSE ST (-0.6)	27.0
10/17	N ILLINOIS (-12.1)	21.5
10/23	AIR FORCE (+2.8)	37.0
11/7	AT UNLV (+17.3)	44.0
11/14	AT UTEP (-5.8)	22.5
11/20	NEW MEXICO (+7.7)	42.0
11/28	CONNECTICUT (-2.4)	31.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.08**
#118 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.6 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

5

3

2

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How does the Cowboys' new offense fare?

In the two seasons under Sawvel, the Cowboys' offense has taken a dump. Despite nine returning starters last season, Wyoming averaged 16 points and 315 yards per game. It ranked 128th in the country in EPA per play and 124th in success rate. To address those issues, Sawvel brought in Christian Taylor to run the offense. Taylor most recently served as an offensive advisor for the Buffalo Bills and was the offensive coordinator for William & Mary from 2020 to 2023. In his time at William & Mary, Taylor led an offense which was great at generating explosive runs, using backs out of the backfield and topped the country in passing efficiency. All of that will be needed to improve this unit.

But seriously, will the offense be better?

Outside of the addition of Taylor on the staff, Sawvel brought in one of his former recruits at William & Mary: quarterback Tyler Hughes. Hughes is a dual-threat who totaled 3,000 yards passing and rushing last season and 31 touchdowns. He is familiar with Taylor's system as well. The Cowboys' leading rusher from last season — Samuel Harris — is back for his sophomore season, and he lines up behind an offensive line with two starters and 41 career starts back. The top four receivers from last season are gone, but this is reportedly a strong group of tight ends, which is important in the new scheme. With Hughes pulling the trigger and adding a dynamic the Wyoming offense has missed in recent seasons, the needle is clearly pointing up.

Is Sawvel the guy for the job?

Sawvel is in the third year of a five-year contract, and the first two years weren't great. The former defensive coordinator took over a program which had three losing seasons under his predecessor, Bohl. One of those was the 2020 COVID-shortened season. Sawvel has only known losing seasons in his time at the top in Laramie. This might be Sawvel's best chance at a winning record. According to Phil Steele, while there aren't many returning starters, 77.2% of this roster is 'homegrown,' meaning a lot of guys who have been in the program. If the offensive changes hit, this should be a team that can improve on its four wins last season.

ODDS TO WIN...

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****20-1****MOUNTAIN WEST**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	14.6	131
YARDS PER POINT	21.1	132
PLAYS PER GAME	66.1	101
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:16	117
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.3%	111
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	308.8	123
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	121
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.1	105
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	126.5	98
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.9	94
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.6	48
COMPLETION %	54.3%	129
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	182.4	109
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.6	132
TURNOVERS	1.5	96
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.7	37
YARDS PER POINT	16.6	21
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.1%	31
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	360.5	47
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	52
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	179.1	100
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	100
COMPLETION %	55.5%	13
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	181.4	16
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	20
SACKS	1.2	121
TURNOVERS	1.2	77

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Average Joe

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PAC-12

Preview

previews by Matt Youmans

It's football season, yet the unveiling of a new-look Pac-12 Conference brings back memories of the late, great Bill Walton. The basketball legend and colorful broadcaster constantly touted the "conference of champions" due to the league's impressive history of NCAA titles. Unfortunately, the schools responsible for almost all of those titles — Stanford, UCLA, USC, Cal, Oregon, Washington, Arizona and Arizona State — are long gone and spread to different conferences all over the map. Oregon State and Washington State, the league's two leftovers, have been joined by a handful of newcomers from the Mountain West (Boise State, San Diego State, Colorado State, Fresno State and Utah State) and a straggler from the Sun Belt (Texas State). The Pac-12 consists of only eight teams and all include the name "State." The conference will not get an automatic qualifier into the College Football Playoff.

Boise State, which won the last three Mountain West championships, is listed by DraftKings as the +170 favorite to win the Pac-12. The Broncos could boast the conference's top quarterback, Maddux Madsen, and top running back, Dylan Riley. San Diego State, the +370 second choice, went 9-4 last season and is led by workhorse running back Lucky Sutton.

The league does present a few intriguing teams beyond the Broncos and Aztecs. In his first season at Fresno State, coach Matt Entz won nine games. Watch out for Entz and the Bulldogs, and keep an eye on Colorado State with new coach Jim Mora Jr., who worked an incredible turnaround at UConn. Texas State arrives with quarterback Brad Jackson triggering an explosive passing attack.

The Pac-12 can make a statement, for better or worse, when Boise State opens its season at Oregon on Sept. 5. On the same day, Fresno State visits USC and Washington State plays at Washington. Other nonconference matchups to circle are San Diego State at UCLA (Sept. 12) and BYU at Colorado State (Sept. 19). In the biggest league games, Fresno hosts Boise on Oct. 10 and Boise hosts San Diego State on Nov. 21.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
BOISE ST	7.5	50.5	3.9	-0.1	39.13 (73)	9.2	2.8	5.8	1.2
SAN DIEGO ST	6.5	43	2.6	0.1	36.74 (78)	7.4	4.6	4.5	2.5
FRESNO ST	6.5	42.5	2.8	-0.3	37.66 (75)	7.4	4.6	4.0	3.0
TEXAS ST UNIV	5.5	37.5	2.7	-0.2	38.48 (74)	6.0	6.0	3.3	3.7
WASHINGTON ST	4.5	38	3.4	0.2	39.67 (72)	5.3	6.7	3.2	3.8
UTAH ST	4.5	36.5	3.9	-0.8	41.67 (67)	4.7	7.3	2.9	4.1
OREGON ST	3.5	32	3.5	-0.6	40.73 (70)	3.8	8.2	2.3	4.7
COLORADO ST	3.5	32.5	1.4	-0.3	39.73 (71)	3.9	8.1	1.9	5.1

BOISE STATE BRONCOS



A decline is evident in the Boise State program, but it's only a minor slip. The Broncos were a powerhouse two years ago, going 12-2 and reaching the College Football Playoff, so last season's 9-5 finish was an obvious step back. The worst part was the bookend losses — 34-7 at South Florida in the season opener and 38-10 to Washington in the LA Bowl. Boise has been winning big for a long time under multiple head coaches, from Dirk Koetter to Dan Hawkins to Chris Petersen to Bryan Harsin and now Spencer Danielson, who guided the Broncos to three consecutive Mountain West championships. Danielson has a senior quarterback and an experienced team that deserves to be the Pac-12 favorite. A bigger, realistic goal is another CFP appearance.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

Aside from the season opener at Oregon, which is a 24.5-point favorite, every other game on the schedule is winnable for the Broncos. The toughest Pac-12 road tests will be at Fresno State and Washington State, but Boise gets a home date with San Diego State and should reach eight wins if Madsen stays healthy. The DraftKings line of 7.5 looks a tick low and the -135 price is fair to pay. It should be noted DraftKings is stipulating 11 games for this win total and excluding the "Flex Game" added to Pac-12 schedules at the end of November. Circa Sports includes the 12th flex game and offers 7.5 Over -180. Instead of locking in all of the final opponents, the league will adjust matchups to maximize bowl eligibility and CFP chances, and the final game will be designated as a non-conference rematch from earlier in the season.

2025 Record: 9-5 SU & 8-5-1 ATS, 6-8 O-U
Head Coach: Spencer Danielson - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT OREGON (+22)	68.5
9/12	MEMPHIS (-12.7)	41.0
9/19	S DAKOTA (-25.4)	29.5
9/26	AT W MICHIGAN (-9.7)	37.5
10/3	UTAH ST (-18.7)	36.5
10/10	AT FRESNO ST (-5.1)	42.5
10/24	AT WASHINGTON ST (-9)	38.0
10/31	TEXAS ST UNIV (-17.1)	37.5
11/7	AT COLORADO ST (-16.5)	32.5
11/14	OREGON ST (-23)	32.0
11/21	SAN DIEGO ST (-11.3)	43.0
11/28	AT UTAH ST (-10)	36.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **39.13**
#73 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

7*

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Maddux Madsen a good bet to bounce back?

A quarterback who's named after a pair of Hall of Famers – pitcher Greg Maddux and shortstop Derek Jeter — is probably worth a bet. Maddux Jeter Madsen owns a 20-6 career record as the Broncos' starter, but he battled injuries and played poorly at times last season. As a sophomore, Madsen completed 62.4% of his passes for 3,018 yards and 23 touchdowns with six interceptions. As a junior, his numbers dipped to 58.3% completions, 2,334 passing yards, 18 touchdowns and nine interceptions. He threw four interceptions in a 28-7 loss at Notre Dame, yet when healthier late in the season, he passed for three touchdowns to lead the Broncos to a 38-21 victory over UNLV in the MW title game.

Madsen was labeled as a game manager two years ago when star running back Ashton Jeanty carried the offense. Madsen is capable of more than he showed last season and Boise's success will depend a lot on how he plays. He could be the top quarterback in the conference.

Will the running attack ground and pound defenses?

Dylan Riley didn't fill Jeanty's shoes, but he had a few flashes of brilliance, including a 201-yard rushing performance on only 15 carries in a 56-31 regular-season win over UNLV. Riley finished the season with 1,125 yards and 10 touchdowns on the ground. He will again be backed up by Sire Gaines, who ended the year with 811 rushing yards. The Riley-Gaines combo will make Madsen's job easier and make the Boise offense tough to stop.

Danielson said he was disappointed the Broncos were not more physical on the offensive line last season and he expects that to change. Boise returns two of the league's top linemen — senior guard Roger Carreon and senior tackle Daylon Metoyer — and welcomes the addition of senior tackle Tyler Ethridge, a transfer from Division II Colorado State-Pueblo. Left tackle Kage Casey moved on to the NFL's Broncos as a fourth-round draft pick by Denver, but there is plenty of depth, experience and size on the line.

Is the defense strong enough to survive?

In 2024, Boise's defense led the nation with 55 sacks, but that number dropped to 27 last season. Edge rusher Jayden Virgin-Morgan returns after leading the team with six sacks. While four of the top five tacklers from last season are gone, junior linebacker Boen Phelps and senior cornerback Jaden Mickey are experienced leaders on a defense that must improve after allowing 24 PPG. The Broncos have some questions to answer on this side of the ball.

ODDS TO WIN...

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+450****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+170****PAC-12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28.2	47
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	66
PLAYS PER GAME	75.6	8
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:12	7
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.3%	22
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	407.6	33
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	74
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.5	32
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	167.7	49
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	68
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	36
COMPLETION %	58.0%	104
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	239.9	52
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	70
TURNOVERS	1.6	104
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.8	57
YARDS PER POINT	13.7	91
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.7%	19
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.9	34
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	51
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	165.5	83
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	109
COMPLETION %	54.7%	8
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	175.5	10
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	21
SACKS	2.1	60
TURNOVERS	1.6	32

COLORADO STATE RAMS



If Jim Mora Jr. turned around the Connecticut program — and he did by going 9-4 and 9-3 in his last two years — he certainly could do something similar at Colorado State. The change is unlikely to be sudden in Fort Collins because Mora must implement more than 60 new players on the roster, and he's got some questions about the quarterback position. The Rams unraveled on the way to a 2-10 record that got Jay Norvell fired at midseason, and the situation is a complete rebuild. Mora brought several players and coaches with him from UConn, including offensive coordinator Pryce Tracy and co-defensive coordinator Kenny McClendon. After the magic he worked the past two years, it's better to bet on Mora than against him.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 3.5

The Rams have the potential to be a surprise team in the Pac-12, a conference that appears to be full of mystery teams aside from favorite Boise State. Mora opens with a pair of home games he can win against Wyoming and Southern Utah. The third home game against BYU on Sept. 19 is one Colorado State is almost certain to lose. With Texas-San Antonio, Oregon State, Utah State and Washington State also on the schedule, it's not a huge leap of faith to predict Mora will win four games or more this season. Bet on it. The Rams' win total at Circa Sports is listed low at 3.5 and includes the 12th flex game, so play it Over -140. It would not be a big surprise if Mora gets this team to 6-6, especially if the quarterback play is impressive.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 4-8 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Jim Mora - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	WYOMING (-4)	30.5
9/12	S UTAH (-11.3)	22.0
9/19	BYU (+24.1)	57.5
9/26	AT TX-SAN ANTONIO (+12.9)	41.0
10/3	OREGON ST (-2.5)	32.0
10/15	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (+8)	37.5
10/24	SAN DIEGO ST (+9.2)	43.0
10/31	AT UTAH ST (+8.2)	36.5
11/7	BOISE ST (+16.5)	50.5
11/14	AT WASHINGTON ST (+9.2)	38.0
11/21	AT FRESNO ST (+13.1)	42.5
11/28	TEXAS ST UNIV (+3.4)	37.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **39.73**
#71 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.4 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

7

OFFENSE

1

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will win the starting quarterback job?

UConn transfer K'saan Farrar might figure to have the inside track due to his history with Mora. Farrar attempted 18 passes as a backup last season when the Huskies' success had a lot to do with star quarterback Joe Fagnano, who finished with 28 touchdown passes and one interception. Still, Farrar could have a difficult time beating out Oklahoma State transfer Hauss Hejny, who was a higher-ranked recruit. Farrar and Hejny both have running ability, something Mora prefers in his quarterbacks. A media source has indicated Hejny has become the favorite to win the job.

Surrounding the QB will be senior running back Mel Brown, a UConn transfer, and Durell Robinson, an Auburn transfer. The top returning receiver is Tommy Maher, who had 32 receptions last year, but another key receiver is likely to be UConn transfer Jackson Harper. The go-to tight end probably will be (you guessed it) a UConn transfer, Juice Vereen. Mora will need to build the offensive line with transfers, a theme that holds true for the entire team.

Will the Rams' rotten defense show significant improvement?

The easy answer is this defense will be improved, mostly because it can't get much worse. Colorado State allowed 30.8 PPG to rank 112th in scoring and the rushing defense (205 yards per game) ranked 125th. This might be hard to believe, but a UConn transfer is expected to lead the unit. Oumar Diomande, a junior linebacker, ranked second for the Huskies in both tackles (116) and sacks (five). The defensive line and linebacker personnel look strong on paper. Kenny McClendon is serving as co-defensive coordinator with Tyson Summers, who was the DC under Norvell and took over as interim coach.

How quickly can Mora create a winning team?

Mora's run as UCLA coach was nothing remarkable at the time. He went 46-30 from 2012 to 2017 before getting fired, but considering the Bruins' struggles after his departure, maybe he performed better than perceived. It's unrealistic to expect he can reach a bowl at Colorado State immediately. In his first two years at UConn, Mora's teams finished 6-7 and 3-9. When he had time to build the roster and find the right quarterback, he started to win big. What's often true with most new coaches is true here: Mora must find a quarterback who can make plays.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****40-1****PAC-12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.3	119
YARDS PER POINT	17.5	119
PLAYS PER GAME	65	111
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:29	129
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.8%	125
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	319.9	113
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	109
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.8	128
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	97.2	126
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	120
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.4	42
COMPLETION %	62.4%	58
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222.7	67
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	95
TURNOVERS	1.4	80
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.1	111
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	86
3RD DOWN CONV. %	49.0%	133
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	444.6	127
YARDS PER PLAY	6.4	128
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	218	130
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.3	128
COMPLETION %	63.3%	82
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.6	73
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.4	121
SACKS	1.5	110
TURNOVERS	1.3	66

FRESNO STATE BULLDOGS



When projecting college football teams, it's no secret the two most important positions of handicapping emphasis are the head coach and quarterback. Fresno State certainly has a winning coach. Matt Entz is about as good as it gets. Entz, 53, coached North Dakota State to two FCS national championships in five years and exited with a record of 60-11. In 2025, he took over a Fresno State team that went 6-7 the previous season and guided the Bulldogs to a 9-4 finish punctuated by a win in the Arizona Bowl. He's got a new quarterback this season, and that position appears to be upgraded, so beware of the Bulldogs. Entz could be lifting Fresno to the top of the Pac-12.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

After the trip to Los Angeles in early September, Fresno will have a realistic shot to reel off three consecutive wins against Sacramento State, San Jose State and Rice. The quarterback will be the key because if Martin matures quickly, the Bulldogs can win almost every game on their schedule. This team is solid in all areas and probably can win seven or eight games even with mediocre QB play. Fresno plays at San Diego State on Oct. 17 and is set to host the Aztecs in the "Flex Game" rematch on Nov. 28. The DraftKings win total, based on 11 games and excluding the flex spot, is 6.5 with Over offered at even money. Circa Sports offers the better bet — 6.5 Over -120 with the 12th flex game included. The coach is the key to this play. Entz won eight regular-season games in his Fresno debut. He's got a better team now and the schedule is manageable. Bet on the Bulldogs being big overachievers.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 7-6 ATS, 5-8 O-U

Head Coach: Matt Entz - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	AT USC (+21.6)	60.0
9/12	SACRAMENTO ST (-23.5)	21.5
9/19	AT SAN JOSE ST (-12.9)	27.0
9/26	RICE (-18)	27.5
10/3	AT WASHINGTON ST (-0.8)	38.0
10/10	BOISE ST (+5.1)	50.5
10/17	AT SAN DIEGO ST (+3.4)	43.0
10/31	OREGON ST (-13.9)	32.0
11/7	AT UTAH ST (-1.8)	36.5
11/14	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (-2)	37.5
11/21	COLORADO ST (-13.1)	32.5
11/28	SAN DIEGO ST (-2.2)	43.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **37.66**
#75 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.8 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

13

7

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will a Maryland transfer pass the test?

While the Bulldogs were good on the ground last season, they were limited by what quarterback EJ Warner could not do. Warner was an accurate passer, yet he didn't have a big arm to stretch the field and finished with 2,030 passing yards, 13 touchdowns and 11 interceptions. Entz brought in Maryland transfer Khristian Martin, who's a dual-threat playmaker at 6-foot-4 and 230 pounds. Martin, a sophomore, is expected to win the job after battling with junior Jayden Mandal and freshman Deagan Rose. Four of the top five pass catchers are returning, including leading receiver Josiah Freeman, who had 52 receptions and six touchdowns. Martin's impact will be a mystery, but he's got the physical skills to make a major impact. He's also got a solid support system with experienced running backs, receivers and offensive linemen.

Is the Fresno State offensive line the league's strongest?

Entz builds winning teams by building a physical offensive line first. He's got three of the top linemen in the league — tackles Brayden Walton and Rolan Fullwood and guard Edward Fonua — to anchor arguably the best and biggest line in the Pac-12. The line will pave the way for running backs Bryson Donelson and Rayshon "Speedy" Luke. Donelson and Luke combined for 1,302 rushing yards and 11 touchdowns last season. In a conference highlighted by running back talent — headlined by Boise State's Dylan Riley and San Diego State's Lucky Sutton — the Bulldogs could boast the most effective offense on the ground.

Are the Bulldogs a threat to USC and Boise State?

Fresno State is a 23.5-point underdog at USC in the Sept. 5 season opener, and that line is likely to get bet higher by kickoff because favorites typically draw action early in the season. But keep an eye on what could be a dangerous underdog. Entz will have his team well prepared, and Fresno's physical offensive line could push around the Trojans up front. USC coach Lincoln Riley is known for fielding finesse teams that are not the most physical up front. The Bulldogs host Boise State on Oct. 10 in what could be the most important matchup of Pac-12 play. Entz coached Fresno, a 17-point underdog, to a 30-7 win at Boise last year. Entz is a bet-on coach and those are two games to circle and consider taking the points.

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****50-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+650****PAC-12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.3	90
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	73
PLAYS PER GAME	66.8	93
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:03	18
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.7%	97
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	341	95
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	94
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.6	49
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	166.3	53
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	41
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.7	99
COMPLETION %	62.5%	55
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	174.8	115
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.1	119
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.8	16
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	51
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.1%	13
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	298.2	10
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	15
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	142.5	51
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	65
COMPLETION %	53.6%	5
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	155.7	3
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.3	1
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	2.1	5

OREGON STATE BEAVERS



Jonathan Smith had it rolling at Oregon State, posting 10 wins in 2022 and eight in 2023, but it seemed inevitable that he would leave for a big payday and he got it from Michigan State. Smith and the Beavers were better off together, as he was fired after two years in East Lansing and the Beavers went 7-17 the past two years. Trent Bray was dumped as coach after starting 0-7 last year and Oregon State finished 2-10. It's time for a new era. JaMarcus Shephard takes over what will be one of the worst teams in the conference, and maybe the worst.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

It's tempting to forecast Oregon State as a surprise team, with Murphy's potential at quarterback and MacIntyre's ability to build the defense. The new coaching staff will put the Beavers in position to win more games and they could get to four or five wins. However, there are way too many holes in the depth chart to be too optimistic, and games against Houston and Texas Tech to open the season will put the Beavers in a hole in early September. This decision on this win total will depend on some other mystery teams on the Pac-12 schedule. Is Oregon State good enough to beat Colorado State, Texas State, Utah State and Washington State? This is not a best bet by any means, so the lean is 3.5 Under +150 with Circa Sports offering a nice Under price on the 12-game line.

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 3-9 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: JaMarcus Shephard - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT HOUSTON (+23.2)	53.0
9/12	TEXAS TECH (+26)	61.5
9/19	MONTANA (+1.2)	36.5
9/26	AT UTEP (-7.3)	22.5
10/3	AT COLORADO ST (+2.5)	32.5
10/10	SAN DIEGO ST (+7.6)	43.0
10/17	WASHINGTON ST (+2.7)	38.0
10/31	AT FRESNO ST (+13.9)	42.5
11/7	TEXAS ST UNIV (+1.8)	37.5
11/14	AT BOISE ST (+23)	50.5
11/21	UTAH ST (+0.20)	36.5
11/28	AT WASHINGTON ST (+10)	38.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **40.73**
#70 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.5 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

5*

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will a new coaching staff improve a vagabond QB?

Maalik Murphy was highly touted out of high school in the Los Angeles area and opted to leave home, picking Texas instead of UCLA. In two years with the Longhorns, he redshirted the first year and did not play because of injury and he appeared in seven games his second year while going 2-0 as a starter. Murphy transferred to Duke in 2024 and posted a 9-3 record as a starter while passing for 2,933 yards and 26 touchdowns. His play has not been that impressive to watch, however, and he declined last season with a bad Oregon State team. Murphy went 1-7 as the starter, passing for 1,805 yards and nine touchdowns with eight interceptions. Cornell Hatcher returns as the featured running back and Shephard brought receiver Aeryn Hampton as a transfer from Alabama. Murphy is not much of a running threat and turns the ball over too much, but he's got a better coaching staff and supporting cast now, so expect to see significant improvement.

Is Shephard the right man for the job?

JaMarcus Shephard was hired away from Alabama, where he was offensive coordinator, and he's got some history in the Pac-12. Shephard was on Kalen DeBoer's coaching staff at Washington when the Huskies won the conference title. Shephard hired Mitch Dahlen as the Beavers' offensive coordinator, and Dahlen was part of the Alabama and Washington staffs that developed star quarterbacks. The coaching staff appears to be a major upgrade, and a big part of that will be defensive coordinator Mike MacIntyre, who has had success at a variety of stops, including head coaching jobs at San Jose State, Colorado and Florida International. Don't expect Shephard to replicate what Jonathan Smith did at Oregon State in terms of wins, but the Beavers should be more competitive during a rebuilding year.

Is the defense the key to Oregon State overachieving?

MacIntyre inherits some returning talent and has made some transfer additions, so there are signs the Beavers will be much better on defense after surrendering 29.4 PPG. Oregon State held Washington State to seven points in a late-season upset and showed improvement. The linebacker group will be a strength, led by senior Aiden Sullivan and former USC transfer Raesjon Davis. Sullivan is the team's top returning tackler and should be one of the league's best defensive players. Duquesne is not known for producing dominant defensive ends, yet that's where Ish Findlayter comes from, and he's bringing high expectations as a top transfer. The front seven looks solid for MacIntyre.

2000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

300-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

30-1

PAC-12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	15.7	129
YARDS PER POINT	21.2	133
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	27
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:32	11
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.0%	96
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	333.9	102
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	123
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.3	91
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	101.9	123
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	128
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.1	16
COMPLETION %	59.6%	89
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232	62
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	114
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.9	102
YARDS PER POINT	12.4	122
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.6%	10
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	382.1	67
YARDS PER PLAY	6	110
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	159.1	73
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	92
COMPLETION %	58.2%	24
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	223	63
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	111
SACKS	1.4	112
TURNOVERS	0.8	116

SAN DIEGO STATE

AZTECS



Sean Lewis predicted a quick turnaround when he took over a losing San Diego State team in 2024, but ugly losses piled up and he went 3-9. Lewis fulfilled his promise last season by posting a 9-4 record and reaching a bowl. The highlights were a 34-0 victory over California and a 17-7 win over Boise State. Lewis is an innovative offensive coach. He's got to find the right quarterback to operate his system. The Aztecs are known for their tradition of tough defenses and stud running backs, and they definitely have the running back in place this season. The defense and quarterback play will determine San Diego State's ceiling.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5
It's tough to be too optimistic about San Diego State when its quarterback is surrounded by questions and its defense is in rebuilding mode. Lewis is a good coach, but this season could turn out to be a disappointment and some regression seems imminent. The Portland State opener is the only spot on the schedule that should be a gimme putt. The Aztecs face road trips to UCLA, Toledo, Oregon State, Colorado State and Boise State and might not win more than one of those games. The rest of the home schedule (James Madison, Texas State, Fresno State, Washington State, Utah State) serves up no cupcakes. The DraftKings win total of 6.5 Under +125 is worth a play. DraftKings rules stipulate 11 games and exclude the "Flex Game" added to Pac-12 schedules on Nov. 28. Circa Sports has posted 7.5 Under -140 and includes the 12th flex game, which will be at Fresno, so that's the better play.

2025 Record: 9-4 SU & 10-3 ATS, 4-9 O-U
Head Coach: Sean Lewis - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	PORTLAND ST (-42.2)	3.5
9/12	AT UCLA (+6.3)	48.0
9/19	JAMES MADISON (-3.3)	41.5
9/26	AT TOLEDO (-3.6)	35.5
10/3	TEXAS ST UNIV (-8.3)	37.5
10/10	AT OREGON ST (-7.6)	32.0
10/17	FRESNO ST (-3.4)	42.5
10/24	AT COLORADO ST (-9.2)	32.5
10/31	WASHINGTON ST (-7.4)	38.0
11/14	UTAH ST (-9.9)	36.5
11/21	AT BOISE ST (+11.3)	50.5
11/28	AT FRESNO ST (+2.2)	42.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 36.74
#78 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.6 / 0.1
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

13

8*

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Lucky Sutton the Aztecs' next Marshall Faulk?

OK, so that's a very unfair comparison and a sensationalized question considering Faulk is the program's No. 2 all-time rusher, but Sutton is continuing the trend of dynamic running backs. He ran for 1,297 yards last season, including 150 against Boise State, to lead the Mountain West. Unlike Faulk, Sutton is not a receiving threat out of the backfield, but he's a big back at 6-foot-1 and 225 pounds and handles a heavy workload. San Diego State must have an effective ground attack to complement a quarterback who needs the help. Sutton can be a star.

Will quarterback Jayden Denegal be the answer?

Lewis' plans for a high-flying passing attack might not materialize. While Denegal is never going to remind San Diego football fans of Dan Fouts, he does have the potential to be much better. A shoulder injury that bothered Denegal last season is apparently repaired, so he should improve on modest numbers (58.8% completions, 1,807 passing yards, nine touchdowns and eight interceptions). The talent is there because Denegal is a former Michigan transfer who was a touted recruit. It certainly helps that the Aztecs' top two receivers, Jordan Napier and Donovan Brown, are returning and Texas A&M transfer Jacob Bostick has been added. Aside from Denegal, the biggest question mark is an offensive line that must replace three starters.

Will a new-look defense still be elite?

The irony in San Diego State's turnaround last season was that Lewis is an offensive-minded coach and it was the defense that led the way. The Aztecs ranked No. 6 in the nation in scoring defense at 15.4 PPG, in the same neighborhood with heavyweights Ohio State, Indiana, Miami and Texas Tech. The Aztecs pitched two shutouts and allowed more than 24 points in only three games. However, only two starters return, after last year's unit returned 10 starters. The top player on that unit was corner Chris Johnson, a first-round pick (27th overall) by the Miami Dolphins. Johnson leaves a huge hole in the secondary, and the Aztecs will need several inexperienced players to grow up in a hurry.

Senior middle linebacker Tano Letuli, senior tackle Gavriel Lightfoot and sophomore cornerback Jamison Starks are expected to spearhead the revamped defense under new coordinator Demetrius Sumler. This defense will take some steps back.

ODDS TO WIN...

600-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****15-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+370****PAC-12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.1	78
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	50
PLAYS PER GAME	64.3	114
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:41	75
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.3%	131
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	349.6	90
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	69
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.1	24
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	198.2	20
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	30
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	21.8	129
COMPLETION %	57.5%	112
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	151.4	126
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7	74
TURNOVERS	1.3	62
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	16.7	7
YARDS PER POINT	18.7	8
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.0%	22
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	311.2	15
YARDS PER PLAY	4.4	7
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	137.1	43
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	39
COMPLETION %	54.6%	7
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	174.1	9
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.3	2
SACKS	2.4	32
TURNOVERS	1.5	39

TEXAS STATE BOBCATS



In three years with the Bobcats, G.J. Kinne has coached the team to records of 8-5, 8-5 and 7-6 and each season concluded with a bowl win. Kinne is a former college and NFL quarterback who's known for creating prolific passing offenses. While the Sun Belt was a relatively soft conference, the move to the Pac-12 is not exactly a massive step up. Texas State is not on Boise State's level yet, but it probably has the talent to hang with every other team in its new league. The Bobcats have an experienced quarterback who will put up big numbers and they have more than enough offensive firepower to find their way to another bowl game.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

Texas State is a 30.5-point underdog at Texas on Sept. 5, when Jackson will go head-to-head with Heisman Trophy contender Arch Manning. Jackson could put up bigger numbers than Manning in that game and for the season. The schedule is not easy and also includes road games against Pac-12 favorites Boise State and San Diego State. The Bobcats figure to be favored in at least six of their seven home games, and they have winnable road dates with Colorado State and Oregon State. With Circa Sports setting the 12-game win total at 6.5, look Over and expect a 7-5 or 8-4 finish. The defense is definitely a concern, but Jackson is a rising star, and the offense will be too hot for most Pac-12 defenses to handle.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-8 ATS, 7-6 O-U
Head Coach: G. J. Kinne - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT TEXAS (+31.9)	66.0
9/12	TX-SAN ANTONIO (+0.3)	41.0
9/19	NORTH TEXAS (-5.6)	34.5
9/26	INCARNATE WORD (-22.6)	17.5
10/3	AT SAN DIEGO ST (+8.3)	43.0
10/15	COLORADO ST (-8)	32.5
10/24	UTAH ST (-4.5)	36.5
10/31	AT BOISE ST (+17.1)	50.5
11/7	AT OREGON ST (-1.8)	32.0
11/14	FRESNO ST (+2)	42.5
11/21	WASHINGTON ST (-2)	38.0
11/28	AT COLORADO ST (-3.4)	32.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **38.48**
#74 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

11

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Brad Jackson the best quarterback in the conference?

The numbers will point to Jackson as the marquee QB in the Pac-12. He completed 71.3% of his passes last season while totaling 3,224 yards and 21 touchdowns with seven interceptions. And there's a lot more. Jackson also ran for 744 yards and 17 touchdowns. He's only a sophomore. The Bobcats ranked 12th in the nation in scoring offense at 36.5 PPG and rolled up 472 yards per game to rank fifth nationally.

Texas State's offense should cause nightmares for defensive coordinators. Not only is Jackson a dual threat, the Bobcats return two of the top receivers in the league — Beau Sparks (84 receptions for 1,200 yards and 10 touchdowns) and Chris Dawn (65 receptions for 1,007 yards). The offensive line is inexperienced, but size matters and the linemen are big, highlighted by 6-foot-6, 375-pound right tackle William Boone, a North Carolina transfer.

Who likes high-scoring games and weak defenses?

The Pac-12 has been known for both throughout the years, so Texas State is a good fit for the conference. The Bobcats could be bad defensively, yet there is hope if a few key players — most notably senior end DonTerry Russell, a former Mississippi State transfer — step up to make an impact. Senior safety Ryan Nolan is among only four starters returning from a defense that allowed 164.8 rushing yards per game and 29 PPG. Look to bet Over the total in most Texas State games this season.

Is the coach a rising star in college football?

Kinne was a big-time passer at Tulsa, finishing his career with 9,472 yards and 81 touchdowns, but his playing career stalled at numerous pro stops. He was signed by the New York Jets as an undrafted free agent in 2012 and landed on NFL practice squads with the Eagles and Giants. He briefly played in the CFL and UFL before becoming a coach and learning under the likes of Gus Malzahn, Sonny Dykes and Chad Morris. In his first head coaching stop at Incarnate Word in 2022, he coached the Cardinals to a 12-2 record and was targeted by Texas State. In an era when innovative offensive coaches are in high demand, Kinne will likely become a hot candidate for bigger jobs in the future. Texas State's high-powered offense this season will help his rise.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****21-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+550****PAC-12**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	36.6	9
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	26
PLAYS PER GAME	73.1	19
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:21	86
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.1%	34
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	478.8	5
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	10
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.8	13
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	223.4	9
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	17
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.2	103
COMPLETION %	70.7%	4
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	255.3	31
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.1	8
TURNOVERS	1.3	62
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.2	104
YARDS PER POINT	12.7	117
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.6%	85
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	396.3	80
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	66
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	168.2	86
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	70
COMPLETION %	66.1%	112
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	228.1	77
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	69
SACKS	2	63
TURNOVERS	0.9	106

UTAH STATE AGGIES



After 11 years and 99 wins at Brigham Young, Bronco Mendenhall decided to take his coaching show on the road. Utah State is his third stop since leaving Provo in 2015, and he has had a losing record since ditching BYU. He went 36-38 in six seasons at Virginia, 5-7 in one year at New Mexico and 6-7 last year with the Aggies. Utah State was close to a much better finish in Mendenhall's first season, losing 29-26 at UNLV and 25-24 to Boise State late in the year. While the Broncos and Rebels played for the Mountain West championship, the Aggies went on to lose the Idaho Potato Bowl. Mendenhall must replace a veteran quarterback, and he has settled on another veteran to lead the team into the Pac-12.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

The call here will be for five wins, but it's a lean and not a bet. The Circa Sports line of 4.5 Over -160 is priced right as the Aggies appear headed for 5-7 or 4-8. The prediction for five is simply giving Mendenhall the benefit of the doubt. Barnes was a big-time playmaker and Hillstead has not played enough for anyone to know if he can handle the quarterback job at a high level. The key to Utah State's win total will be its back-to-back home games against Colorado State and Fresno State in the second half of the season, and if the Aggies split those games, they will likely get to five wins. In the future, Mendenhall would be wise to set up a softer nonconference schedule. Indiana's Curt Cignetti is scheduling cupcakes outside of Big Ten play, for example, while Utah State is lining up Utah and Washington on the road.

2025 Record: 6-7 SU & 10-3 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Bronco Mendenhall - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	IDAHO ST (-16.4)	24.5
9/12	AT WASHINGTON (+24.7)	56.5
9/19	AT UTAH (+22.8)	54.5
9/26	TROY (-3.4)	36.0
10/3	AT BOISE ST (+18.7)	50.5
10/9	WASHINGTON ST (-2.2)	38.0
10/24	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (+4.5)	37.5
10/31	COLORADO ST (-8.2)	32.5
11/7	FRESNO ST (+1.8)	42.5
11/14	AT SAN DIEGO ST (+9.9)	43.0
11/21	AT OREGON ST (-0.20)	32.0
11/28	BOISE ST (+10)	50.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **41.67**
#67 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

12

6

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

How different will the offense look with a new quarterback?

Bryson Barnes was a dual-threat weapon for the Aggies while leading the team in rushing (740 yards and 10 touchdowns) and passing for 2,803 yards and 18 touchdowns. McCae Hillstead, a backup at BYU a year ago, won Utah State's starting job in the spring. Hillstead is a familiar face because he actually started four games for the Aggies in 2023. He's also a running threat. Offensive coordinator Robert Anae is known for aerial attacks, but the ground game will be emphasized more with senior Javen Jacobs returning as the featured back behind Hillstead. The interior line is manned by veterans and appears to be solid. The offense was potent (30.9 PPG) with Barnes running it and the numbers will likely decline a little. Hillstead obviously has big shoes to fill.

Will Bronco build a better defense?

Utah State allowed 28.7 PPG last season — surrendering 55 points in a loss at Vanderbilt and 44 each in losses at Texas A&M and Hawaii. There were positive signs late in the season, however, and one was in Mendenhall's best win, 28-17 at Fresno State. Two of the top three tacklers are returning, including senior safety Brevin Hamblin (114 tackles). The leader of this defense could be well-traveled linebacker Harrison Taggart, who previously played at Oregon, BYU and California. Mendenhall was known for producing strong defenses at BYU, but his reputation on that side of the ball has faded the past few years. The Aggies will be better defensively, but it's tough to say how much better.

Is the road schedule too challenging to overcome?

The Aggies should be 2-2 after four games, assuming they handle home games against Idaho State and Troy. The major problems Mendenhall faces will be away from home because Utah State plays at Washington and Utah in the first month in addition to Pac-12 road games against Boise State, San Diego State and Texas State. Utah State has a 1-15 record against Utah in the Beehive Boot rivalry since 1998. The road schedule stacks the odds against the Aggies returning to a bowl.

ODDS TO WIN...

2000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

100-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

11-1

PAC-12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.5	36
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	31
PLAYS PER GAME	68	70
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:57	128
3RD DOWN CONV. %	28.5%	134
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	391.5	57
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	40
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.3	89
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	148.3	67
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	48
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.3	67
COMPLETION %	59.5%	91
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	243.2	47
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	38
TURNOVERS	0.8	8
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.5	98
YARDS PER POINT	15	56
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.9%	98
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	457.2	130
YARDS PER PLAY	6	109
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	187.6	108
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	117
COMPLETION %	60.2%	43
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	269.6	127
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	65
SACKS	2.1	58
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

WASHINGTON STATE COUGARS



In 2022, a quarterback from Incarnate Word, an FCS program in San Antonio, transferred to Washington State. Cam Ward had put up huge passing numbers in two years at a lower level and proceeded to develop into the real deal in two seasons with the Cougars. He eventually was the first overall pick of the 2025 NFL Draft by the Tennessee Titans. That recent history lesson is relevant because Washington State is now bringing in another FCS quarterback to revive its offense. Caden Pinnick arrives from UC Davis and his play will go a long way in determining how successful new coach Kirby Moore will be in his first season in Pullman.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Back-to-back road games against Washington and Kansas State to open the season will likely leave the Cougars 0-2 before they get a breather against Duquesne. Next up will be home games against Arizona and Fresno State, which could be the Pac-12's second-best team. While it's not impossible to find five potential wins on the schedule, it's highly unlikely. With a new team, new coaching staff and difficult schedule, Washington State is probably headed for 4-8 or worse, and the Circa Sports win total of 4.5 Under +130 is the play. The Cougars will face Oregon State twice, including the 12th flex game in late November, and figure to get a split. The offense has the potential to be entertaining with Pinnick pulling the trigger, but the defense appears to be nowhere near as strong as it was last year and that's a real problem.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 9-4 ATS, 4-9 O-U
Head Coach: Kirby Moore - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	AT WASHINGTON (+22.2)	56.5
9/12	AT KANSAS ST (+16.6)	51.0
9/19	DUQUESNE (-29.9)	12.0
9/26	ARIZONA (+11.6)	52.5
10/3	FRESNO ST (+0.8)	42.5
10/9	AT UTAH ST (+2.2)	36.5
10/17	AT OREGON ST (-2.7)	32.0
10/24	BOISE ST (+9)	50.5
10/31	AT SAN DIEGO ST (+7.4)	43.0
11/14	COLORADO ST (-9.2)	32.5
11/21	AT TEXAS ST UNIV (+2)	37.5
11/28	OREGON ST (-10)	32.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **39.67**
#72 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.4 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

8

OFFENSE

5

DEFENSE

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the Cougars’ new coach bring Moore or less?

As offensive coordinator at Missouri the past three years, Kirby Moore designed dynamic offenses around dual-threat quarterbacks. He is Washington State’s third coach in three years, following Jake Dickert (2024) and Jimmy Rogers (2025). Dickert moved on to Wake Forest, and Rogers took the Iowa State job while also taking several players with him. The Cougars went a combined 15-11 the past two years and still have talent in the program, but Moore had to hit the transfer portal to replenish the roster and found a promising dual-threat quarterback to help the transition. It’s doubtful Washington State will achieve a third straight winning season while rebuilding, so expect less from Moore’s first season.

Is the sky the limit for Caden Pinnick?

At UC Davis, Pinnick was voted Big Sky Freshman of the Year after passing for 3,206 yards and 32 touchdowns while also rushing for 437 yards. The 6-footer completed 70% of his passes and his running ability excites Moore, who outrecruited Colorado to get the quarterback he coveted. Pinnick led UC Davis to nine wins and a spot in the FCS playoffs. The Cougars’ top receiver, senior speedster Tony Freeman, returns along with leading rusher Kirby Vorhees. Freeman had 54 receptions and Vorhees, who transferred from South Dakota State prior to last season, had 576 yards and five touchdowns. The offense brings back a few experienced players, including senior tackle Ashton Tripp, and welcomes Florida transfer receiver Tank Hawkins. The offense will be the obvious strength of the team with Moore designing the plays and Pinnick, Vorhees and Freeman doing a majority of the playmaking.

Will a defense with no returning starters be a disaster?

Blowout losses to North Texas and Washington aside, Washington State was mostly outstanding on defense a year ago while allowing 20.2 PPG to rank 27th in the nation. New coordinator Trent Bray, the former head coach at Oregon State, will need to work miracles to make the Cougars competitive on the defensive side. Senior end Linus Zunk transferred from Vanderbilt and senior corner Jalil Tucker transferred from Oregon as Bray combed the portal to find pieces to the puzzle. Senior linebacker Keith Brown, a former Oregon transfer who missed last season with an arm injury, will be another key player. Bray was a good hire, but this defense has a long way to go, and the Cougars could get into many high-scoring games.

800-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

50-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+800

PAC-12

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.3	89
YARDS PER POINT	15	82
PLAYS PER GAME	67.8	76
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:01	9
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.0%	70
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	350.1	89
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	86
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.8	72
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	139.5	82
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	91
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.3	65
COMPLETION %	63.3%	51
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	210.6	90
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	90
TURNOVERS	1.7	111
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.1	30
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	65
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.0%	21
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	306.3	13
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	28
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	120.1	25
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	34
COMPLETION %	63.9%	89
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	186.2	18
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.7	43
SACKS	2.6	23
TURNOVERS	0.8	121

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SEC Preview

previews by Jonathan Von Tobel

The time at the top of the country has seemingly come to an end for the SEC. It has been three years since a member of the conference won a national championship. The Big Ten has dominated the last three seasons, all with different champions. The conversation all offseason has been about the SEC reclaiming its throne, and there is certainly a strong chance the conference can do just that with its depth of championship contenders.

Georgia — the last SEC team to win it all — looks primed to grab its third title of the Kirby Smart era. The Bulldogs have a Heisman Trophy contender in quarterback Gunner Stockton and one of the most experienced rosters in the country.

Texas has the experience as well, and the blue-chip prospect at quarterback in Arch Manning. Steve Sarkisian has some CFP wins under his belt and is dying to add to that this season. Given the additions the Longhorns made in the portal, as well as the returning production throughout the roster, the market believes this team is a true contender.

Then, you get to some of the dark-horse contenders for both a conference title and national championship.

Alabama and Texas A&M both made the CFP last season, but shared similar fates in being dispatched by the eventual participants in the national championship game. The Crimson Tide will have to work in a new quarterback, but they do have a talented roster with a great defense. So too do the Aggies. The difference between the two is the experience Marcel Reed has at quarterback.

Let's not forget Ole Miss, which finished a drive short of a berth in the final, or Oklahoma, which returns most of the best defense in the country.

The expectations for the SEC are always a national championship. This year is no different, and the conference boasts many potential contenders. The depth of the conference in terms of quality is not on par with the Big Ten, but no one will be shocked if a program from this conference is hoisting a trophy come January.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
GEORGIA	9.5	67.5	1.9	-0.2	48.81 (22)	10.0	2.0	7.1	1.9
TEXAS	9.5	66	3.2	-0.3	53.83 (1)	9.0	3.0	6.6	2.4
ALABAMA	8.5	61	3.7	-0.5	49.59 (14)	8.6	3.4	5.7	3.3
LSU	8.5	60.5	3.5	-0.3	48.72 (23)	8.5	3.5	5.7	3.3
TEXAS A&M	8.5	62.5	2.4	-0.4	49.67 (12)	8.5	3.5	5.6	3.4
OKLAHOMA	7.5	61	3	0.3	52.63 (2)	7.9	4.1	5.5	3.5
OLE MISS	7.5	60.5	3.3	0.1	49.66 (13)	8.0	4.0	5.3	3.7
TENNESSEE	7.5	57	3.9	-0.6	48.36 (26)	7.7	4.3	5.0	4.0
MISSOURI	6.5	54.5	3.3	0.5	47.84 (27)	6.8	5.2	4.2	4.8
SOUTH CAROLINA	6.5	54	2.8	0.7	48.96 (21)	6.6	5.4	4.2	4.8
FLORIDA	7.5	55.5	2.9	-0.4	50.56 (7)	6.6	5.4	4.1	4.9
VANDERBILT	5.5	51.5	2.7	0.5	49.08 (18)	6.4	5.6	3.8	5.2
AUBURN	6.5	52.5	1.7	0.2	48.97 (20)	6.1	5.9	3.5	5.5
MISSISSIPPI ST	4.5	47	2.4	0.1	51.68 (4)	4.3	7.7	2.1	6.9
KENTUCKY	4.5	47	2.4	0.5	51.93 (3)	4.3	7.7	2.0	7.0
ARKANSAS	4.5	45.5	1.6	0.6	51.48 (5)	3.8	8.2	1.7	7.3

ALABAMA

CRIMSON TIDE



After missing out on the College Football Playoff in his first season at the helm, Kalen DeBoer led Alabama to the CFP in 2025. The Crimson Tide were a flawed, one-dimensional offense but managed to dispatch the Sooners before the eventual national champion Hoosiers sent them packing. In Tuscaloosa, that is a disappointing season.

DeBoer must now rebuild the offense after numerous departures, including first-round selection Ty Simpson. Alabama has a young, high-upside quarterback potentially ready to replace him, but can DeBoer meet the lofty expectations set by a rabid fanbase? If everything clicks on offense, this is a Crimson Tide team that has the pieces to bring home its first national title of the DeBoer era.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 8.5
The belief in Alabama rests solely on the shoulders of Russell. Given DeBoer's track record of developing quarterbacks, it's a safe bet that Russell will be what most expect him to be. His athleticism should also help turn around an offense that really struggled to run the ball last year. So too should the investments in the offensive line. Defensively, this unit should be just as productive as it was, with seven starters back.

The Tide have an extremely favorable schedule as well. They avoid Texas and Ole Miss. Alabama must face both Georgia and Texas A&M, but it gets to host both. The toughest road trip in conference will be to LSU in November. Oddly enough, it seems the Crimson Tide, of all programs, is flying under the radar. Bettors should invest early — not only in a win total, but in conference odds and national championship odds.

2025 Record: 11-4 SU & 8-5-2 ATS, 5-10 O-U
Head Coach: Kalen DeBoer - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	EAST CAROLINA (-23.5)	40.5
9/12	AT KENTUCKY (-11.1)	47.0
9/19	FLORIDA ST (-15.1)	50.0
9/26	SOUTH CAROLINA (-10)	54.0
10/3	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (-11.1)	47.0
10/10	GEORGIA (+2.6)	67.5
10/17	AT TENNESSEE (+0.4)	57.0
10/24	TEXAS A&M (-2.6)	62.5
11/7	AT LSU (+3.5)	60.5
11/14	AT VANDERBILT (-6.3)	51.5
11/21	CHATTANOOGA (-51.7)	13.5
11/28	AUBURN (-12)	52.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.59**
#14 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.7 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

3

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who takes over for Ty Simpson at quarterback?

The expectation is that redshirt freshman Keelon Russell will be the starter for Alabama this season, but DeBoer will have a “competition” for the job when fall camp begins. Russell adds an athletic dynamic to the position that Simpson did not, and it is one of many reasons why many expect him to win the job. Russell also fits the RPO offense that DeBoer and offensive coordinator Ryan Grubb want to run. The Tide finished 31st in EPA per play through the air and 21st in success rate when dropping back. Whether it is Russell or senior Austin Mack, both will likely be less efficient than Simpson was a season ago. Bettors can expect more production on the ground from the position, though.

Can Alabama find its rushing attack once again?

There was an immense load on the passing attack’s shoulders last year because Alabama could not run the ball. The Crimson Tide averaged just 3.4 yards per carry and 104 rush yards per game. They finished 132nd in rush success rate (34.5%), placed in the 18th percentile in rush EPA per play and in the sixth percentile in explosive run rate. Leading rusher Jam Miller (520 yards) is gone, and so too are six offensive linemen who started games. Sophomore Michael Carroll — who will start at either right guard or tackle — is the lone returnee. Perhaps that is a good thing for such an anemic rush offense. Either way, finding some semblance of balance with this unit needs to be a priority this season.

Is this team a national championship contender?

If Russell wins the job and is everything most expect, the answer is yes. Many of the questions with the Tide are on the offensive side of the ball. On defense, seven starters are back from one of the better units in college football. The Tide finished 29th in opponent EPA per play and 25th in success rate. In fact, the defense got somewhat unlucky last season, ranking in the 91st percentile in early-down EPA per play but the 51st percentile in late-down success rate. Alabama’s secondary is one of the best in the country, with three starters back and five-star freshman Jorden Edmonds now in the mix. The Tide have what they need on defense. If the offense hits, this team should be able to romp through a manageable schedule and into the College Football Playoff.

ODDS TO WIN...

25-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

+154

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+850

SEC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.6	55
YARDS PER POINT	12.9	21
PLAYS PER GAME	67.3	85
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:05	37
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.9%	63
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	355.6	85
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	81
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.7	122
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	92.6	129
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	127
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.2	23
COMPLETION %	64.9%	34
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	263.1	26
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	50
TURNOVERS	0.8	11
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.6	22
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	42
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.7%	60
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	315.6	18
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	31
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	135	38
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	47
COMPLETION %	62.5%	70
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	180.6	15
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	27
SACKS	2.1	55
TURNOVERS	1.4	57

ARKANSAS RAZORBACKS



After a 2-0 start to the season, the wheels came off for Arkansas. Sam Pittman lost his job in September, the Razorbacks lost the final 10 games of the season, and the program fell into the cellar of the SEC. In order to right the ship, the athletic department brought in Ryan Silverfield from Memphis. Silverfield never won the AAC in his time at Memphis. In fact, he never made it to the conference title game. But he did win 50 games and four bowls. He is the program builder Arkansas needs.

Arkansas has won nine games just once since its last double-digit win season, which was in 2011. Just getting back to bowl season would be a win for Silverfield in his first season, but the challenge is immense with a new roster and a brutal schedule.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

Silverfield has a good offensive background, which should lead to positive development of Jackson at quarterback and decent production from this offense. However, there is a steep mountain to climb for this defense, and the challenge of an SEC schedule will likely do the Razorbacks in.

Arkansas must travel to Utah, Texas A&M and Texas. It hosts Georgia and LSU. There are some spots on this schedule in which the Razorbacks could steal some victories — home games against Tulsa, Missouri and South Carolina are potential wins. So too are road games at Vanderbilt and Auburn. But at best, those are all coin-flip spots that an Over bettor would need to consistently land on the right side of..

2025 Record: 2-10 SU & 4-8 ATS, 8-4 O-U
Head Coach: Ryan Silverfield - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	N ALABAMA (-41.7)	6.0
9/12	AT UTAH (+12.4)	54.5
9/19	GEORGIA (+20.2)	67.5
9/26	TULSA (-15.2)	32.5
10/3	AT TEXAS A&M (+18.8)	62.5
10/10	TENNESSEE (+9.3)	57.0
10/17	AT VANDERBILT (+8.1)	51.5
10/31	MISSOURI (+7.9)	54.5
11/7	AT AUBURN (+8.1)	52.5
11/14	SOUTH CAROLINA (+7.6)	54.0
11/21	AT TEXAS (+23.1)	66.0
11/28	LSU (+13.1)	60.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **51.48**
#5 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.6 / 0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

13

8

5

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What can KJ Jackson provide as the starting quarterback?

Jackson is allegedly in a battle for the starting job with Memphis transfer AJ Hill when fall camp begins, but it is assumed the sophomore will be under center when Arkansas hosts North Alabama in Week 1. Jackson appeared in five games last season but played at length in the final two against Texas and Missouri. In those contests, he went 27-of-46 (58.7%) for 332 yards and two touchdowns. He added 41 rushing yards and a touchdown on the ground. The southpaw showed an ability to be a pocket passer with decent touch in his limited time on the field last season. Bettors should expect him to emerge from camp as the starter, but time will tell if his upside hits.

How does the coaching staff replace all the production at the skill positions?

As is usually the case when a coaching staff gets fired, there was an exodus of production from Fayetteville this offseason. The Razorbacks lost their leading rusher and top three receivers. At running back, Braylen Russell (55 attempts, 291 yards) is the lead returnee. CJ Brown (28 receptions, 319 yards) is the top returning receiver. Sutton Smith followed Silverfield from Memphis, and they nabbed Jasper Parker from Michigan to fill out the running back rotation. Wide receiver Jamari Hawkins (38 receptions, 623 yards) transfers in from Memphis as well. It's unknown how the pecking order will shake out, but Arkansas will be relying on a lot of new faces at the skill positions this season.

How much can this defense improve?

The 2025 season was ugly for this unit. Arkansas gave up 33.8 points per game, 6.3 yards per play and 4.7 yards per carry. The Razorbacks were 134th in adjusted opponent EPA per play and 120th in defensive success rate. There is plenty of hope this group has a better season in it this time around. Defensive end Quincy Rhodes (44 tackles, 8 sacks) elected to return. With him are a litany of transfers, including a nearly rebuilt linebacker group. One of the big wins in the portal was Tulane corner Joker Johnson (42 tackles, 9 pass breakups, 4 interceptions). Rhodes and Johnson are strong cornerstones for this defense. It's likely this group won't be among the best in the country, but it has the pieces to creep back toward average under new defensive coordinator Rob Roberts.

ODDS TO WIN...

400-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****65-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****200-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.2	23
YARDS PER POINT	14.3	60
PLAYS PER GAME	67	87
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:35	107
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.7%	20
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	446	14
YARDS PER PLAY	6.7	5
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.2	92
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	191.7	26
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.8	3
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.4	64
COMPLETION %	59.4%	92
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	254.3	33
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	24
TURNOVERS	1.8	118
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	36.3	130
YARDS PER POINT	12.2	126
3RD DOWN CONV. %	47.5%	129
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	443.2	126
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	124
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	197.3	120
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	107
COMPLETION %	63.9%	90
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	245.9	108
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.7	127
SACKS	1.8	76
TURNOVERS	0.6	129

AUBURN TIGERS



Auburn has hit some dark times. The program has not won a bowl game in over eight years. The last winning season came in 2019, in Gus Malzahn's penultimate season as head coach. The highest place in the AP Poll over the last four seasons came in Week 4 last year at No. 22. A 1-7 SEC campaign — the worst since an 0-8 season in 2012 — seemed to be the lowest point for the program. But it is always darkest before dawn.

The sun rising on the horizon comes in the form of head coach Alex Golesh and transfer quarterback Byrum Brown. The dynamic duo were dominant for South Florida. Now, they come to Auburn with the goal of lifting a once proud program back to prominence.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5
Golesh has everything he needs to hit the ground running in his first season at the helm. He's got one of the best quarterbacks in the country, skill-position talent that has familiarity with the system and a good defense with a strong foundation. There's hardly a better situation for a new coach to be found.

The Tigers do have some stiff tests on the schedule this season. They have to go to Georgia, Ole Miss and Alabama in conference play. But the home schedule is more than manageable, and they avoid both Texas teams this season. Golesh and Brown have already shown an ability to score a big upset. They should be able to handle the winnable opportunities on this schedule and get back to the postseason at the very least. Brown is also a legit threat to contend for the Heisman.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 4-7-1 ATS, 4-8 O-U
Head Coach: Alex Golesh - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	VS. BAYLOR (-5.6)	47.0
9/12	SOUTHERN MISS (-29.3)	25.5
9/19	FLORIDA (+0.9)	55.5
9/26	VANDERBILT (-2.2)	51.5
10/3	AT TENNESSEE (+8.2)	57.0
10/17	AT GEORGIA (+ 16.7)	67.5
10/24	LSU (+6)	60.5
10/31	AT OLE MISS (+ 11.1)	60.5
11/7	ARKANSAS (-8.1)	45.5
11/14	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (-3.3)	47.0
11/21	SAMFORD (-48.8)	5.0
11/28	AT ALABAMA (+ 12)	61.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.97**
#20 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.7 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

5

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can USF win the SEC?

No, that is not a typo. Golesh was hired as head coach this offseason, and to get the ball rolling he decided to essentially bring his entire offense with him. Offensive coordinator Joel Gordon has worked under Golesh the last three years. Brown played for Golesh his entire career, and six wide receiver transfers from South Florida are now in an Auburn uniform. That is all good for continuity, but does the talent level translate to this level of competition? The Tigers must go to Tennessee, Georgia, Ole Miss and Alabama. They host Florida and LSU. Golesh is a great coach, but last season's USF team is essentially taking on an SEC schedule. That could be a disaster in Year 1.

Speaking of Byrum Brown, can he be even better?

Brown was incredible for Golesh and USF last season. The signal-caller completed 65.8% of his passes, amassed 4,238 yards both passing and rushing and totaled 42 touchdowns. He is one of the best quarterbacks in the country, and he already has a win over an SEC program under his belt, as he led the Bulls to a win over Florida in The Swamp. Brown will have a couple of familiar faces to throw the ball to as well. Jeremiah Koger (38 receptions, 597 yards) and Keshawn Singleton (50 receptions, 877 yards) both followed Golesh to Auburn as well. Running back Jeremiah Cobb — one of the few holdovers from the previous regime — should benefit greatly from the offense and the presence of Brown at quarterback. If Brown just matches his production from last season, this could be a dangerous group that can catch teams sleeping in conference.

How much does retaining DJ Durkin at defensive coordinator help?

One of the savvy moves Golesh made was keeping Durkin around on his staff. A lot of things went wrong for Auburn last season, but the defense was consistent and has been under Durkin. Last year, the Tigers allowed just 20.7 points per game and 2.9 yards per carry. For the first two seasons under Durkin, they have allowed fewer than five yards per play. Only four starters are back, but the returning production is huge. Xavier Atkins, the team's leader in tackles, sacks and tackles for loss, is back. Sylvester Smith-Reed and Rayshawn Pleasant return as well after combining for 44 tackles, four pass breakups and two interceptions. There are some positions which need production to emerge, but the returning production and continuity at play-caller could help this team exceed expectations.

80-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+900****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****40-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.5	88
YARDS PER POINT	15.2	87
PLAYS PER GAME	72.9	22
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:02	65
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.4%	87
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	358.2	83
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	110
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.5	36
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	167.7	48
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	55
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.6	76
COMPLETION %	60.2%	82
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	190.5	99
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	116
TURNOVERS	0.7	7
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21	29
YARDS PER POINT	15.6	34
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.4%	24
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	328.4	25
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	24
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	97.9	8
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.9	5
COMPLETION %	62.9%	78
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	230.5	81
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	77
SACKS	2.6	22
TURNOVERS	1.3	66

FLORIDA GATORS



It has been a slow, steady decline for Florida over the last four years. Four of the last five seasons have seen the Gators post a losing record. They have just one bowl win since the Orange Bowl victory over Virginia in 2019, and the program has not appeared in the CFP rankings since 2020.

Enter Jon Sumrall.

Sumrall has known nothing but success as a head coach in college football. He enters his fifth season as a head coach at the FBS level looking for a fifth consecutive berth in a conference title game. Everywhere he goes, winning follows. It's a different beast down south, but the excitement is real in The Swamp, and rightfully so.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

Sumrall is an insane program builder, but the run of conference title game appearances at new programs has to end at some point. He has all the pieces to turn Florida around this season and get them bowling at the very least, but eight or more wins seems like a difficult task.

The Gators will host Ole Miss and Oklahoma, which is obviously beneficial against foes that some believe can contend for the conference title. They go to Auburn and Texas this season, the latter of which will be extremely difficult, though both are losable contests. Florida also gets the short end of the stick in the annual meeting with Georgia, as it will take place in Atlanta due to renovations at EverBank in Jacksonville. That essentially makes it a road game for the Gators. FAU, Campbell and Florida State could all be wins, but outside of the first two there are hardly any high-probability victories on this schedule. Sumrall will have this team playing much better, but it's unlikely eight or more wins is in the cards his first season.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 5-7 O-U

Head Coach: Jon Sumrall - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	FLA ATLANTIC (-25.4)	33.5
9/12	CAMPBELL (-49.1)	9.5
9/19	AT AUBURN (-0.9)	52.5
9/26	OLE MISS (+2.2)	60.5
10/3	AT MISSOURI (+2.7)	54.5
10/10	SOUTH CAROLINA (-3.7)	54.0
10/17	AT TEXAS (+14.1)	66.0
10/31	VS. GEORGIA (+12.2)	67.5
11/7	OKLAHOMA (+2.9)	61.0
11/14	AT KENTUCKY (-5.7)	47.0
11/21	VANDERBILT (-6.4)	51.5
11/27	AT FLORIDA ST (-2.2)	50.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 50.56
#7 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.9 / -0.4
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

13

OFFENSE

7

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will lead the Gators' offense?

The likely answer to this question is Georgia Tech transfer Aaron Philo. Tramell Jones appeared in two games for Florida last year, but he is not Sumrall's guy. Philo was not only brought in by Sumrall, but he also played under offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner at Georgia Tech the last two seasons. Philo — a four-star transfer, according to 247 — has some dual-threat ability to his game, but what the Gators will need most is for him to protect the football, as Florida was -1 in turnover differential. He will also need to turn around an offense which finished 116th in EPA per play through the air. There's nowhere to go but up for this offense after 2025, but signal-caller is a massive question.

Can the defense do its part?

For the past six seasons, Florida's defense has been shockingly average. In 2025 the Gators allowed 24 points per game and 5.7 yards per play. They finished 67th in the country in adjusted opponent EPA per play and 82nd in success rate. A better offense should help this unit by just giving it more time off the field, but it still needs to be better. Six starters from last season are back, and Sumrall brought in defensive coordinator Brad White, who served under Mike Stoops at Kentucky in the same role. The top two tacklers from last season, Myles Graham and Bryce Thornton, as well as the two leaders in sacks, Jayden Woods and Kamran James, return. The pieces are there for improvement.

Does Sumrall's magic translate to the SEC?

Sumrall is the college football version of King Midas. Everything he's touched has turned into gold. He took over a Troy program that went 15-20 in the three previous seasons and went 23-5 while winning the Sun Belt twice. Sumrall then departed for Tulane, led the Green Wave to 20 wins in two seasons and the College Football Playoff. There's no question that he knows how to build a program, but this is a big leap that many have failed in the past. It is unlikely he can get the Gators to the heights of the CFP — Florida has a daunting schedule — but improving on the four-win season Florida posted last season seems likely given Sumrall's success at his previous stops.

ODDS TO WIN...

60-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+400****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****25-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.5	118
YARDS PER POINT	17.9	124
PLAYS PER GAME	63.9	116
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:21	87
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.6%	116
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	331.4	103
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	84
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.5	113
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	131	96
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	76
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.7	74
COMPLETION %	61.2%	73
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	200.4	93
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	97
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.2	70
YARDS PER POINT	15.4	40
3RD DOWN CONV. %	47.1%	128
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	403.8	85
YARDS PER PLAY	5.7	86
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	165.1	82
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	61
COMPLETION %	65.0%	104
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	238.7	98
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.1	115
SACKS	2.3	41
TURNOVERS	1.4	54

GEORGIA BULLDOGS



Since 2017, Georgia has participated in every SEC Championship Game but one, which took place in 2020. The Bulldogs have won the last two and three of the last four. To say an SEC title is the expectation in Athens is an understatement. Georgia has dominated the SEC over the last 10 years. The internal expectation remains the same: Do it again.

The Bulldogs have the horses to get it done for a third consecutive year. Fourteen starters are back from a 12-win team. Gunner Stockton is one of the early expected contenders for the Heisman Trophy, and he has a retooled offensive line in front of him. Kirby Smart has some work to do on a defense that disappointed last season, but his track record tells us he will get that unit right.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 9.5

The pricing on Georgia's win total makes it somewhat difficult to select a best wager. One could lay 180 on the Over 9.5 wins or lay 190 on Under 10.5 wins. Ten wins seems to be the sweet spot for the Bulldogs, but 10 or more should be the likelier outcome.

Georgia does not have to face Texas or Texas A&M this season. Its toughest road trip is to Tuscaloosa, and the team must also go to Ole Miss, the team that ousted them from the CFP a season ago. Five of their conference foes have win totals of 6.5 or less. The non-conference slate of Tennessee State and Western Kentucky lacks a real challenge. Everything is in place for another dominant regular season for Georgia.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 6-8 ATS, 6-8 O-U

Head Coach: Kirby Smart - 11th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TENNESSEE ST (-66.2)	3.0
9/12	W KENTUCKY (-32.7)	36.5
9/19	AT ARKANSAS (-20.2)	45.5
9/26	OKLAHOMA (-8.1)	61.0
10/3	VANDERBILT (-17.4)	51.5
10/10	AT ALABAMA (-2.6)	61.0
10/17	AUBURN (-16.7)	52.5
10/31	VS. FLORIDA (-12.2)	55.5
11/7	AT OLE MISS (-3.5)	60.5
11/14	MISSOURI (-14.4)	54.5
11/21	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (-10.5)	54.0
11/28	GEORGIA TECH (-19.8)	49.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.81**
#22 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1.9 / -0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

14

7*

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Do the Bulldogs have a Heisman contender at quarterback?

Stockton was as clutch as they came last season for Georgia. In the fourth quarter, he completed 83.6% of his passes for 8.5 yards per attempt and totaled nine touchdowns. The Bulldogs also finished in the 79th percentile in late-down success rate despite placing in the 56th percentile in average third-down distance. That was all in large part due to Stockton’s heroics. The redshirt senior has only one of his top five receivers from last season back, but he has a strong offensive line and a great stable of running backs behind him. Georgia is the favorite at one shop and the second choice at another to win the SEC, and they are one of the highest power-rated teams in the country. The team has the 20th-ranked schedule in terms of strength, but that means Stockton has the opportunity to put forth a strong resume for Heisman voters. At 20-1, there are worse bets to be made.

Will the returning production unlock Georgia’s rushing attack?

On paper, the Georgia run game is set up to have a strong season. Three starters are back along the offensive line, one of them being Fourth Team All-American center Drew Bobo. The Bulldogs also return their top three rushers outside of Stockton. Nate Frazier (958 yards, 5.5 yards per carry) should be a 1,000-yard rusher. However, all of this production is back from an inefficient running game last season. Georgia finished 2025 in the 32nd percentile in explosive run rate and the 54th percentile in early-down success rate. Stockton was largely forced to bail the offense out on long third downs, which is not sustainable. The offensive line is projected to have two sophomores and a freshman starting this season, along with Bobo. Perhaps some new blood will allow this running game to find a gear it could not a season ago.

Can the pass defense bounce back?

Georgia ended the season 48th in opponent EPA per play and 80th in EPA per play through the air. That second mark was good for the 40th percentile. While the secondary could be pointed to as the issue, one could make the argument the front seven was the biggest culprit. The Bulldogs totaled just 20 sacks last season, and they regularly struggled to pressure opposing quarterbacks. Smart tried to address the issue by bringing in Auburn transfer Amaris Williams, but he tore his ACL in the spring. A lot of pressure will be on freshman Khamari Brooks to provide a spark for this pass-rush. Georgia should be able to improve on the 20 sacks from last season, but it must be exponentially better if it wants to achieve national success.

+850

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

-240

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+260

SEC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.4	19
YARDS PER POINT	12.4	13
PLAYS PER GAME	71.8	35
TIME OF POSSESSION	33:56	4
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.6%	36
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	401.4	42
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	52
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.2	23
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	182	31
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	49
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.3	88
COMPLETION %	68.2%	11
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	219.4	75
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	49
TURNOVERS	0.8	13
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.5	12
YARDS PER POINT	16.6	22
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.1%	40
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	306	12
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	27
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	84.5	4
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	10
COMPLETION %	60.5%	47
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	221.5	61
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	36
SACKS	1.3	118
TURNOVERS	0.9	105

KENTUCKY WILDCATS



Mark Stoops was the college football equivalent of your favorite pair of jeans: consistent but unremarkable. In 13 seasons, Stoops won 82 games, four bowls and achieved two double-digit win seasons. However, his record had been getting consistently worse, bottoming out last season with a paltry two wins. So, the powers that be ditched the jeans and started rocking some slick chinos.

Thirty-six year old Will Stein comes in from Oregon with a deep offensive background. He is the opposite of Stoops in almost every way. It also seems that Kentucky is reaching into its pockets a bit more and providing Stein with the financial backing needed to make a jump in the SEC.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5
A bet on the Over is a statement of belief in Stein and his offensive prowess. Minchey should thrive learning under him, and Stein brought in a decent amount of talent to supplement the skill positions and give his new QB a good stable of weapons. If Bateman can get this defense to replicate its production from 2025, then the Wildcats have some potential.

The schedule is not overtly daunting for Kentucky. Yes, it gets Texas A&M and Oklahoma on the road. But, it does not face Georgia, Texas or Ole Miss this season. The Wildcats also get to host Alabama, and have plenty of winnable games against mid-tier SEC foes like Vanderbilt, Tennessee, South Carolina and Missouri.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & ATS, 7-5 O-U
Head Coach: Will Stein - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	YOUNGSTOWN ST (-22.1)	27.5
9/12	ALABAMA (+11.1)	61.0
9/19	AT TEXAS A&M (+17.4)	62.5
9/26	S ALABAMA (-19.9)	29.0
10/3	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (+9.3)	54.0
10/10	LSU (+10.8)	60.5
10/17	AT OKLAHOMA (+16.5)	61.0
10/24	VANDERBILT (+2.6)	51.5
11/7	AT TENNESSEE (+13.4)	57.0
11/14	FLORIDA (+5.7)	55.5
11/21	AT MISSOURI (+10.3)	54.5
11/28	LOUISVILLE (+4)	53.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **51.93**
#3 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.4 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

5

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Kenny Minchey be everything he was expected to be?

There was no bigger signal that Kentucky was entering a new era than when it managed to flip Minchey from his commitment to Nebraska in a single day. In the era of NIL, we can guess how the program managed it. The win was huge. Minchey comes in from Notre Dame after competing with CJ Carr for the starting gig, and by all accounts he legitimately pushed Carr in camp. Minchey is a former four-star prospect who completed 20-of-26 passes for 196 yards while rushing for 84 yards and a touchdown in spot duty for the Irish. He joins Stein, who has a long track record of developing quarterbacks in his time at Oregon. Minchey is very talented, but his match with Stein could be the equivalent of peanut butter and jelly: an elite combination.

Speaking of Stein, is he Him?

Stein made headlines when he told the press at SEC media days that he would be the reason why Kentucky succeeds. The confidence was refreshing, and it begs the question, is the first-time head coach ready for the job? Stein is the second-youngest Power Four coach in the country. He's a great offensive mind who spent the last three seasons working under Dan Lanning, and he's had a hand in developing Bo Nix, Dillon Gabriel and Dante Moore. Stein called plays for an offense that finished no lower than 13th in the country in scoring. How does that all translate to being the head coach at Kentucky? Can he continue to develop signal-callers when he has so many other duties now? Will he be able to lead an efficient offense in the SEC with less talent than what he had in Eugene? If his confidence is any indicator, the answer is yes.

What happens to the defense?

Kentucky had always been steady and consistent under Stoops. With him out the door, and an offensive mind in Stein at the helm, what does that mean for this side of the ball? Jay Bateman comes in to run the defense from Texas A&M. A defensive mind from the tree of Mike Elko should be a positive addition. The Wildcats also retained six starters from last season's team, including the team leader in tackles (76) and interceptions (4), Ty Bryant. The defensive line is mostly intact, and it adds six more transfers to a group that had a hand in limiting opponents to 3.7 yards per carry. If Bateman can show some Elko-esque qualities as a play-caller, this group should be able to at least mimic the production from 2025.

ODDS TO WIN...

350-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****30-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****140-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.3	104
YARDS PER POINT	15.5	95
PLAYS PER GAME	69.2	61
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:28	49
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.3%	59
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	329.5	107
YARDS PER PLAY	4.8	117
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.7	59
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	133	90
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	102
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.9	72
COMPLETION %	61.2%	75
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	196.5	94
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	109
TURNOVERS	2	130
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.9	79
YARDS PER POINT	13.8	90
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.1%	74
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	384.5	73
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	71
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	133.7	37
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	25
COMPLETION %	61.8%	62
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	250.7	116
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	119
SACKS	2.2	48
TURNOVERS	1.2	77

LSU TIGERS



Lane Kiffin had a LeBron James-esque winter in 2025 when dragged out the drama of leaving Ole Miss in the midst of a playoff chase in order to take the job at LSU. While Pete Golding has no ill-will for Kiffin, plenty both in and out of Oxford do. Winning silences all of those voices, and Kiffin did his part in the offseason to win early and often in Baton Rouge.

The Tigers brought in the best transfer class in the country, and brought key staff members in from Ole Miss. Kiffin is an elite coach, but success on the biggest stage has eluded him. He's got the resources to get it done at LSU. Now, it's all on him.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

The schedule is going to prove to be a challenge for LSU. While it avoids Georgia, the team gets Alabama, Texas and Texas A&M. All three of those teams make the trip to Death Valley, which is beneficial to the Tigers. LSU must also head to Oxford and face Ole Miss, and it gets Clemson at home to open the season. Conference road trips to Kentucky, Auburn and Tennessee will not be circle wins either.

Perhaps the most talented transfer class is enough to push Kiffin to the top of the SEC, but a challenging schedule and a quarterback coming off a serious foot injury are cause for pause. Eight wins is a good season, and that seems to be the most likely outcome here.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 4-9 ATS, 4-9 O-U

Head Coach: Lane Kiffin - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	CLEMSON (-9.9)	54.0
9/12	LOUISIANA TECH (-31.8)	33.0
9/19	AT OLE MISS (+3.6)	60.5
9/26	TEXAS A&M (-1.9)	62.5
10/3	MCNEESE ST (-53.5)	11.0
10/10	AT KENTUCKY (-10.8)	47.0
10/17	MISSISSIPPI ST (-16.9)	47.0
10/24	AT AUBURN (-6)	52.5
11/7	ALABAMA (-3.5)	61.0
11/14	TEXAS (+1.7)	66.0
11/21	AT TENNESSEE (+0.7)	57.0
11/28	AT ARKANSAS (-13.1)	45.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.72**
#23 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.5 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

14

8

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Sam Leavitt be healthy and effective?

Landing Leavitt in the transfer portal was a win on par with signing Kiffin for LSU. Leavitt — the top-ranked transfer quarterback, according to 247 — burst onto the scene in his time at Arizona State. In 20 games, Leavitt completed 61.3% of his passes, threw 34 touchdowns to nine interceptions and in 2024 led the Sun Devils to the College Football Playoff. However, his season was cut short in 2025 due to a Lisfranc injury, and his recovery from that injury caused him to miss spring practices for LSU. Kiffin told ESPN that he was not concerned about Leavitt's health, but about his transition into the offense. Leavitt has just the fall camp to get reps in with this offense, which could lead to a slow start for the unit this season. Bettors should also monitor how effective Leavitt will be coming off an injury like this.

Does landing the best transfer class of 2026 pay off?

Kiffin hit the portal hard for his first season at Baton Rouge. He brought in 41 commits in the portal alone, the sixth-most in the country. Outside of Leavitt, two other five-star transfers made it to Baton Rouge: defensive end Princewill Umanmielen and offensive tackle Jordan Seaton. In total, Kiffin added 107 starts from the portal, according to Phil Steele. Kiffin is clearly trying to jumpstart his time with LSU, but will the quick-fix work? Some of the position groups are being almost entirely rebuilt. For example, Kiffin brought in nine wide receiver transfers alone. Five other defensive linemen join Umanmielen in the class. The rankings say that the talent level is elite, but others have been burned by trying to build the plane while it is flying. Kiffin might be good enough to finish the build, though.

Will Blake Baker continue to work his magic with this defense?

Kiffin's \$91 million contract was the big headline in the offseason, but do not ignore the more than \$3 million annually that was handed to the defensive coordinator. Baker enters his third season with the program, now under Kiffin. He has been brilliant in his role. When Baker took over, the Tigers were coming off a season in which they had allowed 28 points and 417 yards per game. Last season, LSU allowed only 19.8 points per contest, 3.7 yards per rush and 5.0 yards per play. It finished eighth in adjusted opponent EPA per play. Six starters are back for Baker, and he also gets some elite new toys. Umanmielen totaled 51 pressures and 11 sacks for Ole Miss last year. TJ Dottery — also an Ole Miss transfer — tied for the sixth-most tackles in the SEC last season. Baker has been brilliant since taking up the defensive play-calling, and with some new talent he will likely continue that trend.

ODDS TO WIN...

18-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+160****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+900****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.1	111
YARDS PER POINT	15.8	101
PLAYS PER GAME	63.8	117
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:53	69
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.4%	104
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	317.8	116
YARDS PER PLAY	5	105
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	28.3	132
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	102.1	122
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	106
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.3	43
COMPLETION %	64.0%	42
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	215.8	80
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	101
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.7	24
YARDS PER POINT	16.4	24
3RD DOWN CONV. %	35.9%	39
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	339.4	28
YARDS PER PLAY	5	32
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	126.9	29
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	33
COMPLETION %	60.0%	38
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	212.5	49
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	26
SACKS	1.9	69
TURNOVERS	1.8	21

MISSISSIPPI STATE BULLDOGS



Mississippi State got off to a promising 4-0 SU and ATS start to the season in 2025, but once the Bulldogs made it to SEC play, the wheels came off. Mississippi State ended the season on a 1-7 SU/4-4 ATS slide, losing the last three contests by a combined 61 points.

Head coach Jeff Lebby enters a new era in his tenure at Starkville. Former four-star prospect KaMario Taylor is taking over at quarterback. Eleven starters are back between offense and defense, and Lebby is looking for just his second SEC win as head coach of the program despite entering his third year. It would seem this is a make-or-break season for the offensive minded coach.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

Can Mississippi State win multiple SEC games this season? If it can, then five wins is something that is likely to occur for the Bulldogs. Miss State is a 29.5-point favorite over ULM in Week 1 and should romp Tennessee Tech when they play in November. Can the Bulldogs steal a non-conference road game against Minnesota? Can it beat two of its SEC opponents?

The bet here says Mississippi State can do just that, or some version of it. Taylor truly is an electric threat on the ground. Lebby should be able to craft an offense that leans on that explosiveness at quarterback. The defense needs to be better than the 30.4 points per game it allowed, and Lebby addressed that by bringing back Zach Arnett as defensive coordinator. It's a low bar, but achievable.

2025 Record: 5-8 SU & 8-5 ATS, 7-6 O-U

Head Coach: Jeff Lebby - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	LA MONROE (-28.2)	22.0
9/12	AT MINNESOTA (+5.5)	49.0
9/19	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (+9.7)	54.0
9/26	MISSOURI (+5.6)	54.5
10/3	ALABAMA (+11.1)	61.0
10/17	AT LSU (+16.9)	60.5
10/24	OKLAHOMA (+11.9)	61.0
10/31	AT TEXAS (+22.1)	66.0
11/7	VANDERBILT (+2.6)	51.5
11/14	AUBURN (+3.3)	52.5
11/21	TENNESSEE TECH (-21)	28.0
11/27	AT OLE MISS (+16.7)	60.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **51.68**
#4 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.4 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

11

5

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does the KaMario Taylor era look like?

The hype around Taylor has been building for years. It reached a fever pitch at the end of last year. Taylor had appeared in numerous games last season, but got the start in the last two. Against Ole Miss and Wake Forest, he completed 28-of-53 passes for 419 yards with a touchdown and an interception. He dazzled on the ground, adding 264 yards in the starts and three rushing touchdowns. Taylor is a true dual-threat with an explosive running ability. Blake Shapen could run some, but he was nowhere near the athlete Taylor is. Taylor gives this offense a dynamic it did not have last year, which could unlock a lot more for Lebby's offense.

Can the running game be better this season?

Mississippi State was a largely average rush offense in 2025. It averaged just 3.7 yards per carry and 158 yards per game. With Taylor now taking the reins, bettors should expect this running game to improve, but it's not just on him. Fluff Bothwell is back after rushing for 677 yards on 4.8 yards per carry. He was especially effective at the beginning of the season. Ten of his 17 explosive runs came in the first five weeks, he averaged 5.9 yards per carry and 3.75 yards per carry after contact. With a deadly athlete like Taylor lining up with him, Bothwell could get back to that explosive style and could be a strong bet to become a 1,000-yard rusher for the Bulldogs.

Can Lebby's year-to-year improvement finally translate to the SEC?

The Bulldogs improved from two wins in Lebby's first season to five last year. However, Mississippi State has yet to be anywhere near successful in conference play. Lebby is 1-15 SU in the SEC in his time at the helm. Bettors should know that he is 9-7 ATS in those games, so he is at least beating market expectations. Still, this is about winning football games, and Lebby needs to start doing that in order to keep his job in Starkville. The Bulldogs don't have Georgia or Texas A&M on the schedule, but they do face Alabama, LSU, Oklahoma, Texas and Ole Miss. If Lebby can start winning SEC games, he would score some major upsets in the process.

500-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****35-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****250-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.7	53
YARDS PER POINT	14.1	55
PLAYS PER GAME	77.3	4
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:43	104
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.0%	48
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	389.6	61
YARDS PER PLAY	5	101
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	42.8	13
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	147.3	70
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.4	114
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.9	70
COMPLETION %	62.0%	62
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	242.3	50
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	36
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.8	115
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	106
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.5%	94
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	430.4	113
YARDS PER PLAY	6	111
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	196.6	119
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.1	118
COMPLETION %	60.4%	46
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	233.8	86
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	86
SACKS	1.7	94
TURNOVERS	1.3	71

MISSOURI TIGERS



Missouri has quietly become a consistently good football program under head coach Eliah Drinkwitz. The 2025 season snapped a two-year stretch in which the Tigers won double-digit games consecutively. Drinkwitz has built a foundation; now he has to advance further.

If there was a year and a team, one would be hard-pressed to find a team as ready as the 2026 Mizzou Tigers. The team is experienced on offense, with nine starters back. It boasts an insane attack led by a strong transfer quarterback. The Tigers have averaged 30+ points in two of the last three seasons and won two bowl games. There might be more in store this year.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

It is hard to believe that an offense of this caliber is going to win six or fewer games this season. If Simmons shows the qualities that won him the job over Chambliss at Ole Miss and cuts down on the mistakes, this is one of the offenses in the country. The defense is suspect with only three starters back, but the drop from last season can't be too dramatic.

Mizzou does draw a challenging schedule. It does not face Alabama, but that's about as good as it gets. The Tigers have road trips to Ole Miss and Georgia. They host Texas A&M, Texas and Oklahoma. Still, the schedule has opportunities for wins, and if the offense is as good as it looks on paper, it can steal one or two of the contests against the big boys in the conference.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 6-6-1 ATS, 6-7 O-U

Head Coach: Eli Drinkwitz - 7th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/3	AK-PINE BLUFF (-65.7)	-7.0
9/11	AT KANSAS (-5.8)	46.0
9/19	TROY (-20.8)	36.0
9/26	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (-5.6)	47.0
10/3	FLORIDA (-2.7)	55.5
10/10	TEXAS A&M (+4.3)	62.5
10/17	AT OLE MISS (+8.8)	60.5
10/31	AT ARKANSAS (-7.9)	45.5
11/7	TEXAS (+7.9)	66.0
11/14	AT GEORGIA (+14.4)	67.5
11/21	KENTUCKY (-10.3)	47.0
11/28	OKLAHOMA (+3.5)	61.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **47.84**
#27 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.3 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

12

OFFENSE

9

DEFENSE

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is this the best rush offense in the country?

It sounds hyperbolic, but it might not be an unfair question. First and foremost, Missouri has arguably the best running back tandem in the country. Ahmad Hardy and Jamal Roberts combined to rush for 2,402 yards and 22 touchdowns last season. Hardy (1,649 yards) is one of the best backs in the country. He forced 97 missed tackles and averaged 4.6 yards per carry after contact last year. Despite suffering a gunshot wound in May, he will be ready to roll for fall camp. The duo will line up behind a strong offensive line in 2026. Left tackle Cayden Green is back, and the Tigers have a total of 118 career starts in the room. Like last season, this will be the backbone of this offense.

Could Austin Simmons be the steal of the transfer portal?

Simmons was named the starting quarterback for Ole Miss last season and started the first two games of the year before being injured. By the time he was available again, Trinidad Chambliss had taken the starting gig. Simmons now gets a new life at Missouri. It's rare that a starting-caliber quarterback is available, especially one that didn't necessarily lose the job due to performance. Having said that, Simmons does need to take better care of the football. In 84 dropbacks last season, he threw five interceptions and posted a 5.7% turnover-worthy play rate. He's going to have a strong running game to lean on. If he can cut down on putting the ball in danger, he might be one of the best pickups of any team in the transfer portal.

Can Eliah Drinkwitz take the next step as a head coach?

It took three seasons, but Drinkwitz has finally transformed Mizzou into a winning football program. Over the last three seasons, the Tigers are 29-10 SU overall and 15-9 SU in the SEC; 25-14 ATS in totality over that span. But what it doesn't have is an appearance in the SEC Championship or the College Football Playoff. It's a difficult season to achieve that goal. Texas and Georgia are primed to get to Atlanta, and there are strong contenders on the fringes like Alabama, Ole Miss and Texas A&M. Not many of them have the potential on offense that a team like Missouri has, though. Perhaps this is the season Drinkwitz gets through the ceiling.

90-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+700****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****35-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.7	53
YARDS PER POINT	14.6	71
PLAYS PER GAME	73.1	19
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:00	20
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.7%	35
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	404.3	38
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	60
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	43.3	10
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	229.1	8
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.3	14
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.5	106
COMPLETION %	61.5%	68
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	175.3	114
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	108
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20	19
YARDS PER POINT	14.1	80
3RD DOWN CONV. %	36.8%	44
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	281.6	7
YARDS PER PLAY	4.4	8
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	99.8	10
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.2	13
COMPLETION %	56.7%	17
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	181.8	17
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.1	12
SACKS	2.9	10
TURNOVERS	0.8	112

OKLAHOMA SOONERS



Brent Venables' time in Norman has been consistently inconsistent. The Sooners have two 10-win seasons under Venables' watch, and they have two 6-7 seasons as well. Oklahoma will look for consistency in 2026, coming off a year in which they made the College Football Playoff for the fifth time.

Everything lies on the shoulders of John Mateer and this offense. Mateer's season was derailed with injury. This season, he's looking to regain some of the magic he had two seasons ago in Pullman and lead the Sooners to their first CFP win in program history.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

If the defense is anywhere close to what it was a season ago — which it looks like it will be — Oklahoma's win total floor is extremely high. Can the offense pull its weight? Mateer showed up to the Manning Passing Academy looking bulkier, but told the media he didn't gain weight, but rather got in better shape. Either way, he needs to be better in both facets of his game if this team is to get back to the College Football Playoff.

The schedule provides challenges, like any SEC slate does, but that extends into the non-conference portion as well. The Sooners have road games against Michigan and Georgia. They must host Ole Miss and Texas A&M while also having the usual dalliance with Texas in October. Oklahoma will have to take one, if not two, of those contests to get Over this number, but the team is good enough to do that and more.

2025 Record: 10-3 SU & 7-6 ATS, 3-10 O-U

Head Coach: Brent Venables - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	UTEP (-41.7)	22.5
9/12	AT MICHIGAN (+0.4)	59.0
9/19	NEW MEXICO (-22.2)	42.0
9/26	AT GEORGIA (+8.1)	67.5
10/10	VS. TEXAS (+4.4)	66.0
10/17	KENTUCKY (-16.5)	47.0
10/24	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (-11.9)	47.0
10/31	SOUTH CAROLINA (-9.3)	54.0
11/7	AT FLORIDA (-2.9)	55.5
11/14	OLE MISS (-3.4)	60.5
11/21	TEXAS A&M (-1.9)	62.5
11/28	AT MISSOURI (-3.5)	54.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **52.63**
#2 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3 / 0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

16

9*

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is a healthy John Mateer going to be better?

There is a clear line of demarcation for Mateer's 2025 season. Through the first four games of the season, Mateer completed 67.6% of his passes, averaged 8.5 yards per attempt and had thrown six touchdowns to three interceptions on an average depth of target 8.5 yards downfield. Then, he broke his throwing hand in the win over Auburn. In the following eight games, Mateer completed only 58.8% of his passes, averaged 6.4 yards per attempt and threw eight touchdowns to eight interceptions. Which Mateer shows up in 2026? It would be short-sighted to dismiss the injury to his throwing hand and subsequent decline in play. However, Mateer could have been a better decision-maker. His 16 turnover-worthy plays over those eight games were third-most among SEC quarterbacks. Mateer needs to be healthy, but he needs to be better with the football too.

Can the Sooners run the football?

Mateer was also nowhere near the runner he was in his final season at Washington State. In 2024, he ran for 1,008 yards and 15 touchdowns while averaging 6.8 yards per attempt. Last year, he managed just 565 yards on only 15 fewer attempts. But his struggles on the ground were hardly the only ones. Oklahoma as a whole averaged only 3.5 yards per carry for the season. Tory Blaylock led the team with 480 yards on 120 attempts. The Sooners ended the year 127th in EPA per play rushing and 128th in success rate. Offensive coordinator Ben Arbuckle — Mateer's offensive coordinator at Washington State — has to find a way to get his quarterback and this running attack back to being effective. A couple of new offensive linemen will help, but better play-calling will too.

Will the Sooners be as dominant on defense as they were last year?

The short answer is probably. Seven starters are back for Oklahoma on defense. The Sooners' top two tacklers — Kip Lewis and Owen Heinecke — are among them. Defensive lineman Taylor Wein (7 sacks, 8 tackles for loss) and defensive tackle David Stone lead a defensive line which had a hand in limiting opponents to 2.4 yards per carry last year. In all, Oklahoma allowed just 15.5 points per game and 4.3 yards per play in 2025. The defensive line is experienced, the linebackers remain in good shape with the presence of Heinecke at middle linebacker and the secondary is largely intact. The Sooners were the third-most efficient defense by EPA standards last season and led the country in success rate. With all of the returning production, Venables will have one of the best units in the country again.

ODDS TO WIN...

35-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+210****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****13-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.5	73
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	40
PLAYS PER GAME	68.8	62
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:28	83
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.5%	73
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	342.6	94
YARDS PER PLAY	5	107
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33.6	85
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	119.8	104
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.6	109
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.8	46
COMPLETION %	59.6%	87
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	222.8	66
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	87
TURNOVERS	1.2	46
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	16.5	6
YARDS PER POINT	17.1	15
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.2%	4
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	282.7	8
YARDS PER PLAY	4.1	4
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	74	2
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.2	2
COMPLETION %	59.4%	34
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	208.7	41
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	25
SACKS	3.7	1
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

OLE MISS REBELS



Narratively, Ole Miss might be the best team to follow in the SEC this season. The Rebels went on a magical run to the College Football Playoff semifinals, and led Miami with three minutes remaining before folding. But now that the excitement of that run has worn off, it's time to deal with reality.

Pete Golding is a first-time head coach in charge of maintaining what he achieved in the interim last season. Golding had to replace his offensive staff, retool the skill positions and now has a full offseason as the man. He's got the quarterback, but does he have the ability to be a successful head coach? Or did he benefit from taking Lane Kiffin's team on a run?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

Ole Miss is an experienced group. The Rebels return 16 starters from a team that was just one drive away from making it to the national championship game. But those that don't return will have a major impact. The architects of one of the better offenses in the country. Key pieces both on the offensive and defensive lines. All of those absences will likely be felt. Then there's the challenge of the schedule.

The Rebels have road trips to Florida, Texas and Oklahoma. They must also host LSU in an emotionally charged contest in Week 3, as well as Missouri and Georgia. The season even opens with a challenge against a good Louisville squad in Nashville. Honestly, there is some doubt in Golding as the head ball coach. That, coupled with a taxing schedule, could mean a disappointing season in Oxford.

2025 Record: 13-2 SU & 9-6 ATS, 8-7 O-U

Head Coach: Pete Golding - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/6	VS. LOUISVILLE (-7.2)	53.5
9/12	CHARLOTTE (-42.8)	20.5
9/19	LSU (-3.6)	60.5
9/26	AT FLORIDA (-2.2)	55.5
10/10	AT VANDERBILT (-6.4)	51.5
10/17	MISSOURI (-8.8)	54.5
10/24	AT TEXAS (+8.6)	66.0
10/31	AUBURN (-11.1)	52.5
11/7	GEORGIA (+3.5)	67.5
11/14	AT OKLAHOMA (+3.4)	61.0
11/21	WOFFORD (-46.8)	16.5
11/27	MISSISSIPPI ST (-16.7)	47.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.66**
#13 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.3 / 0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

16

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

9

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What can Trinidad Chambliss do for an encore?

Chambliss did not get the starting job until an injury to Austin Simmons, but when he got on the field he did not look back. Chambliss ended up as the third-highest graded passer by PFF in the SEC. For the season, he completed 65.6% of his passes, averaged 8.8 yards per attempt and threw 22 touchdowns to just three interceptions. The stark contrast between him and Simmons' limited time as the starter was protecting the football. Chambliss' 2.5% turnover-worthy play rate was the third-best among SEC starters. Now, he enters 2026 as the unquestioned starter and a Heisman candidate. Can he replicate the success he had last season with so much change around so much change in the receiver room?

How much will the offense differ after an offseason of change?

Kiffin left before the CFP run for Ole Miss, but the staff members he chose to take stuck around for the postseason last year. Then offensive coordinator Charlie Weis Jr. was massive in helping lead the Rebels' offense, but he is officially out the door and on to Baton Rouge. In comes John David Baker — the offensive coordinator at East Carolina in 2025 — to replace Weis, and to some extent, Kiffin. Having a new play-caller means new terminology, and an unknown when it comes to play structure and flow. Chambliss will also have a whole new group of receivers this season. Either through the draft, transfer portal or other means, the top four receivers from last year are gone. Kewan Lacy is a massive piece in the backfield, but the other changes could possibly lead to a huge shift in this unit's efficiency.

Can Pete Golding prove that he can do it on his own?

It all boils down to this. Golding had Weis to call plays for the offense in the postseason last year. He is gone. Golding had to find a new offensive coordinator, help rebuild position groups like wide receiver and is now in charge of all facets of the program. There is no denying the success Ole Miss had under Golding when he stepped in last season, but this is now extremely different. Golding has never been a head coach before, and must now guide a program with national championship aspirations through a massive season in a brutal conference. He is a defensive mind, but his decision at offensive coordinator will loom over the season, especially if the Rebels' offense struggles out of the gates.

ODDS TO WIN...

30-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+220****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****11-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	36.1	11
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	37
PLAYS PER GAME	73.4	13
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:47	102
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.1%	39
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	482.3	3
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	8
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	38.3	37
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	178.9	34
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	37
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	37
COMPLETION %	63.5%	46
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	303.4	4
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	9
TURNOVERS	0.9	21
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.6	41
YARDS PER POINT	16.2	29
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.0%	55
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	365.6	53
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	45
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	154.1	71
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	73
COMPLETION %	57.1%	20
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	211.5	47
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	33
SACKS	2.2	47
TURNOVERS	1.1	97

SOUTH CAROLINA GAMECOCKS



Intriguing is the word that most closely associates with the South Carolina football program. The Gamecocks have a talented quarterback in LaNorris Sellers. They have a football coach who has shown the ability to get the most out of a roster. But can it all come together in 2026?

Shane Beamer has nine starters back on offense and a new offensive play-caller. The defense needs to be rebuilt to an extent, but that group has been consistent under Beamer. The sixth-year coach has expectations due to his success here, but whether he can meet those with this roster is a big question in a brutal conference.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 6.5

Six wins still gets South Carolina to a bowl game this season, and that seems to be one of the best outcomes for the program this year. The schedule is a bear for the Gamecocks. Road games against Alabama, Florida, Oklahoma and Clemson will be extremely challenging. They host Texas A&M — which will be coming off a bye week — and Georgia. It leaves little margin of error for the team.

What if the regression of Sellers is legitimate? What if Briles cannot help him reclaim the magic from two years ago? Even if he can, how does this offense truly stack up against a slate of opposing defenses which will rank among the best in the country, let alone the SEC? At least a six-win season is an improvement for South Carolina.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 6-6 ATS, 5-7 O-U
Head Coach: Shane Beamer - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	KENT ST (-33.9)	23.5
9/12	TOWSON (-39.4)	16.5
9/19	MISSISSIPPI ST (-9.7)	47.0
9/26	AT ALABAMA (+10)	61.0
10/3	KENTUCKY (-9.3)	47.0
10/10	AT FLORIDA (+3.7)	55.5
10/24	TENNESSEE (-0.4)	57.0
10/31	AT OKLAHOMA (+9.3)	61.0
11/7	TEXAS A&M (+5.3)	62.5
11/14	AT ARKANSAS (-7.6)	45.5
11/21	GEORGIA (+10.5)	67.5
11/28	AT CLEMSON (+1)	54.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.96**
#21 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.8 / 0.7**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

14

OFFENSE

9*

DEFENSE

5

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is LaNorris Sellers going to revert back to form as a passer?

Sellers was one of the reasons this offense declined in 2025. He went from completing 64.8% of his passes in 2024 to a 59.8% completion percentage. Sellers threw five fewer touchdown passes on just five fewer attempts. Shockingly, his play from a clean pocket declined as well. On the dropbacks in which he was kept clean, Sellers completed only 67.3% of attempts for 9.3 yards per attempt, eight touchdowns and five interceptions. The season prior, his stat line was 71.0% completion, 8.7 yards per attempt, 14 touchdowns and two interceptions. The decline from Sellers as a passer was stark. He must return to 2024 form if he's to make good on the hype.

What does the addition of Kendal Briles do for this offense?

Sellers' decline not only derailed the season for South Carolina, but it also cost Mike Shula his job as offensive coordinator just nine games into the year. In the offseason, Beamer brought in Kendal Briles to fill the void. Briles has a long track record of good offense under his watch, and he has experience in maximizing signal-callers. How he uses Sellers is going to be fascinating. One facet of the quarterback's game that fell off in 2025 was running the football. He had just 49 designed rush attempts compared to 79 in 2024. But he averaged 4.64 yards per carry after contact, generated 25 runs of 10 or more yards and averaged 5.3 yards per attempt overall, all of which were on par with his previous season. Briles has to fix Sellers as a passer, but he must also utilize his skill set much more efficiently.

How sturdy is the ground on which Shane Beamer walks?

Beamer signed a contract extension of January 2025 after a nine-win season for South Carolina. However, the Gamecocks followed that up with a 4-8 campaign, the second losing season in three years for Beamer. The program has not won a bowl game since his first season as head coach, and an extremely talented quarterback in Sellers has seemingly regressed under his watch. It might sound foolish to sound the alarm on a coach just barely into a contract extension which locks him in through 2030, but crazier things have happened. If South Carolina struggles again, will Beamer's seat heat to the point that the Gamecocks become a rudderless ship by season's end?

120-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****11-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****50-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	21.3	104
YARDS PER POINT	16.2	105
PLAYS PER GAME	67.1	86
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:14	118
3RD DOWN CONV. %	32.4%	119
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	343.9	93
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	92
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.1	80
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	111	116
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.3	126
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.3	89
COMPLETION %	61.2%	74
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	232.9	60
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8	32
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.2	45
YARDS PER POINT	15.6	37
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.9%	68
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	360.5	48
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	44
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	143.5	53
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	48
COMPLETION %	60.0%	39
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	217.1	55
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.9	52
SACKS	1.5	104
TURNOVERS	1.9	13

TENNESSEE VOLUNTEERS



Two years ago, Josh Heupel and the Volunteers were mercilessly bounced by Ohio State in the College Football Playoff. It was clear Tennessee needed to build to get to the level of national contention, but it was a high point in Heupel's tenure. The program has not experienced any true lows in the Heupel era, and this year is shaping up to be a perfectly adequate season once again.

Tennessee will be one of the better offenses in the SEC, and the country, once again. The question of who will start at quarterback lingers, but this system is extremely user-friendly. Could the Vols surprise some folks and find themselves in the mix for a spot in the SEC title game? Unlikely, but if the true freshman quarterback hits, this could be a sneaky team with higher upside than most expect.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

Heupel has been remarkably consistent in his time as head coach of Tennessee. He's won at least eight games in four straight years, and the lone season he failed to reach that mark, the Volunteers still went 7-5 in the regular season. The offensive talent this season is immense, so even with the questions at quarterback there seems to be a firm floor.

Tennessee gets some high-probability wins on the schedule in the shape of Furman, Kennesaw State and Arkansas. They get to go to a rebuilding Vanderbilt team in conference play as well. The Vols will need to get some coinflips — at Georgia Tech, home dates against Auburn and Kentucky — to go their way, but they are more than capable. It will be a sweat, but eight wins is in the cards again for Tennessee.

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & 5-8 ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Josh Heupel - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	FURMAN (-48.2)	12.5
9/12	AT GEORGIA TECH (-5)	49.0
9/19	KENNESAW ST (-30)	31.5
9/26	TEXAS (+4.8)	66.0
10/3	AUBURN (-8.2)	52.5
10/10	AT ARKANSAS (-9.3)	45.5
10/17	ALABAMA (-0.4)	61.0
10/24	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (+0.4)	54.0
11/7	KENTUCKY (-13.4)	47.0
11/14	AT TEXAS A&M (+8.5)	62.5
11/21	LSU (-0.7)	60.5
11/28	AT VANDERBILT (-2.2)	51.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **48.36**
#26 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

14

7

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Do the Volunteers finally have a long-term answer at quarterback?

Heupel has had a new starting quarterback Week 1 of each season in his time at Knoxville. This season will be no different, but the hope is that it will be the first of many seasons for quarterback Faizon Brandon. The true freshman was a five-star prospect and third-best member of the 2026 class. In high school, Brandon took care of the football, throwing an interception once in every 98 attempts. It should be noted that Heupel swears up and down that Brandon is locked in a battle with redshirt freshman George McIntyre for the job. But every expectation is that Brandon will be the full-time starter once Tennessee emerges from the game against Fuman in Week 1 — in which both will more than likely see time. A true freshman will likely have some growing pains, but this is about the future of the program.

Can the offense continue its scoring run?

Since Heupel took the job, Tennessee has averaged at least 31.8 points per game in every season. The musical chairs at quarterback each season has not stalled an offensive system that seems to come with a high floor. A true freshman starting at quarterback threatens to derail that streak, but the pieces on offense might be too good for that to happen. Whoever wins the job will line up behind an offensive line that lost just one starter and will be in contention for the Joe Moore Award. Outside of leading receiver Chris Brazzell, three of the top four receivers from last season are back. So too is leading rusher DeSean Bishop. Heupel is an elite play-caller, and he's got a deep cupboard of talent. This team is more than capable of surpassing 30+ points per game again.

What becomes of the defense?

The defense took some big hits in the offseason. Tennessee's defensive line must be completely rebuilt after all four starters and three rotation linemen departed in some form or fashion. In the secondary, the Volunteers lost a pair of starters, one of which was an NFL draft selection. Linebacker is a position of strength on paper, with the return of leading tacklers Edwin Spillman and Arion Carter. Plus, they added Amare Campbell from Penn State, the Nittany Lions' leading tackler in 2025. Jim Knowles was hired as well to lead this unit, so it does have an elite play-caller at the controls. But this is a team with some big questions up front and behind.

ODDS TO WIN...

70-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+450****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****20-1****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	37.1	8
YARDS PER POINT	12	6
PLAYS PER GAME	70.9	44
TIME OF POSSESSION	26:29	130
3RD DOWN CONV. %	48.3%	11
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	445.8	15
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	20
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.3	44
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	166.8	51
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	46
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.1	54
COMPLETION %	66.0%	24
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	279.1	13
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.7	12
TURNOVERS	1.3	62
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	29.8	92
YARDS PER POINT	13.8	88
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.2%	99
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	412.3	100
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	62
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	160.6	76
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	57
COMPLETION %	66.3%	117
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	251.7	118
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	78
SACKS	2.9	10
TURNOVERS	1.7	27

TEXAS LONGHORNS



The hope for Texas this season is that Steve Sarkisian does not have to embark on another campaign in hopes of getting his team into the College Football Playoff. Instead, the Longhorns are hoping to earn a seat at the table the old-fashioned way: by winning football games.

Texas brings back one of the most experienced rosters in the country. Sixteen starters are back from last season, including quarterback Arch Manning. The team's biggest weakness — offensive line — has been addressed. Two seasons ago, Sarkisian took Quinn Ewers to the CFP and won two games. It would be shocking if he cannot get this Texas team to the dance in 2026.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 9.5

Phil Steele ranks Texas' schedule as the hardest in the country, and there is obviously some truth to that. The Longhorns must face Ohio State in Week 2, Oklahoma on a neutral site and it must go to both LSU and Texas A&M. However, the devil is in the details for the Longhorns.

Texas leaves the state just once from the beginning of the season until November, when it goes to face Tennessee. The meeting with the Buckeyes is a revenge spot in Austin. The yearly meeting with Oklahoma is in Dallas. Sure, the three-week stretch of Oklahoma, Florida and Ole Miss is difficult, but the Longhorns have a bye prior to the Red River Shootout, and the other two will be at home. If this is a true national title contender, 10 wins should be an attainable goal. So too should a national championship.

2025 Record: 10-3 SU & 5-8 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Steve Sarkisian - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	TEXAS ST UNIV (-31.9)	37.5
9/12	OHIO ST (+2)	71.0
9/19	TX-SAN ANTONIO (-28.7)	41.0
9/26	AT TENNESSEE (-4.8)	57.0
10/10	VS. OKLAHOMA (-4.4)	61.0
10/17	FLORIDA (-14.1)	55.5
10/24	OLE MISS (-8.6)	60.5
10/31	MISSISSIPPI ST (-22.1)	47.0
11/7	AT MISSOURI (-7.9)	54.5
11/14	AT LSU (-1.7)	60.5
11/21	ARKANSAS (-23.1)	45.5
11/27	AT TEXAS A&M (-0.8)	62.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **53.83**
#1 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.2 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

16

OFFENSE

9*

DEFENSE

7

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Does Arch Manning pick up where he left off?

There were many who were disappointed by the season Manning put together, but over the last six games he looked every bit of the blue-chip prospect he was lauded to be. In those contests, Manning threw 14 touchdowns with a turnover-worthy play rate of just 1.2%. He averaged 7.8 yards per attempt and added another five touchdowns on the ground. Texas went 5-1 SU/3-2-1 ATS in those games. For the season, Manning was the eighth-best passer in the conference by PFF standards and barely completed 60% of his passes. But if he can pick up on the form he had by season's end, this offense could be more explosive.

Will the offensive line improve in both facets?

In part, Manning struggled due to the pressure he faced. Manning was pressured on 35.6% of his dropbacks last season. His 165 dropbacks under pressure were the most in the SEC. In the running game, the issues were clear. Texas averaged 4.2 yards per carry and 138 yards per game in 2025. In order to fix the issues, Sarkisian helped his group by hitting the portal, bringing in a few bodies, but right tackle Melvin Siani from Wake Forest was the crown jewel. Couple that with the return of left tackle Trevor Goosby and center Connor Robertson, and this unit should be able to provide better protection for Manning while also giving more push in the run game.

Can the secondary be a bigger strength?

During SEC media days, the Longhorns got a big win when five-star cornerback — and ESPN's top-ranked 2027 corner — John Meredith III reclassified into the 2026 cycle in order to enroll for the fall. It's unknown what role he will play, but a talent like that is never a negative, especially for a unit looking for more. Texas was 66th in defensive success rate against the pass last season and 33rd in opponent EPA per play through the air. Jelani McDonald (80 tackles, 3 pass breakups, 3 interceptions) is back at safety, but the defensive backfield lost three starters. Will Muschamp was also hired to run this defense in the offseason. There should be some improvement with this group overall.

ODDS TO WIN...

+700**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****-200****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+310****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.5	27
YARDS PER POINT	12.8	19
PLAYS PER GAME	66.8	92
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:29	111
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.2%	69
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	388.5	64
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	33
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.8	96
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	137.8	84
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	72
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	32.3	52
COMPLETION %	61.4%	70
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	250.7	41
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	39
TURNOVERS	0.7	6
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	20.3	20
YARDS PER POINT	16.7	20
3RD DOWN CONV. %	33.0%	17
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	338.8	27
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	19
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	103.9	13
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.1	12
COMPLETION %	62.6%	71
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	234.9	89
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	31
SACKS	3	6
TURNOVERS	1.8	19

TEXAS A&M AGGIES



Mike Elko has done a tremendous job as a head coach at both Duke and Texas A&M. At College Station, he's improved the Aggies' record each year. This season, he has the 13th-most experienced roster in the country. The retention of talent is huge, but so too is the task at hand.

The Aggies have an extremely difficult schedule. They are breaking in a new offensive play-caller. Elko must manage all of that while trying to get Texas A&M to its first SEC championship, and perhaps, its first national title in the modern era.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5
Potential is one thing, but reality is another. The reality is that Reed has not shown true progress in his areas of weakness. The defense is a good unit, but in comparison with some of its contemporaries in the SEC is not one of the elite defenses in the country. That isn't to say the sum of those parts is a terrible team. The Aggies can be very good, but it will be a challenge to win nine or more games.

Texas A&M has three extremely high-probability wins against Missouri State, Arkansas and the Citadel. After that, they will likely be favored against Arizona State, Kentucky and even South Carolina, the latter of which is on the road, making it more of a challenge than it initially looks. The Aggies will then have to deal with LSU, Missouri, Alabama, Oklahoma and Texas. Of those, they get to host just the Longhorns. It's a brutal schedule for a team looking to build on an 11-win season and berth in the CFP.

2025 Record: 11-2 SU & 5-8 ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Mike Elko - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MISSOURI ST (-39.8)	25.0
9/12	ARIZONA ST (-14.9)	49.5
9/19	KENTUCKY (-17.4)	47.0
9/26	AT LSU (+1.9)	60.5
10/3	ARKANSAS (-18.8)	45.5
10/10	AT MISSOURI (-4.3)	54.5
10/17	THE CITADEL (-52.2)	12.5
10/24	AT ALABAMA (+2.6)	61.0
11/7	AT SOUTH CAROLINA (-5.3)	54.0
11/14	TENNESSEE (-8.5)	57.0
11/21	AT OKLAHOMA (+1.9)	61.0
11/27	TEXAS (+0.8)	66.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.67**
#12 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.4 / -0.4**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

18

10*

8

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Marcel Reed improve enough as a passer?

In 2025, Reed completed 61.6% of his passes, averaged 8.3 yards per attempt and threw 25 touchdowns to 12 interceptions. Those are all solid numbers, but if Texas A&M is going to move forward he has to improve. Reed ranked 12th among SEC passers in PFF passing grade in 2025. He posted the third-highest turnover-worthy play rate (4.7%) and led the conference in total turnover-worthy plays (22). On throws of 10-19 yards downfield, between the numbers, he completed just 50.8% of passes and threw six touchdowns to five interceptions. He committed nine of his 22 turnover-worthy plays on such attempts. Reed has a new play-caller in Holmon Wiggins this season. Will the change help his development, or will it be more of the same?

Can the defense move into the elite stratosphere?

Elko is known as a defensive mastermind, and almost every one of his teams — either as a coordinator or head coach — have been well above average defensively. This season, Elko has eight starters back, so can they become elite? Texas A&M only allowed 21.0 points per game, 4.2 yards per carry and 5.1 yards per play. Those are all marks placing them inside the top 25 of the country statistically, but what will it take to get the Aggies into the top 10? The defensive line lost three players to the NFL, which is obviously a massive blow. Still, there is talent here. Their leading tackler departed, but Elko added First Team All-AAC linebacker Ray Coney. The secondary remains largely intact as well. Elko always maximizes his defensive talent, but he will have to do more than that to get this defense to a national championship level.

Are we sleeping on Texas A&M's place in the conference and the country?

All of this begs the question, where does Texas A&M truly stack up in both the SEC and national picture? The Aggies are tied with Alabama at DraftKings in odds to win the SEC (+850). They are 20-1 to win the National Championship, behind eight other teams, three of which are in the SEC. Reed is a good quarterback, but has limitations as a passer. The defense is good but not elite, and it needs to retool a defensive line which lost some talent. But what if Reed takes that step forward as a passer? What if Elko turns the corner with this defense and it joins the table of the elite units in college football? In a season that looks to be loaded with parity, maybe the market is sleeping on what Texas A&M can become.

ODDS TO WIN...

20-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****+154****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+850****SEC**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.6	18
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	44
PLAYS PER GAME	70	55
TIME OF POSSESSION	32:27	12
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.3%	60
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	442.2	18
YARDS PER PLAY	6.3	19
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	37.6	42
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	179.7	32
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	33
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.9	70
COMPLETION %	61.5%	69
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	262.5	27
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.5	14
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.8	42
YARDS PER POINT	14.4	72
3RD DOWN CONV. %	24.7%	1
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	327.5	24
YARDS PER PLAY	5	35
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140	44
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	80
COMPLETION %	56.9%	18
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	187.5	19
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	13
SACKS	3.5	2
TURNOVERS	0.8	112

VANDERBILT COMMODORES



Clark Lea has done what he went to his alma mater to do. Vanderbilt is a quality football program under his watch. The Commodores have won 17 games over the last two seasons, and it won its first bowl game since 2013. Lea must now prove he can do it without a superstar quarterback.

The Commodores are staring a regular season with a true freshman starting quarterback in the face. Lea must rebuild the offensive line and navigate a schedule with both opportunity and potential misfortune. He's done a great job, but decline — even if for just a season — is on the horizon.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

This could be an overly pessimistic view on the 2026 Vanderbilt Commodores, but there are just too many potential issues to overlook. A true freshman starting quarterback behind a completely rebuilt offensive line. A secondary which could be one of the worst in the country yet again. Beyond the front seven, which unit do you truly trust for Vanderbilt heading into the regular season?

The schedule opens with opportunities to stack wins against Austin Peay and Delaware, but it immediately steps up when Vandy hosts N.C. State on Sep. 19. They have road games in conference at Auburn, Georgia and Florida. They host Ole Miss, Alabama and Tennessee. Laying a price to get to six wins does not seem like a prudent play for Vanderbilt bettors.

2025 Record: 10-3 SU & ATS, 9-4 O-U
Head Coach: Clark Lea - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AUSTIN PEAY (-26.7)	27.5
9/12	DELAWARE (-23.3)	31.0
9/19	NC STATE (-6.6)	48.0
9/26	AT AUBURN (+2.2)	52.5
10/3	AT GEORGIA (+17.4)	67.5
10/10	OLE MISS (+6.4)	60.5
10/17	ARKANSAS (-8.1)	45.5
10/24	AT KENTUCKY (-2.6)	47.0
11/7	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (-2.6)	47.0
11/14	ALABAMA (+6.3)	61.0
11/21	AT FLORIDA (+6.4)	55.5
11/28	TENNESSEE (+2.2)	57.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **49.08**
#18 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.7 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

13

OFFENSE

6

DEFENSE

7

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What does the post-Diego Pavia era look like?

It's always hard to replace a starting quarterback. It's even harder when that quarterback went 17-9 as a starter, led the program to its first ever 10-win season and finished second in the Heisman Trophy voting his final season. But that is exactly what Lea and the Commodore program have to do. Lea told the media that Vanderbilt will have a competition for the starting job, but it seems that five-star freshman Jared Curtis is the likely starter when the Commodores face Austin Peay to open the season. Curtis was the second-best prospect of his class, according to 247. Early projections have him as a potential first-round pick. He is not exactly a dual-threat, but with a past playing history as a running back, Curtis can extend plays and be potentially dangerous as a designed runner. Still, he is a true freshman taking over a program in the SEC. Equally talented signal-callers have struggled with less demanding circumstances in college football.

Can the offense continue to punish opponents on the ground?

Vanderbilt was a very good rush offense in 2025. The Commodores averaged 176 yards per game and 5.6 yards per carry. Much of that was due to the presence of Pavia, who led the team with 862 yards rushing. But Sedrick Alexander and Makhilyn Young — the next two leading rushers — are back in the fold, giving Lea something to work with. Alexander averaged 5.5 yards per carry and showed some physicality as a runner by averaging 3.43 yards per carry after contact. Young was explosive. He ran for 414 yards on only 47 carries. He averaged 4.21 yards per carry after contact himself. The talent is there, but is the offensive line? Four starters are gone, and they added just one FBS transfer to the position in the portal. This, coupled with Pavia's absence, likely means a stark drop-off on the ground.

Will the defense do enough to make up for the potentially declining offense?

Vanderbilt was an underrated group on defense in 2025. The Commodores limited opponents to just 3.7 yards per carry and 22.8 points per game. They finished 23rd in opponent EPA per rush and 49th in success rate on the ground. However, the secondary was a weakness. It ranked 129th in EPA per dropback and 111th in success rate. Seven starters are back, and most reside in the front seven. All eyes will be on the secondary this season. Lea added some bodies in the portal — including former four-star prospect Ricardo Jones from Clemson — but there will be quite a bit of internal promotion on the backend. Can the new faces help improve the defense's weakness? It will be a necessity considering the obvious growing pains on the horizon for the offense.

150-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

18-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

100-1

SEC

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	37.9	6
YARDS PER POINT	12.2	10
PLAYS PER GAME	63.8	119
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:14	33
3RD DOWN CONV. %	50.0%	5
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	462	7
YARDS PER PLAY	7.2	2
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.9	116
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	173.8	39
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.6	4
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31	68
COMPLETION %	69.4%	7
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	288.2	9
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	9.3	5
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.5	53
YARDS PER POINT	15.4	41
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.6%	114
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	376.1	64
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	67
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	113.2	20
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	38
COMPLETION %	67.2%	123
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	262.9	124
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.2	64
SACKS	2.3	34
TURNOVERS	1.1	89

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SUN BELT

Preview

previews by Adam Burke

The Sun Belt remains the only conference in college football to still use divisions, as the 14 teams in the conference are split right down the middle to form the East and West. Traditionally, the East has been stronger with teams like App State and Coastal Carolina and only got stronger when James Madison and Marshall joined the conference. The West is headlined primarily by Louisiana and Troy, but Louisiana Tech is a conference newcomer this season looking to make some noise. Texas State jumped ship to join the reimagined Pac-12.

Conference favorite James Madison has experienced big changes once again, as Bob Chesney followed predecessor Curt Cignetti to the Big Ten. Billy Napier, lovingly (sort of) referred to as “Sun Belt Billy” for his time at Louisiana, is back in the conference now after falling short of expectations at Florida. Incredibly, he is one of just three new head coaches in the conference, as we usually see a lot of turnover in the Sun Belt and similar leagues. The others are Ryan Beard at Coastal Carolina and Blake Anderson, another former Sun Belt boss, at Southern Miss.

This is a conference that is important to know because of the early-season weeknight games across the ESPN family of networks, so you’re going to get a few standalone Sun Belt nights where those teams are front and center before we really get into the NBA and NHL seasons. There can be some excellent betting opportunities for those who are keeping tabs on the conference.

Of course, the carrot of the College Football Playoff berth that dangles in front of the highest-ranked G6 conference champ is something that adds intrigue to the season. Last year, it was James Madison who locked that up and put forth a decent effort against Oregon, covering the 21-point number in a 17-point loss. The Dukes are +270 to run it back in the “Fun Belt”, but they are +1500 to make the CFP for a second straight year. Old Dominion is the second shot at +460 before we get to Louisiana (7-1) and Troy (8-1), so the East looks to be outpacing the West yet again.

2026 Makinen Projected Standings

TEAM	DRAFTKINGS	2026	HM	RD	SCHD	ALL GAMES		CONFERENCE	
	WINS	SM PR	FLD	FLD	STRG (RK)	PRJW	PRJL	PRJW	PRJL
<u>EAST DIVISION</u>									
JAMES MADISON	8.5	41.5	4.1	0.8	28.99 (129)	9.1	2.9	6.2	1.8
OLD DOMINION	7.5	37	2.8	0.6	30.36 (122)	7.5	4.5	5.4	2.6
MARSHALL	7.5	34	3	0.5	29.93 (124)	7.3	4.7	4.8	3.2
GA SOUTHERN	4.5	33.5	3.7	-0.5	33.93 (94)	5.8	6.2	4.3	3.7
APPALACHIAN ST	5.5	30	2.2	-0.8	31.92 (109)	5.4	6.6	3.6	4.4
COASTAL CAROLINA	4.5	28	2.2	-0.3	31.78 (110)	4.6	7.4	2.9	5.1
GEORGIA ST	4.5	23	1	-0.1	31.33 (115)	3.5	8.5	1.7	6.3
<u>WEST DIVISION</u>									
TROY	6.5	36	2.6	1	31.27 (116)	7.4	4.6	5.1	2.9
ARKANSAS ST	5.5	33.5	3.1	-0.1	30.97 (119)	6.8	5.2	5.0	3.0
LA LAFAYETTE	7.5	32.5	2.9	0.2	29.13 (128)	7.4	4.6	4.9	3.1
LOUISIANA TECH	5.5	33	3.9	-0.8	32.03 (107)	5.9	6.1	4.4	3.6
S ALABAMA	5.5	29	2.1	0.5	32.68 (102)	5.0	7.0	3.6	4.4
SOUTHERN MISS	3.5	25.5	2.4	-0.6	33.23 (98)	3.7	8.3	2.3	5.7
LA MONROE	3.5	22	2.5	-0.8	32.32 (104)	3.0	9.0	1.9	6.1

APPALACHIAN STATE MOUNTAINEERS



The boys from Boone have had back-to-back five-win seasons, an unacceptable outcome for a team that has won 10+ games in a season four times over the last decade. Last year's team got invited to the Birmingham Bowl against division rival Georgia Southern and got waxed in a game that they didn't expect to play and didn't really want to play. Other bowl opt-outs gave the Mountaineers a chance, even though they fell short of the six regular-season wins required for eligibility.

On the plus side, things seem to be looking up in Year 2 for Dowell Loggains. Per 247Sports, App State reeled in the second-ranked transfer portal class, including a few new options at QB, and the top freshman class in the conference. The tempo also appears to be looking up, as new OC Mike Anthony was an assistant under Kendal Briles at multiple stops. App State plays at the highest elevation east of the Mississippi River in FBS and using that to their advantage makes a ton of sense, if Loggains and the new-look offense are able to achieve that.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

This is an alt win total, as 5.5 with heavy Over juice is the prevailing number. I also think that 18-1 to win the conference is worth some thought. App State welcomes both Old Dominion and James Madison to Kidd Brewer Stadium and avoids Louisiana and Troy from the West. The talent level on this team looks a lot stronger, as Shawn Clark had some good seasons, but wasn't really bringing in a ton of athleticism. After two down seasons, App State has a good shot to bounce back. My projection is 5.67 wins, but I think this team can overachieve.

2025 Record: 5-8 SU & 6-7 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Dowell Loggains - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	MAINE (-15)	17.0
9/12	AT EAST CAROLINA (+14.3)	40.5
9/19	CHARLOTTE (-11.2)	20.5
9/26	AT NC STATE (+21)	48.0
10/10	OLD DOMINION (+5.4)	37.0
10/16	AT COASTAL CAROLINA (+1)	28.0
10/22	JAMES MADISON (+10.1)	41.5
10/31	AT GA SOUTHERN (+8)	33.5
11/7	GEORGIA ST (-9.3)	23.0
11/14	AT MARSHALL (+7.8)	34.0
11/21	LA MONROE (-11)	22.0
11/27	AT S ALABAMA (+1.9)	29.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.92**
#109 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.2 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

5

2

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will lead the team up the mountain?

It's probably fair to say that Loggains wasn't enamored with any of his QB options last season, as AJ Swann and JJ Kohl both had nearly the same amount of pass attempts and three other QBs also got some reps. This season, all of them are elsewhere, so the position group had to be rebuilt via the portal. In the end, Loggains and his staff settled on Malachi Singleton from Purdue, Henry Hasselbeck from UCLA, and Tommy Ulatowski from Kent State. Hasselbeck is indeed the son of Matt, who Loggains coached with the Titans in the early 2010s. Hasselbeck and Singleton are more mobile than last year's options and should add more explosiveness to an offense that had just 5.4 YPP and just 24.2 PPG. The Mountaineers had gained at least six yards per play basically every season since joining the SBC prior to last season's poor showing.

Do all the pieces fit on offense?

With a new scheme and a new QB room, the Mountaineers also have a bunch of new faces at wide receiver and running back. Again, this was one of the worst offensive units that App State has had in a long time and Loggains is a guy who has coached offenses in some capacity his entire career. Ja'Quez Cross from Arkansas State and Chris Lofton from Gardner-Webb are two guys that could generate explosives and the others are a collection of highly-touted recruits looking for a fresh start, JUCO transfers, and some holdovers from Year 1. If this offense does run with some tempo, the improved depth at the skill spots is promising.

How good can this defense be?

This is probably the most important question for App State. I fully believe that the offense will be better and the presence of more of a dual-threat QB may be a game-changer. Defensively, though, the Mountaineers, who did improve by 0.7 YPP and 3.1 PPG year over year, were a major disappointment in conference play. They gave up 33 PPG and 450 yards per contest. They were outgained by 1.1 yards per carry and simply stunk up the joint, going just 2-7 in SBC play. DC DJ Smith did a good job at Missouri with Eli Drinkwitz, who coached the Mountaineers to a 12-1 record in 2019 before skipping out before the bowl game. With leading tackler Colton Phares back and a ton of transfers, this is the most important, and most unknown, unit on the team.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****400-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****18-1****SUN BELT (EAST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.5	81
YARDS PER POINT	15.3	90
PLAYS PER GAME	73.4	14
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:35	108
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.8%	124
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	374.3	72
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	95
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.7	109
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	120.8	102
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	98
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.5	11
COMPLETION %	59.1%	95
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	253.5	36
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	104
TURNOVERS	1.5	94
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.2	104
YARDS PER POINT	13.9	84
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.2%	120
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	433.8	117
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	96
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	161.7	78
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	77
COMPLETION %	63.7%	88
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	272.2	128
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.5	89
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

COASTAL CAROLINA CHANTICLEERS



When Jamey Chadwell left for Liberty, Coastal Carolina hired Tim Beck. Many of us in the college football gambling community felt like it was one of the biggest coaching downgrades in the nation. While Beck led the Chants to an 8-5 record in Year 1, back-to-back losing seasons sent him packing and now Ryan Beard has been tabbed to lead the program. Beard oversaw Missouri State's transition from FCS to FBS and got the Bears to a bowl game last season, though he got to work in Conway before that game was played.

The 37-year-old son-in-law of Bobby Petrino is moving up the coaching ranks quickly, but he was at Missouri State for six seasons, three as the DC and three as the head coach. This is a taller task now, especially with about 60 new players in the mix, including a conference-high 42 transfers per 247Sports. Beard did bring his coordinators with him, so there's some continuity on the sideline, but how quickly will all the newbies buy in?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 4.5

This season is all about building for next season. All of the quarterbacks that Beard brought in have eligibility past this season. Same with virtually all of the skill players. This program was unquestionably trending in the wrong direction under Beck and a teardown to the studs makes the most sense. Beard was part of being a program builder at Missouri State, so much so that they went from FCS to FBS. While Coastal is more established with nine years at the FBS level, the program needs a refresh and they'll get it, but probably at the expense of this season's record. My projection is 4.86 wins.

2025 Record: 6-7 SU & ATS, 9-4 O-U
Head Coach: Ryan Beard - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT WEST VIRGINIA (+20.1)	45.0
9/12	FORDHAM (-28.9)	2.0
9/19	AT DELAWARE (+6)	31.0
9/24	LIBERTY (+4.5)	34.5
10/3	GA SOUTHERN (+2.8)	33.5
10/10	AT MARSHALL (+9.3)	34.0
10/16	APPALACHIAN ST (-1)	30.0
10/31	AT GEORGIA ST (-3.7)	23.0
11/7	OLD DOMINION (+7.4)	37.0
11/14	ARKANSAS ST (+3.2)	33.5
11/21	AT LA LAFAYETTE (+7.7)	32.5
11/28	AT JAMES MADISON (+17.9)	41.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.78**
#110 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.2 / -0.3**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

9

OFFENSE

5

DEFENSE

4

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will the Deuce be loose?

The Deuce in question is Deuce Bailey, who backed up Jacob Clark at Missouri State. When Clark got hurt, Bailey got his chance and is a much closer player to Samari Collier, who injected a major spark into the Chanticleers offense last season when he took over for Tad Hudson. Collier, a dual-threat guy with six yards per carry, led the team to over 40 PPG, but he got hurt and it all went to hell from there. Beard is obviously familiar with Bailey and it sure seems like a dual-threat QB is a luxury in the conference. Trever Jackson from Arkansas and JUCO transfer Tre Guerra, who also had offers from Texas Tech, Kentucky, Florida State, LSU, and Virginia, are other options. The talent level at the position as a whole seems a lot better.

How quickly does the offensive line come together?

Beard had the fortune of having a very experienced QB last season in Clark, but he was still sacked 48 times, as the team gave up 52 sacks overall. Furthermore, the Bears had just 3.5 yards per carry, as Clark had 94 scrambles for -16 yards to drag down the average. None of the QB options are experienced at this level, so you have to wonder (and worry) about how many negative plays will come as a result of sacks. This is a girthy offensive line with a bunch of very big dudes, but none of them have really played together and only Daughtry Richardson was a high-ranked recruit. He only played one game at Florida State and transferred to FAU. This is easily the most questionable position group and you can't do much if you don't have an offensive line.

Will a fresh start work for the defense?

Most of the offensive players of note are gone, but a few defenders stuck around. Ja'Marion Wayne, Ibrahim Diawara, and Tray Brown are the most notable, as Wayne tied with fellow holdover Myles Woods for the lead in pass breakups, Diarra had a couple sacks, and Brown had nine tackles for loss. LD Scott was the DC at Missouri State and followed Beard here to take over a unit that allowed 33.1 PPG. The Chants allowed 5.5 yards per carry and 474 yards of offense per game in conference play. What's wild is that Coastal was +9 in TO margin in conference play and went 5-3 while getting scorched on defense. A fresh start can't hurt.

5000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****45-1****SUN BELT (EAST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.9	94
YARDS PER POINT	14	52
PLAYS PER GAME	67.9	71
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:25	124
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.6%	126
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	319.8	114
YARDS PER PLAY	4.7	118
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.2	68
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	147.7	69
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	73
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31	68
COMPLETION %	54.3%	130
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	172.1	116
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	5.6	133
TURNOVERS	1.7	111
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	35.8	128
YARDS PER POINT	13.1	108
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.0%	80
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	468.5	133
YARDS PER PLAY	6.2	119
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	219.1	131
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.2	126
COMPLETION %	63.1%	80
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	249.4	115
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.6	96
SACKS	1.5	107
TURNOVERS	1.8	15

GEORGIA SOUTHERN EAGLES



There's something to be said for an athletic department going into a college football season knowing what to expect in 2026. That's the case for Georgia Southern with head coach Clay Helton, who has gone to a bowl game in each of his four seasons with the program and just picked up his first bowl win to cap off a 7-6 season. While the ceiling hasn't proven to be very high in Statesboro, the floor seems to be. Mix in a paycheck game or two, scoop that ESPN money, and keep the machine running.

Would it be nice for the program to take the next step? Absolutely. After all, the 10-3 season in 2018 under Chad Lunsford feels like an eternity ago. Plus, the allure of a G6 CFP berth is a big motivating factor. But, not having to pay a coach's buyout or constantly shell out money to hire new people and entice new recruits has plenty of perks as well. This season, there are some changes, including a new defensive coordinator.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 4.5

This is tough because the Over 4.5 is juicy, but six wins is a challenge with the schedule. A visit to Clemson and a visit from Houston mean two P4 opponents, plus Troy in cross-division play. This is also an example of how the East Division being much stronger than the West makes it tough for playing some of these futures and props. That being said, this team has a really high ceiling and it might be higher than any of us expect if Mutz can fix the defense. This is one of my biggest overlays with a projection of 5.49 wins, so the alt Over 5.5 is in play.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 7-5-1 ATS, 7-6 O-U

Head Coach: Clay Helton - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	CHARLESTON SOUT (-28.8)	8.5
9/12	AT CLEMSON (+22.7)	54.0
9/19	AT JACKSONVILLE ST (+5.2)	34.0
9/26	HOUSTON (+16)	53.0
10/3	AT COASTAL CAROLINA (-2.8)	28.0
10/10	JAMES MADISON (+5.1)	41.5
10/15	AT OLD DOMINION (+6.8)	37.0
10/31	APPALACHIAN ST (-8)	30.0
11/7	MARSHALL (-2.7)	34.0
11/14	AT GEORGIA ST (-9)	23.0
11/21	AT TROY (+5.6)	36.0
11/28	LOUISIANA TECH (-5)	33.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **33.93**
#94 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.7 / -0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

9

3

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Will Johnson “Max” out his final college football season?

All-time leading passer JC French transferred to Cincinnati after posting a 20/8 TD/INT ratio with 2,929 yards and six more touchdowns on the ground. It should be noted that French is the program's all-time leader with just 5,882 yards. Kyle Vantrease played one season there in 2022 and is the third-leading passer with 4,253 yards. Helton moved the Eagles from an option to a spread and so he's gotten some productive QB play in a relative sense. Max Johnson could have a Vantrease-esque season or better, as he's played at LSU, Texas A&M, and North Carolina over seven seasons. Many people are probably saying “get a job, bro”, but schools keep paying him to come there and he has the chance to have a massive season in his final year of eligibility.

Who emerges as the go-to receiver?

There will be one. This scheme will lead to somebody putting up numbers, but the top five pass-catchers from last season are all gone, including 1,000-yard receiver Camden Brown. Marcus Sanders and Dalen Cobb combined for 107 catches and eight touchdowns. Brown had 65 and 14 of them went for six. Not a bad ratio. Brown is now with the Cowboys, so he's technically an NFL-caliber player that needs to be replaced. Perhaps it will be 6-foot-5 Ashton Hollis from Illinois or Andre Greene, a highly-touted recruit who didn't do much at Virginia. Both Josh Dallas and River Helms were lost for the season early and are back. The WR1 may be unknown, but there are a lot of dudes who can put up stats in this offense, especially with Johnson.

How good can the defense be?

There is a lot of upside to the offense with a very experienced QB in Johnson and a deep skill group. If the defense can take a step forward, then Helton may really be cooking with propane here. Mike Mutz had a defense that generated a ton of negative plays and takeaways last season at Stephen F. Austin. If he can carry over the tackles for loss and sacks, the Eagles will have their first defense with fewer than six yards per play allowed since 2020. This defense managed only 12 sacks last season in 13 games. That should change.

2000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

26-1

SUN BELT (EAST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	26.5	67
YARDS PER POINT	14.8	77
PLAYS PER GAME	70.2	52
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:35	77
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.3%	32
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	392.7	56
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	49
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.8	72
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	150.9	65
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.3	58
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	33	44
COMPLETION %	63.4%	49
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	241.8	51
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	60
TURNOVERS	0.9	15
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	33.6	120
YARDS PER POINT	14.2	78
3RD DOWN CONV. %	49.0%	134
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	475.9	135
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	132
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	227.3	133
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.8	135
COMPLETION %	64.3%	96
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	248.7	114
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	106
SACKS	0.8	136
TURNOVERS	1.4	46

GEORGIA STATE PANTHERS



The Dell McGee era in Atlanta has not gone well. McGee was an imaginative hire by the athletic department, as he's spent a lot of time in Georgia, including several seasons with the Bulldogs as a running backs coach/run game coordinator. His reputation as a recruiter was expected to elevate the talent within the program, but it's still a results-based business and McGee is 4-20 with a 1-15 record in Sun Belt play. The Panthers got skunked in SBC action last season and their lone win was against FCS Murray State.

Injuries didn't help, especially at the QB position, where Cameran Brown is and was clearly the best option. He posted a 13/1 TD/INT ratio and had 4.7 yards per carry with four rushing TDs, but TJ Finley and Christian Veilleux both played and were awful, as they were a big part of the team's -11 TO margin. Georgia State even got really lucky to lose just six of their 17 fumbles, but the defense only mustered six takeaways. OC Hue Jackson is back, but the co-DCs are new as McGee probably needs a decent season to save his job.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

An alt win total at a plus-money price here. McGee hasn't proven to be a college-level head coach. Position coach? Sure. Recruiter? Absolutely. But, this is also a team that is just 5-18-1 ATS over the last two seasons, so they've fallen well short of virtually no expectations. Hurst was a third-round pick, so he's obviously a huge loss. The Panthers do get saddled with Louisiana from the West and go to App State and James Madison. It's a rough schedule with a bad team and probably a lame-duck head coach. My projection is 3.63 wins.

2025 Record: 1-11 SU & 2-10 ATS, 6-6 O-U

Head Coach: Dell McGee - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/4	N CAROLINA A&T (-28.2)	-4.0
9/12	AT KENNESAW ST (+10.6)	31.5
9/19	AT UCF (+24.8)	44.5
9/26	N ILLINOIS (-2)	21.5
10/3	OLD DOMINION (+13.6)	37.0
10/17	AT JAMES MADISON (+22.7)	41.5
10/24	AT ARKANSAS ST (+13.7)	33.5
10/31	COASTAL CAROLINA (+3.7)	28.0
11/7	AT APPALACHIAN ST (+9.3)	30.0
11/14	GA SOUTHERN (+9)	33.5
11/21	AT MARSHALL (+14.1)	34.0
11/28	LA LAFAYETTE (+8.7)	32.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **31.33**
#115 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **1 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

8

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

2

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is Brown the answer that the offense needs?

Brown had that 13/1 TD/INT ratio mentioned above and 61 carries for 284 yards, but he had three games with 200+ yards passing and the Panthers lost all of those, averaging just 25 PPG. Even with Brown's ability to move the ball through the air and on the ground, the defense allowed 41, 41, and 38 points. Given that Finley and Veilleux combined for a 9/10 TD/INT ratio, Brown should theoretically help the defense if he can keep a similar ratio to 2025, but even when he played well, it didn't seem to matter. He didn't even start the team's "best" loss, a 14-7 defeat at the hands of CFP team James Madison. Now Brown goes into the season without 1,000-yard WR Ted Hurst and leading rusher Jordon Simmons, who had 5.6 yards per carry.

Where is all the talent?

McGee was hired because of his recruiting prowess, but the Panthers scored four fewer PPG year over year and allowed four more PPG. While having a mobile QB helped limit the sacks to 18, the team also regressed from a yards per carry standpoint. For this season, McGee did secure the lone freshman recruit graded as a four-star by 247Sports in OL Maxwell Robinson. He also snagged some P4-level talent on the OL with guys from Florida, Georgia, Michigan, Georgia Tech, and Oklahoma State, but guys that played sparingly or not at all. All of the running backs are under six feet tall. Leading returning receiver Grant Hollier is one of the few big bodies, as he had just 21 catches. A guy like McGee makes sense on paper, but he doesn't have a big NIL budget and that's what you need with this kind of head coach.

Are the new co-defensive coordinators going to provide relief?

Georgia State allowed the most points per game in the second half last season with 20.8. They were outscored essentially 21-8 in the second halves of games, as McGee and his staff failed to adjust and the depth simply wasn't good enough. Things were so bad for DC Travis Pearson that he left to take a job in the UFL. Cam Clark was working with quarterbacks at Duke and was a high school DC prior to that. John Haneline's Youngstown State defense gave up 31 PPG last season. With just 18 sacks in back-to-back seasons, a new crop of players probably isn't a bad thing, especially with 37.8 PPG allowed last season, but these seem to be two underwhelming hires.

ODDS TO WIN...

10000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****500-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****150-1****SUN BELT (EAST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	18.2	120
YARDS PER POINT	20.4	131
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	27
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:06	63
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.2%	79
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	371.3	76
YARDS PER PLAY	5.1	93
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	30.4	121
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	120.3	103
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4	92
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.5	8
COMPLETION %	60.0%	83
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	251	40
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	118
TURNOVERS	1.3	67
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	39.4	135
YARDS PER POINT	11.8	130
3RD DOWN CONV. %	48.7%	132
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	464.7	132
YARDS PER PLAY	6.6	131
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	216.5	128
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.3	129
COMPLETION %	64.5%	100
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	248.2	112
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.8	128
SACKS	1.4	112
TURNOVERS	0.5	135

JAMES MADISON DUKES



No team in the Sun Belt has been able to leverage the transfer portal better than James Madison. They do have resources, but Curt Cignetti and Bob Chesney have done a masterful job of finding talent, especially at the QB position. Jordan McCloud and Alonza Barnett upheld the standards of the program, even with the transition from FCS to FBS. The biggest question for Billy Napier heading into this season is who will play that position and can they find similar success to their predecessors? With NIL funds allocated elsewhere, the Dukes didn't go the transfer portal route at QB, really, with the exception of UCF transfer Davi Belfort, who barely played.

247Sports gave James Madison's portal haul the best grade in the conference by a pretty wide margin, which is good because pretty much all of last season's production is gone, but a lot of players are from lower-division schools, FCS, or never saw the field at their P4 programs. The season after Cignetti left for Indiana, the Dukes went 9-4, but 4-4 in conference play. Is a similar transitional year in store?

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 8.5

The first regular season under Chesney led to an 8-4 record and I could see something similar here, as the quarterback position is a major question mark. While the Dukes have a Week 2 tilt with Wagner that is a quasi-bye, they have to play 11 straight weeks without a bye, as they won't be off until the weekend of November 21 before facing Coastal Carolina. The schedule includes a long trip west to San Diego State, a random non-conference roadie at UConn, and road games at Old Dominion and App State. My projection is 8.91 wins, but the road slate really is tricky.

2025 Record: 12-2 SU & 9-5 ATS, 7-7 O-U

Head Coach: Billy Napier - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	LIBERTY (-10.9)	34.5
9/12	WAGNER (-43.2)	3.0
9/19	AT SAN DIEGO ST (+3.3)	43.0
9/26	AT OLD DOMINION (-2.5)	37.0
10/3	MARSHALL (-11.1)	34.0
10/10	AT GA SOUTHERN (-5.1)	33.5
10/17	GEORGIA ST (-22.7)	23.0
10/22	AT APPALACHIAN ST (-10.1)	30.0
10/29	TROY (-8.6)	36.0
11/5	AT SOUTHERN MISS (-14.4)	25.5
11/14	AT CONNECTICUT (-6.9)	31.5
11/28	COASTAL CAROLINA (-17.9)	28.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **28.99**
#129 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **4.1 / 0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

5

OFFENSE

3

DEFENSE

2

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is JC Evans the next star at JMU?

A program rich with resources relative to the rest of the conference opted not to pick up an impact transfer at QB, instead putting some faith in Evans, a 6-foot-5 sophomore from the Miami area. He wasn't a highly sought-after recruit, but he got to learn behind Barnett for two years and has a good returning running back in George Pettaway. He also has transfer Nick Herman, who ran for over seven yards per carry at Drake, so he may not have too much pressure on his shoulders at the outset with a run-heavy approach. The offensive line should lend itself to running the rock effectively. Also, Michigan State wasn't great last season, but their QBs posted a 20/6 TD/INT ratio and pass game coordinator Aaron Pflugrad is the new QB coach for the Dukes.

Should we remember the name Cam Aiken?

Aiken is the new OC here and a rising star in the coaching world. The Clemson grad was on the staff for two National Championships and then spent time under Lane Kiffin at Ole Miss before running an offense of his own at East Tennessee State last season. The Buccaneers racked up over 32 PPG and better than 440 yards per game. He also coached running backs at South Florida and that group had nearly 200 yards per contest in 2022. This appears to be an outstanding hire by Napier and one who should keep the throttle down here with an offense that averaged 6.4 YPP and 37.1 PPG last season. This really does look like a promising coaching staff, which is hugely important with so many transfers.

How big of a step back will the defense take?

Over four FBS seasons, the Dukes have allowed 2.5, 2.6, 3.5, and 2.8 yards per carry, while giving up just 4.7, 5.0, 4.9, and 4.4 yards per play. The transition from Cignetti to Chesney and the accompanying new coaches and coordinators didn't foster any downturn. At some point, it feels like the roster attrition has to take hold and lead to setbacks. I gave a bullish case for the offense, but I'm not sure that I can for the defense, though Amar Thomas and Gannon Weathersby are two returning starters of consequence. New DC Robert Bala has worked under Napier, Jedd Fisch (and DC Stephen Belichick), and Nick Saban over the last three years, so that's a reason for optimism.

ODDS TO WIN...

1000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****15-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+270****SUN BELT (EAST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	36.5	10
YARDS PER POINT	12.4	14
PLAYS PER GAME	72.5	30
TIME OF POSSESSION	34:20	2
3RD DOWN CONV. %	46.2%	18
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	452.8	9
YARDS PER PLAY	6.2	21
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	43.3	11
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	236.5	6
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	8
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	27.5	105
COMPLETION %	58.1%	103
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	216.2	79
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.9	35
TURNOVERS	1.1	37
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19	13
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	66
3RD DOWN CONV. %	29.8%	5
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	275.8	4
YARDS PER PLAY	4.4	6
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	86.7	5
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.9	4
COMPLETION %	51.8%	4
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	189.1	20
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.2	17
SACKS	2.7	20
TURNOVERS	1.1	96

MARSHALL THUNDERING HERD



There are several ways of looking at Marshall's 2025 season.

The first is that the athletic department got what they deserved for letting Charles Huff walk after winning the Sun Belt Conference with a 10-3 record. The second is that even with that turmoil, Marshall started 4-2 and had a real shot at bowl eligibility, but lost three times as a favorite over the final five games to finish just 5-7 and miss bowl eligibility for the first time since 2016.

Given that it was a rebuilding year, Tony Gibson actually did a pretty good job to get the team to where he did, even if the season ended in disappointing fashion, losing to Georgia Southern as a 10-point favorite in Huntington with a bowl game on the line. On the plus side, Carlos Del Rio-Wilson found a home after bouncing around a bit and enough players bought in to the point where they've stuck around. On the other hand, a 5-7 team didn't really get any better via the portal or the freshman class based on their conference ranking.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

This is not a bet, but rather a gamble on the Herd's schedule. They draw South Alabama and UL Monroe from the West Division and all of their home games are winnable in conference play, plus they host a FCS team and a poor Middle Tennessee squad. However, the road games are daunting outside of facing the Warhawks at the end of the season, with trips to Penn State, James Madison, and Old Dominion as the highlights. Coastal Carolina is now coached by Ryan Beard, who dropped 474 yards on the Herd when they played Missouri State last season. It's a tough slate, with a projection of 7.35 wins.

2025 Record: 5-7 SU & 7-5 ATS, 7-5 O-U

Head Coach: Tony Gibson - 2nd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT PENN ST (+25.6)	57.0
9/12	MIDDLE TENN ST (-16.4)	21.0
9/19	AT MISSOURI ST (-6.7)	25.0
9/26	GARDNER WEBB (-21.8)	14.5
10/3	AT JAMES MADISON (+11.1)	41.5
10/10	COASTAL CAROLINA (-9.3)	28.0
10/20	S ALABAMA (-7.5)	29.0
10/31	AT OLD DOMINION (+5.3)	37.0
11/7	AT GA SOUTHERN (+2.7)	33.5
11/14	APPALACHIAN ST (-7.8)	30.0
11/21	GEORGIA ST (-14.1)	23.0
11/28	AT LA MONROE (-10)	22.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **29.93**
#124 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

9

OFFENSE

6*

DEFENSE

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the offense take things up a notch?

The defense took a massive step back last season for Marshall, but the offense was nearly as good as the season prior. The Thundering Herd only saw minor drop-offs in PPG, YPP, and sacks allowed, but gained more yardage on a per-game basis and completed more passes. Del Rio-Wilson was the team's leading rusher with 661 yards and he threw for more than 2,000 yards with 23 total TDs. It was his first crack as a starter after stops at Florida and Syracuse and he took advantage of it. If CDRW can stay healthy, he should be fine, but what will the other guys be able to contribute? This was a by-committee approach at RB and three guys who averaged 5+ yards per carry are gone. Leading WR Demarcus Lacey, who had 28 more receptions than anybody else, is also gone. That said, WR was one of the focal points in the portal and TE Toby Payne is one of the best in the conference at his position.

Will Brad Lambert fix the defense?

Former Charlotte head coach Brad Lambert is back for his third go-round after coaching up the defense here in 2019-20. He also got his start with Marshall in the early '90s. He was the DC at Wake Forest prior to Jake Dickert's arrival and then a defensive assistant at Kentucky. He's been around a long time and this defense badly needs help, so going to an old friend makes sense. While the offense was pretty similar in Huff's absence, the defense allowed 7.2 more PPG and 0.6 more YPP, including an increase of more than 60 passing yards per game. The cornerback position was a big focus in the portal after allowing 262 passing yards per contest and 264 in conference play.

Is Tony Gibson head coach material?

Gibson was a DC for a decade at West Virginia and NC State before getting his first crack as a head coach here with the Herd. In Year 1, his team lost five games as a favorite. The defense was significantly worse than the offense. They fell short of a bowl game and a winning record despite a +6 turnover margin. Two of their losses featured positive yardage differentials of 275 and 156 yards. It was a massive rebuilding job to get enough capable bodies, as the program had just over 40 players after the mass departures in December and January. But, now Gibson won't have those excuses if he once again fails as a favorite or can't close out games.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****150-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****+900****SUN BELT (EAST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.1	30
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	43
PLAYS PER GAME	70.8	46
TIME OF POSSESSION	30:12	57
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.9%	103
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	408.1	32
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	37
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	40.4	26
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	191.6	27
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.7	35
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	29.2	91
COMPLETION %	65.4%	28
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	216.5	77
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.4	56
TURNOVERS	1.2	56
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	32.4	113
YARDS PER POINT	13.6	96
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.8%	86
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	438.9	125
YARDS PER PLAY	6.1	115
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	161.7	79
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	56
COMPLETION %	60.4%	44
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	277.2	131
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.9	129
SACKS	2.1	56
TURNOVERS	1.7	24

OLD DOMINION MONARCHS



The Indiana Hoosiers won 10 of their 16 victories by 14+ points. One of the six games came against Old Dominion, who was badly outgained in the regular-season opener, but lost 27-14 in what turned out to be a sign of things to come. Ricky Rahne's program put it all together and improved by five wins to finish 10-3. What is amazing, though, is that ODU's three losses were by 13, 24, and 36 points, as they were -5 in turnovers against Marshall and got pummeled by James Madison. Otherwise, 10 wins was one fewer than the previous two seasons combined.

These whiplash sorts of seasons are very possible at the G6 level nowadays thanks to the portal, as some teams get completely wrecked and others stay intact enough to take advantage. This season, ODU is one of those teams with very heavy losses, including QB Colton Joseph to Wisconsin after rushing for more than 1,000 yards and throwing for over 2,600 more. He's hardly the only loss, as OC Kevin Decker now holds the same role at Memphis, but Rahne has a favorable schedule to work with.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 7.5

The schedule is kind to Rahne this season, as James Madison and Marshall go to Norfolk and the non-conference road game at UConn, albeit randomly timed, is very winnable, along with hapless Georgia State, newcomer Louisiana Tech, and a Coastal Carolina team in a transitional phase. Drawing Southern Miss and LA Tech from the West Division isn't bad at all and the East Carolina game can be had at home. I have them favored in nine games, with +1.5 and +0.5 in two other games, and a projection of 7.51 wins.

2025 Record: 10-3 SU & 8-5 ATS, 5-8 O-U

Head Coach: Ricky Rahne - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	NORFOLK ST (-43)	-3.5
9/12	AT VIRGINIA TECH (+15.7)	51.0
9/19	EAST CAROLINA (+1.4)	40.5
9/26	JAMES MADISON (+2.5)	41.5
10/3	AT GEORGIA ST (-13.6)	23.0
10/10	AT APPALACHIAN ST (-5.4)	30.0
10/15	GA SOUTHERN (-6.8)	33.5
10/24	AT LOUISIANA TECH (-0.7)	33.0
10/31	MARSHALL (-5.3)	34.0
11/7	AT COASTAL CAROLINA (-7.4)	28.0
11/21	AT CONNECTICUT (-2.2)	31.5
11/28	SOUTHERN MISS (-14.9)	25.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **30.36**
#122 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.8 / 0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

7

1

6

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can Cook keep the offense cooking?

Kody Cook is the new OC after serving as the wide receivers coach last season. He’s also the new QB coach with some shifting across the staff. The Monarchs relied very heavily on their top three receivers last season, as only three guys had 11+ catches and they had 762, 719, and 667 yards while nobody else had more than 200. All three of those guys are gone, so Cook’s old position group needs to be reimagined, but this should be a run-heavy team again. Devin Roche had 5.7 yards per carry, not nearly as good as Trequan Jones’ 7.5 yards per pop, plus JUCO transfer Trey Hall was originally an Ole Miss commit. Quinn Henicle and Jaxon Potter will have skill guys to work with and Cook, who played at Kansas State and coached at Tennessee, was a logical guy to promote with Decker’s departure.

Who gets more reps as the starting QB?

Henicle is the holdover and the guy who knows this system and scheme, but he also wasn’t very good last season. He ran for 4.8 yards per carry on 44 attempts and only completed 42.5% of his passes, as he was just 11-for-25 against a skeleton crew USF team in the bowl game. Meanwhile, Potter, who was a higher-graded recruit, was willing to come all the way from Washington State and head to the other coast as a California native. That said, Henicle was recruited to some FCS schools with good rushing attacks and also Army, so he was clearly viewed as an impact QB in the ground game. Neither guy looks poised to top Joseph’s numbers, but Rahne needs to get this right and fix it early in the season, if he doesn’t coming out of camp.

Should we buy or sell this defense?

Rahne, an offensive-minded guy, seems to have finally rounded that side of the ball into form, going up in yards per carry and points per game in each of the last three seasons. However, the biggest separator for the Monarchs last season was Blake Seiler’s defense. That group shaved off 9.5 PPG and 0.9 YPP from the previous season, holding opponents to just 18.5 PPG and 4.8 YPP. As a team, ODU outgained opponents by 1.9 yards per play. Seiler saw the sack total go from 19 to 26 to 39 in a three-year span and put forth a top-25 third-down defense. Seiler also sees the return of two linebackers who started in 2024, but missed most of last season, and has returning starters at each level of the defense. I’ll buy that they’re better than 2024, but worse than 2025.

1000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

35-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+460

SUN BELT (EAST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.2	28
YARDS PER POINT	14.8	78
PLAYS PER GAME	70.1	54
TIME OF POSSESSION	28:30	110
3RD DOWN CONV. %	42.4%	37
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	447.3	13
YARDS PER PLAY	6.4	16
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	43.3	12
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	236	7
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	5.5	9
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.3	118
COMPLETION %	55.8%	121
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	211.3	87
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.4	18
TURNOVERS	1.9	129
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	19.6	15
YARDS PER POINT	17.3	12
3RD DOWN CONV. %	34.8%	27
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	339.4	28
YARDS PER PLAY	4.6	13
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	140.4	47
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.7	30
COMPLETION %	61.3%	58
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	199	31
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	18
SACKS	3.1	4
TURNOVERS	1.9	11

ARKANSAS STATE

RED WOLVES



It took a couple of seasons for Butch Jones to pick up the pieces in Jonesboro coming out of COVID and the end of Blake Anderson's tenure, but the program has gone to a bowl game three seasons in a row and has their first winning streak in bowl games since 2012-13 under Gus Malzahn and Bryan Harsin. Jones was even able to get his team through Sun Belt play with a 5-3 record despite a ghastly -11 TO margin. We'll see what kind of fortunes the Red Wolves have this season, as they'll play without QB Jaylen Raynor for the first time since 2022, a season in which they finished 3-9.

Depending on how you look at it, Raynor's departure comes at either a good time or a bad time. The running game dropped off precipitously last season and Raynor had a lot to do with it, posting just 2.7 yards per carry. The Red Wolves also have a new OC in Garrett Altman, who was coaching up Diego Pavia at Vanderbilt the last two years, so a new offensive installation is taking place. But, Raynor also leaves at the same time as all-time leading receiver Corey Rucker, so there is a ton of offensive production to replace.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 5.5

The better question here is whether or not you want to venture Over 6.5 wins because the vig is heavy on 5.5. The West Division is rather poor. All SBC road games are winnable, including the one against conference favorite Louisiana, and drawing Coastal Carolina and Georgia State from the East is a boost to the team's forecast. I still think the best approach is betting Over the total on a weekly basis. If a QB emerges, the books will catch up, but if Altman tabs the right guy(s) at the outset, we can take advantage before adjustments are made. My projection is 6.36 wins.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 8-5 ATS, 5-8 O-U

Head Coach: Butch Jones - 6th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT MEMPHIS (+10.5)	41.0
9/12	W GEORGIA (-17.3)	19.0
9/19	AT TCU (+21.1)	51.0
9/26	KENNESAW ST (-5.7)	31.5
10/3	AT LA LAFAYETTE (+2)	32.5
10/8	S ALABAMA (-7.1)	29.0
10/17	AT SOUTHERN MISS (-5.5)	25.5
10/24	GEORGIA ST (-13.7)	23.0
11/7	LA MONROE (-15.4)	22.0
11/14	AT COASTAL CAROLINA (-3.2)	28.0
11/21	AT LOUISIANA TECH (+3.5)	33.0
11/28	TROY (+0.4)	36.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **30.97**
#119 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.1 / -0.1**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

10

7

3

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Who will emerge at quarterback?

The QB puzzle is one that will take some time to put together. Ethan Crawford is the holdover, but he didn't play last season. Trey Owens was a four-star prospect out of Texas and committed to UT, but never saw the field. Drew Dickey and Jeremy St-Hilaire sat behind Pavia at Vandy. So, there is pretty much zero experience on this roster, but there are some reasons to believe any of them could be an option. The ex-Commodores know Altman's philosophy, Owens probably has the most untapped upside, and Crawford knows the skill guys who are back, including top rushers Devin Spencer and Kenyon Clay, plus 5-foot-6 WR Chauncy Cobb, who had 73 catches last season.

Can Altman turn things around on offense?

While Raynor had a career-best 3,361 passing yards last season, he also led the Sun Belt in attempts with 501. While it was his top season by completion percentage, it was also his lowest output in yards per reception and just slightly better than the previous season in yards and adjusted yards per attempt. He also had his worst season from a per-carry standpoint. The Red Wolves fell from 4.2 yards per carry in the previous two seasons to 3.8 and also posted a -7 turnover margin. Altman was still playing college football at TCU just a decade ago and was actually an analyst at New Mexico State when Pavia was there, so he was instrumental in every phase of his development. The Commodores led the nation with 7.47 yards per play last season. He may very well create a much more explosive offense.

Will the Red Wolves be a good Over bet?

First-year DC Griff McCarley came in guns blazing, as the Red Wolves went from 19 sacks up to 39. Even with those negative plays, the defense still allowed over six yards per play, though 6.1 is a lot better than 6.9. The question is whether or not McCarley can find those pressures with a completely new defensive line, as just about everybody with more than one sack is playing somewhere else or ran out of eligibility. Considering that the Red Wolves were tied for sixth in sacks per game and still only forced seven interceptions and gave up a 68.4% completion percentage, I have a ton of doubts about this defense, but fully expect the offense to get better. We could see some track meets with this team.

3000-1**CFP CHAMPIONSHIP****250-1****MAKE THE PLAYOFF****12-1****SUN BELT (WEST)**

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	23.8	86
YARDS PER POINT	15.7	99
PLAYS PER GAME	76.3	7
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:25	84
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.4%	76
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	374	74
YARDS PER PLAY	4.9	112
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.3	78
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	121.6	101
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.5	110
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.8	10
COMPLETION %	64.8%	36
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	252.4	38
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.4	110
TURNOVERS	1.8	122
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.7	76
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	50
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.2%	81
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	418.8	108
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	101
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	176.2	96
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	90
COMPLETION %	68.0%	131
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	242.7	104
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	8.2	118
SACKS	3	6
TURNOVERS	1.2	81

LOUISIANA RAGIN' CAJUNS



Every season is a big one for a head coach nowadays because boosters and fans demand results, but this feels like a really, really big one for Michael Desormeaux. The fact that he was a Ragin' Cajun QB from 2005-08 probably adds some leeway, but Louisiana has three 6-7 seasons on his watch and one 10-4 season that ended with a 31-3 loss in the conference title game and then a 34-3 loss in the bowl game. Not only that, but the former OC under Billy Napier saw his offense drop by 4.9 PPG and 1.3 YPP from 2024 to 2025.

Times have changed, but Billy Napier took a program that went 5-7 in Mark Hudspeth's final season and had wins vacated because of NCAA violations to 11 wins in Year 2. Napier had 33 wins in his final three seasons, as Desormeaux coached the bowl. Desormeaux has just 28 wins in his four seasons at the helm. Maybe more importantly, Napier had seven losses in Year 1 and just five after that. The Ragin' Cajuns enter this season with the fewest portal additions in the conference, so either there's not much money there or nobody's willing to invest money.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 7.5

I don't know that things are working with Desormeaux here and the athletic department may have to make a big decision. He got a five-year extension after the 10-4 season, but reverted right back to what he was doing prior to that year. The complete lack of transfer portal involvement concerns me greatly, as other programs in the conference are getting better externally, while Louisiana is trying to rely on player development internally. The division is bad, and they do host Troy, so they're lucky there, but the trajectory here worries me. My projection is 7.25 wins.

2025 Record: 6-7 SU & ATS, 8-5 O-U
Head Coach: Michael Desormeaux - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	LAMAR (-18.4)	16.5
9/12	AT USC (+31.1)	60.0
9/19	UAB (-10.5)	26.0
9/26	AT CHARLOTTE (-11.2)	20.5
10/3	ARKANSAS ST (-2)	33.5
10/10	AT LOUISIANA TECH (+4.2)	33.0
10/17	TROY (+1.6)	36.0
10/24	AT SOUTHERN MISS (-4.8)	25.5
11/7	S ALABAMA (-5.9)	29.0
11/12	AT LA MONROE (-8.2)	22.0
11/21	COASTAL CAROLINA (-7.7)	28.0
11/28	AT GEORGIA ST (-8.7)	23.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **29.13**
#128 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.9 / 0.2**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

10

OFFENSE

7*

DEFENSE

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

What's on the menu for Lunch?

That would be Lunch Winfield, who led a four-game winning streak at the end of the regular season to get the Ragin' Cajuns to a bowl game. Three of those wins were by four or fewer points and four of the team's five conference wins fit that description. Winfield's running prowess certainly helped, as he was a mediocre-at-best passer with an 11/7 TD/INT ratio and a 58.8% completion rate, but he did run for 667 yards and added nine rushing touchdowns. It is officially his team now after losing out to Walker Howard at the start of last season and then splitting time with Daniel Beale after Howard got hurt. Perhaps that will help, especially since OC Tim Leger can scheme the offense exclusively around him.

Does Desormeaux deserve a pass for last season?

It did take some time to finally settle on a QB, but this offense may not have had steady success regardless. This was a battered and bruised offensive line last season, as three players suffered long-term injuries early and there was constant shuffling as a result of those injuries, plus other guys missing time here and there. It is surprising that Desormeaux and the staff didn't attack the portal more aggressively to find additional depth at that position, but because of the injuries, a lot of guys did get some important reps. It's a big group and clearly the plan is to try to run the ball as much as possible. Louisiana only had one game with 30 pass attempts in conference play last season, so the health of the run-blockers here is paramount.

Will the disappointing defense bounce back?

Jim Salgado had a rough first year as the DC. The secondary was hit hard by absences over the course of the season, but the real concern is that nobody got into the backfield. The Ragin' Cajuns had just 23 sacks in 13 games and tied for 112th in tackles for loss per game. Their top tacklers, Jaden Dugger and Terrance Williams, are gone after 220 stops. Dugger had nine TFL and Jordan Lawson had 10 TFL and those two combined for nine sacks. True sophomore Brent Gordon looks like a player in the secondary, but impact players seem few and far between.

2000-1 CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1 MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+700 SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.3	77
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	39
PLAYS PER GAME	67.7	78
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:52	70
3RD DOWN CONV. %	40.9%	49
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	340.2	98
YARDS PER PLAY	5	102
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	39.1	34
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	172.8	40
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	52
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.7	112
COMPLETION %	54.1%	131
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	167.4	118
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.3	113
TURNOVERS	1.6	98
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	30.8	101
YARDS PER POINT	13.8	89
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.5%	103
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	425.3	111
YARDS PER PLAY	5.9	105
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	198.6	121
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.9	106
COMPLETION %	66.8%	119
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	226.8	74
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	104
SACKS	1.8	82
TURNOVERS	1.3	58

LOUISIANA-MONROE WARHAWKS



Bryant Vincent brought some instant legitimacy to the Warhawks in 2024, getting off to a 5-1 start that included upset wins over UAB, Troy, and James Madison. Unfortunately, the Warhawks couldn't win another game to play in their first bowl since 2012. Sadly, it was a similar story in 2025, as ULM went 3-1 to open the season, but then didn't win another game. In fairness, the Warhawks have losses to Texas, Alabama, and Northwestern, and were an underdog in all but one of the other games that they lost.

But, that, in and of itself, explains the state of this program. Even in the lackluster Sun Belt West, the team has low expectations. They've only been favored five times in 24 games in the Vincent era and won just 10 games over the previous four seasons before he arrived. Vincent, who has spent most of his career as an offensive coordinator, needs to find some offense, otherwise his tenure here could be coming to a close. The Warhawks have scored 21 and 16.6 PPG in his two years at the helm.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

It is an encouraging development that Vincent has decided to give up the OC role so that he can better oversee the program. Too many young and first-time head coaches put a lot on their plates and aren't able to properly manage the other tasks within the program. This offense should create more explosive plays and also provide a different look for conference opponents. But, if the offense doesn't click, the defense will be under heavy fire and that is a huge worry. My projections call for exactly 3.00 wins and have the Warhawks an underdog in every game.

2025 Record: 3-9 SU & 4-8 ATS, 6-6 O-U
Head Coach: Bryant Vincent - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	AT MISSISSIPPI ST (+28.2)	47.0
9/12	AT UAB (+7.5)	26.0
9/19	SE LOUISIANA (-0.4)	24.0
9/26	FLA ATLANTIC (+8.5)	33.5
10/3	AT S ALABAMA (+9.9)	29.0
10/17	LOUISIANA TECH (+7.7)	33.0
10/24	AT TROY (+17.4)	36.0
10/31	SOUTHERN MISS (+0.4)	25.5
11/7	AT ARKANSAS ST (+15.4)	33.5
11/12	LA LAFAYETTE (+8.2)	32.5
11/21	AT APPALACHIAN ST (+11)	30.0
11/28	MARSHALL (+10)	34.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.32**
#104 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.5 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

8

5*

3

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Why will the offense be different in 2026?

Vincent went out and made an outside-the-box OC hire, picking up Iowa Central Community College head coach Jesse Montalto, whose offense was fifth in the NJCAA in PPG with 38.6 and fourth in yards per game with 445.8. The QB run was a big part of ICC's offense, as QB Damarcus Creech led the team with 723 yards and had 5.5 yards per carry. Incumbent QB Aidan Armenta had a 12/8 TD/INT ratio, but only managed 57 net yards on his 60 carries. Backup Landon Graves, also still with the program, had 40 pass attempts and 14 rush attempts. I fully expect dual-threat QB and former Houston Cougar Austin Carlisle to play a lot here. ULM originally offered Carlisle when he was a three-star freshman in Vincent's first year at the school. Now he's here and here for a reason.

Can the defense rewrite the narrative?

This defense has been bad for a long time. They haven't had more than 25 sacks in about a decade and their last two seasons have been the only ones in recent memory with fewer than six yards per play allowed. The 2024 season was even the first in quite some time with under 30 PPG allowed. Even going from -1 to -10 in TO margin, the team only got 3.1 PPG worse on defense. Now in Year 3, DC Earnest Hill at least has his top two tacklers back and a handful of others who played a good amount, plus JUCO transfers. With an offense expected to run with some more tempo, the defense is going to need some help from them to stay off the field. Similarly, the new-look offense could use more than nine takeaways from the D.

Should we play on ULM early and fade them late?

Maybe. Like I said, they started 3-1 last season and then lost every game. They started 5-1 in 2024 and then lost every game. They started 2-0 in 2023, including an outright upset win over Army, and then lost 10 in a row. I'm not sure if it's something about going down to Monroe early in the season when it's still hot and humid or what, but the team plays its best football in September and early October before falling off the face of the earth. Depth is definitely a factor, but maybe Vincent and the coaching staff don't adjust well when other teams have them on film.

10000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

100-1

SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	15.5	130
YARDS PER POINT	20.1	130
PLAYS PER GAME	62	129
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:31	81
3RD DOWN CONV. %	31.4%	127
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	310.9	122
YARDS PER PLAY	5	103
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.2	67
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	147.1	71
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.2	74
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	25.2	119
COMPLETION %	57.0%	116
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	163.8	120
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.5	99
TURNOVERS	1.6	105
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	34.8	123
YARDS PER POINT	11.7	132
3RD DOWN CONV. %	44.1%	111
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	408.1	91
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	90
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	170.2	90
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	75
COMPLETION %	63.5%	83
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	237.9	97
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.8	107
SACKS	1.8	76
TURNOVERS	0.7	123

LOUISIANA TECH BULLDOGS



On the heels of their best season since 2019, the Bulldogs are now in the Sun Belt. Sonny Cumbie's crew went 8-5 last season, capped off by a win over new conference foe Coastal Carolina in the Independence Bowl. Cumbie won 11 games in his first three seasons combined before all the pieces came together last season. The offense finally carried its weight to help out a defense that was very strong for the second straight season, even with a defensive coordinator change.

But, now the Rustonites are in a tougher conference. Conference USA is a poor league and the Bulldogs went 5-3 with two losses by just a point. The West Division is the weaker of the two in the Sun Belt, but it is an objectively stronger conference on the whole and Baylor joins LSU on the non-conference schedule. With notable personnel losses and defensive regression signs, it might be a bad time to switch conferences.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

Plus money on this one with a team that had 3, 3, and 5 regular-season wins for Cumbie before last season's 7-5 mark. I'm high on Georgia Southern and Old Dominion, the two teams from the East Division that the Bulldogs have to deal with. My projection is 5.76 wins, but this defense is very ripe for regression. With a lot of closely-lined games, that's a prominent factor in my handicapping. I only have LT favored by more than two points three times (NW State, UL Monroe, Southern Miss).

2025 Record: 8-5 SU & ATS, 5-8 O-U
Head Coach: Sonny Cumbie - 5th season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	NORTHWESTERN ST (-47.4)	-10.0
9/12	AT LSU (+31.8)	60.5
9/19	AT BAYLOR (+16.4)	47.0
10/3	ARMY (+3.9)	40.0
10/10	LA LAFAYETTE (-4.2)	32.5
10/17	AT LA MONROE (-7.7)	22.0
10/24	OLD DOMINION (+0.7)	37.0
10/31	AT S ALABAMA (-1.1)	29.0
11/7	AT TROY (+6.4)	36.0
11/14	SOUTHERN MISS (-12)	25.5
11/21	ARKANSAS ST (-3.5)	33.5
11/28	AT GA SOUTHERN (+5)	33.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.03**
#107 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **3.9 / -0.8**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

9

OFFENSE

5*

DEFENSE

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is the secondary the primary concern on defense?

Personally, I find the entire defense a concern, but this is going to be a new group of defensive backs. Safety Jakari Foster was one of Conference USA's best players and defensive backs Cedric Woods and Jhamal Shelby had 17 combined pass breakups. But, those aren't the only key departures on D. The team's three leading tacklers were all stat sheet fillers. Collectively, Jacob Fields, Mekhi Mason, and Sifa Leota had over 220 tackles, 7.5 sacks, more than 20 tackles for loss, and 16 pass breakups. The Bulldogs defense actually allowed fewer points per game (20.8 to 21) with first-year DC Luke Olsen, but allowed 0.6 more yards per carry, 67 more passing yards per game, and 0.7 more yards per play. Even without the roster attrition, regression was likely.

Should we buy stock in the offense?

The quarterbacks collectively posted an 8/9 TD/INT ratio last season, but the team did have a completion percentage over 62%. Without Trey Kukuk's running ability, things could have gone very differently, as he had more interceptions than touchdowns, but managed better than six yards per carry. The Bulldogs had almost 11 yards per carry against Sam Houston, 5.9 YPC against Liberty, and 7.6 YPC against Missouri State. That would be 353 rushing yards against New Mexico State, 426 against Sam Houston, 319 against Liberty, and 388 against Missouri State. That was 1,486 of their 2,540 rushing yards, which means that they had just 1,054 yards across the other nine games. Now they head to a better conference.

How big of a difference is being in the Sun Belt?

Using Jeff Sagarin's end-of-season average ratings, Conference USA was 13th at 55.84. The Sun Belt East Division was ninth at 62.38 and the West Division was 10th at 59.22. James Madison does really skew the numbers, but even the West Division outpaces the entirety of Conference USA. In looking at my power ratings for this season, my average PR for the Sun Belt minus Louisiana Tech is 55.2. My average PR for Conference USA is 52.3. My guess is that the average CFB fan and bettor won't think much of it. Even looking just at the SB West, my average PR is 53.6, and that's the weaker side by far.

ODDS TO WIN...

3000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

400-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

10-1

SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	27.6	56
YARDS PER POINT	13.3	33
PLAYS PER GAME	67.9	71
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:52	71
3RD DOWN CONV. %	41.7%	42
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	367.6	80
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	72
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	41.8	19
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	200.6	18
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	32
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	24.5	122
COMPLETION %	61.9%	63
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	167	119
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	81
TURNOVERS	1.4	85
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.5	40
YARDS PER POINT	17	18
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.7%	51
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	383.3	70
YARDS PER PLAY	5.5	65
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	135.3	39
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.4	71
COMPLETION %	55.4%	10
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	248	111
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.6	32
SACKS	1.3	120
TURNOVERS	1.8	15

SOUTH ALABAMA JAGUARS



Let's call this season the rubber match for Major Applewhite. Going 7-6 in Year 1 was a win, especially with 6.8 yards per play, a full yard per play better than opponents, and 34.4 PPG. Going 4-8 in Year 2 was a major disappointment, with just 5.4 YPP on offense and 26.5 PPG, while the defense regressed in several key areas. By no means do I think that Applewhite's job is in jeopardy with another poor showing, but he knows things need to get better. That's why he's going to serve as his own OC and hired football lifer Todd Orlando to fix the defense.

To be fair to Applewhite, he thought his starting QB Gio Lopez was coming back, but North Carolina showed up with a bag after spring practices. This season, Applewhite doesn't have that problem with Bishop Davenport back, but he does have to figure out who will replace 1,000-yard rusher Kentrell Bullock and WR Devin Voisin, who had 67 catches, 27 more than anybody else. While the Jags have the fourth-ranked freshman class per 247Sports, they also have the second-worst transfer portal class.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 5.5

I'm trusting my numbers here by swaying to the Under, as my projection is for 5.12 wins, but this is as high-variance of a team as you'll see in the Sun Belt. If the offense does increase the tempo and create explosives, it's a different story, but that could also negatively impact a team that is very short on depth and very green in the secondary. Drawing Marshall and App State from the East is one of the tougher draws as well.

2025 Record: 4-8 SU & 5-7 ATS, 8-4 O-U
Head Coach: Major Applewhite - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	SE LOUISIANA (-7)	24.0
9/12	AT TULANE (+16.4)	42.5
9/19	OHIO U (+0.7)	31.5
9/26	AT KENTUCKY (+19.9)	47.0
10/3	LA MONROE (-9.9)	22.0
10/8	AT ARKANSAS ST (+7.1)	33.5
10/20	AT MARSHALL (+7.5)	34.0
10/31	LOUISIANA TECH (+1.1)	33.0
11/7	AT LA LAFAYETTE (+5.9)	32.5
11/14	TROY (+5.9)	36.0
11/21	AT SOUTHERN MISS (-1.6)	25.5
11/27	APPALACHIAN ST (-1.9)	30.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **32.68**
#102 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.1 / 0.5**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

8

4*

4

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Does Bishop’s Bunch improve on offense?

OC Rob Ezell left for the same position at Wake Forest following a very successful 2024 season. Not only did the Jaguars have 6.8 YPP, but they also surrendered just 17 sacks. Paul Petrino was not able to keep up those numbers, though he did get a raw deal with Lopez leaving. In any event, Davenport got to prep all summer long knowing that it’s his team. He had a 68% completion rate, as the Jaguars were 12th in the nation in that department. He only had a 12/6 TD/INT ratio, as the team was reliant on the run with Bullock. With Bullock gone, Davenport may be asked to throw more and run more, as he had 116 carries last season, but just for 326 yards. With Applewhite calling the shots, my answer to this question is ‘Yes’.

Can the skill guys make up for the losses of Bullock and Voisin?

In order to achieve the above, this is a big part of the equation. Keenan Phillips had 4.8 yards per carry over 126 attempts and PJ Martin had 5.4 yards per carry. Anthony Eager was second with 40 catches, but only had 339 yards. Some game-breakers need to step forward, especially at WR, where I’m very surprised that the Jaguars didn’t pursue portal options with more fervor. There isn’t a lot of size at WR, but Applewhite will probably run with more tempo to use that group’s speed and get the ball out quickly into space. Under Petrino, South Alabama was 88th in percentage of plays of 7+ yards and 124th in percentage of plays of 10+ yards per BCF Toys. Under Ezell, they were 24th in 7+ yards and 54th in 10+ yards. That’s what Applewhite is looking for.

What is our situation, Dad?

I’m sorry; it has nothing to do with football, but anytime I see the name Todd, all I can think of is Todd Cleary from Wedding Crashers. Todd Orlando steps into something of a mess. Even the Jaguars defense back in 2024 allowed 5.8 YPP, even though they only allowed 25.2 PPG. That was still a big drop from the previous two seasons when Kane Wommack was still the head coach. I’m sure Orlando asked Applewhite what he had to work with and it’s not much, as the top four tacklers are gone, though nobody with 2+ sacks because nobody on the team had 2+ sacks. The biggest loss by far is CB Nehemiah Chandler, who is now at Florida State. This is a completely rebuilt defense with limited portal help.

3000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

300-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

14-1

SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	25.5	74
YARDS PER POINT	15.1	84
PLAYS PER GAME	73.2	16
TIME OF POSSESSION	31:34	30
3RD DOWN CONV. %	43.5%	30
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	383.6	68
YARDS PER PLAY	5.2	82
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	44.5	6
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	201.9	17
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.5	43
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	26.8	110
COMPLETION %	67.5%	15
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	181.7	110
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	88
TURNOVERS	1	22
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	31.3	106
YARDS PER POINT	12.3	125
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.2%	56
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	384.1	71
YARDS PER PLAY	5.8	93
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	175	95
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.8	98
COMPLETION %	61.0%	54
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	209.1	43
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.3	74
SACKS	0.8	133
TURNOVERS	1	98

SOUTHERN MISS GOLDEN EAGLES



Southern Miss caught lightning in a bottle when they were able to enjoy one season with Charles Huff at the helm, as he brought a bunch of Marshall players with him and took the Golden Eagles to a bowl game on the heels of a disastrous 1-11 season. Unfortunately, Huff didn't last long in Hattiesburg, as he is now coaching Memphis. Blake Anderson was on staff as the OC and simply got elevated to the head coach position, his second such post in the Sun Belt.

Anderson was fired from Utah State for allegations that he improperly reported instances of sexual misconduct per university rules in a case that also got the deputy athletic director fired. On Anderson's watch, the offense improved by 13.5 PPG and a full yard per play, so the administration at Southern Miss felt comfortable moving him up despite his recent misgivings, even though all but one of those offensive pieces are gone and the defense has essentially one returning player.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Under 3.5

While my projection is on the plus side of this at 3.86, the -130 juice puts me pretty in line with the market. The truth is that I only have Southern Miss favored twice, with a very tepid favorite role at UL Monroe on Halloween as the only FBS game laying a number. Drawing James Madison and Old Dominion from the East is as brutal as it gets. This isn't a bet, but this is very clearly a transitional season in Hattiesburg.

2025 Record: 7-6 SU & 5-7-1 ATS, 6-7 O-U
Head Coach: Blake Anderson - 1st season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	ALCORN ST (-27.9)	0.5
9/12	AT AUBURN (+29.3)	52.5
9/19	CONNECTICUT (+3.8)	31.5
9/26	AT TULANE (+21)	42.5
10/6	AT TROY (+13.7)	36.0
10/17	ARKANSAS ST (+5.5)	33.5
10/24	LA LAFAYETTE (+4.8)	32.5
10/31	AT LA MONROE (-0.4)	22.0
11/5	JAMES MADISON (+14.4)	41.5
11/14	AT LOUISIANA TECH (+12)	33.0
11/21	S ALABAMA (+1.6)	29.0
11/28	AT OLD DOMINION (+14.9)	37.0

SCHEDULE STRENGTH **33.23**
#98 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS **2.4 / -0.6**
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

1

OFFENSE

1

DEFENSE

0

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Is there a true QB1 on the roster?

Anderson enters a tough spot here because a lot of players went to Memphis with Huff or were guys that simply wanted to play their final season of college football with Huff. There's basically no returning production on the roster and that's true at the QB position. Landry Lyddy did stick around after throwing for 406 yards with a 2/3 TD/INT ratio and 12 yards on six carries. Given that Braylon Braxton had a 24/8 TD/INT ratio with over 3,000 passing yards, maybe Lyddy was just stuck behind him. Either way, Anderson brought in Ethan Hampton from Illinois. He started a few games at Northern Illinois, but barely saw the field with the Illini. John White played in 2024, but not last year. The Golden Eagles threw for 266 yards last season, the most for them since 2019. Don't expect anything like that again.

Should we fear the unknown?

The Golden Eagles had 20 players with at least 20 tackles last season. Nineteen of them are playing somewhere else or not at all. This is a hodgepodge of transfers and guys who stuck around knowing that starting jobs were going to be available. Similarly, there were nine players with at least 15 receptions and every single one of them is outside of the program. A 7-6 season after going 1-11 was a massive achievement, but this was a team that was just +18 in point differential, +0.3 in YPP, got outgained on a per-carry basis, and really benefitted from a +14 turnover margin. To only be +18 in points with that kind of TO margin is hard to believe. Also, the Golden Eagles lost twice in favorite roles over the final three games and also lost as a pick 'em and +1. I'm not saying this team will be better. I'm saying last year's team wasn't that great.

But, should we fear this unknown?

The unknown in question here is DC Joe Bolden, who has never held that position before. He's held a variety of roles, serving as special teams coordinator here last season. He played at Michigan, was a grad assistant there, actually coached at Ohio State, and also had stops at Nevada and Tulsa. He hasn't stayed long at any stop. I'm not sure what to make of that, except feel sorry for his wife and four kids. A ton of JUCOs and FCS transfers with a first-time DC has serious "recipe for disaster" potential.

1000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

500-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

60-1

SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28	51
YARDS PER POINT	14.5	69
PLAYS PER GAME	72.9	21
TIME OF POSSESSION	27:38	123
3RD DOWN CONV. %	39.9%	64
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	405.9	35
YARDS PER PLAY	5.6	56
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	36.1	55
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	136.4	87
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	3.8	99
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	35.2	24
COMPLETION %	63.3%	52
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	269.5	22
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.7	43
TURNOVERS	1.3	62
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	28	80
YARDS PER POINT	14.7	63
3RD DOWN CONV. %	45.9%	123
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	410.7	99
YARDS PER PLAY	5.3	49
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	173.2	93
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.1	55
COMPLETION %	64.3%	97
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	237.5	95
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	62
SACKS	2.3	44
TURNOVERS	2.3	4

TROY TROJANS



One of the nation's top coaching jobs came from Gerad Parker, who captained a four-win improvement at Troy despite a bunch of cluster injuries on the offensive line and at the quarterback position. While 8-6 doesn't stand out all that much, especially after Jon Sumrall went 23-5 over two seasons before heading to Tulane, it is a great sign for the future of this program. Many weren't sure about the hire of Parker, who was the OC at Notre Dame, but was an attractive candidate to Troy because he was the OC at West Virginia under former Trojans head coach Neal Brown.

The last two seasons are kind of tough to gauge. The 4-8 start to Parker's tenure came with a mass exodus of talent post-Sumrall, but the Trojans did win three of their last four games to end on something of a high note. Last season, the Trojans allowed 59 sacks and put up just 2.8 yards per carry with their worst offensive season since the Larry Blakeney era, but found ways to win games. That includes a 6-3 conference record despite getting outgained by nearly a full yard per play. Usually that kind of good fortune regresses to the mean, but the never-ending swarm of injury bugs last season isn't a guarantee to come back this season.

WIN TOTAL SELECTION

Over 6.5

This is a juicy one, but I consider it a bet. I also like Over 7.5 on an alt win total. My projection is 6.86 wins, but there are multiple toss-up games on the slate for the Trojans that I think they can win. I'm also down on Louisiana and some other teams that they face in closely-lined games. Parker got this team to eight wins last season with a dumpster fire of burning tires on the offensive line and two injured QBs. The roster is better now and I can't imagine the health luck is that bad again.

2025 Record: 8-6 SU & 9-5 ATS, 5-9 O-U
Head Coach: Gerad Parker - 3rd season

2026 SCHEDULE

Date	Opponent/Projected Line	Opponent Power Rating
9/5	SAM HOUSTON ST (-20.2)	18.5
9/12	ALABAMA ST (-18.4)	19.5
9/19	AT MISSOURI (+20.8)	54.5
9/26	AT UTAH ST (+3.4)	36.5
10/6	SOUTHERN MISS (-13.7)	25.5
10/17	AT LA LAFAYETTE (-1.6)	32.5
10/24	LA MONROE (-17.4)	22.0
10/29	AT JAMES MADISON (+8.6)	41.5
11/7	LOUISIANA TECH (-6.4)	33.0
11/14	AT S ALABAMA (-5.9)	29.0
11/21	GA SOUTHERN (-5.6)	33.5
11/28	AT ARKANSAS ST (-0.4)	33.5

SCHEDULE STRENGTH 31.27
#116 toughest of 138

FIELD RATINGS 2.6 / 1
(HOME/ROAD)

RETURNING STARTERS

TOTAL

OFFENSE

DEFENSE

6

4*

2

* = Returning QB

THREE BURNING QUESTIONS FOR THE 2026 SEASON

Can the Trojans provide some protection?

One way to avoid unwanted consequences is to use protection. If you want your quarterback to stay healthy, perhaps blocking for him makes some sense. I had to do a triple take to make sure that 59 wasn't a typo in the sack department for Troy. It wasn't. The Trojans allowed seven more sacks than the next closest team. Tucker Kilcrease even had 116 carries and Goose Crowder had 57, so there could have been even more. A couple starters are back on the offensive line, not that that's necessarily a good thing, and the transfer portal was heavily-utilized to fill out the rest. I find it incredible that Troy was exactly even in turnover margin and the QBs had a 20/11 TD/INT ratio while being under duress on seemingly every dropback.

Who is QB1?

Kilcrease and Crowder must be really good friends. Or they really love the school. Either way, it is really rare to see this sort of dynamic in college football nowadays with how easy it is to transfer. Both guys sat behind Matthew Caldwell in 2024 and went into 2025 as 1a and 1b, with them flipping spots depending on the day. Crowder won the starting gig, but got hurt in the third game. When he came back, Kilcrease still got the start against Old Dominion and then he got hurt, as Crowder finished out the season. Based on the betting market action when Crowder got hurt and Kilcrease took over, the sentiment was that Kilcrease was a clear downgrade. There are also quite a few players from East Mississippi CC on this roster now, including 6-foot-5 QB Rodge Waldrop. I'm very curious to see how this all plays out.

Is improvement coming on both sides of the ball?

New OC Adam Austin led a Tarleton offense that had five 50-burgers last season and was the highest PPG team at the FCS level and second to North Texas in all of Division I. DC Dontae Wright led some nice year over year improvements, going from 28.4 PPG in 2024 to 23.9 PPG last season, plus the team shaved more than 6% off of their completion percentage against, had 18 more sacks, and allowed 0.4 fewer yards per play. Unfortunately, pretty much all of his top defensive players are gone. One who isn't is Donnie Smith, who had 11 sacks. Based on the improvement from 2024 to 2025, I'm convinced this staff is adept at finding talent in the portal.

2000-1

CFP CHAMPIONSHIP

150-1

MAKE THE PLAYOFF

+800

SUN BELT (WEST)

2025 STATISTICS

OFFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	22.4	95
YARDS PER POINT	13.4	36
PLAYS PER GAME	70.3	50
TIME OF POSSESSION	29:51	72
3RD DOWN CONV. %	37.2%	90
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	298.9	125
YARDS PER PLAY	4.3	132
RUSH ATTEMPTS PER GAME	34.4	76
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	84.7	131
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	2.5	136
PASS ATTEMPTS PER GAME	31.5	63
COMPLETION %	58.0%	106
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	214.2	82
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	6.8	84
TURNOVERS	1.4	82
DEFENSIVE STATISTICS	#	RANK
POINTS PER GAME	24.2	50
YARDS PER POINT	15.8	33
3RD DOWN CONV. %	38.3%	57
TOTAL YARDS PER GAME	382.2	68
YARDS PER PLAY	5.4	59
RUSH YARDS PER GAME	185	106
YARDS PER RUSH ATTEMPT	4.6	93
COMPLETION %	59.0%	29
PASSING YARDS PER GAME	197.2	27
YARDS PER PASS ATTEMPT	7.1	59
SACKS	2.5	31
TURNOVERS	1.3	65